

FORECAST



BỘ CÂU HỎI BÀI TẬP FORECAST 2026

IELTS SPEAKING INTENSIVE

Mục lục

Lời nói đầu	ii
Hướng dẫn sử dụng	iii
1 Part 1: Personal & General Topics	1
PART 1: PERSONAL & LIFESTYLE TOPICS	1
1.1 Work or Studies	1
1.2 Hometown	8
1.3 Home and Accommodation	13
1.4 The City You Live In	18
1.5 The Area You Live In	22
PART 1: DAILY LIFE & HABITS	25
1.6 Morning Time	25
1.7 Spare Time	27
1.8 Day Off	29
1.9 Having a Break	31
1.10 Going Out	33
1.11 Walking	35
PART 1: PERSONAL PREFERENCES & ACTIVITIES	37
1.12 Hobby	37
1.13 Childhood Activities	39
1.14 Sports Team	41
1.15 Reading	43
1.16 Typing	45
PART 1: VIEWS, PLACES & TRAVEL	47
1.17 Views	47
1.18 Scenery	49
1.19 Building	51
1.20 Museum	53
1.21 Public Places	55
1.22 Crowded Place	57
PART 1: SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL TOPICS	59
1.23 Chatting / Conversation	59
1.24 Sharing	62
1.25 Happy Things	65
1.26 Doing Something Well	68
1.27 Staying with Old People	70
1.28 Life Stages	72
PART 1: OBJECTS, SHOPPING & CONSUMPTION	75
1.29 Gifts	75
1.30 Shoes	77
1.31 Advertisement	79
1.32 Borrowing / Lending	82
PART 1: MEMORY, DREAMS & IMAGINATION	84
1.33 Memory	84
1.34 Dreams	86
1.35 Taking Photos	88

PART 1: NATURE, FOOD & SCHOOL LIFE	91
1.36 Food	91
1.37 Plants	92
1.38 Growing Vegetables / Fruits	93
1.39 Pets and Animals	94
1.40 Rules	95
2 Part 2 & 3: Cue Cards & Discussion Topics	97
2.1 Describe a city you enjoyed visiting	97
2.2 Describe a person who likes to look after the natural world	105
2.3 Describe a short-term job you want to have in a foreign country	112
2.4 Describe a time when you gave advice to others	121
2.5 Describe a person who often helps others	128
2.6 Describe an event you attended in which you didn't enjoy the music played .	136
2.7 Describe one of your friends who learned something without a teacher	143
2.8 Describe a piece of technology (not a phone) that you would like to own . .	152
2.9 Describe a perfect job you would like to have in the future	161
2.10 Describe a child who loves drawing/painting	170
2.11 Describe a program or app on your computer or phone	178
2.12 Describe a person who makes plans a lot and is good at planning	187
2.13 Describe a famous person you would like to meet	196
2.14 Describe an interesting building	205
2.15 Describe a movie you watched and enjoyed recently	214
2.16 Describe something that you can't live without (not a computer/phone) . . .	222
2.17 Describe a city that you think is very interesting / famous	231
2.18 Describe an item on which you spent more than expected	238
2.19 Describe a time when you felt proud of a family member	245
2.20 Describe a bicycle / motorcycle / car trip you would like to go on	252
2.21 Describe a person who solved a problem in a smart way	259
2.22 Describe an occasion when many people were smiling	267
2.23 Describe an occasion when you were not allowed to use your mobile phone .	274
2.24 Describe a time when you encouraged someone to do something that he/she didn't want to do	281
2.25 Describe something important that has been kept in your family for a long time	289
2.26 Describe a time you needed to use your imagination	297
2.27 Describe a book you read that you found useful	304
2.28 Describe a creative person you admire	311
2.29 Describe a long journey you had and would like to take again	319
2.30 Describe a person you know who enjoys working for a family business	326
2.31 Describe a wild animal that you want to learn more about	334
2.32 Describe a time when you broke something	342
2.33 Describe an important old thing that your family has kept for a long time .	349
2.34 Describe a good friend who is important to you	357
2.35 Describe a friend of yours who is good at music / singing	365
2.36 Describe a great dinner you and your friends or family members enjoyed . .	373
2.37 Describe an important decision made with the help of other people	381
2.38 Describe a time when the electricity suddenly went off	388
2.39 Describe an exciting activity you have tried for the first time	395
2.40 Describe an interesting traditional story	402
2.41 Describe a city that you have been to and would like to visit again	409

2.42	Describe a shop / store you enjoy visiting	416
2.43	Describe a time when you received good service in a shop / store	423
2.44	Describe a natural place (e.g. parks, mountains)	430
2.45	Describe a successful sportsperson you admire	437
2.46	Describe an area / subject of science that you are interested in	444
2.47	Describe a TV or online program you like to watch	451
2.48	Describe a quiet place you like to go	458
2.49	Describe a good habit your friend has and you want to develop	465
2.50	Describe a time when you waited for something special that would happen .	472
2.51	Describe a time you saw something interesting on social media	479
2.52	Describe a natural talent (sports, music, etc.) you want to improve	486
2.53	Describe a toy you liked in your childhood	493
2.54	Describe the time when you first talked in a foreign language	500
2.55	Describe an occasion when you lost your way	507
2.56	Describe a time when someone apologized to you	514

Lời nói đầu

Nhằm mục đích hỗ trợ các học viên trong việc chuẩn bị cho kỳ thi IELTS, **The Forum Center** đã ra mắt dự án *IELTS Speaking Forecast Intensive*.

Tài liệu này tập trung vào việc tổng hợp và giải chi tiết các câu hỏi dự đoán (Forecast) bám sát xu hướng đề thi thực tế mới nhất, bao gồm:

- **Part 1:** Các chủ đề xoay quanh cuộc sống thường ngày.
- **Part 2:** Các dạng bài mô tả trọng tâm (Cue Cards) rèn luyện phát triển ý tưởng trong 2 phút.
- **Part 3:** Các câu hỏi nghị luận xã hội đòi hỏi tư duy sâu sắc và cách trả lời logic.

Mỗi chủ đề đều được thiết kế với dàn ý rõ ràng, cung cấp ý tưởng mở rộng, từ vựng ăn điểm và bài mẫu mang tính ứng dụng cao.

Chúc các bạn ôn tập hiệu quả và chinh phục thành công mục tiêu IELTS!

Hướng dẫn sử dụng

Cách tiếp cận bài học

1. **Lên ý tưởng:** Tự phác thảo ý chính dựa trên câu hỏi trước khi tham khảo câu trả lời mẫu.
2. **Đọc hiểu & Phân tích:** Nghiên cứu các cụm từ (collocations) và cách tổ chức ý trong bài giải.
3. **Thực hành phát âm:** Đọc thành tiếng các câu trả lời, chú ý đến các ngắt nghỉ, nhấn nhá đã được gợi ý.
4. **Cá nhân hoá:** Áp dụng từ vựng để tạo câu trả lời của riêng mình.

Chương 1

Part 1: Personal & General Topics

PART 1: PERSONAL & LIFESTYLE TOPICS

1.1 Work or Studies

What work do you do?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

At the moment, I am not working full-time because I am a second-year university student. Most of my weekdays are taken up by lectures, assignments, and a few club activities, so studying is really my main focus for now.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I work as a marketing executive for a mid-sized education company. My job mainly involves planning social media campaigns, writing content, and tracking how well each campaign performs.

What subjects are you studying?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I am majoring in business administration, so I study subjects like marketing, finance, management, and consumer behaviour. I would say marketing is the most enjoyable one because it allows me to be both analytical and creative.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I am not studying at university anymore, but I still take short online courses related to digital marketing and data analysis. They help me stay up to date with industry trends, which is pretty important in my field.

Do you like your subject?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do, although it can be quite demanding at times. What I like most is that the theories are not too abstract; I can actually apply them to real businesses and even small projects with my classmates.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Looking back, I did enjoy my major because it gave me a solid foundation for my current job. Some subjects were dry, especially statistics, but they turned out to be more useful than I expected.

Do you like your job?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Since I am still a student, I do not have a full-time job yet. I do some freelance design work occasionally, and I quite enjoy it because it gives me a taste of professional life without overwhelming my study schedule.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, for the most part. The workload can be intense when deadlines pile up, but I like the fast-paced environment and the feeling of seeing an idea turn into a real campaign.

Why did you choose to study that subject?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I chose business administration because I have always been curious about how companies attract customers and make decisions. Also, it is a fairly versatile major, so it gives me several career options instead of locking me into one path.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I chose marketing-related subjects because I was interested in both creativity and psychology. I liked the idea of understanding what people want and then turning that insight into a message that actually connects with them.

Why did you choose to do that type of work (or that job)?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

For my freelance work, I chose graphic design because it fits naturally with my interests. It is flexible, and I can take on small projects during quieter weeks without affecting my classes too much.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I chose marketing because it is a field where things never stay the same for long. I enjoy that mix of strategy, creativity, and measurable results, so the job keeps me on my toes in a good way.

What requirements did you need to meet to get your current job?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

For the small freelance projects I do, I mainly needed a decent portfolio and the ability to communicate clearly with clients. Grades were not the main issue; people cared more about whether I could deliver clean designs on time.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I needed a bachelor's degree, some internship experience, and a basic understanding of digital tools like Google Analytics and Meta Ads. During the interview, they also cared a lot about problem-solving skills and whether I could work under pressure.

Do you think that your subject is popular in your country?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

Yes, business-related majors are very popular in Vietnam. A lot of students choose them because they seem practical and open the door to different careers, from banking to marketing to entrepreneurship.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Definitely. Marketing and business courses are in high demand because many companies are moving online and need people who understand customers, branding, and digital platforms.

Do you have any plans for your studies in the next five years?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

Yes, my immediate plan is to finish my degree with a strong GPA and complete at least one internship before graduation. After that, I may pursue a master's degree abroad if I can get a scholarship.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I am not planning to go back to university full-time, but I do want to keep learning through professional certificates. In the next few years, I would like to improve my data skills because marketing is becoming much more numbers-driven.

Do you have any plans for your work in the next five years?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

I hope to get an entry-level job in marketing after I graduate. Ideally, I would like to work for a company where I can learn from experienced colleagues and gradually build a clear career path.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I would like to move into a senior role where I can manage a small team and handle bigger campaigns. I am not in a rush, but I want to keep building both technical skills and leadership experience.

Do you prefer to study in the mornings or in the afternoons?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

I prefer studying in the morning because my mind feels fresher then. If I leave difficult tasks until the afternoon, I tend to lose focus and get distracted by messages or other plans.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

When I take online courses, I prefer studying in the evening after work. It is not always ideal because I can be tired, but it is the only time when I can sit down without work meetings interrupting me.

How much time do you spend on your studies each week?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I probably spend around twenty to twenty-five hours a week outside class reviewing lessons and doing assignments. The number goes up sharply before exams because I have to revise, prepare presentations, and finish group projects.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

For professional learning, I usually spend three or four hours a week. It is not a huge amount, but I try to be consistent because small, regular learning sessions are easier to maintain than occasional cramming.

Do you want to change your major?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

No, not really. There are difficult moments, of course, but overall I still feel that my major suits my strengths and gives me enough room to explore different interests.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

If I could go back, I might add more technology-related subjects, but I would not completely change my major. Business gave me a useful base, and I can always fill the gaps through short courses.

Do you want to change to another job?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

At this stage, I am not tied to one job yet, so I am still exploring. I would like to try internships in a few different areas before deciding what kind of work really suits me.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Not right now. I still feel I am learning a lot in my current position, but in the long run I might move to a larger company if it offers better training and career progression.

Are you looking forward to working?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I am, although I know it will be challenging. I am looking forward to becoming more independent, earning my own income, and applying what I have learned in a real workplace.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I already work, but I still look forward to new projects because they keep the job interesting. Whenever I get to launch something fresh, it gives me a sense of momentum.

Do you miss being a student?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I am still a student, so maybe I do not appreciate it fully yet. But I think I will miss the

flexibility, the long breaks, and the chance to spend so much time with friends.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, sometimes. Student life was stressful in its own way, but I miss having fewer responsibilities and being able to learn without worrying too much about bills or workplace pressure.

What technology do you use when you study?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I use my laptop for almost everything, from taking notes to making slides and doing research. I also rely on apps like Google Drive and Notion because they help me organise materials and collaborate with classmates.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

When I study after work, I mostly use online learning platforms, note-taking apps, and sometimes AI tools to summarise long articles. They save me a lot of time, especially when I am already tired after a full day.

What technology do you use at work?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

For my freelance design tasks, I mainly use design software like Canva and Adobe Illustrator. I also use messaging apps to communicate with clients, which makes the whole process much smoother.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I use quite a few digital tools at work, including project management software, analytics dashboards, and content scheduling platforms. Without them, it would be much harder to coordinate tasks and track campaign performance.

What changes would you like to see in your school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I would like my university to offer more practical workshops and company visits. The lectures are useful, but students also need more exposure to real business situations before they graduate.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Thinking back to my university, I wish it had provided stronger career guidance. Many students, including me at the time, knew the theory but felt unsure about how to turn it into an actual career plan.

Who helps you the most? And how?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

My closest friend helps me the most because we study the same major and often prepare for exams together. She explains difficult concepts in a simple way, and she also keeps me

motivated when I feel overwhelmed.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

At work, my line manager helps me the most. She gives clear feedback on my campaigns, points out blind spots, and encourages me to take more ownership instead of just following instructions.

What do you think is the most important at the moment?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Right now, the most important thing for me is building a solid foundation. I want to keep my grades stable, improve my English, and gain some practical experience before entering the job market.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

For me, the priority is maintaining a healthy balance between performance and well-being. I want to do well at work, but I also know that burning out would hurt my career in the long run.

What are the benefits of being your age?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I think the biggest benefit is having time to experiment. I am young enough to make mistakes, try different activities, and change direction without feeling that it is too late.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

At my age, I have more independence than I did as a student, but I am still young enough to learn quickly and take risks. It feels like a good stage for building habits and making long-term career decisions.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
take up	phr v	/teɪk ʌp/	to use or occupy time or space	chiếm thời gian/không gian
solid foundation	n phr	/'sɒl.ɪd faʊn'deɪ.ʃən/	a strong basic understanding	nền tảng vững chắc
versatile	adj	/'vɜː.sə.taɪl/	useful in many different ways	linh hoạt, đa năng
keep someone on their toes	idiom	/ki:p 'sʌm.wʌn ɒn ðeə təʊz/	to make someone stay alert and active	khiến ai luôn tập trung, nhanh nhạy
portfolio	n	/pɔːt'fəʊ.li.əʊ/	a collection of work samples	hồ sơ sản phẩm/năng lực
entry-level	adj	/'en.tri ,lev.əl/	suitable for someone starting a career	ở cấp độ mới vào nghề
career progression	n phr	/kə'riə prə'ɡreʃ.ən/	gradual advancement in a career	sự thăng tiến nghề nghiệp
collaborate	v	/kə'læb.ə.reɪt/	to work together with others	cộng tác
career guidance	n phr	/kə'riə 'ɡaɪ.dəns/	advice about jobs and career paths	định hướng nghề nghiệp
burn out	phr v	/bɜːn aʊt/	to become exhausted from too much work	kiệt sức vì làm việc quá nhiều

1.2 Hometown

Where is your hometown?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

My hometown is Da Nang, a coastal city in central Vietnam. My family still lives there, and I usually go back during semester breaks, so it still feels very much like home to me.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I come from Da Nang, which is one of the most liveable cities in Vietnam. Although I now work in Ho Chi Minh City, I still consider Da Nang my real hometown because most of my family and childhood memories are there.

Is that a big city or a small place?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I would say it is a medium-sized city. It is not as hectic as Hanoi or Ho Chi Minh City, but it is definitely not a sleepy town either, especially during the tourist season.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

It is somewhere in between. Da Nang has modern infrastructure and a growing economy, but it still feels more manageable and less crowded than the major business hubs in Vietnam.

Please describe your hometown a little.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Da Nang is known for its beaches, bridges, and relaxed lifestyle. What I like is that you can go from a busy city street to the seaside in just a few minutes, which makes daily life feel quite balanced.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

It is a clean and well-planned city with a nice mix of nature and urban development. There are beaches, mountains, good restaurants, and enough business activity to make it feel dynamic without being overwhelming.

Do you like your hometown?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, absolutely. I like it because it is peaceful enough for studying and family life, but it still has plenty of cafes, shopping areas, and places to hang out with friends.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do. After living in a bigger city for work, I appreciate Da Nang even more because the pace of life is calmer and people seem less stressed on a day-to-day basis.

What do you like (most) about your hometown?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

What I like most is the beach. Whenever I feel stressed about exams or assignments, I can go there for a walk, get some fresh air, and clear my head quite quickly.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

For me, the best thing is the quality of life. The city has good food, beautiful scenery, and shorter commuting times, so it is much easier to maintain a healthy work-life balance there.

Is there anything you dislike about it?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

If I had to choose one thing, I would say the weather can be a bit harsh. During the rainy season, heavy storms and flooding sometimes disrupt classes and make travelling around the city inconvenient.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The main drawback is that there are still fewer career opportunities compared with bigger cities. For some specialised fields, people often have to move away if they want faster career growth.

How long have you been living there?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

I lived there for most of my childhood before moving away for university. So even though I am not there full-time now, I spent around eighteen years growing up in that city.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I lived there until I finished university, so roughly twenty-two years. I moved to Ho Chi Minh City for work a few years ago, but I still visit Da Nang whenever I get a long weekend.

Do you like living there?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

Yes, I really do. Life there is comfortable, and I like the fact that most places are not too far from each other, so I can get around easily without wasting too much time.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, living there is quite pleasant. If my job allowed remote work permanently, I would seriously consider moving back because the city offers a calmer lifestyle and lower living costs.

Do you think you will continue living there for a long time?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

I am not completely sure. I may need to move to a bigger city after graduation for better job opportunities, but in the long run, I would love to return to Da Nang and settle down there.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Probably not in the immediate future because my current job is based elsewhere. However, I can imagine moving back later in life, especially if I can find a suitable role or start my own business there.

What's your hometown famous for?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It is famous for My Khe Beach, the Dragon Bridge, and local food like Mi Quang. Tourists also use Da Nang as a gateway to Hoi An and Ba Na Hills, so it is quite well-known now.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Da Nang is famous for being clean, scenic, and tourist-friendly. In recent years, it has also built a reputation as a good place for conferences, tourism services, and small start-ups.

Did you learn about the culture of your hometown in your childhood?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, mostly through family activities and school events. For example, I learned about local festivals, traditional food, and the way people in central Vietnam value resilience and hospitality.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I did, but in a very natural way rather than through formal lessons. Growing up there, I absorbed the local culture through food, family gatherings, festivals, and everyday conversations with older relatives.

Did you learn about the history of your hometown at school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but only to some extent. We learned about Da Nang's role as a port city and some historical sites nearby, but I think the lessons were quite brief and textbook-based.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I remember learning about its development from a coastal trading area into a modern city. To be honest, I did not find it very exciting as a student, but I appreciate it more now.

Have you learned anything about the history of your hometown?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Recently, I learned more about how quickly Da Nang has changed over the past few decades. It used to be much quieter, but now it has become a major tourist and transport centre.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, especially after I started paying attention to urban development. I learned that the city's growth was not accidental; it came from long-term investment in infrastructure and tourism.

Are there many young people in your hometown?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, there are quite a lot of young people, especially around universities, cafes, and entertainment areas. However, some still move to bigger cities after graduation because they want broader career options.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

There are many young people, but the city also loses some talent to Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City. That said, more young professionals are staying now because tourism, technology, and service industries are growing.

Is your hometown a good place for young people to pursue their careers?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It depends on the field. For tourism, hospitality, and some creative jobs, Da Nang can be a promising place, but for highly specialised careers, young people may still need to look elsewhere.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I think it is becoming a better place for young professionals. The market is not as large as in Ho Chi Minh City, but the lower living costs and improving business environment make it increasingly attractive.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
coastal city	n phr	/ˈkəʊ.stəl ˈsɪt.i/	a city located near the sea	thành phố ven biển
liveable	adj	/ˈlɪv.ə.bəl/	pleasant and suitable to live in	đáng sống
hectic	adj	/ˈhek.tɪk/	very busy and full of activity	bận rộn, hối hả
manageable	adj	/ˈmæn.ɪ.dʒə.bəl/	easy enough to control or deal with	dễ quản lý, vừa tầm
work-life balance	n phr	/ˌwɜːk laɪf ˈbæl.əns/	a healthy division between work and personal life	cân bằng công việc và cuộc sống
drawback	n	/ˈdrɔː.bæk/	a disadvantage or problem	điểm bất lợi
settle down	phr v	/ˈset.əl daʊn/	to begin living a stable life in one place	ổn định cuộc sống
gateway to	n phr	/ˈɡeɪt.weɪ tuː/	a place that gives access to another place	cửa ngõ dẫn đến
resilience	n	/rɪˈzɪl.i.əns/	the ability to recover from difficulties	sự kiên cường
urban development	n phr	/ˈɜː.bən dɪˈvel.əp.mənt/	the growth and planning of a city	phát triển đô thị

1.3 Home and Accommodation

Who do you live with?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

At the moment, I live with two classmates in a small rented apartment near our university. It is not luxurious, but sharing the place helps us cut down on living costs.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I live by myself in a rented apartment, although my family visits me from time to time. Living alone gives me more privacy, which I really appreciate after a long day at work.

Do you live in an apartment or a house?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I live in an apartment. It is quite compact, but it has everything I need as a student, like a desk, a small kitchen, and a decent internet connection.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I live in an apartment building close to my office. It is convenient because there is security, parking, and a small grocery store downstairs.

Do you prefer living in a house or an apartment?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

For now, I prefer an apartment because it is easier to maintain and usually closer to campus. In the future, though, I might prefer a house if I have a family.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

At this stage of my life, I prefer an apartment. It suits my busy schedule because I do not have to spend much time on repairs, cleaning, or looking after a garden.

What kinds of accommodation do you live in?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I live in a shared student apartment. Each of us has a small bedroom, and we share the kitchen and living area, so it feels both affordable and sociable.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I live in a one-bedroom serviced apartment. It is fairly modern and low-maintenance, which is exactly what I need because my work schedule can be unpredictable.

Can you describe the place where you live?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It is a modest apartment on the fourth floor of an older building. The furniture is simple, but the place gets plenty of natural light, so it feels more comfortable than it looks at first.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

My apartment is small but well-organised. It has a bedroom, a living room, and a little balcony where I keep a few plants, which makes the place feel less boxed in.

Please describe the room you live in.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

My room is quite small, but I have tried to make it practical. There is a study desk by the window, a single bed, and a shelf where I keep my books and class materials.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

My bedroom is simple and tidy, with a queen-sized bed and a small work corner. I try not to clutter it because I want it to be a place where I can properly relax.

What part of your home do you like the most?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I like the desk area in my room the most. It is where I study, watch lectures, and sometimes have video calls with my family, so it feels like my own little corner.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

My favourite part is the balcony. It is not very big, but I can sit there with a cup of coffee in the morning and get some fresh air before work.

What's your favorite room in your apartment or house?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

My favourite room is probably my bedroom because it gives me privacy. Since I share the apartment with others, having a quiet personal space is really important.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I would say the living room. It is where I unwind after work, watch a film, or call my friends, so it is the most relaxing part of the apartment.

What room does your family spend most of the time in?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Back at my family home, we spend most of our time in the living room. My parents usually watch the news there, and I sit with them whenever I am home during the holidays.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

When my family comes over, we usually gather in the living room. It is the most comfortable space for chatting, eating snacks, and catching up with each other.

What do you usually do in your apartment?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually study, cook simple meals, and rest there. On weekends, my roommates and I sometimes watch movies together or order food when we are too lazy to go out.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I mostly relax, prepare meals, and do a bit of housework. Occasionally, I also work from home, so I need the apartment to be quiet enough for online meetings.

What makes you feel pleasant in your home?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

Small things make it pleasant, like clean bedding, enough sunlight, and a tidy desk. When the apartment is organised, I feel much less stressed about my studies.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

For me, it is the sense of calm. After dealing with traffic and deadlines, coming back to a clean, quiet space helps me mentally switch off.

How long have you lived there?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

I have lived there for almost a year. I moved in at the beginning of my second year because it was much closer to campus than my previous place.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I have lived in my current apartment for about two years. I chose it mainly because it is close to work and the rent was reasonable when I first moved in.

Do you plan to live there for a long time?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

Probably not for a very long time. It is suitable while I am studying, but after graduation I may move to another area depending on where I find a job.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I may stay there for another year or two, but not permanently. If my income increases, I would like to move to a slightly bigger place with a proper home office.

Are the transport facilities to your home very good?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

Yes, they are fairly good. There are bus stops nearby, and I can also ride my motorbike to university in about ten minutes, which is very convenient.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

They are decent, but traffic can still be frustrating during rush hour. The good thing is that my apartment is close enough to the office, so my commute is usually manageable.

What's the difference between where you are living now and where you have lived in the past?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

In the past, I lived with my family in a bigger house, so there was more space and less responsibility. Now, I live in a smaller shared apartment, but it has taught me to be more independent.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I used to live with my parents, where everything felt more spacious and familiar. Now my apartment is smaller, but it is closer to work and gives me more freedom over my daily routine.

What kind of house or apartment do you want to live in in the future?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

In the future, I would like to live in a bright apartment with a balcony and a separate study area. It does not need to be huge, but it should feel peaceful and practical.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I would love to own a modern apartment with two bedrooms, good soundproofing, and enough space for a home office. Since remote work is becoming more common, that would be extremely useful.

Do you think it is important to live in a comfortable environment?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, definitely. A comfortable living environment affects my mood and concentration, so it can make a real difference to how well I study.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Absolutely. If your home is noisy, cramped, or messy, it is hard to recharge properly, and that can eventually affect your performance at work.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
rented apartment	n phr	/ˈren.tɪd əˈpɑːt.mənt/	a flat paid for monthly by a tenant	căn hộ thuê
compact	adj	/kəmˈpækt/	small but arranged efficiently	nhỏ gọn
low-maintenance	adj	/ˌləʊ ˈmeɪn.tən.əns/	requiring little time or effort to look after	ít tốn công chăm sóc
natural light	n phr	/ˈnætʃ.ər.əl laɪt/	sunlight that enters a room	ánh sáng tự nhiên
clutter	v	/ˈklʌt.ər/	to fill a space with too many things	làm bừa bộn
unwind	v	/ʌnˈwaɪnd/	to relax after stress or work	thư giãn
switch off	phr v	/swɪtʃ ɒf/	to stop thinking about work or stress	ngừng nghĩ về công việc/căng thẳng
commute	n	/kəˈmjuːt/	the journey between home and work or school	quãng đường đi học/đi làm
soundproofing	n	/ˈsaʊndˌpruːfɪŋ/	material or design that blocks noise	khả năng cách âm
recharge	v	/ˌriːˈtʃɑːdʒ/	to regain energy after being tired	nạp lại năng lượng

1.4 The City You Live In

What city do you live in?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I currently live in Da Nang because my university is there. It is a coastal city, so life feels a bit more relaxed than in the really crowded urban centres.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I live in Ho Chi Minh City at the moment. It is the biggest business hub in Vietnam, and I moved here mainly because there are more career opportunities in my field.

Do you like this city? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I like it a lot. It is lively enough for students, with cafes, beaches, and shopping areas, but it is still not too chaotic, so I can focus on my studies.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I do, although it can be exhausting. The city is energetic and full of opportunities, so if you are ambitious and willing to work hard, it can be a very rewarding place to live.

Is this city your permanent residence?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Not necessarily. I live here for university now, but I may move after graduation depending on where I can find a suitable job.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

For now, yes, but I am not sure whether it will be permanent. My career is here at the moment, but in the long run I might move somewhere quieter.

How long have you lived in this city?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I have lived here for nearly two years. I moved here when I started university, and it took me a few months to get used to living away from home.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I have lived in Ho Chi Minh City for about three years. At first, the traffic and pace of life were a bit overwhelming, but now I have adapted to them.

Are there big changes in this city?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, there are. New apartment buildings, cafes, and tourist services are appearing quite quickly, so the city feels more modern every year.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Definitely. There are new office towers, shopping malls, and metro lines under development, although the rapid growth also brings problems like congestion and higher living costs.

What's the weather like where you live?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It is usually warm and sunny, which is nice for going to the beach. However, the rainy season can be quite intense, and storms sometimes make travelling around difficult.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Ho Chi Minh City is hot most of the year, with a clear rainy season. I do not mind the heat too much, but sudden downpours during rush hour can be really inconvenient.

Are the people friendly in the city?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, generally speaking. People in Da Nang are quite approachable, and I have found that shop owners, neighbours, and even strangers are usually willing to help.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I would say people are friendly but also very busy. They may not stop for long conversations, but in everyday situations they are usually open, direct, and helpful.

Is the city friendly to children and old people?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

To some extent, yes. There are parks, beaches, and safe public spaces, but some roads are still quite busy, so parents and older people need to be careful when crossing streets.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Not completely. There are good hospitals and services, but the traffic, noise, and crowded pavements can be difficult for children and elderly people.

Are there people of different ages living in this city?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, definitely. There are students, young workers, families, and retired people, especially because Da Nang is both a university city and a comfortable place to settle down.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, Ho Chi Minh City has people of all ages. You can see young professionals rushing to work, students hanging out after class, and older residents running small shops in local neighbourhoods.

Do you often see your neighbors?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but mostly in passing. I see them in the hallway or near the entrance of the apartment building, and we usually just smile or say a quick hello.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Not very often. I live in an apartment building where people keep to themselves, so I might see my neighbours in the lift, but we rarely have proper conversations.

Would you recommend your city to others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, especially to students or people who want a balanced lifestyle. Da Nang is affordable, scenic, and not too stressful, which makes it a pleasant place to live.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I would recommend Ho Chi Minh City to people who are career-oriented and enjoy a fast-paced lifestyle. It is not the easiest city to live in, but it offers a lot of room to grow.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
urban centre	n phr	/ˈɜː.bən 'sen.tər/	a busy central city area	trung tâm đô thị
business hub	n phr	/ˈbɪz.nəs hʌb/	an important centre for business activity	trung tâm kinh doanh
chaotic	adj	/keɪ'ɒt.ɪk/	confused, busy, and lacking order	hỗn loạn
rewarding	adj	/rɪ'wɔː.dɪŋ/	giving satisfaction or benefits	đáng giá, thỏa mãn
overwhelming	adj	/ˌəʊ.və'wel.mɪŋ/	too intense or difficult to deal with	choáng ngợp
congestion	n	/kən'dʒes.tʃən/	overcrowding, especially traffic	sự tắc nghẽn
downpour	n	/ˈdaʊn.pɔːr/	a heavy fall of rain	trận mưa lớn
approachable	adj	/ə'prəʊ.tʃə.bəl/	friendly and easy to talk to	dễ gần
keep to oneself	idiom	/kiːp tuː wʌn'self/	to avoid much social interaction	sống khép kín, ít giao tiếp
career-oriented	adj	/kə'reɪ.ɔː.ri.en.tɪd/	focused on career development	định hướng sự nghiệp

1.5 The Area You Live In

Do you live in a noisy or a quiet area?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I would say it is fairly quiet, especially at night. During the day, there is some traffic because many students live nearby, but it is not noisy enough to disturb my study routine.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

My area is a bit noisy because it is close to a main road and several office buildings. Still, my apartment is on a higher floor, so the noise is manageable most of the time.

Do you like the area that you live in?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do. It is close to my university, affordable food stalls, and a few cafes, so it is very convenient for student life.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, overall I like it. It is not the most peaceful neighbourhood, but it is practical because I can get to work quickly and run errands without travelling too far.

Where do you like to go in that area?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I often go to a small coffee shop near my apartment. It has a quiet upstairs space, so I usually study there when I need a change of scenery.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually go to a nearby convenience store or a small gym after work. On weekends, I sometimes visit a brunch place in the area because it helps me unwind.

Are the people in your neighborhood nice and friendly?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, most of them are quite friendly. The food stall owners near my building even remember what I usually order, which makes the area feel more welcoming.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

They are polite, though people tend to keep to themselves. In a busy city, I think that is normal, but whenever I need help, the security guards and shopkeepers are approachable.

Do you know any of your neighbours?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I know a few students who live on the same floor. We are not extremely close, but we sometimes chat in the hallway or lend each other small things like chargers.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Only a few, to be honest. I recognise the people who live next door and we greet each other in the lift, but our conversations are usually very brief.

Do you know any famous people in your area?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Not personally. I have heard that a few local influencers sometimes film videos at cafes nearby, but I have never actually met anyone famous there.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

No, I do not know any famous people in my area. There are some successful business owners around, but they are not celebrities in the usual sense.

What are some changes in the area recently?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Recently, several new cafes and convenience stores have opened because more students are moving into the area. It is becoming livelier, but luckily it still feels quite safe.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

There has been a lot of construction recently, especially new apartment blocks and office spaces. It makes the area more modern, but it also causes dust and traffic jams from time to time.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
disturb	v	/dɪ'stɜ:b/	to interrupt or make someone lose focus	làm phiền, gây gián đoạn
manageable	adj	/'mæn.ɪ.dʒə.bəl/	possible to deal with without too much difficulty	có thể kiểm soát được
run errands	v phr	/rʌn 'er.əndz/	to do small necessary tasks outside the home	đi làm việc vặt
change of scenery	n phr	/tʃeɪndʒ əv 'si:.nər.i/	a different place or environment	thay đổi không gian
unwind	v	/ʌn'waɪnd/	to relax after stress or work	thư giãn
welcoming	adj	/'wel.kəm.ɪŋ/	friendly and pleasant	thân thiện, dễ chịu
keep to themselves	idiom	/ki:p tu: ðəm'selvz/	to avoid much social interaction	sống khép kín
approachable	adj	/ə'prəʊ.tʃə.bəl/	easy and pleasant to talk to	dễ gần
lively	adj	/'laɪv.li/	full of activity and energy	sôi động
apartment block	n phr	/ə'pɑ:t.mənt blɒk/	a large building containing many apartments	tòa chung cư

PART 1: DAILY LIFE & HABITS

1.6 Morning Time

Do you like getting up early in the morning?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

To be honest, I am not naturally a morning person. I like the feeling of waking up early, but during exam periods I often stay up late, so getting out of bed can be a real struggle.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do, mainly because my workday starts quite early. If I wake up ahead of time, I can have breakfast properly and avoid rushing, which puts me in a better mood.

What do you usually do in the morning?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

On weekdays, I usually wash up, grab a quick breakfast, and check my class schedule. If I have an early lecture, I leave home in a hurry, but when my class starts later, I review my notes for a while.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I normally make coffee, read a few work messages, and plan my priorities for the day. After that, I commute to the office, and I usually listen to a podcast on the way.

What did you do in the morning when you were little? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

When I was little, my mornings were much more structured. My parents woke me up, prepared breakfast, and made sure I packed my school bag because I was not responsible enough to organise everything myself.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

As a child, I usually watched cartoons while eating breakfast before school. It was a small routine that made mornings less boring, especially because I did not really enjoy getting up early back then.

Are there any differences between what you do in the morning now and what you did in the past?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, definitely. In the past, my parents handled most things for me, but now I have to manage my own time, cook simple meals, and make sure I am not late for class.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

There is a big difference. My mornings used to be quite carefree, but now they are more purposeful because I need to prepare mentally for meetings, deadlines, and decisions at work.

Do you spend your mornings doing the same things on both weekends and weekdays? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

No, not really. On weekdays, my mornings are shaped by my timetable, but on weekends I usually sleep in, have a slower breakfast, and maybe do some light revision if I have exams coming up.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

No, my weekend mornings are much more relaxed. I do not check work emails unless something urgent comes up, and I often go for a walk or have brunch with friends.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
morning person	n phr	/ˈmɔː.nɪŋ ˈpɜː.sən/	someone who feels energetic in the morning	người thích buổi sáng/dậy sớm
exam period	n phr	/ɪɡˈzæm ˈpiə.ri.əd/	the time when students take exams	giai đoạn thi cử
ahead of time	adv phr	/əˈhed əv taɪm/	earlier than necessary or expected	sớm hơn dự kiến
put someone in a better mood	v phr	/pʊt ˈsʌm.wʌn ɪn ə ˈbet.ə muːd/	to make someone feel happier	khiến ai có tâm trạng tốt hơn
structured	adj	/ˈstrʌk.tʃəd/	organised and planned clearly	có cấu trúc, có kế hoạch
routine	n	/ruːˈtiːn/	a regular way of doing things	thói quen, lịch trình
carefree	adj	/ˈkeə.friː/	free from worries or responsibilities	vô tư, không lo nghĩ
purposeful	adj	/ˈpɜː.pəs.fəl/	having a clear aim or intention	có mục đích rõ ràng
sleep in	phr v	/sliːp ɪn/	to sleep later than usual	ngủ nướng
brunch	n	/brʌntʃ/	a meal between breakfast and lunch	bữa sáng muộn

1.7 Spare Time

Do you often have free time?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I have some free time, but not as much as I would like. My schedule changes from week to week, and assignments can easily take over my evenings.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Not really during weekdays. After work, commuting, and housework, I usually only have a small window of time to relax before going to bed.

What do you usually do in your spare time?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually watch videos, listen to music, or meet friends at a cafe near campus. If I have more time, I like doing a bit of graphic design because it feels creative and relaxing.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually unwind by going to the gym or watching a light series. Sometimes I cook something simple because it helps me slow down after a demanding day.

Do you have more free time on weekdays or at weekends?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Definitely at weekends. On weekdays, classes and homework take up most of my time, but weekends give me more breathing space to rest or catch up with friends.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I have much more free time at weekends. Weekdays are fairly packed, so Saturday and Sunday are when I can properly recharge and do things at my own pace.

Which day do you have more free time on, Saturday or Sunday?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Usually Sunday. I sometimes have group meetings or part-time tasks on Saturday, while Sunday is the day when I can stay home, tidy my room, and prepare for the next week.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I would say Sunday. Saturday is often filled with errands or social plans, but Sunday feels quieter, so I can sleep a bit longer and enjoy a slower day.

Would you like to have more free time in the future?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, absolutely. I would like to have more time for hobbies and exercise because at the moment I sometimes feel that my life revolves too much around deadlines.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I would. I do not want endless free time, but I would like a healthier balance where I can pursue personal interests without feeling guilty about unfinished work.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
take over	phr v	/teɪk 'əʊ.vər/	to occupy or control something completely	chiếm hết, lấn át
small window of time	n phr	/smɔːl 'wɪn.dəʊ əv taɪm/	a short available period	khoảng thời gian ngắn
unwind	v	/ʌn'waɪnd/	to relax after stress or work	thư giãn
demanding	adj	/dɪ'mɑːn.dɪŋ/	requiring a lot of effort	đòi hỏi nhiều sức lực
breathing space	n phr	/'briː.ðɪŋ speɪs/	time or room to rest and think	khoảng nghỉ, không gian để thở
recharge	v	/ˌriː'tʃɑːdʒ/	to regain energy	nạp lại năng lượng
at my own pace	adv phr	/æt maɪ əʊn peɪs/	at a speed that suits me	theo nhịp độ của riêng mình
run errands	v phr	/rʌn 'er.əndz/	to do small necessary tasks	làm việc vặt
revolve around	phr v	/rɪ'vɒlɪv ə'raʊnd/	to have something as the main focus	xoay quanh
unfinished work	n phr	/ʌn'fɪn.ɪʃt wɜːk/	tasks that have not been completed	công việc chưa hoàn thành

1.8 Day Off

When was the last time you had a few days off?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The last time was after my final exams last semester. I had almost a week without classes, so I went back home, slept a lot, and spent some proper time with my family.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I had a few days off during the last public holiday. I did not travel anywhere far, but I used the time to rest, sort out personal errands, and catch up on sleep.

What do you usually do when you have days off?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually slow down and do things I cannot fit into a normal school week. I might meet friends, watch a series, or simply stay at home and recharge.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

On my days off, I try not to think too much about work. I usually clean my apartment, go to a cafe, exercise a little, and maybe have dinner with friends in the evening.

What would you like to do if you had a day off tomorrow?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

If I had a day off tomorrow, I would probably go to the beach in the morning and then study lightly in the afternoon. That would give me a nice balance between relaxation and responsibility.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I would love to have a slow morning, make breakfast at home, and then get a massage or go for a swim. I think one quiet day like that would help me reset mentally.

Do you usually spend your days off with your parents or with your friends?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It depends. If I am back in my hometown, I spend most of my time with my parents, but during the semester I usually hang out with friends because we live close to each other.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I spend them with both, but probably more often with friends because my parents live in another city. Still, I call my family regularly, especially when I have a more relaxed day.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
final exams	n phr	/ˈfaɪ.nəl ɪɡˈzæmz/	important exams at the end of a term	kỳ thi cuối kỳ
public holiday	n phr	/ˌpʌb.lɪk ˈhɒl.ə.deɪ/	a national day off work or school	ngày nghỉ lễ
sort out	phr v	/sɔːt aʊt/	to organise or deal with something	sắp xếp, xử lý
catch up on sleep	v phr	/kætʃ ʌp ɒn sliːp/	to sleep more after not sleeping enough	ngủ bù
slow down	phr v	/sləʊ daʊn/	to become less busy or active	chậm lại, nghỉ nhịp
recharge	v	/ˌriːˈtʃɑːdʒ/	to regain energy	nạp lại năng lượng
reset mentally	v phr	/ˌriːˈset ˈmen.təl.i/	to refresh one's mind	làm mới tinh thần
hang out	phr v	/hæŋ aʊt/	to spend relaxed time with others	đi chơi, tụ tập

1.9 Having a Break

How often do you take a rest or a break?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I try to take a short break every hour when I am studying. If I study for too long without stopping, my concentration drops and I end up reading the same paragraph again and again.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually take two or three short breaks during the workday. They are not long, maybe just five or ten minutes, but they help me stay focused and avoid feeling drained.

What do you usually do when you are resting?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually stretch, drink water, or scroll through my phone for a few minutes. Sometimes I step outside for fresh air, especially when I have been staring at my laptop for too long.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I often walk around the office, make a cup of tea, or chat briefly with a colleague. I try not to open social media too much because it can easily turn a short break into a long distraction.

Do you take a nap when you are taking your rest?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, sometimes, especially after lunch or during exam weeks. A short nap of around twenty minutes can make me feel much more alert without making me too sleepy afterwards.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Not very often on workdays because there is no suitable place for it. But on weekends, I do enjoy taking a quick nap in the afternoon if I feel physically tired.

How do you feel after taking a nap?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

If the nap is short, I feel refreshed and ready to study again. But if I sleep for too long, I wake up groggy and it actually becomes harder to concentrate.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

A good nap makes me feel recharged and calmer. It is almost like pressing a reset button, especially after a busy morning or a stressful week.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
concentration	n	/ˌkɒn.sən'treɪ.ʃən/	the ability to focus	sự tập trung
end up	phr v	/end ʌp/	to finally be in a situation	rốt cuộc là
drained	adj	/dreɪnd/	very tired and low on energy	kiệt sức
stretch	v	/stretʃ/	to extend the body or muscles	duỗi người, giãn cơ
distraction	n	/dɪ'stræk.ʃən/	something that takes attention away	sự xao nhãng
alert	adj	/ə'leɪt/	awake and able to think clearly	tỉnh táo
physically tired	adj phr	/ˈfɪz.ɪ.kəl.i 'taɪəd/	tired in the body	mệt về thể chất
refreshed	adj	/rɪ'freʃt/	feeling rested and energetic again	sảng khoái
groggy	adj	/ˈgrɒɡ.i/	weak or confused after sleep	uể oải sau khi ngủ
press a reset button	idiom	/pres ə 'ri:.set 'bʌt.ən/	to start again with a clearer mind	như khởi động lại tinh thần

1.10 Going Out

Do you always take your mobile phone with you when going out?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, almost always. I use my phone for maps, messages, online payments, and even checking my class group chat, so leaving it at home would make me feel a bit disconnected.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, definitely. My phone is essential because I need it for work calls, banking apps, ride-hailing services, and keeping in touch with colleagues or clients.

Do you often bring cash with you?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually bring a small amount of cash, just in case. Most places accept bank transfers now, but some food stalls near my university still prefer cash.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Not much, to be honest. I mainly pay by card or e-wallet, but I still keep some cash in my wallet for parking fees or small street-food places.

How often do you use cash?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I use cash a few times a week. It is mostly for inexpensive things like breakfast, photocopying documents, or buying snacks from small vendors.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I use cash less and less these days. Digital payments are faster and easier to track, so cash is more of a backup option for me now.

Do you bring food or snacks with you when going out?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Sometimes I do, especially when I have a long day at university. I might bring a sandwich or some biscuits because buying food on campus every day can add up.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Only occasionally. If I know I will be stuck in meetings or traffic, I may carry a protein bar or some nuts, but usually I just buy something nearby.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
disconnected	adj	/ˌdɪs.kəˈnek.tɪd/	not connected or out of touch	mất kết nối
essential	adj	/ɪˈsen.ʃəl/	extremely important or necessary	thiết yếu
ride-hailing service	n phr	/ˈraɪdˌheɪ.lɪŋ 'sɜː.vɪs/	an app-based transport service	dịch vụ gọi xe công nghệ
just in case	adv phr	/dʒʌst ɪn keɪs/	as a precaution	phòng khi cần
e-wallet	n	/iː ˌwɒl.ɪt/	a digital wallet for payments	ví điện tử
vendor	n	/ˈven.dər/	a person who sells things	người bán hàng
backup option	n phr	/ˈbæk.ʌp ˈɒp.ʃən/	an alternative used if needed	phương án dự phòng
add up	phr v	/æd ʌp/	to gradually become a large amount	cộng dồn thành nhiều
protein bar	n phr	/ˈprəʊ.tiːn bɑːr/	a snack bar high in protein	thanh đồ ăn giàu đạm

1.11 Walking

Do you walk a lot?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, quite a lot, especially around campus. My classrooms, library, and favourite cafe are all within walking distance, so walking is part of my daily routine.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Not as much as I should. I sit at a desk for most of the day, so I try to walk after work or during lunch breaks to stay a bit more active.

Where did you go for a walk lately?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

A few days ago, I walked along the beach with one of my classmates after our evening lecture. It was breezy and quiet, so it helped me clear my head.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Recently, I went for a walk around a park near my apartment. I only walked for about twenty minutes, but it was enough to loosen up after sitting in meetings all day.

Did you often go outside to have a walk when you were a child?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I did. When I was little, my parents often took me for walks around the neighbourhood after dinner because it was a simple way for the family to spend time together.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, quite often. I grew up in a quieter area, so I used to walk or ride a bike with other kids in the neighbourhood almost every afternoon.

Why do people like to walk in parks?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I think parks give people a break from screens and traffic. The fresh air, trees, and open space make walking feel more relaxing than just walking along a busy road.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

People like parks because they offer a rare sense of calm in crowded cities. Walking there can reduce stress, improve mood, and make people feel healthier without needing expensive equipment.

Where would you like to take a long walk if you had the chance?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I would love to take a long walk along a coastal road at sunset. I think the sea breeze and the view would make it feel peaceful rather than tiring.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

If I had the chance, I would take a long walk in a quiet mountain town like Da Lat. The cool weather and slower pace would be a nice escape from city life.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
within walking distance	adv phr	/wɪ'ðɪn 'wɔː.kɪŋ 'dɪs.təns/	close enough to walk to	trong khoảng cách đi bộ
daily routine	n phr	/'deɪ.li ruː'tiːn/	regular activities done every day	thói quen hằng ngày
breezy	adj	/'briː.zi/	pleasantly windy	có gió nhẹ, thoáng mát
clear my head	v phr	/kliə məɪ hed/	to feel mentally calmer and clearer	làm đầu óc tỉnh táo
loosen up	phr v	/'luː.sən ʌp/	to relax tight muscles or tension	thư giãn, giãn cơ
open space	n phr	/'əʊ.pən speɪs/	an outdoor area without many buildings	không gian mở
sense of calm	n phr	/sens əv kɑːm/	a feeling of peace	cảm giác bình yên
coastal road	n phr	/'kəʊ.stəl rəʊd/	a road near or along the sea	đường ven biển
sea breeze	n phr	/siː briːz/	a light wind from the sea	gió biển
escape from city life	n phr	/'ɪskeɪp frəm 'sɪt.i laɪf/	a break from urban pressure	thoát khỏi nhịp sống thành phố

PART 1: PERSONAL PREFERENCES & ACTIVITIES

1.12 Hobby

Do you have any hobbies?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, my main hobby is graphic design. I started doing it for fun, but now I sometimes design posters for student clubs, so it feels both enjoyable and useful.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I like cooking and going to the gym. Cooking helps me relax after work, while exercising keeps me from feeling too stiff after sitting at a desk all day.

Did you have any hobbies when you were a child?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I used to draw a lot when I was little. I could spend hours copying cartoon characters, and I think that was where my interest in design first came from.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Definitely. When I was a child, I loved collecting stickers and playing badminton with neighbours. They were simple hobbies, but they made my childhood feel very active and social.

Do you have a hobby that you've had since childhood?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, drawing is the one hobby that has stayed with me. The tools have changed from coloured pencils to design software, but the basic interest is still the same.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I still enjoy badminton, although I do not play as often as before. Whenever I have time, I book a court with friends because it reminds me of my childhood.

Do you have the same hobbies as your family members?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Not exactly. My parents prefer gardening and watching TV, while I am more into creative and digital activities, but we all enjoy listening to music at home.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Partly, yes. My mother enjoys cooking, and I think I picked up that habit from her, although I prefer trying quick modern recipes rather than traditional dishes that take hours.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
graphic design	n phr	/ˈɡræf.ɪk dɪˈzaɪn/	the art of creating visual materials	thiết kế đồ họa
for fun	adv phr	/fə ˈfʌn/	for enjoyment, not as work	để giải trí
stiff	adj	/stɪf/	physically tight or hard to move	cứng cơ, nhức mỏi
copying cartoon characters	v phr	/ˈkɒp.i.ɪŋ kɑːˈtuːn ˈkær.ək.təz/	drawing animated figures by looking at them	vẽ lại nhân vật hoạt hình
collecting stickers	v phr	/kəˈlektɪŋ ˈstɪk.əz/	gathering decorative adhesive pictures	sưu tầm nhãn dán
design software	n phr	/dɪˈzaɪn ˈsɒft.weər/	computer programs used for design	phần mềm thiết kế
book a court	v phr	/bʊk ə kɔːt/	to reserve a sports court	đặt sân thể thao
be into	phr v	/bi ˈɪn.tuː/	to be interested in something	thích, có hứng thú với
pick up a habit	v phr	/pɪk ʌp ə ˈhæb.ɪt/	to gradually start doing something regularly	hình thành/thấm một thói quen

1.13 Childhood Activities

What were your favourite activities when you were a child?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

When I was a child, I loved playing hide-and-seek and riding my bike around the neighbourhood. Those activities were simple, but they gave me a lot of freedom and excitement.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

My favourite activities were outdoor games like football, badminton, and cycling. I spent a lot of time outside because smartphones were not as common then, so children naturally played together more.

What are your favourite activities?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

These days, I enjoy meeting friends at cafes, designing posters, and watching films. I still like going outside, but I probably spend more time on screen-based activities than I did as a child.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Now my favourite activities are exercising, cooking, and having quiet coffee dates with friends. I prefer activities that help me recover from work rather than ones that require too much planning.

Did you prefer to do activities alone or with a group of people when you were a child?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I preferred doing things with a group. I was quite energetic as a child, and games felt much more exciting when there were cousins or neighbours joining in.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I definitely preferred group activities. I grew up in a neighbourhood where children played outside together every afternoon, so being alone felt a bit boring to me.

Are there any differences between the activities you liked when you were a child and those you like now?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, there are quite a few differences. As a child, I liked active outdoor games, but now I enjoy quieter activities like design, films, and cafe study sessions.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, my preferences have changed a lot. I used to love noisy group games, but now I value activities that are calming and flexible because my work life is already busy enough.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
hide-and-seek	n	/ˌhaɪd ən 'si:k/	a children's game where players hide and one person searches	trò trốn tìm
neighbourhood	n	/'nei.bə.hʊd/	the area around where someone lives	khu phố
outdoor games	n phr	/'aʊt.dɔ: geɪmz/	games played outside	trò chơi ngoài trời
screen-based	adj	/skri:n beɪst/	involving phones, computers, or screens	dựa trên màn hình
recover from work	v phr	/'rɪkʌv.ər frəm wɜ:k/	to regain energy after working	hồi sức sau công việc
energetic	adj	/'en.ə'dʒet.ɪk/	full of energy	năng động
joining in	phr v	/'dʒɔɪ.nɪŋ 'ɪn/	taking part in an activity	tham gia vào
preference	n	/'pref.ər.əns/	something someone likes more than another	sở thích, sự ưu tiên
flexible	adj	/'flek.sə.bəl/	easy to change or adapt	linh hoạt

1.14 Sports Team

Have you ever been part of a sports team?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I was part of my class badminton team in high school. We were not professional or anything, but we practised after class and joined a small school tournament. It was a memorable experience because I learned how to cooperate under pressure, not just play for myself.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I used to play on a company football team for a while. We trained once a week after work and sometimes competed with teams from other departments. I was not the best player, but it was a great way to bond with colleagues outside the office.

Do you like watching team games? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do, especially football and volleyball matches. Team games are exciting because the result can change very quickly, and you can see how players support each other. I also enjoy the atmosphere when everyone is cheering for the same side.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I quite enjoy watching team games, mainly because they are unpredictable. Even if one player is talented, the whole team still has to communicate well and follow a strategy. That makes the match more dramatic than just watching one person perform alone.

Are team sports popular in your culture?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, definitely. In Vietnam, football is probably the most popular team sport, and people get incredibly excited during big regional tournaments. At school, students also play basketball, volleyball, and badminton, so team sports are a normal part of student life.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, team sports are quite popular, especially football. Many companies organise football clubs or sports days because they see them as a way to build teamwork. Even people who do not play often enjoy watching national matches with friends or family.

What are the differences between team sports and individual sports?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The biggest difference is responsibility. In team sports, you have to think about other players and adjust your actions to fit the group, while individual sports depend more on self-discipline and personal performance. I think both are useful, but they train different kinds of skills.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Team sports require communication, trust, and coordination, whereas individual sports rely more on personal focus and consistency. In a team, one mistake can affect everyone, but one good decision can also lift the whole group. That is why I think team sports teach people a lot about collaboration.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
school tournament	n phr	/sku:l 'tʊə.nə.mənt/	a sports competition at school	giải đấu ở trường
cooperate	v	/kəʊ'pɪ.ə.reɪt/	to work together with others	hợp tác
bond with colleagues	v phr	/bɒnd wɪð 'kɒl.i:gz/	to build closer relationships with coworkers	gắn kết với đồng nghiệp
unpredictable	adj	/,ʌn.prɪ'dɪk.tə.bəl/	difficult to know what will happen	khó đoán
strategy	n	/'stræt.ə.dʒi/	a planned way to achieve a goal	chiến thuật, chiến lược
regional tournament	n phr	/'ri:.dʒən.əl 'tʊə.nə.mənt/	a competition within a region	giải đấu khu vực
self-discipline	n	/,self 'dɪs.ə.plɪn/	the ability to control oneself and keep working	tính kỷ luật tự thân
coordination	n	/kəʊ'ɔ:di'nei.jən/	the ability to organise actions together	sự phối hợp
collaboration	n	/kə,læb.ə'reɪ.jən/	working together to achieve something	sự cộng tác

1.15 Reading

Do you like reading?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but my reading habits have changed quite a lot. I do not read novels as much as I used to, but I read articles, course materials, and short posts related to business or design almost every day. Reading helps me pick up new ideas without feeling like I am forcing myself to study.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do, although I have less time for it now. I mostly read business books, newsletters, and articles about marketing or productivity. Even twenty minutes of reading before bed helps me slow down and learn something useful.

Do you prefer to read on paper or on a screen?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

For textbooks, I prefer reading on paper because it is easier to highlight important points and write notes in the margin. However, for quick articles or lecture slides, reading on a screen is more convenient. So I would say it depends on the purpose.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I prefer screens for work because documents are easier to search, edit, and share. But when I read for pleasure, I still like printed books because they feel less distracting. A physical book also helps me stay away from notifications for a while.

Do you prefer scanning or detailed reading?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It depends on what I am reading. If I only need the main idea, I scan the text first to save time, especially before class discussions. But for exam preparation, I have to read carefully because small details can make a big difference.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

At work, I often scan reports first because I need to find key numbers or conclusions quickly. After that, if something looks important, I go back and read it in detail. This approach helps me avoid wasting time on information that is not relevant.

When do you need to read carefully, and when not?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I need to read carefully when I study academic materials, exam instructions, or assignment requirements. If I miss one small condition, I might lose marks. But when I read social media posts or simple news updates, scanning is usually enough.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I read carefully when dealing with contracts, client briefs, or important emails because misunderstanding one sentence could cause real problems. On the other hand, I do not read

every newsletter or casual update word by word. For those, I just skim for anything useful.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
reading habit	n phr	/ˈriː.dɪŋ ˈhæb.ɪt/	a regular way of reading	thói quen đọc
course materials	n phr	/kɔːs məˈtɪə.ri.əlz/	learning resources for a subject	tài liệu học tập
newsletter	n	/ˈnjuːz.let.ər/	an email or document with updates	bản tin định kỳ
highlight	v	/ˈhaɪ.laɪt/	to mark important information	đánh dấu nổi bật
margin	n	/ˈmɑː.dʒɪn/	the blank space at the side of a page	lề trang
printed book	n phr	/ˈprɪn.tɪd bʊk/	a physical book on paper	sách in
scan the text	v phr	/skæn ðə tekst/	to read quickly for key information	đọc lướt để tìm ý chính
exam preparation	n phr	/ɪɡˈzæm ˌprep.əˈreɪ.ʃən/	studying before an exam	ôn thi
client brief	n phr	/ˈklaɪ.ənt briːf/	instructions or requirements from a client	bản yêu cầu của khách hàng
skim	v	/skɪm/	to read quickly without focusing on every word	đọc lướt

1.16 Typing

Do you prefer typing or handwriting?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I prefer typing for most school tasks because it is much faster and easier to edit. When I write essays or prepare group reports, typing helps me organise ideas more clearly. That said, I still use handwriting when I need to memorise something because it feels more personal and focused.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I definitely prefer typing because almost everything at work is digital now. Emails, reports, meeting notes, and project updates all need to be typed and shared quickly. Handwriting is still useful for quick brainstorming, but it is not practical for my daily workload.

When did you learn how to type on a keyboard?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I think I learned properly when I was in secondary school. At first, I typed very slowly and looked at the keyboard all the time, but I improved naturally by doing homework and chatting with friends online.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I started learning in high school, but I became much faster at university when I had to write assignments regularly. Later, work made my typing even more efficient because I had to reply to emails and prepare documents under time pressure.

Do you type on a desktop or laptop keyboard every day?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I type on my laptop almost every day. I use it for taking notes, writing assignments, making presentations, and sometimes doing freelance design work. Without a keyboard, my study routine would be much less efficient.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I use a laptop keyboard every working day, and sometimes an external keyboard at the office. I type so much that I have become quite sensitive to whether a keyboard feels comfortable or not.

How do you improve your typing?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I improve mostly through practice rather than formal training. The more I type essays, messages, and notes, the faster I become. I also try to type without looking at the keyboard because that saves a surprising amount of time.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

For me, accuracy matters as much as speed, so I try to slow down slightly when writing important emails. I also use keyboard shortcuts and templates for repetitive tasks. Over

time, those small habits make typing feel smoother and more professional.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
edit	v	/ˈed.ɪt/	to change or correct written content	chỉnh sửa
memorise	v	/ˈmem.ə.raɪz/	to learn something so you can remember it	ghi nhớ
brainstorming	n	/ˈbreɪn.stɔː.mɪŋ/	quickly producing ideas	động não, lên ý tưởng
practical	adj	/ˈpræk.tɪ.kəl/	useful and suitable for real situations	thực tế, tiện dụng
under time pressure	adv phr	/ˈʌn.də taɪm ˈpreʃ.ər/	with limited time available	dưới áp lực thời gian
external keyboard	n phr	/ɪkˈstɜː.nəl ˈkiː.bɔːd/	a separate keyboard connected to a device	bàn phím rời
accuracy	n	/ˈæk.jə.rə.si/	correctness without mistakes	độ chính xác
keyboard shortcut	n phr	/ˈkiː.bɔːd ˈʃɔːt.kʌt/	a key combination that performs an action quickly	phím tắt
repetitive task	n phr	/rɪˈpet.ə.tɪv tɑːsk/	a task done again and again	nhiệm vụ lặp đi lặp lại

PART 1: VIEWS, PLACES & TRAVEL

1.17 Views

Have you seen an unforgettable and beautiful view or scenery?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I once watched the sunrise from My Khe Beach in Da Nang, and it was genuinely unforgettable. The sky slowly turned pink and orange, and the sea looked almost silver in the early light. It was a simple moment, but it made me feel unusually calm before a busy school day.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, the most memorable view I have seen was from a rooftop bar in Ho Chi Minh City at night. The whole skyline was lit up, and you could see streams of traffic moving below. It made the city look chaotic but strangely beautiful at the same time.

Do you like taking pictures of different views?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do, especially when I travel or go to the beach with friends. I am not a professional photographer, but I like capturing views because photos help me remember how I felt at that moment. Sometimes I also use those pictures as design inspiration.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but I do it more casually now. If I see a nice sunset, a quiet street, or an interesting city view, I take a quick photo on my phone. I rarely post everything online, but I like keeping those images as small memories.

Do you prefer views in urban areas or rural areas?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I prefer rural or natural views because they feel more relaxing. Urban views can be impressive, especially at night, but nature gives me a stronger sense of peace. When I am stressed with exams, seeing the sea or mountains helps me clear my mind.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I enjoy both, but I slightly prefer rural views because my daily life is already surrounded by buildings and traffic. A view of rice fields, hills, or a quiet lake feels like a real escape. It reminds me that life does not always have to move so fast.

Do you prefer views in your own country or in other countries?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

For now, I prefer views in my own country because I have not travelled abroad much. Vietnam has beaches, mountains, old towns, and rice terraces, so there is already a lot to explore. I would love to see foreign landscapes too, but I do not feel I have fully discovered

my own country yet.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I appreciate both, but views in my own country feel more meaningful to me. When I see places like Ha Long Bay or the mountains in Da Lat, there is a sense of familiarity and pride. Foreign views can be stunning, but local scenery often feels closer to my heart.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
unforgettable	adj	/ˌʌn.fə'get.ə.bəl/	impossible to forget	không thể quên
sunrise	n	/ˈsʌn.raɪz/	the time when the sun appears in the morning	bình minh
skyline	n	/ˈskaɪ.laɪn/	the outline of buildings against the sky	đường chân trời đô thị
stream of traffic	n phr	/stri:m əv 'træf.ɪk/	a continuous flow of vehicles	dòng xe cộ
capture	v	/ˈkæp.tʃər/	to record something in a photo or video	ghi lại, chụp lại
design inspiration	n phr	/dɪ'zaɪn ˌɪn.spə'reɪ.ʃən/	ideas that help creative design	cảm hứng thiết kế
sense of peace	n phr	/sens əv pi:s/	a feeling of calmness	cảm giác bình yên
rice terrace	n phr	/raɪs 'ter.əs/	stepped fields used for growing rice	ruộng bậc thang
familiarity	n	/fə'mɪl.i'ær.ə.ti/	the feeling of knowing something well	sự thân thuộc
stunning	adj	/ˈstʌn.ɪŋ/	extremely beautiful or impressive	tuyệt đẹp, ấn tượng

1.18 Scenery

Do you look out the window at the scenery when travelling by bus or car?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do it almost automatically, especially when I travel by bus between my hometown and university. Looking at the roads, fields, and small houses outside makes the journey feel shorter. It is also a nice break from staring at my phone for hours.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I often look out the window, particularly when I am not driving myself. Even in the city, I like observing little details such as street vendors, old buildings, and changing neighbourhoods. It gives me something calm to focus on during traffic.

What are the most beautiful sights you have seen while travelling?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

One of the most beautiful sights I have seen was the view from Hai Van Pass. You can see the mountains on one side and the sea on the other, which feels incredibly dramatic. I remember taking lots of photos because the scenery looked different every few minutes.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

For me, the most beautiful sight was in Da Lat, where the hills were covered in mist early in the morning. It was quiet, cool, and completely different from the busy city where I work. That kind of scenery makes me feel as if time slows down.

Do you prefer the mountains or the sea?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I slightly prefer the sea because I grew up near the coast. The sound of waves and the open horizon make me feel relaxed, especially when I am stressed about school. Mountains are beautiful too, but the sea feels more familiar to me.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I prefer the mountains these days. Since I spend most of my time in a hot, crowded city, cool mountain air feels refreshing. I also like the slower pace in mountain towns, where people seem less rushed.

Do you like to take scenery pictures?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I like taking scenery pictures, although I mostly use my phone. I enjoy capturing sunsets, beaches, and quiet streets because those photos can bring back the mood of a trip. Sometimes I even use them as inspiration for my design projects.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but I do not take photos obsessively. If a view is really striking, I take a few pictures and then put my phone away so I can enjoy it properly. I think photos are nice, but they should not replace the actual experience.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
automatically	adv	/ɔː.tə'mæt.ɪ.kəl.i/	without thinking much	một cách tự nhiên, tự động
street vendor	n phr	/stri:t 'ven.dər/	someone who sells goods on the street	người bán hàng rong
dramatic	adj	/drə'mæt.ɪk/	impressive and exciting to look at	ấn tượng, hùng vĩ
mist	n	/mɪst/	thin cloud close to the ground	sương mù mỏng
open horizon	n phr	/'əʊ.pən hə'raɪ.zən/	a wide view where the sky meets the land or sea	đường chân trời rộng mở
refreshing	adj	/'rɪ.freʃ.ɪŋ/	making someone feel fresh and energetic	sảng khoái
capture	v	/'kæp.tʃər/	to record something in a photo	ghi lại, chụp lại
striking	adj	/'straɪ.kɪŋ/	very noticeable or impressive	nổi bật, gây ấn tượng mạnh
actual experience	n phr	/'æk.tʃu.əl ɪk'spiəri.əns/	the real moment or event itself	trải nghiệm thực tế

1.19 Building

Are there tall buildings near your home?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

There are a few tall apartment buildings near where I live, but the area is not packed with skyscrapers. Most buildings around my university are medium-sized, like cafes, dormitories, and small offices. I actually prefer that because the streets feel more open and less overwhelming.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, there are quite a few tall buildings near my apartment. I live close to a business district, so there are office towers, hotels, and modern apartment blocks all around. It looks impressive at night, but it also means the area can be crowded during rush hour.

Do you take photos of buildings?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Sometimes, especially if the building has an interesting design or colourful walls. As someone who likes graphic design, I notice shapes, patterns, and lighting quite a lot. I do not post every picture, but I keep them for inspiration.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, occasionally. When I travel, I like taking photos of old buildings, temples, or unusual modern architecture. They tell you a lot about a place's history and personality, not just how it looks.

Is there a building that you would like to visit?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I would like to visit the Bitexco Financial Tower in Ho Chi Minh City. I have seen it in photos many times, and I think the observation deck would give me a great view of the city. It would also be interesting to compare that skyline with the quieter cityscape in Da Nang.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I would love to visit the Sydney Opera House one day. It is not just famous; its design is so distinctive that you can recognise it immediately. I think seeing it in person would be much more impressive than seeing it online.

Do you want to live in a tall building?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Maybe in the future, but not necessarily now. Living in a tall building could be convenient and offer a nice view, but I would worry about high rent and crowded lifts. As a student, practicality matters more than having a fancy address.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I would not mind living in a tall building if it were well-managed. A high-floor apartment can offer better views, more security, and useful facilities like a gym or swimming pool. However, I would still want the building to be quiet and not too densely populated.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
skyscraper	n	/ˈskaɪˌskreɪ.pər/	a very tall building	nhà chọc trời
overwhelming	adj	/ˌəʊ.vəˈwel.mɪŋ/	too intense or crowded to handle easily	choáng ngợp
business district	n phr	/ˈbiz.nəs ˈdɪs.trɪkt/	an area with many offices and companies	khu thương mại/văn phòng
apartment block	n phr	/əˈpɑːt.mənt blɒk/	a large building with many apartments	tòa chung cư
pattern	n	/ˈpæt.ən/	a repeated design or arrangement	họa tiết, kiểu mẫu
architecture	n	/ˈɑː.kɪ.tek.tʃər/	the design and style of buildings	kiến trúc
observation deck	n phr	/ˌɒb.zəˈveɪ.ʃən dek/	a high area for viewing a city or landscape	đài quan sát
cityscape	n	/ˈsɪt.i.skeɪp/	the visual appearance of a city	cảnh quan thành phố
distinctive	adj	/dɪˈstɪŋk.tɪv/	clearly different and easy to recognise	đặc trưng, dễ nhận ra
densely populated	adj phr	/ˈdens.li ˈpɒp.jə.leɪ.tɪd/	having many people in a small area	đông dân, mật độ cao

1.20 Museum

Do you think museums are important?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I think museums are important because they make history and culture easier to understand. Reading about the past in a textbook can feel quite dry, but seeing real objects, photos, and old documents makes the story more vivid. For students like me, museums can turn learning into something more memorable.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, definitely. Museums preserve things that might otherwise be forgotten, such as traditional crafts, war memories, or local customs. I also think they give busy adults a chance to slow down and reconnect with history instead of only focusing on work and modern life.

Are there many museums in your hometown?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

There are a few, but I would not say there are many. In Da Nang, for example, there are museums about Cham sculpture, local history, and fine arts. They are not huge, but they are still worth visiting if someone wants to understand the city better.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

My hometown has some interesting museums, though not as many as a capital city. The most famous ones are connected to local history and culture. I think they could attract more visitors if they became more interactive and better promoted online.

Do you often visit a museum?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Not very often, to be honest. I usually visit museums when my teachers organise a field trip or when friends from another city come to visit. I enjoy the experience once I am there, but it is not something I do every weekend.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I do not visit museums regularly, mainly because my schedule is quite full. However, when I travel, I try to include at least one museum because it helps me understand the place beyond restaurants and tourist spots.

When was the last time you visited a museum?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The last time was a few months ago when I visited the Museum of Cham Sculpture with some classmates. We had to do a small assignment about local culture, but I ended up enjoying it more than expected. The carvings were detailed, and the atmosphere was very quiet.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The last time was during a short trip to Hanoi last year. I visited the Vietnam Museum of Ethnology, and I was impressed by how it showed the lifestyles of different ethnic groups. It was educational without feeling too heavy.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
preserve	v	/prɪˈzɜːv/	to protect something from being lost or damaged	bảo tồn
vivid	adj	/ˈvɪv.ɪd/	clear, detailed, and easy to imagine	sinh động
reconnect with history	v phr	/ˌriː.kəˈnekt wɪð ˈhɪs.tər.i/	to feel connected to the past again	kết nối lại với lịch sử
Cham sculpture	n phr	/tʃɑːm ˈskʌlp.tʃər/	carved art from Cham culture	điêu khắc Chăm
interactive	adj	/ˌɪn.təˈrækt.tɪv/	involving active participation	có tính tương tác
field trip	n phr	/fiːld trɪp/	an educational visit outside school	chuyến đi thực tế
tourist spot	n phr	/ˈtʊə.rɪst spɒt/	a place popular with visitors	điểm du lịch
carving	n	/ˈkɑː.vɪŋ/	an object or pattern cut from wood or stone	tác phẩm chạm khắc
ethnic group	n phr	/ˈeθ.nɪk gruːp/	a group sharing culture or ancestry	nhóm dân tộc

1.21 Public Places

Do you often go to public places with your friends?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, quite often. My friends and I usually go to cafes, parks, shopping centres, or the beach because those places are affordable and easy to reach. Public places are also more comfortable for students because no one has to host everyone at home.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but mostly on weekends. My friends and I often meet at coffee shops, bookstores, or walking streets because they are convenient meeting points. After a long workweek, I prefer public places that are lively but not too noisy.

Have you ever talked with someone you don't know in public places?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, a few times. For example, I once talked to a tourist at the beach because she needed directions, and we ended up chatting briefly about local food. It was not a deep conversation, but it felt friendly and natural.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, occasionally. I have spoken to strangers in cafes, airports, and queues, usually about simple things like directions or whether a seat is taken. I do not start conversations all the time, but I do not mind them when they happen naturally.

Do you wear headphones in public places?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I often wear headphones when I am on the bus or studying in a cafe. They help me block out background noise and focus better. But if I am walking on a busy street, I keep the volume low for safety.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, especially when I commute or work in a shared space. Headphones help me create a small private bubble in a crowded environment. Still, I try to stay aware of what is happening around me, especially in traffic.

Would you like to see more public places near where you live?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I would love to see more green spaces and study-friendly public areas. Many students need places where they can relax or work without spending too much money. A clean park or public reading space would be really useful.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, definitely. I think cities need more parks, benches, and pedestrian-friendly areas, not just malls and office buildings. Good public spaces make daily life healthier and give people somewhere to breathe outside their apartments.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
affordable	adj	/ə'fɔː.də.bəl/	reasonably priced	giá cả phải chăng
host	v	/həʊst/	to invite and receive guests	tiếp đón, tổ chức tại nhà
meeting point	n phr	/'miː.tɪŋ pɔɪnt/	a place where people agree to meet	điểm hẹn
directions	n	/dɪ'rek.fənz/	instructions for how to get somewhere	chỉ đường
queue	n	/kjuː/	a line of people waiting	hàng chờ
block out	phr v	/blɒk aʊt/	to stop something from being heard or noticed	chặn, loại bỏ
private bubble	n phr	/'praɪ.vət 'bʌb.əl/	a personal mental space in public	không gian riêng tư nhỏ
green space	n phr	/griːn speɪs/	an area with grass, trees, or plants	không gian xanh
pedestrian-friendly	adj	/pə'des.tri.ən 'frend.li/	safe and pleasant for walkers	thân thiện với người đi bộ
somewhere to breathe	n phr	/'sʌm.weə tuː briːð/	a place to relax and feel less crowded	nơi để thư giãn, dễ thở hơn

1.22 Crowded Place

Is the city where you live crowded?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It can be crowded in certain areas, especially near schools, markets, and tourist spots. But compared with larger cities like Ho Chi Minh City, Da Nang still feels quite manageable. I think the crowd is noticeable, but it is not overwhelming most of the time.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, Ho Chi Minh City is definitely crowded. During rush hour, the roads are packed with motorbikes, cars, and buses, so even a short trip can take longer than expected. I have got used to it, but it can still be tiring.

Is there a crowded place near where you live?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, there is a small food street near my apartment that gets crowded in the evening. A lot of students go there for cheap meals and milk tea after class. It is lively, but sometimes it is hard to find a seat.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, there is a shopping mall and a busy intersection near my building. It is convenient because there are many shops and restaurants, but the area becomes quite congested after office hours.

Do you like crowded places?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It depends on the situation. I enjoy crowded places when I am with friends and the atmosphere is exciting, like at a festival or night market. But if I am tired or need to study, crowds make me feel distracted and uncomfortable.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Not really, especially after work. I deal with enough noise and traffic during the day, so I prefer quieter places in my free time. That said, I do not mind crowds if I am attending a concert or a special event.

When was the last time you were in a crowded place?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The last time was probably last weekend when I went to a night market with my classmates. It was packed with people, food stalls, and music, but the atmosphere was fun. We had to move slowly, but we still enjoyed trying different snacks.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The last time was a few days ago during my commute home. The road near my office was extremely crowded because it was raining, and everyone seemed to leave work at the same time. It was not enjoyable, but it was a typical city experience.

Do most people like crowded places?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I think many young people like crowded places when they are lively and entertaining. Crowds can make events feel more energetic. However, most people would probably dislike crowds when they cause long queues, noise, or stress.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I do not think people like crowds in general; they like the activities that happen in crowded places. For example, they may enjoy concerts, festivals, or shopping streets, but not the pushing, waiting, or traffic that comes with them.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
tourist spot	n phr	/ˈtʊə.rɪst spɒt/	a place popular with visitors	điểm du lịch
manageable	adj	/ˈmæn.ɪ.dʒə.bəl/	possible to deal with	có thể kiểm soát được
rush hour	n phr	/ˈrʌʃ aʊər/	the busiest travel time of the day	giờ cao điểm
packed with	adj phr	/pækt wɪð/	full of people or things	chật kín
intersection	n	/ˌɪn.təˈsek.ʃən/	a place where roads cross	giao lộ
congested	adj	/kənˈdʒes.tɪd/	blocked or overcrowded	tắc nghẽn, đông đúc
distracted	adj	/dɪˈstræk.tɪd/	unable to focus	mất tập trung
night market	n phr	/naɪt ˈmɑː.kɪt/	an evening market with food and goods	chợ đêm
long queue	n phr	/lɒŋ kjuː/	a long line of people waiting	hàng dài chờ đợi

PART 1: SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL TOPICS

1.23 Chatting / Conversation

Do you like chatting with friends?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I really enjoy chatting with friends because it helps me relax after classes. Sometimes we talk for hours about university life, relationships, or small problems that happened during the day. Those conversations make me feel less stressed and more connected.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do, although I have less time for it than before. After work, chatting with close friends helps me switch off from deadlines and office pressure. Even a short conversation can make the day feel lighter.

What do you usually chat about with friends?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

We usually chat about classes, exams, part-time jobs, and weekend plans. We also talk about movies, music, and funny things we see online. The topics are not always serious, but they help us stay close.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

With my friends, I usually talk about work, travel plans, food, and personal goals. Sometimes we complain a little about stress, but we also encourage each other. I think adult conversations are more practical, but still very comforting.

Do you prefer to chat with a group of people or with only one friend?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It depends on my mood. Group chats are fun when I want jokes and quick updates, but one-on-one conversations feel more meaningful. If I need advice, I definitely prefer talking to just one close friend.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I prefer one-on-one conversations most of the time. Group conversations can be lively, but they are sometimes noisy and surface-level. With one friend, I can talk more honestly and listen properly.

Do you prefer to communicate face-to-face or via social media?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I prefer face-to-face communication when the topic is important because I can read the other person's expression and tone. But for everyday updates, social media is more convenient. It lets me keep in touch with friends even when we are busy.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

For serious conversations, I prefer meeting face-to-face because it feels more sincere and avoids misunderstandings. However, for quick messages or arranging plans, social media is obviously faster. I think both have their place.

Do you argue with friends?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but not very often. Most arguments are about group assignments or different opinions, and they usually cool down quickly. I think a little disagreement is normal as long as people apologise and do not take things personally.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Occasionally, yes. With close friends, disagreements happen because everyone has different values and experiences. I try to talk things through calmly because I do not want a small issue to damage a long friendship.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
switch off	phr v	/swɪtʃ ɒf/	to stop thinking about work or stress	ngừng nghĩ về áp lực/công việc
stay close	v phr	/steɪ kləʊs/	to maintain a close relationship	giữ thân thiết
personal goal	n phr	/'pɜː.sən.əl ɡəʊl/	an aim in one's personal life	mục tiêu cá nhân
comforting	adj	/'kʌm.fə.tɪŋ/	making someone feel better	an ủi, dễ chịu
one-on-one conversation	n phr	/ˌwʌn ɒn ˈwʌn ˌkɒn.vəˈseɪ.ʃən/	a conversation between two people	cuộc trò chuyện riêng hai người
surface-level	adj	/'sɜː.fɪs ˌlev.əl/	not deep or personal	hời hợt, không sâu
keep in touch	v phr	/kiːp ɪn tʌtʃ/	to continue communicating	giữ liên lạc
misunderstanding	n	/ˌmɪs.ʌn.dəˈstændɪŋ/	a failure to understand correctly	sự hiểu nhầm
cool down	phr v	/kuːl daʊn/	to become calmer after anger	bình tĩnh lại
talk things through	v phr	/tɔːk θɪŋz θruː/	to discuss a problem carefully	nói chuyện để giải quyết vấn đề

1.24 Sharing

Did your parents teach you to share when you were a child?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, they did, mostly through small everyday situations. For example, if I had snacks or toys, my parents encouraged me to share them with my cousins instead of keeping everything to myself. At the time, I did not think much about it, but it helped me become less selfish.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, my parents taught me that sharing is part of being considerate. They did not give long lectures, but they showed it through actions, like sharing food with neighbours or helping relatives when they were in difficulty. I think that influenced the way I treat people now.

What kind of things do you like to share with others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I like sharing study materials, useful websites, and small tips about assignments with my classmates. I also enjoy sharing food when we study together because it makes the atmosphere more relaxed. It is a simple way to support each other.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I like sharing practical information, such as good restaurants, useful apps, or work-related resources. At work, I also share templates or lessons I have learned from past projects. It saves other people time and creates a more cooperative environment.

What kind of things are not suitable for sharing?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I think personal passwords, private messages, and other people's secrets are definitely not suitable for sharing. Even among close friends, there should be clear boundaries. Sharing too much can easily damage trust.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Confidential work information should not be shared, especially client data or internal plans. Personal problems also need care; not everything should be discussed with everyone. I think mature sharing means knowing what to say and what to keep private.

Do you have anything to share with others recently?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Recently, I shared my revision notes with a classmate who missed a few lessons because she was sick. They were not perfect, but they helped her catch up before a quiz. It felt good because I knew I would appreciate the same help if I were in her situation.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Recently, I shared a project checklist with a newer colleague. She was preparing her first campaign and seemed a bit overwhelmed, so I sent her the template I usually use. It was a small thing, but it made her work much easier.

Who is the first person you would like to share good news with?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The first person would probably be my mother. Whenever something good happens, like getting a high score or being accepted into an activity, I want to tell her first because she always sounds genuinely happy for me.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I would usually share good news with my family first, especially my parents. They have supported me through stressful periods, so when something positive happens at work, I want them to feel proud too.

Do you prefer to share news with your friends or your parents?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It depends on the kind of news. If it is about school or personal worries, I often tell my friends first because they understand my daily life better. But for important achievements, I prefer sharing them with my parents.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

For casual updates, I prefer telling friends because the conversation feels lighter. For major decisions or meaningful news, I usually talk to my parents because their advice is more grounded and thoughtful.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
keep something to oneself	idiom	/ki:p 'sʌm.θɪŋ tu: wʌn'self/	to not share something with others	giữ cho riêng mình
selfish	adj	/'sel.fɪʃ/	caring only about oneself	ích kỷ
considerate	adj	/kən'sɪd.ər.ət/	thoughtful about other people's feelings	biết nghĩ cho người khác
study materials	n phr	/'stʌd.i mə'trɪ.ə.ri.əlz/	resources used for learning	tài liệu học tập
cooperative environment	n phr	/kəʊ'ɒp.ər.ə.tɪv ɪn'vaɪ.rən.mənt/	a place where people work together well	môi trường hợp tác
boundary	n	/'baʊn.dər.i/	a limit in relationships or behaviour	ranh giới
confidential	adj	/ˌkɒn.fɪ'den.ʃəl/	private and not to be shared	bảo mật, riêng tư
catch up	phr v	/kætʃ ʌp/	to reach the same level after falling behind	bắt kịp
overwhelmed	adj	/ˌəʊ.və'welmd/	feeling unable to deal with too much	quá tải, choáng ngợp
grounded	adj	/'graʊn.dɪd/	sensible and realistic	thực tế, chín chắn

1.25 Happy Things

Is there anything that has made you feel happy lately?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I recently got a good result on a presentation that I had worked really hard on. My group spent several nights preparing the slides and practising, so hearing positive feedback from the teacher made me feel relieved and proud.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, a small thing actually. My team finished a campaign ahead of schedule, and the client gave us very positive feedback. It was not a huge achievement, but it made the whole week feel more worthwhile.

What made you happy when you were little?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

When I was little, simple things made me happy, like getting a new comic book or going out for ice cream with my parents. I did not need anything expensive. What mattered most was the feeling of being cared for.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

As a child, I was happiest when my family spent time together on weekends. Even a short trip to the park or a simple meal outside felt exciting. Looking back, I think attention mattered more than gifts.

What do you think will make you feel happy in the future?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

In the future, I think I will feel happy if I can find a job that suits my strengths and gives me room to grow. I also hope to stay close to my family and maintain a few genuine friendships. For me, happiness is not only about success but also stability.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I think a balanced life will make me happy in the future. I want to keep developing professionally, but I also want enough time for health, family, and travel. If I can avoid burning out while still moving forward, I will consider that a good life.

When do you feel happy at work? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I do not work full-time yet, but when I do freelance design, I feel happy when a client likes my work. It is encouraging because it shows that my skills are improving. It also makes me feel more confident about future jobs.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I feel happy at work when a project runs smoothly and the team communicates well. It is satisfying to see everyone's effort come together into a real result. I also feel happy when my manager recognises my contribution.

Do you feel happy when buying new things?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, sometimes, especially if it is something useful like a good notebook, a new backpack, or a device that helps me study. But the happiness does not last long if I buy things impulsively. I try to think carefully before spending money.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but only when the item has real value for my life. For example, buying a comfortable chair for my home office made me genuinely happy because I use it every day. Random shopping, though, usually gives only a short burst of excitement.

Do you think people are happy when buying new things?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I think many people feel happy at first because buying something new gives them a sense of reward. However, that feeling can fade quickly if the item is not meaningful or useful. So shopping can create temporary happiness, but not deep happiness.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, to some extent. New things can make people feel refreshed or successful, especially after hard work. But if someone depends on shopping to feel happy all the time, it can become unhealthy and expensive.

Do you prefer to watch happy or sad movies?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually prefer happy or heartwarming movies because they help me relax after studying. That said, I do watch sad films sometimes if the story is meaningful. I just need to be in the right mood for them.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I prefer happy movies most of the time. After a stressful week, I want something light, funny, or uplifting rather than a film that makes me emotionally drained. But a well-made sad movie can still be powerful.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
positive feedback	n phr	/ˈpɒz.ə.tɪv ˈfiːd.bæk/	encouraging comments about someone's work	phản hồi tích cực
worthwhile	adj	/ˌwɜːθˈwaɪl/	worth the time or effort	đáng công, xứng đáng
being cared for	n phr	/ˈbiː.ɪŋ keəd fɔːr/	receiving care and attention	được quan tâm chăm sóc
genuine friendship	n phr	/ˈdʒen.ju.ɪn ˈfrend.ʃɪp/	sincere friendship	tình bạn chân thành
burn out	phr v	/bɜːn aʊt/	to become exhausted from too much work	kiệt sức
recognise someone's contribution	v phr	/ˈrek.əg.naɪz ˈsʌm.wʌnz ˌkɒn.trɪˈbjʊː.ʃən/	to notice and value someone's effort	ghi nhận đóng góp của ai
impulsively	adv	/ɪmˈpʌl.sɪv.li/	suddenly, without careful thought	một cách bốc đồng
short burst of excitement	n phr	/ʃɔːt bɜːst əv ɪkˈsaɪt.mənt/	a brief feeling of pleasure	cảm giác hào hứng ngắn ngủi
temporary happiness	n phr	/ˈtem.pər.ər.i ˈhæp.i.nəs/	happiness that does not last long	niềm vui tạm thời
heartwarming	adj	/ˈhɑːtˌwɔː.mɪŋ/	making someone feel happy and touched	ấm áp, cảm động

1.26 Doing Something Well

Do you have an experience when you did something well?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I once did really well in a group presentation for my marketing class. I was responsible for the visual design and part of the speaking, so I spent several evenings preparing the slides and practising. In the end, our group got one of the highest scores, which made me feel that the effort had paid off.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, recently I helped organise a small marketing campaign that performed better than expected. I coordinated the content schedule, checked the data every day, and made quick adjustments when something was not working. When the final results came in, I felt genuinely proud because my decisions had made a visible difference.

Do you have an experience when your teacher thought you did a good job?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, my English teacher once praised me for writing a clear and well-structured essay. I had rewritten it several times, so hearing that feedback was very encouraging. It also gave me more confidence in my writing, which used to be one of my weaker skills.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Back when I was at university, one lecturer complimented my research project because I used real survey data instead of only relying on theory. That comment stayed with me because it taught me the value of practical evidence. I still try to use that approach in my work now.

Do you often tell your friends when they do something well?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I try to. If my friends give a good presentation or handle a difficult assignment well, I usually tell them directly. A simple compliment can boost someone's confidence, especially when they have put in a lot of effort.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I think it is important. At work and in friendships, people often notice mistakes more than achievements, so I try to acknowledge good effort when I see it. It makes relationships more positive and supportive.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
visual design	n phr	/ˈvɪʒ.u.əl dɪˈzaɪn/	the appearance and layout of visual materials	thiết kế hình ảnh
pay off	phr v	/peɪ ɒf/	to produce a successful result	đem lại kết quả xứng đáng
coordinate	v	/kəʊˈɔː.dɪ.nert/	to organise different parts of an activity	phối hợp, điều phối
visible difference	n phr	/ˈvɪz.ə.bəl ˈdɪf.ər.əns/	a clear and noticeable change	sự khác biệt rõ ràng
well-structured	adj	/ˌwel ˈstrʌk.tʃəd/	organised clearly and logically	có cấu trúc tốt
practical evidence	n phr	/ˈpræk.tɪ.kəl ˈev.ɪ.dəns/	real information used to support an idea	bằng chứng thực tế
boost someone's confidence	v phr	/buːst ˈsʌm.wʌnz ˈkɒn.fɪ.dəns/	to make someone feel more confident	nâng cao sự tự tin
acknowledge	v	/əkˈnɒl.ɪdʒ/	to recognise or show appreciation for something	ghi nhận
supportive	adj	/səˈpɔː.tɪv/	giving help or encouragement	mang tính hỗ trợ

1.27 Staying with Old People

Do you enjoy spending time with old people?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, especially with my grandparents. They tell stories about the past that I would never learn from school, and their way of looking at life is very different from mine. Sometimes the conversations are slow, but they feel warm and meaningful.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do. Older people often have a calmer perspective, and talking with them reminds me not to rush through everything. I especially enjoy conversations with older relatives because they give advice without trying to compete or show off.

Have you ever worked with old people?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Not in a formal job, but I once volunteered at a community event where we helped elderly people use smartphones. It was a bit challenging at first because we had to explain things very patiently. But it was rewarding when they managed to make video calls by themselves.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I have worked with older colleagues in several projects. Some of them were not as quick with new digital tools, but they had strong judgment and a lot of professional experience. I learned that different generations can complement each other well.

Are you happy to work with people who are older than you?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I think I would be happy to. Older people may have more experience and patience, so I could learn a lot from them. Of course, communication styles might be different, but that is also a good chance to become more adaptable.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, definitely. Working with older people can be very useful because they often understand workplace politics, client expectations, and long-term planning better than younger employees. As long as both sides respect each other, the cooperation can be very effective.

What are the benefits of being friends with or working with old people?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The biggest benefit is learning from their life experience. Older people can help young people avoid careless mistakes because they have already gone through similar situations. They also tend to be more patient listeners, which is valuable when you need honest advice.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I think older people bring stability and perspective. They may not always follow trends quickly, but they often make decisions more carefully. Being around them can help younger people become more mature, responsible, and less impulsive.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
perspective	n	/pə'spek.tɪv/	a way of seeing or thinking about something	góc nhìn
meaningful	adj	/'miː.nɪŋ.fəl/	important or emotionally valuable	có ý nghĩa
show off	phr v	/ʃəʊ ɒf/	to try to impress others	khoe khoang
elderly people	n phr	/'el.dəl.i 'piː.pəl/	old people, used politely	người cao tuổi
rewarding	adj	/rɪ'wɔː.dɪŋ/	satisfying and worthwhile	đáng giá, thỏa mãn
judgment	n	/'dʒʌdʒ.mənt/	the ability to make sensible decisions	khả năng phán đoán
complement each other	v phr	/'kɒm.plɪ.mənt iːtʃ 'ʌð.ər/	to work well together by balancing strengths	bổ trợ cho nhau
adaptable	adj	/ə'dæp.tə.bəl/	able to adjust to new situations	dễ thích nghi
workplace politics	n phr	/'wɜːk.pleɪs 'pɒl.ə.tɪks/	informal power relationships at work	quan hệ/quyền lực nơi công sở
impulsive	adj	/ɪm'pʌl.sɪv/	acting suddenly without careful thought	bốc đồng

1.28 Life Stages

Do you enjoy being the age you are now?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do. Being a university student gives me a lot of freedom to explore different interests, meet new people, and make mistakes without feeling that everything is too serious. Of course, there is pressure about exams and the future, but overall I think this is an exciting stage of life.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I quite enjoy my current age. I am old enough to be independent and make my own decisions, but still young enough to learn quickly and take professional risks. It feels like a period where I can build the foundation for the life I want later.

At what age do you think people are the happiest?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I do not think there is one perfect age for everyone. Some people are happiest as children because they have fewer worries, while others feel happiest in their twenties or thirties when they have more independence. For me, happiness depends more on relationships and health than on age itself.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I would say people may be happiest when they have both stability and freedom, maybe in their thirties or forties. By then, many people understand themselves better and have more control over their choices. But honestly, any age can be happy if someone has a meaningful life.

How do people remember each stage of their lives?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

People usually remember life stages through major events, photos, and the people they spent time with. For example, I remember childhood through family trips and school activities, while my university years are linked to friends, exams, and living away from home. Small details can bring back a whole period of life.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I think people remember different stages through turning points, such as graduating, getting their first job, moving cities, or starting a family. Music, places, and even certain smells can also trigger memories. That is why ordinary moments sometimes become meaningful later.

What did you often do with your friends in your childhood?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

When I was a child, I often played outdoor games with friends after school. We rode bicycles, played hide-and-seek, and sometimes invented silly games in the neighbourhood.

Looking back, those activities were simple but full of energy and imagination.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I used to spend a lot of time outside with neighbourhood friends. We played football, cycled around, and bought cheap snacks from small shops. It was a very social childhood, and I think those memories are warmer because we were not glued to screens all day.

Do you have any plans for the next five years?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I have a few plans. I want to graduate with a good degree, improve my English, and gain real work experience through internships. If possible, I would also like to study abroad or at least travel more before settling into a full-time job.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I want to develop my career and move into a more senior position. I also hope to save more money, improve my health, and maybe buy my own apartment. I do not have every detail figured out, but I want my next five years to be more intentional.

What do you think is the most important at the moment?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

At the moment, the most important thing is building a strong base for the future. That means studying seriously, developing useful skills, and keeping good relationships with people around me. I do not want to focus only on grades and forget about personal growth.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

For me, the most important thing right now is balance. I want to perform well at work, but I also need to protect my health and relationships. If I only chase career progress and ignore everything else, I think I will regret it later.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
stage of life	n phr	/stɛɪdʒ əv laɪf/	a period in someone's life	giai đoạn cuộc đời
professional risk	n phr	/prəˈfeʃ.ən.əl rɪsk/	a risk related to work or career	rủi ro nghề nghiệp
stability	n	/stəˈbɪl.ə.ti/	a state of being steady and secure	sự ổn định
turning point	n phr	/'tɜː.nɪŋ pɔɪnt/	an event that causes an important change	bước ngoặt
trigger memories	v phr	/'trɪg.ər 'mem.ər.ɪz/	to cause memories to return	gợi lại ký ức
hide-and-seek	n	/ˌhaɪd ən 'siːk/	a children's game of hiding and finding	trò trốn tìm
glued to screens	adj phr	/gluːd tuː skriːnz/	spending too much time on devices	dán mắt vào màn hình
internship	n	/'ɪn.tɜːn.ʃɪp/	short-term work experience for students	kỳ thực tập
intentional	adj	/ɪn'ten.ʃən.əl/	done with clear purpose	có chủ đích
personal growth	n phr	/'pɜː.sən.əl grəʊθ/	development of character and abilities	sự phát triển cá nhân

PART 1: OBJECTS, SHOPPING & CONSUMPTION

1.29 Gifts

What gift have you received recently?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Recently, I received a new backpack from my older sister. It was not a luxury item, but it was very practical because my old one was almost falling apart. I use it every day for university, so it feels like a thoughtful gift.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The most recent gift I received was a coffee mug from a colleague. It was a small birthday gift, but I liked it because she remembered that I drink coffee every morning. Sometimes simple gifts feel more personal than expensive ones.

Have you ever received a great gift?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, one of the best gifts I have received was a drawing tablet. My parents gave it to me when they noticed I was interested in digital design. It was meaningful because it showed that they supported my hobby, not just my academic studies.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, my parents once gave me a good office chair when I started working from home more often. It may not sound exciting, but it made my daily life much more comfortable. I appreciated it because it was both useful and caring.

Have you ever sent handmade gifts to others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I have made handmade cards for my friends on their birthdays. I usually draw something personal on the card and write a short message inside. It takes more time than buying a card, but it feels warmer.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but not very often. I once baked cookies and packed them nicely for a close friend's birthday. I am not a professional baker, but she appreciated the effort, which made the gift feel special.

What do you consider when choosing a gift?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually think about the person's interests and daily needs. Since I am a student, I also have to consider my budget, so I prefer gifts that are affordable but still personal. A useful gift with a small personal touch is ideal for me.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I consider practicality, taste, and the relationship I have with the person. For close friends, I might choose something more personal, while for colleagues I prefer safe and professional gifts. I also try to avoid anything that might feel too generic.

Do you think you are good at choosing gifts?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I think I am fairly good at it because I pay attention to small details. If a friend mentions something they like, I try to remember it for later. I am not always perfect, but I usually choose gifts that people can actually use.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I would say I am decent at choosing gifts, especially for people I know well. I try not to buy random things at the last minute. Instead, I look for something practical, tasteful, and connected to the person's lifestyle.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
fall apart	phr v	/fɔ:l ə'pɑ:t/	to become broken or unusable	hỏng, rách, xuống cấp
thoughtful gift	n phr	/'θɔ:t.fəl ɡɪft/	a gift chosen with care	món quà chu đáo
luxury item	n phr	/'lʌk.jər.i 'aɪ.təm/	an expensive non-essential thing	món đồ xa xỉ
drawing tablet	n phr	/'drɔ:ɪ.ŋ 'tæb.lət/	a device used for digital drawing	bảng vẽ điện tử
handmade card	n phr	/,hænd'meɪd kɑ:d/	a card made by hand	thiệp thủ công
personal touch	n phr	/'pɜ:.sən.əl tʌtʃ/	a detail that makes something feel personal	dấu ấn cá nhân
practicality	n	/,præk.tɪ'kæl.ə.ti/	usefulness in real life	tính thực dụng
generic	adj	/dʒə'ner.ɪk/	general and not personal or special	chung chung
last minute	adj phr	/,lɑ:st 'mɪn.ɪt/	done just before the deadline	sát giờ, phút chót
tasteful	adj	/'teɪst.fəl/	attractive and showing good judgment	tinh tế, có gu

1.30 Shoes

Do you like buying shoes? How often?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I like buying shoes, but I do not do it very often because I am still on a student budget. I usually buy a new pair only when my old shoes are worn out or when I really need something for a specific occasion. Comfort and price matter more to me than having the latest style.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I quite like buying shoes, especially practical ones for work. I probably buy a new pair every few months, depending on whether my office shoes or sneakers need replacing. Since I walk and commute a lot, I see good shoes as an investment rather than just a fashion item.

Have you ever bought shoes online?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I have bought shoes online a few times, mostly during sales. It is convenient and sometimes cheaper, but the size can be risky because different brands fit differently. I always check reviews carefully before ordering.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I have, especially when I already know the brand and size. Online shopping saves time, but I prefer websites with a clear return policy. Shoes are tricky because they may look good online but feel uncomfortable in real life.

How much money do you usually spend on shoes?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually spend a moderate amount, maybe enough to get a durable pair but not anything too expensive. As a student, I need shoes that can handle walking around campus every day. I would rather buy one reliable pair than several cheap pairs that fall apart quickly.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I am willing to spend a bit more on shoes now than when I was a student. For work shoes, I look for quality and comfort because I may wear them for long hours. Still, I try to avoid overpriced brands unless the quality really justifies the cost.

Which do you prefer, fashionable shoes or comfortable shoes?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I prefer comfortable shoes, although I still want them to look decent. My daily life involves walking between classes, the library, and cafes, so painful shoes would ruin my whole day. If I can find shoes that are both stylish and comfortable, that is ideal.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Comfortable shoes, definitely. Fashion matters to some extent, especially at work, but if the shoes hurt my feet, I will not wear them often. I prefer simple designs that look

professional and can still support a long commute.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
student budget	n phr	/ˈstjuː.dənt ˈbʌdʒ.ɪt/	limited money available to a student	ngân sách sinh viên
worn out	adj	/wɔːn aʊt/	damaged from too much use	bị mòn, cũ hỏng
investment	n	/ɪnˈvest.mənt/	something bought for long-term value	khoản đầu tư
return policy	n phr	/rɪˈtʃːn ˈpɒl.ə.si/	rules for sending a product back	chính sách đổi trả
durable	adj	/ˈdjʊə.rə.bəl/	lasting for a long time	bền
reliable pair	n phr	/rɪˈlaɪ.ə.bəl peər/	a pair that works well and lasts	đôi giày đáng tin cậy
overpriced	adj	/əʊ.vəˈpraɪst/	more expensive than it should be	bị bán quá đắt
justify the cost	v phr	/ˈdʒʌs.tɪ.fai ðə kɒst/	to be worth the money paid	xứng đáng với chi phí
stylish	adj	/ˈstaɪ.lɪʃ/	fashionable and attractive	thời trang, có phong cách
long commute	n phr	/lɒŋ kəˈmjuːt/	a long journey to work or school	quãng đường đi làm/đi học dài

1.31 Advertisement

Do you like advertisements?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It depends on the advertisement. I like ads that are creative, funny, or useful, but I get annoyed when the same ad interrupts my videos again and again. As a student, I also pay attention to ads for courses, apps, or student discounts.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I do not mind advertisements if they are relevant and well-made. Since I work in marketing, I sometimes look at ads professionally and notice the message, design, and target audience. But intrusive ads still bother me, especially when they interrupt something I am trying to read.

What kind of advertising do you like?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I like advertising that tells a short story or has a clever idea. For example, some university or technology ads are memorable because they show real problems and simple solutions. I prefer that to ads that only shout about discounts.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I like ads that feel authentic and emotionally engaging. A good advertisement does not just push a product; it connects the product with a real need or feeling. I also appreciate clean visuals and messages that do not waste the viewer's time.

Do you often see advertisements when you are on your phone or computer?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, all the time. I see ads on YouTube, social media, websites, and even inside some study apps. Sometimes they are useful, but most of the time I scroll past them without thinking.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, constantly. Online ads appear on almost every platform I use, from news websites to social media feeds. Some are surprisingly accurate because they are based on my search history, which is convenient but also a little uncomfortable.

Do you see a lot of advertising on trains or other transport?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I do not take trains often, but I see many ads on buses, taxis, and ride-hailing apps. They are usually for drinks, phone plans, or shopping platforms. I notice them more when I am bored during a long ride.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I see quite a lot of transport advertising, especially on buses and inside ride-hailing cars. Some of it is easy to ignore, but large posters or digital screens can be quite eye-catching.

It is a smart way for brands to reach commuters.

Is there an advertisement that made an impression on you when you were a child?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I still remember some old milk advertisements on TV. They often showed children growing taller, playing sports, and making their parents proud. Looking back, the message was simple, but the music and images were very memorable.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I remember a few emotional Tet advertisements from my childhood. They usually showed family reunions, home-cooked meals, and people returning home after a long year. Even now, those kinds of ads still make me feel nostalgic.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
student discount	n phr	/ˈstjuː.dənt ˈdis.kɑʊnt/	a lower price for students	ưu đãi sinh viên
relevant	adj	/ˈrel.ə.vənt/	closely connected to what someone needs or cares about	phù hợp, liên quan
intrusive	adj	/ɪnˈtruː.sɪv/	annoying because it interrupts private space or attention	gây phiền, xâm phạm
target audience	n phr	/ˈtɑː.ɡɪt ˈɔː.di.əns/	the group an ad is aimed at	đối tượng mục tiêu
authentic	adj	/ɔːˈθen.trɪk/	real and sincere	chân thật
emotionally engaging	adj phr	/ɪˈmeɪʃ.ən.əl.i ɪnˈɡeɪ.dʒɪŋ/	able to attract feelings and attention	thu hút về mặt cảm xúc
search history	n phr	/sɜːtʃ ˈhɪs.tər.i/	records of what someone searched online	lịch sử tìm kiếm
eye-catching	adj	/ˈaɪ.kætʃ.ɪŋ/	visually attractive and noticeable	bắt mắt
commuter	n	/kəˈmjuː.tər/	someone who travels regularly to work or school	người đi làm/đi học hằng ngày
nostalgic	adj	/nɒsˈtæl.dʒɪk/	feeling warm sadness about the past	hoài niệm

1.32 Borrowing / Lending

Have you ever borrowed money from others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but only small amounts. For example, I have borrowed money from friends when I forgot my wallet or needed to pay for lunch quickly. I always try to pay it back as soon as possible because I do not want money to affect friendships.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, a few times, mostly from family rather than friends. When I first moved to the city for work, I borrowed some money from my parents to cover the deposit for my apartment. I paid them back gradually once my salary became more stable.

Have you borrowed books from others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, quite often. I have borrowed textbooks from seniors because some course books are expensive and only needed for one semester. I also borrow novels from friends when they recommend something interesting.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, although less often nowadays. In the past, I borrowed business books from colleagues, especially when I wanted to read something before deciding whether to buy it. These days, I usually read e-books, so borrowing physical books happens less frequently.

Do you like to lend things to others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I do not mind lending small things like stationery, chargers, or books to people I trust. However, I am more careful with expensive items because students can be forgetful. I think lending is fine as long as both people are responsible.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, within reason. I am happy to lend tools, books, or office items to colleagues, but I prefer not to lend anything too personal or costly. Clear communication is important so there is no awkwardness later.

Do you mind if others borrow money from you?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It depends on the amount and the person. If it is a close friend who needs a small amount urgently, I am willing to help. But since I do not have much spare money as a student, I would feel uncomfortable lending large sums.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I do not mind helping close friends or family, but I am cautious. Money can easily create tension in relationships, so I only lend what I can afford to lose. For larger amounts, I would rather discuss the situation carefully first.

How do you feel when people don't return things they borrowed from you?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I feel disappointed, especially if I have to remind them several times. It is not always about the value of the item; it is more about respect. If someone keeps forgetting, I become less willing to lend them things again.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I find it frustrating because it shows a lack of responsibility. If someone borrows something, they should return it without being chased. I may not get angry immediately, but I would definitely trust that person less.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
pay back	phr v	/peɪ bæk/	to return money owed	trả lại tiền đã vay
deposit	n	/dɪ'pɒz.ɪt/	money paid in advance as security	tiền đặt cọc
gradually	adv	/'grædʒ.u.əl.i/	slowly over time	dần dần
textbook	n	/'tekst.bʊk/	a book used for studying a subject	sách giáo trình
stationery	n	/'steɪ.ʃən.ər.i/	pens, paper, and office supplies	văn phòng phẩm
within reason	adv phr	/wɪ'ðɪn 'riː.zən/	within sensible limits	trong giới hạn hợp lý
awkwardness	n	/'ɔː.kwəd.nəs/	an uncomfortable social feeling	sự ngượng ngùng, khó xử
large sum	n phr	/lɑːdʒ sʌm/	a large amount of money	khoản tiền lớn
chase someone	v phr	/tʃeɪs 'sʌm.wʌn/	to repeatedly ask someone to do something	nhắc nhở/đòi nhiều lần
lack of responsibility	n phr	/læk əv rɪ'spɒn.sə'bɪl.ə.ti/	not being responsible enough	sự thiếu trách nhiệm

PART 1: MEMORY, DREAMS & IMAGINATION

1.33 Memory

Are you good at memorising things?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I am fairly good at memorising ideas, but not exact words. For exams, I remember information better when I understand the logic behind it rather than just repeating it. If I only memorise mechanically, I forget everything quite quickly.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I would say my memory is decent, especially for work-related patterns and people's preferences. However, I am not great at remembering random details like phone numbers or passwords. That is why I rely heavily on notes and digital reminders.

Have you ever forgotten something important?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I once forgot the deadline for an online assignment. I realised it only a few hours before the submission closed, so I had to rush and finish it under pressure. Since then, I have become more careful about checking my academic calendar.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I once forgot to reply to an important client email because it got buried under other messages. Nothing terrible happened, but it made me look less professional than I wanted. After that, I started flagging important emails immediately.

What do you need to remember in your daily life?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I need to remember class schedules, assignment deadlines, exam dates, and small personal tasks like paying rent or buying groceries. Student life looks flexible, but there are actually many details to manage. If I do not write things down, I can easily miss something.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I need to remember meetings, deadlines, client requests, and personal errands. Workdays can change quickly, so relying only on memory is risky. I also need to remember birthdays and family plans because those relationships matter outside work.

How do you remember important things?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I usually use a combination of phone reminders and handwritten to-do lists. For study content, I make short summaries and review them several times instead of trying to memorise everything at once. Repetition helps a lot.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I use a digital calendar, task apps, and sometimes sticky notes on my desk. For very important tasks, I set more than one reminder because I do not want to rely on memory alone. It may sound excessive, but it keeps me organised.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
memorise mechanically	v phr	/ˈmem.ə.raɪz məˈkæn.i.kəl.i/	to memorise without real understanding	học thuộc máy móc
decent	adj	/ˈdiː.sənt/	fairly good	khá ổn
digital reminder	n phr	/ˈdɪdʒ.ɪ.təl rɪˈmaɪn.dər/	an electronic alert for a task	lời nhắc điện tử
submission	n	/səbˈmɪʃ.ən/	the act of handing in work	việc nộp bài
academic calendar	n phr	/ˌæk.əˈdem.ɪk ˈkæl.ən.dər/	a school or university schedule	lịch học vụ
buried under messages	adj phr	/ˈber.ɪd ˈʌn.dər ˈmes.ɪ.dʒɪz/	hidden among many messages	bị trôi/lẫn trong nhiều tin nhắn
flag an email	v phr	/flæg ən ˈiː.meɪl/	to mark an email as important	đánh dấu email quan trọng
to-do list	n phr	/təˈduː lɪst/	a list of tasks to complete	danh sách việc cần làm
repetition	n	/ˌrep.əˈtɪʃ.ən/	doing or reviewing something again	sự lặp lại
excessive	adj	/ɪkˈses.ɪv/	more than necessary	quá mức

1.34 Dreams

Can you remember the dreams you had?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Sometimes I can, but not always. I usually remember dreams clearly only when they are strange or connected to something I am worried about, like exams or missing a deadline. After a few minutes, though, the details often fade away.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I remember some dreams, especially when I wake up suddenly in the middle of one. They are often related to work stress, such as being late for a meeting or forgetting an important task. Most of the time, I forget them after breakfast.

Do you share your dreams with others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but only if the dream is funny or unusual. I sometimes tell my roommates in the morning, and we laugh about how random dreams can be. I would not share very personal or scary dreams with everyone, though.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Occasionally, yes. If I have a dream that feels amusing or oddly realistic, I might mention it to a close friend or colleague. But I do not treat dreams too seriously, so I usually just talk about them briefly.

Do you think dreams have special meanings?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

I am not completely sure. I do not believe every dream predicts something, but I do think dreams can reflect our emotions. For example, when I am stressed, my dreams tend to become more chaotic.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I think some dreams may reveal what we are thinking about subconsciously. They do not necessarily have magical meanings, but they can show stress, fear, or hopes that we have not fully processed. So I find them interesting, but I would not base decisions on them.

Do you want to make your dreams come true?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

If you mean life dreams, then yes, definitely. I want to build a stable career, support my family, and travel more in the future. I know those goals will take time, but having them gives me direction.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, of course. My dreams are not unrealistic; I mainly want a meaningful career, good health, and enough financial freedom to live comfortably. I try to turn those dreams into practical plans rather than just wishing for them.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
fade away	phr v	/feɪd ə'weɪ/	to slowly disappear	phai dần, mất dần
work stress	n phr	/wɜ:k stres/	pressure caused by work	căng thẳng công việc
random	adj	/ræn.dəm/	without clear order or reason	ngẫu nhiên
amusing	adj	/ə'mju:.zɪŋ/	funny or entertaining	buồn cười, thú vị
predict	v	/prɪ'dɪkt/	to say what will happen in the future	dự đoán
chaotic	adj	/keɪ'ɒt.ɪk/	confused and disorganised	hỗn loạn
subconsciously	adv	/ˌsʌb'kɒn.jəs.li/	without being fully aware	trong tiềm thức
financial freedom	n phr	/faɪ'næn.ʃəl 'fri:.dəm/	enough money to make life choices freely	tự do tài chính
practical plan	n phr	/'præk.tɪ.kəl plæn/	a realistic plan that can be followed	kế hoạch thực tế

1.35 Taking Photos

Do you like taking photos?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do, especially when I hang out with friends or travel somewhere new. I like taking photos because they help me keep memories of ordinary student life, not just big events. Sometimes a simple cafe picture can remind me of a whole afternoon.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, but I take photos more selectively now. I usually photograph food, city views, or moments with friends and family. Since work life can be repetitive, photos help me notice small enjoyable moments.

Do you like taking selfies?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, occasionally, especially when I am with friends. I do not take selfies every day, but they are fun when we want to capture a mood or remember a trip. I prefer natural selfies rather than heavily edited ones.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Not very much, to be honest. I take selfies when I travel or attend a special event, but I feel awkward doing it too often. I usually prefer taking photos of places or other people.

What is your favourite family photo?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

My favourite family photo is one from a beach trip when I was in secondary school. Everyone looked a bit messy because of the wind, but we were all smiling naturally. It feels special because it captures a time when my whole family was together and relaxed.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

My favourite family photo was taken during Tet a few years ago. We were all standing in front of my grandparents' house, wearing simple but neat clothes. It is not a professional photo, but it reminds me of family warmth and tradition.

Do you want to improve your photography skills?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I would like to improve them, especially composition and lighting. Since I enjoy design, better photography skills would help me create nicer posters and social media content. I do not need to become professional, but I want my photos to look more intentional.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Yes, I do. Good photography is useful for travel, personal branding, and even work presentations sometimes. I would like to learn how to frame shots better instead of just pointing my phone and hoping for the best.

Do you like to print out your photos or just keep them on your phone or camera?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Most of the time, I keep photos on my phone because it is convenient and easy to share. However, I would like to print a few meaningful ones for my desk or scrapbook. Printed photos feel more personal.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

I mostly keep photos digitally because it saves space and is easier to organise. But for important family photos, I think printing them is worth it. A framed photo at home feels warmer than an image hidden in a phone gallery.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
ordinary student life	n phr	/ˈɔː.dən.ər.i 'stjuː.dənt laɪf/	normal daily life as a student	đời sống sinh viên thường ngày
selectively	adv	/sɪˈlek.tɪv.li/	carefully choosing only some things	một cách có chọn lọc
repetitive	adj	/rɪˈpet.ə.tɪv/	happening again and again	lặp đi lặp lại
capture a mood	v phr	/ˈkæp.tʃər ə muːd/	to record a feeling or atmosphere	ghi lại tâm trạng/bầu không khí
heavily edited	adj phr	/ˈhev.i.li 'ed.i.tɪd/	changed a lot using editing tools	chỉnh sửa quá nhiều
composition	n	/ˌkɒm.pəˈzɪʃ.ən/	the arrangement of elements in a photo	bố cục
intentional	adj	/ɪnˈten.ʃən.əl/	done with a clear purpose	có chủ đích
personal branding	n phr	/ˈpɜː.sən.əl 'bræn.dɪŋ/	how someone presents their image professionally	xây dựng thương hiệu cá nhân
frame a shot	v phr	/freɪm ə ʃɒt/	to compose a photo before taking it	căn khung hình
scrapbook	n	/ˈskræp.bʊk/	a book for keeping photos and memories	sổ lưu niệm

PART 1: NATURE, FOOD & SCHOOL LIFE

1.36 Food

What is your favourite food?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

What kind of food did you like when you were young?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Has your favourite food changed since you were a child?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Do you eat different foods at different times of the year?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
word		/pron/		Nghĩa

1.37 Plants

Do you keep plants at home?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

What plant did you grow when you were young?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Do you know anything about growing a plant?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Do Chinese people send plants as gifts?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
word		/pron/		Nghĩa

1.38 Growing Vegetables / Fruits

Are you interested in growing vegetables and fruits?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Do you think it's easy to grow vegetables?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Is growing vegetables popular in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Do many people grow vegetables in your city?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Should schools teach students how to grow vegetables?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
word		/pron/		Nghĩa

1.39 Pets and Animals

Have you ever had a pet before?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

What's your favourite animal? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Where do you prefer to keep your pet, indoors or outdoors?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

What is the most popular animal in China?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
word		/pron/		Nghĩa

1.40 Rules

Are there any rules for students at your school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Do you prefer to have more or fewer rules at school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Do you think students would benefit more from more rules?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Have you ever had a really strict teacher?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Have you ever had a really dedicated teacher?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Would you like to work as a teacher in a rule-free school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

[Nhập câu trả lời vào đây]

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
word		/pron/		Nghĩa

Chương 2

Part 2 & 3: Cue Cards & Discussion Topics

2.1 Describe a city you enjoyed visiting

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a city you enjoyed visiting. You should say:

- Where it is
- When you visited it
- How long you stayed there
- What you did there
- And explain why you enjoyed visiting it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The city I want to talk about is Hoi An, a historic town on the central coast of Vietnam. I visited it last summer with two of my close friends, and we stayed for about four days, which I think was just the right amount of time to explore it properly without rushing.

To be honest, I did not have particularly high expectations going in, but the city surprised me completely. During the day, we wandered through the Ancient Town, which is full of beautifully preserved yellow-painted buildings, old merchant houses, and little wooden shopfronts. We also rented bicycles and rode out to the An Bang beach, which felt refreshingly quiet compared with the busy tourist areas. In the evenings, we joined a lantern-making class, which turned out to be one of the highlights of the whole trip because it was so hands-on and fun.

What made the experience genuinely special was how different the pace of life felt. Back home I am always rushing between lectures and assignments, but in Hoi An everything seemed to slow down. The food was incredible too — we tried Cao Lau and White Rose dumplings, which you apparently cannot get in the same authentic form anywhere else.

Looking back, I think what I loved most was the combination of history, nature, and food all in one place. It is the kind of city that feels alive but not overwhelming, and I would love to go back one day.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The city that immediately comes to mind is Kyoto, Japan, which I visited about two years ago during a Golden Week holiday. I was there for six days in total, travelling with my partner, and it was the first proper international trip we had taken together. Well, Kyoto is famous for its temples and traditional culture, and we tried to make the most of that. We visited Fushimi Inari early in the morning before the crowds arrived,

which meant we had those iconic red torii gates almost to ourselves. We also spent a whole afternoon wandering through the Arashiyama bamboo grove and explored a few quieter neighbourhoods like Gion and Nishiki Market. On one of the days, we actually booked a tea ceremony experience, which was very different from anything I had done before.

What I genuinely appreciated about Kyoto was the sense of order and calm. Coming from Ho Chi Minh City, where everything is loud and fast, Kyoto felt like a complete reset. The streets were clean, the signage was clear, and even the busiest tourist spots had a kind of quiet dignity about them. I think that contrast is what made the trip so refreshing.

From a professional standpoint, I also found it fascinating to observe how the city had managed to preserve its cultural identity while still catering to millions of visitors every year. It gave me a lot to reflect on in terms of sustainable tourism and city planning.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
preserved	adj	/prɪ'zɜ:vɪd/	kept in its original or good condition	được bảo tồn
hands-on	adj	/,hændz 'ɒn/	involving direct practical experience	thực hành trực tiếp
highlight	n	/'haɪ.laɪt/	the most enjoyable or memorable part of something	điểm nổi bật, khoảnh khắc đáng nhớ nhất
authentic	adj	/ɔ:'θen.tɪk/	genuine and original, not copied	chính gốc, xác thực
iconic	adj	/aɪ'kɒn.ɪk/	very famous and easily recognised	mang tính biểu tượng
wandering through	v phr	/'wɒn.dər.ɪŋ θru:/	walking slowly and without a fixed purpose	đi dạo qua
sense of calm	n phr	/sens əv kɑ:m/	a feeling of peace and quietness	cảm giác bình yên
sustainable tourism	n phr	/sə'steɪ.nə.bəl 'tʊə.rɪ.zəm/	tourism that minimises harm to the environment and culture	du lịch bền vững
city planning	n phr	/'sɪ.ti 'plæn.ɪŋ/	the process of organising a city's development	quy hoạch đô thị
cultural identity	n phr	/'kʌl.tʃər.əl aɪ'den.tɪ.ti/	the unique characteristics of a culture	bản sắc văn hóa

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What kinds of facilities do big cities have?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

It can be argued that the defining feature of big cities is the sheer concentration of specialised facilities that would simply be unviable in smaller towns. In terms of healthcare, education, and transport, major urban centres typically house advanced hospitals, multiple universities, and integrated public transit systems such as metro lines. This concentration

exists because economies of scale make it financially feasible to invest in such infrastructure where population density is high enough to sustain it. That said, access to these facilities is far from equal — residents in peripheral districts or lower-income areas are often structurally excluded from the very amenities that make city life appealing. The challenge, therefore, is not just building world-class facilities but ensuring that they are equitably distributed across the entire urban population.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Big cities are fundamentally distinguished by the breadth and specialisation of their infrastructure. Beyond the obvious — hospitals, universities, and transit networks — they also house facilities that support professional and economic life at scale: international conference centres, incubator hubs, financial institutions, and advanced logistics networks. The key reason is that cities function as nodes of economic activity, and the demand generated by large, diverse populations makes high-level investment commercially and politically justified. While it is true that these facilities can become overstretched under pressure — a common criticism levelled at public hospitals and metro systems in rapidly growing cities like Ho Chi Minh City — the solution lies in smarter urban planning rather than rejecting density altogether. A city's quality of life ultimately hinges on whether its infrastructure keeps pace with its population growth.

2. Do you think modern cities are suitable for young people or old people?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

On balance, modern cities are better suited to young people, though not because of deliberate design choices — rather, it is an unintended consequence of prioritising economic productivity over social inclusivity. The entire logic of contemporary urban planning revolves around workforce concentration, digital connectivity, and consumer activity, all of which naturally align with the routines and capacities of younger adults. As a result, older residents often find themselves navigating environments that are structurally hostile — crowded pavements, fast-moving traffic, buildings without adequate accessibility, and social norms that favour speed over community. While it is true that some cities, particularly in Northern Europe and Japan, have begun introducing age-friendly urban frameworks — such as dedicated resting zones, low-floor buses, and community care networks — these remain the exception rather than the rule. The broader implication is that unless cities rethink the metrics of success beyond GDP and mobility, they risk becoming spaces that exclude large and growing segments of their own population.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of suitability cuts to the heart of what a city is actually designed to achieve. If the primary function of a modern city is to maximise economic output, then it will inevitably skew towards the young and productive — and that is precisely what most urban environments do. Job markets, transport systems, and even public spaces are configured around the rhythms of working-age adults. For older residents, this creates a compounding set of barriers: physical inaccessibility, social isolation, and a healthcare system under strain. However, it would be reductive to assume this is unchangeable. Cities like Vienna and Singapore have demonstrated that with deliberate policy investment — in intergenerational housing, accessible infrastructure, and community health services — urban environments can accommodate diverse age groups without sacrificing efficiency. The crux of the issue is political will, not technical capacity.

3. Before you travel to a city, what factors would you consider?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Travel decisions, at their core, involve weighing practical constraints against experiential goals — and for most people, the practical side carries more weight than they might admit. The most critical factors tend to be cost, safety, and transport accessibility, because without these three in reasonable order, even a culturally rich destination becomes difficult to enjoy. For younger travellers or students with limited budgets, accommodation costs alone can determine whether a city is even viable to visit. Beyond logistics, there is also the question of thematic fit — whether the city’s main attractions align with what the traveller actually values, be it history, cuisine, architecture, or nightlife. While social media and travel platforms have made research far more accessible, they also risk creating a homogenised tourist experience, where visitors flock to the same instagrammable landmarks rather than engaging with a city’s deeper character. A more meaningful approach would be to prioritise depth over coverage — spending more time in fewer places rather than rushing through a checklist.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

For anyone approaching travel with limited time — which describes most working professionals — pre-trip planning is not merely a preference but a strategic necessity. The factors that matter most are interconnected: transport infrastructure determines how much time is wasted in transit; the political and social climate affects personal safety; and the timing of the visit relative to seasonal pricing or local events can dramatically alter the experience. What often goes underappreciated is the role of a city’s attitude toward tourists — some destinations are genuinely visitor-friendly at an infrastructural and cultural level, while others treat tourism as a side industry rather than a central concern. That distinction can define the entire quality of the experience. It can be argued, therefore, that choosing where to travel is less about ticking off famous cities and more about matching the destination’s character to one’s own purpose for travelling.

4. What are the disadvantages of living in a very famous city?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The disadvantages of living in a globally recognised city are, in many ways, the direct consequences of the very factors that made it famous in the first place. High international visibility attracts sustained capital investment, luxury tourism, and an influx of affluent residents — all of which exert relentless upward pressure on housing costs and the general cost of living. In cities like London, Paris, or even Da Nang during peak tourist season, rents can rise so sharply that long-term residents — particularly students, young workers, and lower-income families — are effectively priced out of the city centre. Beyond economic pressure, there is also the subtler but equally damaging issue of cultural dilution: as global tourism reshapes demand, authentic local businesses are gradually replaced by souvenir shops and international chains, stripping the city of the very character that once made it worth visiting. While it is true that tourism brings revenue and investment, a city that exists primarily for visitors rather than its own residents has, in a meaningful sense, lost its identity.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Living in a famous city entails a structural trade-off that is rarely acknowledged openly: the same forces that generate prosperity and prestige also produce inequality, overcrowding, and the erosion of community. Economically, the concentration of global demand in a single urban space drives asset prices to levels that exclude most ordinary residents —

a phenomenon visible in cities from New York to Ho Chi Minh City's District 1, where gentrification has displaced entire communities. From a quality-of-life standpoint, persistent congestion, noise pollution, and the psychological weight of living in a densely surveilled, commercially saturated environment take a measurable toll on residents' well-being. That said, it would be overly simplistic to frame famous cities purely as victims of their own success. Strong governance frameworks, rent control policies, and strategic limitations on short-term tourist accommodation — as seen in Amsterdam and Barcelona — have demonstrated that it is possible to manage these pressures without dismantling the city's appeal. The key variable is whether city authorities prioritise the interests of residents over the revenue generated by visitors.

5. Do you prefer to visit well-developed cities or cities with a long history?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Historical cities offer something that well-developed urban centres simply cannot manufacture: a tangible sense of continuity with the past that gives a place its irreplaceable identity. When you walk through the streets of a city that has evolved over centuries — through trade, conflict, artistic movement, and cultural exchange — the experience carries an intellectual and emotional depth that purpose-built modern cities, however efficient, cannot replicate. Well-developed cities, on the other hand, tend to prioritise functionality: seamless transport, modern architecture, and digital connectivity. While these are undeniably valuable, they rarely produce the kind of wonder or reflection that a visit to, say, Hoi An's ancient town or Kyoto's temple district can provoke. That said, the dichotomy is not absolute — the most compelling cities in the world, including Kyoto, Prague, and Istanbul, are precisely those that have managed to layer modern infrastructure onto a historically rich foundation. The ideal destination is therefore one where history is preserved without being frozen, and where modern life coexists with cultural memory rather than erasing it.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The preference for historically rich cities over modern ones reflects a deeper psychological truth about what travel is ultimately for. When people are embedded in fast-paced, efficiency-driven work environments day after day, the appeal of a city that operates on a different temporal logic — one shaped by centuries rather than quarterly targets — becomes genuinely compelling. Historical cities offer not just aesthetic pleasure but a form of perspective: they remind visitors that civilisations have risen, adapted, and endured across timescales that dwarf any individual career or crisis. Well-developed cities, by contrast, excel at comfort and convenience but often lack the layered narrative that makes a place feel meaningful. It can be argued that this is why heritage tourism has grown consistently as a global trend, even as modern urban development accelerates — people are drawn to depth precisely because their daily lives offer so little of it. The most valuable travel experience, then, is one that combines historical authenticity with the practical comfort that allows visitors to engage with that history without logistical frustration.

6. For those who live in cities, is it because they want to or have to?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The honest answer is that for the majority of urban residents, necessity precedes desire — people move to cities because the structural concentration of opportunity leaves them little

alternative. Education, employment, healthcare, and social mobility are all disproportionately located in urban centres, which effectively means that choosing not to live in a city often equates to accepting significant disadvantages in life outcomes. This systemic pull is particularly pronounced in countries with high urban-rural inequality, where the gap in wages, services, and infrastructure between cities and the countryside is substantial. Over time, however, necessity can evolve into genuine preference — cities are dynamic, socially rich environments that generate their own culture, identity, and sense of belonging, and many people come to love urban life even if their initial reason for being there was purely pragmatic. That said, the fact that remote work is now enabling a partial reversal of urbanisation trends suggests that for many, the attachment to city life was always conditional on circumstance rather than deeply held conviction.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

It can be argued that the question of want versus obligation is fundamentally misleading, because in most cases the two cannot be cleanly separated. Structural economic forces — the concentration of high-paying jobs, professional networks, and institutional resources in major cities — effectively constrain individual choice to such a degree that the decision to live in a city is less freely made than it appears. In labour market terms, refusing to live in a major city often means accepting a ceiling on income, career progression, and social capital that most people are unwilling to accept. What complicates this further is that urban environments are highly effective at cultivating what sociologists call the preference for density — the longer one lives in a city, the more one's social relationships, consumption habits, and lifestyle expectations are shaped by it, making departure feel progressively more costly. The emergence of remote work as a viable long-term option represents the first real structural shift that has begun to decouple opportunity from geography — and the fact that many urban professionals are now choosing to relocate suggests that the compulsory dimension of city living was always far stronger than most people cared to acknowledge.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
comprehensive	adj	/ˌkɒm.prɪˈhen.sɪv/	covering all aspects thoroughly	toàn diện
overstretched	adj	/ˌəʊ.vəˈstretʃt/	used beyond its capacity	quá tải
inclusive	adj	/ɪnˈkluː.sɪv/	designed to include all groups of people	toàn diện, không loại trừ
overtourism	n	/ˌəʊ.vəˈtʊə.rɪ.z əm/	excessive numbers of tourists causing damage to a place	tình trạng quá tải du khách
erode	v	/ɪˈrəʊd/	to gradually destroy or weaken something	xói mòn, làm suy yếu dần
social fabric	n phr	/ˈsəʊ.ʃəl ˈfæb.rɪk/	the network of relationships holding a community together	cấu trúc xã hội
sky-high	adj	/ˌskaɪˈhaɪ/	extremely high, especially in price	cực kỳ cao
heritage	n	/ˈher.ɪ.tɪdʒ/	traditions and historic features passed through generations	di sản
urban centre	n phr	/ˈzː.bən ˈsen.tər/	a major city or busy city district	trung tâm đô thị
gradual migration	n phr	/ˈɡrædʒ.u.əl maɪˈɡreɪ.ʃən/	a slow movement of people from one place to another	sự di cư dần dần

2.2 Describe a person who likes to look after the natural world

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a person who likes to look after the natural world. You should say:

- Who this person is
- What he or she does
- How he or she does it
- How often he or she does it
- And explain how you feel about this person.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I want to describe is my biology teacher from secondary school, Ms. Lan. She was not just passionate about the subject — she genuinely lived by the things she taught, which is something you do not come across very often.

What struck me most was how consistently she put her values into action. She ran a small composting programme in the school garden, organised monthly clean-up sessions along the riverbank near our school, and brought plants into the classroom to demonstrate how ecosystems work in real time. She did all of this on top of her regular teaching load, which tells you a lot about how deeply she cared.

To be honest, I used to think environmentalism was just something people preached about without actually practising. Ms. Lan completely changed that perception for me. Watching her get her hands dirty during a clean-up session, or patiently explain to students why a single piece of litter matters, made me realise that real environmental care is not about grand gestures — it is about daily, unglamorous commitment.

Looking back, I think she influenced me more than any textbook ever did. She showed me that protecting nature is not something you outsource to governments or scientists; it is something ordinary people can choose to do every single day.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The person who comes to mind immediately is a colleague of mine named Minh, who works in a completely unrelated field — corporate finance — but dedicates a significant portion of his personal time to environmental conservation.

What makes Minh stand out is the scope and consistency of his involvement. He volunteers with a local NGO that works on reforestation projects in the central highlands of Vietnam, and he typically spends two or three weekends a month either on-site planting trees or helping coordinate logistics for the organisation's fundraising campaigns. Beyond volunteering, he has also shifted his entire lifestyle to reduce his environmental footprint — he cycles to work, maintains a zero-waste kitchen, and refuses single-use packaging so consistently that it has actually become a running topic among our team.

What I find genuinely admirable about Minh is not just the individual actions but the underlying conviction that drives them. He never moralises or lectures colleagues about their habits, yet his quiet consistency makes a far stronger impression than any lecture would. In a work environment where sustainability is often discussed in strategy

meetings but rarely translated into personal behaviour, he represents a meaningful exception.

If anything, knowing him has made me more reflective about the gap between what I say I care about and what I actually do.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
composting	n	/ˈkɒm.pɒs.tɪŋ/	the process of turning organic waste into fertiliser	ủ phân hữu cơ
ecosystem	n	/ˈiː.kəʊ.sɪs.təm/	a community of living things interacting with their environment	hệ sinh thái
unglamorous	adj	/ʌnˈglæm.ər.əs/	not exciting or impressive in appearance	không hào nhoáng
reforestation	n	/ˌriː.fɒr.ɪˈsteɪ.ʃən/	the replanting of trees in a deforested area	tái trồng rừng
environmental footprint	n phr	/ɪnˌvaɪ.rənˈmen.təl ˈfʊt.prɪnt/	the impact a person's activities have on the environment	dấu chân môi trường
zero-waste	adj	/ˌziː.rəʊ ˈweɪst/	producing no waste or as little as possible	không rác thải
conviction	n	/kənˈvɪk.ʃən/	a firm belief or principle	niềm tin vững chắc, tín niệm
moralise	v	/ˈmɒr.əl.aɪz/	to comment on what is right and wrong in a preachy way	thuyết giáo về đạo đức
NGO	n	/ˌen.dʒiːˈəʊ/	non-governmental organisation	tổ chức phi chính phủ
underlying	adj	/ˌʌn.dəˈlaɪ.ɪŋ/	existing beneath the surface; fundamental	nằm bên dưới, căn bản

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Do you think parents should teach their children how to protect the environment?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Parental education on environmental responsibility is arguably more formative than any formal curriculum, precisely because it operates through daily observation rather than instruction. Children internalise values not primarily from what they are told but from what they see modelled in their immediate environment — and the home is where those patterns are established earliest and most durably. When parents routinely separate waste, avoid unnecessary consumption, or make deliberate choices about energy use, they normalise these behaviours at a stage when habits are most malleable. That said, parents alone cannot carry this responsibility without structural support — if waste management infrastructure is inadequate or sustainable products are prohibitively expensive, even the most environmentally conscious household faces systemic barriers that individual effort cannot overcome. The implication is that while parental teaching is essential, it functions most effectively within societies that have already built the enabling conditions for sustainable behaviour.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for parents teaching environmental values to children is not merely persuasive — it is urgent, given that the generation currently being raised will inherit the consequences of today's environmental decisions. The home environment is uniquely powerful as a site of value formation because it operates continuously and without the artificiality of a classroom setting; a child who grows up watching their parents sort recyclables or choose reusable items develops an intuitive sense of environmental responsibility that later formal education can reinforce but rarely implant from scratch. However, it would be a mistake to place the entire burden on individual families, many of whom lack the time, knowledge, or resources to prioritise environmental education. What is needed is a complementary framework in which public education, accessible infrastructure, and credible government policy work in concert with parental guidance — so that families are not asked to compensate for systemic failures through personal virtue alone.

2. What laws about the environment are effective in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Among the environmental measures that have gained meaningful traction in Vietnam, the ban on single-use plastic bags in supermarkets and retail chains stands out as a tangible and relatively enforceable policy. Since its implementation, the visible reduction of plastic bags at checkout points has been noticeable, suggesting that when the barrier to compliance is low and alternatives are readily available, regulation can shift behaviour fairly quickly. However, it would be an overstatement to call Vietnam's environmental legal framework comprehensively effective — enforcement of industrial pollution standards, for instance, remains inconsistent, and penalties are frequently insufficient to deter large-scale violations by manufacturing firms. The crux of the issue is that environmental law in Vietnam, as in many developing economies, tends to be more ambitious on paper than in practice, largely because enforcement mechanisms are underfunded and regulatory agencies often lack the political independence needed to hold powerful industrial actors accountable.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The environmental protection laws that have demonstrated the most practical impact in Vietnam are those tied to direct economic incentives or clear commercial consequences. The requirements imposed on businesses to conduct environmental impact assessments before large-scale construction projects, for example, represent a structural intervention that — at least in principle — embeds environmental consideration into development planning rather than treating it as an afterthought. Similarly, regulations governing emissions from industrial zones have become more sophisticated in recent years, particularly in areas near major rivers. That said, the gap between legislative intent and on-the-ground enforcement remains considerable. From a professional perspective, I have observed in my own industry that compliance with environmental regulations is often treated as a risk management exercise rather than a genuine commitment — companies do the minimum required to avoid penalties rather than building environmental responsibility into their core operations. Closing that gap requires stronger inspection infrastructure, more meaningful penalties, and greater transparency in how violations are reported and addressed.

3. Which do you think people prefer, rewards or punishment, when it comes to government intervention in environmental protection?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Behavioural evidence strongly suggests that people respond more durably to incentive-based frameworks than to punitive ones, though the underlying reason is more nuanced than simply preferring rewards over penalties. Punishment creates compliance under surveillance, but it rarely generates genuine attitudinal change — the moment enforcement loosens, prohibited behaviours tend to resurface. Incentive structures, by contrast, align environmental behaviour with self-interest, which is a far more robust motivational foundation. In practice, effective environmental policy in countries like Denmark and Japan has typically combined both approaches: financial rewards for responsible behaviour — such as tax breaks for household solar installation or deposit-return schemes for packaging — alongside proportionate penalties for violations that are actually enforced. The critical insight is that neither mechanism works well in isolation; rewards without consequences invite free-riding, while punishment without accessible alternatives simply produces resentment. What governments need is not a choice between the two but a well-calibrated combination of both, adapted to the specific behaviour they are trying to change.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The preference for rewards over punishment is psychologically well-documented, but framing the question purely in terms of public preference risks obscuring what is actually effective. From a policy design perspective, the most successful environmental interventions tend not to rely on either reward or punishment as their primary mechanism — they work by restructuring the choice environment so that the environmentally friendly option becomes the default or the most convenient one. Carbon pricing, for example, is technically a form of punishment, yet it has proven effective in jurisdictions like Sweden and Canada not because people enjoy paying more, but because the price signal gradually reshapes investment decisions at both the corporate and individual levels. On the other hand, deposit-return schemes are effectively reward mechanisms, and they have achieved recycling rates above 90% in Nordic countries. The practical conclusion is that environmental behaviour change is less about people's stated preferences for reward versus punishment and more about which mechanism most efficiently removes the structural friction that prevents sustainable choices in the first place.

4. Is it easy for children in cities to get close to the natural world?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

For the majority of urban children, meaningful access to the natural world is structurally constrained in ways that go well beyond a simple lack of nearby parks. The problem is not merely physical distance from nature but the cumulative effect of an urban lifestyle that actively competes for children's attention — through screens, structured activities, and condensed timetables that leave little room for unstructured outdoor time. In cities like Hanoi or Ho Chi Minh City, even when parks exist, they are often heavily paved, managed to the point of sterility, or simply unsafe for independent child exploration. The result is what environmental educators call nature deficit disorder — a generation of children who are physically surrounded by infrastructure but experientially disconnected from living ecosystems. That said, proximity is not the only variable; families with the awareness and means to take regular trips to forests, beaches, or rural areas can compensate for urban limitations to some degree. The inequality embedded in that distinction, however, is significant and rarely acknowledged in policy discussions about urban greening.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

In most major Vietnamese cities, the honest answer is no — not in any meaningful, sustained way. Urban planning in Vietnam has historically prioritised commercial development and residential density over green public spaces, which means that children growing up in cities like Ho Chi Minh City or Da Nang have very limited access to environments where nature operates on its own terms rather than being curated for human convenience. A manicured park with concrete paths and ornamental plants is not the same as an ecosystem, and children require exposure to living, dynamic natural environments to develop both ecological literacy and an emotional connection to the non-human world. Some cities have begun investing in urban green corridors and ecological education programmes within schools, which is an encouraging development. However, without a fundamental reorientation of how cities allocate land — ensuring that genuinely wild or semi-wild green spaces are embedded throughout the urban fabric rather than relegated to the periphery — city children will continue to experience nature primarily through screens and school trips rather than through lived, daily contact.

5. What can people do to protect the natural world?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Individual action matters, but its impact is most meaningful when it is understood within a systemic rather than a purely personal framework. On an individual level, the most consequential changes tend to involve consumption patterns — reducing meat intake, refusing single-use materials, choosing products with minimal environmental impact, and critically evaluating the actual necessity of purchases. These choices are significant not just in themselves but because aggregate consumer behaviour shapes market incentives over time. However, it would be misleading to suggest that personal responsibility alone can drive the scale of change required to address biodiversity loss and climate disruption. The natural world is protected most effectively when individual behaviour change is combined with civic engagement — supporting organisations working on conservation, participating in local environmental advocacy, and holding both businesses and governments accountable

for the externalities their operations produce. The crucial shift in mindset is from treating environmental protection as a private virtue to recognising it as a collective political responsibility.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Protecting the natural world requires a layered response that operates simultaneously at the individual, corporate, and governmental levels, because no single tier of action is sufficient in isolation. At the individual level, the decisions with the highest impact are typically those involving energy use, diet, and mobility — switching to renewable energy sources, reducing consumption of animal products, and minimising air travel collectively account for a disproportionate share of most people’s environmental footprint. At the corporate level, the most urgent need is for businesses to internalise environmental costs that are currently externalised onto the public — which requires both stronger regulation and more sophisticated reporting frameworks like the emerging nature-based accounting standards. At the governmental level, the most powerful tool available is price-based intervention: making environmentally destructive behaviour more expensive through carbon taxes or resource levies, while simultaneously making sustainable alternatives more accessible through investment and subsidy. The consistent pattern across successful conservation outcomes globally is that all three levels must function together; any single lever, operating alone, is insufficient to arrest the pace of ecological degradation.

6. Is it important to teach students environmental protection at school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Environmental education in schools is not merely important — it is one of the most strategically valuable investments a society can make in its long-term capacity to manage ecological challenges. The case rests on a straightforward logic: the students currently in classrooms will be the decision-makers, consumers, engineers, and policymakers of the next several decades, and the values and frameworks they internalise during formative years will shape how they exercise those roles. A student who graduates without a working understanding of ecological systems, resource limits, and the consequences of collective inaction is, in a meaningful sense, incompletely educated for the world they will inhabit. That said, the quality and framing of environmental education matters enormously. Teaching students to recycle is useful but insufficient; what is needed is a curriculum that builds genuine ecological literacy — the ability to understand complex environmental systems, evaluate evidence, and reason through trade-offs between development and conservation. This requires integrating environmental thinking across multiple subjects, not confining it to a single elective or occasional awareness campaign.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The importance of teaching environmental protection in schools extends well beyond the environmental domain itself — it is fundamentally an exercise in systems thinking, civic responsibility, and long-term reasoning, all of which are capacities that benefit every aspect of a student’s intellectual development. Schools are one of the few institutions in society with both the mandate and the access to reach the entire population during the years when cognitive frameworks are most open to formation. A well-designed environmental curriculum teaches students not just about the natural world but about the relationship between human decisions and their downstream consequences — a mode of thinking that is essential for navigating virtually every complex challenge of adult life. The counter-argument — that schools are already overburdened with curriculum requirements and that environmental education is peripheral — underestimates both the severity of the ecological crisis and the integrative nature of environmental knowledge. Far from being an add-on, environmental

literacy should be treated as a foundational competency, on a par with numeracy and critical reading, that equips students to function as informed and responsible members of a world under significant ecological stress.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
internalise	v	/ɪn'tɜː.nə.laɪz/	to absorb and integrate values or attitudes	nội tâm hoá, tiếp thu sâu sắc
malleable	adj	/'mæl.i.ə.bəl/	easily influenced or changed	dễ uốn nắn
enabling conditions	n phr	/'ɪneɪ.blɪŋ kən'dɪʃ.ənz/	circumstances that make something possible	điều kiện cho phép
nature deficit disorder	n phr	/'neɪ.tʃər 'def.ɪ.sɪt dɪ'sɔː.dər/	disconnection from nature due to urban lifestyle	hội chứng thiếu gắn kết thiên nhiên
ecological literacy	n phr	/iː.kə'lɒdʒ.ɪ.kəl 'lɪt.ər.ə.si/	the ability to understand natural systems	hiểu biết về hệ sinh thái
externalise	v	/ɪk'stɜː.nə.laɪz/	to shift costs onto others or the environment	ngoại hoá (chi phí)
biodiversity	n	/'baɪ.əʊ.daɪ'vɜː.sɪ.ti/	the variety of life in an ecosystem	đa dạng sinh học
free-riding	n	/'friː.raɪ.dɪŋ/	benefiting from shared resources without contributing	hưởng lợi mà không đóng góp
carbon pricing	n phr	/'kɑː.bən 'praɪ.sɪŋ/	a policy charging for carbon emissions	định giá carbon
ecological degradation	n phr	/iː.kə'lɒdʒ.ɪ.kəl ,deg.rə'deɪ.ʃən/	the deterioration of natural environments	suy thoái sinh thái

2.3 Describe a short-term job you want to have in a foreign country

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a short-term job you want to have in a foreign country. You should say:

- Where it is
- How you know of it
- What the job is
- And explain why you want to do it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The short-term job I want to talk about is working as a language teaching assistant at a primary school in Japan — specifically in the countryside, somewhere in a region like Tohoku or Niigata where the population is smaller and the community feel is stronger. I came across this kind of opportunity through a friend who had done a similar programme, and she described it in a way that stuck with me. She said it felt less like a job and more like a full immersion into a completely different way of life. The role itself would involve supporting English lessons alongside a local teacher, leading conversation activities, and occasionally sharing things about Vietnamese culture with the students.

What draws me to it is really the combination of doing something meaningful and experiencing Japan at a level that ordinary tourism never gives you. Living in a small Japanese community, cycling to work, shopping at local markets, and getting to know residents over time — that kind of slow, embedded experience is exactly the opposite of what you get from a two-week holiday. Beyond the lifestyle aspect, I think teaching also forces you to communicate clearly in a second language under pressure, which would dramatically improve my English and sharpen my confidence in professional settings.

If there was ever a point in my life where I could afford the time to do something like this, I think the gap between finishing university and starting full-time work would be it.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The short-term role I have always been genuinely drawn to is working as a communications or content consultant for a social enterprise based in Singapore or the UK — somewhere with a strong civil society ecosystem and a mature non-profit sector.

I first became aware of this kind of opportunity through professional networking platforms and a few conversations with colleagues who had taken career breaks to do consulting work abroad. The premise is straightforward: organisations with strong social missions often need people who can help them communicate their impact clearly — writing reports, crafting campaigns, or helping translate complex data into accessible public narratives.

For me, the appeal is layered. Professionally, it would force me to apply my skills in an environment with entirely different cultural expectations around communication,

which I suspect would expose both my strengths and blind spots in ways that working in a familiar context simply does not. Personally, living and working in a densely international city like Singapore — where English genuinely functions as a shared language across ethnic and professional lines — would give me a level of real-world fluency and cross-cultural confidence that no language class could replicate. There is also an element of purpose: doing work that is explicitly tied to a social goal, rather than a purely commercial one, feels like a different kind of professional satisfaction that I have not yet fully experienced in my current role.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
language teaching assistant	n phr	/ˈlæŋ.gwɪdʒ ˈtiː.tʃɪŋ əˈsɪs.tənt/	a person who supports a main teacher in language lessons	trợ giảng ngôn ngữ
full immersion	n phr	/fʊl ɪˈmɜː.ʃən/	complete involvement in a language or culture	hòa mình hoàn toàn
embedded	adj	/ɪmˈbed.ɪd/	deeply integrated into a context or community	gắn kết sâu vào
civil society	n phr	/ˈsɪv.əl səˈsaɪ.ə.ti/	non-government organisations and groups that work for public benefit	xã hội dân sự
social enterprise	n phr	/ˈsəʊ.ʃəl ˈen.tə.praɪz/	a business with a primary social or environmental goal	doanh nghiệp xã hội
cross-cultural confidence	n phr	/ˌkrɒs ˈkʌl.tʃər.əl ˈkɒn.fɪ.dəns/	the ability to communicate comfortably across cultures	sự tự tin giao tiếp đa văn hóa
public narrative	n phr	/ˈpʌb.lɪk ˈnær.ə.tɪv/	the shared story or message communicated to the public	thông điệp truyền thông công cộng
non-profit sector	n phr	/ˌnɒn ˈprɒf.ɪt ˈsek.tər/	organisations that operate without making profit	khu vực phi lợi nhuận
blind spots	n phr	/ˈblaɪnd spɒts/	areas where someone lacks awareness or skill	điểm mù, điểm yếu chưa nhận thức được
career break	n phr	/kəˈrɪər breɪk/	a planned period away from work	khoảng nghỉ trong sự nghiệp

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What short-term jobs do young people do in other countries?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The range of short-term roles that young people take on abroad is considerably broader than most people assume, and it reflects both the globalisation of labour markets and a generational shift in how young adults conceptualise the early stages of their careers. The most common categories include hospitality and tourism work — such as front-of-house positions in hotels or seasonal roles in ski resorts — along with language teaching, agricultural work through programmes like WWOOF, and increasingly, remote freelance contracting that may be carried out from a foreign location. What is notable is that many young people now explicitly seek out these experiences not primarily for financial gain but for the cross-cultural exposure and the kind of adaptive competence that structured education rarely provides. That said, access to such opportunities remains unequal — young people from wealthy countries with strong passports and financial safety nets are far better positioned to pursue international short-term work than their counterparts from developing nations, where visa barriers and financial risk make the same experiences considerably harder to access.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

From a broader labour market perspective, the category of short-term international work undertaken by young people has expanded significantly over the past decade, driven by both technological change and a cultural shift in expectations around career linearity. Beyond the traditional backpacker economy — bar work, hostel reception, and fruit picking — there is now a substantial cohort of young professionals who use platforms like Upwork or Toptal to work remotely as freelancers while living temporarily in another country, effectively creating a portable career that does not require formal employment in a host country at all. Teaching English, working as au pairs, and participating in structured exchange programmes like JET in Japan or the European Voluntary Service also remain popular among those seeking a more structured arrangement. The common thread across these varied options is the desire for experience that is simultaneously professional and formative — young people are increasingly strategic about treating short-term international work not as a gap year diversion but as a deliberate investment in their long-term employability and self-understanding.

2. What challenges do young people face when working abroad?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Working abroad presents a set of challenges that are qualitatively different from those encountered in domestic employment, and the gap between expectation and reality is often wider than young people anticipate. The most immediate difficulties tend to be logistical: navigating foreign visa systems, finding accommodation in an unfamiliar market, and managing finances across different currencies and banking systems. Beyond the practical, there are also significant psychological challenges — isolation is far more common than young people expect, particularly in the early weeks before a social network has been established. Cultural adjustment is another underappreciated difficulty; norms around workplace communication, hierarchy, and punctuality can differ so substantially from what a young person is accustomed to that even competent professionals find themselves making avoidable mistakes. The capacity to manage these stresses without the immediate support of family and close friends is something that many young people develop only through the experience itself, which is arguably why those who successfully navigate an overseas work stint tend to report significantly higher resilience and adaptability afterwards.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The challenges of working abroad are real and multidimensional, and they tend to be systematically underestimated by young people who focus on the aspirational dimension of the experience without adequately accounting for the structural difficulties. Chief among these is the legal and bureaucratic complexity of obtaining the right to work — work visa requirements, sponsorship obligations, and the tax implications of earning in a foreign jurisdiction are not trivial matters, and getting them wrong can have serious consequences. There are also professional challenges that go beyond language barriers: workplace cultures vary enormously in terms of how disagreement is expressed, how feedback is delivered, and how relationships between junior and senior staff are expected to function, and misreading these codes can damage a young professional's credibility before they have had a chance to demonstrate their actual capabilities. Finally, the financial dimension is often harsher than anticipated — salaries in some host countries may not cover the elevated cost of living for a non-resident, particularly in cities like London, Tokyo, or Singapore, where housing costs can consume an unexpectedly large proportion of income.

3. What are the benefits of working for an international company?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

The benefits of working within an international company extend well beyond the obvious credential value on a CV. At a structural level, multinational organisations typically operate with more formalised processes for performance management, professional development, and career progression than many domestic equivalents — which means employees gain exposure to systems and standards that are globally recognised. There is also a measurable advantage in terms of network building: working alongside colleagues from multiple national and cultural backgrounds generates a web of professional relationships that can prove valuable across an entire career, especially as global labour markets become more interconnected. Additionally, international companies are generally required to comply with stricter employment law frameworks, which often translates into more reliable contractual protections and more structured employee support. That said, the benefits are not uniformly distributed — junior employees at large multinationals sometimes find that the same scale and structure that provides stability also creates bureaucratic friction and slower pathways to meaningful responsibility compared with smaller, more agile organisations.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

From a professional development standpoint, working for an international company offers a form of exposure that is genuinely difficult to replicate through any other means. The most significant advantage is the direct encounter with the complexity of cross-cultural communication — learning to present ideas, negotiate, give feedback, and build trust with people who operate according to fundamentally different cultural assumptions is a skill that becomes increasingly valuable as business becomes more global. International companies also tend to invest more heavily in formal training programmes, mentorship structures, and international mobility opportunities than their domestic counterparts, partly because they need to develop talent that can function across geographies. There is also the advantage of operating within a more diverse intellectual environment: teams that bring together perspectives from multiple cultural contexts tend to generate more creative solutions to complex problems, which is why research on organisational performance consistently shows a positive correlation between workforce diversity and innovation output. The caveat, as always, is that these advantages are realised only when diversity is genuinely managed for inclusion rather than treated as a compliance exercise.

4. What personal skills are required to work in an international company?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The skill set required to thrive in an international company is meaningfully different from what is typically emphasised in domestic career preparation, and the most important competencies are often the hardest to develop through formal study. Cultural intelligence — the ability to read, adapt to, and work effectively within unfamiliar cultural frameworks — is arguably the most critical, because even technically excellent employees will underperform if they consistently misread the social and professional norms of their colleagues. Closely related is communication flexibility: the ability to adjust register, directness, and communication style depending on the cultural context, which goes well beyond simple language proficiency. Resilience and ambiguity tolerance are also essential, because international working environments often involve incomplete information, rapidly changing priorities, and a degree of structural uncertainty that more locally-focused organisations tend to manage out. The capacity for genuine intellectual curiosity — a sustained interest in understanding perspectives and systems that differ from one's own — underpins all of these skills and is perhaps the single most reliable predictor of success in a globally diverse workplace.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

In my experience, the competencies that most reliably distinguish effective professionals in international settings are those that cannot easily be acquired through coursework or certification. The first is what organisational psychologists call cultural humility — the recognition that one's own cultural framework is neither universal nor necessarily superior, combined with the genuine curiosity to understand and engage with different ones. The second is adaptive communication: the ability to adjust not just language but tone, directness, and even the degree of formality depending on who you are communicating with and in what context. Third is a capacity for managing uncertainty without defaulting to conflict or withdrawal — international workplaces are inherently more ambiguous than domestic ones, and employees who require constant clarity and task definition tend to struggle. Finally, and perhaps most practically, the ability to build trust quickly with people from different backgrounds — which requires empathy, intellectual generosity, and a willingness to be vulnerable professionally — is what separates those who merely survive international environments from those who genuinely thrive in them.

5. What kind of work can young people do in foreign countries?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The types of work accessible to young people in foreign countries are shaped primarily by three variables: visa category, language proficiency, and whether the work requires location-specific expertise or can be performed remotely. For those with working holiday visas — available to Vietnamese citizens in a growing number of countries, including Australia and South Korea — the options include hospitality, retail, warehouse work, and seasonal agricultural roles, all of which offer a legal pathway to earn while living abroad. For those with stronger academic credentials and language skills, teaching English as a foreign language remains one of the most accessible professional options, with structured programmes available in Japan, South Korea, China, and across Southeast Asia. Increasingly, however, the most sustainable form of international work for young Vietnamese professionals is remote freelancing

— using platforms to offer skills like design, translation, or digital marketing to international clients while residing in a low-cost country. This model essentially decouples earning potential from geographic constraint, which is why it is growing rapidly among young professionals who want international income without the friction of migration.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The landscape of work available to young people internationally has been reshaped significantly by two forces: the expansion of digital service platforms and the post-pandemic normalisation of remote work arrangements. On the formal employment side, young professionals can access structured international roles through graduate schemes at multinational firms, international volunteering programmes, or secondment arrangements within companies that operate across borders. On the informal or self-directed side, the range is even broader: content creation, e-commerce, software development, UX design, and digital marketing can all be delivered remotely to international clients without requiring the person to be physically present in the client's country. What this means in practice is that the traditional framing of working abroad — as something that requires emigration, visa sponsorship, and the full displacement of one's life — is becoming increasingly outdated. Young people today have more options than any previous generation to engage with international work on their own terms, and the most important skill in navigating this landscape is not language proficiency or technical expertise alone, but the entrepreneurial intelligence to identify where one's skills meet genuine international demand.

6. Why are some people unwilling to work in other countries?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The reluctance to work abroad, despite its apparent benefits, is rooted in a set of concerns that are entirely rational rather than simply reflecting a lack of ambition. The most fundamental is family obligation — in many Vietnamese households, particularly those with elderly parents or younger siblings, the expectation that adult children remain geographically proximate is not merely cultural but practically necessary, especially where the state provides limited social support infrastructure. Beyond family, financial risk is a genuine deterrent: the cost of relocating, establishing oneself in an unfamiliar market, and managing the income uncertainty of an early period abroad can represent a significant gamble for young people without financial safety nets. There is also a legitimate concern about professional continuity — relationships, reputation, and organisational knowledge built in a local context do not automatically transfer to a foreign one, and some people correctly calculate that the career they could build at home may ultimately offer better returns than the disruption of an international move. The important point is that choosing not to work abroad is not inherently a failure of adventurousness; it is often a considered response to a specific set of circumstances that outsiders rarely see in full.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The decision not to work internationally is frequently more complex than it appears, and attributing it simply to conservatism or risk aversion misses the legitimate structural barriers that shape individual choices. For many professionals in Vietnam, the primary constraint is not motivation but access — obtaining work visas for desirable destinations requires employer sponsorship, language qualifications, or professional credentials that are not universally available. Beyond access, there is the deeply human dimension of rootedness: professional identity and social belonging are heavily embedded in local networks, and the prospect of dismantling those connections to start again in an unfamiliar environment carries psychological costs that rational agents are right to weigh seriously. There is also the

concern — well-founded in some cases — that international experience accrued in a foreign market may not be recognised or valued upon return, particularly in industries where local relationships and contextual knowledge are primary drivers of professional success. Taken together, these factors suggest that international work mobility is less a matter of individual disposition than of structural opportunity, language capital, and the specific risk calculus of each person's life situation.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
cross-cultural exposure	n phr	/ˌkrɒs 'kʌl.tʃər.əl ɪk'spəʊ.ʒər/	experience gained from working with different cultures	tiếp xúc với đa văn hóa
adaptive competence	n phr	/ə'dæp.tɪv 'kɒm.pɪ.təns/	the ability to adjust effectively in new environments	năng lực thích nghi
cultural intelligence	n phr	/'kʌl.tʃər.əl ɪn'tel.ɪ.dʒəns/	the skill to work effectively across cultures	trí tuệ văn hóa
ambiguity tolerance	n phr	/æmˌbɪɡ.ju.ɪ.ti 'tɒl.ər.əns/	comfort with unclear or uncertain situations	khả năng chịu đựng sự mơ hồ
cultural humility	n phr	/'kʌl.tʃər.əl hju:'mɪl.ɪ.ti/	openness to learning from other cultures without judgement	sự khiêm tốn văn hóa
geographic constraint	n phr	/dʒiː.ə'græf.ɪk kən'streɪnt/	a limitation tied to physical location	hạn chế địa lý
secondment	n	/'sek.ənd.mənt/	a temporary transfer to another role or location	biệt phái tạm thời
professional continuity	n phr	/prə'feʃ.ən.əl ,kɒn.tɪ'nju.ɪ.ti/	maintaining a stable career trajectory	sự liên tục trong sự nghiệp
rootedness	n	/'ruː.tɪd.nəs/	a strong sense of belonging to a place or community	cảm giác gắn bó với quê hương
risk calculus	n phr	/rɪsk 'kæl.kjʊ.ləs/	a careful assessment of potential gains versus losses	tính toán rủi ro

2.4 Describe a time when you gave advice to others

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a time when you gave advice to others. You should say:

- When it was
- To whom you gave the advice
- What the advice was
- And explain why you gave the advice.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The time that comes to mind most clearly was about a year ago, when a close friend of mine was trying to decide whether to transfer to a different university. She had been unhappy with her current programme for a while, but was terrified of starting over, especially because she had already completed one full year of credits.

She came to me quite distressed one evening, and I remember sitting with her for a couple of hours going through the options. My advice, essentially, was that she should not make the decision based on fear of lost time, but rather ask herself honestly whether staying would make the next three years worse than the disruption of switching. I told her that a year of university credits feels enormous when you are inside it, but from the outside, it is a relatively small cost compared with spending three more years studying something you genuinely do not want to do.

The reason I gave that advice is that I had watched another friend stay in the wrong programme out of stubbornness and graduate feeling deeply unmotivated. I did not want the same thing to happen to her. I also felt I had earned the right to say something because she had explicitly asked for my honest opinion, not just reassurance.

She did eventually transfer, and from what she tells me, she is much happier now. I do not know whether my advice was the deciding factor, but I hope it helped her see the situation more clearly.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The situation I want to describe happened about two years ago, when a junior colleague at work came to me feeling overwhelmed and on the verge of resigning from a role she had only been in for three months. She felt she was underperforming, that her manager did not value her, and that she simply was not cut out for the job.

I took her for coffee after work and listened to her for a while before saying anything. What I shared with her was based partly on my own experience in a similar situation early in my career: I told her that the first three to six months in any professional role are almost universally difficult, that the feelings she was describing were textbook adjustment stress rather than evidence of actual incapacity, and that resigning at that point would reset her to zero without giving her the information she needed to make a genuinely informed decision.

I gave her that advice because she was clearly intelligent and capable, and I could see that her distress was being driven by anxiety rather than by a realistic assessment of her performance. I also felt a responsibility as someone more senior to offer perspective rather than platitudes.

She stayed, and within six months she had taken on additional responsibilities and was

visibly more confident. That experience reinforced something I have come to believe fairly strongly: that the most valuable advice you can give someone is not a solution but a clearer frame for understanding their own situation.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
on the verge of	phr	/ɒn ðə vɜːdʒ əv/	very close to doing or experiencing something	sắp, gần đến mức
cut out for	phr v	/kʌt aʊt fɔː/	naturally suited to a particular role	phù hợp, có khiếu
adjustment stress	n phr	/ə'dʒʌst.mənt stres/	emotional difficulty during a period of transition	căng thẳng trong giai đoạn thích nghi
platitudes	n	/'plæt.ɪ.tjuː.dz/	comments that are obvious and not meaningful	những lời sáo rỗng
uninformed decision	n phr	/ˌʌn.ɪn'fɔːmd dɪ'sɪʒ.ən/	a choice made without adequate information	quyết định thiếu thông tin
frame	n	/freɪm/	a way of thinking about or interpreting a situation	khung tư duy, góc nhìn
explicitly	adv	/ɪk'splɪs.ɪt.li/	in a clear and direct way	một cách rõ ràng, tường minh
reassurance	n	/ˌriː.ə'ʃʊər.əns/	comfort given to reduce worry	sự trấn an
incapacity	n	/ˌɪn.kə'pæs.ɪ.ti/	inability to do something	sự không có năng lực
reinforced	v	/ˌriː.ɪn'fɔːst/	made stronger or more confirmed	củng cố, tăng cường

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Should people prepare before giving advice?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The value of preparation before giving advice depends heavily on the nature of the situation, but as a general principle, an unprepared response to a complex problem is more likely to be harmful than helpful. When someone seeks advice on a significant decision — whether about career, relationships, or health — they are typically not looking for an immediate reaction but for a considered perspective, and the quality of that perspective is directly correlated with the adviser’s understanding of the specific context. Unthoughtful advice, even when well-intentioned, risks reinforcing the person’s existing biases rather than offering a genuinely different vantage point. That said, preparation should not shade into delay — advice that arrives after the moment of need has passed has no practical value. The more useful principle, therefore, is not that people must formally prepare but that they should resist the impulse to speak immediately, take a moment to understand the situation accurately, and acknowledge the limits of their own knowledge before offering judgement.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

In professional contexts, the expectation that advice will be informed and considered is generally higher than in personal ones, and the consequences of giving poorly-prepared guidance can be more significant. A mentor or senior colleague who advises a junior employee based on incomplete information or outdated assumptions does not merely fail to help — they can actively mislead, and the damage to trust that follows is difficult to repair. Preparation means different things depending on the context: sometimes it is as simple as asking clarifying questions before responding; in more complex situations it may require researching the relevant domain, consulting additional perspectives, or reflecting on how one’s own experience maps onto the person’s specific circumstances. The critical insight is that the obligation to prepare is proportional to the stakes involved — casual social advice operates under looser norms than professional or high-stakes guidance, and conflating the two is a common source of well-intentioned but poorly-calibrated counsel.

2. Is it good to ask advice from strangers online?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Seeking advice from strangers online is neither inherently good nor inherently bad; its value is almost entirely a function of the platform, the specificity of the question, and the user’s capacity to critically evaluate the responses they receive. For highly specific, factual queries — medical symptoms, legal procedures, technical how-to questions — online communities like specialist forums or condition-specific groups can provide access to expertise that would otherwise be costly or geographically inaccessible, and the aggregate wisdom of a large, engaged community can be genuinely valuable. Where the practice becomes problematic is in emotional or deeply personal domains: when someone seeks validation for a life decision from anonymous strangers who lack context, relationship, and accountability, the responses they receive are likely to reflect the responders’ own biases and blind spots far more than the advice-seeker’s actual situation. The fundamental limitation is the absence of context — advice is only as good as the understanding that underlies it, and strangers on the internet, however well-meaning, are working from a version of the situation that is necessarily incomplete.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether online advice from strangers is beneficial needs to be disaggregated by domain, because a blanket assessment in either direction misrepresents a genuinely complex landscape. In domains where knowledge is relatively standardised and stakes are moderate — travel planning, product recommendations, career pathway questions — crowd-

sourced advice from online communities can be highly efficient and surprisingly accurate. By contrast, in domains where the right answer is deeply personal — relationship decisions, mental health management, major financial choices — the diffusion of responsibility inherent in anonymous online spaces creates a problematic dynamic: responses prioritise engagement and validation over accuracy, and advice-seekers tend to weight responses that confirm their existing inclinations rather than challenge them, an effect psychologists refer to as confirmation bias. There is also the concern that over-reliance on online guidance normalises the outsourcing of judgement to anonymous collectives rather than developing the individual's own capacity for decision-making — which is, in the long run, the more valuable capability to cultivate.

3. What are the personalities of people whose job is to give advice to others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The psychological profile of effective professional advisers — whether they work as counsellors, consultants, or mentors — tends to cluster around a set of traits that go beyond subject-matter expertise. Foremost among these is intellectual humility: the capacity to hold one's own knowledge lightly, acknowledge its limits, and resist the authority bias that professional status can create. Alongside this is a quality of active listening that goes beyond simply waiting for the other person to finish speaking — it involves asking questions that surface assumptions, identifying what is not being said, and resisting the impulse to resolve discomfort prematurely through premature closure. Empathy is essential, but it needs to be tempered by the ability to maintain enough critical distance to offer an honest perspective rather than simply reflecting the advisee's own feelings back to them. What distinguishes truly effective professional advisers from merely competent ones is, in many cases, a genuine tolerance for the discomfort of not having ready answers — the capacity to sit with complexity rather than simplifying it away.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Professional advisers in high-stakes domains — financial planning, legal counsel, clinical psychology, executive coaching — share a set of personality characteristics that make the difference between advice that is technically correct and advice that is genuinely useful. The single most important trait is the ability to build trust quickly with people in a state of vulnerability, which requires a combination of warmth, clarity of communication, and a visible commitment to the client's interests over one's own professional comfort. Equally important is intellectual rigour: the discipline to resist offering confident-sounding answers to questions whose complexity warrants a more qualified response. Good advisers are also comfortable with uncertainty and equipped to help clients navigate it rather than eliminate it artificially. Perhaps the least-discussed trait, but one of the most consequential, is the ability to challenge a client's assumptions without triggering defensiveness — which requires a sophisticated understanding of how people receive difficult information and a calibrated approach to the timing and framing of uncomfortable truths.

4. What are the problems if you ask too many people for advice?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The problems generated by seeking advice from too many sources are not immediately obvious — they appear gradually as the cumulative effect of information overload erodes

rather than enhances decision quality. The most immediate issue is contradictory guidance: when multiple advisers with different frames of reference, risk tolerances, and value systems weigh in on the same problem, the advice-seeker is left not with clarity but with an expanded range of plausible choices and no principled basis for adjudicating between them. There is also the phenomenon of analysis paralysis — the psychological state in which the volume of input makes any decision feel inadequate because there are always more perspectives that have not yet been consulted. Perhaps most insidiously, consulting many people tends to dilute individual accountability; when a decision goes wrong, it becomes easy to distribute the responsibility across a crowd of advisers rather than engaging with the genuine lapse in one's own judgement that may have caused it. The practical implication is that advice-seeking is most valuable when it is targeted — selecting a small number of advisers who have direct knowledge of the domain and a genuine understanding of one's own priorities.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Excessive advice-seeking is a well-recognised pattern in organisational decision-making, and its costs are substantial. At the individual level, soliciting input from too many stakeholders introduces noise into the decision process at a rate that eventually overwhelms the signal — each additional perspective adds marginal information but also additional cognitive load, and beyond a certain threshold, more input actively degrades rather than improves decision quality. There is also a relational dimension: when people become known for seeking excessive reassurance before making decisions, they are perceived — rightly or wrongly — as lacking conviction and autonomy, which can undermine their credibility in professional environments that expect a baseline level of independent judgement. From a psychological standpoint, over-consulting is often a form of procrastination in disguise — a way of deferring commitment under cover of due diligence. The most effective decision-makers, in my experience, are those who know precisely which voices matter for a given type of problem, consult those voices efficiently, and then own the decision clearly rather than continuing to seek external validation after the fact.

5. Why do some people think it is better to ask for advice from friends than from parents?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The preference for peer advice over parental guidance is rooted in a fundamental difference in perspective and relational positioning that is not simply about age. Friends, operating within the same generational context and facing broadly similar social pressures, offer a kind of lateral understanding that parents — however loving and experienced — are structurally positioned to provide less reliably. When a young person discusses a career dilemma, a relationship problem, or a lifestyle choice with a friend, they are talking to someone whose frame of reference is contemporaneous — who knows the current social landscape, shares similar anxieties, and is unlikely to filter their response through the assumptions of a different era. Parents, conversely, bring a wealth of lived experience but also the weight of their own expectations and unresolved aspirations, which can make it difficult for them to offer advice that is genuinely tailored to the child's situation rather than unconsciously shaped by what they would have wanted for themselves. That said, the limitations of peer advice — the lack of life experience, the tendency toward peer confirmation bias — mean that the wisest approach is usually to draw on both sources rather than treating them as mutually exclusive.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The sociological basis for preferring friends over parents as sources of advice is well-established and relates to the distinct nature of horizontal versus vertical relationships.

Friendships are reciprocal in a way that parent-child relationships, despite their depth, fundamentally are not — both parties occupy a similar social position, carry comparable levels of uncertainty, and share an understanding that the advice exchanged does not carry the implicit weight of authority or expectation that parental guidance typically does. This means that people often feel more comfortable disclosing the full complexity of a situation — including aspects they know their parents would find uncomfortable or disapprove of — to friends, which in turn produces advice that is calibrated to the actual problem rather than a sanitised version of it. There is also the question of emotional consequences: advice from parents comes bundled with the relationship itself, meaning that disagreement or rejection of the advice can feel like a rejection of the relationship, while a friend's perspective can be taken or left without the same emotional stakes. For younger adults in particular, this dynamic makes peer advice feel simultaneously safer and more pragmatically relevant.

6. When would old people ask young people for advice?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The scenarios in which older people actively seek advice from younger ones are more numerous than common assumptions about intergenerational knowledge transfer would suggest, and they are expanding as the pace of technological and cultural change accelerates. The most obvious domain is digital technology: smartphones, social media platforms, streaming services, and online banking systems have developed with sufficient speed that many older adults find themselves genuinely dependent on younger family members for navigation support. Beyond technology, older people increasingly seek advice from younger generations on questions of social norms — how to communicate respectfully across gender and cultural lines that have shifted significantly, or how to engage with conversations around identity that have evolved rapidly in recent years. There is also a subtler form of advice-seeking that occurs around consumer choices and lifestyle — younger people who are deeply embedded in current markets often have more practical knowledge about fitness trends, nutrition guidance, or app-based services that older adults want to access but find confusing. What is worth noting is that this dynamic, when navigated with mutual respect, represents one of the more constructive forms of intergenerational exchange available — the young offering currency, the old offering depth.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The frequency with which older adults seek advice from younger people is increasing, and this reflects not just technical change but a broader cultural shift in the distribution of relevant knowledge across age groups. In professional contexts, reverse mentoring — a practice in which younger employees formally advise senior colleagues on digital tools, social platforms, or emerging consumer trends — has become a recognised feature of forward-thinking organisations, precisely because the traditional assumption that expertise flows downward from seniority is no longer consistently valid. Outside of work, older people increasingly rely on younger relatives and friends for guidance on navigating digital government services, understanding healthcare information online, or communicating with grandchildren through platforms they did not grow up with. What is perhaps most interesting about this shift is what it reveals about the nature of knowledge itself: in a rapidly changing world, recency of experience is becoming as valuable a form of capital as depth of experience, and the most adaptive individuals — of any age — are those who recognise this and adjust their advice-seeking behaviour accordingly.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
confirmation bias	n phr	/ˌkɒn.fəˈmeɪ.ʃən ˈbaɪ.əs/	the tendency to favour information that confirms existing beliefs	thiên kiến xác nhận
analysis paralysis	n phr	/əˈnæl.ɪ.sɪs pəˈræl.ɪ.sɪs/	inability to decide due to over-thinking or too much information	tê liệt phân tích
intellectual humility	n phr	/ˌɪn.tɪˈlek.tʃu.əl hjuːˈmɪl.ɪ.ti/	openness to being wrong and learning from others	sự khiêm tốn trí tuệ
active listening	n phr	/ˈæk.tɪv ˈlɪs.ən.ɪŋ/	fully concentrating on and engaging with what someone says	lắng nghe chủ động
reverse mentoring	n phr	/rɪˈvɜːs ˈmen.tər.ɪŋ/	when junior employees mentor senior ones	cố vấn ngược chiều
intergenerational exchange	n phr	/ˌɪn.tə.dʒen.əˈreɪ.ʃən. ɪksˈtʃeɪndʒ/	the sharing of knowledge between age groups	trao đổi giữa các thế hệ
lateral understanding	n phr	/ˈlæt.ər.əl ˌʌn.dəˈstænd.ɪŋ/	empathy between people in similar life situations	sự đồng cảm theo chiều ngang
procrastination	n	/prəˈkræs.tɪˈneɪ.ʃən/	delaying a task or decision unnecessarily	sự trì hoãn
premature closure	n phr	/ˈpriː.mə.tʃər ˈkləʊ.ʒər/	resolving a problem too quickly without fully exploring it	kết thúc quá sớm, bỏ qua chiều sâu
calibrated	adj	/ˈkæl.ɪ.breɪ.tɪd/	carefully adjusted to suit a specific context	được hiệu chỉnh phù hợp

2.5 Describe a person who often helps others

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a person who often helps others. You should say:

- Who this person is
- How often he/she helps others
- How/why he/she helps others
- And how you feel about this person.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

There is a senior student in my faculty, Khoa, who has become something of a quiet institution in our department. He is three years ahead of me, but he is the first person nearly everyone in the lower years reaches out to when they are struggling — academically or otherwise.

What Khoa does is not dramatic or organised; it is more like a constant, low-level availability that you only fully appreciate when you actually need it. He answers questions on the group chat at odd hours, reviews CVs when classmates are applying for internships, and sometimes sits with people who are genuinely distressed about their grades and just listens without immediately offering solutions. I have seen him spend an afternoon helping someone restructure a project proposal without once making that person feel incapable.

What strikes me about him, beyond the generosity, is the absence of any visible expectation of return. He does not do it for recognition or to build some kind of social currency — he just seems to find it natural to help when something in someone else is off balance.

I think people like Khoa are the structural glue of institutional life. He is not solving grand problems, but he is making the immediate environment more humane for dozens of people, one small interaction at a time. Knowing him has made me more conscious of how much that kind of quiet, sustained availability actually costs a person, and how rarely it gets acknowledged.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I want to describe is my former direct manager, Ms. Thu, who I worked under for about two years earlier in my career. She was one of the most technically capable people in our organisation, but what set her apart was not her expertise — it was the way she gave her time.

She had a habit that I have never seen replicated in any other manager: she kept what she called an open thirty, a thirty-minute slot every Friday that had no agenda and was available to anyone on the team for any reason — work-related or not. In practice, people used it for everything from discussing a difficult client to figuring out how to have a conversation with another team member they were in conflict with. She never seemed to mind what people brought, and she rarely offered immediate answers; she mostly helped people think more clearly about whatever was in front of them.

Beyond that, she had a reliable instinct for spotting when someone on the team was quietly struggling before it became visible in their work — and she would initiate a conversation before being asked, which is rare in a professional context.

I feel a combination of gratitude and something like professional admiration for her. She modelled a kind of leadership that was not performative or strategically calculated, and it has genuinely shaped what I look for in the people I want to work with and eventually become.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
low-level availability	n phr		the ongoing readiness to help without making an occasion of it	sự sẵn sàng giúp đỡ âm thầm
social currency	n phr	/ˈsəʊ.ʃəl ˈkʌr.ən.si/	influence or favour gained through social interactions	vốn xã hội, uy tín giao tiếp
structural glue	n phr		something that holds a group or system together	chất kết dính, yếu tố gắn kết
humane	adj	/hjuːˈmeɪn/	showing compassion and respect for others	nhân văn, có tình người
performative	adj	/pəˈfɔː.mə.tɪv/	done to create an impression rather than from genuine feeling	mang tính trình diễn
instinct	n	/ˈɪn.stɪŋkt/	a natural ability to sense or do something without thinking	bản năng
initiate	v	/ɪˈnɪʃ.i.əɪt/	to start or begin something	khởi xướng, chủ động bắt đầu
replicate	v	/ˈrep.lɪ.keɪt/	to copy or reproduce something	tái tạo lại, bắt chước
in conflict with	phr	/ɪn ˈkɒn.flɪkt wɪð/	having a disagreement or problem with someone	có mâu thuẫn với
modelled	v	/ˈmɒd.əld/	demonstrated a behaviour for others to follow	làm gương, thể hiện qua hành động

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What can children do to help their parents?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of what children can meaningfully contribute within a household is often underestimated, both in terms of the practical value and the developmental significance of what they do. Beyond the obvious — tidying their own spaces, washing dishes, or running small errands — children are capable of providing a form of emotional presence that parents, particularly those under chronic work pressure, find restorative: engaging in genuine conversation, showing interest in family concerns, and simply being reliably present without requiring constant management. It can be argued that the most valuable contribution children make is not the specific task completed but the practice of orientation toward others' needs, which forms the experiential basis of empathy and responsibility. The complication arises when academic pressure or extracurricular scheduling leaves children with so little unstructured time that even minimal household contribution becomes a site of negotiation rather than natural participation — a dynamic that reflects a structural problem in how childhood has been organised in many East Asian societies, including Vietnam.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The forms of support children can offer their parents span a spectrum from the immediately practical to the affectively significant, and both ends matter more than is commonly acknowledged. On the practical side, children who consistently take ownership of age-appropriate tasks — managing their own schedules, helping with younger siblings, contributing to meal preparation — reduce the invisible cognitive and logistical load that parents carry continuously. On the affective side, children who are emotionally attuned to their parents' stress levels and who express care and appreciation actively — rather than passively consuming parental attention — provide a form of relational sustenance that is genuinely meaningful. The broader sociological point is that families function as systems, and when children are treated exclusively as beneficiaries rather than contributors, both parties are impoverished: children miss the experience of genuine usefulness, and parents carry the full burden of household maintenance without the normalisation of shared responsibility that most healthy households require.

2. Should children help their parents with household chores?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The argument for children participating in household labour is not primarily instrumental — it is not mainly about the tasks getting done — but developmental. Children who are expected to contribute to shared domestic responsibilities from an early age develop a practical competence and a social orientation that is qualitatively different from what formal education provides. Research on household labour consistently suggests that young people who perform regular chores develop stronger self-regulation, greater work ethic, and a more robust capacity for delayed gratification than those who are insulated from domestic responsibility. The counter-argument — that academic demands already place excessive burdens on children, particularly in high-pressure education systems — is well-founded, but it conflates quantity of demand with type of demand. Domestic chores, by their nature, involve physical action, concrete outcomes, and immediate feedback, which makes them cognitively restorative rather than depleting, particularly for children whose school day consists primarily of sedentary, abstract mental work.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for children helping with household chores is, at its core, a case for the normalisation of shared responsibility as a family value rather than a pragmatic arrangement. In households where only adults perform domestic labour, children absorb an implicit message about who is responsible for maintaining shared spaces and who is entitled to inhabit them without contribution — a message with lasting consequences for how they relate to partners, flatmates, and colleagues in adult life. The objection that children are too busy or that chores are beneath the priority of academic achievement reflects a cultural hierarchy of activities that systematically devalues practical competence and care work. The irony is that the skills developed through regular domestic participation — attention to detail, task completion, managing physical environments — are precisely those that employers and life partners value highly but that schools rarely explicitly cultivate. The case for chores, then, is not about keeping a tidy house; it is about forming adults who understand that competent living requires sustained, unglamorous effort from everyone who benefits from it.

3. What kind of help do people need when looking for a new job?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Job searching is a process that most people approach with far less strategic awareness than it requires, and the help that proves most useful tends to be structural rather than motivational. The most critical support is access to accurate, field-specific information: understanding what skills are genuinely in demand, how the hiring process works in a given industry, what compensation is realistic, and which types of organisations will provide the most meaningful early career experience. Alongside information, practical skill-building support — help with CV writing, cover letters, and interview preparation — is often transformative, particularly for graduates entering the labour market with strong academic credentials but limited understanding of how those credentials are read and evaluated by employers. Networking assistance, whether through introductions, mentorship, or simply helping someone understand how professional relationships function, is equally valuable, and arguably more so, given that a substantial proportion of roles in most markets are filled through informal channels before they are ever publicly advertised.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The forms of support most valuable during a job search differ significantly depending on the career stage of the person involved. For early-career candidates, the most impactful help tends to be around articulation — helping them understand and communicate the specific value they offer, which is a skill that most young professionals have not had occasion to develop. For mid-career professionals changing industries or roles, the need tends to be different: they require help navigating unfamiliar market norms, constructing a coherent career narrative that makes their transition legible to hiring managers, and managing the emotional difficulty of temporarily inhabiting a lower status position in an unfamiliar domain. Across both groups, what is universally underappreciated is the value of honest, specific feedback — the kind that tells someone what is actually not working rather than offering generic encouragement. Friends and family, however well-intentioned, often lack either the knowledge or the willingness to provide this kind of feedback, which is why professional career coaching, where accessible, tends to produce faster and more targeted results.

4. Who should people ask for help, colleagues or family members?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The appropriate source of help depends fundamentally on the nature of the problem, and conflating the two domains often produces advice that is well-meaning but structurally misaligned with what the situation requires. For problems rooted in academic or professional content — how to approach a difficult assignment, how to handle a conflict in a group project, how to understand a technical concept — colleagues share the relevant context and terminology that family members typically lack, making them far more useful as practical advisers. For problems that carry significant emotional weight — decisions that involve identity, relationships, or personal values — family members, assuming the relationship is trusting, offer a depth of history and unconditional care that colleagues are rarely positioned to provide. The risk in consistently favouring one source over the other is asymmetric exposure: relying exclusively on family for professional guidance produces naïve advice; relying exclusively on colleagues for personal guidance produces analytically calibrated but affectively thin counsel. The most resilient approach is to maintain clear categories and route each type of problem to those best equipped, by both knowledge and relationship, to address it.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

In professional contexts, the choice between colleagues and family as sources of help should be informed by what type of help is actually being sought, not by which relationship feels more comfortable to approach. Colleagues bring domain knowledge, organisational context, and professional credibility that family members cannot replicate — when someone is navigating a workplace conflict, considering a career pivot, or trying to improve a specific professional skill, input from a trusted colleague is almost always more practically useful. Family, by contrast, offers the relational safety needed to process the emotional dimensions of professional challenges — the anxiety of underperformance, the stress of a toxic work environment, or the fear of making a wrong career decision — without the social stakes that attend disclosure to a colleague. The critical failure mode to avoid is using each source for the wrong type of support: asking family for technical professional advice risks generating decisions based on incomplete information, while asking colleagues for emotional processing risks creating professional vulnerability. The most effective approach uses both, functionally rather than sentimentally.

5. Do you think schools should teach children to do household chores?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The idea of incorporating practical household skills into formal school curricula is frequently dismissed as tangential to the core educational mission, but this dismissal reflects a narrow definition of what education is for. Schools have always played a role in socialising children into the norms and competencies required for functional adult life — and in an era where many children arrive at adulthood without the ability to cook a basic meal, manage a budget, or maintain a clean living space, the case for systematic practical education becomes compelling. Japan's school lunch programme, in which students serve and clean up after their own meals, offers a well-documented example of how domestic responsibility can be embedded in school culture in a way that is both practically effective and formatively valuable. The counter-argument that these skills are the family's responsibility is valid in theory but increasingly fragile in practice — as family structures change and parents spend more hours in employment, the home as a site of practical skill transmission is becoming less reliable, and schools may need to fill that gap.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Whether schools should formally incorporate household skills into their teaching depends partly on what we believe schools are for, and partly on a realistic assessment of what families in contemporary society are actually providing. If we accept that schools have a mandate not just to impart subject knowledge but to prepare students for autonomous and socially responsible adult lives, then the exclusion of practical domestic competence from the curriculum is difficult to justify. The more pressing argument, however, is equity: children from households with attentive, educationally engaged parents will learn these skills at home, while children from more chaotic or under-resourced households may not. In the absence of school-based practical education, this discrepancy compounds existing socioeconomic inequality — children who most need to develop self-sufficiency are precisely those least likely to acquire it through family socialisation alone. Teaching basic cooking, financial management, and household maintenance in schools is not a trivial concession to practicality; it is a meaningful investment in the long-term functional independence of the most vulnerable students.

6. Why are employees reluctant to ask their managers for help?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The reluctance of employees to seek help from their managers is a well-documented phenomenon with roots in both organisational culture and individual psychology. At its core, the hesitation stems from the perceived risk of appearing incompetent — in most professional environments, the ability to handle challenges independently is associated with competence and readiness for greater responsibility, and asking for help is susceptible to being read as evidence of the opposite. This perception is particularly acute for junior employees who are still in the process of establishing their professional identities and who may be acutely sensitive to how they are assessed relative to their peers. Compounding this is the power differential inherent in the manager-employee relationship: disclosing a difficulty to someone who controls one's evaluation, promotion, and continued employment is not irrational fear but a reasonable calculation about institutional risk. The tragedy of this dynamic is that the reluctance to seek help frequently produces exactly the outcome it is designed to prevent — errors that either persist until they become visible problems, or that compound quietly over time into a pattern of underperformance.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The structural reasons why employees avoid seeking help from managers go beyond individual psychology and reflect deep features of how organisations are designed and how performance is evaluated. In most conventional workplace cultures, professional identity is constructed around the capacity for independent problem-solving — asking for help signals dependency, which conflicts with the self-image that ambitious professionals actively cultivate. There is also a political dimension that is rarely acknowledged openly: the manager-employee relationship is simultaneously a support relationship and an evaluative one, and the tension between those two functions creates a fundamental ambiguity about whether disclosing a difficulty is safe. Managers who are truly effective mitigate this tension by actively normalising help-seeking — through their own willingness to acknowledge uncertainty, through explicit statements that asking early is valued over struggling silently, and through consistent behaviour that demonstrates that disclosure will not be held against the person who makes it. In environments where that normalisation has not occurred, the rational response for most employees is to attempt to solve problems independently until they are no longer concealable, which is almost always the worse outcome for everyone involved.

 - **career narrative** (n phr) (/kə r ər nær.ə.t v/): the story a professional tells about their career path | câu chuyện

sự nghiệp - **asymmetric exposure** (n phr) (/ e .s met.r k k spə . ər/): an imbalanced reliance on one source of support | sự phụ thuộc mất cân bằng - **power differential** (n phr) (/ pa .ər d f.ə ren. əl/): the difference in authority between two people | sự chênh lệch quyền lực - **compound** (v) (/ k m.pa nd/): to make a problem worse by adding to it | tích lũy, làm trầm trọng hơn - **normalise** (v) (/ n .mə.la z/): to make something seem acceptable or standard | bình thường hóa - **self-sufficiency** (n) (/ self.sə f .ən.si/): the ability to provide for oneself without help | sự tự chủ, tự lực - **socioeconomic inequality** (n phr) (/ sə .si.ə i .kə n m. k n i .kwəl .ti/): unequal access to resources based on social and economic status | bất bình đẳng kinh tế xã hội

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
developmental significance	n phr	/,dev.əl.əp'men.təl sɪɡ'nɪf.i.kəns/	the importance of an experience in shaping a person's growth	tầm quan trọng phát triển
delayed gratification	n phr	/dɪ'leɪd ,græt.i.fɪ'keɪ.ʃən/	the ability to resist immediate reward for a greater future benefit	sự hài lòng trì hoãn
care work	n phr	/keər wɜ:k/	unpaid labour that involves looking after others or a household	công việc chăm sóc (thường không được trả công)

2.6 Describe an event you attended in which you didn't enjoy the music played

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe an event you attended in which you didn't enjoy the music played. You should say:

- What it was
- Who you went with
- Why you decided to go there
- And explain why you didn't enjoy it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

About a year ago, a group of friends persuaded me to go to an outdoor music festival near the city centre — the kind of event that gets promoted heavily on social media with professional photos that make it look far more atmospheric than it turns out to be.

I went mainly because the people going were close friends and I did not want to miss out on a shared experience, rather than because I had any particular interest in the artists performing. That turned out to be the relevant detail.

The music was aggressive EDM — the kind where the bass is so heavy that you feel it physically rather than hear it, and where any sense of melody is essentially sacrificed to the rhythm. I have nothing against the genre in the abstract, but the volume was disorienting and the relentlessness of it — no pauses, no variation, no moment of quiet — became exhausting in a way that surprised me. What I wanted from the experience was the social energy of being with people in a shared space; what I got, instead, was a sense of isolation, because the music was too loud for conversation and too monotonous to absorb on its own terms.

My friends clearly had a different experience. They were energised by exactly what depleted me — which taught me something useful about how differently people relate to music, and why recommendations from friends are often less reliable than we assume.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The occasion was a corporate gala dinner that my company hosted about two years ago — the kind of event that is assembled quickly and where the entertainment choices are made by people whose priorities are catering costs rather than musical coherence. I attended because it was a mandatory professional engagement, and I went with my direct team. The music that had been arranged was a live band playing a continuous set of Vietnamese pop covers — technically proficient, polished enough, but delivered at a volume and energy level that was wildly mismatched with the purpose of the event, which was supposed to be a formal appreciation dinner with meaningful table conversations.

What I found frustrating was not the music itself but the environmental effect it produced. Every conversation at our table required effort that should not have been necessary. People were leaning forward, cupping their ears, and eventually giving up and defaulting to polite silence or gestures. The music, which was presumably intended

to create a festive atmosphere, had the functional effect of atomising the room — putting each table inside its own acoustic bubble and making the collective experience feel fragmented rather than celebratory.

It confirmed something I have come to believe: in social settings, music that is too loud or tonally mismatched is not neutral background — it actively restructures the social experience, and rarely in the direction the organisers intend.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
EDM	n	/i:.di:'em/	electronic dance music	nhạc điện tử để nhảy
disorienting	adj	/,dis.ɔ:.'ri'en.tɪŋ/	causing confusion about one's surroundings or situation	gây mất phương hướng
monotonous	adj	/mə'nɒt.ə.nəs/	lacking variation and therefore boring	đơn điệu, nhàm chán
gala dinner	n phr	/'gɑ:.lə 'dɪn.ər/	a formal celebratory meal, often for an organisation	tiệc gala
tonally mismatched	adj phr	/'təʊ.nə.li 'mis.mætʃt/	having a mood or tone that does not fit the occasion	không phù hợp về không khí, giai điệu
atomise	v	/'æt.ə.maɪz/	to break something into isolated fragments	chia cắt, làm phân tán
acoustic bubble	n phr	/ə'ku:stɪk 'bʌb.əl/	a zone isolated from others by sound	bong bóng âm thanh
mandatory	adj	/'mæn.də.tər.i/	required by rules or obligation	bắt buộc
relentlessness	n	/rɪ'lent.ləs.nəs/	the quality of being continuous without pause	sự không ngừng nghỉ
coherence	n	/kəʊ'hiər.əns/	logical consistency and harmony	sự nhất quán, tính hài hòa

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What kind of music events do people like today?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The landscape of music event preferences among young people today is considerably more fragmented than it was even a decade ago, and this fragmentation reflects the broader individualisation of musical taste driven by streaming algorithms. Rather than converging around a small number of dominant genres — as previous generations did around pop, rock, or R&B — today's young audiences tend to develop highly specific tastes that cut across genre boundaries, which means their event preferences are equally varied. That said, certain formats have proven consistently popular: intimate live performances in small venues, festival-style outdoor events where the social and aesthetic experience extends beyond the music itself, and DJ-driven club nights where the collective physical experience of shared rhythm is the primary draw. What is striking about contemporary event culture is the extent to which the surrounding experience — the visual design, the food and drink offer, the social dynamics of the space — has become as important to event choice as the music itself. Events that offer a curated, aesthetically coherent environment are consistently more successful than those that rely on musical programming alone.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The most meaningful trend in live music event attendance over the past decade is the growing prioritisation of experience over performance — audiences are increasingly interested not just in hearing music but in inhabiting a carefully designed social and sensory environment. This has driven the success of festival formats that combine music with art installations, food curation, and community programming, as well as the resurgence of smaller, more curated live music venues that offer acoustic quality and intimacy that stadium-scale events cannot provide. At the same time, there is a parallel trend toward nostalgia-driven programming — tribute concerts, anniversary tours, and events organised around classic albums — which speaks to an older adult demographic that is both financially able and actively seeking shared communal experiences that connect to formative periods of their lives. The common thread is a desire for music events that offer something irreproducible — an experience that streaming and home listening platforms cannot adequately substitute, and that justifies both the financial cost and the social commitment of attendance.

2. Do you think children should receive some musical education?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for musical education in childhood is compelling and extends well beyond the cultivation of musical skill itself. A substantial body of developmental research has established that engagement with music — particularly structured learning of an instrument — produces measurable improvements in phonological awareness, working memory, attention regulation, and spatial reasoning, all of which are foundational cognitive capacities that benefit academic performance across subjects. More broadly, learning to play an instrument involves a form of disciplined practice that most other childhood activities do not replicate: the experience of beginning with incompetence, tolerating frustration over an extended period, and achieving gradual mastery through sustained effort is exactly the kind of formative challenge that builds psychological resilience in children. The qualification that must be

attached to this argument, however, is that the benefits depend heavily on how musical education is delivered — if it is experienced primarily as a source of performance pressure or parental expectation rather than as an intrinsically rewarding activity, the developmental advantages are likely to be significantly attenuated.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Musical education in childhood is one of those investments whose returns are distributed across a much wider domain than its stated purpose would suggest. The primary value is not that children become musicians — most will not — but that the experience of learning to produce sound intentionally, listen critically, and perform collaboratively forms a cluster of capacities that transfer broadly: patience, attentiveness, creative risk-taking, and an ability to receive and integrate feedback without becoming defensive. In professional contexts, I have observed consistently that colleagues who received serious musical training in childhood — regardless of whether they continued playing into adulthood — tend to demonstrate stronger executive function and a more refined capacity for sustained concentration than those who did not. The argument against mandatory musical education — that it consumes time better spent on academic subjects — misunderstands the nature of cognitive development; it is not a zero-sum competition, and the evidence suggests that musical engagement, when done well, enhances rather than competes with academic performance.

3. What are the differences between old and young people's music preferences?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The differences in musical taste between older and younger generations are genuine but frequently overstated, and they are better understood in terms of how preferences are formed rather than in terms of any inherent conflict between generations. The most reliable finding in music psychology is that the music people encounter during adolescence and early adulthood becomes deeply embedded as a kind of emotional reference point — the period roughly between fourteen and twenty-four years of age is consistently identified as the most formative for musical identity, which explains why adults often describe music from their youth as objectively better rather than simply personally significant. Young people, by contrast, are in the process of forming those preferences and are therefore more open to novelty, more susceptible to peer influence on taste, and more drawn to music that signals generational identity and distinction. The practical consequence of this is that older adults often interpret younger people's music as lacking depth, while younger people interpret older adults' music as inaccessible or irrelevant — when in reality both are responding predictably to the same underlying psychological mechanism operating at a different phase of development.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The generational divide in music preference is real, but it is less about intrinsic quality or complexity than about the social functions music is being asked to serve. For younger audiences, music is frequently a vehicle for shared experience, identity formation, and social signalling — it marks membership in communities, expresses emerging values, and provides the soundtrack to emotionally formative experiences. For older adults, music tends to function more as a repository of memory and a source of emotional continuity — a connection to significant life periods, relationships, and developmental phases that have otherwise receded. These different functions produce different preferences: younger listeners tend to prioritise energy, novelty, and cultural currency, while older listeners tend to prioritise lyrical depth, acoustic warmth, and associative resonance. Neither set of preferences is more sophisticated than the other; they reflect the different psychological needs that music is being selected to

meet. What is interesting is that specific artists — those who combine emotional authenticity with musical craft — tend to maintain appeal across generational boundaries in ways that purely trend-driven acts do not.

4. What kind of music events are there in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Vietnam's live music landscape has expanded significantly in variety and scale over the past decade, driven by the growth of youth urban culture and increased investment in the creative economy. At the largest scale, international music festivals — notably Monsoon Music Festival in Hanoi and 8Wonder in Ho Chi Minh City — have established a format that brings together international and domestic artists in outdoor settings with strong production values and a diverse audience. Below that tier, there is a thriving ecosystem of smaller live music venues — jazz clubs, acoustic cafés, and rooftop performance spaces — that cater to audiences looking for intimacy and variety over spectacle. Traditional music events also remain a significant part of the cultural calendar, particularly in central and northern Vietnam, where forms like quan họ folk singing, cải lương, and royal court music performance are maintained both as living cultural practices and as elements of heritage tourism. The tension between the rapid growth of international-format commercial events and the preservation of these traditional forms is one of the more interesting cultural dynamics in Vietnam's contemporary music scene.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The music event ecosystem in Vietnam reflects the country's broader cultural duality: a rapidly internationalising urban youth culture coexisting with a deep tradition of regional musical heritage that has not yet been fully integrated into mainstream entertainment infrastructure. At the commercial end, the K-pop and Western pop influence has driven strong demand for concert formats built around choreographed performance and high production spectacle, and Vietnamese artists increasingly present within those frameworks. The corporate events sector — company galas, awards ceremonies, product launches — represents another substantial slice of live music activity, typically featuring cover bands or pop artists performing truncated sets. What remains underserved in the Vietnamese market is the mid-tier — the kind of thoughtfully programmed, regularly scheduled live music venues that sustain creative communities and develop audiences for more diverse musical forms. Cities like Bangkok or Kuala Lumpur have significantly more developed ecosystems of this kind, and their existence is not incidental to the relative strength of those cities' broader creative economies.

5. Why do many people like listening to music while doing sports?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The relationship between music and physical performance is well-documented in sports science, and the reasons people prefer exercising with music go beyond simple preference for a pleasant soundtrack. The most established mechanism is what researchers call the dissociation effect: music directs attention outward and away from internal physiological signals — fatigue, discomfort, elevated heart rate — which has the practical effect of reducing the perceived exertion of physical activity, allowing people to train for longer or at higher intensities than they would without music. There is also a synchronisation effect: when people match their movement to a musical beat, their motor efficiency improves, reducing the

metabolic cost of repetitive activities like running or cycling. Beyond the physiological, music serves a motivational function — the right track, at the right moment, can produce a genuine emotional state of arousal or confidence that translates directly into performance. Taken together, these mechanisms suggest that music during exercise is not merely a preference but a meaningful ergogenic tool, which explains its near-universal adoption among recreational and competitive athletes alike.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The preference for music during exercise can be explained at multiple levels, and the most illuminating is probably the psychological rather than the physiological. At the most basic level, exercise — particularly solitary, repetitive forms like running or gym training — involves a sustained confrontation with physical discomfort that most people find aversive when experienced in silence. Music provides what psychologists call a motivational regulation strategy: it manages the emotional quality of the exercise experience without altering the objective physical demands, making the same activity subjectively more tolerable and sometimes genuinely pleasurable. Beyond regulation, there is the identity dimension: the curated exercise playlist has become a form of self-expression and personal ritual for many people, and the music choices people make for exercise often reflect deeply held values about energy, resilience, and self-image. This ritualistic function means that for many people, specific music is not simply accompaniment to exercise but a component of the psychological state that makes exercise possible — which is why disruptions to the playlist can have an outsized negative effect on performance that is disproportionate to their musical significance.

6. What are the differences between listening to music at home and at a live concert?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The distinction between home listening and live concert attendance goes far deeper than the obvious physical differences in volume and setting, and touches on something fundamental about what music is for. Home listening, particularly in the age of high-quality streaming and personal audio equipment, offers a form of musical intimacy that live concerts rarely replicate: the ability to give full attention to every detail of a recording, to pause and replay, to choose the precise moment and environment in which a piece is heard. It is a fundamentally private, self-directed experience that places the listener in control of the relationship with the music. A live concert reverses almost every one of those conditions: the sound is shared, the moment is unrepeatable, the setting is determined by others, and the experience is profoundly social rather than solitary. What live attendance offers in exchange is irreproducibility — the knowledge that what is happening will never happen in exactly this way again, which generates a form of presence and emotional intensity that recorded listening, however technically superior, cannot replicate. The two experiences are, in the most meaningful sense, different activities that happen to involve the same art form.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The comparison between home listening and live concert experience is ultimately a comparison between consumption and participation, and this distinction matters more than any technical difference in sound quality or convenience. When listening at home, music is encountered as a product — an object that can be summoned, paused, and replayed at will, and that exists in a relationship of complete availability to the listener. A live concert places the listener inside an event rather than in front of a product: the music unfolds in real time, in shared space, with an unpredictability that creates genuine stakes — the possibility of something unexpected, transcendent, or disappointing that does not exist in recorded form.

The social dimension is equally significant: attending a concert is a collective act, and the experience of sharing an emotional response with thousands of other people — the collective surge of recognition when a beloved song begins, the physical sensation of bass in a room of bodies — produces a quality of experience that is genuinely categorically different from private listening. This is why live performance retains cultural and economic value in an era when recorded music has become effectively free: it offers something that no reproduction technology can substitute.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
dissociation effect	n phr	/ˌdɪs.əʊ.si.əɪ.ʃən ɪ'fekt/	music's ability to divert attention away from physical discomfort	hiệu ứng phân tán chú ý
ergogenic	adj	/ˌɜː.dʒə'dʒen.ɪk/	enhancing physical performance	tăng cường hiệu suất thể chất
motivational regulation	n phr	/ˌməʊ.tɪ.veɪ.ʃən.əl ˌreg.jʊ'leɪ.ʃən/	managing one's emotions and drive to perform	điều tiết động lực
acoustic quality	n phr	/ə'kuː.stɪk 'kwɒl.ɪ.ti/	the standard of sound in a space	chất lượng âm thanh
irreproducibility	n	/ˌɪr.ɪ.prə'djuː.sɪ'bɪl.ɪ.ti/	the quality of being unable to be replicated exactly	tính không thể tái tạo
phonological awareness	n phr	/ˌfɒn.ə'lɒdʒ.ɪ.kəl ə'weər.nəs/	sensitivity to the sounds of language	nhận thức về âm vị học
curated	adj	/kjuə'reɪ.tɪd/	carefully selected and organised	được chọn lọc kỹ càng
attenuated	adj	/ə'ten.ju.eɪ.tɪd/	reduced in strength or effect	bị giảm bớt, suy yếu
synchronisation	n	/ˌsɪŋ.krə.naɪ'zeɪ.ʃən/	the coordination of movements or actions to a rhythm	sự đồng bộ hóa
associative resonance	n phr	/ə'səʊ.ʃə.tɪv 'rez.ə.nəns/	the emotional power of music due to memories it triggers	sự cộng hưởng liên kết ký ức

2.7 Describe one of your friends who learned something without a teacher

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe one of your friends who learned something without a teacher. You should say:

- Who he/she is
- What he/she learned
- Why he/she learned this
- And explain whether it would be easier to learn from a teacher.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The friend I want to talk about is Trang, who I have known since secondary school. She is studying economics now, which makes what she taught herself all the more impressive — she learned to produce electronic music entirely on her own, starting around the time we were in eleventh grade.

It began, as far as I can tell, because she had a playlist in her head that did not exist anywhere else and decided — with a kind of quiet stubbornness that is typical of her — that the only way to hear it was to make it herself. She downloaded a free version of a digital audio workstation, found tutorials on YouTube, and spent what I can only describe as an absurd amount of time in her room for the better part of a year.

What she produced eventually was genuinely listenable — not polished in a commercial sense, but coherent and emotionally intentional in a way that suggested real craft. She now produces music for a student short film collective and occasionally posts tracks online that get a modest but real following.

When I asked her whether she wished she had taken formal lessons, her answer was interesting: she said a teacher might have gotten her to a competent level faster, but would probably have also channelled her into someone else's aesthetic framework before she had developed her own instincts. I think she was right about that, and it says something important about the relationship between instruction and originality.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I want to describe is a former colleague named An, who worked in client services at my company but was teaching himself Japanese in the margins of his regular working life — during commutes, lunch breaks, and the hour before sleep each night. He had no formal instruction at any point. He used a combination of spaced repetition flashcard apps for vocabulary, shadowing recordings of native speakers for pronunciation, and parallel reading of Japanese novels with English translations for grammar acquisition. Within about two and a half years of starting this regime, he passed the JLPT N3 — the intermediate level of the official Japanese proficiency test — on his first attempt.

What struck me was not just the outcome but the system he had built around it. He was not relying on willpower or enthusiasm; he had engineered a set of habits and constraints that made the daily effort nearly automatic. He would tell you, if you asked, that a classroom could have provided him with structure and social accountability that self-study lacks — but that for someone with an irregular schedule and a specific

learning pace, the flexibility of autonomous study was ultimately more efficient than any course he could have enrolled in.

His approach has since influenced how I think about skill development outside of formal education — particularly the idea that deliberate, well-structured self-directed learning can in some contexts outperform instruction, provided the learner has both the metacognitive awareness to identify their gaps and the discipline to address them systematically.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
digital audio workstation	n phr	/ˈdɪdʒ.ɪ.təl ˈɔː.di.əʊ ˈwɜːk.steɪ.ʃən/	software used to record, edit, and produce audio	phần mềm sản xuất âm nhạc (DAW)
aesthetic framework	n phr	/esˈθet.ɪk ˈfreɪm.wɜːk/	a set of ideas shaping one's sense of beauty and style	khung thẩm mỹ cá nhân
spaced repetition	n phr	/speɪst ˌrep.rɪˈtɪʃ.ən/	a learning technique using increasing intervals to memorise information	lặp lại ngắt quãng (kỹ thuật học)
shadowing	n	/ˈʃæd.əʊ.ɪŋ/	mimicking a recording of a speaker to improve pronunciation	kỹ thuật bắt chước giọng nói
metacognitive awareness	n phr	/ˌmet.ə.kɒɡ.nɪ.tɪv əˈweər.nəs/	the ability to think about and understand one's own learning process	nhận thức về quá trình tư duy của bản thân
autonomous study	n phr	/ɔːˈtɒn.ə.məs ˈstʌd.i/	self-directed learning without external supervision	học tự chủ
social accountability	n phr	/ˈsəʊ.ʃəl əˌkaʊn.təˈbɪl.ɪ.ti/	being responsible to others for one's actions or progress	trách nhiệm giải trình với người khác
deliberate	adj	/dɪˈlɪb.ər.ɪt/	done consciously and intentionally	có chủ đích, được suy tính kỹ
JLPT	n	/ˌdʒeɪ.el.piːˈtiː/	Japanese Language Proficiency Test	bài kiểm tra năng lực tiếng Nhật
hybrid	adj	/ˈhaɪ.brɪd/	combining two different elements or approaches	kết hợp, lai ghép

1. Is it necessary to keep learning after graduating from school?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

The necessity of continuing to learn after formal education ends is not a matter of debate in any economy that is changing at the pace of the contemporary one; it is a structural requirement that the pace of technological, professional, and social change has made unavoidable. The knowledge and skills that were sufficient to secure and sustain a career a decade ago are increasingly insufficient today, not because learners have lost those skills but because the environment in which they are deployed has shifted under them. The half-life of specialist knowledge — the time it takes for a given body of expertise to become partially obsolete — has shortened dramatically in most fields, which means that someone who leaves education at twenty-two and does not continue learning actively is likely to be operating with a declining professional advantage by their early thirties. The question, therefore, is not whether continued learning is necessary but what forms it should take, how it should be structured, and who bears the responsibility for enabling it — the individual, the employer, or the state.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The argument that formal education should be treated as the complete foundation for a career was already questionable twenty years ago; in the current environment, it is simply untenable. The most significant driver of this shift is not any single technological development but the compounding of multiple simultaneous disruptions — automation, platform economics, globalisation of labour markets, and the emergence of AI-augmented workflows — all of which are reshaping what constitutes valuable professional capability at a rate that no fixed educational system can track. In practical terms, this means that the most professionally resilient people are not necessarily those who received the strongest formal education, but those who have developed the habit, infrastructure, and motivation to continue learning independently throughout their working lives. Organisations have also begun to reflect this: employers increasingly value demonstrated learning agility — the capacity to acquire new competencies quickly — over static credential portfolios, which represents a fundamental shift in what it means to be professionally qualified in a contemporary labour market.

2. Should teachers make learning in their classes fun?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

The imperative for teachers to make learning enjoyable is compelling but needs to be qualified carefully to avoid collapsing into an undifferentiated endorsement of entertainment as pedagogy. The research basis for engagement as a precondition for effective learning is robust: students who are emotionally engaged with material process it more deeply, retain it longer, and are more likely to make connections between new information and existing knowledge. Teachers who design learning experiences that are genuinely interesting — through well-chosen problems, provocative questions, or creative applications of content — produce qualitatively better outcomes than those who rely on passive transmission of information. The important qualification, however, is that enjoyment and challenge are not the same thing, and the conflation of the two is a common source of pedagogical confusion. Some of the most educationally valuable learning experiences are neither comfortable nor immediately satisfying — they involve the productive struggle of encountering genuine difficulty, being wrong, and revising one's understanding. A classroom that prioritises fun

at the expense of rigour is not educationally effective; the goal is to make the difficulty itself feel meaningful and worth engaging with.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether teachers should make learning fun contains an important ambiguity that needs to be resolved before it can be meaningfully answered. If fun means engaging, stimulating, and intellectually alive — then yes, absolutely, because passive and uninspiring teaching is demonstrably less effective than active, participatory pedagogy. If fun means comfortable, effortless, and entertaining at the expense of cognitive challenge — then the answer is more complicated, because that form of enjoyment tends to produce shallow engagement rather than deep learning. The most effective teachers I have observed and worked with are those who create an atmosphere where the learning feels purposeful and the difficulty feels surmountable — where students are stretched consistently but never to the point of helplessness. The teacher's role in this respect is not to entertain but to design experiences that make the inherent interest of the subject visible and the inherent challenge of mastering it feel like a worthwhile investment of effort — which is a very different, and considerably harder, pedagogical task.

3. Do you think there are too many subjects for students to learn?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The critique that modern school curricula are overloaded is widely shared and has genuine validity — but the conclusion that follows from it depends heavily on what we believe education is for. If the purpose of schooling is to produce graduates with deep mastery of a small number of strategically important subjects, then yes, the breadth of most curricula represents a poor allocation of limited learning time. The argument for breadth, however, is that exposure to a wide range of disciplines during adolescence serves an important exploratory function: it gives students the raw material from which to identify genuine interests and aptitudes that they would not have discovered in a narrower system. The problem with the Vietnamese curriculum in particular is less the number of subjects per se and more the way content is structured within them — a relentless emphasis on factual coverage and examination performance over conceptual understanding and genuine intellectual engagement. The reform needed is not necessarily removal of subjects but a fundamental reconceptualisation of depth and purpose within each one.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The perception that students are asked to learn too many subjects reflects a real tension in how educational systems conceptualise their own purposes. Traditional curricula were designed for an era in which breadth of knowledge was itself a signal of education — the generalist was the ideal. Contemporary labour markets, by contrast, increasingly reward depth and demonstrated capability over encyclopaedic coverage, which makes the overhead of maintaining twelve or fourteen school subjects seem difficult to justify from a purely vocational perspective. That said, I am unconvinced by arguments for radical curriculum narrowing, for two reasons. First, students at school age are genuinely unable to know what subjects will prove relevant to a life they cannot yet imagine, and premature specialisation risks closing off possibilities before they have been meaningfully explored. Second, broad exposure to diverse domains of knowledge builds the kind of cross-disciplinary thinking that is increasingly valuable in complex professional environments. The solution is not fewer subjects but better teaching — choosing depth over coverage within each subject and making connections across them more explicit.

4. Is it better to focus on a few subjects or to learn many subjects?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The binary between focus and breadth is more contextually dependent than it might appear, and the optimal balance shifts significantly depending on the stage of education and the specific goals of the learner. At the secondary level, where most students are still forming their intellectual identities and discovering genuine interests, breadth serves an important exploratory function that specialisation precludes. At the tertiary and professional levels, the calculus changes: depth of expertise becomes the basis of credibility and value in most domains, and the opportunity cost of continuing to spread attention across many fields increases substantially. What makes this question complex in practice is that intellectual breadth and depth are not simply competing allocations of the same learning resource — they are synergistic in a significant number of high-value domains. The most creative and impactful thinkers in fields like design, research, and strategy are frequently those who have developed genuine depth in one area while maintaining active intellectual engagement with several others — a profile that neither pure specialisation nor unfocused breadth produces.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether to focus on few or many subjects is one that educational policy, individual learners, and employers all answer differently — and the divergence reflects genuine differences in what each party is optimising for. Individual learners who are early in their development benefit from exposure to multiple domains because they lack the information needed to make an intelligent specialisation decision; forcing depth too early produces expertise in something the learner may subsequently discover is the wrong thing for them. Later in a career, the equation reverses: employers and professional environments reward recognised depth, and general curiosity without demonstrated mastery becomes a credential liability rather than an asset. The most practically sophisticated answer is a sequential one — breadth first, to develop an informed basis for choice, followed by deliberate depth-building in a focused domain, followed by the development of what some professionals call a T-shaped skill profile: genuine depth in one area combined with functional literacy across several adjacent ones. This profile is both intellectually satisfying and professionally durable in ways that neither pure generalism nor narrow specialisation tends to be.

5. Do you think enterprises should provide training for their employees?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for employer-provided training rests on a straightforward alignment of interests: employees whose skills are developed perform more effectively, adapt more readily to changing organisational needs, and are more likely to remain engaged with their work — all of which represent direct value to the organisation. The argument that training investments are risky because trained employees may leave is real but frequently overstated; research on employee retention consistently shows that workers are more likely to stay in organisations that invest in their development than in those that do not, because training signals organisational commitment and creates a reciprocal sense of loyalty. The more compelling limitation on employer-provided training is not the risk of departure but the risk of insularity — training ecosystems designed entirely in-house tend to reinforce existing organisational thinking rather than challenging it, which can produce highly capable execution of the wrong strategies.

The most effective approach tends to combine internal skill development with exposure to external perspectives, professional communities, and industry-wide knowledge exchange.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

From a business perspective, employer-funded training is not primarily a welfare provision — it is a strategic investment in organisational capability, and treating it as a cost rather than an asset reflects a short-term view of human capital that is increasingly inconsistent with how high-performing organisations manage talent. In competitive markets where the most capable people have genuine mobility between employers, the offer of meaningful professional development is a critical component of the value proposition that attracts and retains talent above a certain threshold of ambition. There is also a structural argument: the pace of change in most industries means that the skill sets companies hired for five years ago are not identical to the ones they need today, and without continuous investment in employee development, the gap between organisational capability and market requirement widens until it becomes a competitive liability. The companies that understand this treat learning not as an occasional event but as an ongoing operational norm — building it into the rhythms of how work is done rather than scheduling it as an annual interruption.

6. Do you think it is good for older adults to continue learning?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The benefits of continued learning for older adults are significant and operate across domains that are often considered separately: cognitive health, social connection, professional relevance, and personal meaning. On the cognitive dimension, the evidence from neuroscience is consistent and clear — sustained intellectual engagement, particularly in the form of acquiring genuinely new skills rather than rehearsing familiar ones, promotes neuroplasticity and is associated with delayed cognitive decline. The social dimension is equally important: structured learning contexts — whether classes, online communities, or informal study groups — provide forms of purposeful social interaction that older adults are at risk of losing as professional networks and family structures change with age. The challenge is cultural rather than physiological: many older adults have internalised a narrative in which learning is associated with youth and formal education, and in which returning to the position of learner in later life feels uncomfortable or inappropriate. Dismantling that narrative is not simply an individual task — it requires deliberate cultural investment in making lifelong learning socially normal rather than exceptional.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for older adults continuing to learn is strong on both individual and societal grounds, and the barriers to it are more cultural and structural than they are about capacity. Contrary to the still-common assumption that learning ability declines significantly with age, the research indicates that while certain types of rapid information processing do slow, the capacity for complex reasoning, synthesis of experience with new knowledge, and deep conceptual understanding is maintained — and in some respects enhanced — well into later life. In practical terms, older adults who continue to learn — through formal courses, skill development, travel, or sustained engagement with complex reading — tend to report higher levels of life satisfaction, stronger social integration, and a more robust sense of agency and identity than those who do not. The societal argument is equally pressing: as populations age and working lives extend, the economic case for maintaining the capability and adaptability of older workers through continuous learning investment is not peripheral to workforce policy — it is, increasingly, central to it.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
half-life of knowledge	n phr		the time before a body of knowledge becomes significantly outdated	vòng đời tri thức
learning agility	n phr	/ˈlɜː.nɪŋ əˈdʒɪl.ɪ.ti/	the ability to quickly acquire and apply new skills	sự linh hoạt học hỏi
T-shaped skill profile	n phr		depth in one area plus breadth across several others	kỹ năng hình chữ T
neuroplasticity	n	/ˌnjuːr.əʊ.plæˈstɪs.ɪ.ti/	the brain's ability to reorganise and form new connections	tính dẻo dai thần kinh
passive transmission	n phr	/ˈpæs.ɪv trænsˈmɪʃ.ən/	one-way delivery of information without active student engagement	truyền đạt thụ động
productive struggle	n phr		the process of working through difficulty in a way that promotes learning	đấu tranh có ích trong học tập
credential portfolio	n phr	/krɪˈden.ʃəl pɔːtˈfœʊ.li.əʊ/	a collection of qualifications and certifications	hồ sơ bằng cấp
human capital	n phr	/ˈhjuː.mən ˈkæp.ɪ.təl/	the skills, knowledge, and experience of a workforce	vốn con người
insularity	n	/ˌɪn.sjʊˈlær.ɪ.ti/	the tendency to be closed off from outside ideas	tính cục bộ, khép kín
deliberate depth-building	n phr		intentionally focusing effort on gaining deep expertise	xây dựng chiều sâu có chủ đích

2.8 Describe a piece of technology (not a phone) that you would like to own

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a piece of technology (not a phone) that you would like to own. You should say:

- What it is
- How much it costs
- How you knew it
- And explain why you would like to own it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The piece of technology I most want to own right now is a good e-ink reading tablet — specifically one of the larger Remarkable or Kindle Scribe models, which retail for somewhere between four and six million Vietnamese dong depending on the configuration.

I came across them through a friend who studies abroad and uses one for annotating academic papers. She showed me how it worked during a video call, and I remember thinking it looked almost nothing like what I expected from a tech device — the display is completely matte, there is no backlight glare, and the writing experience apparently feels close enough to paper that your brain processes it differently from typing. That detail stuck with me more than anything else.

What I find compelling about it is not just the functionality but the specific problem it solves for me. I read a lot — mostly PDFs, journal articles, and long-form essays — and I have tried doing all of it on my laptop and on my phone, and neither works particularly well for sustained reading. The screen is too bright, there are too many distractions in proximity, and I find myself summarising rather than actually reading. An e-ink tablet removes most of those variables. It is essentially a single-purpose device, and I think that is its greatest strength — it does one thing without competing with itself.

I have not bought it yet mainly because of cost, but it is genuinely the first piece of technology in a long time that I have wanted for a reason that feels substantive rather than aspirational.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The technology I have been considering seriously for the past year is a portable air quality monitor — specifically a handheld sensor that can measure PM2.5 particulate levels, VOCs, CO concentration, and humidity in real time.

I first came across the category of device through an article about indoor air quality in office environments, which cited research showing that CO levels above a certain threshold measurably impair cognitive performance — specifically concentration and decision-making quality. Given that I spend the majority of my working hours in enclosed spaces, the idea that the air I am breathing might be directly affecting the quality of my thinking was something I could not easily dismiss.

The device I have in mind costs around three to five million dong, which puts it in

the range of a considered purchase rather than an impulse buy. What I find genuinely useful about it is that it would give me actionable information — not just ambient data, but a basis for making specific decisions about when to ventilate a room, when to step outside, and how to evaluate different working environments. In a city like Ho Chi Minh City, where outdoor air quality is often poor and indoor air quality is rarely monitored, having that kind of personal environmental intelligence feels meaningfully different from simply hoping the air is fine.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
e-ink	n	/i:..ɪŋk/	a display technology that mimics the look of printed ink	màn hình mực điện tử
backlight glare	n phr	/'bæk.laɪt gleər/	uncomfortable brightness from a screen's background light	ánh sáng chói từ màn hình
single-purpose device	n phr		a gadget designed for one specific function	thiết bị chuyên dụng một chức năng
PM2.5	n	/pi:..em'tu:..pɔɪnt.fɑ:v/	fine particulate matter harmful to human health	bụi mịn PM2.5
VOC	n	/vi:..əʊ'si:/	volatile organic compound; chemical vapour that can affect air quality	hợp chất hữu cơ dễ bay hơi
cognitive performance	n phr	/'kɒg.nɪ.trɪv pə'fɔ:..məns/	the quality of mental processes like thinking and memory	hiệu suất nhận thức
actionable	adj	/'æk.fən.ə.bəl/	capable of being acted upon; practically useful	có thể hành động dựa trên đó
ambient	adj	/'æm.bi.ənt/	relating to the surrounding environment	xung quanh, môi trường xung quanh
annotation	n	/,æn.ə'teɪ.fən/	notes or comments added to a text	chú thích, ghi chú trong văn bản
configuration	n	/kən'fɪg.ju'reɪ.fən/	the arrangement of parts in a system; a product variant	cấu hình, phiên bản cấu hình

1. What are the differences between the technology of the past and that of today?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The most fundamental difference between past and present technology is not one of capability but of relationship — specifically, the relationship between people and their devices. Technology of the past operated at a distance from its users: machines were distinct objects with defined purposes that people turned to when they needed something specific, and turned away from when that need was met. Contemporary technology, by contrast, has collapsed that distance almost entirely — devices are worn, carried constantly, and increasingly integrated into cognitive processes rather than simply augmenting physical ones. The smartphone in the pocket is the most visible example, but the broader trend is toward ambient computing — technology that is woven into environments and operates continuously rather than on demand. This shift has enormous implications for attention, autonomy, and the very nature of privacy, most of which have not yet been fully processed in cultural or regulatory terms. The gain in convenience is genuine and significant; the costs are real but unevenly distributed between those who can navigate the digital environment critically and those who cannot.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The distinction between historical and contemporary technology is most clearly legible through the lens of what each type assumed about its users. Technology of the industrial era assumed a relatively passive user who interacted with machines through defined interfaces — buttons, levers, keyboards — and received outputs that were largely predictable. The intelligence, such as it was, resided primarily in the machine's mechanical design rather than in any capacity for adaptation. Contemporary technology, by contrast, is increasingly characterised by adaptive intelligence — systems that learn from user behaviour, anticipate preferences, and modify their own operation in response. This has made technology dramatically more efficient at tailoring itself to individuals, but it has also introduced a new category of risk: the opacity of algorithmic decision-making. When a machine is deterministic, its failures are intelligible and correctable. When it adapts autonomously, understanding why it behaves in particular ways — and holding it accountable when it behaves badly — becomes substantially more difficult, which is one of the central governance challenges of the present technological moment.

2. What technology do young people like to use?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The technology preferences of young people today are organised around a set of consistent underlying values — immediacy, social connectivity, expressive flexibility, and low friction — rather than around any specific device category. Short-form video platforms like TikTok and Reels are dominant not because young people are particularly interested in video per se, but because the format delivers stimulation at a pace and with a social feedback loop that aligns precisely with how they have learned to consume information. Wireless audio technology — earphones and headphones — has become something close to a cultural uniform among young urban adults, both as a tool for personal media consumption and as a social signal of a certain aesthetic identity. Gaming, which was once a more niche interest, has expanded significantly in both its demographic reach and its social function — online multiplayer environments now serve as primary social spaces for a substantial proportion of young men

in particular. The pattern across all these preferences is an appetite for technology that enables simultaneous consumption and connection rather than either in isolation.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

From an organisational and market perspective, the technology preferences of young people are significant not just as consumer patterns but as leading indicators of how cognitive and social behaviour is being restructured across the population. The dominance of short-form video as the default content format reflects a shift in attention economy that has consequences well beyond entertainment: the same abbreviated attention span that makes TikTok appealing increasingly shapes expectations in professional communication, education, and even interpersonal interaction. At the same time, young people are also among the heaviest users of productivity and learning technology — note-taking apps, AI writing assistants, online course platforms, and project management tools — which suggests that the relationship between young people and technology is not simply about passive consumption but about building augmented workflows for both personal and professional life. The challenge for organisations and educators is to engage productively with the former tendency while developing the latter.

3. What are the differences between online and face-to-face communication?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The differences between online and face-to-face communication are more consequential than they are typically recognised, because they extend well beyond the obvious physical dimensions of presence and absence. In face-to-face communication, meaning is constructed through a dense layering of verbal and non-verbal signals — tone, facial expression, eye contact, posture, and physical proximity — all of which operate simultaneously and provide a continuous stream of feedback that helps each party interpret and respond to the other in real time. Online communication, even with video, strips away much of this complexity: the field of view is narrow, latency disrupts the natural rhythm of turn-taking, and the absence of shared physical space removes the environmental cues that inform how formal, how relaxed, and how committed a conversation is. The consequence is not simply that online communication is an inferior substitute for face-to-face interaction — it is that it is a categorically different mode of communication with its own strengths, including a reduced inhibition effect that sometimes allows people to express things online that social pressure would prevent them from saying in person.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The comparative value of online versus face-to-face communication is highly context-dependent, and the tendency to treat one as simply better or worse than the other misses the more useful question of which mode is best suited to which communicative task. For routine information exchange, task coordination, and stakeholder updates, asynchronous digital communication is generally more efficient than face-to-face alternatives — it is faster, leaves a record, and allows participants to engage at a time that suits their workflow. For building new relationships, navigating conflict, generating creative ideas, or making decisions with significant emotional stakes, face-to-face interaction consistently outperforms digital equivalents because it provides the full range of social and environmental cues that underpin trust-building and high-stakes communication. The post-pandemic professional environment has highlighted both the genuine flexibility that remote communication enables and the genuine costs — in relationship quality, creative collaboration, and organisational culture — of treating in-person interaction as optional. The most effective approach is deliberate selection: using each mode for the tasks it genuinely serves best rather than defaulting to

one at the expense of the other.

4. Do you think technology has changed the way people communicate?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Technology has not merely changed how people communicate — it has restructured both the infrastructure and the social grammar of communication in ways that are still being fully understood. At the most visible level, digital technology has dramatically expanded the scale and speed of human communication: people can now maintain relationships across geographic distances that would have made sustained contact impossible a generation ago, and can reach audiences of thousands through personal publishing platforms at virtually no cost. At a more subtle level, the norms of communication have shifted in ways that are harder to name but equally significant. The expectation of near-instant response to messages has compressed the acceptable rhythm of communication to the point where a delayed reply acquires social meaning that it would not have had in an era of letters or even voicemail. The prevalence of asynchronous text-based communication has reduced the prominence of oral literacy — the ability to speak clearly, fluently, and persuasively in real time — as a vehicle for social and professional influence. These changes are not uniformly negative or positive; they represent a reconfiguration of communicative capacity whose consequences will continue to unfold for decades.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The effect of technology on communication is perhaps most clearly visible not in what has been gained but in what has quietly been lost. The gains are obvious and well-documented: reach has expanded, speed has accelerated, access to information has democratised, and the barrier to connecting with people across distance and difference has been radically lowered. What is less frequently discussed is the concurrent narrowing of certain communicative capacities that were cultivated by older technological constraints. The discipline of writing a formal letter — structuring an argument, anticipating the reader's questions, sustaining a coherent thread without the possibility of real-time correction — produced a form of communicative rigour that informal digital communication does not require and therefore does not develop. Similarly, the tolerance for silence and for slower rhythms of exchange — the space in which careful thought and genuine reflection could occur — has been progressively compressed by a technological environment that equates responsiveness with presence and delay with disengagement. These losses are real and worth acknowledging alongside the genuine benefits, because without that acknowledgement, the design of future communication technology will continue to optimise for speed and volume at the expense of depth and quality.

5. What negative effects does technology have on people's relationships?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The negative effects of technology on human relationships operate at multiple levels, and the most damaging tend to be the least visible. At the surface level, the effect most commonly discussed is simple distraction — the presence of devices at meals, in social settings, and in conversations that competes with the attention owed to the person physically present. This effect is real, but it is arguably less significant than a deeper structural problem: the way that social media platforms have made relationship management a performance activity

rather than a private one. When friendships are maintained partly through the management of public content and mutual visibility on platforms designed to maximise engagement, the quality and authenticity of those relationships is subtly but significantly altered. The most intimate and meaningful forms of connection tend to require vulnerability, sustained attention, and willingness to be fully present — all of which are actively undermined by an environment that rewards curated self-presentation and continuous partial engagement. The long-term consequence of this shift, which is already visible in reported data on youth loneliness and relational dissatisfaction, is not yet fully understood.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

From an organisational and sociological perspective, the relational costs of technology are most clearly visible in two domains: the boundary between work and personal life, and the quality of sustained social attention. The first is a workplace issue that has intensified significantly with the normalisation of digital communication tools: the expectation of availability outside of formal working hours that platforms like email and messaging apps create imposes a chronic low-level stress that degrades both the quality of professional recovery time and the depth of personal relationships. When a professional is never fully off — when dinner, weekends, and holidays are all permeable to work demands — the people who bear the cost of that permeability are typically partners, children, and close friends who find themselves competing with a professional obligation that has no defined endpoint. The second issue — attentional fragmentation — produces a subtler but equally real relational cost: people who have conditioned themselves to multi-task attention across digital environments find sustained, single-focus engagement with another person increasingly difficult to maintain, which undermines precisely the quality of presence that close relationships require.

6. What are the differences between making friends in real life and online?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The differences between real-world and online friendship formation are significant, but the most important are those that relate to the underlying conditions under which trust is built and intimacy develops over time. In real-life settings, friendships emerge from shared physical experience — repeated proximity, accidental interaction, shared routines, and the accumulated weight of having been through things together in the same space. The slowness of this process, which can feel like a limitation, is in some respects what gives real-world friendships their depth: trust is built incrementally, based on consistent observation of how a person actually behaves under varied conditions. Online friendships often begin from a point of stated common interest — a shared fandom, a professional community, or a mutual connection — which can accelerate a sense of intimacy more quickly but does so on a narrower base of knowledge. The absence of physical presence removes the environmental information that normally informs social judgement, which means online impressions can be either more positive or more distorted than what face-to-face contact would produce. That said, for people with specific interests, physical limitations, or social anxiety, online friendship formation can provide access to meaningful connection that geography or temperament might otherwise preclude.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The distinction between real-life and online friendship is becoming increasingly difficult to maintain as a binary, because the social lives of most adults now operate across both registers simultaneously — with real-world friendships maintained partly online and online connections sometimes transitioning into real-world relationships. That said, there are genuine structural differences in how friendships are formed in each context that have lasting effects

on the character of the relationship. Real-world friendship formation involves a degree of involuntarity — you encounter the people who share your physical environment, and some of those encounters develop into relationships through sustained proximity rather than prior selection. This involuntarity means that real-world friends are often people you would not have chosen in advance, which is partly what makes the relationship valuable: it exposes you to perspectives and ways of being that you were not specifically seeking. Online friendship formation is more elective — you engage with people who match pre-existing interests or networks — which produces relationships characterised by high initial alignment but potentially less capacity for genuine challenge and growth. Both have irreplaceable value; the concern is when one entirely displaces the other.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
ambient computing	n phr	/ˈæm.bi.ənt kəmˈpjʊ:.tɪŋ/	technology integrated seamlessly into the environment	máy tính môi trường xung quanh
algorithmic opacity	n phr	/,æɪ.lgəˈrɪð.mɪk əʊˈpæ.sɪ.ti/	the difficulty of understanding how an algorithm makes decisions	sự không minh bạch của thuật toán
attention economy	n phr	/əˈten.ʃən ɪˈkɒn.ə.mi/	a model treating human attention as a scarce resource	nền kinh tế chú ý
asynchronous	adj	/erˈsɪŋ.krə.nəs/	not happening at the same time; communication where responses are delayed	không đồng bộ
attentional fragmentation	n phr		the breakdown of sustained focus caused by multitasking habits	sự phân mảnh chú ý
oral literacy	n phr	/ˈɔ:.rəl ˈlɪt.ər.ə.si/	the ability to communicate effectively through spoken language	năng lực giao tiếp miệng
curated self-presentation	n phr		the deliberate management of one's image for others	tự trình bày hình ảnh được chọn lọc
inhibition effect	n phr	/,ɪn.hɪˈbɪʃ.ən ɪˈfekt/	reduced social restraint in online contexts	hiệu ứng giảm ức chế xã hội
involuntariness	n	/ɪnˌvɒl.ənˈtær.ɪ.ti/	the quality of not being chosen or controlled	tính không chủ động lựa chọn
permeability	n	/,pɜ:.mi.əˈbɪl.ɪ.ti/	the degree to which something can be penetrated or crossed	tính thấm thấu, dễ xâm nhập

2.9 Describe a perfect job you would like to have in the future

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a perfect job you would like to have in the future. You should say:

- What it is
- How you knew it
- What you need to learn to get this job
- And explain why you think it is a perfect job for you.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The job I find myself thinking about most seriously right now is UX research — specifically doing qualitative research for digital products: conducting user interviews, analysing how people think and behave when interacting with technology, and translating those findings into recommendations that shape what gets built and how. I came across the field through a design elective in my second year, which included a unit on user-centred research methods. What struck me immediately was that it was not really a design discipline in the visual sense — it was closer to applied social science, which matched both my background and the kind of thinking I find genuinely satisfying.

To become competitive for roles in this field, I would need to build a portfolio of practical research projects, develop proficiency with research tools and analysis frameworks, and ideally gain some working familiarity with design software to communicate more fluently with the product teams I would collaborate with.

What makes it feel like a good fit is the combination of the intellectual and the applied — you are genuinely studying how people think and make sense of the world, but within a context where your findings have direct, visible consequences. The work does not disappear into an abstract report; it shapes something real that other people will use. I find that kind of tangible, human-centred impact more motivating than almost anything else I can imagine doing professionally.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The role that represents something close to an ideal for me is what might be called an independent strategy consultant with a specific niche — working with organisations in the social enterprise or non-profit sector to help them develop more rigorous theories of change, improve how they measure impact, and make better resource allocation decisions.

I came to this picture gradually, mostly through noticing what parts of my current work I find genuinely energising versus what I merely execute competently. The project work that has consistently produced the strongest sense of engagement has been the diagnostic and analytical work — helping an organisation understand why something is not working as intended and designing a more effective approach — rather than the implementation management that constitutes most of my day-to-day output.

To reach that kind of role meaningfully, I would need to deepen my expertise in impact evaluation methodologies, build a more credible profile in the social sector, and develop

the network of clients and collaborators without which independent consulting is not viable.

What makes it feel close to ideal is the alignment between the kind of thinking I most enjoy and the outcomes I care about most. The organisations I want to help are doing genuinely important work with insufficient analytical capacity — and the gap between the rigour they have and the rigour they need is exactly where I believe I could make a meaningful and durable contribution.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
UX research	n phr	/ju:'eks 'ri:sɜ:tʃ/	user experience research; studying how people interact with products	nghiên cứu trải nghiệm người dùng
user-centred	adj	/'ju:.zər 'sen.təd/	designed with the needs of users as the primary focus	lấy người dùng làm trung tâm
theory of change	n phr		a model explaining how an organisation's activities lead to desired outcomes	lý thuyết thay đổi (mô hình logic)
impact evaluation	n phr	/'ɪm.pækt ɪ.væl.ju'eɪ.jən/	measuring the effects of a programme or intervention	đánh giá tác động
resource allocation	n phr	/rɪ'sɔ:s ,æl.ə'keɪ.jən/	deciding how to distribute available resources among competing needs	phân bổ nguồn lực
social enterprise	n phr	/'səʊ.ʃəl 'en.tə.prəɪz/	a business that prioritises social goals over profit	doanh nghiệp xã hội
diagnostic	adj	/,daɪ.əg'nɒs.tɪk/	relating to identifying the nature of a problem	mang tính chẩn đoán, xác định vấn đề
portfolio	n	/pɔ:t'fəʊ.li.əʊ/	a collection of work samples showing one's skills	hồ sơ năng lực, danh mục công việc
viable	adj	/'vaɪ.ə.bəl/	capable of working successfully	khả thi
niche	n	/ni:ʃ/	a specialised area of a market or field	lĩnh vực chuyên biệt, ngách

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What kind of job can be called a 'dream job'?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The concept of a dream job is more complex and contextually dependent than popular career discourse tends to acknowledge. In its most widely used form, the phrase suggests a role where passion, purpose, and material sufficiency align perfectly — where the work itself feels intrinsically rewarding, the compensation is adequate, the environment is psychologically healthy, and the social contribution is meaningful. That combination is both genuinely desirable and statistically rare, which is why treating any single role as a permanent definition of a dream job is probably a category error. A more useful framing might be that a dream job is one where the core activities of the work align closely with the things the person finds genuinely energising, where there is sufficient autonomy to perform at one's best, and where the impact of the work — on the organisation, on clients, or on the broader world — is legible and genuinely valued. By that definition, dream jobs are less likely to be found than constructed: they emerge from the deliberate development of skills, the cultivation of working environments, and the gradual discovery of what kinds of problems one finds meaningful to solve.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The term dream job, in professional and career development discourse, is increasingly recognised as a narrative simplification that can be as misleading as it is motivating. The idea that there exists a single role perfectly and permanently suited to any given person implies a degree of stability in both individual preferences and occupational realities that is simply not consistent with how people and labour markets actually change over time. A more useful framing, developed in much of contemporary career research, is the concept of a good-enough job — one that provides meaningful engagement, sustainable compensation, room for development, and alignment with personal values — rather than the pursuit of a singular ideal that may not survive contact with professional reality. That said, the aspiration encoded in the dream job concept is not entirely without value: it directs attention toward the question of what kinds of work feel genuinely meaningful rather than merely tolerable, and that question is worth asking seriously even if the answers it produces are more fluid and more contextual than the phrase implies.

2. What jobs do children want to do when they grow up?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The career aspirations of children are shaped less by any considered understanding of occupational realities than by the cultural visibility and social prestige of the roles they encounter — through family experience, media representation, and the narratives that their immediate social environment frames as admirable. For several decades, the most consistently popular aspirations among children in Vietnam and across much of Asia have clustered around a relatively small number of high-status professional categories: medicine, teaching, law, and engineering. More recently, these traditional preferences have been supplemented — and in some demographics surpassed — by aspirations toward content creation, gaming, and technology entrepreneurship, reflecting the extent to which digital careers have become culturally visible and aspirationally legitimate in ways they were not a generation ago. What is interesting about children's career aspirations as a cultural data point is not their accuracy

but their internal logic: they reliably reflect which occupations enjoy the highest social visibility and moral loading in the child's environment, which is itself a reasonably useful indicator of what a given society currently values and rewards.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The childhood career aspirations reported across most surveys follow a pattern that is remarkably consistent across cultures and time periods: children gravitate toward roles that are dramatic, visibly purposeful, and prominently represented in the most accessible cultural narratives. Professional athlete, doctor, teacher, pilot, and — increasingly — influencer and game designer constitute the upper tier of most compilations. What this pattern reflects is not so much occupational knowledge as a reliable index of cultural salience: children aspire to what they can see and recognise as worthy, which means that careers with low cultural visibility — crucial but unglamorous roles in logistics, public administration, data management, or social work — are systematically underrepresented in children's aspirations regardless of their actual social value or economic sustainability. The pedagogical implication is significant: career education that engages children earnestly with the range and character of actual occupational life — rather than simply celebrating high-status exceptions — is likely to produce more informed and ultimately more satisfying professional trajectories.

3. Do people's ideal jobs change as they grow up?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The evolution of career aspirations across the life course is one of the most reliably documented phenomena in occupational psychology, and the pattern it follows is both unsurprising and instructive. In childhood, as already noted, aspiration is shaped primarily by cultural visibility and emotional resonance. Adolescence introduces the complicating variables of performance feedback — the discovery of what one is actually good at, relative to peers — and social comparison, which begins to calibrate aspiration to perceived realism. Young adulthood introduces the further complications of financial constraint, labour market reality, and the lived experience of actual work, which frequently diverges from the imagined version in ways that require significant psychological adjustment. What research consistently shows is that the people who navigate this evolution most successfully are those who are able to distinguish the underlying values and activities that drive their motivation — the need for autonomy, the desire to work with people, the satisfaction of solving complex problems — from the specific occupational vehicles they initially imagined those values being expressed through.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The answer to whether ideal jobs change as people grow up is almost certainly yes, but the more interesting question is why they change and what the change reveals. Early career aspirations are typically constructed from limited information — about the self, about the labour market, and about the conditions under which different types of work are actually performed. As people accumulate professional experience, they develop a more calibrated understanding of their own motivations, tolerances, and the specific environmental conditions under which they perform well. This recalibration is often described as a narrowing of aspiration, but it is more accurately described as a refinement: the aspirations that survive contact with reality are those grounded in genuine self-knowledge rather than in cultural fantasy or social expectation. For many people, the ideal job that emerges from this process is quite different in form from what they imagined at twenty-two — perhaps less prestigious, less dramatic, or less well-known — but is significantly better aligned with the conditions that actually sustain their engagement and wellbeing over time.

4. What should people consider when choosing jobs?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The factors most worth considering in a job choice are not necessarily those most prominently featured in the narratives through which career decisions are typically framed. Compensation is an obvious and legitimate consideration, but research on the relationship between income and work satisfaction consistently shows that beyond a threshold level — roughly the point at which financial security is achieved — additional income contributes diminishing marginal returns to subjective wellbeing. What tends to matter more, and to sustain engagement over longer professional horizons, is the quality of the work itself: whether the core activities of the role are genuinely engaging, whether the environment provides adequate autonomy and recognition, and whether the contribution of the work is legible and feels meaningful. The organisational culture of the prospective employer deserves more weight than most early-career candidates give it — the quality of management, the culture of feedback and development, and the ethical standards of the organisation will shape day-to-day professional experience far more directly than the formal description of the role. Growth trajectory — the extent to which a role provides opportunities for developing competence and taking on increasing responsibility — is also worth weighing carefully, particularly for people early in their careers.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

From the perspective of someone who has observed many career decisions and their consequences over time, the most common error in job selection is optimising for the wrong variables — specifically, overweighting compensation, prestige, and short-term excitement, and underweighting the factors that determine sustained professional wellbeing: managerial quality, cultural fit, the intrinsic nature of the daily work, and the trajectory of development the role enables. The difficulty is that the variables most likely to predict long-term satisfaction are often the hardest to assess during a hiring process: organisational culture, for instance, is extremely difficult to evaluate accurately from interviews and workplace visits, and management quality varies dramatically at the team level in ways that aggregate employer data rarely captures. This is part of why professional networks and honest conversations with people currently doing the role in question are so much more valuable in job search than the employer's own marketing materials. The question worth asking is not only whether the role is impressive from the outside, but whether the conditions it actually provides are ones in which you are likely to do your best work over a meaningful period of time.

5. Is salary the main reason why people choose a certain job?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Salary is a dominant consideration in job choice, particularly among people entering the labour market under conditions of financial pressure — which describes most early-career candidates in Vietnam. But the claim that it is the main reason, while plausible as a description of first-job decisions, becomes increasingly difficult to sustain as a general explanation once people have achieved a baseline of financial stability. The research literature on job choice and job satisfaction is consistent on this point: beyond the threshold where material needs are met, intrinsic factors — the meaningfulness of the work, the quality of relationships in the workplace, the degree of autonomy, and the sense of competence and

growth — explain work satisfaction more reliably than compensation levels. What salary does is set a floor: a job that pays inadequately relative to financial obligations is difficult to sustain regardless of its other qualities. But within the range of adequate pay, the things that determine whether someone stays, performs well, and finds the work worth doing are rarely primarily financial. The implication for career decision-making is not to ignore salary, but to refuse to treat it as a substitute for a careful analysis of a role's other properties.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The relationship between salary and job choice is more nuanced than either the purely rational economic model or the romanticised passion-first model tends to acknowledge. Salary matters most as a signal and a constraint: as a signal, it communicates how a role is valued relative to others in the market, which has implications for professional identity and social standing that are genuinely real; as a constraint, it determines whether the role is financially viable given the individual's obligations. Beyond those functions, however, salary is a poor predictor of professional engagement and sustained performance. The evidence is robust and consistent: organisations that compete primarily on compensation attract people whose primary allegiance is financial, which tends to produce teams with lower commitment and higher attrition than organisations that compete on culture, purpose, and the quality of the developmental environment they provide. For individuals, the lesson is similarly pragmatic: optimising for salary at the expense of conditions that sustain engagement and growth is a strategy that tends to produce short-term comfort and long-term dissatisfaction in roughly equal measure.

6. What kind of jobs are the most popular in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

In Vietnam, the most popular job categories can be understood on two levels: what is actually occupied by the largest numbers of people, and what is most aspirationally valued in cultural and educational discourse. In terms of sheer employment volume, agriculture, manufacturing, retail, and service-sector roles still account for a substantial proportion of the working population, particularly outside the major urban centres. In terms of educational and aspirational priority, however, the dominant categories are the professions traditionally associated with high social status and family approval — medicine, law, public administration, and engineering — alongside the rapidly growing technology sector, which has become increasingly prestigious among younger cohorts as Vietnam has positioned itself as a regional technology hub. The gap between what is aspirationally valued and what actually constitutes the majority of employment is significant, and it creates a persistent mismatch between the outputs of the educational system — heavily skewed toward university-track academic preparation — and the skill needs of an economy that still relies heavily on technical, vocational, and service-sector competencies.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The occupational landscape in Vietnam reflects the country's position at a particular phase of economic development — one characterised by simultaneous rapid industrialisation, urbanisation, and digital economy growth, all of which create demand for different and sometimes conflicting skill sets. Manufacturing and logistics dominate employment by volume, driven by Vietnam's integration into global supply chains as a production hub. The public sector remains a significant employer and retains considerable social prestige, despite years of reform reducing its relative size. The most rapidly expanding employer categories are in technology, finance, and professional services — sectors clustered in Ho Chi Minh City and Hanoi — where salary levels and career trajectories are substantially more favourable than in

the traditional high-status professions. What is most interesting from a structural perspective is the emergence of digital economy roles — content creation, e-commerce operations, digital marketing — that did not exist as coherent employment categories a decade ago and are now absorbing a significant and growing share of young talent, creating professional pathways that have no direct precedent in the occupational structures within which current employers and educational institutions were designed to operate.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
theory of change	n phr		how activities are expected to lead to outcomes	lý thuyết thay đổi
intrinsic motivation	n phr	/ɪn'trɪn.zɪk ,məʊ.trɪ'veɪ.jən/	drive that comes from within, not from external rewards	động lực nội tại
cultural salience	n phr	/'kʌl.tʃər.əl 'seɪ.li.əns/	the degree to which something stands out in a culture	mức độ nổi bật trong văn hóa
labour market	n phr	/'leɪ.bər 'mɑː.kɪt/	the supply and demand for employment	thị trường lao động
occupational psychology	n phr	/'ɒk.jʊ'peɪ.jən.əl saɪ'kɒl.ə.dʒi/	the study of human behaviour in professional settings	tâm lý học nghề nghiệp
prestige	n	/pres'tiːʒ/	widespread respect and admiration for a profession or person	uy tín, danh giá
attrition	n	/ə'trɪʃ.ən/	the gradual reduction of a workforce through resignation or retirement	tỷ lệ nghỉ việc, sự hao mòn nhân lực
supply chain	n phr	/'sʌp.laɪ tʃeɪn/	the network of businesses involved in producing and delivering a product	chuỗi cung ứng
cohort	n	/'kəʊ.hɔːt/	a group sharing a particular characteristic, often age	nhóm cùng thế hệ
vocational	adj	/vəʊ'keɪ.jən.əl/	relating to practical skills for a specific job or trade	hướng nghiệp, dạy nghề

2.10 Describe a child who loves drawing/painting

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a child who loves drawing/painting. You should say:

- Who he/she is
- How/when you knew him/her
- How often he/she draws/paints
- And explain why you think he/she loves drawing/painting.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The child I want to talk about is my eight-year-old cousin, Bảo, who I see fairly regularly during family visits. He is the youngest child in my extended family, and he has had a sketchbook in his hands for as long as any of us can remember.

What Bảo draws is not typical children's art — or at least it does not look that way to me. He is obsessed with vehicles: trains, aeroplanes, buses, and particularly cross-sections of things — he will spend an afternoon drawing what a submarine looks like from the inside, or where the engine sits in a truck he has seen on the street. He seems to find great satisfaction in making sense of how things fit together and representing that understanding on paper.

What strikes me about his drawing is both the frequency and the absorption with which he does it. He draws every single day, for long stretches, often with the kind of focused silence that most adults struggle to achieve. He does not seem to be performing for an audience — he draws for his own understanding, and the finished product feels more like a record of a thought process than a piece of art intended to be seen.

I think he loves drawing because it is his primary way of making sense of the world around him. In a household with older siblings who communicate through words and text, the sketchbook seems to be the medium through which he thinks most fluently — and watching him use it has been one of the more interesting things I have observed in recent years.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The child I want to describe is my neighbour's daughter, Linh, who is about seven years old and who I have been observing with increasing interest over the past eighteen months or so, partly because she has the most sustained and purposeful approach to drawing I have seen in a child her age.

Linh does not simply draw spontaneously — she has what appears to be a system. She keeps her drawings in a folder organised by theme: people in one section, animals in another, buildings in a third. She references the folder when starting a new piece, compares it to what she is working on mid-process, and occasionally revisits and revises older drawings with visible critical intent.

She draws for at least an hour most evenings, from what I can observe, and her focus during that period is striking — she does not respond to noise in the way that children her age typically do, and she becomes visibly unsettled if interrupted before she considers a piece finished.

I believe what drives her engagement with drawing is a combination of two things: first, a temperamental orientation toward visual observation — she notices the way light

falls on surfaces and how things look from different angles in a way that most adults do not consciously register; and second, the particular satisfaction that comes from the measurable improvement that sustained drawing practice produces — she can see herself getting better, in a concrete and visible way, which is a form of feedback that other childhood activities rarely offer as clearly.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
cross-section	n	/'krɒs.sek.ʃən/	a view of an object cut open to show its interior	mặt cắt ngang
absorption	n	/əb'zɔ:p.ʃən/	deep focus and engagement in an activity	sự chìm đắm, tập trung sâu
spontaneously	adv	/spɒn'teɪ.ni.əs.li/	without being planned; naturally	một cách tự nhiên, không có kế hoạch
critical intent	n phr		the purpose of evaluating and improving something	ý định đánh giá, phê bình
temperamental	adj	/,tem.pər.ə'men.təl/	relating to a person's natural character or disposition	thuộc về tính cách bẩm sinh
visual observation	n phr	/'vɪʒ.u.əl ,ɒb.zə'veɪ.ʃən/	the careful noticing of what can be seen	quan sát thị giác
fluently	adv	/'flu:.ənt.li/	smoothly and naturally, with ease	một cách trôi chảy, thuần thục
sketchbook	n	/'sketʃ.bʊk/	a book of blank paper used for drawing	sổ phác thảo
sustained	adj	/sə'steɪnd/	maintained over a long period	được duy trì liên tục
revise	v	/rɪ'vaɪz/	to look at and improve something again	xem xét lại và cải thiện

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What is the right age for a child to learn drawing?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of when drawing education should begin is often framed as if there were a developmental threshold below which instruction is premature — but the evidence suggests that the more relevant question is not when to begin, but what kind of engagement with drawing is appropriate at different stages. Children begin making marks intentionally from around eighteen months, and the developmental trajectory from random mark-making to representational drawing is already well underway by age three or four. The argument for early engagement with drawing — not formal instruction, but access to materials, time, and an environment where drawing is treated as a legitimate and valued activity — is that this is precisely the period when children are most naturally oriented toward visual exploration and least inhibited by the self-consciousness that typically develops in middle childhood and that causes drawing frequency to decline sharply in most children around age eight or nine. Formal instruction, in the sense of structured technique-teaching, probably makes most sense from around age six or seven, when children have developed sufficient fine motor control and enough representational intention to benefit from guidance on how to translate what they see into what they produce.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of the right age to begin drawing instruction reflects a broader tension in early childhood education between structured learning and developmental readiness, and the most useful answer is almost certainly: earlier than most formal education systems currently begin, but differently than those systems typically teach. The developmental case for early engagement with visual representation is strong: drawing is fundamentally a cognitive activity — it externalises thought, trains observation, and develops the capacity to represent three-dimensional reality on a two-dimensional surface, all of which are forms of reasoning that have relevance well beyond the arts. The mistake most art education makes is treating drawing as a performance skill to be assessed rather than a cognitive tool to be developed — which introduces exactly the kind of evaluative self-consciousness that suppresses natural drawing development in most children by middle childhood. The implication is that the right age to begin is essentially from the point at which a child can hold a mark-making implement intentionally — but that the pedagogical approach should prioritise exploration over technique until the child themselves is motivated to learn specific skills.

2. Why do most children draw more often than adults do?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The discrepancy in drawing frequency between children and adults is one of the more interesting cultural phenomena in creative development, and it has less to do with declining ability than with the changing social meaning of drawing as people age. Young children draw constantly and without apparent self-consciousness because they have not yet internalised the social norm — common in most educational and professional environments — that equates visual expression with artistic talent, and talent with either possession or absence rather than development. When children reach middle childhood and begin to compare their drawings with those of peers and with adult professional art, many experience a form of

what researchers call the realism crisis: a recognition that their drawing does not match what they can see, which, in the absence of adequate developmental support, often produces the conclusion that they cannot draw, and therefore should not try. Adults who do not draw are not developmentally less capable than children — they are socially more constrained, having internalised a permission structure that makes doing something imperfectly in the presence of others far more threatening than it is for a five-year-old.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The observation that children draw far more frequently than adults is essentially a story about progressive inhibition — the accumulation of social constraints, critical comparisons, and outcome-focused performance culture that gradually extinguishes what is, at its root, a universal human capacity. Adults did not lose the ability to draw in any neurological sense; they lost the social permission and psychological safety to do it without feeling that the product will be evaluated as evidence of their capability. This inhibition is unfortunate not only because it represents a genuine loss of a creative outlet, but because the cognitive benefits of drawing — enhanced observation, spatial reasoning, and the capacity to think visually about complex problems — do not disappear with age and continue to be valuable. The adults who maintain drawing practice tend to be those who have found professional contexts — design, architecture, medicine, research — where visual representation is sufficiently embedded in the culture of the work that the social inhibition around it is lower. This suggests that the decline in adult drawing is not inevitable but is a product of the specific cultural and institutional environments most adults inhabit.

3. Why do some people visit galleries or museums instead of viewing artworks online?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The preference for in-person gallery and museum visits over online viewing is grounded in something that digital reproduction consistently fails to capture: the phenomenology of physical encounter with a work of art. When a painting is viewed in person — particularly a large-format work, a piece with significant surface texture, or a sculpture — the viewer enters a physical relationship with it that is qualitatively different from the experience of looking at a high-resolution image on a screen. Scale, proportion, the quality of paint application, the presence of brushwork, the relationship between the object and the space it occupies — all of these carry information that is either absent from or fundamentally distorted by digital reproduction. Beyond the perceptual, there is also the contextual: the museum or gallery provides a curated environment designed to frame the encounter with art in ways that create meaning and establish relationships between works that online browsing rarely achieves. The wandering through a museum — the accidental discovery of a work you were not looking for, the extended contemplation made possible by the absence of competing digital stimuli — is itself a form of aesthetic experience that the online gallery cannot replicate.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The persistence of gallery and museum attendance in an era when digital access to high-quality art images is effectively free and universally available tells us something important about what gallery-going is actually for. If it were primarily about information acquisition — learning what a particular work looks like — digital access would have replaced in-person visits far more completely than it has. The fact that it has not suggests that gallery attendance serves purposes that digital viewing cannot. The most significant of these is the quality of contemplative attention that the physical gallery environment supports — an attention that is sustained, unhurried, and protected from the competitive distraction of

the digital environment. There is also a social and cultural dimension: gallery-going is a form of self-cultivation that carries specific social meaning, and the act of visiting significant cultural institutions is itself a form of engagement with a shared cultural heritage that feels meaningfully different from private browsing. For organisations trying to understand how cultural value is created and maintained, the gallery visit is a useful case study in how physical spaces continue to offer forms of experience and meaning that digital platforms, despite their evident capabilities, have not yet been able to substitute.

4. Do you think galleries and museums should be free of charge?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The argument for free access to public galleries and museums is primarily an equity argument, and it is a compelling one. Art and cultural heritage, as national public goods, should in principle be accessible to all members of a society regardless of their economic circumstances — and admission fees, however modest they may appear to middle-class visitors, function as a real barrier for lower-income individuals, families with multiple children, and young people without independent income. The United Kingdom's decision to make the permanent collections of its national museums free in 2001 produced a documented and substantial increase in attendance, with the largest gains among demographic groups — lower-income families, ethnic minority communities, and first-time visitors — whose engagement most benefits the goal of cultural democratisation. The counterargument — that free admission deprives institutions of necessary revenue — is real but addressable: the most financially sustainable models typically combine free general admission with paid special exhibitions, event programming, and commercial amenities, a formula that maintains access while generating sufficient supplementary income to sustain operations.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for free admission to publicly funded cultural institutions rests on a coherent underlying principle: if a society decides collectively to fund the creation and maintenance of cultural collections, consistency requires that the access those collections provide should be available to all members of that society, not only to those with disposable income to spare. The practical evidence supports this principle: data from museums that have transitioned to free admission consistently shows increased visitor diversity — not simply higher absolute attendance, but a more representative demographic composition — which is precisely what public cultural investment is supposed to achieve. The more interesting complication arises with privately funded institutions, where the obligation to support public access is weaker and the revenue dependence on ticket sales is greater. Even in those cases, however, the most successful models in comparable cities tend to involve some form of free or heavily subsidised access for educational groups, students, and lower-income residents — recognition that cultural institutions serve a social function that extends beyond service to fee-paying visitors and that justifies some degree of cross-subsidy in the name of genuine public accessibility.

5. How do artworks inspire people?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The mechanisms through which art produces inspiration are multiple and not entirely well understood, but the most consistent accounts centre on three related processes: recognition, expansion, and permission. Recognition is the most immediate: when a work of art gives

form to an experience, emotion, or perception that the viewer has had but never successfully articulated, the response is a form of profound validation — the sense that something privately known or felt has been confirmed as real and worth attending to. Expansion follows from recognition: the encounter with a work that does this also suggests possibilities beyond the familiar — ways of seeing, feeling, or understanding that the viewer had not previously considered. Permission is perhaps the most quietly significant of the three: great art grants implicit permission to take seriously the things that everyday life tends to deprioritise — beauty, grief, uncertainty, the complexity of ordinary experience — which can have a liberating effect on how people approach both their creative and their non-creative lives. Together, these processes explain why the experience of being genuinely moved by a work of art often produces not simply aesthetic pleasure but a specific kind of energisation that motivates creative effort and sustains it over time.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The inspirational function of art is often discussed in language that is too mystical to be analytically useful, but the phenomenon itself is real and can be described with some precision. Art inspires in at least two distinct ways: by demonstrating possibility and by creating resonance. When someone encounters a work that achieves something they had not imagined achievable — a level of emotional honesty, a formal innovation, a synthesis of beauty and rigour — it shifts their sense of what is possible in their own domain, whether that domain is creative or professional. This possibility-expansion effect is particularly powerful when the inspiration crosses disciplinary boundaries: architects inspired by music, scientists inspired by visual art, writers inspired by mathematical elegance — in each case, the encounter produces not imitation but a recalibration of what is worth attempting. The resonance function is different: art that captures an experience or emotion the viewer recognises but has not been able to name provides a form of clarity about one's own inner life that has genuine motivational consequences. The person who leaves a museum or cinema feeling that something has been named that was previously formless is often in a state of heightened creative readiness — not because they want to produce something similar, but because something previously diffuse has been brought into focus.

6. What are the differences between reading a book and visiting a museum?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The comparison between reading a book and visiting a museum is one between two fundamentally different modes of cultural engagement, each with distinct strengths that the other cannot replicate. Reading is a sustained, private, and temporally structured activity: the reader follows a single author's thought through time, in an order the author has determined, with a depth of linguistic specificity that no visual medium can match. The knowledge and experience it provides is sequential, cumulative, and deeply personal — the relationship between reader and text is exclusive in a way that no gallery encounter is. A museum visit is, by contrast, spatially rather than temporally structured, inherently selective, and fundamentally sensory in ways that reading is not. The visitor moves through physical space, encounters works whose scale and materiality are part of their meaning, and makes choices at every turn about what to attend to and for how long. Both experiences build knowledge and stimulate imagination, but they do so through entirely different cognitive and sensory processes — and the people who engage with both regularly tend to develop a particularly rich capacity for integrating different modes of understanding.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The distinction between book-reading and museum-visiting, from the perspective of how

each shapes understanding and professional capability, is essentially a distinction between depth and breadth, and between sequential and spatial modes of knowledge acquisition. Reading builds the capacity for sustained linear reasoning: following a complex argument or narrative over hundreds of pages requires and develops a specific kind of intellectual discipline that has no equivalent in museum attendance. Museum visits build a different but equally valuable set of capacities: the ability to read visual and spatial information quickly and accurately, to identify relationships between objects without verbal mediation, and to maintain extended focus in the presence of rich sensory stimulation. In professional contexts, the most analytically sophisticated people I have encountered tend to be those who are genuinely fluent in both modes — who can sustain the logical discipline of careful reading and the perceptual agility of visual and spatial intelligence. These capacities are, to a significant extent, complementary rather than competing, and the cultural tendency to treat reading as the more intellectually serious activity reflects a bias toward verbal reasoning that underestimates the cognitive sophistication of high-quality visual and spatial engagement.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
realism crisis	n phr		the developmental stage when children recognise a gap between their art and reality	khủng hoảng hiện thực trong nghệ thuật trẻ em
phenomenology	n	/fɪˌnɒm.iˈnɒl.ə.dʒi/	the study of conscious experience and perception	hiện tượng học
cultural democratisation	n phr	/ˌkʌl.tʃər.əl dɪˌmɒk.rə.tərˈzeɪ.ʃən/	making cultural access available to all social groups	dân chủ hóa văn hóa
cross-subsidy	n phr	/ˌkrɒs ˈsʌb.sɪ.di/	using income from one source to fund access for another group	trợ cấp chéo
contemplative attention	n phr	/kənˈtem.plə.tɪv əˈten.ʃən/	slow, deep focus given to experiencing something	chú ý chiêm nghiệm
spatial reasoning	n phr	/ˈspeɪ.ʃəl ˈriː.zən.ɪŋ/	the ability to understand and think about shapes and space	lý luận không gian
possibility-expansion	n phr		the shift in beliefs about what is achievable, triggered by encountering great work	mở rộng nhận thức về khả năng
fine motor control	n phr	/faɪn ˈməʊ.tər kənˈtrəʊl/	precise movement of small muscles, especially in the hands	kiểm soát vận động tinh
inhibition	n	/ˌɪn.hɪˈbɪʃ.ən/	the restraining of an impulse or behaviour	sự ức chế, kìm hãm
representational	adj	/ˌrep.rɪ.zenˈteɪ.ʃən.əl/	depicting objects as they appear in reality	mang tính tái hiện, biểu đạt thực tế

2.11 Describe a program or app on your computer or phone

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a program or app on your computer or phone. You should say:

- What it is
- How often you use it
- When/how you use it
- When/how you found it
- And explain how you feel about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The app I want to talk about is Obsidian, which is a note-taking and knowledge management application that I have been using almost daily for about a year. It runs on my laptop rather than my phone, though a mobile version exists — I find I only do serious thinking work on the laptop.

I came across it through a forum post about personal knowledge management systems, sometime around the period when I was becoming frustrated with how difficult it is to retrieve anything you have written in a conventional note-taking app. One of the features that made me try it was the concept of linked notes — you can connect any piece of writing to any other piece, building a visible web of related ideas that accumulates and becomes more useful over time.

I use it primarily for reading notes and essay planning. When I finish an article or a book passage, I write a summary in my own words, tag it with relevant concepts, and link it to other notes it relates to. When I start a writing task, I pull the linked notes together as a kind of scaffolding before I begin.

What I feel about it is difficult to articulate precisely, but the closest I can get is: it makes thinking feel less ephemeral. Without it, ideas and readings scatter. With it, there is something that slowly accumulates, and that accumulation feels like a genuine intellectual asset in a way that other note-taking tools have not.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The tool that has had the most significant impact on how I work over the past two years is Notion — specifically the way I have configured it as a personal project management and information dashboard.

I was introduced to it by a colleague who was using it to track client deliverables, and I initially adopted it for the same purpose. What happened over time, however, was that it expanded far beyond project management into something closer to a second brain: I maintain a reading log, a decision journal — where I record the context and reasoning behind significant professional choices — and a running document of professional principles that I revise periodically.

The feature I find most valuable is the database functionality, which allows me to filter and view the same underlying information in multiple different formats depending on what I need at any given moment — a task list, a calendar, a table of prioritised decisions. It is not a perfect tool — it is slow, occasionally unreliable, and the learning

curve for non-obvious features is steeper than it should be — but the underlying concept of a unified, customisable workspace has been genuinely transformative for how I manage complex information across multiple ongoing projects.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
knowledge management	n phr	/ˈnɒl.ɪdʒ 'mæn.ɪdʒ.mənt/	the process of organising and using information effectively	quản lý tri thức
scaffolding	n	/'skæf.əl.dɪŋ/	a temporary support structure; in learning, it means structured support for thinking	giàn giáo; hỗ trợ cấu trúc tư duy
ephemeral	adj	/ɪ'fem.ər.əl/	lasting for only a short time	thoáng qua, ngắn ngủi
decision journal	n phr	/dɪ'sɪʒ.ən 'dʒɜː.nəl/	a record of decisions and the reasoning behind them	nhật ký quyết định
database	n	/'deɪ.tə.beɪs/	an organised collection of structured information	cơ sở dữ liệu
learning curve	n phr	/'lɜː.nɪŋ kɜːv/	the rate at which a skill becomes easier with practice	đường cong học tập, độ khó ban đầu
personal knowledge management	n phr		a system for organising one's own notes and information	quản lý tri thức cá nhân
interface	n	/'ɪn.tə.feɪs/	the visual layout through which a user interacts with a program	giao diện
integrate	v	/'ɪn.tɪ.ɡreɪt/	to combine parts into a working whole	tích hợp
dashboard	n	/'dæʃ.bɔːd/	a display that shows key information at a glance	bảng điều khiển, màn hình tổng quan

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What are the differences between old and young people when using apps?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The differences in how older and younger people engage with apps reflect generational divergences in both the cognitive frameworks people bring to digital interfaces and the social contexts in which they learned to use technology. Younger users — who typically encountered smartphones before they encountered most other complex technology — tend to approach new apps with a relatively high tolerance for exploration and a willingness to discover functionality through trial and error rather than instruction. This produces faster initial adoption but also a certain shallowness: many young users use only a fraction of an app's functionality because they have never been compelled to investigate further. Older users, who often learned to use technology in contexts requiring sequential instruction and explicit documentation, tend to be slower to adopt new tools but more thorough in their use once they have committed to learning a particular application. The more consequential difference lies in purpose: younger users tend to adopt apps that serve social and expressive functions, while older users are more likely to engage with apps that serve defined practical ends — navigation, banking, communication — and to be more resistant to ambiguous tools whose value requires investment to discover.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

From an organisational and product design perspective, the generational differences in app usage are most significant in two areas: onboarding behaviour and tolerance for complexity. Younger users, habituated to intuitive interfaces from childhood, tend to resist extensive onboarding tutorials and prefer to discover functionality organically — a preference that shapes how the majority of mainstream consumer apps are designed. Older users, particularly those who adopted smartphones and apps later in life without the benefit of digital-native socialisation, often find intuitive interfaces less intuitive than their designers intend, and benefit from more structured introduction to functionality. The underlying reason is not cognitive decline — most of the research on digital literacy suggests that the gap is primarily experiential rather than inherent — but exposure: people who grew up with touchscreen interfaces have internalised a set of gestural conventions that are not obvious to those who did not. The design implication is significant: apps optimised exclusively for young users tend to systematically exclude older adults from functionality that could be genuinely useful to them, which is both a business limitation and a social equity concern.

2. Why do some people not like using apps?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The resistance some people have toward using apps is generally more rational than it appears from the outside, and dismissing it as technophobia misses the substantive concerns it often encodes. The most commonly stated objections relate to privacy and data security: many apps require access to personal information — location, contacts, camera, and browsing behaviour — whose commercial use is opaque to most users, and people who have developed a more critical understanding of how that information is monetised have legitimate reasons to limit their app footprint. Beyond privacy, there are functional objections: many apps are poorly designed, slow, unreliable, or cluttered with features that serve the developer's

business model rather than the user's actual needs. The frustration of apps that require accounts to perform simple functions, that deliver constant notifications, or that bury the most-used features behind several interface layers is a rational response to real design failures, not an irrational rejection of technology. A third category of resistance is philosophical: some people have made a considered decision that the convenience apps offer is not worth the attentional and psychological costs of maintaining an device-mediated version of every aspect of daily life.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The aversion to apps among certain professional and older-adult populations is substantially underanalysed as a phenomenon, because it is typically characterised as resistance to technology rather than as a reasonable response to a specific set of design and business practices. The more accurate framing is that many apps are designed primarily to acquire and retain users rather than to serve user needs, and people who have spent enough time with technology to recognise this pattern develop a healthy scepticism toward new apps that is actually a form of sophisticated digital literacy rather than its absence. The pervasive business model of free apps monetised through data collection or attention sale introduces a structural conflict of interest between app designers and users that is not present in, say, a paid software tool with a defined function. People who have internalised this structural reality — who understand that if a product is free, they are the product — often choose deliberately to limit their app usage to tools where the value exchange is transparent and proportionate. This is a more sophisticated response than uncritical adoption, and it deserves to be characterised as such.

3. What apps are popular in your country? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

In Vietnam, the most widely used applications reflect a specific intersection of the country's demographic profile, infrastructure characteristics, and social communication preferences. Zalo is perhaps the most distinctively Vietnamese success story in the app market: a domestic messaging and social platform that has maintained dominance despite competition from international alternatives, largely because it is deeply embedded in both personal and official communication — many government services, school communications, and workplace channels operate through it. Grab has similarly become a near-essential utility across the major cities, combining ride-hailing, food delivery, and payment functions in a way that reflects both the strength of Vietnam's gig economy and the inadequacy of alternative delivery and transport infrastructure. TikTok has achieved extraordinary penetration among Vietnamese youth — Vietnam is among the platform's highest per-capita usage markets — which reflects both the quality of the product itself and broader patterns of media consumption among a young, urban, and increasingly digitally fluent population.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The app landscape in Vietnam is interesting precisely because it reflects the coexistence of strong domestic platforms and global tools, each serving distinct functions in a divided market. In the professional sphere, Microsoft Teams and Zoom became entrenched during the pandemic and have retained significant market share in corporate settings, while Google Workspace has become the standard for collaborative work across a wide range of organisations. In the consumer sphere, Zalo's dominance in personal communication is a genuinely unusual outcome in the regional context — most Southeast Asian markets have been more thoroughly colonised by WhatsApp or Facebook Messenger — and it reflects effective government positioning of Zalo as the preferred channel for official communication, which created a captive user base that subsequently drove broader adoption. The payment app market

is more contested: both MoMo and ZaloPay have significant user bases, with adoption patterns partly determined by which is most integrated with services people already use. The structural dynamic underlying all of this is the Vietnamese market's combination of high smartphone penetration, a young population with significant digital appetite, and continuing infrastructure gaps in physical services — particularly in transport and retail delivery — that apps are well positioned to fill.

4. Should parents limit their children's use of computer programs and computer games? Why and how?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for parental regulation of children's digital media use is well-supported at the level of principle — but the way it is implemented makes an enormous difference to whether it achieves its intended effects. The developmental concern underlying the argument for limits is genuine: extended sedentary screen time, particularly of the passive consumption or repetitive gaming variety, is associated with poorer sleep quality, reduced physical activity, and — in high-exposure cases — with attentional patterns that make sustained focus on less stimulating activities more difficult. Blanket prohibition, however, tends to be both practically ineffective and educationally counterproductive: it prevents the development of self-regulatory capacity, drives usage underground, and deprives children of the digital literacy that comes from engaged and reflective use of the technology they will inhabit for the rest of their lives. The more defensible approach is structured engagement rather than prohibition: establishing clear temporal limits for recreational use, creating digital-free periods and spaces — particularly around meals and at bedtime — and maintaining active rather than passive parental engagement with the content children are consuming.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether parents should limit children's digital media use is one that requires distinguishing between the type of use being regulated, the age of the child, and the criteria by which a limit is judged to be achieving its purpose. Regulation that targets specific harm vectors — screens in the bedroom after a certain hour, unsupervised access to social media before adolescence, gaming that is displacing sleep or physical activity — has a coherent empirical basis and is likely to produce better developmental outcomes than unrestricted access. Regulation that operates as blanket time restriction without regard to content type conflates meaningfully different activities: thirty minutes of coding practice, cooperative online gaming with social peers, or educational video watching are categorically different from thirty minutes of algorithmic infinite-scroll content, and treating them identically under a time budget is both pedagogically unsophisticated and practically resented by children old enough to notice the distinction. The most effective models of digital parenting tend to involve consistent parental engagement with children's digital activity — knowing what they are playing, watching, and communicating — rather than purely enforcement-based limitation.

5. Do you think young people are more and more reliant on these programs?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The increasing reliance of young people on digital programs and apps is a real and documentable trend, but the value of that reliance depends almost entirely on what is being

relied upon and for what purpose. Dependence on navigation apps, language translation tools, or writing assistance software for tasks that people previously completed through trained skills represents a genuine substitution that may have long-term consequences for the development of those skills — a dynamic that researchers sometimes describe as cognitive offloading. The concern is not that using these tools is inherently bad, but that over-reliance can suppress the development of underlying capacities that the tools are designed to augment rather than replace. At the same time, reliance on apps for scheduling, communication, information access, and task management represents a form of cognitive extension that is arguably no more problematic than reliance on earlier technologies — books, calculators, or maps — for equivalent purposes. The distinction worth making is between reliance that supplements human capacity and reliance that progressively substitutes for it; the latter warrants more careful scrutiny than the former.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

In professional contexts, the growing reliance of young employees on digital programs is a double-edged phenomenon that deserves more nuanced analysis than it typically receives. On one side, the facility with which younger workers integrate productivity tools, communication platforms, and analytical software into their workflows represents a genuine competitive capability — they can accomplish certain types of work faster and with less friction than counterparts who did not grow up with these tools. On the other side, there are growing concerns in professional education and management circles about what might be called app-mediated deskilling: the gradual attrition of foundational analytical and communication capabilities in workers who have always had access to tools that perform those functions automatically. The specific concern is not that tools are being used, but that they are being used without sufficient understanding of the underlying processes they are automating — which produces workers who can operate effectively when tools function as expected but struggle to identify errors, apply judgement, or adapt when tools fail or produce unexpected outputs. Building genuine capability rather than tool-dependency is increasingly a conscious priority for the organisations that develop and retain professional talent most effectively.

6. What do you think about some countries banning children from using social media?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The policy of banning children from social media platforms — as Australia has begun to implement for users under sixteen — is best understood as a response to a genuine documented harm rather than as moral panic, and the evidence base for concern about social media's effects on adolescent mental health has strengthened considerably in recent years. The mechanisms that make social media particularly damaging for younger adolescents are reasonably well understood: social comparison at a scale and intensity that no previous generation has experienced, exposure to algorithmically optimised content designed to maximise emotional arousal, and the displacement of time previously available for face-to-face interaction, sleep, and physical activity. The case against age-based bans rests on implementation concerns rather than substantive disagreement with the underlying motivation: age verification is technically difficult to enforce without creating new privacy problems, and blanket prohibition may drive usage to less visible platforms that are even harder to regulate. The more nuanced position is that the goal — protecting developmental space for children and adolescents from an environment designed by and for adults with commercial interests — is right, but the mechanisms for achieving it require more careful design than blunt access prohibition.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

National policies restricting children’s social media access represent a significant regulatory intervention in a domain that has previously operated largely without oversight, and they deserve to be evaluated seriously rather than dismissed as either excessive paternalism or insufficient protection depending on one’s political starting point. The underlying justification is substantive: social media platforms are designed by engineers and product managers to maximise engagement using psychological mechanisms — variable reward schedules, social validation triggers, and algorithmic personalisation — that are known to be particularly potent in adolescent brains that are still developing the prefrontal regulation capacities needed to manage impulsive behaviour. Age restrictions of the kind Australia has introduced represent a decision by a democratic government that the terms under which commercial platforms have been allowed to operate with users below a certain age are not acceptable — a decision that is, at minimum, coherent and defensible. The implementation challenges are real, but they are engineering and policy design problems rather than reasons to accept the status quo. The more interesting question is whether age restriction alone addresses the underlying structural problem — the fundamental tension between the commercial incentives driving platform design and the wellbeing of the users those platforms are designed to exploit — or whether it simply shifts the harm threshold to a slightly older, slightly more regulation-resistant cohort.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
cognitive offloading	n phr	/'kɒɡ.nɪ.trɪv 'ɒf.ləʊ.dɪŋ/	using external tools to perform mental tasks	giảm tải nhận thức bằng công cụ bên ngoài
deskilling	n	/di:'skɪl.ɪŋ/	the gradual loss of skills due to over-reliance on automation	mất kỹ năng do phụ thuộc vào công nghệ
age verification	n phr	/eɪdʒ ,ver.ɪ.fɪ'keɪ.ʃən/	confirming a user's age before granting access	xác minh độ tuổi
variable reward schedule	n phr		a pattern of unpredictable rewards that drives compulsive behaviour	lịch trình thưởng ngẫu nhiên (gây nghiện)
prefrontal regulation	n phr	/,pri:.frʌn.təl ,reg.jʊ'leɪ.ʃən/	the brain's ability to control impulses and emotions	điều tiết vùng tiền trán
onboarding	n	/'ɒn.bɔɪ.dɪŋ/	the process of introducing a new user to a product	quá trình làm quen với phần mềm
monetise	v	/'mɒn.ɪ.taɪz/	to convert something into a source of income	kiếm tiền từ, thương mại hóa
digital literacy	n phr	/'dɪdʒ.ɪ.təl 'lɪt.ər.ə.si/	the ability to use and critically evaluate digital tools	hiểu biết kỹ thuật số
infinite scroll	n phr	/'ɪn.fɪ.nɪt skrɔʊl/	a design feature that continuously loads content to keep users engaged	cuộn vô hạn (thiết kế giữ người dùng)

2.12 Describe a person who makes plans a lot and is good at planning

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a person who makes plans a lot and is good at planning. You should say:

- Who he/she is
- How you knew him/her
- What plans he/she makes
- And explain how you feel about this person.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I immediately think of when it comes to planning is my close friend, Minh, who is studying engineering at the same university as me. He is not the most conspicuous person in a social setting — he does not seek attention, and he is generally quite quiet in large groups — but anyone who has worked with him on a project quickly comes to realise that he has an unusually structured relationship with time and task management.

What Minh does is not excessive planning for its own sake — it is planning in service of a very clear-eyed understanding of how projects actually go wrong. He maintains what he calls a project brief for any significant commitment: a one-page summary of the goal, the constraints, the major tasks, their sequencing, and the most likely failure points. Every group project I have done with him has finished on time and without the frantic last-minute revision that characterises most student work.

What I feel about him is complex. I admire the capacity and what it produces enormously — working with him is genuinely calmer and more satisfying than working with people who operate on instinct. But I sometimes also notice something that looks like discomfort when situations develop in ways the plan does not account for — which suggests that planning, for him, also serves an anxiety-management function rather than purely an efficiency one. That observation has made me think carefully about the difference between planning as a tool and planning as a way of controlling what cannot ultimately be controlled.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The person with the most sophisticated planning practice I have personally observed in a professional setting is my former line manager, Ms. Phương, who led the strategy team at the organisation where I worked for three years.

What distinguished her approach to planning from the perfunctory planning I had seen elsewhere was the degree of disciplined uncertainty she built into every plan. Most project plans I had encountered treated timelines and deliverables as commitments rather than estimates — the implicit assumption being that if things were planned correctly they would proceed as anticipated. Her plans always included explicit risk registers documenting the conditions under which each assumption was most likely to fail, designated decision points at which plans would be formally reconsidered, and buffer allocations that were calculated rather than simply appended.

The effect of this was twofold: her projects genuinely did run more smoothly than

comparable ones, partly because problems were anticipated and partly because the team's psychological contract with the plan was more realistic and therefore more resilient. And her capacity to pivot without drama when circumstances changed was significantly greater than that of managers who treated deviation from the plan as a failure rather than as information.

I left that role with a substantially different relationship to planning than I arrived with — less focused on the plan as an end product and more interested in the quality of thinking the planning process makes possible.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
project brief	n phr	/ˈprɒdʒ.ekt bri:f/	a short document outlining the goals and structure of a project	tóm tắt dự án
risk register	n phr	/rɪsk ˈredʒ.ɪ.stər/	a document identifying potential project risks and responses	sổ đăng ký rủi ro
buffer	n	/ˈbʌf.ər/	time or resource kept in reserve to absorb unexpected changes	vùng đệm, dự phòng
psychological contract	n phr	/ˌsaɪ.kəˈlɒdʒ.ɪ.kəl ˈkɒn.trækt/	unwritten expectations between a team and its commitments	hợp đồng tâm lý
sequencing	n	/ˈsiː.kwəns.ɪŋ/	the ordering of tasks in a logical or efficient series	sắp xếp thứ tự
constraint	n	/kənˈstreɪnt/	a limitation that a plan must work within	ràng buộc, hạn chế
contingency	n	/kənˈtɪn.dʒən.si/	a plan for what to do if something goes wrong	kế hoạch dự phòng
pivot	v	/ˈpɪv.ət/	to change direction or approach in response to new information	xoay trục, thay đổi hướng
perfunctory	adj	/pəˈfʌŋk.tər.i/	done routinely without real effort or care	qua quýt, làm lấy lệ
resilient	adj	/rɪˈzɪl.i.ənt/	able to recover quickly from setbacks	kiên cường, có khả năng phục hồi

1. Do you think it's important to plan ahead?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Planning ahead is important, but its importance varies significantly depending on the nature of the activity and the degree of uncertainty involved — and the tendency to treat it as universally valuable regardless of context is itself a form of planning fallacy. For activities with a high degree of interdependence — coordinating multiple people, managing complex projects with many sequential dependencies, or making irreversible decisions with long-term consequences — prior planning is almost always preferable to improvisation, because the cost of conflicts, delays, and misaligned expectations is significantly higher than the cost of the time spent planning. For activities that are inherently unpredictable, highly interpersonal, or where the value of the experience derives from spontaneity and responsiveness to the moment, excessive planning can actually reduce quality by removing the adaptability that makes the activity valuable. The most defensible position is that planning is a tool whose value depends on fit between the planning approach and the nature of the task — and that the skill of knowing when and how much to plan is as important as the skill of planning itself.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The value of planning ahead in professional contexts is well-supported by evidence, but the evidence also reveals some important caveats that are not always acknowledged in standard management advice. Planning is most clearly valuable in situations where coordination costs are high: when multiple parties need to act in a particular sequence, when resources need to be reserved in advance, or when the consequences of failure are significant and asymmetric. In these contexts, the cognitive work of planning — thinking through sequences, identifying dependencies, and anticipating failure modes — produces a shared mental model that makes execution significantly more reliable. What the evidence also shows, however, is that the planning fallacy — the systematic tendency to underestimate the time, cost, and complexity of future tasks — is pervasive and largely resistant to deliberate correction. People who plan with high specificity and confidence for long-horizon projects consistently underestimate the uncertainty they will encounter. The implication is not that planning is futile but that good planning must explicitly incorporate uncertainty — through scenario analysis, risk registers, and staged decision points — rather than treating the plan as a forecast of how things will actually unfold.

2. Do you think children should plan their future careers?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether children should plan their future careers is one that requires distinguishing between the educational value of career exploration and the developmental hazards of premature career commitment. Encouraging children to think about careers — to explore what different professions involve, what they find engaging, and what kinds of problems they would like to spend their lives on — is clearly beneficial: it develops occupational literacy, connects learning to purpose, and helps children build a richer understanding of the relationship between education and adult life. Requiring children to commit to specific career plans, however, is both developmentally premature and practically counterproductive: children's interests, capacities, and values change substantially across adolescence, and early commitments made before adequate self-knowledge has developed tend to be either abandoned or followed too rigidly in ways that foreclose more appropriate alternatives. The most useful

approach treats career exploration as an ongoing, revisable process that encourages curiosity and self-reflection rather than as a planning exercise that produces a fixed destination.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The policy and pedagogical question of whether career planning should be introduced in childhood reflects broader debates about the appropriate balance between structure and exploration in education. The case for early career planning, as articulated in much vocational education discourse, is that it provides motivational orientation: knowing why one is learning a particular subject makes that learning more purposeful and therefore more effective. The case against early career commitment — which is compelling and well-supported by developmental psychology — is that the opportunity costs of premature specialisation are substantial and largely invisible: the student who commits to medicine at fifteen and discovers at twenty-three that she would have been a more fulfilled architect has lost the developmental flexibility that less directed exploration might have preserved. The strong version of career planning in childhood is therefore probably counterproductive; a lighter-touch version — career education that builds broad occupational awareness and self-knowledge without requiring commitment — is both educationally defensible and practically valuable as preparation for the increasingly non-linear career trajectories that characterise contemporary labour markets.

3. Is making study plans popular among young people?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Study planning is a practice that enjoys wide endorsement in educational discourse but more limited uptake in actual student behaviour — and the gap between what students know they should do and what they actually do reflects some important dynamics about how planning is taught and why it often does not work in practice. Among the students I know, there is a spectrum: some plan carefully and revise their plans regularly; many plan in bursts of motivated optimism at the start of a term and then abandon the plan when reality diverges; and a substantial proportion do not plan systematically at all, relying instead on deadline pressure and intuition about priorities. The social media culture around studying — the aesthetic display of study schedules, annotated timetables, and colour-coded planners — creates the impression that structured study planning is more prevalent than it actually is, because what is shared is the plan rather than the execution. The evidence on what actually differentiates effective from ineffective student study habits suggests that the quality of planning matters far more than its aesthetic elaborateness: simple, accurate estimates of task time and consistent weekly review are more predictive of academic success than elaborate schedules.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The observed behaviour of young people in academic settings suggests that study planning is widely aspired to but inconsistently practised, which is itself an interesting and somewhat underinvestigated phenomenon in educational psychology. The structural reason for this gap is the planning fallacy — most people, and young people especially, systematically underestimate how long tasks will take and how many demands will compete for their time, which means that even well-intentioned plans are built on inaccurate foundations and are therefore routinely overridden by reality. The motivational reason is that planning is cognitively demanding in exactly the moments when it is most needed — at the beginning of a demanding semester, when the cognitive bandwidth required for planning is also being claimed by the learning itself. Effective study planning, as distinct from aspiration to study planning, requires not just the initial construction of a plan but the habitual practice of

reviewing and revising it — a metacognitive discipline that is rarely taught explicitly in educational settings despite its proven relevance to academic performance.

4. Do you think choosing a college major is closely related to a person's future career?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The relationship between college major and career trajectory is more complex and less deterministic than the anxiety surrounding major selection typically implies. In certain professional fields — medicine, law, engineering, architecture — the major directly determines the available career paths, and the connection between study discipline and professional practice is direct and structural. In the broader landscape of degree programmes, however, the connection is considerably looser: graduates in humanities, social sciences, and business disciplines frequently work in roles that do not correspond directly to their degree subject, and the most in-demand graduate capabilities — analytical thinking, communication, project management, and adaptability — are developed across a wide range of academic disciplines rather than being specific to any one. The evidence from labour market data consistently shows that the skills and dispositions a person develops during their degree — their capacity to learn, to problem-solve, and to work effectively with others — are more predictive of career success than the specific subject matter of their major in most non-technical fields. This does not mean major selection is irrelevant, but it does suggest that the weight placed on it in popular discourse is significantly disproportionate to its actual long-term career consequences.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The relationship between university major and career outcome is one that management practitioners regularly observe to be far weaker than either students or their parents tend to assume. In my own experience across multiple organisations and sectors, the people performing most effectively in complex roles have come from diverse academic backgrounds — a pattern that reflects the fact that the analytical and interpersonal capabilities that drive professional performance develop across many academic disciplines and are not the exclusive property of subjects that appear directly relevant to the role. The practical implication is that major selection is most consequential in fields with direct credentialing requirements, and significantly less consequential in the many professional domains where what employers are actually selecting for is demonstrated learning capacity and interpersonal skill rather than subject-specific knowledge. The more productive question — which students rarely ask — is not which major leads to which career but which major will develop the specific capacities that the student wants to have, in an environment that will challenge and stretch them most effectively. That question tends to produce better major selections and, eventually, better careers.

5. What activities do we need to plan ahead?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The activities that most benefit from prior planning share a set of structural characteristics: high interdependence with other people's actions, significant lead time for preparation or resource acquisition, irreversibility of key decisions, and high consequences of failure. Travel is the most obvious everyday example: even a relatively short trip involves coordination

across accommodation, transport, and activities whose availability is constrained by booking requirements and capacity limits, and the difference between a planned and an improvised trip is often the difference between a functional and a frustrating experience. Academic and professional project work is similarly planning-sensitive: when multiple tasks must proceed in sequence, when contributions from different people must arrive in a coordinated order, and when deadlines are fixed and external, the absence of prior planning creates coordination failures and quality problems that are difficult to recover from under time pressure. At the opposite end of the spectrum, many forms of creative work, social interaction, and personal leisure benefit from less planning rather than more: excessive premeditation can suppress the responsiveness and spontaneity that make those activities most rewarding.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The practical answer to which activities require planning is best arrived at by asking which activities generate the highest costs when coordination fails, time is wasted, or resources are unavailable when needed. In professional settings, the clearest cases are projects with multiple participants, regulatory timelines, or capital investment requirements — activities where the failure to plan imposes costs not just on the individual but on everyone involved. Strategic decisions — choices about direction, resource allocation, or significant commitment — are planning-sensitive in a different way: the value of planning here is not logistical coordination but the quality of deliberation, the consideration of alternatives, and the explicit articulation of assumptions that planning makes possible. In personal life, the activities most worth planning are those where the gap between intention and action is historically large — recurring commitments to health, development, relationships, or financial management that are easy to defer in the absence of a structured commitment. The activities that benefit least from planning are those driven primarily by relationship and responsiveness — conversations, creative exploration, and social encounters, where planning can easily produce rigidity rather than focus.

6. Should children ask their teachers and parents for advice when making plans?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of when and how much children should seek external guidance when making plans is essentially a question about the appropriate balance between developing autonomous decision-making capacity and accessing the benefits of accumulated wisdom and relevant experience. The developmental argument for encouraging children to consult trusted adults is strong during the stages when self-knowledge is still being formed and when the consequences of misinformed decisions are significant: a child choosing subjects for the final years of secondary school, for instance, is making choices that have real structural consequences for their subsequent options, and doing so without the benefit of occupational experience, labour market knowledge, or an accurate understanding of their own developing capabilities. Seeking guidance in those contexts is not a failure of independence but a form of intelligent resource utilisation. The countervailing concern — that excessive adult direction in planning produces learners who are dependent on external validation rather than capable of trusting and exercising their own judgement — is genuine and important. The most balanced approach is to cultivate the habit of consulting adults as one input among several, rather than as the source of the correct answer, which gradually develops the child's capacity to weigh advice critically and integrate it with their own considered preferences.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The pedagogical case for encouraging children to seek guidance from teachers and parents

when making significant plans is well-established, but the manner in which that guidance is offered matters enormously for its developmental effect. Guidance that takes the form of providing information, exploring consequences, and asking good questions — rather than directing a specific answer — develops the metacognitive and decision-making capacities that are ultimately more valuable than any specific planning outcome. The most educationally effective adult contribution to a child's planning process is typically not the provision of the plan but the modelling of how to approach the planning process: how to define what one is trying to achieve, how to identify and evaluate alternatives, how to think about risk, and how to commit to a course of action while remaining capable of revision. Adults who take over planning for children — who make the decision rather than supporting the child's decision-making process — produce an outcome that appears to solve the immediate problem while depriving the child of exactly the developmental opportunity that the planning challenge was providing.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
planning fallacy	n phr	/ˈplæn.ɪŋ ˈfæl.ə.si/	the tendency to underestimate the time and effort a task requires	sự sai lầm trong lập kế hoạch
metacognitive	adj	/ˌmet.ə.ˈkɒɡ.nɪ.tɪv/	relating to awareness and understanding of one's own thought processes	thuộc tư duy siêu nhận thức
interdependence	n	/ˌɪn.tə.dɪˈpen.dəns/	the state of being mutually reliant on each other	sự phụ thuộc lẫn nhau
irreversibility	n	/ɪˌrev.ə.sɪˈbɪl.ɪ.ti/	the quality of not being able to be undone	tính không thể hoàn tác
scenario analysis	n phr	/sɪˈnɑː.ri.əʊ əˈnæl.ɪ.sɪs/	examining possible future situations to plan responses	phân tích kịch bản
credentialing	n	/krɪˈden.ʃəl.ɪŋ/	the formal process of certifying someone's qualifications	cấp chứng chỉ, xác nhận năng lực
lead time	n phr	/liːd taɪm/	the time required between starting and completing a process	thời gian chuẩn bị trước
non-linear	adj	/ˌnɒn ˈlɪn.i.ər/	not following a straight or predictable path	phi tuyến tính
resource utilisation	n phr	/rɪˈzɔːs juː.tɪ.laɪˈzeɪ.ʃən/	making effective use of available resources	tận dụng nguồn lực
premeditation	n	/ˌpriː.med.ɪˈteɪ.ʃən/	thinking or planning something out in advance	sự suy tính trước

2.13 Describe a famous person you would like to meet

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a famous person you would like to meet. You should say:

- Who he/she is
- How you knew him/her
- How/where you would like to meet him/her
- And explain why you would like to meet him/her.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I would most want to meet, given the chance, is Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie — a Nigerian novelist and essayist whose work I have been reading since my second year of university.

I first encountered her through a TED Talk titled "The Danger of a Single Story," which a literature lecturer recommended. I watched it expecting a conventional cultural commentary and found instead something that reframed how I thought about narrative, identity, and the political weight of whose stories get told and whose do not. That talk led me to her novels — particularly *Americanah* and *Purple Hibiscus* — and eventually to her essays.

What draws me to her work is a quality I find rare: the ability to hold intellectual rigour and emotional honesty in the same sentence. She does not choose between argument and feeling — she integrates them, which is a form of writing I aspire to and find technically very difficult.

If I could meet her, it would not necessarily be to ask about her writing — I think she has answered most questions about that in documented interviews and essays. What I would most want to understand is how she navigates the particular tension she has written about: being a public intellectual with specific, strongly held positions in a world that constantly demands that you either soften or perform your views. That seems to me a question about intellectual integrity under social pressure, and I do not think she has addressed it directly in any form I have found.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The person whose thinking I would most want access to in a direct conversation is Amartya Sen — the Indian economist and philosopher whose work on development, poverty, and human capability has influenced my own understanding of what public policy is actually for.

I came across his ideas in graduate school through his book *Development as Freedom*, which offered a framework for thinking about wellbeing that moved decisively beyond income metrics toward what he called capabilities — the actual freedoms people have to live lives they have reason to value. It was both intellectually elegant and practically challenging in ways that most development economics is not.

What I would want to discuss with him is not historical material from published texts but his current thinking on a specific problem: the tension between the universalist aspirations of capabilities theory and the political realities of implementation in societies with deep institutional fragility. That tension appears in his work but is not, I think, fully resolved — and I am curious whether he considers it a genuine

unresolved problem or a manageable practical compromise. That kind of conversation — honest intellectual engagement at the frontier of someone's actual thinking — is what makes the prospect of meeting someone whose work you know deeply so different from simply attending a public lecture.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
essayist	n	/ˈes.eɪ.ɪst/	a writer who specialises in essays	nhà văn chuyên viết tản văn
framing	n	/ˈfreɪ.mɪŋ/	the way something is presented or described	cách đặt vấn đề, cách tiếp cận
public intellectual	n phr		a thinker who engages with public issues through writing and media	trí thức công cộng
capability	n	/ˌkeɪ.pəˈbɪl.ɪ.ti/	the real freedom of a person to achieve what they value	năng lực/ khả năng thực tế để sống tốt
wellbeing	n	/ˌwelˈbiː.ɪŋ/	the state of being comfortable, healthy, and content	phúc lợi, sự thịnh vượng
universalist	adj	/ˌjuː.nɪˈvɜː.səl.ɪst/	applying to or affecting all people everywhere	mang tính phổ quát
institutional fragility	n phr		weakness in the structures that uphold social order and governance	sự yếu kém về thể chế
intellectual rigour	n phr	/ˌɪn.tɪˈlek.tʃu.əl ˈrɪɡ.ər/	precise, careful, and well-reasoned thinking	sự nghiêm ngặt trí tuệ
narrative	n	/ˈnær.ə.tɪv/	a story or account; also the broader way a topic is framed	câu chuyện; cách kể chuyện
frontier	n	/ˈfrʌn.tɪər/	the edge or most advanced point of knowledge or activity	biên giới, ranh giới (của tri thức)

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What are the advantages and disadvantages of being a famous child?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The situation of a famous child — whether as a child actor, a social media phenomenon, a sporting prodigy, or the child of already-famous parents — is one whose disadvantages are substantially more serious than public discourse typically acknowledges, and the advantages are less durable than they appear from the outside. The most commonly cited advantage is economic: exceptional income generation at an age when most children have no independent financial resource. This is real, but it is significantly complicated by the legal and institutional structures — or, in many cases, the absence of adequate structures — that govern how that income is managed. The more significant disadvantages are developmental: fame imposes on children a set of social demands — public scrutiny, performance expectation, loss of privacy, and premature identity crystallisation — at precisely the moment in their lives when gradual, protected identity exploration is most developmentally important. The documented experiences of child actors and early-fame athletes suggest that the psychological costs of public exposure during childhood are substantial and frequently lasting, particularly when the fame ends — as most childhood fame does — before adult identity has become consolidated enough to provide a stable basis for navigating its loss.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The structural disadvantages of celebrity during childhood are well-documented in the clinical and biographical literature on child fame, and they cluster around two related dynamics. The first is the compression of the developmental timeline: childhood and early adolescence are periods during which identity is legitimately fluid, and the privacy to explore, fail, and revise that identity is a genuine developmental resource. Public exposure removes that privacy, which means that mistakes, uncertainties, and the inevitable incoherences of developing selfhood become public material rather than private experience. The second dynamic is the premature commodification of identity: the child who becomes famous for a particular attribute — athletic prowess, appearance, performance skill, or even precocious intelligence — learns that they are valued for a specific, externally validated characteristic rather than for their full and developing personhood. When that attribute fades, which for most forms of early fame it inevitably does, the identity built around it becomes genuinely precarious. The advantages — financial, reputational, and occasionally genuinely meaningful in terms of opportunities accessed — are real, but they are disproportionately concentrated in the early period of fame and rarely compensate in the long run for the developmental costs incurred.

2. What can today's children do to become famous?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The pathways to childhood fame have expanded dramatically in the digital era, and the most significant change is the decoupling of fame from institutional gatekeeping. In previous generations, becoming famous as a child required access to a relatively small set of institutional channels — the entertainment industry, elite competitive sport, or occasionally academic or artistic prodigy recognition — each of which involved substantial selection processes controlled by adults. Today, any child with access to a smartphone and a reliable internet connection can theoretically reach a global audience through social media platforms,

and a significant number have done so. The practical routes most commonly observed include content creation on platforms like TikTok and YouTube, which reward consistency, relatability, and algorithmic alignment; competitive gaming, which has a substantial young-talent market and a growing spectator culture; and early engagement in niche communities — art, science, music, language learning — where demonstrated expertise can achieve significant recognition within specific online communities even without mainstream visibility. The democratisation of this pathway is real, though it is worth noting that the distribution of outcomes remains extremely skewed: for every child who achieves meaningful fame through digital channels, vastly more produce content that never reaches a significant audience.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The contemporary landscape of childhood fame-pursuit reflects both the genuine expansion of accessible pathways and the continued concentration of most successful outcomes around a relatively small set of structural advantages. Access to production quality, algorithmic literacy, personal branding capability, and in many cases parental support, financial investment, and adult network access — all of which correlate strongly with socioeconomic privilege — continue to determine competitive outcomes in media-based fame pursuits, notwithstanding the apparent accessibility of the channels themselves. For sport, the pathways have not changed as fundamentally as digital optimists sometimes suggest: early identification, intensive training investment, access to quality coaching, and geographical proximity to competitive infrastructure remain the primary determinants of progression to elite level, all of which have significant cost barriers. What has genuinely changed is the range of domains in which fame is achievable — the child who would have had no recognised channel for their interest in entomology or medieval history twenty years ago can now find and grow a specific audience that is genuinely interested in those subjects — which represents a meaningful, if partial, democratisation of recognition.

3. What can children do with their fame?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The ways in which famous children use their public prominence depend significantly on the type of fame, the age at which it is achieved, and the degree of adult guidance available — but the most socially significant uses tend to fall into three categories: advocacy, aspiration modelling, and platform conversion. Advocacy — using public visibility to draw attention to causes or issues that would not otherwise receive it — is perhaps the most obviously socially valuable use of childhood fame, and the examples that have captured most public attention in recent years are the environmental and mental health advocacy that certain young people have conducted with a combination of genuine conviction and sophisticated media fluency. Aspiration modelling — simply existing publicly as a successful example of what a particular kind of young person can achieve — has significant social value that is often underrecognised: seeing someone who resembles you in background, ethnicity, or circumstance achieving something substantial genuinely expands the perceived possibility space for children in similar circumstances. Platform conversion — using the initial fame generated by one activity to build the resources needed for subsequent independent activities — is the most instrumentally sophisticated use of childhood fame and the one that most frequently produces durable long-term outcomes.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The strategic question of what a famous child should do with their fame is, in many cases, a question best answered by the adults responsible for managing it with appropriate ethical constraint. The most defensible approach — and the one most clearly supported by

the evidence on what produces good long-term outcomes for famously young people — is one that prioritises developmental continuity over fame optimisation: using the resources and opportunities that fame provides to access excellent mentorship, education, and experience, while actively protecting the developmental space that fame tends to compress. The child who uses their public profile primarily as a vehicle for cause advocacy that they genuinely believe in is, on average, in a better developmental position than the child whose fame is managed primarily as a content franchise to be monetised. The former builds social capital and purpose; the latter builds financial capital and brand awareness while incurring the psychological costs of continuous self-promotion. Adults responsible for managing child fame — parents, managers, and institutions — carry a genuine ethical obligation to prioritise the second category of outcome even when the first is more immediately financially attractive.

4. Do people become famous because of their talent?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The relationship between talent and fame is considerably less direct than the cultural narrative of meritocratic recognition implies, and the gap between the distribution of talent and the distribution of fame is one of the more reliably observed phenomena in the sociology of cultural production. Talent is a necessary condition for sustained excellence in most competitive domains, but it is far from sufficient for fame, which depends crucially on a set of factors that are largely independent of the quality of what is produced: visibility — being known to the right people at the right time — networked support — having champions and advocates who can amplify your work — aesthetic alignment with prevailing cultural taste — producing something that the current audience is primed to recognise as valuable — and sometimes simple luck of circumstance. The people who achieve fame most durably tend to be those who combine genuine ability with high visibility in appropriate contexts, which is why the most reliable path to lasting recognition in most fields is not simply working harder in private but deliberately building the relationships, credentials, and public presence that enable talent to be recognised by those with the power to distribute it.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

From a sociological and management perspective, the question of whether talent produces fame is best reframed as a question about how recognition systems work rather than about individual capacity. Most domains in which fame is achievable — entertainment, sport, business, academia, public life — have specific institutional mechanisms through which talent is identified, endorsed, and promoted: talent scouts and agents, academic peer review, venture capital, journalism, social media algorithms. Each of these mechanisms has both genuine talent-identifying properties and significant systemic biases: they tend to identify talent that is visible, legible within existing categories, and located in proximity to existing sources of social and institutional power. The practical consequence is that the gap between talent distribution and fame distribution is partly a reflection of unequal access to recognition systems — people with equivalent ability but different social capital, geographic location, or institutional affiliation will systematically achieve different levels of recognition. Understanding this is useful both for individuals navigating recognition systems and for institutions trying to identify talent more effectively across the full population where it is distributed.

5. Is it easy to become famous in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Whether it is easy to become famous in Vietnam depends almost entirely on the domain and the definition of fame one is considering. Within specific digital communities — gaming, content creation, beauty, or fitness — it has become genuinely more accessible over the past decade: the combination of affordable smartphones, low-cost internet access, and a large, active young audience on domestic and international platforms has created real pathways to significant followings for people with consistent output and sufficient algorithmic literacy. In more traditional domains — film, music, literature, sport — the institutional gatekeepers remain powerful and the barriers to entry substantial, which means that fame in those areas continues to reflect a combination of talent, connection, and financial investment that is not broadly accessible. The overall picture is one of meaningful democratisation at the level of niche and community-specific recognition — Vietnam has produced a substantial number of social media personalities with significant audiences — alongside continued concentration of mainstream fame in the hands of people with access to established industry channels and existing social capital.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of how accessible fame is in Vietnam reflects broader structural features of the country's media and cultural industry that are worth understanding clearly. The entertainment industry is relatively small and geographically concentrated — the majority of significant production and talent development resources are located in Ho Chi Minh City and Hanoi — which creates a structural accessibility barrier for talent in other regions. The digital media economy has partially disrupted this concentration: regional content creators with specific cultural knowledge and authentic voices have built significant audiences by offering what centralised media production often cannot. The political environment introduces an additional structural constraint: content that engages with politically sensitive topics is subject to regulatory scrutiny that does not apply in many comparable markets, which narrows the range of themes through which fame can be achieved through commentary or social advocacy and concentrates attention on entertainment, lifestyle, and commercial content. Within those constraints, the social media landscape offers genuine, if unevenly distributed, opportunities for people willing to invest the consistent effort that algorithmic visibility requires.

6. Do you want to be a famous person?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

My honest answer to this question is no — or more precisely, not under the terms that fame in its current form typically involves. The things I would value that fame might facilitate — access to interesting people and conversations, the ability to influence cultural or intellectual discourse, institutional credibility that makes it easier to do certain kinds of meaningful work — are real and genuinely attractive. But the conditions that contemporary fame requires are, on balance, unappealing to me: the continuous presence on public platforms, the management of a personal brand, the constant negotiation between what one actually thinks and what one can say in a particular public context without triggering a disproportionate response. The particular version of public recognition I would actually value — being known for having contributed something of genuine quality within a specific field by the people whose judgement I respect — is probably better described as reputation than fame, and it is achievable through sustained work without most of the costs that public celebrity typically involves.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether I want to be famous is one I have found it genuinely useful to think about carefully, because it is really a question about what kind of social impact I am trying to have and through what mechanisms I want to have it. Fame, properly understood, is a vehicle for influence — it increases the reach and resonance of what you say and do. Whether that vehicle is worth the costs it imposes depends on whether fame is actually the most efficient route to the impact you are trying to achieve. In most professional and intellectual domains, I have observed that reputation — rigorous and specific, built within a defined community of practice — is a more effective vehicle for meaningful influence than broad celebrity, because the people whose behaviour and thinking you most want to affect are rarely motivated by popularity and are specifically resistant to arguments that rest on fame rather than substance. The cases where fame becomes genuinely valuable are those where the audience you need to reach is very large, very diffuse, and not accessible through professional channels — which applies to political leadership and mass public advocacy, but does not describe most of the work that I find most worth doing.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
prodigy	n	/ˈprɒd.ɪ.dʒi/	a person with exceptional talent at a young age	thần đồng
gatekeeping	n	/ˈgeɪt.kiː.pɪŋ/	controlling who is allowed access to a domain or opportunity	kiểm soát ngưỡng vào (quyền truy cập)
commodification	n	/kəˌmɒd.ɪ.fɪˈkeɪ.ʃən/	treating something as a commercial product	sự thương phẩm hóa
meritocratic	adj	/ˌmer.ɪ.təˈkræt.ɪk/	based on achievement and ability rather than privilege	dựa trên năng lực thực sự
aspiration modelling	n phr		providing a visible example that expands others' sense of the possible	mô hình hóa khát vọng
algorithmic literacy	n phr		understanding how to work effectively within platform algorithms	hiểu biết về thuật toán
platform conversion	n phr		using fame in one area to build resources for another	chuyển đổi nền tảng nổi tiếng
social capital	n phr	/ˈsəʊ.ʃəl ˈkæp.ɪ.təl/	the networks and relationships that provide advantage	vốn xã hội
community of practice	n phr		a group of people who share expertise and learn together	cộng đồng thực hành
identity crystallisation	n phr		the premature fixing of one's sense of self before full development	kết tinh bản sắc sớm

2.14 Describe an interesting building

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe an interesting building. You should say:

- Where it is
- What it looks like
- What function it has
- And explain why you think it is interesting.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The building I want to describe is the Hội An Ancient House Museum — specifically the Tấn Ký House on Nguyễn Thái Học Street in Hội An Old Town — which I visited during a field trip in my final year of secondary school.

From the outside, it does not announce itself the way a conventional tourist attraction might. It is narrow-fronted and low — typical of the merchant houses built along the central Vietnamese coast in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, when width was heavily taxed and depth was not. The façade is mostly dark lacquered wood with traditional carved detailing, and the street entrance is through a pair of wooden doors that feel slightly too small for an adult.

Inside, however, what appears from the street to be a modest townhouse unfolds over several courtyards and function areas that served the family as shop front, warehouse, living quarters, and ancestral hall simultaneously. Every structural element — the carved roof beams, the inlaid mother-of-pearl panels, the worn stone threshold — has documentary significance: it reflects the cultural intersection of Vietnamese, Chinese, and Japanese influences that makes Hội An architecturally distinctive.

What I find genuinely interesting about the building is not any single feature but the density of historical information it contains at scales that a casual viewer does not immediately notice. Living space and commercial space coexist in a way that tells you something specific about how trade, family, and community organised themselves in a pre-industrial economy — and the fact that people lived in variations of this structure continuously for two hundred and fifty years makes it a remarkably intact piece of social history.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The building I would choose is the Vietnam Architecture Museum in Hanoi — specifically the way it occupies and adapts a French colonial villa on Chu Văn An Street, rather than anything about the contemporary architecture it exhibits.

I visited it during a professional conference in Hanoi two years ago, and what struck me immediately was the functional tension the building embodies: a colonial structure built to project metropolitan authority and cultural superiority, now repurposed to house and celebrate Vietnamese architectural history and professional identity. There is something architecturally honest about that reuse — it does not efface the building's history, but neither does it treat that history as the point.

The building is a two-storey villa with characteristic louvred shutters, high ceilings, and a shaded verandah. The interior has been adapted for exhibition use without being aggressively modernised — original floor tiles and ceiling mouldings remain, creating

a contextual conversation between the spaces and what they currently contain. What makes it interesting to me is that it makes visible a historical problem — the relationship between colonial architectural legacy and contemporary Vietnamese professional and cultural identity — without pretending to have resolved it. The building is a site of productive tension, which is the kind of complexity that good architecture tends neither to smooth over nor to dramatise unnecessarily.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
façade	n	/fə'sɑ:d/	the front face of a building	mặt tiền tòa nhà
louvred shutters	n phr	/'lu:.vəd 'ʃʌt.əz/	window coverings with angled slats for airflow	cửa chớp có nan nghiêng
colonial	adj	/kə'ləʊ.ni.əl/	relating to the period and style of colonial rule	thuộc địa
ancestral hall	n phr	/æn'ses.trəl hɔ:l/	a room in a traditional home dedicated to honouring ancestors	nhà thờ tổ tiên
mother-of-pearl	n phr	/'mʌð.ər.əv.'pɜ:l/	iridescent material from the inside of shells, used in decoration	xà cừ
threshold	n	/'θreʃ.həʊld/	the strip of material at the bottom of a doorway	ngưỡng cửa
verandah	n	/və'ræn.də/	a roofed platform along the outside of a building	hành lang ngoài có mái
moulding	n	/'məʊl.dɪŋ/	decorative strips of shaped material used as architectural ornament	đường gờ trang trí kiến trúc
repurpose	v	/'ri:pɜ:.pəs/	to adapt something for a new use	tái sử dụng cho mục đích mới
pre-industrial	adj	/'pri:ɪn'dʌs.tri.əl/	relating to the period before modern industry	tiền công nghiệp

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What types of buildings are popular in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The building stock of Vietnam reflects a layered history of cultural influence, economic transformation, and rapid urbanisation that is architecturally distinctive and often visually chaotic in ways that have begun to attract serious scholarly interest. In residential terms, the tube house — a narrow, deep dwelling that developed in response to street-frontage taxation during the French colonial period and earlier — remains the dominant urban building type in most Vietnamese cities, though modern versions are frequently built several storeys high with little of the craft quality that characterises their historical predecessors. In commercial and public construction, the post-renovation era has produced a landscape in which glass-and-steel towers and French-influenced neo-classical government buildings coexist with vernacular shophouses and informal settlements in ways that no single planning vision fully accounts for. What is perhaps most architecturally interesting about Vietnam's building landscape is its density of historical layering: French colonial villas, Soviet-influenced workers' housing blocks, traditional merchant houses, and contemporary commercial towers frequently occupy the same street, creating a compressed record of political and economic history that more uniform cities cannot offer.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of which building types are most prevalent in Vietnam can be approached from either a numerical or a cultural significance perspective, and the answers are interestingly different. By sheer quantity, the attached tube house is the dominant residential unit in urban Vietnam; by cultural significance, the traditional communal house — the *đình* — remains the most symbolically loaded building type in Vietnamese architecture, anchoring village spatial organisation and collective identity in ways that persist across centuries of urban transformation. In the commercial sector, the retail shop-house — typically a narrow structure with commercial ground floor and residential upper floors — constitutes the dominant type in most urban commercial corridors and reflects a business model that integrates domestic and commercial life in ways that large-footprint retail has not fully displaced. Public institutional buildings during the socialist period following 1975 were characterised by Soviet-influenced functionalism — austere concrete structures with broad facades and minimal ornamentation — whose utilitarian aesthetic still shapes the visual character of many public institutions.

2. Is it worth spending a lot of money on the exterior appearance of a building?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether significant investment in exterior appearance is justified depends critically on what the building is for and who experiences it. For public and civic buildings — government offices, cultural institutions, public libraries, transport hubs — investment in exterior quality is generally defensible on the grounds that these buildings shape the shared visual environment of a city in ways that private buildings do not, and that the quality of public space has documented effects on civic participation, community wellbeing, and urban identity. The argument that public buildings should be functional and not decorative conflates two things that are separable: there is nothing inherently expensive about well-proportioned, well-detailed architecture, and there is nothing necessarily civic or dignified about cheapness. For private residential buildings, the economics are different: whether interior or exterior investment is prioritised is appropriately a private decision, though planning regulations in most cities legitimately restrict certain exterior choices on the grounds that buildings form a collectively experienced streetscape regardless of who owns them.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The investment calculus for building exteriors in a commercial context is reasonably well-established: the exterior of a building communicates brand values, creates first impressions, and shapes the experience of the surrounding public realm in ways that have measurable effects on both the building's commercial performance and its contribution to the urban environment. The evidence from retail and hospitality real estate consistently shows that exterior quality affects footfall, dwell time, and brand perception — which provides a genuine commercial rationale for investment in appearance that does not depend on purely aesthetic arguments. The public interest dimension is also real and less frequently acknowledged in commercial development discourse: buildings, unlike most private goods, are experienced by the public whether they choose to or not, which creates a legitimate societal interest in the quality of the visual environment they collectively produce. This is the rationale underlying planning regulations that govern exterior appearance — not aesthetic paternalism but recognition that architecture, unlike most consumer choices, imposes externalities on the surrounding community.

3. Is it more important for a building to look good on the outside or on the inside?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of exterior versus interior architectural quality is in many respects a false dichotomy, because in the best buildings the relationship between exterior and interior is not an either/or but an integration — the exterior gives you a truthful account of what is happening inside, and the interior reflects the spatial logic established by the exterior form. That said, the relative importance depends substantially on building type and primary user. For buildings with high public footfall — museums, civic buildings, major corporate headquarters — the exterior carries a disproportionate share of the building's communicative burden because most people who experience it do so from the outside without ever entering. For buildings that are primarily used and experienced from within — schools, hospitals, residential buildings, workplaces — the interior quality has a far greater effect on the wellbeing and effectiveness of the people who use them. In those cases, the argument for prioritising interior quality over exterior appearance has a clear empirical basis: natural light, spatial generosity, acoustic quality, and the quality of materials in contact with the human body all have documented effects on cognitive performance, mood, and physical health that no exterior aesthetic consideration can substitute for.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The architectural hierarchy of interior versus exterior importance is one of the more productive debates in building design, and the position one takes tends to reveal underlying values about what architecture is fundamentally for. The tradition that prioritises interior experience — traceable through the Arts and Crafts movement, modernist social housing advocacy, and contemporary evidence-based design research — argues that architecture's primary obligation is to the people inside it: their light, air, acoustic comfort, spatial legibility, and psychological wellbeing. The tradition that prioritises exterior expression — traceable through classical civic architecture and much of contemporary starchitecture — argues that buildings have an obligation to the city and to posterity that is not exhausted by serving their immediate occupants. Both positions have genuine substance. What the evidence most consistently supports is that underinvestment in interior quality — in daylighting, acoustic separation, spatial quality, and material durability — produces buildings whose occupants are less productive, less healthy, and less psychologically well than comparable buildings with higher interior quality. The costs of that underinvestment typically exceed the savings

that cheap interiors appear to produce when measured over the full lifecycle of the building.

4. Why do people like to visit historical sites?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The appeal of historical sites is multi-layered and extends well beyond the most commonly cited motivation of curiosity about the past. At the most fundamental level, visiting a historical site provides a form of temporal anchoring that everyday environments rarely offer: the experience of standing in a space that has been continuously occupied or used over centuries creates a felt sense of historical continuity — a recognition that the present is not the only or inevitable form that human life has taken — that is difficult to replicate through reading or viewing images. Historical sites also serve a social and identity function: people visit places associated with their national, cultural, or family history partly to confirm a relationship to a heritage that is simultaneously personally significant and collectively shared. At a more experiential level, historical sites typically offer a texture of materials, proportions, and spatial qualities — the wear of ancient stone, the particular quality of light in a medieval building, the scale and detailing of pre-industrial construction — that contemporary built environments rarely reproduce and that many people find genuinely compelling in ways they find difficult to articulate precisely.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The consistent appeal of heritage sites across demographic groups and cultures reflects a set of human needs that are more fundamental than simple curiosity about the past. One of the most important is the need for narrative continuity: historical sites provide physical evidence that the past was real — that the people, events, and ways of life documented in texts and images actually occupied space and left material traces — which produces a form of historical conviction that secondary sources cannot provide. From an identity perspective, visiting sites associated with shared history is a form of participatory citizenship: it reinforces a sense of belonging to a community that extends through time rather than being bounded by the present. From a professional design and planning perspective, the persistent visitor demand for heritage sites also represents important economic evidence about the value that people attach to the preservation of historical built environments — a value that market mechanisms consistently underprice and that requires deliberate institutional protection to sustain.

5. Do you think it's reasonable to charge an entry fee for visiting interesting buildings?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for entry fees at heritage and architecturally significant buildings rests on a genuine conservation argument: the maintenance and conservation of historical buildings is expensive, and the communities and states responsible for them rarely have sufficient public funding to cover those costs through general taxation alone. Entry fees that are directed transparently toward conservation work are therefore not simply revenue extraction but a functional contract with visitors: access to something of exceptional value in exchange for a contribution to its preservation. The equity concern — that fees create barriers to access for lower-income groups — is real and important, but it is addressable through graduated pricing, free admission for residents, concessions for students and elderly visitors, and fully

free access periods rather than through the abolition of fees altogether. The more substantive concern is about what happens when entry fees become primarily a revenue mechanism for the broader institution rather than a conservation funding tool — at which point they may generate sufficient income to create a perverse incentive against limiting visitor numbers to levels that are genuinely compatible with conservation.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The economics of heritage site access are more complex than either the free-access advocates or the pure revenue-maximisers typically acknowledge, and the most defensible position depends on the specific character of the site and its ownership structure. For privately owned heritage buildings opened to the public, entry fees are clearly legitimate — the owner is providing a public service at private cost, and visitor contributions are a reasonable mechanism for sustaining that. For publicly owned and publicly funded heritage sites, the argument for fees is more contested: if the maintenance and preservation of the site is funded through general taxation, there is a coherent argument that access to it should be universal as a matter of public equity. The practical resolution in most well-managed systems involves a combination of public subsidy — ensuring baseline conservation regardless of visitor income — and visitor contributions through tiered pricing that preserves access for those who cannot pay full fees while generating revenue from those who can. The critical condition is transparency: visitors should be able to see a clear relationship between what they pay and what it sustains.

6. Is it better to live in a new building or an old one?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether living in new or old buildings is preferable is one that produces genuinely different answers depending on what one prioritises, and neither position is categorically correct. New buildings, at their best, offer modern insulation, acoustic separation, reliable mechanical systems, and interior layouts designed around contemporary household patterns — a significant practical advantage over older stock whose systems may be outdated and whose spatial arrangements often reflect historical domestic arrangements very different from those of contemporary urban residents. Older buildings, at their best, offer a quality of construction — in terms of material durability, ceiling height, window proportion, and neighbourhood context — that contemporary construction rarely matches and that has a significant effect on how it feels to live in a space over time. The most honest answer is that the building matters less than the quality of what is inside it: a well-maintained and thoughtfully updated older building in a walkable, socially rich neighbourhood is likely to be a better place to live than a new-build with inadequate sound insulation in an isolated suburban development, and neither generalisation about new or old reliably predicts residential quality.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The new versus old residential building question is one that my professional experience has given me a fairly clear view on, partly because it is one that many of my colleagues and clients have navigated with mixed outcomes. The systematic advantages of newer buildings are real: energy efficiency, compliance with contemporary safety standards, and lower maintenance burden in the early years of ownership significantly reduce occupancy costs. But these advantages are frequently overstated in the marketing of new developments, and the systematic disadvantages — construction quality that in many markets has declined significantly relative to historical standards, thin walls, inadequate natural light, and the absence of the neighbourhood and community fabric that develops over decades — are underweighted in most purchasing decisions because they are harder to quantify at the point of sale. The most reliable predictor

of residential satisfaction over a ten-year horizon is not the age of the building but the quality of the surrounding neighbourhood — the walkability, the access to daily services, the social mix across age groups, and the sense that the area has genuine longstanding character rather than having been recently assembled primarily around real estate investment.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
tube house	n phr		a characteristically narrow, deep Vietnamese urban dwelling	nhà ống
vernacular	adj	/və'næk.ju.lər/	relating to the local and traditional building style of a region	mang tính bản địa, phong trào kiến trúc dân gian
daylighting	n	/'deɪ.laɪ.tɪŋ/	the controlled admittance of natural light into a building	chiếu sáng tự nhiên
footfall	n	/'fʊt.fɔ:l/	the number of people entering a building or area	lượng khách đến
acoustic separation	n phr		the degree to which sound is prevented from passing between spaces	cách âm giữa các không gian
built environment	n phr	/bɪlt ɪn'vaɪ.rən.mənt/	the man-made surroundings in which people live and work	môi trường xây dựng
temporal anchoring	n phr		the experience of feeling connected to a specific moment in time	neo thời gian, cảm giác kết nối với lịch sử
heritage	n	/'her.ɪ.tɪdʒ/	valued traditions and features passed down from earlier generations	di sản
tiered pricing	n phr		a pricing structure with different rates for different groups	giá theo bậc
lifecycle	n	/'laɪf.saɪ.kəl/	the total useful life of a product or building	vòng đời (của công trình)

2.15 Describe a movie you watched and enjoyed recently

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a movie you watched and enjoyed recently. You should say:

- When and where you watched it
- Who you watched it with
- What it was about
- And explain why you watched this movie.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The film I want to talk about is **Past Lives** — a 2023 drama written and directed by Celine Song — which I watched alone at home on a streaming platform about three months ago, after a friend mentioned it in passing as a film she had watched twice in the same week.

The film follows two childhood friends from South Korea — Nora and Hae Sung — who reconnect twice as adults after years of separation, the first time through social media when they are in their mid-twenties, the second time face-to-face in New York when they are in their mid-thirties. Nora has emigrated to North America, built a life, married. Hae Sung has stayed in Seoul. The film is fundamentally about the paths not taken — the versions of a life that become inaccessible once certain choices have been made — told with extraordinary restraint and emotional precision.

What I found most impressive was how little the film relies on dramatic incident. Almost nothing "happens" in the conventional cinematic sense, and yet the emotional accumulation across its runtime is substantial and genuinely affecting. The final scene in particular — which I will not describe — is one of the most quietly devastating things I have seen in recent cinema.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The film that has stayed with me most clearly from the past year is **Oppenheimer** — Christopher Nolan's 2023 biographical drama on J. Robert Oppenheimer — which I saw with two colleagues in a cinema in the first week of its release.

My interest in seeing it was partly professional and partly personal: I had worked peripherally on a project related to science and technology ethics, and Oppenheimer's particular moral predicament — a person of extraordinary scientific intelligence navigating the institutional, political, and ethical consequences of having created something whose full implications he understood better than anyone and could not reverse — seemed to me not an abstract historical question but a contemporary one. The film is formally ambitious in ways that are occasionally difficult to follow but ultimately rewarding: it uses a non-linear structure and two distinct visual modes to contrast Oppenheimer's subjective experience with the bureaucratic proceedings that later attempted to destroy him. What it does with exceptional intelligence is to make the moral question — was it right to build the bomb? should he have refused? — genuinely uncomfortable, rather than resolving it in either direction. It holds the ambiguity honestly, which I found more intellectually serious than most historical cinema manages to be.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
restraint	n	/rɪ'streɪnt/	the quality of being measured and controlled rather than excessive	sự tiết chế, kìm chế
non-linear structure	n phr		a narrative that does not follow chronological order	cấu trúc phi tuyến tính
biographical drama	n phr		a film based on the real life of a historical person	phim tiểu sử điện ảnh
moral predicament	n phr	/'mɒr.əl prɪ'dɪk.ə.mənt/	a situation requiring a deeply difficult ethical decision	tình huống đạo đức tiến thoái lưỡng nan
ambiguity	n	/,æm.brɪ'ɡjuː.ɪ.ti/	the quality of being open to more than one interpretation	sự mơ hồ, đa nghĩa
cinematographer	n	/,sɪn.ə.mə'tɒɡ.rə.fər/	the person responsible for a film's visual composition and lighting	nhà quay phim
narrative arc	n phr		the overall trajectory or shape of a story	cung truyện
climax	n	/'klaɪ.mæks/	the most intense or important point of a story	cao trào
character development	n phr		the way a character changes and grows throughout a story	sự phát triển nhân vật
thematic depth	n phr		the degree to which a film or text engages with meaningful ideas	chiều sâu chủ đề

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What kinds of movies do you think are successful in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The films that perform most consistently well in Vietnamese cinemas reflect a specific audience profile: predominantly young urban viewers who are cinema-going as a social activity as much as a film-watching one, and who therefore favour genres that reward communal viewing — horror, comedy, and romantic drama — over genres best experienced in contemplative solitude. Vietnamese domestic horror in particular has had a remarkable run of commercial successes over the past decade, with films like **Quỷ Cổ Truyện** and **Kẻ Ăn Hồn** demonstrating that locally made genre films, when they engage with culturally specific folklore and social anxieties, can compete effectively with international releases in ways that locally produced films of other genres rarely manage. The success of comedy — particularly the kind of broad social comedy exemplified by the work of directors like Vũ Ngọc Đăng — reflects a Vietnamese audience appetite for domestic social observation that international film cannot satisfy. What is perhaps most interesting about the current moment is the emergence of a second tier of commercially significant Vietnamese films that are more tonally complex and thematically ambitious than pure genre films, suggesting that the domestic audience is diversifying.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The commercial success patterns of the Vietnamese film market reveal something interesting about how entertainment preferences interact with social behaviour at cinema-going scale. The most broadly successful film categories in Vietnam are those that reward group viewing: horror — because fear is an inherently social emotion and the shared experience of being frightened is a significant part of the cinema-going motivation — comedy — because laughter is similarly contagious and communally amplified — and romantic drama — because they provide shared emotional reference points and post-film conversation material. International blockbusters, particularly from Hollywood and the Korean film industry, continue to perform strongly in premium cinema segments, reflecting both the production values that domestic budgets cannot match and the cultural aspirational dimension of international cultural consumption among urban younger adults. The policy issue underlying all of this is the relatively thin commercial cushion that Vietnamese domestic production operates within: the market is large enough to sustain genre films with modest budgets but not yet large enough to regularly finance the kind of mid-budget auteur filmmaking that characterises the most internationally visible output from other regional film industries.

2. What are the factors that make a successful movie?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The factors that determine whether a film is commercially successful and whether it is artistically significant are related but not identical, and conflating them produces confused analysis. Commercial success — measured in box office and streaming numbers — correlates most strongly with genre fit, marketing investment, release timing, and the alignment of the film's emotional experience with what audiences are currently primed to seek. Films that provide reliable delivery of a genre's core pleasures — the right kind of horror, the right emotional beats in a romantic drama — can succeed commercially regardless of their artistic distinction. Artistic significance — the quality of a film that makes it worth watching twice

and discussing at length — correlates with a different set of factors: the clarity and specificity of the film’s vision, the quality of its performances and cinematography, the integrity of its thematic development, and the degree to which it offers something — an observation about human experience, an emotional precision, a formally innovative structure — that audiences did not previously have access to. The films that achieve both commercial success and lasting artistic reputation simultaneously are genuinely rare, which is precisely what makes them culturally significant.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of film success factors is best approached by distinguishing between what drives opening-weekend commercial performance and what determines a film’s lasting cultural and critical significance — two timelines with quite different determinants. Opening-weekend performance is driven primarily by marketing spend, IP recognition (whether the film is based on an established franchise, novel, or real event), and genre positioning. These factors can drive substantial audiences to weak films and, conversely, can prevent strong films from finding their audience at critical early junctures. Long-term cultural and commercial performance — what streaming metrics now sometimes make measurable in ways that were previously invisible — correlates more strongly with the factors that drive word-of-mouth: emotional resonance, a quality of performance or screenplay that audiences feel compelled to tell others about, and a thematic relevance that connects the film’s concerns to broader cultural conversations. The most commercially and artistically successful films tend to be those that deliver genre expectations while simultaneously offering something that exceeds them — a performance of unexpected depth, a tonal innovation, a genuine formal ambition — which is a combination that is structurally difficult to engineer and therefore relatively rare.

3. Do Chinese people prefer to watch domestic movies or foreign movies?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The viewing preferences of Vietnamese audiences reflect a dynamic that is common across many middle-income film markets: a strong preference for international production values combined with a growing appetite for domestic cultural specificity that only local films can satisfy. For high-spectacle genres — action, science fiction, animation — international films, particularly from Hollywood and South Korea, hold a decisive quality advantage that domestic production cannot currently match in budget terms, and audiences recognise and respond to that gap. For content that depends on cultural specificity — social comedy, horror drawing on Vietnamese folklore, romantic drama set in recognisable Vietnamese contexts — domestic films offer something that no international production can replicate, and this has produced a genuinely competitive domestic genre market. The trajectory of the past decade suggests a gradual strengthening of the domestic sector, with increasing audience willingness to pay cinema ticket prices for local films — a meaningful indicator of confidence in local production quality — alongside continued strong performance by international blockbusters in the premium cinema segment.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The domestic versus foreign film preference question in Vietnam is one that the industry data presents somewhat differently from the way it is popularly discussed. By box office market share, international films — particularly Hollywood and Korean productions — continue to dominate the premium end of the market, and the total box office revenue generated by imports significantly exceeds that of domestic productions in most years. By number of films released and by the diversity of audience demographics served, the domestic

sector is more significant than box office share alone suggests: Vietnamese films tend to draw audiences that international productions do not predominantly attract, including older viewers and regional audiences for whom cultural familiarity and language accessibility are significant factors. The more interesting trend is the emergence of co-productions and domestically produced films with international distribution ambitions — a development that reflects the increasing sophistication of domestic production infrastructure and the growing interest of international platforms in Vietnamese content for diaspora and regional audiences.

4. Do you think only well-known directors can create the best movies?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The assumption that directorial reputation is a reliable predictor of film quality is one that the history of cinema consistently undermines. Many of the most formally innovative and emotionally significant films have been made by first-time or early-career directors working with limited budgets and significant creative freedom precisely because they lacked the institutional constraints that success imposes: the pressure to replicate a signature style, the studio expectations attached to a track record, and the creative conservatism that can accompany professional reputation. Conversely, some of the most commercially prominent directors have produced their weakest work at the peak of their institutional power, when no one in the production system had either the standing or the incentive to challenge their decisions. What reputation reliably predicts is not quality but access: well-known directors can attract large budgets, established collaborators, and distribution resources that debut directors cannot, which means that their films reach audiences more effectively regardless of their relative quality. The best films tend to come from directors who combine a clear creative vision with sufficient command of their medium to realise it — attributes that correlate only loosely with public recognition.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The relationship between directorial reputation and film quality is an important one for both audiences and industry stakeholders to understand clearly, because the heuristic of following established names produces systematically biased consumption and investment patterns. From an audience perspective, relying on directorial reputation as a quality signal leads to both false positives — films by well-known directors that are funded and marketed beyond their actual merit — and false negatives — films by unknown directors that fail to find audiences because they lack the discovery infrastructure that reputation provides. From an industry investment perspective, concentrating development resources around proven names reflects a risk-management logic that is commercially rational in the short term but structurally inhibits the talent development that sustains industry health over longer horizons. The streaming era has partially disrupted this dynamic by creating data-driven discovery mechanisms that can surface strong content regardless of directorial recognition — though the evidence on whether algorithmic discovery actually compensates for the reputational advantages of established names is more mixed than the platforms' self-presentation tends to suggest.

5. Do you think successful movies should have well-known actors or actresses in leading roles?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The relationship between star power and film success is one of the clearest examples in the entertainment industry of a factor that is statistically correlated with commercial performance but causally ambiguous in ways that matter for how the industry should invest. Well-known actors drive opening-weekend box office partly because of genuine performance magnetism and partly because their names function as marketing signals that reduce audience uncertainty about whether a film is worth attending — which is an informational rather than a purely artistic effect. The streaming era has begun to complicate this relationship: on-demand platforms, where discovery happens through algorithmic recommendation rather than opening-weekend decision-making, show rather weaker correlations between star attachment and viewership than theatrical box office data does. The artistic question is even clearer: some of the most celebrated film performances in the past decade have come from actors who were relatively unknown before the film's release, and many of the most commercially reliable stars have significant reputations built partly on charisma and marketing rather than on the consistency of their actual screen performance.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether star casting is necessary for commercial film success is one whose answer has become noticeably less clear over the past decade, as the theatrical and streaming distribution models have diverged in ways that significantly affect the mechanisms through which audiences discover and choose films. In theatrical distribution, star attachment continues to function as a risk-reduction signal for audiences making a relatively high-friction, time-constrained decision about whether to attend a specific film on a specific evening — the star's presence simplifies this decision in ways that are commercially meaningful. In streaming, where the friction of choosing is much lower and the consequence of a poor choice is minimal, the discovery process is primarily algorithmic, and star attachment is a weaker predictor of viewership relative to genre, mood-tagging, and algorithmic placement. The implication for the industry is that films conceived primarily for streaming distribution may genuinely require less star investment than films conceived for theatrical release — a structural shift in pre-production economics that has begun to reshape how studio development decisions are made.

6. Why do people prefer to watch movies in the cinema?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The persistent appeal of cinema attendance in an era of abundant home viewing options reflects a set of irreducible experiential qualities that domestic environments cannot replicate, alongside a social dimension that streaming fundamentally does not provide. The most obvious irreducible quality is scale: the visual and sonic experience of a well-equipped cinema — the screen size, the projection quality, and particularly the calibrated surround sound — produces an immersive intensity for certain genres that no domestic setup, regardless of its quality, can fully match. Beyond the purely technical, there is the social dimension: cinema attendance is an occasion — a shared commitment of time that creates a shared experience, including the communal reactions of laughing, gasping, and falling silent simultaneously with a room full of strangers — that has a social texture fundamentally different from watching the same film at home. There is also a quality-of-attention argument: the cinema environment, by eliminating the domestic interruptions that make home viewing frequently fragmented and inattentive, creates conditions for a more sustained and therefore more satisfying engagement with the film.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of cinema attendance persistence is best understood not primarily as a

question about technology — most home viewing setups have improved dramatically — but as a question about what people are actually seeking when they choose to attend a cinema rather than watch at home. The evidence from consumer behaviour research suggests that cinema attendance is increasingly experienced as a social and ceremonial activity rather than a purely entertainment one: people go to the cinema to mark occasions, to have a shared experience with a specific companion, or to access a specific film under optimal conditions as an act of deliberate attention rather than casual consumption. This positioning of cinema as a premium, occasion-based activity is arguably more stable than the mid-century model of cinema as the default entertainment medium — it is not susceptible to disruption by home viewing technology in the same way because it is not primarily competing with home viewing on convenience grounds. The structural implication for cinema operators is that investment in experience quality — seating, sound, service, social environment — is more commercially critical than it was when cinema's dominant competitive advantage was content access rather than experience quality.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
IP recognition	n phr		audience familiarity with a brand, character, or franchise	nhận diện thương hiệu/nhân vật
word-of-mouth	n phr	/ˌwɜːd.əvˈmaʊθ/	informal recommendation between people	truyền miệng
box office	n phr	/'bɒks ˌɒf.ɪs/	the commercial performance of a film measured by ticket sales	doanh thu phòng vé
auteur	n	/əʊˈtɜː/	a filmmaker whose personal vision dominates their work	đạo diễn phong cách cá nhân
genre	n	/'ʒɒn.rə/	a category of artistic work defined by shared conventions	thể loại
immersive	adj	/ɪˈmɜː.sɪv/	creating a deeply involving experience	gây đắm chìm, tạo trải nghiệm nhập vai
heuristic	n	/hjuˈrɪs.tɪk/	a practical rule of thumb used to make quick decisions	phương pháp phán đoán nhanh
surround sound	n phr	/səˈraʊnd saʊnd/	audio technology producing sound from multiple directions	âm thanh vòm
distribution	n	/ˌdɪs.trɪˈbjʊː.ʃən/	the process of making a film available to audiences	phân phối phim
streaming	n	/'striː.mɪŋ/	watching digital content delivered over the internet in real time	xem trực tuyến

2.16 Describe something that you can't live without (not a computer/phone)

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe something that you can't live without (not a computer/phone). You should say:

- What it is
- What you do with it
- How it helps you in your life
- And explain why you can't live without it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The thing I genuinely feel I cannot function well without is my notebook — not any specific brand, just a blank, ruled, physical paper notebook that I carry almost everywhere.

I started using one seriously in my second year of university, when I was struggling to retain anything I read and a lecturer suggested that the problem might be the medium rather than the material: that writing by hand activates a different and in some ways more durable mode of encoding than typing does. I tried it somewhat sceptically, and the difference in what I was able to retain several days later was immediate and significant enough that I have used paper notebooks for reading and thinking notes ever since.

What I use it for, specifically, is thinking through ideas before I'm ready to write about them — sketching arguments, noting connections between concepts, writing out things I don't understand in my own words until I understand them better. I also use it for lists, plans, and occasionally for writing down things I want to remember from conversations.

The reason I feel I cannot live without it — in the specific sense that I notice its absence very clearly — is that without it, ideas that arise during the day tend to dissipate rather than accumulate. The act of writing something down by hand seems to commit it to a different kind of mental processing than simply thinking about it does, and the result is that I think better, and more productively, with the notebook open beside me than without it.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The object I am most consciously dependent on is my fountain pen — specifically, the pen I use for handwritten notes, correspondence, and the kind of slow, deliberate writing that I find impossible to do adequately at a keyboard.

I received my current pen as a gift from a senior colleague when I was promoted into a role with more external-facing responsibilities, and the accompanying note said something I have thought about since: that the quality of the attention you bring to written communication signals, to the reader, the quality of the attention you will bring to the relationship. I am not sure whether that is entirely true, but it shaped how I thought about the pen.

What I use it for is principally first drafts of important correspondence, the

handwritten marginalia I make when reading documents that require careful analysis, and the kind of reflective note-taking — meeting with mentor, reading a significant report — where the slower pace of handwriting is more useful than the faster pace of typing precisely because it imposes a greater selectivity. You cannot write everything by hand at the speed of thought, and the constraint is productive.

The dependency, practically speaking, is not absolute — I can function without it. But the quality of my written thinking degrades noticeably without the friction and pace of handwriting, and I regard that as a meaningful dependency even if not a survival-level one.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
encoding	n	/ɪn'keʊ.dɪŋ/	the process by which information is stored in memory	mã hóa thông tin vào bộ nhớ
marginalia	n	/ˌmɑː.dʒɪ'neɪ.li.ə/	notes written in the margins of a text	ghi chú bên lề
deliberate	adj	/dɪ'lɪb.ər.ət/	done consciously and intentionally	có chủ đích, thận trọng
selectivity	n	/sɪˌlek.'tɪv.ɪ.ti/	the quality of choosing carefully among options	tính chọn lọc
cognitive load	n phr		the total amount of mental effort being used	tải nhận thức
tactile	adj	/'tæk.taɪl/	relating to the sense of touch	thuộc về xúc giác
dissipate	v	/'dɪs.ɪ.pert/	to gradually disappear or scatter	tan biến, phân tán
retention	n	/'rɪ'ten.ʃən/	the ability to keep information in memory	khả năng ghi nhớ
correspondence	n	/ˌkɒr.ɪ'spɒn.dəns/	formal written communication	thư từ, giao tiếp văn bản
friction	n	/'frɪk.ʃən/	in this context: productive resistance or slowness that improves quality	sự cản trở có lợi (trong tư duy/viết)

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Why are children attracted to new things (such as electronics)?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Children's attraction to new things — and to electronics in particular — reflects several intersecting developmental and environmental factors that are worth distinguishing clearly

rather than attributing to a single cause. The most fundamental is novelty-seeking: the human nervous system is wired to orient toward new stimuli, and this orientation is stronger during childhood and adolescence when learning is most rapid and when the neural circuits associated with novelty-response are most active. Electronics are particularly effective at capturing and maintaining this orientation because they are extraordinarily good at delivering unpredictable, varied, and high-intensity stimuli at a pace calibrated to the user's engagement — a combination that no static toy or activity can match. There is also an imitation dynamic: children observe that the adults and older peers whose world they are aspiring to enter use electronic devices continuously, and the desire to possess and use the same tools is partially aspirational. Finally, there is a social dimension: the specific electronics that children most strongly desire tend to be those that their peer group uses for communication and entertainment — and the social cost of not having access to them is therefore real and perceived acutely.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The attraction of children to new electronic devices is best understood as the intersection of normal developmental curiosity with exceptionally well-designed commercial products. The developmental dimension is simply the universal human pull toward novelty — the neurological trait that makes exploration and learning happen — which is strongest in childhood and peaks during adolescence. The commercial design dimension is distinctive to contemporary electronics: these products are engineered by teams whose full-time objective is to maximise user engagement, using behavioural psychology research that identifies and exploits the specific mechanisms through which the developing brain is most effectively captured. The combination produces an attraction that is qualitatively different from children's historical attractions to new toys or experiences — more intense, more sustained, and more difficult to redirect — because the products are not passively interesting but actively optimised to hold attention. This distinction matters for how parents and educators should think about managing children's engagement with electronics: the attraction is not simply childish impulsiveness but a response to sophisticated commercial design, which warrants a more structured response than simply telling children to put the device down.

2. Why do some grown-ups hate to throw out old things (such as clothes)?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The reluctance of adults to discard old possessions — clothes in particular — is a psychologically complex phenomenon that deserves a more nuanced analysis than the standard framing of "sentimentality" provides. The most thoroughly documented mechanism is loss aversion: the psychological tendency to weight losses more heavily than equivalent gains, which means that discarding something that has been in one's possession for years is experienced as a loss disproportionate to its actual use value. Related to this is the endowment effect: the tendency to attribute greater value to objects simply because one owns them than one would attribute to identical objects one did not possess. Beyond these general psychological mechanisms, certain possessions — clothing, in particular — carry genuine biographical significance: a specific garment can be associated with a specific period, relationship, or identity that the owner values and does not wish to erase. Discarding the object can feel, even unconsciously, like a form of erasure of the experience it represents. These dynamics are not pathological; they reflect an appropriate human relationship with the objects that have accumulated through a lived life.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional and psychological literature on attachment to possessions frames the general reluctance to discard old objects around two well-evidenced phenomena: loss aversion and identity extension. Loss aversion — the asymmetry in how we experience gains and losses of equivalent magnitude — means that giving away or throwing out something we own feels significantly worse than acquiring it felt good, regardless of whether the item is still useful. Identity extension is a subtler dynamic: research in consumer psychology shows that people incorporate certain possessions into their self-concept, particularly objects associated with significant life transitions, relationships, or selves they have inhabited. For many adults, older clothing and other personal possessions serve as physical anchors to prior identities they value — not because they wish to return to those identities, but because the object preserves the evidence that those identities were real. The sustainability and minimalism movements that have gained contemporary popularity address this dynamic with varying sophistication: the more thoughtful versions recognise that deliberate, considered relationship with possessions — including the deliberate decision to let go — requires psychological work rather than simple exhortation.

3. Is the way people buy things affected? How?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The ways in which consumer behaviour has changed over the past decade are substantial and structurally driven by the intersection of digital technology, changing social media dynamics, and the post-pandemic reshaping of shopping norms. The most significant single change is the shift from a browse-at-leisure, purchase-at-specific-location model to an always-available, algorithmically prompted, and socially amplified model in which the boundary between content consumption and commercial transaction has been progressively eroded. Social commerce — the integration of purchase functionality directly into social media content — has transformed what would previously have been inspirational media consumption into a direct commercial channel. This has had significant effects on impulse purchasing: the friction between seeing something desirable and completing its purchase has been systematically reduced to the point where the decision-making process that once intervened between stimulus and transaction has been substantially compressed. The psychological consequence is a form of consumption that is less deliberate, more reactive, and more susceptible to social comparison and algorithmic prompting than the brick-and-mortar retail model it is progressively replacing.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The transformation of consumer purchasing behaviour is one of the most extensively documented structural shifts in commercial literature of the past fifteen years, and its implications for both businesses and consumers are substantial. At the structural level, the progressive migration of retail from physical to digital channels has fundamentally altered the economics of consumer decision-making: search costs — the effort required to compare options and prices — have collapsed, which in theory should produce more rational purchasing but in practice has produced a different kind of irrationality in which the sheer volume of available options, combined with sophisticated algorithmic personalisation, generates decision fatigue that makes consumers more rather than less susceptible to commercially motivated nudges. The business model implications of this transformation are equally significant: the shift from a model in which physical shelf presence determined product visibility to one in which algorithmic placement and online review architecture determine it has transferred substantial commercial power to the platforms that control those mechanisms — a structural shift whose full implications for consumer welfare and market competition are still being

debated by regulators.

4. What do you think influences people to buy new things?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The influences that drive consumer purchasing can be usefully organised along a spectrum from rational to social to psychological. At the rational end, genuine functional need — a product that is worn out, a service that solves a real practical problem — remains a significant purchase driver, though it accounts for a smaller proportion of total consumer spending than the rational actor model of economics would predict. Social influence — observation of or communication about what peers, aspirational reference groups, or influential media figures are buying — is a more powerful and less consciously acknowledged driver: the desire to signal membership of a valued social group, to maintain parity with one's immediate social context, or to access the social experience that certain products are believed to provide motivates substantial purchasing that would not occur on purely functional grounds. At the psychological end, the mechanisms that advertising and commercial design actively exploit — scarcity signalling, social proof, anchoring, and loss aversion — are well-documented and produce significant purchasing behaviour that is largely outside the buyer's conscious awareness. The most sophisticated consumer behaviour education focuses on building awareness of these mechanisms rather than simply advocating for restraint.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The drivers of consumer purchasing are of significant practical and policy interest because understanding them accurately is a prerequisite for both effective marketing and effective consumer protection. From a marketing perspective, the most productive insight of behavioural economics for applied commercial purposes is that purchasing decisions are rarely the product of deliberate deliberation and are far more responsive to contextual cues — price anchoring, option framing, default settings, and social norm displays — than to the information content of product descriptions. Consumers who believe they are making independent, rational purchasing decisions are, in most cases, responding to a carefully designed choice architecture that is the product of significant commercial investment in understanding and directing consumer psychology. The policy implication is that consumer welfare and financial education interventions that focus primarily on improving access to information substantially underestimate the cognitive mechanisms through which purchase decisions are actually made — and that structural regulatory interventions in the choice architecture itself may be more effective protections than disclosure requirements alone.

5. Why do all children like toys?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The universal appeal of toys to children across cultural and historical contexts strongly suggests that it is rooted in something fundamental about childhood development rather than being simply a product of commercial culture. The most compelling explanatory framework comes from developmental psychology: play — and objects that support play — serves critical functions in early cognitive and social development that cannot be adequately fulfilled through other means. Constructive play with physical objects develops spatial reasoning, fine motor control, and causal understanding. Role play with dolls, figures, and props develops theory of mind — the capacity to understand that others have perspectives, motivations,

and emotional states different from one's own — and social reasoning capacities that are foundational to later interpersonal competence. Competitive and rule-based play develops the capacity to manage frustration, to operate within shared constraints, and to navigate disagreement — all of which are core social skills. The pleasure children take in toys is therefore not incidental to their development but integral to it: toys are, at their best, the tools through which children do the developmental work that their stage of life requires.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of why children universally engage with toys is one that sits at the intersection of developmental psychology, evolutionary biology, and cultural anthropology, and the convergence of those distinct disciplines on a broadly similar answer is itself significant. The evolutionary account is straightforward: play behaviour — including play with objects — is observed across all mammalian species whose offspring have protracted developmental periods, which strongly suggests that it serves adaptive functions in preparing the organism for adult competencies. In humans, the specific competencies that toy-supported play develops are those that are most distinctive and most dependent on specific developmental windows: language and symbolic reasoning, through imaginative play; causal and mechanical reasoning, through constructive play; social cognition and emotional regulation, through role-play and competitive game. The contemporary commercial toy industry has both responded to and shaped these developmental needs in ways that are not always well-aligned: the most commercially successful toys are not always the most developmentally productive, and some — particularly those with heavy electronic components that make specific sounds or movements — may actually constrain the open-ended play behaviour that produces the most broadly beneficial developmental outcomes.

6. Do you think it is good for a child to always take his or her favourite toy with them all the time?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The practice of children carrying a favourite toy or comfort object — what developmental psychologists call a transitional object — is a normal and in most cases developmentally beneficial behaviour during early and middle childhood. The function of the transitional object is precisely what the name implies: it provides a portable source of security that helps the child navigate transitions — between home and school, between waking and sleep, between parental presence and absence — that would otherwise require emotional resources that many young children have not yet fully developed. The toy or object serves as a proxy for the security of the attachment relationship, allowing the child to move more confidently into less familiar situations than they could manage without it. Whether this is "good" depends on context and age: as a strategy for supporting emotional regulation in younger children, the transitional object is clearly beneficial. As children mature and develop more robust internal emotional regulation capacities — typically through middle childhood — dependency on comfort objects naturally diminishes, and its persistence beyond that point may occasionally warrant attention if it appears to be compensating for unresolved anxiety rather than simply being a pleasant habit.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The developmental and practical question of whether constant access to a favourite toy is beneficial for a child is one that benefits from distinguishing between the different developmental stages at which the question is most relevant. In toddlers and young children, the transitional object is a well-recognised and positive developmental feature: it supports emotional self-regulation in the absence of the primary caregiver and facilitates rather than

impedes independence, because it reduces the emotional cost of separation to manageable levels. The concern that constant access to comfort objects produces dependency is generally not well-supported by the evidence for this age group: children who are securely attached to caregivers and have access to transitional objects tend to separate more confidently, not less. In older children — beyond the age of roughly six or seven, when emotional regulation capacities are typically more developed — the question becomes more contextually sensitive: a school-age child who requires constant access to a comfort toy in social situations may be managing persistent anxiety that would benefit from adult support, or may simply be slower to transition out of a behaviour whose function they no longer need. The most useful parental approach is to observe the function the object is serving rather than applying a chronological rule about when attachment to toys should end.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
transitional object	n phr		a comfort item (like a toy) that helps a child manage separation from caregivers	đối tượng chuyển tiếp (đồ vật mang lại cảm giác an toàn)
loss aversion	n phr	/ləs ə'vɜː.ʒən/	the tendency to feel losses more strongly than equivalent gains	sự ác cảm với mất mát
endowment effect	n phr		the tendency to value things more because you own them	hiệu ứng quyền sở hữu
social proof	n phr		using others' behaviour as a guide to form one's own	bằng chứng xã hội
choice architecture	n phr		the design of environments in which people make decisions	kiến trúc lựa chọn
impulse purchasing	n phr		buying something without planning or deliberation	mua sắm bốc đồng
theory of mind	n phr		the ability to understand that others have thoughts and feelings different from one's own	lý thuyết tâm trí
anchoring	n	/'æŋ.kər.ɪŋ/	the cognitive bias of relying too heavily on the first piece of information encountered	neo nhận thức
social commerce	n phr		commercial transactions integrated into social media platforms	thương mại xã hội
developmental window	n phr	230	a critical period during which a	cửa sổ phát triển (giai đoạn nhạy cảm)

2.17 Describe a city that you think is very interesting / famous

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a city that you think is very interesting / famous. You should say:

- Where it is
- What it is famous for
- How you knew this city
- And explain why you think it is very interesting / famous.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The city I find most fascinating — and that I've spent a disproportionate amount of time reading about relative to my direct experience of it — is Kyoto, in Japan's Kansai region, which I first encountered through a documentary series about Japanese craft traditions that I watched during a school holiday about three years ago. Kyoto was Japan's imperial capital for over a millennium and retains an architectural and cultural density unusual even by Japanese standards: more than seventeen hundred Buddhist temples, several hundred Shinto shrines, and an urban fabric in which traditional wooden machiya townhouses sit beside modern infrastructure in a combination that feels less like a heritage zone than like a genuinely inhabited city that has never fully modernised. What makes it most interesting to me — beyond the visual quality, which is striking in itself — is the relationship between its preserved surface and its active living culture: the tea ceremony traditions, the weaving arts of Nishijin, the seasonal festival calendar that continues to structure civic life across centuries without feeling like performance tourism. It's a city that has maintained identity through an unusually deliberate kind of cultural continuity, which is interesting in itself as a model of how cities relate to their own histories.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The city that has occupied my professional imagination most persistently over the past few years is Singapore — partly for reasons directly connected to work, since several of our international partnerships involve Singapore-based counterparts, and partly because the city-state represents such an unusual configuration of policy, urban design, and economic development that it functions as a kind of ongoing experiment in urban governance that is consistently interesting to observe from a professional distance. Singapore's fame rests on several things simultaneously: its position as a global financial centre, its unusually efficient physical infrastructure, its deliberate multilingualism and multiculturalism as official state policies, and its reputation for effective and somewhat stringent governance. What I find most genuinely interesting about it professionally is the tension — which the city makes visible in an unusually articulated way — between economic openness and social control: Singapore maintains extraordinarily permeable economic borders while maintaining substantially tighter social and political borders, and the combination produces a city that is simultaneously one of the world's most internationally connected and one of the most carefully managed.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
machiya	n	/mə:'tʃi:.jɑ:/	traditional Japanese wooden townhouse	nhà phố gỗ truyền thống Nhật Bản
heritage zone	n phr		an officially designated area preserved for its historical significance	khu vực di sản được bảo tồn
civic life	n phr		the activities and institutions that constitute community and public life	đời sống công dân, sinh hoạt cộng đồng
city-state	n	/'sɪt.i.steɪt/	an independent state consisting of a city and its surrounding territory	thành bang
multilingualism	n	/ˌmʌl.ti'liŋ.gwə.lɪ.zəm/	the use of more than two languages	đa ngôn ngữ
urban governance	n phr		the way cities are managed and administered	quản trị đô thị
cultural continuity	n phr		the preservation and transmission of cultural practices across generations	sự liên tục văn hoá
disproportionate	adj	/ˌdɪs.prə'pɔ:.ʃən.ət/	not in proportion; larger or smaller than expected	không tương xứng
permeable	adj	/'pɜ:.mi.ə.bəl/	allowing passage through; open	có thể thấm thấu, thông thoáng
imperial capital	n phr		a city that serves as the seat of an empire's government	thủ đô đế chế

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What advantages can tourism bring to a city?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Tourism's economic contribution to cities operates through several channels that tend to aggregate into substantial aggregate demand effects: direct spending by visitors on accommodation, food, transport, entertainment, and retail creates income for businesses across a range of sectors, and that income generates further local economic activity through the multiplier effect as business revenues circulate through local supply chains and wages. The urban infrastructure benefit is the second major advantage — tourism generates the revenue and political support for investment in cultural facilities, transport networks, public spaces, and environmental quality improvements that improve city quality for residents as well as visitors. The less commonly discussed advantage is the reputational effect: cities with strong tourism profiles benefit from international visibility that attracts foreign direct investment, international talent, and institutional partnerships beyond the tourism sector itself.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional urban economics analysis of tourism benefits identifies economic diversification as the most structurally significant long-term advantage for cities that successfully develop tourism as a major sector. Tourism distributes economic activity across a wider range of business types — hospitality, entertainment, craft, food production, transportation, cultural institutions — than most industrial or financial service concentrations, which creates a more resilient urban economy less vulnerable to single-sector downturns. The employment benefit is particularly significant for cities in developing economies: tourism generates substantial employment in sectors accessible to workers without highly specialised qualifications, which makes it an unusually effective inclusion mechanism for urban populations whose educational and skill profiles limit access to higher-barrier employment sectors.

2. Why do some young people like to live in cities?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Young people's preference for urban residence reflects a coherent set of calculations about where the conditions for the most important aspects of early adulthood — career development, social connection, cultural participation, and romantic partnership — are most reliably available. The labour market argument is the most straightforwardly economic: the density of employers, industries, and professional networks in cities creates substantially more diverse and higher-value employment opportunities than non-urban areas, and the option value of that density — the ability to switch jobs, change industries, and develop careers through proximity to multiple employers — is particularly valuable during the career-formation phase of early adulthood. The social density argument is equally powerful: cities provide the critical mass of young people with diverse interests and backgrounds that makes the formation of the social networks, friendships, and romantic partnerships that early adulthood prioritises substantially easier than in lower-density environments.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional urban sociology analysis of young people's residential preferences identifies the agglomeration of opportunity as the primary structural driver and the experience economy as the secondary cultural driver. Young adults in contemporary societies are extending the exploratory phase of early adulthood — the period of career experimentation, lifestyle

diversification, and identity formation before the settling commitments of partnership, home ownership, and family — and cities are the environments that best support this extended exploration by providing the widest range of professional, social, cultural, and experiential options within a geographically accessible area. The tolerance and diversity argument is also significant: cities — particularly major urban centres — offer social environments characterised by greater acceptance of lifestyle diversity, identity experimentation, and non-conformity than more homogeneous suburban or rural environments, which makes them disproportionately attractive to young people whose identities or interests locate them outside mainstream cultural norms.

3. Do most elderly people live in the city or in the countryside?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The residential distribution of elderly populations varies substantially across countries and reflects the specific migration histories, welfare system structures, and housing market dynamics of each context rather than a universal pattern. In Vietnam, the pattern reflects the historical rural-urban migration dynamic: the parental generation of current urban migrants often remained in rural areas while their children moved to cities for work, which means that rural elderly populations are disproportionately concentrated and often without proximate family support — a demographic and welfare challenge that is increasingly recognised by policy makers but incompletely addressed by existing support structures. The urban elderly population is typically smaller as a share of the elderly total but has its own challenges: high accommodation costs, physical environments that are often poorly adapted to the needs of older people, and social isolation in high-density environments without the community structures that rural settings historically provided.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional urban planning and ageing policy perspective identifies the city/countryside distribution of elderly people as a function of three interacting factors: the original settlement patterns of cohorts now entering old age, the migration decisions made during their working-age years, and the residential decisions made specifically in response to retirement and ageing. In most developed economies, the pattern is increasingly urban: improved urban healthcare access, the concentration of specialist medical services in cities, and the proximity to adult children who have themselves urbanised draws elderly populations toward cities even as health and mobility decline makes urban living more physically challenging. The policy challenge this creates — designing urban environments that are genuinely liveable for people with reduced mobility, visual acuity, and social networks — is increasingly central to urban planning in rapidly ageing societies.

4. Do you think well-developed tourism will have negative effects on local people?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Well-developed tourism's negative effects on local populations are well-documented and include a cluster of impacts that tend to intensify as tourism volume increases beyond a threshold that the host environment and community can absorb without significant quality-of-life degradation. The most immediately visible effect is accommodation market displacement: high tourist demand for short-term rental properties in desirable urban areas drives housing

costs upward and reduces the supply of long-term rental accommodation, displacing local residents from central areas they have historically occupied — a process documented across major tourist cities from Barcelona to Amsterdam to Hôì An. The cultural commodification effect is equally significant if less economically measurable: the pressure to present local culture as consumable product for tourism audiences reshapes cultural practices in ways that gradually hollows out the authentic living character that originally attracted tourists, producing a feedback loop in which tourism success progressively undermines the quality it depends on.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional tourism impact analysis identifies the distribution of tourism benefits and costs between local communities and tourism industry operators as the central policy variable: tourism's negative effects on local populations are substantially reduced when local communities capture a significant share of tourism revenues and maintain meaningful agency over tourism development decisions in their areas. The overtourism phenomenon — where tourist volume exceeds the carrying capacity of a destination across dimensions including infrastructure, environmental quality, and social tolerance — has been identified across dozens of major global destinations and has produced a growing policy response including visitor caps, tourism taxes directed toward infrastructure and community benefit, and zoning restrictions on short-term rental accommodation. The professional consensus is that tourism's costs to local populations are not inherent to tourism development but are a consequence of governance failures that allow tourism revenues to be captured by external operators while distributing costs to local communities.

5. What are the benefits of urbanization?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Urbanisation's economic and social benefits are among the most consistently documented relationships in development economics: the correlation between urbanisation rates and economic growth, educational attainment, health outcomes, and access to public services is robust across development contexts and reflects the genuine productivity advantages that urban density creates. The agglomeration economy — the productivity gains that arise from the density of workers, firms, and knowledge in urban areas — is the primary economic mechanism: urban workers are substantially more productive than rural workers in equivalent occupations, partly because urban density facilitates knowledge transfer, specialisation, and the matching of workers' skills to firms' needs that diffuse rural environments cannot support at equivalent scale. The public services efficiency argument is equally important: the delivery of health, education, sanitation, and transport infrastructure is substantially more cost-effective per capita in dense urban environments than in dispersed rural ones, which means urbanisation creates the conditions for welfare improvements that rural populations at equivalent incomes cannot access.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional urban development analysis of urbanisation benefits places the human capital accumulation effect — urbanisation's role in expanding educational access, skill development, and social capital formation — alongside the more commonly cited economic productivity benefit. Urban educational institutions, professional networks, and exposure to diverse populations and employment models accelerate human capital development in ways that rural environments structurally cannot replicate at equivalent scale, and these human capital gains compound over generations to produce significant cross-generational welfare improvements. The gender equity dimension of urbanisation is particularly significant in

developing country contexts: urbanisation is consistently associated with improvements in women's educational attainment, labour market participation, and autonomy — because urban labour markets value women's skills more equally than rural economic structures, urban social environments are more tolerant of women's independence, and urban geography provides greater physical separation from the family and community structures that enforce traditional gender constraints.

6. Do you think the big cities in China today will become even larger in the future?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

China's major cities are likely to continue growing over the next two to three decades, though the pace and pattern of that growth will be shaped by a set of policy and demographic forces that make simple extrapolation from current trends unreliable. The structural driver of continued growth is the urbanisation transition that China is still completing: despite already having some of the world's largest cities, China's urbanisation rate remains significantly below the levels typical of high-income economies, and the demographic pressure of rural-to-urban migration is likely to continue generating urban growth in major centres for at least another generation. The countervailing forces — including the government's explicit policy preference for directing urbanisation toward smaller and mid-sized cities rather than allowing further concentration in mega-cities, and the demographic headwind of China's declining birth rate — will moderate but are unlikely to reverse the trend toward continued growth in the largest cities.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional urban economics analysis of Chinese mega-city growth trajectories identifies the government's active spatial planning policy as the most distinctive and uncertain variable in any projection. China's urbanisation has been unusually shaped by deliberate policy intervention — including hukou registration systems that historically restricted rural-to-urban migration, special economic zone designations that channelled development into specific locations, and more recent infrastructure investment strategies like the cluster and corridor development model — in ways that make Chinese urban growth substantially more policy-sensitive than urbanisation in more market-driven economies. The current policy direction — investing heavily in transport infrastructure connecting second-tier cities, developing new urban clusters at distance from existing mega-cities, and restricting population growth in Beijing and Shanghai specifically — suggests that official policy will constrain the growth of the largest existing cities even as total urban population continues to expand.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
agglomeration economy	n phr		productivity gains arising from clustering of firms and workers	lợi thế kinh tế tập trung
overtourism	n	/,əʊ.və'tʊər.i.zəm/	excessive tourist volumes that damage the host environment and community	hiện tượng du lịch quá tải
carrying capacity	n phr		the maximum number of visitors a destination can sustain without harm	sức chứa tối đa (của điểm đến)
cultural commodification	n phr		turning cultural practices into marketable products	thương mại hoá văn hoá
hukou	n	/'hu:.kəʊ/	China's household registration system that ties social services to place of birth	hệ thống đăng ký hộ khẩu Trung Quốc
human capital	n phr		the economic value of a worker's skills, education, and experience	vốn con người
spatial planning	n phr		government policy guiding where development and population are distributed	quy hoạch không gian
multiplier effect	n phr		the amplified economic impact of initial spending as it circulates through an economy	hiệu ứng số nhân kinh tế
mega-city	n	/'meg.ə.sɪt.i/	a city with a population of more than ten million	siêu đô thị
tolerance	n	/'tol.ər.əns ²³⁷ /	willingness to accept differences and diversity	sự khoan dung, chấp nhận sự khác biệt

2.18 Describe an item on which you spent more than expected

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe an item on which you spent more than expected. You should say:

- What it is
- How much you spent on it
- Why you bought it
- And explain why you think you spent more than expected.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The purchase I most clearly remember as having exceeded my original budget was a mechanical keyboard — the kind designed for people who type a lot and care about the tactile quality of the keystroke — that I bought about a year and a half ago when I was looking for something to replace a cheap membrane keyboard that had started to give me wrist discomfort. I went into the search expecting to spend around 800,000 to a million đồng, which is what basic laptop-style keyboards cost, but discovered quite quickly that the mechanical keyboard market is stratified in a way I hadn't anticipated: there's a clear quality threshold at around two to three million, and beyond that a premium segment where the quality differences become more subtle but the prices increase substantially. I ended up spending about four million — roughly four times my initial expectation — on a keyboard that I'd been persuaded by a combination of online reviews, hands-on comparison in a store, and the specific ergonomic recommendation of a friend who types professionally. I've never regretted the purchase — it does make a genuine difference to the experience of extended typing — but the process of arriving at that number was essentially a controlled escalation that the keyboard community's culture of enthusiast comparison actively encourages.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The item on which I most substantially overspent relative to my initial expectation was my current laptop — not in the sense of an impulsive or regretted purchase, but in the sense that the specification I actually needed for the work I was doing at the time turned out to be significantly more demanding than the specification I'd budgeted for when I started the research process. I'd budgeted for a mid-range business laptop at around twenty to twenty-five million đồng, based on my understanding of what the work required — primarily document production, occasional video calls, and light data analysis. What the purchase research revealed fairly quickly was that the specific combination of features I genuinely needed — sufficient RAM for running several resource-intensive applications simultaneously, adequate processing power for video editing that I hadn't initially factored in, and a display quality adequate for extended working hours — pointed consistently toward a specification that started at around thirty-five million. The final purchase was thirty-eight million: within a range I could justify, but sixty percent above the original expectation, and a useful reminder that budgeting for major technology purchases based on the cheapest option in a category is rarely an accurate approach.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
mechanical keyboard	n phr		a keyboard using individual mechanical switches for each key	bàn phím cơ học
membrane keyboard	n phr		a keyboard using a single pressure pad rather than individual switches	bàn phím màng
tactile	adj	/'tæk.taɪl/	relating to the sense of touch; perceptible by touch	xúc giác, có thể cảm nhận qua chạm
stratified	adj	/'stræt.i.faid/	arranged in layers or levels according to quality or price	phân tầng, có cấp độ
escalation	n	/,es.kə'leɪ.ʃən/	a gradual increase in scope, intensity, or cost	sự leo thang, tăng dần
specification	n	/,spes.i.fɪ'keɪ.ʃən/	the detailed description of a product's features and requirements	thông số kỹ thuật
resource-intensive	adj		requiring a large amount of computing power or memory	tiêu thụ nhiều tài nguyên (máy tính)
ergonomic	adj	/,ɜ:.gə'nɒm.ɪk/	designed for comfort and efficiency in use	công thái học, tiện dụng
enthusiast	n	/ɪn'θju:.zi.æst/	a person with a strong interest in a particular activity or subject	người đam mê, tín đồ
budget	v	/'bʌdʒ.ɪt/	to plan how much money to spend on something	lên ngân sách, dự trù chi phí

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Do you often buy more than you expected?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The pattern of purchasing more than planned is widespread enough to have generated substantial research in consumer psychology, and reflects a predictable set of cognitive and environmental influences rather than simple impulsiveness — which means the honest answer for most people, including me, is yes, with the frequency varying substantially by shopping context. The retail environments and online platforms through which most purchasing now occurs are specifically designed to facilitate unplanned purchasing: recommendation algorithms, related product displays, bundle offers, and the frictionless checkout processes of e-commerce reduce the cognitive barriers to purchase addition in ways that systematically shift the planned-versus-unplanned ratio toward the latter. The specific vulnerability in my own purchasing is the research process: going into a purchase with inadequate information typically leads to discovering, in the course of researching the initially budgeted option, that adjacent higher-specification products offer meaningfully better value at a price increase that is easy to rationalise once the research has identified it.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional purchasing management perspective identifies the distinction between planned overspending — where additional expenditure beyond the original budget is a deliberate and justified response to new information discovered during the purchase process — and unplanned overspending driven by marketing influence, social pressure, or in-the-moment rationalisation. My own purchasing pattern leans toward the former: in professional and major personal purchases, the overspending that occurs is typically justified by specification requirements I hadn't fully anticipated, and the original budget was therefore insufficiently informed rather than simply exceeded. In everyday purchasing contexts — particularly food retail and app-store purchases — the pattern is closer to the latter: the accumulated small additions to a basket or subscription that seemed individually trivial add up to a meaningfully larger total than the initial intention.

2. What do you think young people spend most of their money on?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Young people's spending priorities reflect a predictable pattern shaped by life stage: the categories that absorb the largest shares of young adult discretionary income are those that serve the social, experiential, and identity functions that early adulthood prioritises — food and beverage social experiences, fashion and personal care, digital entertainment subscriptions, and technology. The social experience category is particularly significant: research on young adult spending consistently shows that food and dining out — which functions simultaneously as social bonding, experiential consumption, and identity expression — is among the highest-discretionary-spend categories for people in their late teens and twenties. The shift toward experiential spending — allocating discretionary income to travel, concerts, events, and activities rather than to material goods — is a well-documented trend among younger cohorts relative to previous generations, and reflects both the specific social media dynamics that make experiential sharing highly visible and the housing market circumstances that make asset accumulation through property purchase unattractive or

inaccessible for many young people.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional consumer market research on young adult spending identifies digital products and services as a category whose share has grown more rapidly among young adults than any other — reflecting both the technological embeddedness of younger cohorts' social and professional lives and the subscription economy's success in converting what were previously one-time purchases into recurring revenue streams. The smartphone and its associated ecosystem of apps, platforms, and services represents a category of infrastructure spending — expenditure on tools that feel obligatory for social and professional participation — that has no real generational precedent, and whose cost when aggregated across subscriptions, hardware upgrades, and data services is substantially larger than most young adults consciously account for. The experiential category remains significant: research consistently shows that young adults prioritise spending on experiences over goods more strongly than older cohorts, which reflects both cultural values and a rational response to the constraints — limited living space, high mobility, uncertain career trajectories — of early adult life.

3. Do you think it is important to save money? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Saving is important, but the degree and method of saving that is appropriate varies substantially with individual circumstances in ways that make universal prescriptions about saving rates misleading. The fundamental case for saving is the insurance argument: liquid savings provide the resource buffer that protects against financial shocks — unexpected medical costs, job loss, urgent home or vehicle repairs — whose probability is non-trivial across a multi-year horizon and whose financial impact, in the absence of savings, can be deeply disruptive to otherwise stable lives. The second argument is the compounding returns argument: savings invested over long time horizons — decades rather than years — benefit from the mathematical effect of compounding that makes early accumulation substantially more valuable than equivalent accumulation later, which means that the person who saves modestly from their early twenties will typically accumulate substantially more than the person who saves the same absolute amount from their thirties.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional personal finance perspective on saving importance identifies the distinction between precautionary saving — the emergency fund maintained as insurance against income disruption and unexpected costs — and goal-directed saving — the accumulation toward specific future expenditures including housing, education, and retirement — as the organisational framework most useful for practical saving behaviour. The professional consensus is that the precautionary fund — typically three to six months of essential expenditure in an accessible liquid form — is the highest priority saving objective because it provides the financial security foundation that makes all other financial planning coherent: without it, any unexpected disruption forces either debt or the liquidation of longer-term savings at potentially disadvantageous times. The retirement saving argument has gained additional urgency in the Vietnamese professional context as the shift from defined-benefit pension systems toward individual retirement saving responsibility — still in progress — transfers the risk and obligation of providing adequate retirement income from state and employer to individual.

4. Do people buy things they don't need?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Consumer psychology's most consistently robust finding is precisely this: people systematically purchase goods whose objective functional value to them is lower than their purchase price, driven by a well-catalogued set of cognitive and emotional mechanisms that marketing practice is specifically designed to exploit. The most powerful of these mechanisms is the gap between anticipated and experienced utility — the tendency to overestimate how much pleasure a good will provide before purchase relative to the pleasure it actually provides after — which produces a systematic bias toward purchasing goods in the belief that they will be more satisfying than they turn out to be. The second major mechanism is social signalling: many purchases are motivated substantially by their communicative function — what they convey about the purchaser's status, taste, and group membership — rather than by their functional utility, which means that the "need" being met is social rather than material and may be met at the price of goods substantially more expensive than their purely functional equivalents.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional behavioural economics analysis of unnecessary purchasing identifies the retail and e-commerce environment as an active participant in producing excess consumption rather than a neutral conduit for pre-existing consumer demand. The architecture of contemporary retail — both physical and digital — is specifically engineered to stimulate purchasing decisions that consumers would not have made without environmental cueing: through placement of high-margin products in high-attention locations, algorithmically personalised recommendations designed to surface goods the consumer is likely to want before the consumer has consciously identified the want, and frictionless payment systems that reduce the psychological resistance that would otherwise moderate impulse purchasing. The most effective individual countermeasures are structural: introducing mandatory delay between the identification of a want and its purchase satisfaction, maintaining a list-based purchasing discipline that routinises pre-commitment to specific goods, and consciously tracking the post-purchase utility of goods purchased on impulse — all of which increase the friction that retail environments are designed to eliminate.

5. Do you think it is the rich people's responsibility to donate money to people in need?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether wealthy individuals have a responsibility to donate to people in need is contested between positions that differ not primarily in empirical assessment but in foundational ethical commitments about the nature of property rights, social obligation, and the appropriate scope of voluntary versus institutional redistribution. The argument for moral responsibility rests most compellingly on the effective altruism reasoning developed by philosophers including Peter Singer: if a wealthy person could prevent significant suffering at modest personal cost, the failure to do so constitutes a moral choice with consequences comparable to actively causing that suffering — which is a position that is difficult to argue against without claiming that geographical and social distance creates moral distance, which most ethical frameworks reject. The argument for institutional redistribution rather than individual charity rests on the efficiency and reliability arguments: charitable giving is discretionary, arbitrary in its distribution, and subject to donor preferences that may not

align with recipient need — whereas a well-administered tax and transfer system distributes resources according to need more reliably and at lower transaction cost than the charitable sector can achieve.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional development economics perspective on private philanthropy versus public redistribution identifies both mechanisms as complementary rather than as alternatives, with each having comparative advantages in different dimensions of poverty and inequality reduction. Private philanthropy — particularly the high-capacity institutional philanthropy characteristic of major foundations — has comparative advantages in funding experimental, risk-tolerant interventions that public budget processes are too politically conservative and accountability-constrained to support, and in addressing specific problem areas that fall outside political priorities at any given moment. Public redistribution — through taxation and social transfer systems — has comparative advantages in scale, reliability, universality, and democratic accountability: it can redistribute at the scale that addresses structural poverty in ways that even the largest private philanthropies cannot match, and it does so through processes that are at least theoretically subject to democratic oversight in ways that private philanthropic decisions are not.

6. What kind of things are people happy to pay a high price for?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The categories of goods and services whose customers are reliably willing to pay substantially above the commodity price for what is ostensibly the same core utility cluster around a set of psychological functions that distinguish them from purely functional purchases. The most significant is the identity-signalling function: goods whose possession communicates something about the owner's status, taste, or group membership — luxury fashion, premium vehicles, high-end technology, certain wines and foods — command substantial premiums over functional equivalents because the social communication value is itself a genuine utility that customers are paying for. The second category is the experience premium: goods and services where the quality of the experience substantially exceeds what cheaper alternatives provide — fine dining, premium travel, high-quality musical instruments, professionally crafted furniture — where the additional spend is justified by genuine qualitative differences in the experience itself rather than purely by signalling.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional consumer behaviour analysis of premium pricing acceptance identifies trust and reliability as the most commercially powerful premium justification across categories: consumers are consistently willing to pay premium prices for goods and services where the consequences of quality failure are high and where premium pricing is associated with credibly lower failure probability. Healthcare is the clearest example — the willingness to pay for higher-quality medical services, premium health insurance, or expensive specialist consultation reflects a combination of genuine quality difference and the high stakes of health outcomes. The same logic applies to professional services — legal advice, financial management, professional education — where the quality differential between premium and commodity providers can have substantial and lasting consequences, and where the cost of the cheaper option's failure substantially exceeds the premium cost of the better option.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
discretionary income	n phr		income remaining after essential expenses, available for optional spending	thu nhập tùy ý (sau khi trừ chi phí bắt buộc)
impulse purchase	n phr		a buying decision made without prior planning	mua hàng bốc đồng
compounding returns	n phr		earnings calculated on both the initial amount and accumulated interest	lợi nhuận kép
precautionary saving	n phr		money set aside to cover unexpected costs	tiết kiệm phòng ngừa
effective altruism	n phr		a philosophy advocating using evidence to maximise the good one does with resources	chủ nghĩa vị tha hiệu quả
premium pricing	n phr		charging a higher price based on perceived quality or exclusivity	định giá cao cấp
identity-signalling	adj phr		relating to goods used to communicate social status or group membership	phát tín hiệu bản sắc
defined-benefit pension	n phr		a retirement plan guaranteeing a fixed income regardless of investment performance	lương hưu xác định lợi ích
retail architecture	n phr		the deliberate design of shopping environments to influence purchasing behaviour	kiến trúc bán lẻ (thiết kế môi trường mua sắm)
liquidity	n	/lɪˈkwɪd ɪ ti/	the ease with	tính thanh khoản

2.19 Describe a time when you felt proud of a family member

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a time when you felt proud of a family member. You should say:

- When it happened
- Who the person is
- What the person did
- And explain why you felt proud of him/her.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The moment I felt most proud of a family member happened two years ago, when my younger sister received a scholarship to study abroad — something she had worked toward entirely independently, without telling anyone she had applied.

My sister is three years younger than me and has always been quieter and less outwardly ambitious than I am. She spent most of her final year of secondary school preparing an application portfolio while maintaining her schoolwork and never asking for help or attention from the family. When the scholarship result arrived — she won a full award to study environmental engineering in Japan — she told us at dinner with no preamble, simply placing the acceptance letter on the table.

What made me proud was not the scholarship itself, impressive as it was, but the quality of character it revealed: the capacity to set a significant goal, pursue it with sustained effort in private, and manage the emotional uncertainty of a long application process without the validation of sharing it as it happened. I realised, watching her at that dinner table, that she had been developing a form of self-sufficiency I had not previously noticed, and that is a more interesting and admirable thing to observe in someone you love than any single achievement it produces.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The occasion that comes to mind most readily when I think about pride in a family member is the day my father gave his first public lecture after retiring from a career in civil engineering.

He had spent his professional life as a practitioner rather than a communicator — he built things, managed teams, solved technical problems — and had never spoken publicly about his work. After retirement, he was invited by a local professional association to speak about bridge construction methods used in Vietnamese infrastructure projects from the 1980s through the early 2000s. He spent three months preparing, learning presentation design, rehearsing his delivery, and consulting academic literature he had no previous reason to read.

The lecture itself was technically precise, well-structured, and delivered with a composure that surprised everyone who knew how uncomfortable he had been with the invitation. What made me proud was not the performance — it was the willingness, at sixty-three, to learn a completely new form of communication and to take seriously the discomfort that learning required. That kind of intellectual courage, exercised quietly and without anyone requiring it of him, seems to me far more admirable than the

professional achievements that the audience was there to hear about.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
self-sufficiency	n	/ˌself.səˈfɪ.ən.si/	the ability to manage independently without external support	sự tự lực
preamble	n	/'pri:.æm.bəl/	an introductory statement before the main point	lời mở đầu, lời dẫn
composure	n	/kəm'pəʊ.ʒər/	calmness under pressure	sự điềm tĩnh
portfolio	n	/pɔ:t'fəʊ.li.əʊ/	a collection of documents showcasing achievements	hồ sơ thành tích
validation	n	/ˌvæl.rɪ'deɪ.ʃən/	the recognition or confirmation of one's worth	sự công nhận, thừa nhận
practitioner	n	/præk'tɪʃ.ən.ər/	a person actively working in a professional field	người hành nghề
intellectual courage	n phr		willingness to engage with difficult or uncomfortable ideas	dũng khí trí tuệ
sustained effort	n phr		continuous, consistent work toward a goal	nỗ lực bền vững
rehearse	v	/rɪ'hɜ:s/	to practise before a performance or presentation	tập dượt, luyện tập
precision	n	/prɪ'sɪʒ.ən/	the quality of being exact and accurate	sự chính xác

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. When would parents feel proud of their children?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Parental pride is most consistently triggered by evidence that a child has developed qualities that the parent values rather than simply achieved outcomes the parent desired — and those two things are less identical than they might appear. A parent who values resilience will feel proudest when a child recovers confidently from failure; a parent who values social contribution will feel proudest when a child acts generously without prompting. The conflation of parental pride with academic or professional achievement reflects a specific cultural emphasis rather than a universal human pattern, and the research on parental wellbeing suggests that parents who derive pride primarily from achievement-based outcomes tend to experience higher anxiety and less satisfaction than those whose pride is rooted in character-based observations. The most durable form of parental pride is probably that which arises from recognising that the child has become capable of living well independently — a recognition that requires letting go of the specific form the success takes.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Parents feel pride most intensely at moments that confirm their child has internalised values the parent considers important — not merely performed well on measures the parent externally nominated. The distinction matters because the former reflects a genuine developmental outcome while the latter may simply reflect compliance or performance under observation. In professional contexts where I have spoken with parents about this, the most commonly cited occasions of genuine pride involve the child making a difficult or generous decision independently, without parental knowledge, in a situation where the parent would have hoped they made that choice. The evidence on parent-child relationship quality suggests that children whose self-esteem rests on meeting parental achievement expectations, rather than on internalised values, are more vulnerable to anxiety and identity fragility than children whose pride in themselves is grounded in who they are rather than what they have produced.

2. Should parents reward children? Why and how?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether parents should reward children requires distinguishing sharply between the type of reward, the behaviour being rewarded, and the developmental stage at which the reward is given. Tangible rewards for intrinsically motivated behaviours — paying a child who loves reading for every book finished — are well-documented to undermine the intrinsic motivation they appear to reinforce, a phenomenon psychologists call the overjustification effect. Rewards for behaviours that are genuinely difficult, socially beneficial, or require sustained effort against internal resistance have a stronger empirical basis: they provide the external reinforcement that helps habits form before intrinsic satisfaction becomes self-sustaining. The most developmentally sound approach is therefore selective rather than systematic: reserve rewards for genuine effort and character rather than for achievement, and reduce reliance on them as intrinsic motivation develops.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The parenting and educational psychology research on reward systems consistently supports a nuanced conclusion: rewards are most effective when they support the development of intrinsic motivation rather than substituting for it. Verbal and relational rewards — specific,

genuine acknowledgement of what a child did and why it mattered — are more consistently beneficial than material ones across developmental stages. The concern with material reward systems, particularly when applied systematically, is that they commodify behaviours that ideally become intrinsically motivated: a child who helps at home only when paid will not develop the sense that contribution is part of what it means to be a family member. Parents who use rewards strategically — for bridging difficult transitions, reinforcing newly established habits, and acknowledging extraordinary effort — tend to produce better long-term outcomes than those who use them uniformly or punitively.

3. Is it good to reward children too often? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Excessive reward is counterproductive, and the mechanism through which it causes harm is reasonably well established in behavioural psychology. Constant or predictable rewards shift children's motivational orientation from internal to external: they learn to work for the reward rather than for the activity itself, which means that when the reward is withdrawn, the behaviour frequently stops. There is also an expectation escalation dynamic: children who are rewarded frequently for ordinary behaviour develop a higher baseline expectation of reward, which means that the same reward loses its motivational power over time and must be escalated to maintain effect. The developmental goal of parenting is, among other things, to produce a child who acts well because of who they are rather than because of what they will receive — which requires deliberate restraint in the use of external incentives.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Frequent reward produces diminishing motivational returns and, in some developmental contexts, actively damages intrinsic engagement with learning and prosocial behaviour. The most robust finding in this area — replicated across multiple research traditions — is that rewarding behaviour that children already find intrinsically interesting reduces their subsequent interest in that activity, an effect that is particularly strong when the reward is tangible and predictable. In organisational and educational settings, the most effective motivational environments are those that combine appropriate challenge with autonomy and genuine social acknowledgement, rather than systematic material incentivisation. The practical implication for parents is not that rewards should be withheld entirely but that they should be earned by extraordinary effort rather than routine compliance, and delivered in a form — genuine recognition rather than material goods — that carries relational rather than transactional meaning.

4. On what occasions would adults be proud of themselves?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Adult self-pride is most meaningfully grounded in occasions where one has acted in accordance with a deeply held value under conditions that made it genuinely difficult to do so. This is qualitatively different from pride in outcomes: a person who achieves a significant goal through circumstances partly beyond their control experiences a different kind of satisfaction than one who maintains integrity under social or professional pressure, chooses generosity at personal cost, or does something difficult purely because it is right. The second category of pride tends to be more durable and more accurately self-attributed because the relevant causal chain runs more directly through the person's character. The occasions that generate

the most meaningful and lasting self-pride are therefore typically not moments of external recognition but moments of private decision.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

In professional contexts, I observe that adults most commonly cite pride in occasions when they maintained a principled position under pressure that would have made abandoning it much easier — not pride in having been right, but pride in having behaved with integrity when it cost something. This pattern suggests that self-pride, at mature developmental stages, is primarily a moral rather than an achievement emotion: it is the signal that one has lived up to one's own standards rather than met some externally imposed criterion. The occasions that adults most reliably report with pride — raising a child well, supporting a colleague at personal cost, completing something difficult that no one else required of them — share the characteristic of having required sustained character over time rather than a single impressive performance.

5. Do rewards help a child become better?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Whether rewards help a child become better depends entirely on what "better" means and what kind of reward is being used. If "better" means more compliant in a specific context in the short term, then tangible rewards are effective; if it means more genuinely motivated, resilient, and prosocially oriented over the long term, the evidence is considerably more equivocal. The most beneficial forms of reward in child development are relational and informational — specific acknowledgement that tells the child what they did and why it mattered — rather than material. These forms of recognition support the development of a stable and accurate self-concept, which is a much more durable basis for future behaviour than the anticipation of tangible gain.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The evidence on reward systems in child development is clear that reward **type** matters far more than reward **frequency**. Informational feedback — specific, genuine, and connected to effort or character rather than outcome — consistently improves performance and long-term motivation; material reward for the same behaviour produces short-term compliance with long-term motivational costs. The most sophisticated parenting and educational approaches distinguish explicitly between different purposes of reward: extrinsic reward to establish habits that are not yet intrinsically motivating, and increasingly intrinsic and relational acknowledgement once habits are established. Children who develop intrinsic motivational orientations — who work hard because they care about what they are doing — consistently outperform those whose motivation remains primarily extrinsic across most long-term developmental measures.

6. What do you think about children working hard just for grades?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Children who work primarily for grades rather than for learning represent a misalignment between schooling's stated purpose and its operational incentives — and the consequences of that misalignment for long-term intellectual development are well-documented. Grade-oriented studying optimises for performance under the specific conditions of assessment rather than for durable understanding, which means that the knowledge acquired is typically

shallower and less transferable than knowledge acquired through genuine intellectual engagement. The motivational pattern is also fragile: students who work for grades are significantly more vulnerable to anxiety, burnout, and motivation collapse when grades are unavailable or unfavourable than those whose motivation is rooted in genuine curiosity. Addressing this requires structural change in how schools assess and communicate educational value, not simply individual exhortation to students to "love learning."

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Working hard for grades is a rational response to an incentive system that treats grades as the primary signal of educational success — and the appropriate critical target is the incentive system rather than the children responding to it. Educational environments that diversify assessment, reward genuine intellectual risk-taking, and communicate substantively about learning rather than simply about performance consistently produce students with stronger intrinsic motivation and more durable capability than those that reduce success to numerical ranking. The deeper concern is that grade-oriented students tend to develop a strategic rather than a curious relationship with knowledge: they learn to identify what will be tested rather than what is genuinely interesting, which is precisely the cognitive orientation that is least useful in professional and intellectual environments that reward novel thinking. Schools that are serious about producing genuinely capable graduates need to confront the fact that grade optimisation and genuine learning are not only different things but are, in many institutional contexts, in active tension.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
overjustification effect	n phr		the reduction of intrinsic motivation caused by adding external rewards	hiệu ứng biện hộ quá mức
intrinsic motivation	n phr	/ɪn'trɪn.zɪk ,məʊ.tɪ'veɪ.jən/	motivation driven from within, not from external rewards	động lực nội tại
extrinsic reward	n phr	/ek'strɪn.zɪk/	a reward given from an external source (e.g. money, grades)	phần thưởng bên ngoài
prosocial	adj	/,prəʊ'səʊ.ʃəl/	relating to behaviour intended to benefit others	mang tính vì người khác, xã hội tích cực
burnout	n	/'bɜːn.aʊt/	exhaustion caused by prolonged stress or overwork	kiệt sức, cháy hết
incentive system	n phr		the structure of rewards and penalties that shapes behaviour	hệ thống khuyến khích
resilience	n	/rɪ'zɪl.i.əns/	the ability to recover from setbacks	sức bật, khả năng phục hồi
internalise	v	/ɪn'tɜː.nəl.aɪz/	to absorb and adopt a value as part of one's own beliefs	nội tâm hóa, tiếp thu thành giá trị bản thân
self-concept	n	/'self.kən.sept/	a person's understanding and image of themselves	tự nhận thức
compliance	n	/kəm'plaɪ.əns/	obedience to rules or authority	sự tuân thủ

2.20 Describe a bicycle / motorcycle / car trip you would like to go on

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a bicycle / motorcycle / car trip you would like to go on. You should say:

- Who you would like to go with
- Where you would like to go
- When you would like to go
- And explain why you would like to go by bicycle / motorcycle / car.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The trip I have wanted to take for several years is a motorcycle journey along the coast from Đà Nẵng to Hội An and then through the Hải Vân Pass — a route I have read about often but never actually done.

I would want to go with two close friends — one who has already made the journey and knows the road, and one who has not, because the combination of someone experienced and someone experiencing it for the first time seems like the most interesting social configuration for travel. We would go in late September, after the peak tourist season, when the road is quieter and the light in the late afternoon along the coastal stretches is at its best.

The reason I specifically want to go by motorcycle rather than by car or bus is spatial: on a motorcycle, you are in the environment rather than merely passing through it, and the particular experience of riding over the Hải Vân Pass — the wind, the grade, the sight of the sea appearing and disappearing on either side — seems to me like something that requires being exposed to rather than being insulated from.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The trip I have been planning without yet quite committing to is a car journey through the Central Highlands — starting from Buôn Ma Thuột and travelling through Kon Tum toward the border provinces — which I would like to make with my spouse and no fixed itinerary beyond a general direction.

My interest in this route is partly geographical — the landscape of the highlands is genuinely unlike anything in the coastal cities where I spend most of my time — and partly connected to a longer-term project of understanding parts of the country I know primarily from documents rather than from presence. Some of the most significant events in Vietnamese history in the second half of the twentieth century took place in this region, and there is a quality of understanding derived from physical presence in a landscape that no amount of reading fully replicates.

I want to go by car rather than by motorcycle because the journey would take several days, and the ability to carry equipment, stop anywhere, and find somewhere to sleep without planning it in advance requires the storage capacity and weather protection that a car provides. The condition of unplanned arrival in places I have never been, with enough of the right books and sufficient time, is the form of travel I find most genuinely restorative.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
itinerary	n	/aɪ'tɪn.ər.ər.i/	a planned route or schedule for a journey	lịch trình, kế hoạch hành trình
restorative	adj	/rɪ'stɔː.rə.tɪv/	having the quality of refreshing or renewing energy	phục hồi, tái tạo năng lượng
spatial	adj	/'speɪ.ʃəl/	relating to space and the physical environment	thuộc không gian
configuration	n	/kən'fɪg.jʊ'reɪ.ʃən/	the way parts are arranged or set up	cấu hình, cách sắp xếp
grade	n	/greɪd/	the degree of inclination in a road or path	độ dốc
insulate	v	/'ɪn.sjʊ.lət/	to protect from external conditions	cách ly, bảo vệ khỏi môi trường bên ngoài
province	n	/'prɒv.ɪns/	an administrative region of a country	tỉnh
replicates	v	/'rep.lɪ.ket/	to reproduce or duplicate an effect	tái tạo, sao chép
coastal	adj	/'kəʊ.stəl/	relating to or near a coast	ven biển
infrastructure	n	/'ɪn.frə.strʌk.tʃər/	the physical systems (roads, power, etc.) supporting a society	cơ sở hạ tầng

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Which form of vehicle is more popular in your country, bikes, cars or motorcycles?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The motorcycle is unquestionably the dominant personal transport vehicle in Vietnam, for reasons rooted in both historical economics and urban spatial constraints. During the decades when incomes were too low to support car ownership at scale, the motorcycle was the maximum accessible form of independent mobility, and a transport culture — its infrastructure, its commercial ecosystem, its social norms — developed around it that persists

even as incomes have risen significantly. Urban road networks built during this period were also designed around motorcycle proportions rather than car proportions, which means that the city-level infrastructure still favours motorcycles over cars in many practical respects. The rising rate of car ownership among middle-income Vietnamese households reflects growing affluence rather than any change in the underlying logic, and the result — more cars on roads designed for motorcycles — is most visible in the traffic conditions of Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Vietnam's transport mode landscape is one of the most motorcycle-dominated in the world, and the reasons are structural rather than simply cultural preference. The combination of low vehicle acquisition cost, low operating cost, and exceptional navigational flexibility through dense urban road networks made the motorcycle the economically optimal transport solution for the income levels and urban configurations that characterised Vietnam's cities from the 1980s through the early 2000s. As household incomes have risen and middle-class aspirations have expanded, car ownership has grown rapidly, but the spatial logic of Vietnamese cities — narrow streets, dense development, limited off-street parking — continues to make the motorcycle more practically efficient for daily urban transport even for households that own a car. The bicycle, while politically favoured in climate and urban planning discourse, has very limited practical penetration in Vietnamese cities because the infrastructure — dedicated lanes, secure parking, and the distances involved — has not yet developed to support it at scale.

2. Do you think air pollution comes mostly from mobile vehicles?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Vehicle emissions are a significant contributor to urban air pollution in Vietnamese cities, but attributing most air pollution to mobile vehicles oversimplifies a more complex picture. In cities like Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City, where road dust, construction activity, and industrial emissions from facilities within and around the urban area are also substantial pollution sources, vehicle emissions are the dominant contributor in some time periods and areas but not universally. The particular pollution profile of Vietnamese urban transport is further complicated by the ageing vehicle fleet: motorcycles and trucks operating with older engine technology and inadequate maintenance contribute disproportionately to particulate and hydrocarbon emissions relative to their numbers. Addressing air quality effectively requires targeting the highest-emitting vehicles and uses rather than the modal category as a whole.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The attribution of urban air pollution in Vietnam primarily to mobile vehicles reflects a commonly held assumption that is broadly correct at the city level but requires considerable nuance at the empirical level. In Hanoi, air quality monitoring data shows that PM2.5 concentrations — the particulate size most harmful to respiratory health — spike on days with minimal wind regardless of traffic volume, suggesting that local combustion sources (cooking, waste burning, construction activity) and regional transport of pollution from neighbouring provinces are significant contributors alongside vehicle emissions. The implication for policy is that vehicle emission standards and fleet modernisation — both clearly desirable — will not alone resolve Vietnam's air quality problem if other emission sources remain unaddressed. A credible national air quality strategy requires accounting for the full emission inventory, not only the most politically visible source.

3. Do you think people need to change the way of transportation drastically to protect the environment?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

A drastic shift in transport behaviour is necessary at the global level, but the form it needs to take is different in different urban and economic contexts rather than being a single universal transition. In high-income cities with well-developed public transport and cycling infrastructure, the most impactful shift is from private car use to active and public transport. In middle-income cities like Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City, where motorised transport has much higher baseline emissions than in cities with modern fleets, the highest near-term impact comes from fleet modernisation — replacing old motorcycles and commercial vehicles with low-emission alternatives — because the modal shift to public transport that would require decades of infrastructure investment can deliver only long-term results. The most environmentally effective transport policy is therefore pragmatic and context-specific rather than based on a single ideologically preferred modal solution.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for significant transport system transformation is well-established in climate science — transport represents a substantial share of global greenhouse gas emissions and cannot be decarbonised without structural change — but "drastic" requires careful definition. The most effective transport transitions globally have been those that make lower-emission alternatives genuinely more convenient and economical than higher-emission ones, rather than those that rely primarily on restriction of existing behaviour. In the Vietnamese context, the most productive near-term interventions are the electrification of the motorcycle fleet — for which the economics are becoming increasingly favourable — and the development of public transport capacity in the major cities, which reduces the effective transport cost of not owning a private vehicle. Both are achievable without the social and political costs of sudden restriction-based transitions, which tend to be implemented unevenly and resisted most acutely by those with the fewest transport alternatives.

4. How are the transportation systems in urban areas and rural areas different?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The transport disparity between urban and rural Vietnam is one of the most significant and least discussed dimensions of spatial inequality in the country. Urban residents in major cities have access to ride-hailing services, public bus networks (with variable reliability), and a dense commercial ecosystem that reduces the daily transport distance required for most life functions. Rural residents, particularly in mountainous and remote provinces, often lack access to any motorised public transport, depend entirely on private motorcycle ownership for all non-walking mobility, and face distances to essential services — healthcare, secondary education, markets — that make transport cost a significant proportion of household expenditure. The consequence of this infrastructure gap is not merely inconvenience but a compounding of other forms of disadvantage: limited access to healthcare, education, and economic opportunity is substantially mediated by transport access in rural contexts.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The urban-rural transport infrastructure gap in Vietnam reflects both historical investment patterns and the structural challenge of providing viable public transport across geographically dispersed, low-density settlement patterns. Urban transport investment has concentrated in

the major cities — Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City are building metro systems; ride-hailing has transformed urban mobility economics — while rural transport has received primarily road infrastructure investment with minimal public transport service development. The result is a transport system in which urban residents can increasingly access employment, services, and social opportunities without private vehicle ownership, while rural residents' effective radius of daily life is bounded almost entirely by what they can reach by private motorcycle. This asymmetry has significant implications for rural economic development and for the persistence of urban-rural migration: transport access is one of the primary mechanisms through which urban opportunity is made accessible or inaccessible to rural young people.

5. Why do more people own and drive private cars now?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The growth in private car ownership in Vietnam reflects the intersection of rising household incomes, expanding consumer credit, declining vehicle prices, and the aspirational dimension of car ownership in a society where it has historically been associated with upper-middle-class status. As household incomes have crossed the threshold at which car ownership becomes affordable — not necessarily comfortable, but achievable — a proportion of households have shifted from motorcycle to car, particularly for family transport needs where the motorcycle's carrying capacity is a practical limitation. The practical preference for private cars also reflects the inadequacy of public transport in most Vietnamese cities: in the absence of reliable, comfortable, and comprehensive public transport, the car is the rational choice for households that can afford it and that need to make regular trips across the city. This is a structural rather than a purely aspirational driver, and it will only be addressed structurally — by making public transport more attractive — rather than by shaming or restricting car ownership.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Rising private car ownership in Vietnam is driven primarily by income growth and the persistent failure of public transport to provide a credible alternative for city-wide mobility needs. The aspirational dimension is real — car ownership remains a status marker in Vietnamese social culture — but its explanatory power is somewhat overstated: surveys of car purchasers consistently show that practical transport need and family requirement are the primary stated justifications, with status a secondary consideration. The more structurally important dynamic is the feedback loop between car ownership and urban form: as car numbers increase, roads are widened and parking is expanded at the expense of pedestrian and cycling infrastructure, which makes non-car transport less practical and car ownership more necessary, producing the urban form outcomes — sprawl, congestion, and reduced walkability — that are most costly to reverse.

6. What do you think of the future of electric cars?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Electric vehicles represent the most credible near-term pathway to decarbonising private road transport, and the trajectory of the technology and the market over the past decade strongly supports the view that widespread EV adoption is a matter of when rather than whether. The cost parity between electric and internal combustion vehicles has been reached in several segments and is approaching it in others; charging infrastructure is expanding;

and battery energy density continues to improve at a pace that is eliminating the range limitations that were previously the most significant adoption barrier. In the Vietnamese context, the growth of VinFast as a domestic EV manufacturer with a specific strategy for the local motorcycle and car markets is an interesting structural intervention: if successful, it could accelerate the electrification of Vietnam's transport fleet at a pace that purely import-dependent markets could not achieve.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The future of electric vehicles is substantially positive from both an environmental and an economic perspective, though the transition will be more differentiated and more contested than the most optimistic accounts suggest. The environmental benefit of EVs depends critically on the electricity source: an EV charged primarily from a coal-dominated grid produces significantly lower lifecycle emissions than a petrol vehicle but the difference is much smaller than the zero-tailpipe-emission framing implies. In Vietnam, where coal still accounts for a large proportion of electricity generation, the full environmental benefit of EV adoption will not be realised until the electricity generation mix is also substantially cleaner — which is the more fundamental and politically difficult transition. The economic transition is clearer and more imminent: the total cost of EV ownership is declining rapidly, and within a decade it seems highly likely that internal combustion vehicles will be economically disadvantaged in most market segments regardless of government policy.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
modal shift	n phr		a change in the predominant form of transport used by people	chuyển đổi phương thức vận tải
fleet	n	/fli:t/	the total number of vehicles in operation	đội phương tiện
electrification	n	/ɪˌlek.trɪ.fɪ'keɪ.ʃən/	the transition to electric power	điện khí hóa
PM2.5	n phr		fine particulate matter in the air that poses health risks	bụi mịn PM2.5
decarbonise	v	/di:'kɑ:ˌbæ.naɪz/	to reduce or eliminate carbon emissions	khử carbon, giảm phát thải carbon
lifecycle emissions	n phr		total emissions produced over the entire lifespan of a product	phát thải vòng đời
sprawl	n	/spro:l/	unplanned, spread-out urban development	đô thị hóa tràn lan
ride-hailing	n	/'raɪd.hei.lɪŋ/	a service (like Grab) for booking transport via a smartphone app	gọi xe công nghệ
emission standard	n phr		a regulation limiting the amount of pollutants vehicles may produce	tiêu chuẩn khí thải
spatial inequality	n phr		unequal access to services or opportunities based on location	bất bình đẳng không gian

2.21 Describe a person who solved a problem in a smart way

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a person who solved a problem in a smart way. You should say:

- Who this person is
- What the problem was
- How he/she solved it
- And explain why you think he/she did it in a smart way.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I want to talk about is a classmate named Minh Trí, who found a remarkably practical solution to a problem that had frustrated our entire study group for most of our first semester.

The problem was coordination: eight people trying to revise together across different schedules, different accommodation arrangements, and different working speeds. Every attempt to plan group sessions ended in either non-attendance or sessions that were only productive for the people who happened to be in the same place at the same time. Minh Trí's solution, implemented quietly without proposing it to the group first, was to create a shared online document where everyone contributed one summary page per topic after studying it independently — so that by the time we needed to revise, there were eight perspectives on each topic in one place and no one had needed to coordinate a single meeting to produce it.

What I found genuinely smart about it was the identification of the real problem: we did not need more meetings, we needed a system that produced the output of meetings without requiring the coordination that made meetings difficult. That reframing of the problem — away from "how do we get people to attend" toward "how do we produce useful material without requiring attendance" — was the intelligent move, not the particular technology used.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I would describe is a junior colleague at my previous company — I will call her Lan — who resolved a serious interdepartmental communication breakdown that had been causing project delays for over a year, without any formal authority to do so.

The problem was structural: two teams whose workflows were interdependent had developed incompatible documentation formats and an implicit mutual resentment that meant information was not being shared promptly. Multiple management-level meetings had produced agreements that were not implemented. Lan's approach was to spend two weeks doing informal one-on-one conversations with members of both teams, identifying the specific points of friction, and then proposing a documentation template that addressed the concrete objections of both sides without requiring either to concede the principle of their original approach.

The template was adopted within a month and the delays resolved. What made it smart was the diagnostic precision: she understood that the stated conflict (documentation

format) masked a real conflict (perceived disrespect between teams), and that solving the stated conflict in a way that acknowledged the real one was the only approach that would actually be implemented. That kind of social intelligence — reading what a problem is actually about beneath what it appears to be about — is the most practically valuable form of problem-solving in organisational contexts.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
reframe	v	/ˌriːˈfreɪm/	to present or think about a problem in a different way	tái định nghĩa vấn đề
diagnostic	adj	/ˌdaɪ.əɡˈnɒs.tɪk/	relating to identifying the root cause of a problem	liên quan đến chẩn đoán, xác định nguyên nhân
interdepartmental	adj	/ˌɪn.tə.dɪ.pɑːt.'men.tl/	involving more than one department	liên bộ phận
friction	n	/'frɪk.ʃən/	conflict or difficulty between people or groups	ma sát, mâu thuẫn
implicit	adj	/ɪm'plɪs.ɪt/	suggested without being directly stated	ngầm hiểu, không nói ra
coordination	n	/kəʊˌɔː.dɪ'neɪ.ʃən/	the organisation of people or things to work effectively together	sự phối hợp
lateral thinking	n phr		solving problems using indirect or creative approaches	tư duy sáng tạo theo chiều ngang
concede	v	/kən'siːd/	to admit or yield a point in an argument	nhượng bộ, thừa nhận
template	n	/'tem.pleɪt/	a standard format used as a model	mẫu, khuôn mẫu
social intelligence	n phr		the ability to understand and navigate social situations effectively	trí tuệ xã hội

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Do you think children are born smart or they learn to become smart?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The nature-nurture framing of intelligence is one that developmental science has substantially complicated: both genetic endowment and environmental input shape cognitive capacity, and the question of whether someone is "born smart" obscures how inseparably these factors interact. Current evidence suggests that general cognitive ability has a significant heritable component, but that heritability does not imply environmental immutability — the same genetic predisposition produces very different outcomes in different learning environments, nutrition contexts, and developmental experiences. The most practically important insight from this research is that intelligence is not a fixed quantity distributed at birth but a capacity that develops through engagement with stimulating environments, effective teaching, and the kind of persistent effort that is itself partly a product of how a child has been taught to relate to difficulty. "Smart" as a description of a child's current performance is therefore more a statement about what they have experienced than about what they are inherently capable of.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The empirical position on intelligence development is now reasonably clear: cognitive capacity is neither purely innate nor purely developed — it is the product of gene-environment interaction across the entire developmental period, with the relative contribution of each shifting across domains and developmental stages. The more policy-relevant insight is that assuming intelligence is fixed produces educational and parenting environments that systematically underinvest in children who begin with lower measured performance, because the assumption of fixity makes investment appear futile — a self-fulfilling prophecy with well-documented negative consequences for educational equity. Carol Dweck's research on growth mindset, though sometimes oversimplified in its popular applications, captures a real and important truth: students who are taught to understand their intelligence as developable outperform equally capable students who have been taught to understand it as fixed, across a wide range of conditions and domains.

2. How do children become smart at school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Schools develop cognitive ability most effectively through the quality of the thinking they require children to do rather than the quantity of information they transmit. The research on effective pedagogy consistently shows that tasks requiring children to explain their reasoning, connect new information to prior knowledge, and produce something — an argument, a solution, an explanation — rather than simply receive and reproduce content produce substantially stronger and more durable learning outcomes than passive instruction. Perhaps most importantly, schools that create environments in which intellectual risk-taking is genuinely safe — where being wrong is treated as a normal part of learning rather than a performance failure — consistently develop more cognitively capable and more intellectually engaged students than those that treat error as something to be concealed.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The school-level factors that most consistently predict student cognitive development are teacher quality, curricular challenge, and the degree to which assessment rewards genuine understanding rather than recall. Teacher quality — defined not primarily as subject expertise but as pedagogical skill and the capacity to identify and respond to individual student misunderstanding — is the single highest-leverage in-school variable in educational research, consistently accounting for more variance in student outcomes than curriculum design, resources, or class size. Schools that invest in teacher development rather than primarily in curricular

content tend to produce better outcomes, which suggests that the quality of the intellectual relationship between teacher and student is the primary mechanism through which schooling develops young minds.

3. Why are some people well-rounded and others only good at one thing?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The spectrum from breadth to depth of ability reflects the interaction of innate inclination, developmental environment, and deliberate choice rather than a single determining factor. Some people have genuinely broader cognitive profiles — their strongest abilities span multiple domains rather than concentrating in one — which predisposes them to breadth of engagement and development. Others have profiles that are significantly stronger in specific domains, and the positive feedback that early success in those domains provides — attention, recognition, the pleasure of competence — naturally draws sustained effort and hence further development in that direction. The environments in which children develop further shape this: educational systems that value breadth reward and develop it; families and institutions that provide sustained specialist resources create the conditions for depth.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The distinction between generalist and specialist ability profiles is one that has significant implications for both individual career development and organisational design. At the individual level, depth of expertise in a specific domain is typically developed through sustained deliberate practice — the kind of focused, effortful engagement with difficulty that is both cognitively demanding and intrinsically motivating only for those who have developed sufficient basic competence to find the domain genuinely engaging. Breadth tends to be associated with environments and temperaments that sustain curiosity across domains without the motivational concentration that deep domain engagement requires. Neither profile is inherently superior; both are valuable, and the most effective organisations are those that create structures in which genuine depth and genuine breadth can coexist and mutually inform each other.

4. Why does modern society need talents of all kinds?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Modern societies are characterised by unprecedented functional complexity — the range of problems they need to solve and the range of systems they need to maintain is substantially broader than any historical precedent — and this complexity creates genuine demand for diversity of cognitive profile and talent. The reduction of talent to a small set of academically measured abilities has consistently produced social and economic costs that far exceed the apparent efficiencies of standardisation: engineering-dominant organisations that cannot navigate social and political environments, data-rich analytical systems that cannot formulate the normative questions worth analysing, and creative industries that cannot translate their insights into systems that sustain them. The argument for pluralism of talent is therefore not simply a social justice argument but an efficiency argument: complex problems require diverse approaches, and homogeneous talent pools systematically produce blind spots.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The practical case for talent diversity in modern organisations rests on a well-evidenced finding from organisational psychology: cognitively diverse teams consistently outperform homogeneous ones on complex problem-solving tasks, even when the homogeneous team

has higher average measured ability. This is because complex problems require multiple approaches — analytical, creative, practical, interpersonal — and a team composed entirely of people who approach problems similarly will find certain categories of solution systematically inaccessible regardless of their individual capability. The social infrastructure of modern societies further amplifies this point: the systems that make economic life possible — healthcare, education, social services, civic governance — require skills that are not captured in any single talent taxonomy, and their effective provision requires recruiting and developing people whose strongest capacities lie across a genuinely wide range.

5. Do you think smart children are happier than other children?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The assumption that high cognitive ability is associated with greater happiness in childhood is not well-supported by the research and is arguably closer to the opposite in certain crucial respects. Children with unusually high measured intelligence often experience specific social difficulties: they may find it harder to form peer relationships with age-mates whose intellectual interests and communication styles differ substantially from their own, may be more acutely aware of discrepancies between adult behaviour and stated values, and may experience school environments calibrated for average ability as chronically understimulating in ways that produce frustration and disengagement rather than satisfaction. The relationship between intelligence and happiness is also moderated heavily by the environment: a cognitively capable child in a well-matched, stimulating educational environment with strong peer relationships is likely to be highly satisfied; the same child in a mismatched environment may be significantly less so.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Intelligence and happiness are different psychological constructs with a complex and non-linear relationship that varies considerably across developmental contexts. The popular assumption that smart children are happier conflates two things: the pleasure of intellectual mastery, which genuinely motivates and satisfies curious children, and general psychological wellbeing, which is much more strongly predicted by the quality of attachment relationships, a sense of belonging, and effective emotional regulation than by cognitive ability. High-ability children who experience their intelligence primarily as a source of social differentiation — as something that separates them from peers rather than positioning them within a community — tend to report lower wellbeing than those whose intelligence is an integrated rather than a separating feature of their social identity. The question for parents and educators is therefore not whether to develop children's abilities but how to do so in environments that support rather than undermine their social and emotional development simultaneously.

6. Is it important for schools to identify and develop each student's talents?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The identification and development of individual student talents is important to the extent that schools understand the full range of what counts as talent rather than applying a narrow definition that privileges academically standardised abilities. A school that identifies and develops a narrow band of mathematical and linguistic ability has not meaningfully addressed this question, because the students whose strongest capacities lie in practical reasoning, social intelligence, artistic or spatial domains, or physical competence are not

served by identifying only a subset of potentially valuable human capabilities as worthy of development. The genuine version of this commitment requires both curricular breadth and assessment approaches that make a wider range of abilities visible and rewarded — neither of which is structurally inexpensive or politically uncontested.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for personalised talent identification and development in schools is strong in principle and substantially more complicated in practice. The research on personalised learning suggests that interventions calibrated to individual student ability profiles and learning approaches produce better outcomes than undifferentiated instruction — but implementing this at scale requires teacher capacity, diagnostic tools, and institutional flexibility that most school systems do not currently have. The more fundamental question is whether schools should aspire to develop every student’s existing strong points or to ensure every student develops a common core of capabilities — and the answer, most plausibly, is that both are necessary: a common foundation of literacy, numeracy, and civic understanding that enables participation in social and economic life, combined with genuine room for the diversification that makes both individual flourishing and social complexity possible.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
heritable	adj	/ˈher.ɪ.tə.bəl/	capable of being passed from parent to child genetically	có thể di truyền
pedagogy	n	/ˈped.ə.gə.dʒi/	the theory and practice of teaching	phương pháp giảng dạy, sư phạm học
growth mindset	n phr		the belief that abilities can be developed through dedication and effort	tư duy phát triển
deliberate practice	n phr		highly focused practice designed to improve specific skills	luyện tập có chủ đích
cognitive diversity	n phr		a range of different thinking styles and approaches within a group	đa dạng nhận thức
cognitive profile	n phr		the pattern of a person's different mental strengths and weaknesses	hồ sơ nhận thức
predispose	v	/ˌpriː.dɪˈspəʊz/	to make someone likely to think or behave in a particular way	khiến có xu hướng
self-fulfilling prophecy	n phr		a belief that causes itself to become true through behaviour	lời tiên tri tự hiện thực hóa
homogeneous	adj	/ˌhɒm.əˈdʒiː.ni.əs/	of the same type or nature; lacking diversity	đồng nhất
undifferentiated	adj	/ˌʌn.dɪˈfer.ən.ji.əl.tɪd/	not adapted to individual differences	không phân hoá, không cá nhân hoá

2.22 Describe an occasion when many people were smiling

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe an occasion when many people were smiling. You should say:

- When it happened
- Who you were with
- What happened
- And explain why most people were smiling.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The occasion that comes to mind most readily is the last session of a ten-week community reading programme that my university's literature club organised in a neighbourhood library — an event that ended in a way none of us had planned.

We had been running weekly sessions for elderly residents, mostly reading aloud from Vietnamese short stories and occasionally discussing them. The final session was supposed to be a simple closing ceremony, but one of the elderly participants — a seventy-eight-year-old woman named Bà Hạnh — had prepared, without telling anyone, a short poem she had written during the programme, inspired by one of the stories we had read together. She stood up and read it with complete composure and evident enjoyment. It was a genuinely accomplished piece, formally attentive and emotionally precise.

When she finished, the room was briefly silent and then everyone smiled — not a polite social smile but one that comes when something unexpected is also unexpectedly good. It was the particular smile of shared recognition: everyone in that room had just witnessed something they had not anticipated and did not have words for, and the smiling was the only adequate response available.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The occasion I think of most readily is the moment during a team debrief meeting — which I was facilitating — when a very junior team member gave a five-minute presentation that was, by a considerable margin, the best piece of analytical work produced by anyone in the project.

The project had been running for four months and had been difficult in the way that complex institutional projects usually are — scope disagreements, resource constraints, interpersonal friction between senior team members. The junior analyst, who had worked primarily in the background throughout, had noticed a data pattern that no one else had identified and had prepared a concise, precise, and clearly communicated summary of its implications in her limited spare time, without being asked.

When she finished, there was a pause, and then I noticed that almost everyone in the room was smiling — including the two senior team members who had been in significant disagreement with each other throughout the project. What that smile expressed, I think, was something like gratitude: gratitude that the work had produced something genuinely good, that the difficulty had been worth it, and that someone in the team had simply done excellent work without requiring recognition as the condition of doing it.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
composure	n	/kəm'pəʊ.ʒər/	calmness and self-control, especially in difficult situations	sự bình tĩnh, điềm tĩnh
debrief	n	/,di:'bri:f/	a meeting to review and discuss what happened during a project or event	buổi tổng kết, báo cáo sau sự kiện
attentive	adj	/ə'ten.tɪv/	paying close and careful attention	chú tâm, cẩn thận
gratitude	n	/'grætɪ.tju:d/	the feeling of being thankful	lòng biết ơn
interpersonal	adj	/,ɪn.tə.'pɜː.sən.əl/	relating to relationships between people	giữa người với người
scope	n	/skəʊp/	the range or extent of something	phạm vi
concise	adj	/kən'saɪs/	expressed clearly and briefly	súc tích
composure	n		calmness under pressure	sự điềm tĩnh
anticipate	v	/æn'tɪs.ɪ.pert/	to expect or predict something in advance	dự đoán, đoán trước
implicit	adj	/ɪm'plɪs.ɪt/	suggested without being directly stated	ngầm hiểu

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Do you think people who like to smile are more friendly?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The relationship between smiling and friendliness is directionally true but less simply causal than the popular claim implies. Smiling functions as a social signal that reduces the perceived threat or uncertainty of interaction, and people who smile readily do tend to be experienced as more approachable — which in turn generates more social interaction and the

relational warmth that sustains it. However, the relationship runs in both directions: friendly people smile more, and smiling more produces more friendly interactions, so the causal arrow is not cleanly unidirectional. Cultures and individuals also differ substantially in how much smiling is appropriate in public contexts, so reading frequent smiling as friendliness — and infrequent smiling as unfriendliness — is a cultural inference that does not generalise globally.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The inference from smiling to friendliness is one that social psychology research examines with considerable nuance: smiling does consistently increase social approval and approach behaviour in others, and people who smile more are rated as warmer and more trustworthy in first impressions. However, the relationship is complicated by the well-documented cultural variation in display rules — the norms governing when and how much emotional expression is appropriate — that mean a Vietnamese professional's relatively infrequent public smiling and an American colleague's near-constant one may both represent equally warm interpersonal orientations expressed in culturally different registers. The practical implication for cross-cultural professional environments is that inferring character from smile frequency is an unreliable heuristic that can generate systematically misleading interpersonal assessments.

2. Why do most people smile in photographs?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The convention of smiling in photographs is a relatively recent historical development that became dominant during the twentieth century as photography shifted from formal portraiture to informal social documentation. The functional explanation is that photographs serve as social artefacts — shared memories, communication tools, identity presentations — and smiling in them signals that the moment captured was positive, that the relationships depicted are warm, and that the person photographed wishes to be remembered as happy and approachable. The convention has also been reinforced by decades of photographic instruction that literally tells subjects to smile, creating a behavioural norm that is now largely automatic. That automaticity means that many photographic smiles are performative rather than expressive — a social compliance signal rather than a genuine emotional readout.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The norm of photographic smiling reflects the social function that photographs serve in contemporary culture more than the emotional states of the people in them. Photographs circulate as social signals — on social media, in family albums, in professional profiles — and the smile functions as a shorthand for the social message the photographer and subject wish to convey: that they are happy, that the occasion was good, and that their relationships are warm. The performative nature of most photographic smiling does not necessarily make it insincere; it is rather a form of social communication that uses the body the way a caption uses words. The interesting exception is in serious photographic portraiture, where the absence of the smile is itself communicative — signalling that the subject is asking to be seen as a full person rather than as a social artefact.

3. Do women smile more than men? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Research does consistently find that women smile more frequently than men in social contexts, and the most compelling explanations are social rather than biological. Women are

socialised from early childhood to use smiling as a social-affiliative behaviour — to signal agreement, warmth, and non-threat — and the social costs of violating this expectation are higher for women than for men in most cultural contexts. Men, by contrast, are socialised in many cultures toward expressions that signal competence, authority, and emotional control, for which excessive smiling may be negatively coded. These patterns are culturally variable rather than universal: in more gender-egalitarian cultural contexts, the gender difference in smiling frequency is smaller, which strongly suggests that the pattern is socially constructed rather than biologically determined.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The gender differential in smiling frequency is well-documented across cultures, though its magnitude and expression vary considerably, and the explanation is primarily social rather than innate. Women's higher smiling frequency reflects the convergence of socialisation norms that associate warmth and social attentiveness with femininity, professional contexts in which women may use smiling strategically to manage the social costs of authority and competence, and the genuinely higher social penalties that women face for emotional expressions perceived as cold or unfriendly. The organisational implication deserves attention: in professional contexts, the expectation that women should smile more frequently than men constitutes an asymmetric performance demand that imposes real costs — in terms of emotional labour and the undermining of authoritative positioning — that organisations concerned with gender equity should examine explicitly.

4. Do people smile more when they are younger or older?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The relationship between age and smiling frequency is not as straightforwardly linear as the common assumption — that children smile most and elderly people least — would suggest. Young children do smile frequently, largely because social referencing and the genuine novelty of most experiences produce regular positive affect. Adolescents and young adults typically smile less in public contexts, partly because of increased self-consciousness and the social costs of displaying vulnerability. Research on emotional experience in older adulthood, however, consistently finds that older adults report more positive affect, greater emotional regulation capacity, and a higher proportion of positive to negative emotional experiences than younger adults — a finding that suggests older people may genuinely have more reasons to smile, even if they do so less publicly.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The developmental trajectory of smiling is more complex than simple age-based intuitions suggest. Children's high smiling frequency reflects both genuine positive affect from novel experiences and a less developed understanding of the social management of emotional expression; adolescents and young adults develop more sophisticated social self-monitoring that typically reduces public emotional display. The more counterintuitive finding is from positive psychology research on ageing: older adults — particularly those who have developed what psychologists call socioemotional selectivity — focus more on meaningful relationships and present positive experience than on achieving future goals, which produces a genuine positive affect advantage over younger comparison groups. The implication is that whatever smiling expresses, it may reflect accumulated wisdom about what matters as much as simple good fortune.

5. Is smiling important in your culture?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Smiling holds an ambivalent position in Vietnamese social culture that is somewhat misunderstood by outsiders: it is simultaneously highly valued as a marker of sociability and warmth in specific interpersonal contexts, and subject to significantly more restrictive display norms in formal, professional, and public-facing contexts than smiling conventions in, for instance, American or Australian cultures. The phrase "nụ cười"—literally "the smile bud"—carries poetic and social weight in Vietnamese, and smiling at the right moment in the right relational context is a deeply valued social act. The important cultural specificity is that smiling is primarily relationship-indexed rather than ambient: it is directed at specific people in specific relational contexts rather than deployed as a general social lubricant with strangers, which is the pattern that leads outsiders to perceive Vietnamese public culture as reserved.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

In professional Vietnamese culture, smiling signals are more context-specific and more carefully managed than they are in Western professional cultures, and the underlying social logic is worth articulating clearly. Smiling at a client, a senior colleague, or a service provider in appropriate contexts signals warmth, respect, and relational attentiveness — all highly valued in Vietnamese professional norms. Smiling inappropriately — during a criticism, a formal address, or a moment of institutional gravity — signals a lack of seriousness that is negatively interpreted. The most practically important cultural competence for cross-cultural professionals working with Vietnamese counterparts is therefore not to smile more or less, but to develop the contextual sensitivity to understand when smiling expresses appropriate warmth and when it undermines one's communicative intent.

6. Are there any occasions when people need to pretend to smile?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Performative smiling — what psychologists call a "social smile" or a "Duchenne marker-absent smile" — is both extremely common and socially necessary in most cultural contexts. The occasions that most reliably require it include service interactions where genuine warmth is absent but social smoothness is necessary, formal ceremonies where group positive affect is a social requirement regardless of individual feeling, and professional contexts where displaying genuine emotion would impose costs on the displayer or discomfort on others. The ethical question this raises is not whether performative smiling is deceptive — social life would be considerably more unpleasant if everyone expressed only authentic emotion — but whether the expectation that certain people must smile more than others regardless of how they feel constitutes an unfair emotional labour requirement.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Performative smiling is an unavoidable component of professional and social life, and dismissing it as simply "fake" misses the genuine social function it serves. In service contexts — hospitality, healthcare, education, customer relations — the display of warmth through smiling is a professional skill that enables better interactions for the recipients of the service, regardless of whether the provider is genuinely feeling what they express. The concept of emotional labour, developed by sociologist Arlie Hochschild, captures the real cost of sustained performative emotional display: when required continuously over long time periods without appropriate recovery, it produces genuine psychological wear. The organisational

implication is that managing the emotional labour demands on service workers — through adequate recovery time, genuine relational support from managers, and recognition of the skill involved — is a genuine and often underattended component of workplace wellbeing.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
display rules	n phr		cultural norms about which emotions are appropriate to express	quy tắc biểu đạt cảm xúc
social artefact	n phr		an object or behaviour that carries social meaning	hiện vật/biểu hiện mang ý nghĩa xã hội
performative	adj	/pə'fɔ:.mə.trɪv/	done for social effect rather than genuine expression	mang tính trình diễn
affiliative	adj	/ə'fɪl.i.ə.trɪv/	relating to a desire for social connection and belonging	liên kết, gắn kết xã hội
socioemotional selectivity	n phr		an age-related tendency to prioritise meaningful goals and relationships	tính chọn lọc cảm xúc xã hội
emotional labour	n phr		the effort of managing one's emotions as part of a job	lao động cảm xúc
self-monitoring	n phr		the ability to regulate one's own behaviour based on social cues	tự điều chỉnh hành vi
positive affect	n phr		the experience of positive emotional states	cảm xúc tích cực
gender norms	n phr		social expectations about how men and women should behave	chuẩn mực giới
cross-cultural	adj	/ˌkrɒs.'kʌl.tʃər.əl/	involving or comparing different cultures	liên văn hóa

2.23 Describe an occasion when you were not allowed to use your mobile phone

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe an occasion when you were not allowed to use your mobile phone. You should say:

- When it was
- Where it was
- Why you were not allowed to use your mobile phone
- And how you felt about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The occasion I remember most clearly is a ten-day academic field camp I attended at the end of my second year of university, organised by the faculty of social sciences for students working on research methodology.

The camp was held at a residential centre in the mountains of Lâm Đồng, and the coordinator announced on the first evening that phones were to be surrendered each morning after breakfast and returned each evening after dinner — the rationale being that the value of the programme depended on sustained, uninterrupted attention, and that the presence of phones had historically made that impossible. I was frustrated initially and mildly resentful, which I now recognise as a more significant data point about my own phone dependency than I found comfortable at the time.

What I did not anticipate was how quickly the absence normalised. By the third day I noticed I was not missing it between sessions, and by the fifth day I found the pace of conversation, thinking, and discussion during the phone-free hours qualitatively different from anything I experienced in ordinary university life — slower, more sustained, and more genuinely responsive to what was actually being said. It remains the most intellectually productive ten-day period of my student life.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The situation I would describe is a two-day senior leadership retreat organised by my organisation's executive team, which included an explicit and enforced rule that phones were not permitted in any of the working sessions.

I was attending as a mid-level participant — invited to contribute a perspective rather than to lead — and the no-phone rule was explained in terms I found entirely convincing: senior executives are among the most distracted people in organisations precisely because they are most in demand, and the condition of genuinely strategic thinking requires the kind of sustained attention that continuous availability makes impossible. The rule was enforced not by collection but by the social norm of the room: when one person's phone appeared briefly on the table, the discomfort it produced was immediate and effective.

What I noticed most acutely was the difference in the quality of listening. Without the persistent exit option that a phone provides — the possibility of retreat into a private screen — people were present in the discussion in an unusually full way: they maintained eye contact longer, they followed arguments to their conclusions,

and they responded to what had actually been said rather than to a version of it processed through partial attention. The retreat produced more genuinely useful strategic thinking than any meeting I have attended with phones present.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
surrender	v	/sə'ren.dər/	to hand something over, especially by requirement	nộp lại, giao nộp
resentful	adj	/rɪ'zent.fəl/	feeling bitterness or indignation about something	bực bội, cảm thấy bực bội
normalise	v	/'nɔ:.mə.laɪz/	to become or make acceptable and ordinary	trở nên bình thường, quen dần
dependency	n	/dɪ'pen.dən.si/	the state of relying too much on something	sự phụ thuộc
rationale	n	/ˌræʃ.ə'nɑ:l/	the underlying reasons for a decision	cơ sở lý luận, lý do
retreat	n	/rɪ'tri:t/	a period spent away from normal work for reflection or training	kỳ rút lui/tĩnh tâm
strategic	adj	/stre'ti:.dʒɪk/	relating to careful planning for long-term goals	mang tính chiến lược
uninterrupted	adj	/ˌʌn.ɪn.tə'rʌp.tɪd/	continuing without being stopped	không bị gián đoạn
enforce	v	/ɪn'fɔ:s/	to make sure a rule is followed	thực thi (quy tắc)
sustained attention	n phr		the ability to maintain focus over a long period	sự chú ý bền vững

1. How do young and old people use mobile phones differently?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The generational divide in mobile phone use reflects both different formative relationships to the technology and different functional needs at different life stages. Young people — particularly those who grew up with smartphones — tend to use them as continuous, ambient presences that mediate social life, entertainment, identity construction, and navigation simultaneously; the phone is less a tool that is picked up for specific tasks than an environmental constant that is occasionally put down. Older adults, who typically adopted smartphones as supplementary tools added to existing communication and information habits, tend to use them more instrumentally — for specific tasks like calls, maps, and information lookup — and with greater conscious intentionality. The difference is not simply a matter of digital literacy but of whether the phone was adopted into an already-formed adult life or whether the adult life was formed in a world where the phone was already present.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The functional difference in mobile phone use across age groups reflects the different stage at which each cohort encountered the technology and the different social ecosystems it has been used to access. For young people, the smartphone is the primary infrastructure through which social relationship management, entertainment, identity expression, and information access all occur simultaneously — the boundary between “using the phone” and “living life” is genuinely permeable. For older adults, the phone remains a communication and information tool added onto social and professional lives that were already structured without it, producing a more bounded and purposive usage pattern. The professional implication of this difference — for workplace design, communication norms, and digital wellbeing policy — is that interventions calibrated to the usage patterns of one cohort will be systematically miscalibrated for the other.

2. What positive and negative impact do mobile phones have on friendship?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Mobile phones have both expanded the conditions under which friendship can be maintained and introduced new forms of friction and misunderstanding that are genuinely novel to human social life. The positive impact is primarily relational continuity: phones allow friendships to sustain across distances and time gaps that would previously have caused them to fade, and the availability of low-friction contact means that casual mutual awareness — knowing broadly what a friend is doing without a specific conversation — is now possible in ways that were not previously. The negative impacts are more varied: the availability of the phone as an alternative to present attention creates a persistent temptation toward partial presence in in-person interactions; social media dimensions of phone use introduce new forms of social comparison and status anxiety into friendship dynamics; and the asynchronous nature of text communication removes the paralinguistic cues — tone, timing, body language — that make in-person communication less prone to misinterpretation.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The relationship between mobile phone use and friendship quality is one of the most actively researched areas in contemporary social psychology, and the findings are more nuanced than either “phones destroy friendship” or “phones enhance it” captures. The clearest positive finding is that phones do help maintain geographically dispersed friendships and enable the kind of low-cost, casual contact that sustains emotional connection between people

who cannot meet frequently. The clearest negative finding concerns the cost of concurrent phone use during in-person interactions: research consistently shows that the mere presence of a phone on a table between two people reduces the depth and quality of conversation, even when neither person uses it, because both parties are aware of the option to withdraw. The relationship between phones and friendship is therefore best understood as a design problem: the question is not whether to use them in friendship but how to manage their presence and absence to preserve the quality of attention that friendship requires.

3. Is it a waste of time to take pictures with mobile phones?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The claim that mobile photography is a waste of time reflects a particular view of photography as either a high-art practice or a purely instrumental memory-recording function — and on both grounds, casual phone photography falls short. But this framing dismisses the genuine social function that mobile photography serves in contemporary life, which is not primarily archival or artistic but communicative: photos taken on phones are typically shared immediately, used as conversation starters, and experienced as a form of social participation rather than documentation. The more substantive concern is not that phone photography wastes time but that the orientation toward capturing an experience can substitute for living it — the habit of photographing a meal, a view, or an event rather than attending to it directly does carry a real experiential cost that the social benefits do not always compensate for.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether mobile photography is a waste of time is best approached as a question about what the activity is actually for, which varies considerably across individuals and contexts. At its best, phone photography is a form of attentive looking — noticing what is worth recording, which is a perceptual practice with real value — and a communicative tool that enables the sharing of experience across social networks in ways that sustain connection. At its worst, it is an anxiety-driven performance of experience rather than actual experience: photographing something as a substitute for genuine engagement with it, or as a social positioning gesture rather than an act of genuine attention. The productive question for individuals is not whether to photograph at all but whether their photograph-taking is preceded by genuine attention to the thing being photographed or is itself the mechanism that forecloses that attention.

4. Do you think it is necessary to have laws on the use of mobile phones?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Legal regulation of mobile phone use is clearly justified in the contexts where it already exists — primarily driving, where the evidence on phone-related impairment of driving performance is unambiguous and the risk is borne by third parties — and considerably more contested in other contexts. The case for regulation rests on the well-documented externalities of certain phone use patterns: distracted driving is the clearest case, but the public health effects of sustained social media use on adolescent mental health, and the effects of phone-based distraction in certain professional settings, are emerging as additional areas where voluntary individual behaviour consistently fails to produce socially optimal outcomes. The strongest objection to broader regulation is its difficulty of enforcement and

the risk of producing surveillance infrastructure — the mechanisms required to enforce phone use restrictions — that creates greater harms than the phone use it aims to regulate.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The policy case for mobile phone regulation is most clearly established in contexts where the harm of phone use is borne by people other than the user — driving being the paradigm case — and less clear in contexts where the harms are primarily to the user themselves, where paternalism concerns are more weighty. The emerging debate about age restrictions on social media access and smartphone ownership for children reflects a substantive policy question about the appropriate scope of protective regulation: there is growing evidence that unrestricted early smartphone access produces measurable mental health harms in adolescents, and the question of whether parents alone can be trusted to manage this risk is a genuine and important one. The most defensible regulatory approach is targeted and evidence-based: focus regulation on uses where external harm is clear and significant, provide robust public education and institutional support for contexts where harm is primarily to the user, and build the evidentiary basis for broader regulation carefully rather than reactively.

5. What are examples of good and poor phone manners?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Good phone manners are fundamentally a subset of good social manners: they require being aware of how one's phone use affects others and treating that effect as a moral consideration rather than an inconvenience. The clearest examples of good manner are contextual: silencing or storing the phone when in a meeting, a meaningful conversation, or a social occasion; responding to messages at appropriate times rather than mid-conversation; and asking permission before photographing or sharing images of others. Poor manners are the inverse: answering calls or checking notifications during conversations without acknowledgement; using a phone in contexts — funerals, medical consultations, classroom instruction, intimate meals — where the implied disrespect is clear; and using speakerphone in shared public spaces without regard for others.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The norms of phone etiquette in professional contexts are becoming more explicitly codified as organisations respond to the effects of ubiquitous phone presence on meeting quality and professional relationships. In professional settings, the clearest markers of good phone manners are: placing the phone face-down or out of sight during meetings and conversations, notifying others if you must take an urgent call in advance and apologising briefly when you do, and matching your phone use expectations to those of the most senior person in the room unless explicit norms have been established otherwise. Poor manners in professional contexts — checking phones during presentations, texting visibly during conversations, using phones in a way that signals that the current interaction is less important than the phone — are damaging not only to the immediate interaction but to the professional's reputation for attentiveness and respect. The most productive organisational approach is to establish explicit meeting phone norms rather than relying on implicit professional socialisation that produces uneven outcomes.

6. How does the internet benefit people?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The benefits of internet access are so broadly distributed across domains of human activity that cataloguing them risks both understatement and a kind of completeness that obscures what is most important. The most transformative benefits are in information access — the internet has removed geographic and economic barriers to knowledge that previously confined high-quality education and professional information to those with access to specialist libraries and universities — and in communication, where it has made possible forms of social connection across distance that were previously either impossible or prohibitively expensive. The second-order benefit that is perhaps most significant for long-term human welfare is the democratisation of production and publication: the internet allows individuals and small organisations to communicate, create, and distribute content without requiring the institutional gatekeepers that controlled these functions in all prior media systems.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The economic and social benefits of internet access are among the most robustly evidenced development findings of the past two decades: access to reliable, affordable internet is correlated with gains in educational attainment, income, health outcomes, and civic participation across a wide range of country and demographic contexts. The mechanism operates through multiple channels simultaneously — access to information, access to markets, access to financial services, access to social and professional networks — all of which compound in ways that make internet access among the highest-return public infrastructure investments available to governments. The distributional dimension deserves equal attention: the benefits of internet access are not evenly distributed, and the gap between those with high-quality, affordable, reliable access and those with restricted, expensive, or no access represents one of the most significant and fastest-growing dimensions of contemporary inequality.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
ambient	adj	/ˈæm.bi.ənt/	present and surrounding in an environment, often unnoticed	xung quanh, hiện diện khắp nơi
paralinguistic	adj	/ˌpær.ə.lɪŋˈɡwɪs.tɪk/	relating to vocal and non-verbal cues that accompany speech	cận ngôn ngữ
instrumentally	adv	/ɪnˈstrʌ.men.tə.li/	used as a means to an end	mang tính công cụ
paternalism	n	/pəˈtɜː.nəl.ɪ.zəm/	restricting someone's freedom for their own good	chủ nghĩa bảo hộ (can thiệp vì lợi ích người khác)
externality	n	/ˌek.stəˈnæl.ɪ.ti/	a cost or benefit that affects a third party	ngoại ứng (tác động ngoài)
gatekeeping	n	/ˈɡeɪt.kiː.pɪŋ/	controlling access to information or resources	kiểm soát quyền truy cập
etiquette	n	/ˈet.ɪ.kɪt/	the customary code of polite behaviour	lễ nghi, phép lịch sự
democratisation	n	/dɪˌmɒk.rə.tarˈzeɪ.ʃən/	making something accessible to all	dân chủ hóa
infrastructural	adj	/ˌɪn.frəˈstrʌk.tʃər.əl/	relating to the basic systems and services	thuộc cơ sở hạ tầng
cognitive impairment	n phr		a reduction in mental abilities such as attention or memory	suy giảm nhận thức

2.24 Describe a time when you encouraged someone to do something that he/she didn't want to do

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a time when you encouraged someone to do something that he/she didn't want to do. You should say:

- Who he or she is
- What you encouraged him/her to do
- How he/she reacted
- And explain why you encouraged him/her to do it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I encouraged was my closest friend at university, Hoàng, who is by temperament thoughtful and reserved and had been working on a research essay for our academic writing course that I genuinely believed was the best thing either of us had produced that semester.

The essay examined the social effects of rapid urban development on traditional neighbourhood networks in Hanoi, and it drew on both original fieldwork and secondary sources in a way that I found intellectually serious and original. When Hoàng said he was going to submit it without entering it in the faculty essay competition — on the grounds that he "didn't think it was ready" and didn't want the attention — I pushed back, not aggressively but persistently over three conversations, and eventually persuaded him to submit it.

He won the competition. His reaction when he was announced as the winner was characteristically understated — a quiet "I suppose you were right" — but what I found more interesting than the outcome was the process: his reluctance was not really about the essay's quality, which I think he knew was strong, but about the discomfort of being visible and evaluated. Encouraging him was less a matter of persuading him about the work than of helping him distinguish between a well-founded concern about quality and an unfounded concern about exposure.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The occasion that comes to mind involved a more senior colleague — I will call her Dr. Ngọc — who had been working on an academic paper for three years and had not submitted it for publication because she considered it "not yet finished."

I had read a draft of the paper at her request and found it to be well-argued, grounded in strong evidence, and significantly more complete than she appeared to believe. Over several conversations, I raised the point — carefully, because she is senior to me and this required some navigational care — that the paper reflected a standard of completion that was well above the publication threshold for the journal she was targeting, and that continued revision without submission was not improving it in the ways she had identified but was reducing her confidence in it through overexposure. Her initial reaction was defensive: she had specific concerns about two sections that she considered inadequately developed.

We agreed that she would share those sections with a trusted methodologist colleague,

who confirmed that neither concern was substantive. She submitted the paper the following month, it was accepted with minor revisions, and she told me afterwards that the most useful thing I had done was not provide reassurance about the work but name the dynamic clearly — that the obstacle was not the paper but the accumulated anxiety of having worked on it for too long. That is the kind of encouragement I think is genuinely useful: not cheerleading, but diagnostic honesty delivered with care.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
temperament	n	/ˈtem.prə.mənt/	a person's natural way of thinking, behaving, or reacting	tính khí, khí chất
persistent	adj	/pəˈsɪs.tənt/	continuing firmly in a course of action despite difficulty	kiên trì
understated	adj	/ˌʌn.dəˈsteɪ.tɪd/	expressed or described with less emphasis than expected	kiệm lời, không phô trương
diagnostic honesty	n phr		the act of clearly naming what the real problem is	sự thành thật mang tính chẩn đoán
exposure	n	/ɪkˈspəʊ.ʒər/	the state of being publicly visible or evaluated	sự phơi bày, công khai
threshold	n	/ˈθreʃ.həʊld/	the level at which something begins or is considered sufficient	ngưỡng
overexposure	n	/əʊ.vər.ɪkˈspəʊ.ʒər/	excessive familiarity with something causing reduced perspective	tiếp xúc quá mức
methodologist	n	/ˌmeθ.əˈdɒl.ə.dʒɪst/	an expert in research methods	chuyên gia về phương pháp nghiên cứu
reassurance	n	/ˌriː.əˈʃʊər.əns/	the act of removing doubts and fears	sự trấn an, củng cố niềm tin
navigational care	n phr		tactful management of a sensitive social situation	sự khéo léo trong giao tiếp

1. How can leaders encourage their employees?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Effective leadership encouragement operates primarily through two mechanisms that are more distinct than they might appear: providing genuine recognition of specific contributions, and creating conditions in which the work itself is inherently motivating. The first mechanism — recognition — is most powerful when it is specific, timely, and accurate: a leader who notices and names precisely what an employee did well, and articulates why it mattered, produces a much more durable motivational effect than one who offers generic praise. The second mechanism — work design — is arguably more important for sustained motivation: employees who have appropriate autonomy, clear and meaningful goals, and sufficient challenge consistently report higher engagement than those who have the same level of recognition but in work that is tediously designed. The most effective leaders attend to both, recognising that recognition without meaningful work produces hollow compliance, while meaningful work without recognition produces unnecessary attrition.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Leadership encouragement in professional contexts is most effective when it operates on the level of developing employees' self-efficacy — their belief in their own capacity to succeed — rather than simply generating positive affect. Specific, evidence-based feedback that identifies what an employee did well and connects it to their underlying capabilities ("you did this because you have the capacity to...") produces more durable motivational outcomes than generalised praise. Leaders who give employees progressively more challenging work accompanied by genuine support — which means providing resources, removing obstacles, and maintaining confidence when employees doubt themselves — build the kind of self-belief that is far more resilient than mood-based encouragement. The critical leadership skill is calibration: encouragement that consistently outpaces actual performance produces overconfidence; encouragement calibrated just above current capability produces genuine development.

2. When should parents encourage their children?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Parental encouragement is most developmentally beneficial when it is timed to moments of genuine difficulty rather than routine success — that is, when a child is facing something that genuinely stretches their current capacity and needs support to sustain their effort rather than to be reassured that everything is fine. Encouragement at moments of easy success can inadvertently communicate that the child needs external validation even for things they are clearly capable of. Conversely, encouragement that "difficulty is temporary and effort is worthwhile" at moments of genuine struggle communicates something important about the nature of learning that children who are only ever encouraged during success do not develop as a stable belief. The timing principle is therefore: encourage effort at the point of resistance, and acknowledge achievement more quietly and specifically than many parents do.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The research on effective parental encouragement suggests that the question is not only "when" but "in what form": the most developmentally beneficial encouragement is process-oriented (directed at effort, strategy, and persistence) rather than outcome-oriented (directed at achievement or ability). Process encouragement is most useful at moments of difficulty — when a child is struggling with something and is at risk of giving up or concluding that they

lack the capacity to succeed. Outcome-oriented praise at moments of success is significantly less developmentally useful than it feels: it reinforces the idea that the child's value lies in what they produce rather than in what they do, which is a motivational orientation that is fragile under conditions of failure. Parents who develop the habit of directing their most enthusiastic encouragement toward the effort a child makes in a difficult moment — rather than toward the result — tend to produce children with significantly more resilient motivational orientations.

3. What kind of encouragement should parents give?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The most effective kind of encouragement parents can give is specific, honest, and grounded in observation rather than general positivity. Telling a child "you worked really hard on that and found a way through it" produces a more useful self-belief than "you're so smart"—because the former draws the child's attention to something they can control (effort and strategy) while the latter attributes success to a fixed quality they either have or lack. Encouragement that is truthful — that acknowledges difficulty honestly rather than minimising it — is more motivationally effective than encouragement that is simply warm: a child knows when something was hard, and being told "that was hard and you did it anyway" is more meaningful than being told "that was easy, you're great." The emotional quality of encouragement matters too: warmth and genuine enthusiasm are important, but they work best when they are grounded in something specific rather than generic.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The parenting research on encouragement distinguishes consistently between encouragement that develops durable intrinsic motivation and encouragement that produces only short-term compliance or mood improvement. The most effective encouragement is characterised by specificity (it refers to what the child actually did), accuracy (it reflects genuine assessment rather than indiscriminate positivity), and developmental orientation (it draws the child's attention to processes — effort, strategy, persistence — rather than to fixed outcomes or abilities). Parents who provide "autonomy-supportive" encouragement — which acknowledges difficulty, expresses confidence in the child's capacity to manage it, and leaves the decision to continue ultimately with the child — consistently produce children with stronger intrinsic motivation, higher resilience, and better developed emotional regulation than those who use predominantly directive or reward-based encouragement.

4. Do you think some people are better than others at persuading?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Persuasive ability is genuinely variable across individuals, and the variation reflects the distribution of a cluster of capacities — rather than any single trait — that can develop with conscious practice. The most consistently effective persuaders share a common orientation: they are genuinely curious about the perspective they are trying to shift, which allows them to address the actual reasons for resistance rather than the stated ones, and they are patient enough to build trust before attempting persuasion. The capacity to identify the distinction between a well-founded objection and an unfounded one — and to address the former with evidence while giving space for the latter — is the core persuasive skill that most distinguishes effective from ineffective persuaders. The encouraging finding from

persuasion research is that this capacity is substantially learnable: most ineffective persuaders are ineffective because they focus on their own argument rather than on the other person's perspective, and redirecting that focus is a learnable practice.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Individual variation in persuasive effectiveness is real and practically significant, and the mechanisms underlying it are reasonably well understood in social and organisational psychology. Effective persuaders are characterised by a combination of social intelligence — the ability to understand what the other person actually values and fears — narrative competence, the capacity to construct propositions in a form that is comprehensible and resonant for the specific audience, and what might be called persuasive integrity: the willingness to acknowledge the limits of one's own position rather than overselling it, which paradoxically increases the listener's confidence in what is being claimed. The implication for organisations is that persuasive skill is a professional competency that can be assessed, developed, and deployed — it is not a mysterious individual gift but a teachable practice with identifiable components.

5. Should children do everything their parents ask them to do?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether children should comply with all parental requests depends crucially on distinguishing between compliance as an unconditional norm and as a developmental default that gradually transfers authority to the child. Unconditional compliance — the expectation that children should do whatever parents ask because of the parental role — is neither developmentally desirable nor practically defensible: it produces children who have not developed the capacity to evaluate requests on their merits, which leaves them more vulnerable to authority from any source rather than specifically developing the moral agency that is the longer-term goal. The developmentally appropriate position is a graduated one: young children need clear parental authority and should generally comply, with the rationale explained; older children and adolescents should progressively develop the capacity to engage with parental requests critically, and parents should progressively treat their reasoning as worth engaging with. This is more difficult than either unconditional compliance or unconditional autonomy, but it is the only model that actually produces well-functioning adults.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The cultural and developmental arguments for parental authority are real and should be taken seriously, but the conclusion that children should comply with all parental requests conflates necessary authority with desirable compliance at a level that does not serve children's long-term development. Children who are raised with unconditional compliance expectations consistently show lower autonomous decision-making capacity, lower resilience under authority from non-parental sources, and — perhaps most importantly — a weaker sense of their own moral agency than those raised in environments that combine appropriate authority with genuine engagement with the child's reasons and objections. The more useful framing for parents is not "should my child comply?" but "am I building the capacity for my child to make good independent judgements?" — a question that requires that children's objections be engaged with as informative rather than simply as resistance to be overcome.

6. How can employers encourage their staff?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The most effective employer encouragement operates through work design as much as through direct motivational intervention — creating conditions in which the work is intrinsically motivating reduces the amount of external encouragement needed and produces more durable engagement. The specific design dimensions that consistently predict employee motivation are autonomy over how work is done, task significance (an understanding of why the work matters), feedback that is timely and specific, and sufficient challenge that work requires genuine engagement rather than routine execution. Direct encouragement — through recognition, specific positive feedback, and expressed confidence in capacity — is most effective when it is embedded in this kind of motivating work environment: encouragement in a poorly-designed job is a palliative that never fully compensates for its demotivating structural features.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Employer encouragement in organisational contexts is best understood through the lens of self-determination theory, which identifies three basic psychological needs whose satisfaction predicts sustainable work motivation: autonomy, competence, and relatedness. Employers who create environments that genuinely support employee autonomy — giving real discretion over how goals are achieved rather than purely nominal independence — produce higher motivation, better performance, and lower attrition than those who use reward systems as a substitute for genuine autonomy. Competence support — through meaningful feedback, developmental challenge, and management that removes rather than creates obstacles to effective work — produces the sense of growing capability that is the most motivationally sustaining condition for professional employees. The practical implication for managers is that the question "how can I encourage my staff?" should be preceded by "are the structural conditions of the work actively discouraging them?" — because encouragement applied on top of structural demotivators produces diminishing returns.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
self-efficacy	n	/ˌself.ˈef.ɪ.kə.si/	a person's belief in their own ability to succeed	tự tin vào năng lực bản thân
autonomy-supportive	adj phr		an environment that nurtures independent decision-making	hỗ trợ tính tự chủ
intrinsic motivation	n phr	/ɪnˈtrɪn.zɪk/	drive that comes from within rather than external rewards	động lực nội tại
attrition	n	/əˈtrɪʃ.ən/	gradual reduction in staff through resignation, not dismissal	hao hụt nhân sự tự nhiên
self-determination theory	n phr		a psychological framework that explains motivation through autonomy, competence, and relatedness	lý thuyết tự quyết
moral agency	n phr		the capacity to make independent ethical decisions	năng lực hành đạo đức
calibration	n	/ˌkæl.ɪˈbreɪ.ʃən/	the process of adjusting something to the right level	hiệu chuẩn, điều chỉnh đúng mức
palliative	adj	/ˈpæl.i.ə.tɪv/	relieving symptoms without solving the root cause	xoa dịu tạm thời, không trị tận gốc
relatedness	n	/rɪˈleɪ.tɪd.nəs/	the sense of meaningful connection to others	cảm giác được kết nối với người khác
graduate	v	/ˈgrædʒ.u.ət/	to move or progress through a staged process	tiến dần qua từng giai đoạn

2.25 Describe something important that has been kept in your family for a long time

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe something important that has been kept in your family for a long time. You should say:

- What it is
- When your family had it
- How your family got it
- And explain why it is important to your family.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The object I would describe is a small ceramic tea set that has been in my family for four generations — probably since the early twentieth century, though no one in the family is entirely certain of its exact origin.

The set consists of a teapot, six cups, and a tray, all in a deep celadon glaze with a very fine crackle pattern that one of my grandmothers told me is characteristic of a particular kiln tradition from the north. My great-grandmother apparently received it as part of her household when she married, which was the conventional form of property transfer for women in that period, and it has passed through each generation of women in my family since then. It is not financially valuable by any standard that matters, and no one has ever had it appraised.

What makes it important is the practice it has sustained: it is the set used for tea during specific family occasions — Tết visits, family announcements, and significant conversations — which means it carries an associative weight that no other object in our household approximates. Using it is an act that places you in a line of people who have used it for the same purpose, across circumstances that include both extraordinary joy and significant difficulty, and that sense of temporal connection is something I find genuinely more moving than any financial valuation could express.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The object I think of most naturally when asked this question is a journal kept by my paternal grandfather during the years 1965 to 1972 — a period that encompasses some of the most consequential events in Vietnamese twentieth-century history — written in a small, densely packed hand across what turned out to be eleven notebooks.

My grandfather was a secondary school teacher in a provincial town in what was then North Vietnam, and the journals record the daily texture of civilian life during the American War: the organisation of community air raid shelters, the evacuation of students, the management of a school that continued operating despite repeated bombing damage, and — most extensively — his observations on the moral and social quality of life under sustained collective threat. They are remarkably unsentimental, written with the precision and analytical detachment of someone who appears to have understood, even at the time, that their historical interest would outlast their personal significance.

My family knew the journals existed but almost no one had read them until I, at

twenty-five, asked to borrow them and read them in full. The experience of reading them significantly altered my understanding of both my grandfather and the historical period, and they represent — for me and increasingly for other family members who have since read them — the most direct available line to a period that all of us know about but none of us lived. That is the function they serve: not as heirlooms in the decorative sense, but as a form of transmitted testimony that makes the past genuinely present rather than merely historical.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
celadon	n	/ˈsel.ə.dən/	a pale grey-green ceramic glaze originating in East Asia	men sứ xanh ngọc celadon
crackle pattern	n phr		a decorative texture of fine cracks in ceramic glaze	hoa văn nứt tế vi trên men gốm
appraise	v	/əˈpreɪz/	to assess the monetary value of something	định giá, thẩm định
testimony	n	/ˈtes.tɪ.mə.ni/	a firsthand account of events or experiences	chứng nhân, lời chứng
associative weight	n phr		the emotional significance an object gains through shared memory	trọng lượng liên tưởng
consequential	adj	/ˌkɒn.sɪˈkwɛn.ʃəl/	having significant impact or importance	quan trọng, có hệ quả lớn
transmitted	adj	/ˈtrænsˈmɪ.tɪd/	passed from one person or generation to another	được truyền lại
heirloom	n	/ˈeə.lu:m/	a valuable object passed down through generations	di vật gia truyền
temporal	adj	/ˈtem.pər.əl/	relating to time	thuộc về thời gian
detachment	n	/dɪˈtætʃ.mənt/	emotional distance when observing or describing events	sự khách quan, tách biệt cảm xúc

1. What things do families keep for a long time?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Families tend to keep objects that serve as anchors of collective memory and identity rather than those with the highest financial value — a distinction that is sometimes misunderstood when the question is framed purely economically. The most commonly preserved objects are those that were used at ritually significant moments: tableware associated with family ceremonies, clothing worn at significant occasions, photographs, written correspondence, and tools associated with the particular form of work that defined a family's livelihood or identity. The common thread is that these objects function as materialised memory: they are kept not for use but because discarding them would feel like discarding a portion of the family's shared past, which carries a psychological cost that most families intuitively recognise even if they cannot articulate it clearly.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The objects that families preserve across generations tend to cluster around two categories: objects associated with significant life transitions and objects that embody the labour, skill, or sacrifice of ancestors. The first category — wedding jewellery, ceremonial garments, objects given at births or deaths — carries significance because it marks moments when the family's continuity was enacted or affirmed; the second carries significance because it represents a connection to a form of human effort or achievement that the current generation wishes to honour. The interesting sociological observation is that what families choose to preserve is also culturally variable: Vietnamese families are more likely to preserve objects associated with ancestors and religious practice; Western families more likely to preserve objects tied to personal achievement and individual identity — a difference that reflects deeper divergences in the cultural construction of what the family itself is for.

2. What's the difference between things valued by people in the past and today?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The most significant shift in what people value in objects has been from durability and functional craftsmanship toward novelty, experience, and experiential symbolism. Objects in earlier generations were valued, preserved, and repaired because production costs were high relative to income and because the skill embedded in a well-made object was visible and legible to its owners in a way that mass-produced objects cannot replicate. Contemporary consumer culture values novelty, brand association, and the experiential or social meaning that objects carry — the signal they send about the owner's values and identity — more than the intrinsic quality of the object itself. The consequence is a dramatically shorter object lifespan and a dramatically reduced tendency to preserve and repair, which has both environmental costs and a less obvious cultural cost: the loss of the forms of accumulated domestic knowledge that sustained repair and reuse required.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The shift in object valuation between generations reflects genuine structural changes in the economics of production and the sociology of consumption rather than simply a change in moral character. In agricultural and early industrial economies, objects of high craftsmanship represented significant accumulations of time and skill that made their preservation economically rational alongside its sentimental appeal — a good piece of furniture or a well-made tool was expensive relative to income and worth repairing many times over. Contemporary economies

of mass production and planned obsolescence have inverted this: objects are cheap relative to income, repair is often more expensive than replacement, and the meaning of consumption has shifted from long-term stewardship to short-cycle identity expression. The environmental implications of this shift are severe and increasingly visible, which is producing a significant policy conversation about how to redesign the economics of objects to make durability and repairability rationally attractive rather than economically irrational.

3. What kinds of things are kept in museums?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Museums preserve objects, documents, and artefacts that represent what a society has collectively decided merits preservation and public access — a selection process that is far less neutral than the institutional authority of the museum setting suggests. The conventional categories are broad: art, historical artefacts, natural specimens, scientific instruments, ethnographic objects, and archival documents. But which specific items within these categories are preserved and which are not is always a function of who controls the collecting institution, what society considers culturally significant, and whose history is treated as worth documenting — determinants that have historically favoured the cultures, genders, and classes with most institutional power, producing collection biases that contemporary museum practice is slowly and incompletely addressing.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The collecting scope of museums reflects both a civilisational aspiration — the idea that certain forms of human achievement and natural history are worth preserving and sharing across time — and a set of historical contingencies, power dynamics, and curatorial choices that have produced collections whose composition is never fully representative of human cultural diversity. The most contested dimension of contemporary museum practice is the question of colonial collections: objects removed from their cultures of origin during periods of colonial extraction that now reside in major Western institutions under contested ownership. The legitimate arguments on both sides of this debate — preservation capacity and access versus cultural sovereignty and community connection — reflect genuinely different frameworks for understanding what museums are for, and the resolution will require institutional redesign rather than simply the return or retention of specific objects.

4. What's the influence of technology on museums?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Technology has transformed museums both operationally and in terms of how collections are experienced, and the effects are substantially positive when managed thoughtfully. Digitisation has made collections accessible to audiences who cannot physically visit the institution — a significant equity gain for communities distant from major museum cities — and has enabled forms of scholarly access to collection data that were impossible in the era of physical-only access. Interactive and immersive technologies — augmented reality, virtual reconstruction, haptic interfaces — have created new possibilities for visitor engagement, particularly for historical objects whose original context is inaccessible. The significant risk is that technology becomes a substitute for the quality of curation and object selection rather than a complement to it: a poorly curated collection displayed with impressive technology remains a poorly curated collection.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The technological transformation of museums has proceeded across three distinct dimensions simultaneously: access (digitisation making collections globally available), experience (interactive technologies reshaping the visitor encounter with objects), and operations (data management, preventive conservation, and audience analytics). The access dimension is arguably the most democratically significant: high-resolution digital archives of major collection objects, available freely online, have fundamentally changed the researcher's ability to study collection items without physical travel, reducing one of the sharpest historical inequalities in cultural access. The experience dimension produces the most visible public debate: the question of whether immersive, interactive museum environments enhance or diminish engagement with primary objects is genuine and the evidence is mixed. The most intellectually defensible position is that technology should serve curation rather than replace it, amplifying the encounter with significant objects rather than providing an alternative to it.

5. What are the benefits of technology for learning history?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Technology has substantially expanded both the accessibility and the modality of historical learning in ways that are genuinely democratising rather than merely convenient. The primary benefit is access: digitised archives, newspapers, maps, and records that were previously accessible only to researchers with institutional affiliations and travel budgets are now available to anyone with an internet connection, which has meaningfully expanded who can engage seriously with primary historical sources. Visualisation technologies — geographical information systems, three-dimensional reconstructions of historical environments, animated timelines — have made the spatial and temporal dimensions of historical events more intuitively comprehensible for learners who struggle with traditional text-based historical presentation. The risk is that the abundance of accessible historical content without adequate interpretive frameworks produces confident misinformation rather than enhanced understanding — which is why technological access to historical sources is most beneficial when accompanied by genuine historical reasoning instruction.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The benefits of technology for historical learning are most evident in three areas: source access, interpretive visualisation, and community connection to localised histories. Source access improvements are the most structurally significant: the digitisation and open publication of archival collections has made primary historical research accessible in ways that dramatically reduce the socioeconomic barriers that previously confined serious historical engagement to those affiliated with well-resourced universities. The community history dimension is particularly interesting: digital tools have enabled communities to document, archive, and share local historical knowledge that would not otherwise be preserved in institutional collections, producing a significant democratisation of historical documentation alongside the better-resourced institutional efforts. The significant caveat is that technology is no substitute for historical thinking — for the capacity to evaluate evidence, identify perspective and bias, and construct reasoned interpretations — and educational approaches that provide digital access without developing these capacities produce technologically equipped but historically illiterate learners.

6. Why do people visit museums?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

People visit museums for a highly varied set of reasons that coexist and are not always conscious, including cultural self-improvement, leisure, social experience, and the specific form of encounter with primary objects that no digital reproduction substitutes for. The distinction between museum visiting as an educational activity and as a leisure one is less sharp than institutions often imply: research on visitor motivations consistently finds that the most satisfying museum experiences are those that combine intellectual engagement with social experience and aesthetic pleasure — the encounter with a remarkable object, shared with someone who cares about it, in a setting that does it justice. The specific draw of the original object — the experience of being in the presence of something that was made by or used by specific people in specific historical circumstances — is one that digital access cannot replicate and that represents the museum's most irreplaceable function.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The motivational landscape of museum visiting is more varied and more contextually specific than the institution's educational mission framing suggests. Research on museum visitor experience consistently identifies five primary motivational clusters: intellectual curiosity, social experience, entertainment, identity connection (visiting museums associated with one's own cultural heritage), and professional or scholarly purpose. The distribution across these motivations varies significantly by museum type, visitor demographic, and cultural context: history and national museums attract stronger identity-connection motivations; art museums attract stronger aesthetic and social motivations; science museums attract stronger curiosity and educational motivations for family groups. The implication for museum programming is that a single mission statement and programming approach is unlikely to serve all five motivational clusters effectively, and institutions that develop distinct programming streams for different visitor orientations tend to produce better visitor experience outcomes than those that design for a single imagined universal visitor.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
digitisation	n	/ˌdɪdʒ.ɪ.taɪ'zeɪ.ʃən/	the process of converting information into digital form	số hóa
curatorial	adj	/ˌkjʊə.ə'tɔɪ.ri.əl/	relating to the work of organising a museum or exhibition	thuộc về curation (quản lý bộ sưu tập)
artefact	n	/'ɑː.tɪ.fækt/	an object made by humans, especially one of historical interest	hiện vật
colonial extraction	n phr		the removal of cultural objects from colonised lands	khai thác thuộc địa (văn hoá)
planned obsolescence	n phr		designing products with a limited useful life to encourage replacement	lỗi thời có kế hoạch
stewardship	n	/'stjuː.əd.ʃɪp/	the responsible management of something entrusted to one's care	sự quản lý có trách nhiệm
haptic	adj	/'hæp.tɪk/	relating to the sense of touch in technology interfaces	xúc giác (trong công nghệ)
equity	n	/'ek.wɪ.ti/	fairness and equal access to opportunities	công bằng, bình đẳng
interpretive	adj	/ɪn'tɜː.pri.tɪv/	relating to explaining or understanding the meaning of something	mang tính diễn giải
primary source	n phr		original documents or artefacts from the time period under study	tài liệu gốc, nguồn sơ cấp

2.26 Describe a time you needed to use your imagination

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a time you needed to use your imagination. You should say:

- When it was
- Why you needed to use imagination
- How difficult or easy it was
- And explain how you felt about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The occasion I think of most readily is a group project in my second year at university — a social science course requirement in which each group had to design a public awareness campaign on a topic of our choosing, with no template and no predetermined format.

My group chose the topic of noise pollution in urban residential areas — which sounds specific enough to be manageable but turned out to be genuinely difficult to make visually and emotionally compelling since the subject is invisible. We had to construct a campaign that made an abstract, persistent, and ordinarily unremarked harm visible and persuasive to people who had never consciously noticed it as a problem. That required imagining the audience's perceptual world first — what it would take to make someone notice something they had always been present for but never attended to — and working backward from that into the campaign design.

The process was harder than anything I had done in a standard academic format precisely because there was no established procedure to follow: the constraint of the blank canvas produced a specific kind of cognitive discomfort that took me several days to recognise as productive rather than as evidence of failure. The final campaign included sound mapping, ambient audio installations planned for a university common area, and a simple visual infographic. It was the project I thought about longest after the course ended.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The moment I most associate with necessary imaginative effort in professional life was a strategic planning exercise I facilitated about three years ago, in which a team I was working with had to develop a five-year organisational vision for a context that was changing sufficiently rapidly that standard extrapolation from past performance was demonstrably inadequate.

The problem was well-defined but methodologically unprecedented for most of the team: how do you plan purposefully when your confident assumptions about the environment are invalidated every six to eight months? Facilitating a genuine answer to this question required designing a process that moved the team from their habitual forecasting mode — which involved projecting recent trends forward — into a genuinely exploratory one, in which multiple highly divergent futures were constructed, inhabited imaginatively, and used as the basis for identifying what was robust across them rather than what would be optimal in any single one.

This kind of scenario-based strategic imagination is genuinely demanding because it requires suspending the comfort of confident prediction in favour of something more

honest: a deliberate encounter with uncertainty, followed by structured reasoning about what you can control regardless of which future arrives. I found it both intellectually difficult and deeply rewarding, and the exercise produced a substantially more resilient strategic framework than the team had started with.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
scenario planning	n phr		a strategic method using multiple imagined futures to prepare robust plans	lập kế hoạch dựa trên kịch bản
extrapolation	n	/ɪkˌstræp.əˈleɪ.ʃən/	extending known data into unknown territory	ngoại suy
ambient	adj	/'æm.bi.ənt/	relating to the surrounding environment or atmosphere	xung quanh, bầu không khí
perceptual	adj	/pə'sep.tʃu.əl/	relating to the ability to interpret sensory experience	thuộc tri giác
divergent	adj	/daɪˈvɜː.dʒənt/	developing in different directions; not converging	phân kỳ, khác nhau
robust	adj	/rəʊˈbʌst/	strong and effective across a range of conditions	bền vững, có khả năng chống chịu
exploratory	adj	/ɪkˈsplɒr.ə.tər.i/	intended to investigate rather than to confirm	mang tính khám phá
cognitive discomfort	n phr		the mental unease produced by uncertainty or contradiction	sự khó chịu nhận thức
compelling	adj	/kəmˈpel.ɪŋ/	convincing and powerfully persuasive	thuyết phục, hấp dẫn
suspend	v	/səˈspend/	to temporarily set aside or delay	tạm gác lại

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Do you think adults can have lots of imagination?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The common assumption that imagination is primarily a childhood capacity that declines with age is empirically incomplete and probably reflects a confusion between two different things: the frequency of spontaneous, playful imaginative activity, which does decline across the lifespan in most people, and the capacity for imaginative reasoning, which does not decline and may actually develop. Adults who maintain curious, open, and exploratory relationships with their fields of work and interest show no measurable decline in imaginative capacity; it is rather the social permission and structural conditions that support spontaneous imaginative play that narrow for adults rather than the underlying capacity. The most imaginative adults are typically those who have either maintained a child-like relationship to exploration in their professional practice, or who have actively cultivated their imaginative capacity through creative, analytical, or artistic engagement throughout their adult lives.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Adult imaginative capacity is one of the most misunderstood psychological constructs in popular discourse about creativity. The evidence from creativity research is clear that divergent thinking — the generation of multiple, varied possibilities from a single prompt, which is the most commonly used index of imaginative capacity — is present in adults across the full lifespan, though it is expressed differently in adult contexts than in children's. Adults' imaginative capacity is typically more domain-specific and more constrained by accumulated expertise, which produces a paradox: deep knowledge can both enable more sophisticated imagination within a domain and narrow spontaneous exploration across domains. The practical implication is that maintaining imaginative capacity as an adult requires deliberate effort to create conditions of genuine exploration — contexts in which the social norms and cognitive habits of expertise are temporarily suspended.

2. Do you think imagination is essential for scientists?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Imagination is essential to science at the level of hypothesis generation, which is the creative core of the scientific enterprise, even though science's public image tends to emphasise the analytical and verificational phases of scientific work rather than the imaginative ones. The generation of a testable hypothesis requires imagining a world in which a specific causal relationship holds — which is a genuinely imaginative act that precedes any empirical test and which determines what the empirical test can discover. Many of the most significant scientific advances in history — Einstein's thought experiments, Darwin's conceptualisation of natural selection, Watson and Crick's double helix model — were products of sustained imaginative reasoning rather than of direct empirical observation. The relationship between imagination and rigour in science is not a tension but a sequence: imagination proposes, and rigour tests.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The essential role of imagination in science is one of the most important things that popular scientific education consistently underemphasises in favour of the verification and application phases of scientific practice. The phases of science that require imagination —

generating novel hypotheses, designing experiments in genuinely new ways, constructing theoretical frameworks that unify previously unconnected observations — are those that produce the advances that verification subsequently confirms or disconfirms. The history of science provides a clear pattern: the scientists who produced the most significant advances were characteristically both imaginative and rigorous, and the scientists who were exclusively rigorous tended to produce technically excellent work within existing paradigms without transforming those paradigms. Imagination without rigour in science is speculation; rigour without imagination is competent but not generative.

3. What kinds of jobs need imagination?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The conventional answer — creative industries, design, the arts — is true but significantly understates how broadly imaginative capacity matters in professional life. Architecture, engineering, and product design require imagination at the level of conceptualisation — the capacity to construct in the mind what does not yet exist and evaluate its properties before building it — as much as any artistic field. Teaching requires imagination in the pedagogical sense: a teacher who cannot imagine what the content looks like from inside a student's incomprehension cannot design the explanations, examples, and activities that bridge from confusion to understanding. Even ostensibly analytical fields like law, medicine, and economics require imagination at the level of counterfactual reasoning — imagining what would have happened under different conditions — which is the basis of both causal inference and normative judgment.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of which jobs need imagination is better framed as a question of what kind of imagination different jobs require, since the imaginative demands of different fields are genuinely different in kind rather than simply different in degree. Strategic roles — in business, policy, and military contexts — require the specific imaginative capacity to construct multiple plausible futures and reason about what is true across all of them. Design and creative roles require the capacity to hold in mind something that does not yet exist and work toward its realisation. People-facing roles — in management, education, healthcare, and social work — require specifically social and empathic imagination: the capacity to construct an accurate model of another person's subjective experience and respond to that rather than to one's own assumptions about it. The most valuable professionals across all these fields are those who have developed not generic creativity but the specific form of imaginative capacity that their field's most important challenges require.

4. What subjects are helpful for children's imagination?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The subjects most consistently associated with imaginative development in children are those that require construction rather than reception — that ask children to make something, rather than to receive and reproduce something. Literature and creative writing develop imaginative capacity most directly through the practice of narrative construction: building internally consistent worlds, inhabiting characters whose perspectives differ from one's own, and communicating experience in forms that are both honest and accessible to others. The visual arts develop spatial and conceptual imagination; mathematics — particularly in its

more open-ended, problem-solving forms — develops the capacity for abstract imaginative reasoning about structures and relationships. Music develops temporal imagination and auditory construction. The common thread across all of these is that they work best when they require children to originate rather than reproduce.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The educational research on imagination development in children identifies several consistent findings about which subject-level experiences are most beneficial. Open-ended problem-solving in mathematics — as distinct from computational drill, which develops a different cognitive capacity — is one of the most robustly evidenced pathways to imaginative reasoning development, because it requires children to construct solution approaches from first principles. Literature, particularly when it is discussed interpretively rather than used primarily as a source of comprehension exercises, develops the social imaginative capacity — the ability to inhabit a perspective other than one's own — that is one of the most practically valuable forms of imagination in adult life. The subjects that are most importantly missing from many school curricula are those that develop design and making capacity: the ability to translate imaginative conceptions into physical reality, which requires a form of iterative practical imagination that few other school subjects develop.

5. What games help develop children's imagination?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The games that most consistently develop imagination in children are those with the fewest constraints: unstructured imaginative play — what developmental psychologists call "free play" or "pretend play" — in which children construct their own scenarios, roles, and rules, produces more robust gains in imaginative capacity than structured digital games or sports with fixed rules. The mechanism is straightforward: in unstructured play, children must generate and maintain a coherent internally consistent imagined world rather than operating within a pre-given one, which is the defining cognitive task of imagination. Construction toys — tangible blocks, modelling materials, loose parts — develop the specific form of spatial and physical imagination required for design and making, and are among the most imaginatively productive play materials across a wide age range.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The research on play and imagination development distinguishes importantly between games that exercise imagination and those that primarily test other cognitive capacities. Role-playing games and narrative games — in which children construct characters, stories, and social worlds — are the most directly imaginatively productive, particularly when they are child-generated rather than adult-scripted. Strategy games, including both board games and some digital strategy games, develop planning-based imaginative capacity: the ability to construct multiple future states from current conditions and reason about which are desirable and achievable. The concern about screen-based play is not that digital games cannot develop imaginative capacity — some clearly can — but that they typically provide more of the imaginative content externally and leave less for the child to generate, which is precisely where the developmental benefit lies.

6. How important is imagination to children?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Imagination is not a supplementary capacity in child development — it is foundational to the cognitive, emotional, and social development that all other capacities depend upon. Cognitively, imaginative capacity underlies the ability to reason about counterfactuals, plan ahead, and understand abstract concepts — all of which require holding in mind states of affairs that are not directly perceivable. Emotionally, imagination is the basis of empathy: the ability to model what another person is experiencing requires constructing that experience in one's own mind in its absence. Socially, imaginative play is the primary mechanism through which young children learn to negotiate, collaborate, compromise, and sustain shared fictional worlds — all of which are the precursors to adult social and professional competencies.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The developmental importance of imagination in childhood is difficult to overstate because it underpins so many other capacities that are not visibly imaginative in form. Academic learning across all disciplines becomes more effective and durable when it is anchored in imaginative engagement — when children can construct mental models of what they are learning rather than simply receiving information as isolated facts. Social development is substantially mediated by the narrative imagination that pretend play develops: children's ability to understand that other people have different beliefs, desires, and perspectives — what developmental psychologists call "theory of mind"— is significantly accelerated by sustained experience of imaginative play in which multiple subjective positions are inhabited. The practical argument for protecting children's access to imaginative play from the constant displacement of structured academic and extracurricular activity is therefore not simply one of wellbeing but of the foundations of the learning and social capacities that structured activity aims to develop.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
divergent thinking	n phr		the process of generating many different ideas or solutions	tư duy phân kỳ
theory of mind	n phr	/ˈθɪər.i ɒv maɪnd/	the ability to attribute mental states to others	lý thuyết tâm lý (hiểu người khác có suy nghĩ riêng)
pretend play	n phr		imaginative role-playing in young children	trò chơi giả vờ, đóng vai
counterfactual	adj	/ˌkaʊn.tə.ˈfæk.tʃu.əl/	relating to alternative scenarios that did not occur	phản thực tế, giả định ngược
spatial reasoning	n phr		the ability to mentally visualise and manipulate objects in space	tư duy không gian
paradigm	n	/ˈpær.ə.dɑɪm/	a typical example or framework of thinking in a field	mô hình tư duy, hệ hình
free play	n phr		unstructured, child-directed play without adult-imposed rules	chơi tự do
narrative imagination	n phr		the capacity to construct and inhabit stories or mental scenarios	trí tưởng tượng kể chuyện
iterative	adj	/ɪt.ər.ə.tɪv/	involving repetition of a process to refine a result	lặp đi lặp lại để cải tiến
hypothesis	n	/haɪˈpɒθ.i.sɪs/	a testable proposition that explains observed phenomena	giả thuyết

2.27 Describe a book you read that you found useful

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a book you read that you found useful. You should say:

- What it is
- When you read it
- Why you think it is useful
- And explain how you felt about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The book I would describe is **Thinking, Fast and Slow** by Daniel Kahneman, which I read during the summer between my second and third years at university, when I was looking for something that would help me understand why intelligent people — including myself — so often reason badly.

The book distinguishes between two modes of cognitive processing: a fast, intuitive, and largely automatic system, and a slow, deliberate, and effortful one. What I found most genuinely useful was not the theoretical framework itself but the specific cognitive biases it describes and the experimental evidence it uses: anchoring effects, the planning fallacy, availability bias, and loss aversion. Each of these was immediately recognisable in decisions I had already made and could see being made around me, which is the defining quality of useful intellectual content — it makes the previously invisible visible. The book altered the way I approach decisions in study and in social situations: I now habitually question whether an initial judgment is the product of deliberate reasoning or a fast-thinking heuristic, and I ask for a second opinion on any decision I feel particularly confident about, because the research suggests confidence and accuracy are poorly correlated. That practice has been, by some measure, the most practically useful habit I have built from any single book.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The book that has had the most persistent and measurable influence on my professional practice is **The Principles of Product Development Flow** by Donald Reinertsen, which I read at a point in my career when I was managing multiple concurrent projects and experiencing the kind of queue-related delays and coordination failures that the book turned out to explain with unusual precision.

Reinertsen applies queuing theory and economic reasoning to the management of product development work, and the central insight — that the most costly aspect of most development processes is not the work itself but the waiting, and that reducing variability and managing queue length are therefore more important than optimising individual task efficiency — was both counterintuitive and immediately testable. I implemented several of the book's recommendations within months of reading it, with measurable improvements in throughput and lead time. The intellectual quality that makes it genuinely useful rather than simply interesting is the density of its analytical reasoning: every recommendation is derived from a principle, and the principle is explained with enough rigour that the reader can generate their own applications rather than merely following the book's prescriptions.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
heuristic	n	/hjuˈrɪs.tɪk/	a mental shortcut used to make decisions quickly	phương pháp tư duy tắt, heuristic
cognitive bias	n phr		a systematic error in thinking that affects judgments	thiên kiến nhận thức
anchoring effect	n phr		the tendency to rely too heavily on the first piece of information encountered	hiệu ứng neo đậu
loss aversion	n phr		the tendency to prefer avoiding losses over acquiring gains	ác cảm thua lỗ
throughput	n	/ˈθruː.pʊt/	the amount of work completed in a given period	năng suất xử lý, thông lượng
queuing theory	n phr		the mathematical study of waiting lines and their effects	lý thuyết hàng đợi
counterintuitive	adj	/ˌkaʊn.tər.ɪnˈtjuː.ɪ.tɪv/	contrary to what one would expect	trái với trực giác
variability	n	/ˌveər.i.əˈbɪl.ɪ.ti/	the tendency to change or vary	tính biến thiên
availability bias	n phr		the tendency to overweight easily recalled examples	thiên kiến sẵn có
prescription	n	/prɪˈskrɪp.ʃən/	a recommended course of action	hướng dẫn, chỉ định hành động

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What are the types of books that young people like to read?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Young readers in Vietnam, as in most countries, distribute across several broad categories that reflect both developmental preference and social influence. Fantasy and science fiction

attract readers who want the imaginative expansion of encountering fully realised alternative worlds with their own coherent rules; light fiction — romance, thriller, and young adult narratives — attracts readers who want emotionally engaging plots with relatable characters; and a growing segment of younger Vietnamese readers is drawn to popular non-fiction on psychology, productivity, and self-development, which reflects both genuine intellectual curiosity and an awareness of competitive self-improvement pressures. The most sociologically interesting observation is that social media reading recommendations have substantially altered which specific books within these categories young people actually read, concentrating attention on a narrower set of titles than diversified individual recommendation networks previously produced.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The reading preferences of young people are shaped by an interaction between developmental psychological needs — identity formation, social belonging, emotional exploration, and world-building — and the specific social filtering mechanisms of each generation's information environment. In the current context, short video platforms and social reading recommendation apps have significantly increased the cultural visibility of a specific subset of titles — primarily popular psychology, self-help, and narratively driven fiction — while reducing the proportion of readers who encounter books through serendipitous browsing, teacher recommendation, or literary prize coverage. The most significant concern for reading culture is not that young people are reading the wrong kinds of books but that algorithmic recommendation systems tend to amplify preference rather than expand it, which produces readers who are well-supplied with books they are already likely to enjoy but less frequently exposed to books that would develop them in ways their existing preferences do not.

2. What should the government do to make libraries better?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The most consequential library investments governments can make are those that address the fundamental barrier to library use: the perceived relevance of the library to the life of the potential user. Practical improvements — extending opening hours, modernising collection development to include digital resources and recent popular titles, improving physical environments to make them genuinely welcoming — are necessary but not sufficient if the library remains primarily associated in the public imagination with formal academic study and childhood story time. The most effective government investments in libraries in recent decades have been those that repositioned libraries as general-purpose community knowledge infrastructure: a place where job-seekers can access digital services, families can find professional advice, students can study, and curious people of all ages can encounter books and ideas they did not know to look for.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for government investment in public libraries rests on a well-evidenced public goods argument: libraries provide access to information, education, and cultural resources to people who could not otherwise afford them, and this access has measurable positive effects on educational attainment, civic participation, health literacy, and economic mobility. The most productive government interventions are therefore those that target libraries as critical equity infrastructure rather than as cultural luxuries: ensuring adequate provision in low-income communities where private alternatives are least available, funding digital access to compensate for the physical inaccessibility of remote communities, and staffing libraries with professionally qualified librarians who can actively support information literacy rather than simply curate physical collections. The evidence from countries with well-funded public

library systems — the Nordic and Anglophone cases are most studied — consistently shows that per-capita library investment correlates with a range of social goods that are expensive to produce through other mechanisms.

3. Do you think old people spend more time reading than young people?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The evidence on reading patterns across age groups suggests that reading time does tend to increase with age, but the explanation is more structural than it is generational: older adults have more discretionary time than those in working and parenting life stages, and reading is a recreational form that benefits from sustained attention in quiet conditions — which are more available to people in their sixties and beyond than to those managing multiple competing demands. It is therefore not that older people value reading more than younger ones — the reading attitudes of older readers were formed when they were young, and their reading habits tend to reflect those earlier formed preferences — but that time and environmental conditions align more favourably with sustained reading at older life stages.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The comparison between older and younger reading volumes is complicated by the significant change in what counts as reading. If reading is defined narrowly as extended engagement with book-length text, older adults do tend to read more than younger ones, and the reasons are primarily about time and environment rather than values. If reading is defined more broadly to include all sustained text engagement — including long-form journalism, online essays, academic materials, and extended social media content — the age difference is considerably smaller, and the advantage may even reverse for some content categories. The more productive question for understanding reading culture is not who reads more but what conditions — of time, environment, material access, and educational preparation — enable the kind of sustained, deep engagement with text that produces long-term educational and cognitive benefits, and how those conditions can be made more widely available across age groups.

4. Which one is better, paper books or e-books?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The paper versus e-book comparison is one where the empirical evidence and the reader's subjective preference often diverge, and both deserve consideration. Research on reading comprehension across formats consistently finds that paper produces better retention of complex, sequential material — particularly for academic and non-fiction reading — and is associated with fewer distractions and better sustained attention. E-books offer genuine advantages in portability, accessibility, searchability, and the ability to adjust text size and contrast, which are particularly important for readers with visual impairments or for those reading in low-resource environments. The honest answer is that neither is universally better: the best format is the one that matches the reader's purpose, the nature of the material, and the reading environment, and a reading practice that uses both formats strategically is probably more effective than a dogmatic preference for either.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The practical comparison between paper and digital reading formats requires separating several distinct dimensions: comprehension, convenience, accessibility, environmental cost,

and the social and cultural functions of the book object. On comprehension, the research modestly favours paper for complex, non-linear material, though the effect size is smaller than the intensity of the popular preference debate would suggest. On accessibility and equity, e-books are substantially superior: digital access extends reading to geographically and economically underserved populations at a marginal cost far below that of physical distribution. On environmental grounds, the comparison is not as clear as sustainability advocates often claim: the energy costs of e-reader production and digital infrastructure are substantial, and low-volume readers may have a smaller carbon footprint from paper than from digital reading. The pragmatic conclusion is that the format question is less important than the reading question: a society that reads more in either format is better than one that reads less in the preferred one.

5. Have libraries changed a lot with the development of the internet?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Libraries have changed substantially in response to the internet, but the nature of the change is more disruptive than a simple evolution of services suggests. The internet has rendered the library's traditional core function — providing access to information not otherwise available to the general public — significantly less distinctive, since most of the factual content that only libraries previously provided is now accessible to anyone with a connection. This has forced libraries to redefine their value proposition: from information provision to information literacy support, from collection access to curated and qualified guidance, and from physical space for solo reading to community space for shared intellectual activity. The libraries that have navigated this transition most successfully are those that understood clearly what the internet cannot replace — curated expertise, physical community infrastructure, and the particular quality of encounter with primary objects — and invested in those rather than attempting to compete with digital access on its own terms.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The internet has transformed libraries from unique access points for information into one node in a much larger networked information ecosystem, and the strategic challenge this creates for library institutions is genuine and ongoing. Libraries that have responded by adding digital services — e-book lending, online database access, digital literacy programmes — have maintained relevance more effectively than those that have resisted digital integration, but the most important transformations have been those that redefined the library's institutional identity rather than simply expanding its service menu. The most valuable thing a contemporary library can provide is not information itself — which is abundantly available outside the library — but the human, curatorial, and community infrastructure that helps people navigate, evaluate, and use information effectively: reference librarians, community programming, research support, and the particular credibility of the institutionally curated collection as a counterweight to the unfiltered abundance of the open web.

6. What should we do to prevent modern libraries from closing down?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The strategic case for preventing library closures rests on articulating clearly what libraries provide that no other institution provides — which is increasingly not a question about books but about equitable access to information, community space, and professional

knowledge support for people with the fewest alternatives. The most effective advocacy for library preservation makes this equity argument explicitly and quantitatively: library closure most severely affects the populations least served by commercial and digital alternatives — children in low-income households, elderly people, job-seekers, and people without reliable internet access — and the costs of the alternatives that would partially fill the gap are considerably higher than the cost of the library itself. Practically, the libraries most successfully resisting closure are those that have diversified their service offering to become community hubs — providing digital access, professional advisory services, community programming, and safe public space — rather than remaining narrowly defined as book-lending institutions.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Library preservation requires both political advocacy and institutional evolution, and the two are inseparable: institutions that have not made the case for their contemporary relevance are politically indefensible when budget pressures require choices, while institutions that have diversified their value proposition and demonstrated community impact are substantially more resilient. The evidence from countries that have sustained or increased library funding despite fiscal pressure consistently identifies two enabling factors: strong public awareness campaigns that make the equity argument for library access explicit and emotionally resonant, and library institutions that have actively demonstrated community impact through rigorous outcome measurement — documenting who they serve, what the service achieves, and what the alternative cost would be. The lesson for library advocates is that the argument from cultural heritage — “we should have libraries because libraries are good”— is insufficient in the contemporary political environment; the argument must be made in the economic and equity terms that political decision-makers can defend.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
serendipitous	adj	/,ser.ən'dɪp.i.təs/	occurring by happy chance or pleasant accident	tình cờ may mắn
discretionary time	n phr		time free from obligatory duties	thời gian tự do, tùy ý sử dụng
curate	v	/kjʊ'reɪt/	to carefully select and organise content for an audience	chọn lọc và tổ chức nội dung
information literacy	n phr		the ability to find, evaluate, and use information effectively	năng lực thông tin
equity infrastructure	n phr		systems designed to ensure fair access for all	cơ sở hạ tầng bình đẳng
value proposition	n phr		the reason why someone should choose a service or product	giá trị đề xuất, lý do chọn dùng
algorithmic recommendation	n phr		suggestions generated by automated systems based on user behaviour	đề xuất thuật toán
marginal cost	n phr		the cost of producing one additional unit	chi phí cận biên
outcome measurement	n phr		the process of tracking the results and impacts of a programme	đo lường kết quả
heritage	n	/'her.i.tɪdʒ/	the traditions, values, and objects passed down through history	di sản

2.28 Describe a creative person you admire

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a creative person (e.g. an artist, a musician, an architect, etc.) you admire. You should say:

- Who he/she is
- How you knew him/her
- What his/her greatest achievement is
- And explain why you think he/she is creative.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I would describe is a graphic designer named Anh Tuấn, who graduated from my university four years before I began studying there, and whose work I first encountered when a lecturer used one of his projects as a case study in my first-year design thinking seminar.

Tuấn had created a series of visual communication pieces for a non-governmental organisation working on water access in rural Việt Nam — not conventional charity infographics, but typographically sophisticated and conceptually unusual posters that repurposed Vietnamese calligraphic traditions to encode statistical information. They were striking because they accomplished something rare in design: they were genuinely beautiful at the level of surface and simultaneously rigorous at the level of informational content, without either quality compromising the other. I looked him up after the lecture and found that he had since gone on to work on several broadly distributed public health campaigns, maintaining the same commitment to design that serves communication rather than substituting spectacle for it.

What I admire about him specifically is that his creativity is never self-indulgent: every formal and aesthetic decision in his work is accountable to a communicative purpose, and his ability to find genuinely unexpected solutions within that accountability is what I would define as creative excellence — the capacity to produce something both surprising and right.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I find most genuinely creatively admirable in my professional experience is an architect named Linh — now a senior partner at a firm in Hà Nội — whom I worked alongside on a mixed-use development project in my early career.

Linh's approach to spatial design was distinguished by a quality that is rarer than it sounds: she never designed from typology — never started with "this is the form that a building of this type takes" — but always from a granular understanding of how the specific people in the specific context would actually inhabit the space, which she developed through direct observational research that took up a substantial portion of every project's early phase. The consequence was that her designs tended to look unusual by the conventions of the type — her residential buildings had shared spaces where other buildings had private ones, her commercial spaces had proportions that most comparable buildings did not — and the unusual quality was always in service of a use-pattern analysis that, once explained, was obvious and obviously right.

I find her creative because she is willing to do the methodological work — the sustained,

patient observation and analysis — that enables genuinely novel solutions rather than taking the shortcut of stylistic novelty, which is a far more common and considerably less admirable form of being different.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
typographically	adv	/ˌtaɪ.pəˈɡræf.i.kli/	in a way relating to the style and arrangement of text	về mặt typography (nghệ thuật sắp chữ)
calligraphic	adj	/ˌkæl.iˈɡræf.ɪk/	relating to the art of beautiful handwriting	thuộc thư pháp
self-indulgent	adj	/ˌself.ɪnˈdʌl.dʒənt/	focused on personal gratification rather than purpose	tự chiều chuộng, không chú ý nhu cầu người khác
typology	n	/taɪˈpɒl.ə.dʒi/	a system of classification based on shared types	loại học, phân loại theo kiểu
granular	adj	/ˈɡræn.jʊ.lər/	detailed and specific rather than general	chi tiết, cụ thể
spatial	adj	/ˈspeɪ.ʃəl/	relating to space and how things are arranged within it	thuộc về không gian
accountability	n	/əˌkaʊn.təˈbɪl.ɪ.ti/	responsibility or answerability for one's decisions	trách nhiệm giải trình
observational research	n phr		research based on systematic direct observation	nghiên cứu quan sát
spectacle	n	/ˈspek.tə.kəl/	something visually striking but perhaps lacking substance	cảnh tượng hoành tráng, trình diễn
conceptually	adv	/kənˈsep.tʃu.ə.li/	in terms of underlying ideas or principles	về mặt khái niệm

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Do you think children should learn to play musical instruments?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Learning a musical instrument is one of the most robustly evidenced developmental activities available to children, producing measurable benefits in a wider range of cognitive and non-cognitive domains than most comparable educational activities. The cognitive benefits are well-documented: sustained musical training improves working memory, phonological processing, mathematical understanding of proportion and pattern, and fine motor control. The non-cognitive benefits — including the development of disciplined practice habits, the capacity to accept failure and sustain effort through difficulty, and the experience of producing something beautiful through one's own sustained effort — are arguably more significant for long-term development than the cognitive ones. The important caveat is that these benefits are associated with sustained practice in a supportive environment, not simply with initial exposure, and the conditions of learning matter as much as the activity itself.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for musical instrument training in childhood is strong and goes considerably beyond the popular appeal to cognitive enhancement, which tends to be overstated. The most substantive developmental arguments are about what sustained musical practice develops in terms of character rather than cognition: the ability to engage with a difficult skill over a long time horizon, accept the discomfort of incompetence as a transitional rather than permanent state, and derive genuine satisfaction from improvement rather than from achievement. These capacities — patience, persistence, intrinsic motivation, and tolerance for process — are the foundations of professional excellence in virtually every demanding field, and musical training is among the most effective available pedagogical contexts for developing them. The question for parents is therefore not whether their children will become professional musicians but whether musical practice, in the right conditions and with appropriate support, would develop capacities that will be valuable regardless of what their children ultimately do.

2. How do artists acquire inspiration?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The popular image of artistic inspiration as a sudden, unprepared arrival of creative insight is empirically inaccurate and does a disservice to the serious work that precedes and enables creative breakthroughs. The more accurate account, supported by research on creative processes in art, literature, music, and design, is that inspiration operates as the resolution of a problem that has been held in active attention for an extended period — a moment of synthesis that is prepared for by sustained work and observation rather than visited randomly upon the passive recipient. Artists who are consistently creatively productive tend to maintain active practices of looking, noticing, and engaging with a wide range of material outside their own immediate field — what cognitive psychologists call "wide sampling" — which provides the raw material that prepared attention can then synthesise into original work.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of how artists acquire inspiration is best addressed by distinguishing between the spontaneous quality that inspiration feels like from the inside and the systematic conditions that produce it. From the inside, creative inspiration is typically experienced as a sudden connection — a perception that two previously unconnected things are related in a productive way — that feels effortless and involuntary. From the outside, the research on creative

biographies consistently shows that these moments of apparent spontaneity are preceded by sustained immersion in the relevant problem, broad and curious engagement with the world beyond the immediate field, and deliberate periods of incubation in which the problem is held in background attention without being actively worked. The practical implication for people in creative fields is that inspiration is something to be cultivated through structured conditions — sustained engagement, disciplined practice, intentional rest — rather than passively awaited.

3. Do you think pictures and videos in news reports are important?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Visual elements in news reporting serve several distinct functions that range from the genuinely informative to the manipulative, and the evaluation of their importance depends on which function is being considered. At their best, images and videos provide documentary evidence of events that written reporting can only describe — images of disaster, conflict, social injustice, and public celebration carry an immediacy and specificity that text cannot replicate — and this documentary function is one of journalism's most historically important contributions to political accountability. At their worst, visual elements in news reporting exploit the disproportionate emotional impact of imagery relative to text — particularly for threatening or distressing events — to produce audience states that distort rather than inform judgment about the frequency, severity, and appropriate response to reported events.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The role of visual elements in news reporting warrants the kind of careful, medium-specific analysis that popular media commentary typically does not provide. Visual journalism at its most valuable serves functions that text cannot: the documentation of events through direct evidence, the provision of context through spatial and environmental imagery, and the humanisation of statistical or abstract reporting through individual narrative. The significant concern is the systematic effect of visual news consumption on risk perception: psychological research consistently finds that visual representation of events — particularly salient, emotionally arousing events — produces overestimation of their frequency and severity relative to base rates, which distorts both individual risk judgment and collective political prioritisation. The most intellectually responsible position is that visual elements are important, but that news consumers and news organisations both have responsibilities to understand and partly compensate for these systematic perceptual biases.

4. What can we do to help children stay creative?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Protecting children's creativity requires both removing constraints and providing conditions, and both are more actively required than most educational policy discussions acknowledge. The most damaging constraint on children's creativity is the excessive structuring of time: children who spend most of their time in adult-directed activities — academic study, organised sport, supervised extracurricular programmes — have significantly less opportunity to develop the self-initiated creative capacity that unstructured time, boredom, and self-directed play produce. The most important positive condition is exposure to a wide range of materials, ideas, and experiences across domains — which both provides raw creative material and prevents the early specialisation that narrows creative possibility. Teachers and parents who

model the creative process — who think aloud, who are visibly uncertain, who try things that do not work and continue anyway — also make a significant contribution that is often overlooked in favour of more tangible structural interventions.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Sustaining children’s creativity in educational and home contexts requires a clear analysis of what tends to diminish it, since most of the effective interventions are protective rather than additive. The primary diminishers of children’s creativity in contemporary contexts are: excessive performance pressure (the requirement to produce correct rather than interesting answers), excessive adult direction of activity (leaving children insufficient autonomy to generate their own approaches), and the displacement of open-ended play by screen-based passive entertainment (which is consumptive rather than generative). The most effective institutional interventions — in schools and organisations concerned with creative capacity — are those that create genuine space for exploratory activity without predetermined correct outcomes, and that evaluate and reward the process of creative inquiry as highly as its products.

5. How does drawing help to enhance children’s creativity?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Drawing is one of the most developmentally productive creative activities available to children because it simultaneously develops several distinct capacities that together constitute creative competence. At the basic perceptual level, drawing trains careful visual attention — the ability to actually look at the world rather than to draw the symbol one has learned to associate with the object — which is a foundational observational skill that transfers across creative domains. At the conceptual level, drawing requires translating internal visual ideas into external marks, which develops the capacity to externalise and evaluate mental representations — a fundamental creative skill that drawing uniquely makes visible. At the iterative level, drawing provides immediate feedback on the gap between intention and execution, which develops tolerance for imperfection and the capacity to refine through repeated attempts.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The developmental research on drawing and creativity identifies drawing as one of the clearest available bridges between perceptual experience and symbolic representation, which makes it a particularly valuable creative practice in early to middle childhood. Drawing requires and reinforces a particularly productive form of attention — looking at the world as it actually is rather than as categorical knowledge tells us it should be — that is foundational to creative perception across all domains. The externalisation function is equally important: drawing makes internal representations visible and therefore criticisable, which is the basis of the iterative refinement process through which creative work develops. Design education at every level is built on drawing precisely because the habit of visual thinking — of representing, evaluating, and revising visual ideas externally — is the cognitive infrastructure on which domain-specific creative skills are most effectively built.

6. What kind of jobs require creativity?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The scope of jobs requiring creativity is considerably wider than the popular identification

of "creative professions" with the arts and design industries captures. Any job in which novel problems arise — which is increasingly the majority of economically significant professional roles — requires creative problem-solving: the capacity to generate multiple possible approaches, evaluate their likely effectiveness, and select and adapt the most promising. The jobs where creativity is most clearly and constantly demanded are those involving design in the broad sense — the deliberate shaping of complex systems toward intended outcomes — which includes architecture, engineering, product development, marketing, organisational design, policy development, and teaching, in addition to the arts. The interesting socioeconomic question for the next two decades is the relationship between artificial intelligence and creativity in professional contexts: AI is substantially better than humans at high-volume pattern reproduction within established domains, and substantially worse at generating genuinely novel responses to genuinely novel problems, which suggests that creative capacity will become progressively more — not less — economically valuable.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional landscape of creativity is better understood through the lens of what specific creative demands different roles place rather than through categorical distinctions between "creative" and "non-creative" work. Roles that require generative creativity — the production of genuinely new solutions, products, or frameworks — include design, research, strategy, entrepreneurship, and the arts. Roles that require adaptive creativity — the application of existing methods to novel contexts in ways that require genuine judgment — include medicine, law, teaching, management, and engineering. Roles that require interpretive creativity — finding meaning and pattern in complex, ambiguous data — include analysis, journalism, and scholarship. The common thread across all three types is the requirement to engage productively with problems that do not have pre-specified correct answers — which is precisely the domain where human creative capacity has proven most resistant to automation.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
phonological processing	n phr		the ability to hear and manipulate sound units in language	xử lý ngữ âm
incubation	n	/ˌɪŋ.kjʊˈbeɪ.jən/	a period of unconscious problem-solving while mentally resting	ủ ý tưởng (giai đoạn tiềm thức)
base rate	n phr		the underlying frequency of an event in a population	tỷ lệ nền, tần suất cơ bản
documentary evidence	n phr		proof based on recorded records or images	bằng chứng tài liệu
salience	n	/'seɪ.li.əns/	the quality of being particularly noticeable or important	sự nổi bật
externalise	v	/ɪk'stɜː.nə.laɪz/	to express or represent internal thoughts outwardly	biểu đạt ra bên ngoài
iterative refinement	n phr		improving something through repeated cycles of revision	tinh chỉnh lặp đi lặp lại
wide sampling	n phr		exposure to a broad range of ideas and stimuli to fuel creativity	lấy mẫu rộng (trong nghiên cứu sáng tạo)
generative creativity	n phr		the ability to produce entirely new ideas or solutions	sáng tạo sinh thành
adaptive creativity	n phr		creativity applied to solving problems in new contexts	sáng tạo thích ứng

2.29 Describe a long journey you had and would like to take again

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a long journey you had and would like to take again. You should say:

- When/where you went
- Who you had the journey with
- Why you had the journey
- And explain why you would like to have it again.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The journey I would describe is a two-week overland trip from Hà Nội to Cà Mau that I made with three friends at the end of my second year — not by the fastest route, but by a series of roads and ferries that deliberately followed the coastline wherever possible.

The trip was conceived as both a celebration of surviving our second year and something more serious: we had all been studying regional development and urbanisation and wanted to actually see, in sequence and continuity, the landscape we had been reading statistics about. We spent nights in fishing villages, provincial towns, and one uncomfortable night on a ferry across the mouth of a delta river. We ate whatever was available locally, which was sometimes extraordinary and occasionally not.

What made it a journey I want to take again is not nostalgia for the specific places — though several were beautiful — but the particular cognitive experience of geographical continuity: seeing the landscape change gradually from temperate to tropical, watching how the relationship between water, agriculture, and settlement evolved across latitude, and feeling the country as a connected physical reality rather than a set of discrete destinations. I have not experienced that quality of geographic comprehension in any other form of travel, and I would like to try to recover it — probably more slowly, at this point, and with better preparation for the mosquitoes in the Mekong delta.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The journey I would describe is a twelve-day research trip I made to five provincial cities in the northern and central highlands — Bắc Kạn, Hà Giang, Điện Biên, Sơn La, and Lai Châu — which I undertook as part of a policy research project on rural infrastructure investment.

The journey was primarily professional in purpose — visiting project sites, interviewing local officials and community members, and collecting observational data — but the cumulative experience of the landscape, the quality of the conversations, and the pace of information that travel by road produces made it one of the most intellectually productive periods of my working life. I had the particular experience of seeing the same policy framework applied across dramatically different topographic, ethnic, and economic contexts in quick succession, which made visible dimensions of policy implementation that would have been entirely invisible from a desk in Hà Nội.

I would like to make the journey again because I understand now what I did not fully

understand the first time: how much of what I saw I processed too quickly and retained too shallowly. Returning to those environments with better questions, more time, and the context that the first journey provided would, I think, be a substantially different — and more productive — experience than the original.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
overland	adj/adv	/ˌəʊ.vəˈlænd/	travelling by road or land rather than air or sea	theo đường bộ, bằng qua đất liền
latitude	n	/ˈlæt.ɪ.tjuːd/	distance north or south of the equator	vĩ độ
topographic	adj	/ˌtɒp.əˈɡræf.ɪk/	relating to the physical features of an area of land	địa hình học
continuity	n	/ˌkɒn.tɪˈnjuː.ɪ.ti/	the unbroken connection of successive parts	tính liên tục
implementation	n	/ˌɪm.plɪ.menˈteɪ.ʃən/	the process of putting a plan into action	thực thi, thực hiện
sequential	adj	/sɪˈkwen.ʃəl/	following a particular order; one after another	tuần tự, theo thứ tự
infrastructure	n	/ˈɪn.frə.strʌk.tʃər/	the basic physical systems supporting a society	cơ sở hạ tầng
itinerary	n	/aɪˈtɪn.ər.ər.i/	a planned route or journey schedule	hành trình, lịch trình
temperate	adj	/ˈtem.pər.ət/	having mild weather, not extreme heat or cold	ôn đới
discrete	adj	/dɪˈskriːt/	individually separate and distinct	riêng biệt, không liên kết

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Do you think it is a good choice to travel by plane?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Air travel is a rational choice for specific purposes and a poor one for others, and the question is best evaluated through a matrix of criteria rather than a single-factor judgment. For long-distance travel where time is the binding constraint — international journeys, travel for professional commitments, travel to remote destinations with no practical surface alternative — air travel is clearly the appropriate choice and has no meaningful practical substitute. For shorter journeys, particularly within a single country or region, the calculus is less clear: the time advantage of flying is often substantially reduced by the access and processing time at airports, and the journey quality — in terms of environmental experience, serendipitous discovery, and genuine encounter with geography — is categorically different on surface transport. The environmental dimension increasingly complicates this in ways that individual travelers cannot reasonably resolve without systemic policy support.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Evaluating air travel as a choice requires separating several distinct criteria that are often conflated: efficiency (time per kilometer of distance covered), environmental cost, journey quality, and total economic cost including the full door-to-door time accounting. On pure efficiency for long-haul journeys, air travel is clearly superior to all alternatives; on environmental cost, it is the worst available option per passenger kilometer for distances where surface alternatives exist; on journey quality, the comparison is highly context-dependent. The most interesting professional productivity case involves long-distance train travel: research and practical experience consistently show that business travelers on long-haul rail services produce more useful work, are less cognitively depleted on arrival, and report higher travel satisfaction than equivalent air travelers — a finding that has significant implications for corporate travel policy in countries with adequate rail infrastructure.

2. What are the differences between group travelling and travelling alone?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Group travel and solo travel are so different in their characteristic experiences that comparing them on a single "better/worse" axis substantially misrepresents the situation: they are different activities that produce different things, and the choice between them depends on what the traveler is actually trying to get from the experience. Solo travel maximises encounter with the unfamiliar: without a pre-existing social structure to inhabit, the solo traveler is more exposed to chance conversations, unexpected re-routings, and the particular quality of alert attention that mild uncertainty produces. Group travel maximises social depth and shared reference: the experience of encountering something remarkable with people you know well — and the shared memory that persists — is a different and not necessarily lesser thing than encountering the same thing alone. The practical differences — in safety, in logistical efficiency, in the ability to access accommodation and restaurants easily — tend to favour groups for certain destinations and solo travel for others.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional context in which group versus solo travel most commonly arises — business travel — is worth considering alongside leisure travel because the dynamics are meaningfully different. Solo business travel tends to produce higher cognitive productivity

than group business travel: without the social management that travelling companions require, the solo traveler has more mental space for the reflective and preparatory thinking that professional travel occasions. Group leisure travel, conversely, is often preferred precisely because the social management is itself enjoyable and the shared experience has relational value that solo travel does not. The most relevant dimension for deciding between the two for any given journey is therefore what you most want to bring back: if the primary value is what you will see and think, solo travel often produces more; if the primary value is the experience of travelling itself and its effect on your relationships with specific people, group travel does.

3. What do we need to prepare for a long journey?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Preparation for a long journey falls into three categories that are less evenly attended to than they should be: logistical, physical, and cognitive. Logistical preparation — transport, accommodation, documents, insurance, health precautions, and financial access — is what most people focus on and what most travel advice addresses. Physical preparation — appropriate fitness for the activity demands of the journey, health management for the environments involved, and physical equipment suited to the conditions — is better attended to by experienced travellers than by first-time ones. Cognitive preparation — developing a sufficient understanding of the cultural, historical, and geographic context of the destination to make genuine encounter possible rather than superficial tourism — is the most consistently underprepared category and arguably the most determinative of whether the journey is genuinely worthwhile or merely comfortable.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Professional preparation for long research or business journeys has a specific logic that differs from leisure travel preparation: the most important preparation is intellectual rather than logistical, since logistical preparation for experienced professional travelers is largely habitual. For research-oriented travel, the most productive preparation involves developing a clear set of questions that the journey is intended to answer, a sufficient understanding of the relevant literature and context to recognise significant information when encountered, and the interpersonal network preparation — establishing contacts and securing access in advance — that enables the journey to produce data rather than merely impressions. The specific professional discipline that distinguishes effective from ineffective research travel is systematic field note practice: the commitment to recording what is observed with sufficient immediacy, specificity, and analytical engagement that it is genuinely recoverable for later analysis.

4. Why do some people like making long journeys?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The appeal of long journeys reflects a set of psychological needs that shorter travel and local experience relatively poorly satisfy: the need for genuine encounter with difference, the experience of sustained personal challenge in a novel environment, and the particular quality of perception that extended displacement from familiar contexts produces. The research on travel and wellbeing suggests that the most beneficial effects — in terms of creative renewal, perspective-taking, and reduced cognitive rigidity — are associated with journeys

that involve sustained immersion in genuinely different environments rather than short visits to tourist-formatted experiences, because it is extended exposure to difference that shifts cognitive frameworks rather than brief contact with it. Long journeys also have a temporal dimension that shorter travel lacks: the experience of time passing differently — more slowly, more attentively — is itself a value that many habitual travellers identify as central to why long journeys feel disproportionately important relative to their duration.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional and developmental value of long journeys is distinct from — and in some respects more important than — their recreational value, which is the dimension most commonly discussed. Extended professional travel to different institutional, cultural, and economic contexts produces a form of comparative understanding — a sense of the range of ways human problems can be organised and addressed — that is very difficult to acquire from reading, analysis, or shorter visits. The executives, policymakers, and researchers I have observed who have the most genuinely broad and flexible strategic intelligence are disproportionately those who have spent significant extended time in environments quite different from their home contexts, whether by preference, professional necessity, or accident of career. The mechanism appears to be cognitive: sustained exposure to different ordering principles forces a level of adaptive thinking that recalibrates frameworks in ways that short-term exposure cannot.

5. Why do some people prefer to travel in their own country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The preference for domestic travel reflects a set of advantages that are often undervalued relative to the cultural prestige that international travel enjoys. Language access — the ability to read, ask questions, and understand responses without interpretation — dramatically expands the range and quality of encounter available to the traveler: a fluent speaker can access local media, overhear public conversation, engage spontaneously with unfamiliar people, and navigate complex situations in ways that are not available to the foreign-language traveler. Cultural familiarity — knowing how social situations work, what is expected, and how to interpret behaviour — reduces the cognitive load of travel and enables deeper engagement with places and people. And domestic travel offers what is often the most underappreciated travel experience: discovering the genuine strangeness and complexity of one's own national geography and society, which sustained cultural familiarity tends to obscure.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Domestic travel is underrated as a professional development and intellectual renewal activity, partly because the reward structures of professional life tend to value international exposure more than domestic depth. The professional case for systematic domestic travel is that understanding the full complexity of one's own country — its regional variations, economic geographies, cultural multiplicity, and the local conditions that national-level data systematically obscures — provides an analytical foundation for policy, strategy, and research work that no amount of international exposure can substitute for. Vietnamese professionals who have travelled extensively domestically — who have spent time in the highland provinces, the Mekong delta, the northern border regions, and the central coast — tend to have a more empirically grounded and less Hà Nội-centric understanding of their country's development challenges than those whose travel is primarily international.

6. Why do some people prefer to travel abroad?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

International travel offers a specific and important kind of experience that domestic travel cannot replicate: encounter with a social, cultural, and linguistic order that is genuinely different from one's own in ways that cannot be habituated to quickly. This encounter — with different assumptions about how public space works, how social relationships are managed, how time is used, and what counts as important — is cognitively and experientially valuable precisely because it makes visible the contingency of one's own familiar arrangements: things that feel natural and necessary turn out to be one option among others, which is a perspective-expanding discovery that is much more difficult to achieve within a familiar cultural context. International travel also provides access to specific forms of historical, architectural, and natural environment that do not exist domestically — which is a legitimate and important motive that is sometimes treated dismissively but reflects a genuine desire for encounter with the world in its full diversity.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional and intellectual case for international travel is well-established: exposure to different institutional models, policy frameworks, business practices, and cultural approaches to common problems is one of the most consistently cited sources of innovative thinking among professionals who have worked across national contexts. The mechanism — encountering a fundamentally different solution to a problem one has assumed only has one solution — is cognitively disruptive in a specifically productive way: it forces the recognition that one's existing framework is a locally valid model rather than a universal truth, which is the starting point for genuinely adaptive and creative professional thinking. The more interesting question for professionals weighing international against domestic travel is not which is superior but which specific information and perspective gaps the individual most needs to address — and honest answers to that question sometimes point toward domestic depth as much as toward international breadth.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
calculus	n	/ˈkæl.kjʊ.ləs/	a method of reasoning about trade-offs or complex decisions	phép tính cân nhắc lợi hại
serendipitous	adj	/ˌser.ənˈdɪp.ɪ.təs/	occurring by chance in a beneficial way	tình cờ may mắn
recalibrate	v	/ˌriːˈkæl.ɪ.breɪt/	to adjust one's thinking or approach based on new information	điều chỉnh lại framework nhận thức
immersion	n	/ɪˈmɜːʃən/	complete involvement in a different environment or culture	sự đắm chìm (trong môi trường mới)
contingency	n	/kənˈtɪŋ.dʒən.si/	the fact that something depends on uncertain conditions	tính ngẫu nhiên, phụ thuộc hoàn cảnh
cognitive rigidity	n phr		the tendency to think in fixed, inflexible mental patterns	cứng nhắc nhận thức
habituate	v	/həˈbɪtʃ.u.eɪt/	to become so accustomed to something that it no longer draws attention	quen dần, mất cảm giác mới lạ
field note	n phr		written observations made by researchers during direct fieldwork	ghi chú thực địa
door-to-door	adj phr		accounting for the total time from origin to final destination	từ cửa đến cửa (tổng thời gian di chuyển)
perspective-taking	n phr		the cognitive act of understanding a situation from another's point of view	lấy góc nhìn người khác

2.30 Describe a person you know who enjoys working for a family business

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a person you know who enjoys working for a family business (e.g. a shop, etc.). You should say:

- Who he/she is
- What the business is
- What his/her job is
- And explain why he/she enjoys working there.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I would describe is my cousin, Minh Tú, who is twenty-six years old and works primarily as the production manager and — unofficially — the product development lead for her family's preserved fruit and traditional confectionery workshop in Đà Lạt.

The business has been run by her family for three generations: her grandmother started it, her parents expanded it into a small production facility, and Tú has been working in it since she was fifteen, initially during school holidays and then progressively more formally after she completed a degree in food technology at a university in Hồ Chí Minh City. She manages the production schedule, quality control, and has been responsible for developing a set of new products — including several that adapt traditional Đà Lạt fruit varieties into formats with better shelf life and broader market appeal — that have accounted for most of the business's growth over the past three years.

What she has told me she most values about working in the family business is the combination of genuine responsibility and genuine belonging: she makes decisions that significantly affect the business without the institutional distance of a corporate role, and she works with people — her parents, two aunts, and a small team of long-term employees — whose relationship to the business involves investment and care that is not purely contractual. She finds that the business gives her work a texture of significance that she suspects would be absent from a large company.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I would describe is a former colleague — I will call him Khang — who left a mid-level analytical position at a financial services firm to return full-time to his family's hardware and construction materials business in Bình Dương, a decision that most of his professional peers at the time found puzzling.

Khang's family had operated the business for twenty years before he joined it, and what he returned to was not a simple retail operation but a supplier relationship network that his father had built over decades — one with genuine trust-based depth that Khang's professional training in financial analysis and supply chain management enabled him to substantially improve without disrupting. He described his role as being primarily about making something his father had built intuitively into something that could sustain growth without losing the relational qualities that had made it successful: which meant building systems and processes that amplified rather than replaced the

trust-based supplier and customer relationships at the core of the business.

What he values most, he has told me, is the directness of the feedback between his decisions and their consequences — a lack of institutional distance from the real effects of his work that he found missing in corporate environments — and the sense that the work he is doing is building something that will compound over decades rather than producing quarterly results for shareholders he will never meet. He is, without question, more intellectually engaged and professionally satisfied than he was during the corporate period of his career.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
confectionery	n	/kən'fek.jən.ər.i/	sweets and other sugar-based food products	bánh kẹo, đồ ngọt
shelf life	n phr		the length of time a product remains usable or sellable	thời hạn sử dụng
contractual	adj	/kən'træk.tʃu.əl/	relating to or based on a formal agreement	theo hợp đồng
supplier relationship	n phr		the ongoing connection between a business and those who provide goods	mối quan hệ với nhà cung cấp
supply chain	n phr		the entire system of production, processing, and distribution of goods	chuỗi cung ứng
compound	v	/'kɒm.paʊnd/	to grow by accumulation over time	tích lũy, gia tăng theo thời gian
institutional distance	n phr		the separation between an employee and the real-world effects of their work	khoảng cách thể chế
relational	adj	/'rɪ.leɪ.jən.əl/	relating to or based on personal connections and trust	dựa trên mối quan hệ
quality control	n phr		the process of maintaining standards in production	kiểm soát chất lượng
amplify	v	/'æm.plɪ.faɪ/	to increase the strength or effect of something	khuếch đại, tăng cường

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Would you like to start a family business?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The prospect of starting a family business is one I find genuinely interesting rather than straightforwardly appealing, because the evidence on family businesses as both economic entities and relational systems is considerably more complex than the idealised version of family entrepreneurship that popular discourse tends to present. The economic case is moderately strong: family businesses have lower agency costs than non-family ones, because the alignment between ownership and management reduces the principal-agent problem that generates most of the monitoring and incentive costs of large corporations. The relational case is more fraught: the overlap between family relationships and professional authority structures creates specific tensions — around succession, performance management, and conflict resolution — that are significantly more difficult to manage than equivalent tensions in non-family organisations. My honest assessment is that I would find the entrepreneurial aspects of family business appealing but would need to think very carefully about which family members I would build it with and what governance mechanisms would manage the relational risks.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Starting a family business is something I have thought about seriously and will continue to evaluate against specific opportunities rather than as an abstract preference. The structural advantages of a well-designed family business — long-term orientation, strong relational capital, patient capital from family investors who understand the business deeply, and the motivational intensity that comes from equity in something you have built — are genuine and significant. The structural risks are equally genuine: undiversified human capital concentration (family members invested in both the business and in relationships with each other), the difficulty of separating family and professional authority, and the challenge of maintaining fair and effective performance management with people you also love. The businesses I have observed that manage these risks well are those that establish explicit governance structures early — separating family ownership from business management, creating clear decision-making protocols, and establishing norms for how business disputes will be resolved — rather than relying on goodwill and family cohesion that business pressure tends to erode.

2. Would you like to work for a family business?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Working for another family's business is a different proposition from working for one's own family business, and both are different from working for a large non-family corporation. The appeal is in the qualities that family businesses tend to have in greater abundance than large corporations: a clearer connection between individual contribution and organisational outcomes, more direct relationships with decision-makers, and a relational quality to the work environment that most large organisations cannot replicate. The risks are the specific dynamics of family governance: an employee who is not a family member operates in a context where some decisions will be made for non-meritocratic reasons, where succession is not primarily a question of professional capability, and where the informal power structures of family relationships can significantly complicate the formal professional ones. Whether

working in a specific family business would be a good choice depends almost entirely on the specific culture and governance of that family business — the generalisation is that the variance is very high.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The decision to work for a family business as a non-family professional is one that requires careful evaluation of a specific set of factors that are less relevant in non-family corporate contexts. The critical question is the nature of the relationship between family ownership and professional management: family businesses that have made a genuine commitment to professional management — where non-family managers have real authority, where performance is evaluated on professional rather than relational criteria, and where succession to non-family leadership is a real possibility — offer most of the advantages of the family business model without most of its governance risks for outside professionals. Family businesses where the family-professional boundary is ambiguous and where professional authority is consistently subordinated to family hierarchy offer significantly fewer attractions for an ambitious professional. Investigating this distinction carefully before joining is the most important due diligence that a professional considering a family business role can do.

3. Why do some people choose to start their own company?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The motivations for entrepreneurship are more varied than the dominant narrative — primarily economic opportunity and innovation — captures. Some people start companies primarily for autonomy: the desire to have genuine control over how they work, what they work on, and how they manage their time, which is systematically constrained in employment regardless of seniority. Some people start companies because they have identified a specific opportunity — a market gap, an unsolved problem, an underserved customer — and cannot see an existing organisation through which to address it effectively. Some people start companies because the alternative — continuing in unsatisfying employment — feels more risky in the deep sense of a life not well-used than the financial risk of entrepreneurship. And some people start companies because they want to build something that will outlast their professional career and carry their name and values forward.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The entrepreneurial motivation research distinguishes systematically between opportunity-driven and necessity-driven entrepreneurship: the former reflects a choice to pursue a specific opportunity that the founder believes they can convert into a valuable business; the latter reflects the absence of satisfactory employment alternatives. Both are legitimate and both produce successful businesses, but they are associated with different risk profiles and different personal characteristics. The most neglected dimension of entrepreneurial motivation in popular accounts is the organisational frustration explanation: a significant proportion of high-performing professionals who start their own companies do so primarily because their existing organisations are too slow, too risk-averse, or too politically complex to let them do the work they know needs doing — and entrepreneurship becomes the fastest available path to the quality of impact they are seeking. Understanding what is actually driving a potential founder's entrepreneurial impulse matters both for the founder's self-knowledge and for the investors and partners who are asked to share the risk.

4. What are the advantages and disadvantages of family businesses?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Family businesses have a distinctive profile of advantages and disadvantages that follows directly from the structure of family control and ownership rather than from any arbitrary feature of specific businesses. The core advantages are long-term orientation — family owners with generational investment in a business make decisions with longer time horizons than professional managers whose accountability is quarterly — and the lower agency costs that come from aligning ownership, control, and stakeholder interest in a way that non-family organisations cannot easily replicate. The core disadvantages are the governance risks that arise from conflating family relationships with professional authority: succession that follows family logic rather than capability logic, the difficulty of maintaining professional performance standards with relatives, and the risk that family conflict becomes business conflict in ways that non-family organisations can more easily contain.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The comparative performance of family businesses relative to non-family ones is one of the more robustly studied questions in business economics, and the findings are nuanced. Family businesses outperform non-family ones on long-run outcomes, particularly in contexts where relational capital, long-term investment, and stakeholder loyalty are primary competitive advantages — which describes many stable industrial and service sectors. They tend to underperform on innovation-intensive and rapid-growth metrics, where the patient capital and conservatism that produce long-run stability impede the risk tolerance that rapid change requires. The governance dimension is the most critical single determinant of whether a specific family business falls above or below the average: family businesses with professionalised governance — independent board members, professional management at appropriate levels, equity structures that don't conflate family membership with ownership rights — substantially outperform those without it.

5. What family businesses do you know in your local area?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The local economy in most Vietnamese urban areas is substantially constituted by family businesses operating across a wide range of sectors, and the specific character of each typically reflects both the sector's competitive dynamics and the particular family's accumulated knowledge. The most visible in my neighbourhood are restaurant and food businesses — often extending over two or three generations, with the founding generation's recipes and supplier relationships constituting the core competitive advantage and the second generation typically managing operations and service quality. Hardware, textiles, and small manufacturing operations also tend to be family-structured in Vietnamese local economies, reflecting the initial capital accumulation and supplier relationship patterns through which these industries historically developed. What I find most interesting about local family businesses is the specific form of embedded knowledge they represent: a third-generation restaurateur knows things about their local suppliers, their regular customers, and the specific demands of their neighbourhood that cannot be replicated by any outside competitor entering the same market.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Family businesses in Vietnamese local economies operate with a relational density — in supplier, customer, and community relationships — that is both their primary competitive

advantage and the feature of the model most difficult to transfer or replicate. The most robust and longest-established family businesses I know locally are those that have built genuine trust-based relationships across multiple stakeholder groups: they have long-term supplier relationships that provide preferential access in tight supply conditions, long-term customer relationships that produce loyalty through genuine knowledge of individual needs, and community relationships that generate referrals, goodwill, and the kind of social capital that reduces transaction costs across the full range of business activity. The challenge for the next generation of these businesses is maintaining these relational assets while simultaneously developing the operational and technological capacities that the competitive environment now requires.

6. What makes a successful family business?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The factors that consistently distinguish successful from unsuccessful family businesses are more institutional than personal — they are features of governance and structure rather than of character — which is an important and often underappreciated finding. The most critical structural factor is the quality of succession planning: family businesses that succeed across generations are those that plan succession early, develop successor capability intentionally rather than assuming it, and have governance mechanisms that allow succession to be based on capability rather than birth order or family politics. The second critical factor is the capacity to professionalise without losing the relational qualities that give family businesses their distinctive competitive advantage: implementing systems, processes, and governance structures that can carry the business through scale without replacing the relationship capital that early-stage success was built on.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The research on multi-generational family business success identifies a remarkably consistent set of enabling factors that cut across cultural and sectoral variation. The most important is what organisational researchers call the "employment of family cohesion"— the capacity to maintain strong family relationships while managing the inevitable conflicts that arise from the overlap of family and professional authority, which requires explicit governance systems rather than an assumption that family love will be sufficient. The second most important factor is strategic adaptability: the multi-generational family businesses with the best long-run records are those that have been willing to fundamentally change their business model in response to market change while maintaining continuity of the relational and reputational capital that their name represents. The businesses that fail across generations are typically those that conflate the specific form of their founding success — a particular product, market, or method — with the underlying capabilities that produced it.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
principal-agent problem	n phr		a conflict of interest between owners and hired managers	vấn đề ủy thác - đại lý
succession planning	n phr		preparing for the transition of leadership to the next generation	lập kế hoạch kế thừa
meritocratic	adj	/ˌmer.ɪ.təˈkræt.ɪk/	based on ability and performance rather than privilege	dựa trên năng lực
agency cost	n phr		costs resulting from the conflict of interest between owners and managers	chi phí đại lý
governance	n	/ˈɡʌv.ər.nəns/	the system by which an organisation is controlled and directed	quản trị (tổ chức)
relational capital	n phr		the value embedded in trusted relationships with stakeholders	vốn quan hệ
patient capital	n phr		long-term investment that does not demand quick returns	vốn kiên nhẫn, đầu tư dài hạn
stakeholder	n	/ˈsteɪk.həʊl.dər/	anyone with an interest in or affected by an organisation	các bên liên quan
embedded knowledge	n phr		expertise deeply rooted in context and relationships	tri thức nhúng/tiềm ẩn
undiversified	adj	/ˌʌn.dɑːˈvɜːsɪ.faɪd/	overly concentrated in one area without spreading risk	chưa đa dạng hoá

2.31 Describe a wild animal that you want to learn more about

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a wild animal that you want to learn more about. You should say:

- What it is
- When/where you saw it
- Why you want to learn more about it
- And explain what you want to learn more about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The animal I would describe is the Irrawaddy dolphin (**Orcaella brevirostris**), a species I have encountered twice — once on a boat trip along the Mekong near the Cambodian border and once, unexpectedly, from the shore of a small island in the Phú Quốc archipelago — and whose existence I find considerably more compelling the more I read about it.

What struck me initially was the physical oddness of the animal: it lacks the beak of the more familiar coastal dolphins, has a rounded, almost bulbous head, and moves with a peculiar rolling motion quite unlike the acrobatic behaviour I associated with dolphins from nature documentaries. The behaviour that most interested me on both sightings was the apparent deliberateness of the animal's surfacing: it seemed to orient toward the boat in a way that was neither fearful nor indifferent but something closer to curious, which raised a question I subsequently found is the subject of active research — whether Irrawaddy dolphins in the Mekong have a uniquely cooperative relationship with traditional fishermen in which they herd fish toward nets in exchange for access to the concentrated fish populations that nets create.

What I want to learn more about is precisely the ecology of that cooperative behaviour — how it is initiated, maintained, and whether it is transmitted culturally through dolphin populations — and also the conservation status of this species, which is listed as endangered in its riverine populations and about which I have read articles suggesting that the Mekong populations have declined to critically low numbers in the past two decades.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The animal I find most intellectually compelling is the clouded leopard (**Neofelis nebulosa**), which I first saw — briefly and at a distance — in a wildlife sanctuary in Nghệ An province during a work trip about five years ago, and which I have thought about periodically since then without having had the opportunity to properly investigate.

The clouded leopard's combination of extreme morphological specialisation and behavioural obscurity makes it both fascinating and extraordinarily difficult to study: it is primarily arboreal, strongly nocturnal, and inhabits some of the most topographically complex and inaccessible forest in mainland Southeast Asia and the Himalayan foothills, which means that almost everything known about its behaviour in the wild has been inferred from camera trap data and short-duration radio telemetry

studies rather than direct observation. The specific questions I want to understand better are those around its predatory ecology — what it actually hunts in different habitats, how it uses the forest’s three-dimensional structure for ambush, and whether its extraordinarily large canine teeth relative to skull size reflect a dietary specialisation distinct from other large felids.

The conservation concern is significant: the clouded leopard’s dependence on intact forest makes it highly sensitive to the forest fragmentation that is the dominant land-use change pressure across its range, and the populations in Vietnam are now considered critically small by most assessments, though the data is so limited that confident population estimates are not possible.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
arboreal	adj	/ɑː'boʊ.ri.əl/	living in or adapted to life in trees	sống trên cây
morphological	adj	/ˌmɔː.fə'lɒdʒ.ɪ.kəl/	relating to the form and structure of an organism	về hình thái học
telemetry	n	/tɪ'lem.ɪ.tri/	the process of remotely tracking animals via electronic devices	đo lường từ xa (theo dõi động vật)
felid	n	/'fiː.lɪd/	a member of the cat family (Felidae)	họ mèo
camera trap	n phr		a remotely triggered camera used to photograph wildlife	bẫy ảnh (thiết bị chụp ảnh động vật hoang dã)
riverine	adj	/'rɪv.ər.aɪn/	relating to or situated on a river	thuộc môi trường sông
endangered	adj	/ɪn'deɪn.dʒəd/	at serious risk of extinction	nguy cấp (về bảo tồn)
fragmentation	n	/ˌfræɡ.men'teɪ.ʃən/	the breaking up of a habitat into isolated patches	phân mảnh (sinh cảnh)
nocturnal	adj	/nɒk'tɜː.nəl/	active at night	hoạt động ban đêm
cooperative	adj	/kəʊ'ɒp.ər.ə.tɪv/	involving mutual effort between different parties	hợp tác, cùng làm

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Why should we protect wild animals?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for wild animal conservation rests on multiple distinct arguments that are stronger together than any single one is alone. The ecological argument is foundational:

wild animal species are embedded in ecosystem relationships — as predators, prey, seed dispersers, pollinators, and decomposers — that maintain the functional integrity of the ecosystems that produce the clean water, stable soil, flood regulation, and climate buffering that human civilisation depends upon. The extinction of species therefore involves not only the irreversible loss of the species itself but progressive degradation of the ecosystem services that the web of ecological relationships it participated in was producing. Any policy framework for conservation that addresses only the direct costs of species loss without accounting for the systemic ecological consequences of biodiversity decline will systematically underestimate what is actually at stake.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The economic case for wild animal conservation is more robust than its political weakness in most policy contexts suggests. Wild species represent biological capital — an inventory of proven evolutionary solutions to the problem of surviving in specific environments — whose value for pharmaceutical discovery, agricultural genetics, and materials science is large and incompletely explored; the loss of a species is the permanent deletion of that capital, which is irreversible in a way that most other forms of environmental damage are not. The ecosystem service valuation literature — which attempts to express the economic value of what functional ecosystems produce, from pollination to water purification to carbon sequestration — consistently finds that the total economic value of functioning biodiversity is very large relative to the direct costs of conservation, which makes the political failure to invest adequately in conservation one of the clearer examples of systematic market and policy failure in contemporary governance.

2. Why are some people more willing to protect wild animals than others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The variation in conservation concern across individuals reflects a well-documented set of psychological, cultural, and experiential differences rather than moral variation. Direct experience with nature is one of the most consistent predictors of conservation concern: people who have spent time in natural environments — who have actually seen wild animals, heard ecosystems functioning, noticed the difference between a biodiverse and a degraded landscape — are substantially more likely to have conservation concern than those whose experience of the natural world is primarily mediated by screens. Cultural frameworks matter significantly: cultures with traditions of human embeddedness in the natural world — in which nature is understood as something one belongs to rather than something one uses — tend to produce stronger baseline conservation dispositions than those organised around a more instrumental relationship between humans and the natural world.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The social psychology of conservation motivation identifies several consistent predictors of who is more likely to act on conservation concern, and understanding these offers important guidance for conservation communication strategy. Proximity and familiarity are significant: people are more motivated to protect species they have direct experience of or feel cultural connection to — the so-called “charismatic megafauna” effect, whereby large, visible, and anthropomorphically appealing species attract disproportionate conservation support relative to their ecological importance — than those that are scientifically important but experientially remote. Identity is also important: conservation concern is significantly higher among people whose sense of self is organised around a relationship with the natural world, which is shaped by early experience, socialization, and sustained exposure, rather than being a fixed trait.

3. Do you think it's important to take children to the zoo to see animals?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Zoo visits can be valuable for conservation education, but the value depends critically on the quality of the zoo and the quality of the educational experience, and the blanket claim that zoos are important for children's conservation connection is not well supported by the evidence. The evidence on what zoos actually produce in terms of lasting conservation attitudes in children is mixed: short-term visits to well-designed zoos with strong educational programming produce measurable increases in conservation knowledge and reported concern immediately after the visit, but long-term attitudinal effects are less consistent. The strongest argument for zoo visits is not wildlife knowledge but the provision of direct experience with non-human animals that most urban children would otherwise not have — and the quality of that experience depends far less on the size and variety of the collection than on the conditions in which the animals are kept and the pedagogical quality of the interpretation provided.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The zoo question warrants careful distinctions between different kinds of zoos and different kinds of educational goals, because the blanket advocacy and blanket condemnation of zoos that public discourse tends to produce both misrepresent the evidence. Contemporary accredited zoos with conservation breeding programmes, naturalistic habitat design, and sophisticated interpretation represent a very different institution from the collection-display model of twentieth-century zoological parks, and the evidence for their educational value is genuinely more positive than the evidence for the earlier model. The most defensible position is that high-quality zoo experiences — encounters with live wild animals in carefully designed environments with excellent interpretation — are among the most effective available tools for connecting children to conservation concern, and that the institutional standards required to make this true are both achievable and worth insisting upon as a condition of public and charitable support.

4. Why do some people attach more importance to protecting rare animals?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The disproportionate conservation attention devoted to rare and endangered species relative to common ones reflects both rational ecological reasoning and a set of psychological dynamics that sometimes diverge from ecological priority. The rational case is clear: the extinction of any species involves the irreversible loss of a unique evolutionary lineage and its ecological roles, and rarity itself is often a signal of ecological sensitivity — a species that has declined dramatically is usually doing so because the environmental conditions it depends upon have deteriorated in ways that threaten the broader ecosystem. The psychological dynamics are less straightforwardly rational: rarity activates the loss aversion response, in which the prospect of permanent loss triggers stronger motivation than equivalent ongoing harm to a common species — which is why the imminent extinction of a single charismatic species can mobilise resources that the slow degradation of a common species' habitat cannot.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Conservation priority-setting is one of the most contested areas of applied ecology, and the systematic prioritisation of rare and charismatic species over common but ecologically

important ones represents a genuine tension between what the science suggests matters most and what generates public support most effectively. Many of the species most important to ecosystem function are neither rare nor charismatic: common insects, abundant fungi, ubiquitous soil bacteria, and non-glamorous predators like wolves and large raptors perform ecological functions that rare flagship species cannot match in importance. The funding distortion produced by charisma bias — the systematic over-resourcing of flagship species conservation relative to their ecological importance — is a recognised problem in conservation science, and the recommended response is not to abandon flagship species communication but to use it strategically to fund broader ecosystem conservation that benefits both the flagship and the ecologically irreplaceable commons.

5. Should people educate children to protect wild animals?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Conservation education for children is broadly supported by evidence and intuitively defensible, but the specific form that education takes matters more than its presence or absence. Teaching children biological facts about endangered species — population numbers, range maps, threats — produces knowledge without necessarily producing the experiential and emotional connection to the natural world that motivates conservation behaviour. The most effective conservation education is that which develops children's relationship with living nature through direct, repeated, and unmediated experience — combined with the conceptual frameworks that help them understand what they are experiencing and why it matters — rather than that which delivers information about distant species in classroom settings. The latter can complement the former but should not be mistaken for an equivalent substitute.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for early conservation education rests on two related empirical findings: that environmental attitudes and behavioural dispositions toward the natural world are substantially formed in childhood and early adolescence, making early education a high-leverage intervention for long-term conservation culture; and that experiential nature contact in childhood is among the strongest predictors of adult conservation behaviour and support. The most productive form this education takes is not primarily the transmission of conservation science — though scientific literacy is a component — but the structured facilitation of children's encounter with and developing attachment to specific natural environments: local wildlife, accessible green spaces, and the particular species and ecosystems that children can develop genuine relationship with. The implication is that conservation education is most effective when it is embedded in place and rooted in direct experience rather than organised around global conservation narratives.

6. Is it more important to protect wild animals or the environment?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The framing of this question as a binary choice rests on a conceptual error: wild animals and the environments they depend upon are not separable conservation targets but aspects of a single integrated ecological system, and conservation interventions that protect one without the other are systematically less effective than those that address both simultaneously. An endangered species whose habitat is unprotected will continue to decline regardless of direct

species-level protection efforts; a protected habitat from which the functionally important species have been removed will be ecologically degraded even as it preserves the physical landscape. The most scientifically defensible conservation strategy is therefore ecosystem-level in its scope: protecting intact habitats that support the full community of species within them, while providing targeted protection for species whose population dynamics are most vulnerable to specific pressures.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The species versus habitat conservation debate has largely been resolved in the scientific literature in favour of habitat conservation as the foundation, with species-level interventions as supplements for the most critically threatened cases. The evidence is clear: the primary driver of the current global biodiversity crisis is habitat loss and degradation, which means that no amount of species-level conservation intervention — captive breeding, translocation, targeted protection — will stabilise biodiversity loss at scale if habitat destruction continues at its current rate. The practical implication for policy is that land use and development regulation, forest protection, and the management of agricultural expansion are more important conservation instruments than the species protection legislation that receives more political attention — though the latter is important for the most critically threatened populations and for the political visibility it provides to conservation as a public concern.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
biodiversity	n	/ˌbaɪ.əʊ.dɑː'vɜː.sɪ.ti/	the variety of living species in a habitat or on Earth	đa dạng sinh học
ecosystem services	n phr		the benefits that ecosystems provide to humans	dịch vụ hệ sinh thái
charismatic megafauna	n phr		large, appealing animals that attract public conservation attention	động vật lớn hấp dẫn (thu hút sự ủng hộ bảo tồn)
loss aversion	n phr		the tendency to feel losses more strongly than equivalent gains	ác cảm mất mát
translocation	n	/ˌtræns.lə'keɪ.ʃən/	the deliberate moving of species to new habitats for conservation	chuyển vị (di chuyển loài để bảo tồn)
captive breeding	n phr		the process of breeding wild animals in controlled environments	nhân giống trong điều kiện nuôi nhốt
flagship species	n phr		a high-profile species used to raise conservation awareness	loài biểu tượng bảo tồn
pollinator	n	/ˈpɒl.ɪ.neɪ.tər/	an animal that transfers pollen between plants	côn trùng thụ phấn
seed disperser	n phr		an animal that spreads plant seeds across habitats	vật phát tán hạt giống
carbon sequestration	n phr		the process of capturing and storing atmospheric carbon dioxide	hấp thụ carbon

2.32 Describe a time when you broke something

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a time when you broke something. You should say:

- What it was
- When/where that happened
- How you broke it
- And explain what you did after that.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The occasion I would describe is when I broke my grandmother's ceramic mortar — a heavy, pale-green object that she had used daily for as long as I could remember and that had, in retrospect, probably been in the household for two or three decades before the incident.

It happened during the school holidays when I was fourteen. I was helping to prepare ingredients in my grandmother's kitchen, was carrying the mortar from the storage shelf to the counter, and managed to clip it against the corner of the kitchen doorframe with enough force that it fractured cleanly into three pieces. The break was not ambiguous — the mortar was clearly beyond functional repair, and the sound of it hitting the stone floor was exceptional — and I stood with the pieces in my hands for longer than was sensible before accepting that there was nothing to be done about it. What I did was tell my grandmother immediately, which was harder than it sounds because I knew she had used the object every day and because the household did not have excess money for replacements. She was not angry in the way I expected — she said, more or less, that objects are things and things get broken, and made us go that afternoon to buy a replacement, which she let me choose. I have thought about that response fairly often since then, because it was quite a specific form of equanimity that I think most adults in that situation would not produce.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The episode I find most illustrative in the context of this question is not a physical object but a professional one: about four years into my career, I was responsible for a client presentation that I had prepared carefully but had slightly misread the scope of — and during the presentation I realised, about halfway through, that I was addressing a problem the client had already resolved with a different intervention and that half of my analysis was therefore redundant.

The discovery was jarring because I had invested significant time in the preparation, had brought two junior colleagues into the room, and was representing my organisation in a context where credibility matters. The right response — which I managed to produce, though not without considerable internal discomfort — was to acknowledge the gap clearly and without excessive apology, redirect to the portions of the analysis that were still relevant, and use the remaining time to understand the client's current challenge well enough to provide a useful response. What I did not do was attempt to salvage the irrelevant material by reframing it, which would have wasted their time and damaged credibility more than the honest acknowledgment.

What I learned from it was the specific professional skill of transparent recovery:

the ability to recognise a failure of preparation in real time, name it without self-flagellating, and refocus on the remaining value — which is a capacity that requires significant prior development of ego security to execute competently in high-stakes settings.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
mortar	n	/ˈmɔː.tər/	a bowl-shaped tool used for grinding substances	cối xay, cối giã
equanimity	n	/ˌek.wəˈnɪm.i.ti/	mental calmness in the face of difficulty	sự bình thản, bình tĩnh
redundant	adj	/rɪˈdʌn.dənt/	no longer needed or useful	thừa, không còn cần thiết
self-flagellating	adj	/ˌself.ˈflædʒ.ə.leɪ.tɪŋ/	excessively punishing or criticising oneself	tự trách mình thái quá
credibility	n	/ˌkred.ɪˈbɪl.i.ti/	the quality of being trusted or believed	uy tín, sự đáng tin cậy
salvage	v	/ˈsæl.vɪdʒ/	to save something from a damaging situation	vớt vát, cứu vãn
articulate	v	/ɑːˈtɪk.jʊ.leɪt/	to express ideas clearly and effectively	diễn đạt rõ ràng
ego security	n phr		a stable sense of self that is not threatened by failure	sự vững vàng về bản thân
transparent	adj	/trænsˈpær.ənt/	open and honest; easy to understand	minh bạch, thành thật
fractured	adj	/ˈfræk.tʃəd/	broken or cracked	bị vỡ, nứt gãy

1. What kind of things are more likely to be broken by people at home?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The objects most commonly broken in domestic settings are those that combine fragility, high handling frequency, and the specific form of inattention that familiarity produces. Ceramics and glassware — cups, bowls, plates, and drinking glasses — account for a disproportionate share of household breakage because they are used multiple times daily, are often handled while the mind is engaged elsewhere, and are inherently brittle under the lateral forces that dropping and clipping against hard surfaces produces. Electronic devices, particularly smartphones, follow a similar logic: they are carried constantly, are handled in an enormous range of conditions including physical activity and distraction, and have form factors — large, thin glass screens — that are structurally vulnerable to exactly the forces that habitual handling produces. The common thread is that objects are most frequently broken at the intersection of handling frequency and inattention rather than at the intersection of handling frequency and recklessness.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The domestic breakage pattern is largely predictable from a combination of material properties and handling contexts. Objects made from materials with low impact strength — glass, ceramic, and thin plastics — account for most breakage events by volume, because the physical forces associated with routine domestic handling — being set down on hard surfaces, clipped against edges, dropped from counter height — are sufficient to fracture them but not the more impact-resistant materials used in furniture, appliances, and structural elements. The most relevant observational finding is that most domestic breakage occurs not during exceptional events — dramatic accidents, rough play, major falls — but during entirely routine handling in contexts of divided attention: carrying something while distracted, moving quickly through constrained spaces, or operating in familiar environments where the automatic mode of processing has reduced the alertness that would prevent the mishap.

2. What kind of people like to fix things by themselves?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The tendency to repair rather than replace broken objects reflects a recognisable psychological profile that is associated with a set of values and characteristics that research on repair behaviour has documented reasonably well. People who prefer to fix things themselves tend to have higher scores on curiosity and openness to experience — they are interested in understanding how things work, which makes the repair context attractive as a form of applied problem-solving — and higher tolerance for the specific frustration of operating at the limit of one's technical competence. They also tend to have a stronger connection to the objects they own — a preference for objects as repositories of use and history rather than as fungible commodities — which makes the psychological cost of replacing an object proportionally higher than for those with a more transactional relationship to their possessions.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The self-repair tendency is more complex in its professional correlates than its popular characterisation as a personality type suggests. The research on repair behaviour in domestic contexts identifies two distinct motivational orientations that produce the same behaviour for different reasons: a mastery orientation — the intrinsic satisfaction derived from developing and applying technical skill — and an economic or environmental values orientation, in

which repair is valued because it conserves resources that replacement would waste. The professional contexts that most strongly develop the mastery orientation are those involving engineering, craft, making, and applied technical work of any kind; the values orientation is more strongly associated with environmental concern and with economic constraints. The two motivational profiles overlap substantially in the repair-positive population but they respond to different kinds of encouragement and are sustained by different reinforcement mechanisms.

3. Do you think clothes produced in the factory are of better quality than those made by hand?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The factory versus handmade quality comparison is one that requires careful definition of "quality" before it can be meaningfully answered, because the two production modes optimise for different dimensions of quality rather than competing on the same ones. Factory production excels at dimensional consistency, material uniformity, and the specific quality of precision fit that standardised pattern-making and industrial cutting machines produce: a well-made factory garment will have seams of identical width, consistent grain alignment, and tolerances that hand-sewing rarely achieves at speed. Handmade garments can offer superior quality in the dimensions of material selection — the maker can choose precisely the weight and composition best suited to the garment's purpose — construction tailoring to a specific body rather than a standardised size, and the use of construction techniques that are too time-intensive for factory production but produce superior durability and finish.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The quality comparison between industrial and artisanal production in garment making is most usefully framed through the lens of which quality attributes each production mode is best equipped to optimise. Industrial production's quality advantages are in the scale-dependent attributes: the consistency of component specification, the precision of machinery-executed construction, and the quality assurance systems that large-scale production makes economically viable. Artisanal production's quality advantages are in the individual-dependent attributes: the fit customisation that bespoke tailoring provides, the material and construction choices that an individual maker can optimise for a specific garment and wearer, and the construction depth — the internal structure of careful hand-finishing — that industrial production has systematically eliminated to achieve its cost and speed advantages. The highest-quality garments in any objective sense are typically those that combine industrial material processing with artisanal construction: the best of each mode rather than a choice between them.

4. Do you think handmade clothes are more valuable?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The value of handmade clothes is not well captured by a simple comparison with factory alternatives, because handmade garments carry forms of value — cultural, artisanal, and relational — that factory production cannot produce regardless of its technical sophistication. The economic value — market price — of genuinely handmade garments from skilled makers is typically substantially higher than factory equivalents, because the labour content is high and the skill required is not easily or quickly acquired. Beyond economic value, handmade

garments often carry a form of cultural value — as bearers of specific craft traditions, regional techniques, and aesthetic knowledge accumulated over generations — that is entirely independent of their material quality and that becomes more significant as those traditions become scarcer relative to the mass-produced alternative.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The valuation of handmade clothing in contemporary market contexts reflects a complex interaction between quality perception, cultural meaning, scarcity, and the specific form of authenticity that industrial production cannot replicate. The luxury goods research is clear that consumers attach significant non-utilitarian value to goods perceived as crafted by skilled individual makers — the provenance, the maker's identity and tradition, and the evidence of skilled human labour in the object — in a way that persists even when objective quality difference from high-end industrial production is small or absent. This authenticity premium is most pronounced for culturally significant craft traditions — Vietnamese áo dài made by master tailors, Japanese kimono from traditional weavers — where the handmade object is a bearer of cultural knowledge and continuity that its industrial substitute is not.

5. Is the older generation better at fixing things?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The popular perception that older generations are more capable of repairing things than younger ones is substantially accurate as an empirical pattern but requires careful explanation to avoid misattributing the cause. The repair competence advantage of older generations is primarily a product of historical context rather than generational character: people who grew up in conditions of material scarcity — where repair was economically necessary, where consumer culture had not yet made replacement systematically cheaper than repair, and where the skills of maintenance and fixability were embedded in daily life — acquired repair skills as a matter of practical necessity that younger people growing up in conditions of relative material abundance and planned obsolescence have not had equivalent reason to develop. As economic and material conditions change, the repair skills gap is more likely to reflect the different learning contexts of different periods than any genuine generational difference in aptitude or inclination.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The generational repair competence difference is real but its causes are more instructive than the gap itself. Research on skill acquisition shows that practical repair competence is almost entirely learned rather than innate, and that it is most effectively developed through early exposure to maintained objects, parental and community modelling of repair behaviour, and the specific economic and material conditions that make repair seem worthwhile. The generation that grew up in Vietnam during the post-war period of material shortage and before the proliferation of cheap imported consumer goods had all of these conditions; the subsequent generation has had progressively fewer of them. The more interesting question is whether the repair skills gap reflects a permanent cultural shift or a reversible one: the emerging environmental sustainability movement, the right-to-repair advocacy in consumer electronics policy, and the cultural interest in craft and making among younger urban populations suggest that the conditions for repair culture may be partly recovering.

6. Do you think elderly people should teach young people how to fix things?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The transmission of practical repair skills from older to younger generations has both immediate instrumental value — the specific skills transferred — and a broader significance as a form of intergenerational knowledge transfer that is in decline in most urban societies. The instrumental argument is clear: repair skills reduce material waste, extend object lifespans, and provide economic benefits that become particularly significant in periods of financial constraint or environmental pressure. The broader significance is that practical skill transmission between generations is one of the most relationship-building and dignity-affirming forms of intergenerational contact available: it reverses the typical dynamic in which the older generation is positioned as the recipient of younger-generation assistance, and creates a context in which older adults' accumulated practical knowledge has direct and visible value in the contemporary lives of younger people.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for intergenerational repair skill transmission is well-established both instrumentally and relationally, but the practical question of how to structure it effectively deserves more attention than the advocacy literature typically provides. Skills transfer between generations is most effective when it is embedded in genuine collaborative practice rather than structured as formal instruction: elderly makers and repairers teaching in the context of actual repair work — in community repair cafes, in household maintenance contexts, in school-based making programmes — transfer skills more effectively than in classroom-style instruction, because repair skill is substantially tacit, meaning it is acquired through embodied practice and observation rather than through verbal explanation alone. The institutional design question is therefore how to create contexts that bring generations into genuine collaborative practical engagement around maintenance and repair, which are available in more forms — community workshops, school-based programmes, community centre facilities — than the discourse about its importance usually acknowledges.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
tacit knowledge	n phr		knowledge that is difficult to transfer through words, learned through practice	tri thức âm tính/ngầm hiểu
planned obsolescence	n phr		designing products to fail or become unfashionable quickly	lỗi thời có kế hoạch
repair cafe	n phr		a community space where volunteers help repair broken items	quán sửa chữa cộng đồng
intergenerational	adj	/ˌɪn.tə.dʒen.ə'reɪ.jən.	relating to or involving people of different generations	liên thế hệ
artisanal	adj	/ɑ:'tɪz.ə.nəl/	made in a traditional, skilled way using non-industrial methods	thủ công mỹ nghệ
provenance	n	/'prɒv.ɪ.nəns/	the place of origin or history of an object	xuất xứ, nguồn gốc
bespoke	adj	/br'spəʊk/	made to order for a specific person; custom-built	đặt riêng, may đo riêng
right-to-repair	n phr		a policy movement giving consumers the right to repair their own devices	quyền được sửa chữa
brittle	adj	/'brɪt.əl/	hard but likely to break easily	giòn, dễ vỡ
fungible	adj	/'fʌn.dʒɪ.bəl/	interchangeable; replaceable by another identical item	có thể thay thế lẫn nhau

2.33 Describe an important old thing that your family has kept for a long time

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe an important old thing that your family has kept for a long time. You should say:

- What it is
- How/when your family first got this thing
- How long your family has kept it
- And explain why this thing is important to your family.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The object I would describe is a black-and-white photograph — mounted in a wooden frame that is visibly older than I am — of my great-grandparents on what appears to be their wedding day, which has hung in the main room of my grandparents' house for as long as any living member of our family can remember.

The photograph was taken sometime in the late 1950s in a provincial town in the north, and while the photographic quality is limited by the technology and conditions of the period, what it captures is clear: two young people in formal attire, looking toward the camera with an expression that I have always found slightly difficult to read — formal, certainly, but not without the specific kind of seriousness that people adopt when they understand that the moment is being permanently recorded. My grandmother has told me that the photograph survived several relocations, including one during a period of significant difficulty in the family's history, because it was the one object my great-grandmother specifically asked to have with her when the family moved.

What makes it important to our family is partly the direct historical connection — these are people whom some of us knew and all of us are descended from — and partly the specific way it functions as an anchor for family narrative: when we look at it together, particularly across generations, it occasions the kind of storytelling about who these people were, what their circumstances were like, and how the family came from there to here that I think is one of the most important things that material objects can do for family cohesion.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The object I would describe is a silk merchant's ledger book from the early twentieth century that belongs to my family on my father's side — a hand-written account book from the family's textile trading business in Hôi An that covers a period of roughly fifteen years and which my family has kept across at least four generations and three major relocations.

The book is not fragile in the way a photographic print is: it was made to be used and has the particular durability of objects designed to withstand daily handling — the paper is dense and has aged to a warm ochre, the ink, while faded, is still fully legible, and the calligraphic handwriting of whoever maintained it is precise and confident. What it contains — columns of transactions, names of trading partners, notes in the margins in a hand that might be different from the main entries — is both economically

interesting (the commodities, routes, and prices it records are genuinely informative about regional trade in that period) and personally significant: there are family names in the transaction records that we can trace to relatives still living in the Hội An area. My family has kept it because it is one of the few material traces of what the family was doing and who they were dealing with before the various disruptions of the twentieth century severed so many of those connections — and because my grandfather, who is trained as a historian, has been gradually transcribing and annotating it for the past decade as a project of both family and local history.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
ledger	n	/ˈledʒ.ər/	a book for recording financial transactions	sổ cái, sổ kế toán
calligraphic	adj	/ˌkæl.ɪˈɡræf.ɪk/	relating to artistic, decorative handwriting	thuộc thư pháp
ochre	n/adj	/ˈəʊ.kə/	a yellowish-brown colour; an earthy pigment	màu vàng nâu đất
transcribe	v	/trænˈskraɪb/	to put written or spoken material into another form	sao chép, chép lại (văn bản)
cohesion	n	/kəʊˈhiː.ʒən/	the quality of forming a unified whole	sự gắn kết
attire	n	/əˈtaɪər/	clothing, especially formal or distinctive clothing	trang phục (thường trang trọng)
material trace	n phr		a physical object that serves as evidence of past existence	dấu vết vật chất
relocation	n	/ˌriː.ləʊˈkeɪ.ʃən/	the act of moving from one place to another	sự di chuyển, tái định cư
annotate	v	/ˈæn.ə.teɪt/	to add explanatory notes to a text or document	chú thích, ghi chú bổ sung
anchor	n/v	/ˈæŋ.kər/	something that provides stability or a fixed point of reference	mỏ neo; điểm neo (ẩn dụ)

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What kind of old things do people in your country like to keep?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The objects that Vietnamese families typically retain across generations tend to cluster in a few recognisable categories that reflect both cultural values and the specific domestic material culture of the country. Photographs are among the most universally kept objects: family photographs — particularly of ancestors, wedding occasions, and significant family milestones — function as the primary material support for family memory and ancestor veneration, and are typically displayed prominently rather than stored. Religious and ceremonial objects — ancestral altars and their associated implements, incense burners, ceremonial vessels — are kept both for their continued ritual function and for their connection to the family's religious history. Practical objects that embody significant craft or material quality — lacquerware, silk textiles, ceramic pieces, traditional tools — are retained both for use and for their representative quality as markers of a family's material history and aesthetic sensibility.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The category of objects retained across generations in Vietnamese families reflects the intersection of cultural values, material durability, and the specific historical experience of the twentieth century — which created selection pressure on what was preserved, since many families experienced periods in which only the most portable and most valued objects survived major transitions. Ancestral photographs and portrait paintings are among the most consistently retained categories because of their central role in the ancestor veneration practices that remain important across a wide range of Vietnamese households. Documents with legal or economic significance — land deeds, business records, official correspondence — are retained as both practical resources and historical records. And objects of high craft quality — particularly those associated with traditional industries in which the family had connection: silk weaving, lacquer craft, ceramics, silversmithing — are retained as both aesthetic objects and markers of family occupational history.

2. Why do people keep old things?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The motivations for keeping old objects are considerably more varied and psychologically complex than the simple sentimental account suggests. The most basic function of retained objects is mnemonic: they serve as material triggers for episodic memory — the specific, personal, situated memories of people, events, and places — that tend to be activated more effectively by encounter with a physical object than by verbal description or photographic representation alone. Beyond their mnemonic function, old objects perform an important identity function: they constitute the material dimension of family and personal narrative, providing a temporal depth to present identity that connects it to specific people, places, and histories rather than leaving it entirely in the present. Objects also function as bonds between living and deceased family members — a particular function in cultures with strong ancestor veneration practices — materialising a relationship that is otherwise only sustained through memory and ritual.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of why people retain old objects is best approached through the lens of what functions those objects perform that cannot be as effectively served by photographs, documents, or verbal narrative. The most important is the haptic and sensory vividness of physical encounter: holding an object that a deceased grandparent used daily — feeling its weight, its texture, the wear patterns of its use — produces a form of connection that representational media cannot replicate, because it is the same physical object that the other person actually touched. Old objects also perform an intergenerational communication

function: they carry implicit information about the aesthetic preferences, practical priorities, and material circumstances of the people who made, acquired, and used them that verbal accounts rarely fully convey. For families with significant historical disruptions — which describes a substantial proportion of Vietnamese families — retained old objects carry an additional significance as physical evidence of continuity across breaks that might otherwise feel total.

3. What are the differences between the things old people keep and those young people keep?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The differences in what older and younger people retain reflect a combination of lifecycle stage, the different temporal horizons within which each generation operates, and the material culture changes that have occurred across their lifetimes. Older people's retained objects tend to be more durably physical — ceramics, textiles, furniture, photographs printed on paper — and their retention logic is more explicitly memorial and relational: they keep things because of who owned them, who gave them, or what events they are associated with. Younger people's retained objects — to the extent that they retain physical objects at all — tend to reflect a more experiential rather than relational retention logic: concert tickets, travel souvenirs, objects from specific experiences or periods of life that represent the bearer's developing sense of identity and personal history rather than the family narrative that tends to organise older people's retention choices.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The generational difference in retention patterns is substantially a difference in what category of objects is felt to carry sufficient meaning to warrant the physical and cognitive costs of keeping. Older adults' retention portfolios are characterised by the depth of memorial association: the objects they keep tend to be those whose significance is embedded in specific relationships and events, and whose loss would feel like the loss of something genuinely irreplaceable. Younger adults' retention portfolios, in a context of digital media and subscription-based consumption, are characterised more by the exceptionality of the object in a material landscape of prevalent interchangeability: things that were made or selected with evident individual care, things that are handcrafted or artisanal, or things with a clear and specific personal provenance stand out in a consumption context that makes most objects experientially equivalent.

4. What are the differences between the things that people keep today and the things that people kept in the past?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The difference between contemporary and past retained objects reflects primarily the massive change in the material landscape of everyday life that mass manufacture and digital technology have produced. People in previous generations retained objects that were scarce, expensive to replace, or representative of significant craft investment — objects whose material quality gave them permanent value independent of their sentimental associations — because the material conditions of their time made replacement costly and quality differentiation high. Contemporary retention is more likely to be driven by sentimental association in a context where most functional objects are neither scarce nor expensive to replace: the mass-

manufactured object has no intrinsic reason to be retained because its functional equivalent is cheap and readily available, so what gets retained is what has personal or relational significance rather than what has intrinsic material value.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The most significant structural difference between past and present retention patterns is the emergence of digital objects as a new category of personal memory container that competes with physical objects for the psychological role of life documentation and memory anchoring. People in past generations had no choice but to organise personal memory around physical objects — photographs, letters, diaries, keepsakes — because no other medium was available for persistent personal documentation. Contemporary people have the option of storing vast quantities of documentation digitally at negligible cost, which has substantially reduced the role of physical objects as primary memory media. The interesting consequence is that physical objects retained today are more clearly chosen — selected from a much larger available set because of specific significance rather than because they were the only available documentation — which paradoxically makes the retained objects of the digital age more specifically meaningful than those of past generations, whose retention often reflected availability as much as significance.

5. What can we see in a museum?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The contemporary museum encompasses a substantially wider range of content and institutional purpose than its traditional public conception as a repository of historical artefacts captures. In history and archaeology museums — the most traditional category — visitors encounter material evidence of past human life: the objects, documents, architectural fragments, and art of previous periods, organised to support understanding of how people in the past lived, worked, believed, and made. In science and natural history museums, visitors encounter specimens, models, and interactive installations that support understanding of the natural world — its physical processes, its biological diversity, and the scientific methods through which it has been investigated. In art museums, visitors encounter works organised to support aesthetic and interpretive engagement with human creative production across periods, cultures, and media.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The museum as a cultural institution is undergoing a significant reconceptualisation in the contemporary period, as institutions engage with questions about whose history is represented, how collections acquired in colonial or unequal contexts should be curated and potentially repatriated, and how digital technology changes the relationship between museums and their publics. The most sophisticated contemporary museums present not only their collections but the curatorial frameworks through which those collections have been selected, organised, and interpreted — making visible the choices and power relations behind what is displayed and how it is contextualised. This reflexive curation produces a qualitatively different visitor experience from the traditional mode of authoritative display: it invites critical engagement with the institution's own knowledge-production practices rather than passive reception of established interpretations.

6. What can we learn from a museum?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The learning that museums make possible is more various than the common reduction of museum learning to historical information conveys. The most distinctive thing museums can provide — that other educational formats cannot replicate — is encounter with original material objects: the specific experience of being in the presence of a thing rather than a representation of a thing, which produces a form of historical and aesthetic engagement that photographs, texts, and digital representations cannot fully substitute for. Beyond information, the best museums support the development of interpretive and analytical skills — the ability to read objects as evidence, construct arguments from material culture, and evaluate competing historical interpretations — which are forms of reasoning that have broad transferability to contexts beyond the museum.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional and educational case for museums rests primarily on what they uniquely provide: access to original material objects and specimens in a context of expert curation and interpretation, combined with the spatial and temporal experience of moving through organised historical and aesthetic content that digital alternatives cannot fully replicate. The most important cognitive skills developed through sustained museum engagement are those of material culture analysis: the ability to infer information about past people and societies from the objects they made and used, to recognise geographic, temporal, and cultural style in material evidence, and to construct and evaluate evidence-based historical arguments. These skills are foundational to historical thinking, archaeological reasoning, and a range of professional disciplines — including design, conservation, heritage management, and journalism — that depend on the ability to read the material world as a source of evidence and meaning.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
mnemonic	adj/n	/nɪ'mɒn.ɪk/	relating to memory or memory aids	ghi nhớ, thuộc trí nhớ
haptic	adj	/'hæp.tɪk/	relating to the sense of touch	xúc giác
ancestor veneration	n phr		the cultural practice of honouring deceased relatives	thờ cúng tổ tiên
artefact	n	/'ɑː.tɪ.fækt/	an object made or modified by human beings, especially one of historical interest	hiện vật, đồ tạo tác
curatorial	adj	/ˌkjʊər.ə'tɔː.ri.əl/	relating to the selection and organisation of a collection	thuộc quản lý bộ sưu tập
repatriate	v	/ˌriː'pæt.ri.ət/	to return cultural objects to their country of origin	hồi hương (hiện vật văn hoá)
material culture	n phr		the physical objects and artefacts that characterise a society	văn hoá vật chất
reflexive	adj	/rɪ'flek.sɪv/	characterised by reflection on one's own processes	phản tư, tự nhận thức
episodic memory	n phr		memory of specific personal events and experiences	trí nhớ sự kiện (ký ức cụ thể)
keepsake	n	/'kiːp.seɪk/	a small object kept as a reminder of a person or event	vật kỷ niệm

2.34 Describe a good friend who is important to you

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a good friend who is important to you. You should say:

- Who he/she is
- How/where you got to know him/her
- How long you have known each other
- And explain why he/she is important to you.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The friend I would describe is Phương — a classmate I met on the first day of university orientation, now in our third year — who has become the person I am most consistently honest with and whose judgment I trust most reliably among everyone I know at this stage of my life.

We met in the queue for registration, struck up a conversation because we had both misread the timetable in the same way, and discovered — over subsequent weeks of sharing the same seminars — that we had a compatible but not identical intellectual temperament: we are both interested in ideas and argumentative in our engagement with them, but our areas of most serious interest are different enough that we push each other rather than simply reinforcing the same positions. Phương studies urban planning; I study economics; we have argued about the relationship between economic and spatial thinking in urban development for three years with neither of us winning definitively, which both of us considers a sign the discussion is worthwhile.

What makes her important to me specifically is a quality that I have come to understand is rare: she is able to disagree with me — about ideas, about decisions I am considering, about judgments I have made — in a way that is genuinely critical without being unkind, and that consistently makes my thinking better without making me feel worse about myself. I have had other close friends, but I have not previously had a friendship whose primary dynamic was intellectual mutual improvement, and I find I value that beyond almost anything else a friendship could provide at this point in my life.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The friend I would describe is Hùng — we have known each other for eleven years, having first met as junior colleagues in the same government ministry — and I would describe him as the person who has most consistently told me what I most needed to hear at the times when I was most reluctant to hear it, which is a capacity I have come to regard as one of the highest forms of friendship.

We have stayed close through two job changes each, his marriage, the birth of his two children, my own career transitions, and a period of significant personal difficulty about four years ago during which I relied on his judgment in a way that I could not have relied on anyone else's — partly because he understood the professional context from the inside, and partly because he has a form of practical wisdom that is very difficult to describe but consistently produces the right question at the right moment. What distinguishes him from other close colleagues I have had is that his interest in my wellbeing is independent of his interest in any professional benefit our friendship

might provide: he is as direct with me about personal matters as professional ones, and he engages with the same quality of attention and care in both.

I have thought about what makes certain friendships more important than others, and the best account I have arrived at is that the most important friendships are those where the other person is genuinely invested in your development as a person rather than merely in the continuation of the relationship — and Hùng is, in that sense, the person who has most consistently contributed to who I am becoming rather than simply accompanying who I already was.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
intellectual temperament	n phr		one's characteristic style of thinking and engaging with ideas	tính khí trí tuệ
relying on judgment	v phr		trusting another person's reasoning in a decision	dựa vào sự phán đoán của ai
mutual improvement	n phr		a two-way process of helping each other develop	cải tiến lẫn nhau
forthright	adj	/ˈfɔːθ.rart/	direct and outspoken, especially about difficult truths	thẳng thắn, dám nói thật
integrity	n	/ɪnˈteg.rɪ.ti/	the quality of being honest and having strong moral principles	chính trực
solidarity	n	/ˌsɒl.ɪˈdær.i.ti/	unity and support within a group	sự đoàn kết
reinforce	v	/ˌriːɪnˈfɔːs/	to strengthen or support an existing idea	củng cố, tăng cường
practical wisdom	n phr		the ability to make sound decisions in complex real-world situations	trí tuệ thực hành
vulnerable	adj	/ˈvʌl.nərə.ə.bəl/	open to emotional harm or in need of support	dễ tổn thương
invested in	adj phr		genuinely interested in and committed to someone's wellbeing	quan tâm thật sự đến

1. How do children make friends at school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Children's school-based friendship formation follows a set of mechanisms that are reasonably well understood developmentally and that differ meaningfully from adult friendship formation. The most basic mechanism is proximity: children form friendships with the people they are physically near most consistently — classmates they share a desk with, children assigned to the same group or team — and the friendship-forming potential of this initial proximity depends on whether subsequent interaction produces a sense of similarity or complementarity that sustains engagement. In early childhood, shared activity is the primary bonding mechanism: children become friends by playing together, by sharing materials and space in ways that require cooperation, and by the repeated positive interaction that sustained proximity and shared activity produces. As children move into middle childhood, shared interests and values become progressively more important alongside proximity, beginning the transition toward the interest-based friendship formation that characterises adult social networks.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The school environment creates a distinctive friendship formation context — defined by sustained proximity, structured shared activity, and a relatively fixed peer group over time — that produces a characteristically different friendship quality from those formed in most adult contexts. The research on childhood friendship consistently finds that school-based friendships are the most common site of the development of social skills that persist into adult life: the skills of managing disagreement without terminating a relationship, of negotiating competing preferences within ongoing cooperation, and of maintaining a relationship through periodic conflict — all of which require the time depth and repeated encounter that school friendships provide. What schools contribute that most other childhood environments do not is the relative permanence of the social group: the fact that the same children encounter each other repeatedly over years creates conditions for the development of trust and the repair of relationship ruptures that less stable social environments cannot provide.

2. How do children make friends when they are not at school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Out-of-school friendship formation in children is more diverse in its mechanisms and more variable in its outcomes than school-based friendship formation because the structured environment that makes school friendships relatively predictable is absent. The most significant out-of-school friendship contexts are neighbourhood-based play — which is significantly less common than it was for previous generations, due to changes in how children's unstructured time is managed and to reduced parental comfort with unsupervised outdoor activity — and organised activities: sports clubs, music groups, hobby classes, and community organisations that bring children with shared interests into repeated contact. Digital contexts have introduced a new and expanding friendship formation environment for older children and adolescents: online gaming, social media, and interest-based online communities create the shared activity and repeated interaction that produce friendships even without physical co-presence, though the developmental consequences of friendships formed primarily in digital rather than physical contexts remain incompletely understood.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The out-of-school friendship ecology of contemporary children differs substantially from that of previous generations in two major ways: the decline of unstructured neighbourhood

play and the rise of organised activities as the primary non-school social context. Both shifts reflect the same underlying change in how children's time is structured by parents — a move toward supervised, scheduled activity and away from the self-organised, semi-supervised outdoor play that characterised childhood in earlier decades. The developmental consequence of this shift is potentially significant: unstructured play, particularly mixed-age outdoor play, produced friendship skills — including the management of disagreement, the negotiation of rules, and the experience of social exclusion and recovery — that organised activities, which are typically adult-supervised and rule-governed, develop less effectively. The adult generation that most benefited from the older model has a responsibility to think carefully about what the structured activities it substitutes are and are not developing.

3. Do you think it is better for children to have a few close friends or many casual friends?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The research on childhood friendship quality versus quantity is relatively clear in its broad finding: the developmental benefits of friendship for children are more strongly associated with the quality of a small number of close relationships than with the quantity of casual ones. One or two genuine close friendships — characterised by mutual understanding, reliable support, honest communication, and the capacity to manage conflict without terminating the relationship — produce more substantial developmental benefits for self-esteem, emotional regulation, and social skill than a larger network of more superficial connections. The important qualification is that close friendship and broad social inclusion serve different developmental functions: close friendships develop the deep dyadic skills (conflict management, intimacy, trust-building), while broader social inclusion develops the group social skills (reading social cues, managing impression, navigating complex group dynamics) that children also need.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The adult professional perspective on childhood friendship quantity versus quality is that both serve distinct developmental functions, but that the contemporary educational and parenting culture has tended to prioritise broad social popularity over close friendship depth in ways that may not be developmentally optimal. The research on adult social wellbeing identifies the quality and reliability of a small number of close relationships as the strongest predictor of subjective wellbeing and psychological health — more important than the size of social networks, financial security, or professional achievement — which suggests that the skill of forming and sustaining deep relationships is more developmentally important than the skill of maintaining a large social network. The implication is that parents and educators who help children invest in fewer, deeper relationships rather than maximising social breadth are probably making the better developmental choice, even when broader popularity is more socially visible and celebrated.

4. Do you think a child's relationship with friends can be replaced by that with other people, like parents or other family members?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Peer friendships in childhood serve developmental functions that parent-child and family relationships cannot fully substitute for, which is the strongest argument against the view that parental closeness can replace peer friendship. The most critical of these peer-specific

functions is the experience of a relationship between equals: unlike parent-child or sibling relationships, which are inherently unequal in power, experience, and developmental status, peer friendships provide the experience of negotiating with someone who has approximately equivalent power, knowledge, and needs — a context that develops the specific skills of horizontal relationship management that family relationships do not. A second peer-specific function is the experience of voluntary rather than ascribed relationship: peer friendship is a relationship that must be created and sustained through mutual choice rather than maintained by biological or institutional bond, which introduces a developmental challenge — the risk of rejection, the need to offer something worth a peer's voluntary investment — that family relationships do not provide in the same form.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The developmental psychology research is clear that peer and family relationships serve distinct and non-substitutable functions in children's social development, and that deficits in either type produce characteristic developmental consequences rather than simply reduced social experience. Children who have strong family relationships but limited or absent peer friendships tend to develop strong skills of vertical relationships (relationships with authority, with parents, with older people) but weaker skills of horizontal relationships (between peers and equals), which creates a specific social competence profile that tends to create challenges in adult peer and professional relationships. Conversely, children with rich peer relationships and weaker family attachment develop different competence profiles with different characteristic vulnerabilities. The developmental ideal is completion of both relational contexts rather than prioritisation of either.

5. What are the differences between friends made inside and outside the workplace?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Workplace friendships and out-of-work friendships are formed in such different contexts and serve such different functions that comparing them on a single quality axis substantially misrepresents the situation. Workplace friendships are typically initiated by the proximity and shared purpose of professional collaboration: people become friendly with colleagues because they work together regularly, share professional challenges, and develop mutual understanding of domain-specific knowledge and experience that non-colleagues cannot easily share. Out-of-work friendships, formed through shared interest, neighbourhood, or social occasion, tend to be based on voluntary affinity rather than imposed proximity — the friendship is chosen rather than emerged, which produces a different kind of commitment and a somewhat different quality of investment. The practical consequence is that workplace friendships tend to be more contextually specific and more vulnerable to professional changes (transfers, departures, role changes) than friendships formed outside professional settings.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Workplace friendships are often underestimated as a source of genuine relationship depth because they are assumed to be primarily instrumental — useful within the professional context and shallow outside it. The research on workplace wellbeing consistently finds that having at least one close friend at work is one of the strongest predictors of employee engagement and job satisfaction, and that the shared professional challenge that workplace friendships are built around creates a specific form of mutual understanding and bonding that voluntarily-formed friendships rarely achieve. The most durable workplace friendships tend to be those that have been tested by professional difficulty — shared failure, difficult projects, periods of organisational uncertainty — and survived: the adversarial bonding

dynamic produces a form of mutual trust that is harder to develop in less challenging social contexts.

6. Do you think it's possible for bosses and their employees to become friends?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Genuine friendship between leaders and their direct reports is possible but structurally more difficult to develop and sustain than friendship between peers, because the power differential that defines the professional relationship creates specific asymmetries that genuine friendship requires partially transcending. The difficulty is not primarily attitudinal — most people understand the conceptual distinction between professional authority and personal friendship — but structural: the boss makes decisions that affect the employee's livelihood, evaluates their performance, and controls consequences for their behaviour, which creates an interest-alignment problem that makes the candour and equality fundamental to genuine friendship genuinely difficult to maintain. The cases where boss-employee friendship works tend to be those where the power is exercised transparently and fairly enough that the employee trusts the professional relationship outside the friendship, and where both parties maintain clear enough boundaries that the friendship does not produce either favouritism or inhibition of honest professional feedback.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The boss-employee friendship question is one I have navigated directly, and the honest professional answer is that genuine friendship is possible but requires more deliberate management than friendship between peers and carries higher risk of complication when the professional relationship changes. The fundamental tension is that genuine friendship requires mutual candour — including the ability to be honest about one's own failures, insecurities, and ambivalences — which is structurally more difficult when one person has formal authority over the other's career. My practical experience is that the friendships between leaders and their reports that work best are those where the professional relationship is clean — where authority is exercised fairly and consistently, where evaluation processes are transparent, and where neither party attempts to use the friendship to circumvent professional norms — rather than those where the friendship is used to substitute for professional clarity.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
dyadic	adj	/daɪ'æd.ɪk/	relating to a pair or two-person relationship	thuộc quan hệ đôi (hai người)
ascribed	adj	/ə'skraɪbd/	assigned based on birth or social category, not earned	được gán theo (xuất thân, không phải nỗ lực)
voluntary affinity	n phr		a connection chosen freely rather than assigned by circumstance	sự gắn kết tự nguyện
candour	n	/'kæn.dər/	the quality of being open, frank, and honest	sự thẳng thắn, thành thật
power differential	n phr		an imbalance of authority between two people	chênh lệch quyền lực
inhibition	n	/,ɪn.hɪ'bjʊ.ən/	a feeling that prevents free or natural expression	sự ức chế, sự kiềm chế bản thân
circumvent	v	/,sɜː.kəm'vent/	to find a way around a rule or difficulty	lách qua, né tránh
adversarial bonding	n phr		the forming of strong bonds through shared challenges	gắn kết qua thử thách, nghịch cảnh
peer	n	/piər/	a person of the same rank, status, or age group	người ngang hàng
horizontal relationship	n phr		a relationship between equals, without hierarchy	quan hệ ngang hàng

2.35 Describe a friend of yours who is good at music / singing

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a friend of yours who is good at music / singing. You should say:

- Who he/she is
- When/where you listen to his/her music/singing
- What kind of music/songs he/she is good at
- And explain how you feel when listening to his music/singing.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I would describe is Kiên — a close friend from secondary school who now studies at a conservatoire in Hà Nội — who plays classical guitar at a standard that most people who encounter him, not knowing his background, find genuinely surprising. Kiên began playing at the age of seven and has practised with a consistency and seriousness that I have observed over the fourteen years of our friendship — he plays for at least two hours daily, has done so for as long as I have known him, and approaches the instrument with a relationship to practice and improvement that I would characterise as professional rather than enthusiastic in the hobbyist sense. I have heard him perform on several occasions — twice at recitals his conservatoire organises, and several times in more informal settings, including once on a small outdoor platform at a cultural festival where his playing drew a spontaneous audience of considerable size.

What I feel when I listen to him is something I find difficult to describe without sounding either romantic or imprecise: there is a quality of attention that his playing requires of its listener — a pull toward focal engagement with the sound that interrupts the divided consciousness of ordinary listening — that I have experienced with recorded music only occasionally and never so reliably as when listening to someone I know perform live. I think the explanation lies in the combination of the instrument's acoustic directness and the visible presence of a person I know doing something beautiful: both dimensions of the experience — the sonic and the human — are more vivid than either would be alone.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The person I would describe is Lan — a colleague who sings in a semi-professional capacity in her time outside our shared workplace — who has one of those voices that produces in listeners an effect that is disproportionate to what the analytical description of its qualities would suggest.

Lan sings primarily in the category that Vietnamese music journalists call "nhạc trữ tình" — the lyrical, melodically complex genre of mid-twentieth-century Vietnamese popular song — and her interpretation of the repertoire has the specific quality of seeming entirely inhabited: she does not perform the emotional content of the songs but appears to be inside it, which produces a form of listening experience qualitatively different from technically accurate but emotionally external singing. I have heard her sing at several colleagues' celebrations over the years — birthday dinners, a wedding reception, a farewell gathering — and the consistent observation of everyone present at

these events is that her singing changes the quality of the occasion; the room focuses in a way rooms do not usually focus around incidental entertainment.

What I find most interesting about listening to her — from a professional perspective rather than a purely aesthetic one — is the specific form of attention management that skilled live musical performance produces in an audience: the collective orientation of a room of people toward a single focus, with the social and temporal experience of the event restructured around the duration and character of the performance.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
conservatoire	n	/kən'sɜː.və.twaɪr/	a school specialising in music or other arts	nhạc viện
recital	n	/rɪ'saɪ.təl/	a solo or small-group musical performance	buổi biểu diễn độc tấu/đơn ca
repertoire	n	/rep.ə.twaɪr/	the range of music a performer is able to play or sing	tiết mục biểu diễn
nhạc trữ tình	n phr		Vietnamese lyrical music, often with romantic or nostalgic themes	nhạc trữ tình (Việt Nam)
acoustic	adj	/ə'kuːs.tɪk/	relating to natural, non-amplified sound	âm thanh tự nhiên (không khuếch âm)
focal engagement	n phr		concentrated, undivided attention directed at one thing	sự tập trung cao độ
inhabited	adj	/ɪn'hæb.ɪ.tɪd/	(of a performance) deeply felt and fully lived from the inside	(diễn xuất) hoá thân thật sự
incidental	adj	/ɪn.sɪ'den.tl/	occurring by chance or as a minor accompaniment	tình cờ, thứ yếu
semi-professional	adj		performing to a high standard but not as a primary occupation	bán chuyên nghiệp
disproportionate	adj	/ˌdɪs.prə'pɔːʃən.ət/	larger or greater than expected in proportion	không cân xứng, quá mức tương ứng

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What kind of music is popular in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The Vietnamese popular music landscape is substantially more diverse and internally differentiated than its international characterisation as a single category captures. The largest audience segment in contemporary Vietnam is attracted to what the industry categorises as “V-pop”—a genre that has converged structurally with Korean and Japanese pop production conventions while retaining elements of Vietnamese melodic and lyrical tradition — and whose most commercially successful artists have substantial international visibility within the Southeast Asian market. A significant and demographically distinct audience retains strong preference for older genres: “nhạc vàng”(southern Vietnamese popular music of the pre-1975 period), bolero, and the lyrical mid-century repertoire that Lan sings, which remain enormously popular among listeners of middle age and above and maintain a presence in live performance and broadcast contexts that is disproportionate to their commercial market share.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The contemporary Vietnamese music market is characterised by a pronounced segmentation that reflects underlying demographic and cultural diversity more than most public accounts acknowledge. The commercially dominant popular music — V-pop and its international K-pop-influenced variants — captures the primary youth market in urban centres and drives the industry’s commercial metrics: streaming numbers, concert ticket sales, and social media engagement. Alongside this, however, there are active audiences for several distinct alternative markets: a significant folk and ethnic music audience (both as appreciation for regional traditions and as demand for contemporary fusions incorporating folk elements), a substantial classical and instrumental music audience concentrated in the major cities and among the professional and educational class, and a growing hip-hop and rap community whose emergence represents one of the more culturally interesting developments in Vietnamese music of the past decade.

2. What kind of music do young people like?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Young people’s musical preferences are more diverse than the generational generalisations that popular discourse typically imposes, though there are recognisable trends that reflect shared generational experience. The most consistent generalisation that holds across young people in urban Vietnamese contexts is a preference for produced, sonically complex music — music in which production value (the quality and sophistication of the electronic, studio, and mixing elements) is a significant part of the aesthetic experience rather than a neutral delivery mechanism for melody and lyrics. Within this broad preference, there is substantial diversity: K-pop and its derivatives attract a large and engaged audience, but hip-hop, electronic dance music, indie pop, and various fusion genres all have significant youth audiences that are internally differentiated by values, subculture, and social context.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The research and commercial intelligence on young people’s music consumption in Vietnam consistently identifies several structural features that distinguish it from older cohorts’ preferences. Consumption is substantially platform-mediated: young people encounter and explore music

primarily through streaming platforms with algorithmic recommendation, which differs fundamentally from the broadcast radio and physical media consumption that shaped older generations' musical tastes. The algorithmic context produces a more eclectic and less genre-bound consumption pattern: young listeners move between genres, discover international music with lower barriers than previous generations, and are less likely to define their musical identity around a single genre or tradition. The social music experience — attending concerts and festivals, discovering music with friends, sharing on social media — is also a more explicitly social-identity-formation activity for young people than for older cohorts.

3. What are the differences between young people's and old people's preferences in music?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The generational differences in musical preference reflect structural differences in how music is consumed, what social function it serves, and the specific emotional and cultural registers that different life stages make available. Older listeners tend to show stronger attachment to a stable repertoire accumulated during the formative period of late adolescence and early adulthood — this is the "reminiscence bump" phenomenon, in which music encountered during a particular developmental window retains disproportionate emotional salience throughout life — which makes their preferences more stable and more historically anchored than those of younger listeners whose formative musical experiences are still being accumulated. Younger listeners show greater openness to novelty, higher sensitivity to production and sonic innovation, and a preference for music that serves the social-identity function of situating one within a generational and subcultural peer group.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional music industry's understanding of generational preference differences is substantially more granular than the popular characterisation as a simple generation gap captures. The consistency of generational musical preference division is real — research reliably finds that the music people most strongly prefer as adults was predominantly encountered between the ages of twelve and twenty-five — but the mechanism is not a fixed generational aesthetic: it reflects the formative function that music serves during the period of identity formation, in which musical preference becomes deeply entangled with the development of self and social identity in ways that later musical encounters do not typically replicate. The implication is that the musical preferences older people have are not worse or less sophisticated than younger people's — they reflect a different life stage relationship to music rather than a different aesthetic capacity.

4. What are the benefits of children learning a musical instrument?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The developmental benefits of musical instrument learning in children are multi-dimensional and better documented than most popular accounts convey. The cognitive benefits include measurable improvements in working memory, phonological processing, fine motor coordination, and mathematical reasoning — all outcomes associated with sustained musical training that transfer to academic performance in related domains. The non-cognitive benefits — development of disciplined practice habits, capacity to tolerate and persist through difficulty, the experience of producing something beautiful through sustained personal effort — are

arguable more significant for long-term development than the cognitive ones, because they constitute character formation rather than skill development. The relational and emotional dimension is also significant: learning an instrument in a group or ensemble context develops listening, coordination with others, and the experience of collective aesthetic creation that is developmentally distinct from solo achievement.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional education and development case for musical instrument learning rests on what the research identifies as the highest-value long-term outcomes, which differ somewhat from the cognitive enhancement arguments that dominate popular advocacy. The most robust finding in the research on musical training and development is not the transfer to academic performance — which is real but moderate — but the development of what psychologists call “growth mindset” and related capacity for effortful improvement: children who master a musical instrument, which requires sustained practice to develop competence from initial incompetence, develop a framework for the relationship between effort and improvement that transfers to other challenging domains. The second most important finding is social-emotional: ensemble musical experience develops the specific capacity for attentive listening to others — adjusting one’s own output in real time in response to what others are producing — that is foundational to effective teamwork and collaboration in adult professional contexts.

5. Do you know what kind of music children like today?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Children’s current musical preferences are substantially shaped by the algorithmic recommendation environments they inhabit from very early ages, and the result is a musical landscape that is simultaneously more diverse and more internationally convergent than children’s music preferences of previous generations. The algorithmically recommended content that children encounter on platforms like YouTube and TikTok does not distinguish sharply between children’s and adult music in the way broadcast media did: children are routinely exposed to the same V-pop, K-pop, and international popular music that older teenagers and young adults consume, and their preferences reflect this exposure. At the same time, a significant segment of children’s musical preference remains shaped by the specific musical content created for children — educational songs, character-associated music from animated media, and games with musical components — which produces a dual consumption pattern that was less pronounced in earlier media environments.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional observation on children’s current musical preferences is that the platform-mediated exposure environment has dramatically accelerated the convergence of children’s and young adult music consumption in ways that were not characteristic of previous media environments. Children are encountering the same commercial music as teenagers and young adults from an earlier age than any previous generation — largely because the platforms that recommended that music to teenagers make the same recommendations to children without significant age-gating — which means that the music industry categories of “children’s music” and “youth music” are becoming progressively less distinct as a feature of actual consumption patterns even if they remain distinct as commercial categories.

6. Do you think the government should invest more money in concerts?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

The case for public investment in live music and concert programming is stronger than the popular framing of it as a luxury cultural expenditure suggests, but the specific mechanisms and targeting of that investment matter more than the aggregate level. The strongest public goods argument for concert investment is in the areas of access and infrastructure: publicly subsidised concerts reduce the economic barriers to live musical experience that make quality live performance in practice available only to higher-income audiences in commercial markets, supporting a more equitable distribution of cultural access across economic groups. The secondary argument — for investment in venues, orchestras, and educational concert programming — rests on the role of live musical institutions in maintaining the performance ecology that training, discovery, and professional development of musicians depends on.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The policy case for government investment in concerts and live music is best analysed through the specific categories of investment being considered rather than as a single undifferentiated proposition. Investment in symphonic orchestras and classical performance institutions has a specific public goods rationale: these are institutions whose costs are too high for commercial markets to sustain at the quality level required for their long-term artistic viability, but whose contribution to national cultural life and to musical education is substantial enough to justify public subsidy on cultural public goods grounds — the same rationale that justifies public funding of museums, theatres, and public libraries. Investment in commercial popular music concert infrastructure and events has a weaker public goods rationale and a stronger economic development rationale: live music events generate significant local economic activity and can function as significant cultural assets in national soft power and tourism contexts, which may justify various forms of public facilitation and support without necessarily requiring direct subsidy.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
reminiscence bump	n phr		the tendency to vividly remember music/events from ages 15–25	đỉnh hoài niệm (hiệu ứng tâm lý)
formative period	n phr		the developmental stage most important for shaping identity	giai đoạn hình thành (nhân cách)
algorithmic recommendation	n phr		automated suggestions based on user data and patterns	gợi ý thuật toán
subculture	n	/ˈsʌb.kʌl.tʃər/	a group with shared values and practices within a larger culture	tiểu văn hoá
public goods	n phr		resources available to all and not diminished by use	hàng hoá công cộng
age-gating	n phr		restricting content access based on the user's age	rào cản độ tuổi
ensemble	n	/ɒnˈsɒm.bəl/	a group performing music together	nhóm nhạc, dàn nhạc
phonological processing	n phr		the ability to perceive and manipulate sound units in language	xử lý ngữ âm
soft power	n phr		influence through culture and values rather than force	quyền lực mềm
subsidy	n	/ˈsʌb.sɪ.dɪ/	financial support given by government to help an activity or industry	trợ cấp, hỗ trợ tài chính

2.36 Describe a great dinner you and your friends or family members enjoyed

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a great dinner you and your friends or family members enjoyed. You should say:

- What you had
- Who you had the dinner with
- What you talked about during the dinner
- And explain why you enjoyed it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The dinner I would describe took place about a year ago — the last night of a four-day trip to Đà Lạt that I took with four university friends — at a small restaurant near the central market that one of us had found on a local recommendation rather than through any of the usual platforms.

We had a set of dishes I associate strongly with how good highland food can be: artichoke soup with its extraordinary bitterness-and-sweetness, braised duck with galangal root, and a hotpot with locally foraged mushrooms whose variety I have not encountered in restaurants in Hà Nội. The combination of the food quality, the setting — genuinely cold evening, a table next to a window overlooking a street lamp and rain — and the conversation we had that night produced an experience I have thought about often since. The conversation ranged from the genuinely personal (one of our group announced that evening that she was seriously considering leaving her degree programme, and the way the group responded to her — with honesty and without judgment — felt significant) to the genuinely trivial, and the movement between registers felt natural in a way that group conversations often do not.

What made it great was not any single element but the convergence of all of them: good food made with evident care, people I trust and am at ease with, a physical setting that was beautiful in an uncomplicated way, and enough time — we stayed for three hours without noticing — that the conversation could reach the places that conversations at their best reach.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The dinner I would describe was a meal I hosted at my apartment about two years ago for five colleagues who had worked together on a project that had been unusually demanding — six months, significant pressure, an outcome that was ultimately good but not before a period of genuine uncertainty — and which I organised specifically to mark the end of something that had required a lot from each of us.

I cooked myself, which is something I do not often do for professional groups, and the choice was deliberate: cooking for people is a different act of hospitality than taking them to a restaurant, and the informality it creates — people in the kitchen while things are being prepared, the imprecision of home cooking relative to restaurant presentation — produces a specific quality of social ease that more formal settings resist. We talked about the project, which was appropriate and in retrospect necessary: there was debrief

that needed to happen that had not yet had a context in which it could happen freely. We also talked about things entirely unrelated to work, and the transition between those modes of conversation was easy in a way that it rarely is in professional settings. What made the dinner significant was that it transformed a professional relationship into something with dimensions that professional contexts don't normally create space for, and did so in a way that strengthened rather than complicated the professional relationships that followed.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
galangal	n	/ˈɡæl.ən.ɡəl/	a fragrant root related to ginger, used in Southeast Asian cooking	củ riềng
foraged	adj	/ˈfɔr.ɪdʒd/	gathered from the wild rather than cultivated	hái/thu lượm từ tự nhiên
debrief	n/v	/ˌdiːˈbriːf/	a meeting to review and discuss a completed event or project	họp tổng kết, báo cáo sau sự kiện
hospitality	n	/ˌhɒs.prɪˈtæl.i.ti/	the friendly and generous reception of guests	lòng hiếu khách
register	n	/ˈredʒ.ɪ.stər/	the level of formality or tone used in a situation	phong cách (ngôn ngữ, giao tiếp)
convergence	n	/kənˈvɜː.dʒəns/	the process of coming together	sự hội tụ
set meal	n phr		a fixed menu offered at a single price	bữa ăn theo suất cố định
informality	n	/ˌɪn.fɔːˈmæl.i.ti/	the quality of being relaxed and unceremonious	tính thân mật, không trang trọng
commemorate	v	/kəˈmem.ə.reɪt/	to mark an event with a ceremony or celebration	kỷ niệm, tưởng niệm
uncomplicated	adj	/ˌʌnˈkɒm.plɪ.keɪ.tɪd/	simple and free from difficulty	đơn giản, không phức tạp

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Do people prefer to eat out at restaurants or eat at home during the Spring Festival?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The Spring Festival (Tết) eating preference in Vietnam reflects a strong and culturally-grounded preference for home meals that is more robust than the general trend toward eating out in other contexts. The symbolic and ritual significance of the Tết meal — particularly the reunion dinner on New Year's Eve, which is organised around specific traditional dishes that carry both culinary and cultural meaning — makes home cooking the strongly dominant mode: the meal is not primarily about food quality in a culinary sense but about the performance of family gathering, continuity with tradition, and the specific emotional experience of a household gathered around a table that a restaurant setting cannot replicate. The trend toward eating out at Tết has grown among younger urban families who have less capacity or tradition for home cooking, but it remains a minority practice and one that many families who engage in it describe with a degree of ambivalence.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The Tết eating pattern is one of the clearest examples in Vietnamese life of a cultural practice that has maintained its essential character — the multi-generational household meal — despite enormous changes in the surrounding material and social environment. The restaurant industry's data consistently shows that restaurant dining during the core Tết period (New Year's Eve through to around the third or fourth day) is substantially lower than in equivalent non-festival periods, which reflects the strength of the home-cooking preference during the festival itself. The pattern that has changed in the past decade is the pre-and post-Tết period: many families now combine home meals for the ritually significant occasions with restaurant outings for the more socially flexible days of the extended holiday, which represents an adaptation of the tradition rather than its erosion.

2. What food do you eat on special occasions, like during the Spring Festival or the Mid-autumn Festival?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The festival food of Vietnamese occasions is characterised by the combination of culinary quality and symbolic meaning in ways that ordinary everyday food is not, and the specific dishes associated with each festival carry cultural significance that persists even when the culinary quality of any given preparation varies. Tết food has a geographically-inflected character: in the north, "bánh chưng"(square sticky rice cake with pork and mung bean filling, wrapped in "lá dong"leaves) is the most symbolically central dish, while southern preparations tend toward "bánh tét"(a cylindrical version) and a different but overlapping set of preserved and festive dishes. The Mid-Autumn Festival is distinguished by its central ritual object — the mooncake ("bánh trung thu") — which has become increasingly diverse in its available varieties and is consumed both as a genuine food and as a gift object whose packaging value can be substantial.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The festival food economy in Vietnam reveals an interesting tension between cultural authenticity and commercial evolution that is worth examining carefully. The core festival foods — bánh chưng, xôi gấc, thịt đông for Tết; bánh trung thu for Mid-Autumn — maintain their symbolic centrality even as their commercial forms evolve substantially: the mooncake market, in particular, has generated an enormous range of premium, imported, and fusion variants that are valued as consumer and gift products in ways that are quite different from the traditional ritual object they originate from. This commercialisation is sometimes critiqued as loss of authenticity, but a more nuanced view is that it reflects the adaptation of living traditions to changing economic conditions and preferences — the symbolic core (the gathering, the specific occasion, the category of food) is maintained even as the specific

preparation evolves.

3. Why do people like to have meals together during important festivals?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The shared meal is one of the most fundamental and cross-culturally consistent forms of social bonding that human communities practise, and its centrality to festival observance reflects the role it plays as both a practical activity and a social ritual. At the practical level, preparing and sharing food is a naturally cooperative activity that requires coordination, creates shared physical space, and produces a shared experience of nourishment that has been the foundation of social bonding from the earliest stages of human sociality. At the ritual level, the festival meal has a symbolic dimension that transcends its practical function: the specific dishes prepared, the way the table is set, and the order in which activities occur around the meal are all carriers of cultural meaning and family tradition that connect the present gathering to past gatherings — ancestors, family history, and collective identity — in ways that ordinary meals do not.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The sociological significance of the festival meal is best understood through the concept of "ritual" in the anthropological sense: a structured, repeated practice whose function is not primarily instrumental but symbolic — the enactment and renewal of social relationships and cultural identity. The festival meal's social function is the production of "communitas" — the experience of unity, equality, and shared humanity that anthropologist Victor Turner identified as the characteristic product of ritual experience — which temporarily dissolves the status hierarchies, role distinctions, and professional distances that structure ordinary social life and reinstates the primordial family unit as the primary social category. In the contemporary context of Vietnamese families increasingly dispersed by internal migration for work, education, and economic opportunity, the festival meal has acquired additional significance as the occasion that reassembles the dispersed household, making its social function more important rather than less as mobility increases.

4. Is it a hassle to prepare a meal at home?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The perception of home meal preparation as a hassle is real and increasing, but it is produced by specific contextual changes rather than reflecting an intrinsic quality of the activity itself. The primary driver of the hassle perception is the time cost imposed by market access in urban environments: in cities where good-quality ingredients require travel to markets or the use of delivery services, and where food stalls and restaurants offering good-quality food at low prices are available on every corner, the opportunity cost of home cooking relative to the alternatives is genuinely higher than it was for previous generations in the same cities. The secondary driver is the skill deficit: cooking is a practised skill that becomes less effortful with practice, and households in which home cooking has declined over a generation are those in which successive generations acquire progressively less cooking competence, which makes the activity genuinely more effortful for those who undertake it with less practice.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The home cooking "hassle" perception warrants examination from an economic and time-

use perspective rather than simply as a subjective experience. The components of the task that produce the hassle perception are well-identified: ingredient acquisition (which in urban contexts has become more varied in option but not necessarily less time-costly), preparation time (which is skill-dependent and varies substantially with practised cooking competence), and the cleanup cost that kitchen cooking imposes but restaurant eating does not. Against these costs must be set the benefits that home cooking produces — economic savings over equivalent restaurant quality, control over ingredient quality and preparation, and the specific relational and health benefits that household cooking more reliably produces than eating out. The perceived hassle is partially a reflection of genuine cost and partially a reflection of undervaluation of those offsetting benefits in contexts where the immediate cost is salient and the diffuse benefits accumulate invisibly.

5. What do people often talk about during meals?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Meal conversation has a distinctive character across cultural contexts because it occurs in a social setting — seated, face-to-face, bounded in time, and structured around a shared activity — that produces a specific conversation dynamic that differs from conversations conducted in other settings. In Vietnamese family meal contexts, the conversation tends to be dominated by the social information-sharing function: what each person has been doing, what has happened in the lives of family members and the wider network, and the collective processing of shared news and events. This information-sharing function serves the relational purpose of maintaining interconnect among people whose daily lives are largely separate — the meal conversation is the moment when the dispersed activities of individual family members are brought into shared awareness.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The research on meal conversation — which has been studied in both family and professional contexts — finds consistent patterns in what makes food-context conversation distinctive. The shared activity of eating, combined with the temporal boundedness of the meal, creates a conversation context that is naturally less pressured and more associative than discussions organised around a specific agenda: the food itself, the occasion, and the social context generate conversation topics without the need for deliberate agenda-setting. The most important function that meal conversation performs in professional contexts is relationship building through the self-disclosure and personal information-sharing that meal settings elicit more naturally than office meetings — which is why the professional meal remains one of the most effective available tools for developing relationships that office meetings cannot easily generate.

6. People are spending less and less time having meals with their families these days. Is this good or bad?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The decline of family meals is worth taking seriously as a social trend but warrants analysis rather than simple moral evaluation. The research evidence on family meals is fairly consistent: regular shared family meals are associated with measurably better outcomes for children on a range of indicators including academic performance, dietary health, emotional wellbeing, and language development — outcomes large enough and consistent enough across

studies that the family meal is widely considered one of the most accessible family practices with the strongest evidence base for child development benefit. The decline of shared family meals is therefore a genuine loss for children's development, and the argument that equivalent outcomes can be produced by other mechanisms is not well-supported by the available evidence.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The decline in family meal frequency reflects structural changes in work, urban living, and family organisation that are unlikely to be reversed by attitude change alone, which means the policy-relevant question is not whether the trend is good or bad in the abstract but what the most effective available responses to it are. The evidence that family meals produce child development benefits is robust enough to make the trend genuinely concerning from a social policy perspective; the evidence for mechanisms suggests the benefits come primarily from the quality of interaction — the conversation, the mutual attention, the shared domestic experience — rather than from the meal itself, which implies that the loss can be partly offset by creating other contexts for the same quality of interaction but not fully substituted by any easily available alternative. The most realistic response is probably a combination of structural change (flexible work arrangements that make family meals more feasible) and deliberate cultural prioritisation — treating consistent family meals as a practice worth protecting rather than a pleasant optional extra.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
communitas	n	/kə'mju:.nɪ.təs/	the feeling of shared humanity and equality in a ritual setting	cộng đồng tình người (nhân học)
ritual	n	/'rɪtʃ.u.əl/	a repeated symbolic practice with social or religious significance	nghi thức, lễ nghi
self-disclosure	n phr		voluntarily sharing personal information about oneself	tự tiết lộ thông tin cá nhân
opportunity cost	n phr		the value of the next-best alternative foregone	chi phí cơ hội
dispersed	adj	/dɪ'spɜ:st/	spread widely across different locations	phân tán, rải rác
salient	adj	/'seɪ.li.ənt/	most noticeable or important	nổi bật, đáng chú ý
nourishment	n	/'nʌr.ɪʃ.mənt/	food and drink necessary for health and growth	sự nuôi dưỡng
primordial	adj	/praɪ'mɔ:di.əl/	existing from the very beginning; most ancient	nguyên thủy, cơ bản nhất
debunk	v	/,di:'bʌŋk/	to expose the false claims of something widely believed	bác bỏ, vạch trần
associative	adj	/ə'səʊ.si.ə.tɪv/	characterised by free, topic-linked connections rather than rigid structure	liên tưởng, tự do

2.37 Describe an important decision made with the help of other people

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe an important decision made with the help of other people. You should say:

- What the decision was
- Why you made the decision
- Who helped you make the decision
- And how you felt about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

There was a decision a couple of years ago — whether to switch from my original economics programme to a joint degree in economics and data science — that felt genuinely consequential in a way most choices at that age don't, and which I couldn't have made well without two people whose judgment I trusted. My older cousin Minh had taken a comparable programme at a different university and was about eighteen months ahead of me in seeing where it led professionally; my academic advisor, independently, was pushing me toward quantitative methods in a way that was making me question whether the single-subject track I was on would close options I wasn't ready to close. Talking to both of them — separately, because they approached it differently, one from a career perspective and one from a purely intellectual one — clarified something I hadn't been able to see on my own: that my hesitation wasn't about ability or interest but about the specific anxiety of changing something that was already going fine. I made the switch about six weeks after those conversations, and I remember feeling a particular kind of relief that I think only comes when you realise a decision that seemed complicated had actually resolved itself once you'd collected enough honest input rather than opinions you were already looking for.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

About three years ago, I had to decide whether to accept an offer to lead a newly established regional office — the first posting of that kind our organisation had created in the central provinces — while my family was at a stage where moving would have disrupted my wife's work and my daughter's school year. The offer was professionally significant; the timing was genuinely bad; and I was not, frankly, capable of thinking about it clearly at the time because I was simultaneously excited and guilty in a way that made both responses unreliable. Three conversations changed the shape of the decision: one with my wife, who gave me a clear position that was less negative than I had anticipated; one with a senior colleague who had taken a comparable role eight years earlier and was able to separate out what had been genuinely difficult from what had only seemed difficult in prospect; and one with my department head, who told me, straightforwardly, what the consequences for my professional trajectory were likely to be in either direction. What I felt afterward — once I'd accepted and the initial pressure had cleared — was something I would describe as clarity rather than confidence: not the feeling that it was certainly the right choice, but the feeling that I had made it with enough information and enough honest input that I could commit

to it fully without continued second-guessing.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
trajectory	n	/trə'dʒek.tər.i/	the course of development of a career or life	quỹ đạo (sự nghiệp)
consequential	adj	/ˌkɒn.sɪ'kwɛn.ʃəl/	important and having significant results	quan trọng, có hậu quả đáng kể
second-guessing	n	/ˌsek.ənd'ges.ɪŋ/	continuing to doubt a decision already made	ngghi ngờ lại quyết định đã đưa ra
in prospect	adv phr		as something anticipated or imagined in advance	trong viễn cảnh, khi hình dung trước
foresight	n	/ˈfɔː.sart/	the ability to predict what will happen and plan accordingly	tầm nhìn xa
deliberate	adj	/dɪ'lɪb.ər.ət/	done consciously and intentionally	có chủ ý, thận trọng
autonomous	adj	/ɔː'tɒn.ə.məs/	making independent decisions without external control	tự chủ
cognitive bias	n phr		a systematic pattern of deviation from rational judgment	thiên kiến nhận thức
confirmation bias	n phr		the tendency to search for information that confirms existing beliefs	thiên kiến xác nhận
resolve	v	/rɪ'zɒlv/	to settle or find a solution to a problem or decision	quyết định, giải quyết

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What kind of decisions do you think are meaningful?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The decisions that carry the most lasting significance are generally those that realign — rather than simply extend — the existing direction of a person's life: choices about what to study, where to live, who to commit to, and what kind of work to invest oneself in. These are decisions meaningful because they determine the structure within which the vast majority of subsequent smaller decisions are made, which makes their consequences disproportionately large relative to the immediate moment of choice. The decisions that feel significant but are not — those that involve high visible stakes but low consequential depth, such as which car to buy or which university cohort event to attend — are distinct from genuinely meaningful decisions in exactly this way: their outcomes don't redirect the longer arc.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The decisions I would identify as genuinely meaningful are those where the chooser cannot return to the prior state once the choice is made — what economists call irreversible decisions — because the irreversibility is what gives the choice its distinctive weight. Professional choices in this category include changing industry or function (not merely employer), relocating geographically, committing to a senior leadership role whose demands will reshape life outside work, or choosing to leave institutions before they have given what one came for. The characteristic feature of meaningful decisions is not their apparent size at the moment of choice but the degree to which they foreclose alternatives: the decision that seems small but closes many futures is more meaningful than the decision that seems large but leaves most options open.

2. What important decisions should be made by teenagers themselves?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The decisions that teenagers should make for themselves are primarily those in the domains of identity formation — how they spend their discretionary time, which friendships they prioritise, what creative or intellectual interests they pursue — because these are the domains in which the development of genuine self-knowledge requires actual choices with actual consequences rather than directed outcomes. The important qualification is that self-made decisions in these domains are most developmentally productive when they occur within structures that limit the most severe potential consequences: a teenager should make their own choices about what music to engage with, what literature to read, and what activities to try, but these choices should occur within a framework that limits exposure to genuinely high-stakes irreversible risks. The goal of the developmental period is to produce a person capable of consequential autonomous choice — and that capacity is developed through practice, not through protection from choice.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The adult professional answer to this question is shaped by what we know about the relationship between decision-making practice and decision-making competence. Teenagers should make decisions in areas where the consequences of error are recoverable, the domain is one in which their developing self-knowledge is more reliable than adults' projections of their needs, and the choice is genuinely theirs in the sense that it reflects their values rather than those they have been instructed to hold. Academic specialisation — the subjects they pursue

most seriously, the educational paths they pursue beyond compulsion — is a domain where teenage autonomy is both developmentally important and practically appropriate, because the knowledge of one's own intellectual character that guides these choices is more accessible to the teenager than to any external observer.

3. Why are some people unwilling to make quick decisions?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The resistance to rapid decision-making reflects a set of psychological and contextual factors that are more varied than the simple characterisation of "indecisiveness" captures. The most straightforward explanation is genuine uncertainty: when a person lacks the information or the evaluative framework needed to compare alternatives reliably, delay is a rational strategy rather than a personality failing, and the appearance of indecisiveness may simply be appropriate epistemic humility about the limits of current knowledge. A second, less rational explanation is loss aversion operating through the option-preservation effect: choosing one alternative forecloses the others, and people who weight potential losses more heavily than equivalent gains will systematically prefer to delay choice in order to preserve options that the delay does not actually make more achievable.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The reluctance to make quick decisions in professional contexts most commonly reflects one of three patterns, each of which requires a different organisational response. The first is genuine information deficit — the decision-maker does not yet have enough information to choose well, which is a legitimate reason for delay that should be addressed by improving information flow rather than pressuring faster choice. The second is accountability anxiety — the decision-maker is more concerned about being held responsible for a bad outcome than about making the best available decision, which produces a systematic preference for delay, consultation, and collective endorsement that distributes rather than eliminates accountability. The third is a preference for reversible decisions that cannot be made reversible — an unwillingness to accept the irreversibility that genuinely consequential choices require — which is the most problematic pattern because it leads to either chronic delay or the disguised refusal to decide at all.

4. Do people like to ask for advice more for their personal life or their work?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The asymmetry in advice-seeking between personal and professional contexts is real and reflects the different social norms governing disclosure in each domain. Students and young adults typically seek advice more readily for academic and career decisions than for personal ones, partly because the social infrastructure for career advice — counsellors, advisors, family members with professional experience — is more developed and more culturally legitimate than the infrastructure for personal advice-seeking. Personal decisions attract more protective privacy and more concern about judgment: admitting uncertainty about a personal choice requires a form of vulnerability that not all relationships can accommodate, which means effective personal advice-seeking depends on the quality of specific relationships in a way that professional advice-seeking does not.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional contextual pattern, in my observation, is that experienced professionals

seek advice more actively for personal decisions than for professional ones — which is the inverse of what many younger people expect. The reason is that professional experience develops the judgment to navigate professional decisions with increasing confidence, while personal decisions — about relationships, family, health, and values — remain in a domain where professional competence provides no particular advantage and where the advice of trusted people with different perspectives remains genuinely valuable. The pattern breaks down with professional decisions of the highest stakes — the decisions that are simultaneously career-defining and irreversible — where the same vulnerability that characterises personal advice-seeking tends to re-emerge.

5. Why do some people like to ask others for advice?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

People seek advice for a mixture of rational and psychological reasons that are not always easy to disentangle, and understanding the distinction matters for how we evaluate the advice-seeking behaviour. The rational case for advice-seeking is clear: other people have knowledge, experience, and perspectives that the decision-maker lacks, and systematically ignoring these resources is irrational regardless of one's level of confidence in one's own judgment. The psychological dimension is more complex: advice-seeking also performs a social function of sharing the weight of a decision — distributing the psychological burden of choice across multiple people — and an emotional function of seeking reassurance that the preferred option is defensible, which may produce confirmation-seeking rather than genuine input-seeking.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The most thoughtful professional advice-seekers I have encountered are those who use advice-seeking specifically to expose the blind spots that their own perspective systematically produces rather than to validate conclusions they have already reached. The distinction between these two modes of advice-seeking — one genuinely open to having one's view changed, the other seeking endorsement — is visible in behaviours: the genuine advice-seeker presents the decision openly, asks what they might be missing, and responds to challenge with curiosity rather than defensiveness; the endorsement-seeker presents the preferred conclusion, frames alternatives tendentiously, and deflects challenge. The mentor-mentee relationship is most valuable when the mentee has developed enough self-awareness to bring the former mode rather than the latter.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
epistemic humility	n phr		recognition of the limits of one's own knowledge	sự khiêm tốn về nhận thức
loss aversion	n phr		the tendency to weigh potential losses more heavily than gains	ác cảm mất mát
option-preservation	n phr		the desire to keep choices open rather than commit	bảo toàn lựa chọn
tendentiously	adv	/ten'den.jəs.li/	in a way that promotes a particular cause or point of view	theo cách thiên lệch
accountability anxiety	n phr		fear of being blamed if a decision leads to a bad outcome	lo ngại trách nhiệm
epistemic	adj	/,ep.i'stem.ɪk/	relating to knowledge and the conditions required for it	thuộc nhận thức luận
discretionary	adj	/dɪ'skreʃ.ən.ər.i/	left to personal choice and judgment	tuỳ ý, tự quyết
endorse	v	/ɪn'dɔ:s/	to declare one's public approval or support	chứng thực, ủng hộ
disentangle	v	/,dɪs.ɪn'tæŋ.gəl/	to separate things that are confused or mixed together	gỡ rối, phân tách
blind spot	n phr		an area where one fails to see or understand	điểm mù (tư duy)

2.38 Describe a time when the electricity suddenly went off

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a time when the electricity suddenly went off. You should say:

- When/where it happened
- How long it lasted
- What you did during that time
- And explain how you felt about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

There was a power cut that lasted about five hours on a Sunday afternoon during my second year of university — not unusual by itself, except that I was halfway through an assignment due the following morning and had not saved as often as I should have, which turned an inconvenience into something considerably more stressful. It was late August, the fan went off with the lights, and within about half an hour the apartment was genuinely uncomfortable — hot in a way that made concentration on the salvaged handwritten work I switched to difficult after a point. What I ended up doing was taking my notebook to a nearby café that hadn't lost power, where I sat for three hours finishing the assignment by hand and having it retyped later, which was inefficient but in retrospect not the worst outcome: being forced off my laptop and onto paper meant I thought differently about what I was writing and came back with a draft I was more satisfied with than I'd expected. By the time I got home the power had returned and my flatmate had cooked on the gas stove, which meant the evening ended well. The dominant feeling the episode left me with was not frustration but a specific form of productivity anxiety — the realisation of how deeply my working patterns had become dependent on a single system I had given very little thought to.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The power cut I remember most clearly happened during a client presentation rehearsal — the evening before a major pitch — and lasted about four hours at a point when we still had significant preparation to complete. Our team was working in the office, three people, each running their own machine, and when the building's backup generator failed to engage properly we were left with laptops running on battery and phones as the only light sources. The practical response was quick: we redistributed tasks to those with fuller batteries, moved the remaining work to a shared document on mobile data, and accepted that certain elements of the presentation would be less polished than we had planned. What the situation revealed — and I have found this in most crisis contexts — was a useful diagnostic of who on the team escalated in unhelpful ways and who became more effective under constraint: the presentation itself the following day was, perhaps because of the shared adversity, delivered with more cohesion and directness than many more prepared ones I have been part of.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
backup generator	n phr		a device that provides power when the main electricity supply fails	máy phát điện dự phòng
adversity	n	/əd'vɜː.sɪ.ti/	a difficult or unpleasant situation	nghịch cảnh, khó khăn
power outage	n phr		a period when the electricity supply is cut off	mất điện (sự cố lưới điện)
grid	n	/ɡrɪd/	the network of electricity supply lines	lưới điện
surge	n	/sɜːdʒ/	a sudden powerful increase in electric current	tăng đột ngột điện áp
constraint	n	/kən'streɪnt/	a limitation or restriction	ràng buộc, hạn chế
diagnostic	adj/n	/,daɪ.əɡ'nɒs.trɪk/	used to identify the nature of a problem	chẩn đoán, nhận biết
cohesion	n	/kəʊ'hiː.ʒən/	the quality of working together effectively	sự gắn kết
mobile data	n phr		internet access through a cellular network	dữ liệu di động (mạng 4G/5G)
escalate	v	/ˈes.kə.leɪt/	to become more serious or intense	leo thang, trở nên nghiêm trọng hơn

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Which is better, electric bicycles or ordinary bicycles?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The comparison between electric and ordinary bicycles is most productively framed not

as a general superiority question but as a context-specificity question: each is substantially better than the other for a specific set of users and use cases. Ordinary bicycles are superior for users primarily motivated by physical conditioning, those making short flat-terrain journeys, and those in contexts where charging infrastructure is unavailable or unreliable — and they have advantages in maintenance simplicity and initial cost that matter significantly across much of the world. Electric bicycles are superior for longer commutes, for users with physical limitations that make sustained pedalling difficult, and for urban contexts where the alternative to cycling is motorised transport rather than walking — where the electric assist makes cycling the dominant option for a population segment that ordinary bicycles do not serve.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional urban transport perspective on this question is that both are significantly underused relative to their potential, and that the policy question of which to prioritise depends less on the vehicles' intrinsic merits than on the demographic and geographic characteristics of the city in question. In dense flat-terrain cities with short average commutes, ordinary bicycles outperform electric alternatives for most users: the infrastructure cost and battery management complexity of electric bicycles adds cost without adding proportionate commute benefit. In hillier cities, in cities with longer average commute distances, or in populations with higher average ages, electric bicycles are more likely to serve as genuine car replacements — which is the highest-value transport outcome available — because they bring more of the city within comfortable cycling range for more of the population.

2. Do you think electric bicycles will replace ordinary bicycles in the future?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The trajectory of electric bicycle adoption suggests growth but not replacement: electric and ordinary bicycles serve overlapping but distinct user populations, and the advantages of ordinary bicycles for specific use cases will remain, which means the more likely future is a substantially expanded cycling population that includes both types rather than a transition from one to the other. The most significant variable is battery technology: as battery weight, cost, and charging time continue to improve, the primary remaining disadvantages of electric bicycles become less constraining, which will expand the population for whom they are the preferable option. The environmental and public health evidence for expanding cycling of both types is sufficiently strong that the more productive policy question is how to increase the total share of cycling in urban transport rather than which specific technology to favour.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The replacement framing mischaracterises how transport technology transitions typically work. New vehicle categories more commonly expand the total cycling-eligible population than they convert existing cyclists between technologies — which means the more accurate prediction is that electric bicycles will bring into cycling a population that ordinary bicycles could not reach, while ordinary bicycles retain the population they currently serve. The policy implication is that infrastructure investment in cycling should be technology-agnostic — dedicated lanes, secure parking, and well-maintained surfaces serve both categories effectively — rather than betting on one technology displacing the other.

3. Which is better, electric cars or petrol cars?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The lifecycle environmental comparison favours electric vehicles in most contexts today and will favour them more strongly as electricity grids decarbonise, which is the direction of travel across most national energy systems. The honest complexity is in the transition period: electric vehicles manufactured today carry a significant embodied carbon cost from battery production, and their emissions advantage over combustion vehicles depends on the carbon intensity of the local electricity grid — in contexts where grid electricity is primarily coal-generated, the advantage is reduced and in some cases eliminated in the short term. The strongest case for electric vehicles is therefore not as a currently pure alternative but as a platform technology capable of delivering progressively lower emissions as the grid cleans, whereas petrol cars lock in a fixed emission trajectory.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The decision framework for whether electric or petrol cars are preferable is primarily a function of ownership context rather than vehicle technology in the abstract. Total cost of ownership for electric vehicles is favourable in contexts of high annual mileage, access to reliable home or workplace charging, and grids with relatively low carbon intensity — which currently describes a significant portion of the professional and urban population in Vietnam’s major cities. The infrastructure gap — charging network coverage and reliability outside major urban centres — remains the most significant practical constraint on electric vehicle adoption, and this is a solvable problem through deliberate public investment rather than a fundamental technology limitation.

4. How did people manage to live without electricity in the ancient world?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Pre-electrical societies organised their lives around fundamentally different constraints and temporal rhythms than contemporary ones, and the question of how they “managed” without electricity reflects a perspective shaped by assumptions about necessity that pre-electrical people did not share. The most significant organising principle was daylight: productive activity — agriculture, craft, trade, most domestic work — was principally conducted during daylight hours, and the period after dusk was either lit by fire, lamp, or candle at significant fuel cost, or given over to rest in a way that virtually no contemporary urban lifestyle is. The social and economic consequences of this temporal structure were pervasive: they shaped when markets operated, how long the working day lasted, how and when family and community life was conducted, and the fundamentally different relationship to seasonal variation that pre-industrial societies depended on.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional relevance of this historical question is that it productively disrupts the assumption that electricity is a prerequisite for human flourishing rather than an enabler of particular historically specific forms of it. The most important observation is that pre-electrical societies produced the full range of human achievement — art, philosophy, science, engineering, governance, literature — under constraints that contemporary people would find severely limiting, which suggests that human capability is substantially more context-independent than the assumption of electricity’s necessity implies. The practical lesson for contemporary contexts — particularly for thinking about energy resilience and the vulnerability of complex systems to disruption — is that the skills and practices of managing without continuous electrical power are more worth cultivating than most contemporary planning assumes.

5. Is it difficult for the government to replace all the petrol cars with electric cars?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

The transition from combustion to electric vehicles at national scale is a complex challenge involving economic, infrastructure, and social dimensions that make it genuinely difficult regardless of the political will to attempt it. The economic challenge is the simultaneous disruption of the existing combustion vehicle manufacturing and maintenance ecosystem — which employs large numbers of people in activities that do not transfer directly to electric vehicle production and maintenance — while building the supply chains, manufacturing capacity, and charging infrastructure that electric vehicle adoption requires. The social challenge is the cost distribution of the transition: if electric vehicles remain significantly more expensive than combustion alternatives during the transition period, the policy question of who bears that cost is politically contentious in ways that can slow or derail otherwise technically feasible transitions.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The government's challenge in managing the petrol-to-electric transition is less technical than it is political and distributional. The technology exists; the timetable question is fundamentally about how to manage the interests of sectors, regions, and populations that benefit differently from different transition speeds. The most successful national transitions — Norway being the clearest example — have used a combination of financial incentives that reduce the ownership cost gap, infrastructure investment that removes range anxiety as a barrier, and regulatory timelines that give manufacturers and consumers enough certainty to plan investment decisions — rather than relying on either pure market price signals or command-and-control mandates alone.

6. Do people use more electricity now than before?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

The trend in electricity consumption is unambiguously upward at the aggregate level, and the mechanisms are well-identified: the electrification of activities previously powered by other fuels (cooking, heating, transport), the proliferation of electrical devices including smartphones and personal computers, and the expansion of digital infrastructure including the data centres that cloud computing relies on. The per-capita trend in high-income countries shows some efficiency gains that partially offset the expansion of electrical applications — improvements in appliance efficiency, better building insulation, and the replacement of energy-intensive processes with digital equivalents — but these gains have been more than offset by the expansion in the number and type of electrical applications. In Vietnam and comparable rapidly developing economies, per-capita electricity consumption has grown significantly faster than in already-developed economies as electrification matures and living standards rise.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The electricity consumption trend is increasing at global scale but with significant variation in trajectory across countries at different development stages and with different energy transition policies. The policy challenge is that increasing total consumption is occurring simultaneously with the need to decarbonise electricity generation, which means that the rate of renewable energy capacity addition needs to exceed the rate of demand growth to produce

falling rather than constant or rising grid carbon intensity. The most sophisticated national energy policies are therefore not focused on reducing electricity consumption — which is often associated with reduced economic activity — but on ensuring that the consumption growth that economic development generates is met with clean rather than fossil generation, which requires significant and sustained investment in both generation capacity and grid infrastructure.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
grid decarbonisation	n phr		the process of reducing carbon emissions from electricity generation	phi carbon hoá lưới điện
embodied carbon	n phr		emissions produced in the manufacture of a product	carbon tích hợp (trong quá trình sản xuất)
range anxiety	n phr		fear of running out of battery before reaching a charger	lo lắng về phạm vi pin xe điện
lifecycle emissions	n phr		total emissions across a product's creation, use, and disposal	phát thải toàn vòng đời
combustion engine	n phr		an engine that generates power by burning fuel	động cơ đốt trong
electrification	n	/ɪˌlek.trɪ.fɪˈkeɪ.ʃən/	the process of converting to electricity as a power source	điện khí hoá
carbon intensity	n phr		the amount of CO emitted per unit of energy	cường độ carbon
mandate	n	/'mæn.deɪt/	an official order or authority to do something	ủy quyền, lệnh bắt buộc
per-capita	adj/adv	/ˌpɜː 'kæp.ɪ.tə/	calculated per person in a population	tính theo đầu người
infrastructure	n	/'ɪn.freˌstrʌk.tʃər/	the basic systems needed for society to function	cơ sở hạ tầng

2.39 Describe an exciting activity you have tried for the first time

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe an exciting activity you have tried for the first time. You should say:

- What it is
- When/where you did it
- Why you thought it was exciting
- And explain how you felt about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

About a year ago, a group of friends from university persuaded me to try canyoning for the first time in a gorge in the mountains outside Đà Lạt — an activity that, had anyone described it to me in detail beforehand, I would have found compelling reasons to decline. Canyoning involves descending a rocky canyon using a combination of rappelling, swimming, sliding down natural rock chutes, and jumping into pools whose depth you have to trust on the basis of a guide's assurance rather than your own prior knowledge, which is precisely the kind of trust-the-process experience that I have historically been reluctant to practise. What persuaded me to go was a combination of not wanting to be the one person in a group of eight who opted out, and a more genuine curiosity — once I read about it — about the specific experience of moving through terrain by whatever physical means the terrain required. The activity itself was significantly more engaging than I had prepared myself for: the rappelling section was technically intimidating in a way that overrode most other thought, and the swimming sections through narrow rock passages had a quality of physical immersion in a landscape — cold, immediate, entirely present — that I have not encountered in any other activity. The feeling I carried home was less about having done something dramatic and more about having discovered that the specific form of fear that new physical challenges produce — the sharp, focused kind, not the diffuse anxious kind — is something I find surprisingly worth seeking.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The activity I would describe is sea kayaking — specifically, a two-day kayaking trip through the islands of Lan Hạ Bay that I undertook last year with my spouse, neither of us having paddled anything more serious than a pedal boat — which I agreed to on the basis that it was described as "moderate difficulty" by the operator and which turned out to involve about twenty kilometres of open-water paddling per day in conditions that were not moderate in the early afternoon when the wind came up. The experience was genuinely demanding in a way I had not prepared for: my shoulders and back were exhausted by mid-morning on the first day, the technique required to maintain direction and momentum in choppy conditions was not intuitive, and the open-water crossing between islands on the second morning was the closest I have come in years to a situation I was not certain I could complete. What I found in that context was something I had not expected: that the combination of physical exhaustion and genuine environmental challenge — paddling in a place of extraordinary beauty with

no option of early withdrawal — produced a quality of absorption and presence that is very difficult to access in ordinary professional life, and which I have thought about repeatedly as a reference point for what full engagement with a challenging situation actually feels like.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
canyoning	n	/ˈkæn.jən.ɪŋ/	the sport of descending a canyon using multiple movement techniques	môn leo thác
rappelling	n	/ræˈpel.ɪŋ/	descending a cliff face using a rope	kỹ thuật hạ dốc bằng dây
kayaking	n	/ˈkaɪ.æk.ɪŋ/	paddling a small narrow boat using a double-bladed paddle	chèo thuyền kayak
choppy	adj	/ˈtʃɒp.i/	(of water) with many small rough waves	(sóng) gồ ghề, lắc lư
absorption	n	/əbˈzɔ:p.jən/	complete concentration on an activity	sự đắm chìm, tập trung hoàn toàn
adrenaline	n	/əˈdren.əl.ɪn/	a hormone released in exciting or dangerous situations	adrenaline (chất gây hưng phấn)
momentum	n	/məˈmen.təm/	the force gained by a moving object	đà, lực quán tính
opt out	v phr		to choose not to participate in something	chọn không tham gia
diffuse	adj	/dɪˈfju:s/	spread over a wide area; not concentrated	lan tỏa, khuếch tán
immersion	n	/ɪˈmɜː.jən/	deep involvement or absorption in an experience	sự đắm chìm, trải nghiệm toàn diện

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Why are some people unwilling to try new things?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The resistance to novelty reflects a well-documented set of psychological dispositions whose origins are partly evolutionary and partly experiential. The most basic mechanism is loss aversion applied to experience rather than outcomes: people systematically overweight the potential negative outcomes of new experiences — embarrassment, failure, discomfort — relative to the potential positive ones, which makes the expected value of novelty appear lower than its actual expected value. The experiential component is habituation to existing preferences: the activities and environments one already engages with reliably deliver the satisfaction they are expected to deliver, whereas new experiences are genuinely uncertain in their payoff, and the uncertainty itself is aversive for people with low tolerance for ambiguity.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional corollary of reluctance to try new things is reluctance to try new professional approaches, which is recognisably related to the same underlying psychological mechanisms but has distinct organisational drivers. In professional settings, the reluctance to try new methods, technologies, or approaches is substantially driven by accountability structures that penalise failed experiments more heavily than they reward successful ones — which is a rational response to the incentive environment rather than a personality failing. The organisations that most successfully cultivate a culture of experimentation are those that have deliberately redesigned their accountability structures to reward learning from well-designed experiments regardless of outcome, rather than those that simply exhort their people to be bolder without changing the conditions under which boldness is evaluated.

2. Do you think fear stops people from trying new things?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Fear is certainly among the factors that reduce willingness to try new things, but the relationship is more complex than a simple causal statement captures. The fear most relevant to avoidance of new experiences is not primarily fear of physical danger — which is relevant only for a small subset of novel activities — but fear of social judgment: the anticipated embarrassment of performing badly, looking incompetent, or revealing limitations in front of others. This form of fear is particularly powerful because it is socially calibrated — it is more intense in front of audiences whose opinion matters more — which means that the same activity will feel more fear-inducing in front of colleagues than in front of strangers, and the social context of the new experience is often a more significant variable than the activity itself.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The honest professional answer is that fear is a necessary but not sufficient explanation for avoidance of new things: the fear component is real, but it intersects with cognitive inertia — the default preference for familiar approaches — and with the specific time cost that learning new things imposes on people whose existing competencies allow them to perform efficiently. Senior professionals are often reluctant to engage with genuinely new domains because the novice experience — the discomfort of performing below the level one is accustomed to — is disproportionately aversive for people who have invested significant time in developing high

competence in their current domain. The organisations that manage this most effectively create structured contexts — workshops, secondments, innovation projects — in which the novice experience for senior people is explicitly normalised and senior people's willingness to be seen learning is modelled as a virtue.

3. Why are some people keen on doing dangerous activities?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The attraction to dangerous activities reflects a set of motivational patterns that are better understood through the psychology of experience than through the lens of risk-seeking as a simple trait. The most important mechanism is the quality of attention that genuine physical challenge produces: activities that require full attentional deployment — where divided consciousness is not possible because the environment demands continuous responsive engagement — produce a form of experiential intensity that is very difficult to access through activities that don't carry real stakes. The second mechanism is the specific social reward that successful completion of difficult activities provides: having done something that is genuinely challenging produces a form of self-knowledge — a data point about one's capacity — that cannot be obtained through activities whose outcome was never in question.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional psychology of risk-seeking in recreational contexts reflects a broadly documented relationship between occupational stress and preference for sharply bounded, outcome-clear challenges in leisure. People in high-ambiguity professional roles — where effort and outcome have a complex and uncertain relationship, where feedback is delayed and indirect, and where the consequences of performance are diffuse — consistently show higher rates of engagement with physically demanding and outcome-clear recreational activities: marathon running, climbing, extreme sports. The explanation is that these activities provide what the professional context often does not: a clear relationship between effort and outcome, immediate feedback on performance, and a sharply defined success condition — all of which are psychologically restorative in the context of the ambiguity that sophisticated professional work typically imposes.

4. Do you think that children adapt to new things more easily than adults?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Children's apparent advantage in adapting to novelty is real in some domains — language acquisition being the clearest example — but the generational superiority narrative is overstated as a general claim. Children adapt more easily to experiences where the limiting factor is neurological plasticity: early language, musical pitch perception, and certain types of motor skill acquisition are genuinely easier before specific developmental windows close. Adults, by contrast, adapt more effectively to experiences where the limiting factor is transferable knowledge and strategic approach: adults learning a third language benefit from the cognitive framework of prior language acquisition in ways that children do not, and adults learning new professional skills can map the new domain onto existing conceptual structures rather than building from scratch.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The children-versus-adults adaptability comparison is most productively framed as a

difference in the nature of the adaptive process rather than its speed. Children’s adaptation involves higher plasticity in fundamental cognitive architecture — their neural systems are more malleable in ways that support certain kinds of learning that become progressively harder with age. Adults’ adaptation involves higher efficiency in mapping new experiences onto existing frameworks — metacognitive strategies, prior domain knowledge, and the ability to identify structural similarities between familiar and novel situations. The practical implication for adult learning design is that effective adult training should explicitly leverage the mapping advantage — using analogies, structural comparisons, and connection to existing competencies — rather than attempting to replicate a childhood learning context that adults’ cognitive architecture does not match.

5. What can people learn from doing dangerous activities?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Dangerous activities teach things that are difficult or impossible to learn from safe ones, which is the most concise statement of their distinctive developmental value. The most important thing they teach is an accurate calibration of one’s own capacity under genuine pressure: many people’s self-models overestimate their competence in comfortable conditions and are poorly calibrated for what they can actually do when conditions become genuinely demanding. Successfully completing a physically challenging and risky activity provides a specific form of self-knowledge — that the person discovered something about their actual capability rather than their projected capability — that is functionally different from knowledge derived from safe performance contexts.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The learning available from genuinely challenging activities in the professional context is primarily about the pattern of one’s response to situations where control is limited and outcome is uncertain — which is directly relevant to most high-stakes professional contexts even if the specific domain differs. The most organisationally valuable learning from difficult recreational activities is the behavioural self-portrait: understanding whether one escalates or stabilises under pressure, whether one’s decision quality improves or degrades as stakes rise, and whether one’s capacity to communicate and cooperate with others is enhanced or diminished by stress. These are patterns that are very difficult to observe in ordinary professional contexts where stakes rarely approach the clarity of genuine physical challenge.

6. What are the benefits of trying new things?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The benefits of novelty-seeking are well-documented across both psychological and neurological research, and they operate at multiple levels simultaneously. At the most immediate level, new experiences produce what psychologists call “hedonic adaptation interruption”— they break the process by which familiar experiences lose their capacity to produce positive affect through repetition — which means that novel experience is one of the most reliable available tools for maintaining subjective wellbeing across time. At a deeper level, new experiences produce new cognitive resources: exposure to unfamiliar contexts, challenges, and ways of doing things builds the repertoire of analogies, frameworks, and strategies that sophisticated reasoning in complex situations draws on.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional case for systematically trying new things rests primarily on what organisational learning research identifies as the most reliable driver of sustained adaptability: the regular practice of performing below one's current competence level in new domains. Professionals who routinely engage with genuinely novel challenges — domains, technologies, approaches, and contexts they have no prior experience in — maintain a form of cognitive flexibility that those who remain within established domains of expertise progressively lose. The implication for professional development is that the most valuable development activities are not those that deepen existing competency but those that routinely expose the professional to the experience of genuine novice-level learning — which requires deliberate design, because the natural incentive structure of professional life strongly favours deepening existing expertise over developing new capacities.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
hedonic adaptation	n phr		the process by which people's happiness returns to a baseline after positive/negative events	thích nghi khoái lạc
neurological plasticity	n phr		the brain's ability to form new connections and change structure	tính linh hoạt thần kinh
metacognition	n	/,met.ə,kɒg'nɪʃ.ən/	thinking about one's own thinking processes	siêu nhận thức
cognitive inertia	n phr		the tendency to prefer familiar methods of thinking	quán tính nhận thức
secondment	n	/sɪ'kɒnd.mənt/	a temporary transfer to another job or organisation	biệt phái ngắn hạn
self-model	n phr		a person's internal representation of their own abilities	mô hình tự nhận thức
hedonic	adj	/hɪ'dɒn.ɪk/	relating to pleasure and the factors affecting wellbeing	thuộc về khoái lạc, hạnh phúc
exhort	v	/ɪg'zɔ:t/	to strongly encourage or urge someone to do something	thúc giục, khuyến khích mạnh
novice	n/adj	/'nɒv.ɪs/	a person new to a skill or activity	người mới bắt đầu, tập sự
attentional deployment	n phr		the directing of conscious attention to specific stimuli	triển khai sự chú ý có ý thức

2.40 Describe an interesting traditional story

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe an interesting traditional story. You should say:

- What the story is about
- When/how you knew it
- Who told you the story
- And explain how you felt when you first heard it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

One story that has stayed with me since childhood is the legend of Sơn Tinh and Thủy Tinh — the mountain god and the sea god who both sought to marry the same princess, My Nương, and whose rivalry explains, in mythological terms, why Vietnam floods every year. My grandmother told it to me when I was probably six or seven, during one of those long afternoons at her house in the countryside when the television wasn't working and she was the entertainment. What I remember most vividly is not the plot itself — which is essentially a contest and a cosmic grudge — but the way she told it: she had a way of making Thủy Tinh's anger genuinely frightening, and the image of the sea rising and rising each year as the water god repeated his failed assault on the mountain stayed with me in the way images from adult fiction rarely did. I was old enough to know it wasn't literally true but young enough to feel the truth of it as explanation — there's something deeply satisfying about a myth that takes an annual natural phenomenon and gives it an emotional cause: jealousy, rejection, the refusal to accept defeat. Looking back, what interests me more now is the structure of the story as cultural technology — a way of making the unavoidable comprehensible and the frightening liveable.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The traditional story I find most enduringly interesting is the tale of Tấm and Cám — the Vietnamese Cinderella analogue that is, on close reading, considerably darker and more morally complex than Western versions of the same archetype. I first encountered it as a picture book around the age of five, but I came to understand it differently when my mother read it again to my daughter a few years ago and I was present as an adult listener. The story is unusual among folk tales in that the heroine does not remain passive — in later versions, Tấm takes active vengeance against her stepsister, including forms of violence that Disney adaptations of comparable stories would find unfilmable — which raises genuinely interesting questions about what moral order the story is actually encoding. What struck me as an adult listener was the sophisticated emotional logic underneath the fairy-tale surface: Tấm's patience is not virtue for its own sake but a strategic disposition; her final authority is not granted by a prince but earned through suffering and demonstrated worth. I found myself explaining this to my daughter differently than I would have expected — not as a simple good-versus-evil story but as a story about what it takes to persist when the system is structurally against you.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
legend	n	/ˈledʒ.ənd/	a traditional story handed down from the past	truyền thuyết
archetype	n	/ˈɑː.kɪ.taɪp/	a typical or original model of a character or story type	nguyên mẫu, khuôn mẫu
cosmic	adj	/ˈkɒz.mɪk/	relating to the universe or forces beyond human scale	vũ trụ, bao la
myth	n	/mɪθ/	a traditional story explaining natural or cultural phenomena	thần thoại
narrative	n	/ˈnær.ə.tɪv/	a spoken or written account of connected events	câu chuyện, tường thuật
moral	n/adj	/ˈmɒr.əl/	a lesson conveyed by a story or experience	bài học đạo đức
folk tale	n phr		a traditional story passed down orally among ordinary people	truyện dân gian
motif	n	/məʊˈtiːf/	a recurring element or theme in a story or culture	mô-típ, chủ đề lặp lại
encode	v	/ɪnˈkəʊd/	to convert information into a symbolic system or hidden meaning	mã hoá, ẩn chứa
analogue	n	/ˈæn.ə.lɒɡ/	something that is similar to or corresponds with another thing	tương đương, tương tự

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What kind of stories do children like?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Children's story preferences reflect their developmental stage more than any fixed aesthetic: the stories that attract children most strongly are those that give imaginative access to experiences their actual lives don't yet provide — danger without genuine risk, moral clarity without real-world complexity, transformation without the irreversibility that makes real change frightening. The consistent cross-cultural finding is that children prefer stories with high narrative stakes — where something important hangs in the balance — and clear moral resolution: the satisfaction of the villain's defeat and the hero's reward is not naive but developmentally appropriate to a stage at which clear causal models of justice are being constructed. The preference for fantasy and anthropomorphic characters reflects the same dynamic: these devices lower the cognitive threshold for engaging with emotional material that would be too close and potentially overwhelming in realistic form.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional and developmental perspective on children's story preferences emphasises the distinction between what children enjoy and what adults assume they should enjoy or can handle. The research consistently shows that children are not frightened away from stories with dark elements — loss, injustice, genuine threat — when the narrative framework provides sufficient emotional scaffolding; what they find genuinely distressing is unresolved threat or moral ambiguity that the story's structure does not provide tools to process. The implication is that the bowdlerisation of traditional stories — the removal of darkness and complexity from fairy tales and folk narratives — may actually serve adult anxiety more than child wellbeing, and that children benefit from engagement with difficult material when the narrative context makes its difficulty manageable.

2. What are the benefits of listening to stories before bed?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Bedtime storytelling provides a distinctive set of developmental benefits that arise specifically from the combination of its temporal context — the transition to sleep — and its relational character: it is one of the few remaining daily activities that involves sustained, undivided co-attention between parent and child in an undistracted environment. The sleep transition context adds a specific dimension: the stories heard at bedtime are processed during sleep, including during the REM phases most associated with emotional memory consolidation, which some research suggests makes narrative material heard at bedtime disproportionately influential on the emotional schemas being formed during early development. The language development benefit is well-documented: sustained exposure to the vocabulary and sentence structures of storytelling — typically more varied and complex than ordinary conversational speech — is one of the most reliable drivers of the lexical range that predicts later reading comprehension.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for bedtime stories as a significant parenting practice rests on evidence that extends beyond their immediate enjoyment value. The ritual dimension — the consistency and predictability of the practice — provides the specific psychological benefit of a reliable transition structure: children whose bedtime routines include a consistent story report lower sleep onset anxiety, which has downstream effects on sleep quality and daytime emotional regulation. The attention and co-presence dimension is arguably the most significant: storytelling

at bedtime is one of the few parenting activities in which the quality of engagement is intrinsic to the activity rather than something that has to be consciously maintained against competing demands.

3. Why do most children like listening to stories before bedtime?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Children's consistent preference for bedtime stories reflects both the functional role the story plays in managing the sleep transition and the relational meaning of the ritual itself. The sleep transition is psychologically significant for young children in a way adults often underestimate: it involves separation from the waking social world and the adults who provide it security — a transition that is manageable with appropriate scaffolding and genuinely difficult without it. A story provides exactly the required scaffolding: it gives the mind an absorbing focus that progressively reduces the arousal of the waking day, shifts attention from the immediate environment to an imaginative space that is less demanding, and does so in the presence of a trusted adult whose voice is itself a source of calm.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The bedtime story preference persists well past the age at which children are capable of reading independently, which suggests it is serving functions beyond the informational: children who can read choose to be read to, because the experience of being read to by a trusted adult is qualitatively different from self-directed reading. The relational specificity of the experience is the key: it is not the story in the abstract that children value but the story in the context of a relationship — the particular voice, the particular comfort, the undivided attention that most of waking life does not provide. This relational dimension makes bedtime storytelling one of the parenting practices most resistant to technological substitution: recorded stories, audiobooks, and digital storytelling devices can deliver equivalent narrative content but cannot replicate the co-presence that accounts for much of the practice's value.

4. What can children learn from stories?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Stories are among the most efficient available technologies for transmitting complex social and moral knowledge to children, which is why narrative has been the dominant mode of cultural transmission across virtually all human societies throughout recorded history. The primary learning that stories provide is emotional: they give children access to the inner lives of characters — to fear, loss, injustice, love, decision, and consequence — in a form that is safely distanced from the immediacy of the child's own experience, which allows emotional understanding to develop ahead of the circumstances that will eventually require it. The moral learning stories provide is more complex than simple rule-transmission: well-constructed stories present moral dilemmas rather than moral conclusions, which develops the evaluative reasoning capacity that abstract rule-following does not.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The learning available from stories is multi-layered in ways that direct instruction cannot easily replicate. At the cognitive level, stories develop narrative comprehension — the ability to track causality, motivation, and consequence across extended sequences of events — which is foundational to the kinds of reasoning that complex adult professional and social situations

require. At the social-emotional level, stories develop theory of mind: the capacity to attribute mental states to others and to reason about how people's beliefs, desires, and feelings generate their behaviour — a capacity that research identifies as one of the most important predictors of social and professional effectiveness. The cultural transmission function is perhaps most significant of all: stories carry the values, concerns, and wisdom of specific communities across generations in forms that abstract statement cannot.

5. Do all stories for children have happy endings?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The assumption that children's stories should have happy endings is largely a product of twentieth-century Western commercial children's publishing and its particular model of childhood as a space to be protected from unpleasant reality — a model that is historically recent and culturally specific rather than universal. Traditional folk tales across most of the world's storytelling traditions include far greater varieties of ending: stories where the protagonist fails, where justice is imperfect, where loss is permanent, and where the moral is not consolation but warning. The developmental argument against requiring happy endings is that children who are only exposed to narratives with guaranteed resolution are poorly prepared for the experience of living in a world where resolution is not guaranteed.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional developmental perspective on story endings is that the question of happy versus unhappy is less important than the question of emotionally resolved versus emotionally unresolved. Children can process genuinely sad or difficult story outcomes when the narrative framework provides sufficient emotional scaffolding — the sadness is acknowledged, the response to it is modelled, and the child is not left with unmanageable affect at the end of the story. What children find genuinely distressing in stories is not sadness or loss per se but narratives that generate strong negative affect and then fail to provide any emotional processing structure — stories that leave them anxious and uncertain rather than sad and acknowledged.

6. Is a good storyline important for a movie?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

A compelling storyline is the foundation of sustained viewer engagement in a way that no other cinematic element — performance, visual effects, cinematography, score — can substitute for, because narrative is the primary mechanism through which films generate emotional investment and the motivation to continue watching. Films with visually spectacular but narratively weak content consistently produce a specific dissatisfaction pattern: initial engagement with the spectacle followed by progressive disengagement as the absence of narrative stakes becomes apparent. The counter-argument — that certain genres (action, horror, certain forms of art cinema) can sustain engagement without conventional strong narrative — is partially valid but overstated: even these genres depend on some form of narrative tension or question to sustain attention, even if that question is not resolved in conventional ways.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The industry data on what drives sustained commercial performance for films is unambiguous in identifying narrative quality as the most robust predictor: films with strong scripts —

coherent structure, compelling characters, and meaningful stakes — consistently outperform visually superior but narratively weak productions over the medium term, even when the narratively weaker productions may have higher opening-weekend numbers driven by marketing and spectacle. The implication that the industry has been slower than the evidence warrants to absorb is that investment in script development — the least visually impressive and most intellectually demanding phase of film production — produces better long-term commercial returns than equivalent investment in production values. The streaming era has partially corrected this miscalibration: algorithmic completion rate data has made the correlation between narrative quality and sustained viewer engagement much more visible to commissioners than theatrical box office data alone permitted.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
narrative stakes	n phr		the sense of what is at risk for characters in a story	những gì đang bị đặt cược trong câu chuyện
bowdlerise	v	/ˈbaʊd.lə.raɪz/	to remove offensive or disturbing content from a text	tẩy trắng nội dung, kiểm duyệt quá mức
scaffolding	n phr		temporary support provided to help someone learn or manage difficulty	giàn giáo hỗ trợ (giáo dục/cảm xúc)
theory of mind	n phr		the ability to understand that others have their own beliefs and desires	lý thuyết về tâm trí người khác
REM sleep	n phr		rapid eye movement sleep, important for memory and emotion processing	giấc ngủ REM (chuyển động mắt nhanh)
completion rate	n phr		the percentage of viewers who finish watching a piece of content	tỷ lệ xem hết
anthropomorphic	adj	/ˌæn.θrə.pəˈmɔː.fɪk/	attributing human characteristics to non-human things	nhân cách hoá
lexical range	n phr		the breadth of vocabulary a person knows and uses	phạm vi từ vựng
cultural transmission	n phr		the passing of knowledge and values between generations	truyền tải văn hoá qua các thế hệ
commissioner	n	/kəˈmɪʃ.ən.ər/	a person who formally arranges for a creative work to be produced	người đặt hàng sản phẩm sáng tạo

2.41 Describe a city that you have been to and would like to visit again

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a city that you have been to and would like to visit again. You should say:

- When you visited it
- What you did there
- What it was like
- And explain why you would like to visit it again.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The city I keep wanting to go back to is Hội An — I visited for the first time about two years ago with a group of friends from university, and I have thought about it regularly since in the specific way I only think about places that feel like they gave me something I couldn't have anticipated beforehand. We had four days, which was enough to get beyond the most crowded parts of the Old Town and find the rhythm of the place — the quieter streets of the eastern quarter in the early morning before the lanterns come on for the tourist circuit, the rice fields on the outskirts that nobody goes to because nothing happens there, the fact that it's a genuinely small city in a way that Hà Nội and Hồ Chí Minh simply are not. What I want to go back for is less about specific things I missed and more about returning to a place I feel I partially understood: there's a quality of stillness in Hội An that I found surprisingly restorative, and I suspect it would mean something different to me now than it did then. I'm also aware that Hội An is changing — the volume of tourism is transforming it in ways that are already visibly different from photographs taken a decade ago — which gives the desire to return a slight urgency.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Singapore is the city I most want to return to, and the reason is primarily professional rather than tourist: I visited for four days about three years ago for a conference, which meant I saw the city in a specific mode — the conference hotel, the immediate neighbourhood, two evenings of deliberate exploration — that gave me enough of the texture of the place to want to understand it more fully but not nearly enough time to do so. What struck me on that visit was the quality of urban design in ways that are difficult to articulate precisely: not the architectural spectacle — that is visible in photographs — but the functional thoughtfulness of how the city manages pedestrian circulation, shade, humidity, public transport integration, and the relationship between commercial and civic space in a way that most Southeast Asian cities have not achieved at comparable scale. I want to go back specifically to understand whether what I experienced was a genuine model worth thinking about professionally — Singapore as a case study in what conscious urban design at the level of a city-state can produce — or whether the impressions of four days and a conference schedule were misleadingly positive. I suspect it's the former, but the question is worth a longer investigation.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
Old Town	n phr		the historic central area of a city, often preserved or restored	phố cổ
civic space	n phr		publicly accessible areas designed for community use	không gian công cộng đô thị
pedestrian circulation	n phr		the movement of people on foot through an urban area	lưu thông người đi bộ
urban design	n phr		the planning and arrangement of buildings, streets, and public spaces	thiết kế đô thị
restorative	adj	/rɪ'stɔː.rə.tɪv/	having the effect of restoring health, energy, or wellbeing	hồi phục, phục hồi
articulate	v	/ɑː'tɪk.jʊ.leɪt/	to express an idea clearly and effectively	diễn đạt rõ ràng
infrastructure	n	/ˈɪn.freˌstrʌk.tʃər/	the basic systems that allow a city to function	cơ sở hạ tầng
texture	n	/'teks.tʃər/	the quality and feel of a place or experience	kết cấu, chất cảm của nơi chốn
circuit	n	/'sɜː.kɪt/	a route that forms a loop or covers a specific area	tuyến đường khép kín
spectacle	n	/'spek.tə.kəl/	a visually striking or impressive display	cảnh tượng, quang cảnh ấn tượng

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What's the difference between the city and the countryside?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The city-countryside distinction operates across multiple dimensions simultaneously — economic, social, environmental, and psychological — and the most superficially obvious differences (density, infrastructure, pace) are often less significant than the less visible ones. The most consequential structural difference is economic: cities concentrate a density and diversity of economic activity — commercial, professional, educational, cultural — that rural areas cannot sustain at comparable scale, which makes them both generators of greater average income and destinations for internal migration from rural areas seeking the economic opportunities that concentration creates. The lifestyle differences that most people notice most readily — pace, anonymity, noise, access to amenity — are derivative of this economic structure rather than independent characteristics.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional understanding of city-countryside differences has moved significantly beyond the simple quality-of-life comparison that dominates popular discussion. The most important structural finding is that the city-countryside divide is increasingly a divide between two different economic and social regimes rather than two points on a single quality continuum: cities have captured the majority of high-productivity economic activity in almost every country where this has been measured, which means the rural-urban gap in income, educational attainment, and access to services reflects a structural economic divergence rather than a simple preference difference. The policy challenge this creates is that interventions designed to reduce the gap — rural investment programmes, decentralisation policies — face the structural headwind of agglomeration economies that consistently make urban concentration more economically efficient.

2. Some people say large cities are suitable for old people. What do you think?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Large cities are simultaneously more and less suitable for older people than rural areas in ways that depend heavily on each individual's specific circumstances, physical capacity, and social situation. The case for cities being suitable for older people rests on the density of services they provide: proximity to medical care, transport that doesn't require a car, cultural and recreational amenity, and access to diverse social networks — all of which become more valuable as physical mobility reduces and the consequences of health events become more serious. The case against is the ways in which urban environments are optimised for younger, economically active populations: noise, crowding, pollution levels, pace of pedestrian traffic, and the social anonymity of dense urban contexts are all characteristics that become more burdensome as people age.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The suitability of large cities for older residents is largely an urban design question rather than an inherent feature of city scale: cities that have deliberately designed for age-inclusivity — with accessible public transport, safe pedestrian infrastructure, neighbourhood-level community services, and mixed-age social environments — are demonstrably more suitable for older people than those that have not, regardless of size. The relevant comparison is not city-versus-countryside but well-designed-city versus poorly-designed-city, and the policy direction in ageing societies that have recognised this has been toward age-friendly

urban design standards rather than encouraging older people to leave cities for rural environments that often lack the service density that their needs require.

3. Do you think it is possible that all of the population move to cities?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Complete urbanisation — the movement of all or virtually all of a country's population into cities — is theoretically conceivable but practically limited by the economic and ecological functions that rural populations continue to serve. The most binding constraint is food production: agricultural systems in most countries cannot be fully operated by a workforce that commutes from urban centres, and the spatial distribution of agricultural activity requires at minimum a population distributed across rural and peri-urban environments. A second constraint is the agglomeration diseconomies of extreme urban density: very large cities generate congestion, pollution, and social costs that progressively reduce the net advantage of further concentration, which creates an economic limit to the degree to which urban concentration can increase.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The trajectory of urbanisation globally is toward very high but not complete urban population shares, and the countries that have progressed furthest along this trajectory — such as Singapore, which has an essentially entirely urban population — are city-states whose geographic specificity makes them poor models for larger territorial states. The functional limit of urbanisation in territorial states is set by the irreducibly spatial character of certain economic activities — agriculture, mineral extraction, energy generation, nature-based tourism — that require distributed geographic presence rather than urban concentration. What changes as urbanisation increases is not the elimination of rural activity but the reduction in the population required to conduct it: mechanisation and precision agriculture continue to reduce the agricultural workforce without reducing agricultural output, which means that rural population decline and agricultural productivity improvement are complementary rather than contradictory trends.

4. Do you think people in the countryside are friendlier than people in the city?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The perception that rural people are friendlier than urban people is widespread but reflects the specific social context of encounters with strangers in low-density versus high-density settings rather than a genuine personality difference between populations. In rural environments, encounters between strangers are infrequent enough to justify and reward social engagement: acknowledging a stranger on a country road is a relatively low-cost, high-return social act. In dense urban environments, the social arithmetic is reversed: the volume of potential stranger-encounters is so high that acknowledged engagement with all of them is impossible, which produces the selective inattention that urban residents learn as a functional adaptation to density rather than as a cultural preference for coldness.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The urban-unfriendly stereotype is a persistent mischaracterisation that conflates withdrawal from public stranger-interaction with general social coldness — a conflation that doesn't survive examination of how urban residents behave in contexts where stranger-engagement

is appropriate. Urban residents are consistently more socially diverse in their networks, more likely to have engaged in voluntary civic activity, and more likely to develop and maintain deep friendships across social and geographic distance than rural counterparts — precisely because the urban environment provides greater exposure to diverse human beings and a richer infrastructure for social connection. What cities don't provide is the low-threshold public sociability of small communities — the automatic acknowledgment of shared local space — which is sometimes mistaken for warmth when it is more accurately described as the social technology of a low-density environment.

5. Are there any changes in your city?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Vietnamese cities — and Hà Nội in particular — have undergone changes in the past decade that are substantial enough to be visible within a single generation's lived experience, which makes the comparison with the city ten years ago a genuinely vivid rather than abstract one for most residents. The most visible changes are infrastructural: the metro system, the expansion of the road network into previously peri-urban areas, the displacement of older low-rise commercial and residential stock by high-rise development across much of the inner city. Less visible but arguably more consequential are the social and economic changes: the displacement of lower-income and traditional residents from central areas by rising land values, the transformation of neighbourhood commercial patterns by e-commerce, and the progressive disappearance of the specific urban street culture that characterised Hà Nội's inner core.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The pace of change in Vietnamese cities over the past decade is unusual by international comparison: it would take most European cities three to four decades to accumulate the degree of physical and social transformation that Hà Nội and Hồ Chí Minh have undergone in ten years — a pace that creates both rapid improvements in material standards and rapid losses of the urban character that constituted each city's specific identity. The professional urban planning perspective on this pace is ambivalent: the infrastructure improvements and economic development are genuine and important gains; the loss of architectural heritage, neighbourhood spatial character, and socially mixed inner-city populations are genuine and important losses; and the institutional frameworks for managing these trade-offs have not yet developed at the speed the change requires.

6. What should the government do to improve citizens' safety?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Urban safety is a multidimensional problem whose most effective interventions are consistently identified in public safety research but are systematically underprioritised relative to their evidence base. Street design is the most reliable safety lever available to governments: pedestrian infrastructure quality, footpath continuity, street lighting, and the elimination of uncontrolled vehicle access to pedestrian spaces produce measurable reductions in both traffic accidents and street crime at costs that are usually modest relative to their impact. The second most evidence-based intervention is social investment: crime rates are most strongly and consistently predicted by neighbourhood-level economic inequality and the availability of productive social activity for at-risk populations, which means social services, youth programming,

and community infrastructure are more effective crime reduction investments than equivalent expenditure on enforcement.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The evidence on urban safety policy is sufficiently robust to support a clear hierarchy of interventions, though this hierarchy is not always reflected in government priorities. Traffic safety — which in Vietnam accounts for significantly more premature deaths annually than crime — is the area where evidence-based intervention has the clearest potential for large rapid impact: enforcement of speed limits and helmet laws, infrastructure redesign to reduce pedestrian-vehicle conflict, and graduated licensing systems are all interventions with strong evidence bases and large potential benefits relative to current Vietnamese mortality data. Crime reduction, which receives disproportionate political attention relative to its contribution to urban mortality, is most effectively addressed through the social investment approaches mentioned above rather than through increased police presence alone — an intervention that research consistently finds has weaker effects on crime rates than equivalent investment in the social determinants of criminal behaviour.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
agglomeration economies	n phr		benefits gained when firms or people cluster together in cities	lợi kinh tế từ sự tập trung địa lý
peri-urban	adj	/ˌper.i'ɜː.bən/	relating to areas on the edge of cities	vùng ven đô
inattention	n	/ˌɪn.ə'tenʃən/	failure to notice or pay attention to things	sự thiếu chú ý
displace	v	/dɪ'spleɪs/	to force something or someone to leave their place	di dời, thay thế
graduated licensing	n phr		a system where driving privileges increase with experience and age	cấp phép lái xe theo giai đoạn
social determinants	n phr		social and economic conditions that affect health and behaviour	yếu tố xã hội quyết định hành vi
heritage	n	/'her.ɪ.tɪdʒ/	features belonging to the culture of a particular society	di sản văn hoá
civic	adj	/'sɪv.ɪk/	relating to the rights and duties of citizens in a community	thuộc công dân, đô thị
mortality	n	/mɔː'tæl.ɪ.ti/	death rate in a population	tỷ lệ tử vong
enforcement	n	/ɪn'fɔːs.mənt/	the act of making rules and laws obeyed	thực thi (pháp luật)

2.42 Describe a shop / store you enjoy visiting

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a shop / store you enjoy visiting. You should say:

- What the shop's name is
- Where it is
- How often you visit it
- And explain why you like to visit it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

There's a small second-hand bookshop on Đinh Lễ street in Hà Nội — it doesn't have a proper sign, just books stacked in both windows and spilling into cardboard boxes on the pavement — that I've been going to since my first year of university whenever I'm in the Old Quarter with a bit of spare time. I go about once a month, sometimes less, but the visits feel disproportionately significant relative to how brief they usually are — I've never spent more than forty minutes there, but I almost always leave with something I didn't know I was looking for. What I like about it has almost nothing to do with the specific books, which are unpredictable and not necessarily cheap: it's the quality of the browsing experience, which requires a different kind of attention than shopping with a specific purpose. You have to look at things without knowing what you want, which is an experience contemporary consumer culture increasingly doesn't make room for. The owner — an older man who rarely speaks but occasionally recommends something by simply placing a book on top of whatever you're holding — is part of what makes it feel like a place rather than just a shop.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The shop I find myself returning to most reliably is a kitchen supply store near Chợ Hôm in Hà Nội that stocks professional-grade cooking equipment alongside the ordinary domestic range — the kind of place where you can find Japanese ceramic knives alongside Vietnamese clay pots and French copper saucepans in the same few square metres. I started going there about four years ago when I began taking cooking more seriously as a weekend activity, and I've been back probably a dozen times since, which is unusual for me given that I don't go there to buy anything specific — I go because the quality of what they stock reflects genuine expertise rather than retail calculation, and browsing it is a form of education. There's something the shop demonstrates about the difference between professional and amateur equipment that is very difficult to understand from descriptions or online reviews: you need to hold a properly balanced knife, or feel the weight of a good cast-iron pan, to understand why the difference matters. I leave most visits with something I didn't plan to buy and no regrets about the purchase, which is not a description I could apply to many shopping experiences.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
second-hand	adj		previously owned by someone else	cũ, đã qua sử dụng
browse	v	/braʊz/	to look through things in a casual or leisurely way	đọc lướt, xem qua
retail	adj/n	/ˈriː.teɪl/	the sale of goods to consumers, not businesses	bán lẻ
professional-grade	adj		of a standard used by professionals rather than hobbyists	cấp độ chuyên nghiệp
amenity	n	/əˈmiː.nɪ.ti/	a feature that makes a place comfortable or enjoyable	tiện nghi, tiện ích
cast-iron	adj		made of a hard heavy alloy, used for durable cookware	gang (vật liệu nồi, chảo)
impulse purchase	n phr		something bought spontaneously without prior planning	mua hàng ngẫu hứng
consumer culture	n phr		a social system driven by the buying and selling of goods	văn hoá tiêu dùng
stall	n	/stɔːl/	a small stand or shop, often in a market	quầy hàng, gian hàng
expertise	n	/ˌek.spɜːˈtiːz/	expert skill or knowledge in a particular field	chuyên môn, chuyên nghiệp

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Do people in your country go to the shopping mall frequently?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Shopping mall attendance in Vietnam has increased substantially over the past decade, particularly in the major cities, but the pattern of use is more complex than the frequency data alone suggests. Malls in urban Vietnam serve functions beyond retail: they are air-conditioned public spaces in a climate where outdoor comfort is limited for much of the year, which attracts visitors — particularly young people and families — for social and leisure purposes that have only a loose relationship to shopping. The most visited areas of major Vietnamese malls are consistently the food courts and cinema complexes rather than the retail floors, which suggests that malls are functioning more as urban leisure infrastructure than as primarily commercial retail environments.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The frequency of mall attendance in Vietnam reflects the country's rapid urban retail development rather than a stable cultural preference: the mall as a primary leisure destination is a phenomenon largely of the past fifteen years in major Vietnamese cities, driven by rising urban middle-class incomes and the inability of traditional street retail to provide the standardised, climate-controlled, entertainment-integrated shopping experience that this demographic increasingly expects. That said, the model's sustainability is uncertain: global data on mall performance shows significant divergence between malls that have successfully evolved into experiential leisure destinations and those that have remained primarily retail-focused, with the latter showing consistent footfall decline as e-commerce captures their commodity retail function.

2. How have people's shopping habits changed in recent decades?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The transformation of consumer shopping behaviour over the past two decades is among the most rapid structural changes in any aspect of daily economic life — driven primarily by e-commerce, but also by changing attitudes toward ownership, sustainability, and the relationship between shopping and identity. The most consequential change is the channel shift: the movement of commodity purchasing — standardised goods whose physical characteristics don't require evaluation in person — from physical retail to online platforms, which has hollowed out the commodity retail segment of physical shopping while leaving the experiential and social retail segments relatively more robust. A secondary but increasingly significant change is the rise of second-hand and rental consumption as a response to both cost pressure and growing environmental consciousness, particularly among younger consumers.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional retail analysis of shopping habit changes identifies a bifurcation in consumer behaviour as the dominant structural shift. Commodity purchasing has moved decisively online — a trend that COVID-19 significantly accelerated across all age groups — while experiential retail (dining, entertainment, services, and physical product categories that benefit from in-person evaluation) has shown more resilience and in some categories has increased demand for the very physicality that commodity retail is losing. The implication for retail strategy is that physical retail must increasingly compete on experience quality rather than product access: any product available online for cheaper delivery cannot sustain a physical retail location on price competition alone, which means physical retail's sustainable value proposition is now experiential rather than transactional.

3. Do you think shops and shopping malls will disappear in the future?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Complete disappearance of physical retail is implausible, but the current form of the shopping mall as a primarily retail destination is under serious structural pressure that will produce major reconfiguration rather than simple decline. The merchandise categories most vulnerable to e-commerce displacement — electronics, apparel, household goods, media — are precisely those that anchor most current mall tenant mixes; the categories most resistant to displacement — food, entertainment, services, and physical experience — are those that malls have been adding but which require fundamentally different spatial configurations than traditional retail floors. The mall that survives the next twenty years will look substantially more like a leisure and community facility than the primarily retail environment of the past thirty.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of physical retail survival is best answered at the category level rather than as an aggregate. Commodity physical retail — shops whose primary function is providing access to standardised products at competitive prices — will continue to decline as e-commerce logistics become more cost-efficient. Experiential physical retail — shops whose value lies in the physical experience of the space, the expertise of the staff, and the social context of the visit — has a durable value proposition that online environments cannot replicate, and this segment is likely to grow in relative importance even if it remains smaller in absolute terms. The shopping malls most likely to survive are those that recognise this distinction and reconfigure their tenant mix and physical design accordingly.

4. What are the differences between shopping in street markets and big shopping malls?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Street markets and shopping malls represent fundamentally different retail philosophies rather than simply different scales of the same activity. Street markets are characterised by negotiation, sensory richness, vendor personality, and the absence of standardisation — prices, quality, and selection vary from stall to stall in ways that reward knowledge and engagement — whereas malls are characterised by standardised pricing, branded environment, climate control, and the elimination of negotiation and unpredictability. The experiential difference these structural differences produce is significant: street markets require more active consumer engagement and offer greater reward for expertise and bargaining skill, while malls offer convenience, predictability, and comfort at the cost of the specific forms of engagement that market shopping requires.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional distinction between markets and malls is most productively framed as a distinction between relational and transactional retail environments. Street markets are relational: the transaction is embedded in a social interaction with a specific vendor, involves personal communication and often negotiation, and builds over repeated visits into a form of relationship and trust. Malls are transactional: the transaction is a standardised exchange with a brand rather than a person, governed by fixed prices and return policies, and optimised for completion rather than relationship. These are not simply different aesthetic preferences

— they serve different social and economic functions, and the decline of market retail relative to mall and e-commerce retail reflects partly genuine consumer preference and partly the systematic undervaluation of the social functions that relational retail environments provide.

5. What are the differences in the shopping habits of different age groups?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Generational differences in shopping behaviour reflect both differing relationships to technology and differing life stage priorities rather than purely cultural preferences. Younger consumers — particularly those who grew up with smartphones — have substantially higher rates of e-commerce use for most product categories, lower preference for physical retail browsing, and higher engagement with peer review and social media recommendation as purchase inputs. Older consumers show higher retention of physical retail habits, particularly for certain product categories — fresh food, clothing, pharmaceuticals — where physical evaluation remains important, and lower engagement with the algorithmic discovery processes that shape younger consumers' awareness of products.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The generational shopping behaviour data reveals a useful distinction between channel preference and value orientation. Younger consumers differ from older ones not only in their preference for digital channels but also in the values that drive their purchasing decisions: sustainability considerations, brand ethics, and social impact credentials are significantly more influential among younger consumers than older ones, which is transforming the competitive landscape for retail categories where these attributes can be credibly communicated. The retail businesses that are managing this generational transition most effectively are those that have invested in making their supply chain and ethical commitments legible to younger consumers rather than those competing purely on price and convenience.

6. What are the differences between shopping online and in-store?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Online and in-store shopping differ across multiple dimensions — price, convenience, sensory engagement, social context, and the quality of information available about products — and the optimal channel for any given purchase depends on which of these dimensions matters most for that specific category. For standardised commodity products — where the specification is known and the decision is primarily about price and availability — online shopping is systematically superior in convenience, price comparison, and selection breadth. For products where physical evaluation is important — fit, texture, weight, freshness, or the specific experience of using or wearing something — in-store shopping provides access to information that online channels can approximate but not yet fully substitute for.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The online-versus-in-store comparison is increasingly relevant to retail strategy because the rise of "showrooming"— evaluating products in-store and purchasing online — and "webrooming"— researching online before purchasing in-store — complicates the simple channel attribution that retail analytics historically relied on. The most sophisticated retailers now design their physical and digital channels as complementary rather than competing — using physical stores to provide the experiential and relational value that drives brand affinity and long-term customer relationships, while using digital channels to maximise the

convenience and selection breadth that drives repeat transactional volume. The retailers who are declining are those still treating the two channels as competitors for the same purchasing occasion rather than as complementary touchpoints in an integrated customer experience.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
showrooming	n		evaluating a product in a physical store but buying it online for a lower price	xem hàng tại cửa, mua online
webrooming	n		researching a product online before buying it in a physical store	tìm hiểu online, mua trực tiếp
footfall	n	/ˈfʊt.fɔːl/	the number of people entering a shop or area	lượng khách đến
tenant mix	n phr		the combination of different shops or businesses in a mall	cơ cấu thuê mặt bằng
bifurcation	n	/ˌbaɪ.fɜːˈkeɪ.jən/	the division of something into two branches or parts	sự phân kỳ thành hai nhánh
attribution	n	/ˌæt.rɪˈbjʊː.jən/	identifying the cause or source of a result	phân bổ (trong phân tích kinh doanh)
touchpoint	n	/ˈtʌtʃ.pɔɪnt/	any point of contact between a brand and a customer	điểm tiếp xúc (khách hàng)
commodity	n/adj	/kəˈmɒd.i.ti/	a standardised product traded on price rather than differentiated features	hàng hoá thông thường
brand affinity	n phr		the emotional connection and loyalty a customer feels toward a brand	sự gắn kết thương hiệu
supply chain	n phr		the sequence of processes involved in producing and delivering a product	chuỗi cung ứng

2.43 Describe a time when you received good service in a shop / store

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a time when you received good service in a shop / store. You should say:

- Where the shop is
- When you went to the shop
- What service you received from the staff
- And explain how you felt about the service.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

About eighteen months ago I walked into a running shoe shop on Thái Hà street completely unprepared — I'd been referred there by a friend who runs seriously, I had almost no knowledge of what I actually needed, and I half expected to leave quickly with something generic and expensive. The staff member who helped me — a younger guy who ran marathons, as it turned out — spent about thirty minutes watching me walk, asking specific questions about how far I was running, on what surfaces and at what pace, and then brought out four pairs in a specific order with clear explanations of why each differed from the last. He wasn't upselling: two of the four pairs were actually cheaper than what I'd come in expecting to spend, and when I gravitated toward one of the more expensive options on aesthetic grounds he told me, quite straightforwardly, that the sole was probably over-built for my current training volume and that the cheaper pair would serve me better. I bought the cheaper pair, and he was right. What stayed with me wasn't the transaction itself but the quality of attention it involved — the experience of being helped by someone who clearly understood what I needed better than I did and whose purpose was getting the answer right rather than maximising the sale.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The instance of genuinely good service that I remember most clearly happened at a small wine shop near Hồ Tây about two years ago, when I went to buy something appropriate for a dinner I was hosting for a colleague who I knew had strong opinions about wine but whose specific preferences I didn't know well enough to guess. The shop owner — an older woman who had been running the shop for about fifteen years — asked a series of questions that were notably not the questions I expected: not "what's your budget" but "what are you serving, and what do you want the dinner to feel like?" When I described the situation — including my uncertainty about my colleague's preferences — she said, without any additional prelude, that I should probably explain the uncertainty to my colleague rather than trying to compensate for it through the wine choice, and that the two bottles she was recommending were both good enough that neither would be wrong. The advice was more useful than she was obligated to give, and the dinner was fine. What I remember about the experience is the specific form of confidence it involved — the confidence of someone who knows enough about their domain to give advice that serves the customer rather than the transaction.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
upsell	v	/ˈʌp.səl/	to persuade a customer to buy something more expensive than planned	bán thêm sản phẩm cao cấp hơn
sole	n	/səʊl/	the bottom part of a shoe	đế giày
transaction	n	/trænˈzæk.ʃən/	an instance of buying or selling	giao dịch
over-built	adj		having excess features or materials beyond what is needed for the purpose	quá cầu kỳ, dư thừa tính năng
domain	n	/dəˈmeɪn/	a specific area of knowledge or activity	lĩnh vực chuyên môn
prelude	n	/ˈprel.juːd/	an introductory or preliminary action	phần mở đầu, dẫn nhập
gravitate toward	v phr		to be naturally attracted or drawn to something	bị thu hút về phía
referred	v pp	/rɪˈfɜːd/	directed to a person or place by another	được giới thiệu đến
recommendation	n	/ˌrek.ə.menˈdeɪ.ʃən/	a suggestion that something is good or suitable	sự gợi ý, khuyến nghị
maximise	v	/ˈmæk.sɪ.maɪz/	to make as large or great as possible	tối đa hoá

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Why are shopping malls so popular in China?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The Chinese shopping mall phenomenon reflects a convergence of demographic, climatic, and infrastructural factors that together make malls a rational leisure destination for a

larger portion of the Chinese urban population than in most comparable markets. The most important driver is the emergence of a large urban middle class with disposable income but limited alternative leisure infrastructure: in many Chinese cities, malls compete primarily with uncontrolled outdoor environments and residences rather than with the diverse recreational facilities available in older European or American cities. The climate dimension reinforces this: in both northern cities where winters are severe and southern cities where summers are extremely hot, the air-conditioned, weatherproof environment of a mall provides everyday comfort that outdoor alternatives cannot reliably deliver.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The Chinese mall's popularity reflects a genuine gap that it fills in the urban lifestyle of a rapidly urbanising society. The most important gap is social and recreational rather than commercial: Chinese urban residents have experienced rapid rises in income but slower development of the public spaces, cultural institutions, and community facilities that older societies developed incrementally over longer periods — which makes the mall, as a privately managed but publicly accessible leisure environment, a functional substitute for the urban commons that Chinese cities' rapid development has not yet fully built. The experience-over-goods shift visible in Chinese mall tenant mixes — the shift from retail-dominant to food, entertainment, and experience-dominant configurations — reflects the maturation of this dynamic: malls that understood their primary function as social rather than commercial have sustained footfall better than those that remained primarily retail-focused.

2. What are the advantages and disadvantages of shopping in small shops?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Small shops offer a specific cluster of advantages that large format retail cannot replicate, centred on the relational and knowledge dimensions of the shopping experience. The knowledge advantage is the most practically significant: small specialists typically have deeper product knowledge in their specific category than staff in large generalist retailers, which makes them disproportionately valuable for purchase decisions that require genuine expertise — specialist food, technical equipment, unusual clothing sizes or styles, complex service categories. The disadvantages are structural: small shops cannot offer the selection breadth, price competition, or operating consistency of large format retail, which means they serve segments of the market well while being genuinely less competitive for the commodity purchasing that most shopping volume consists of.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional analysis of small versus large format retail advantages identifies experience quality and expertise as small shops' durable competitive assets. That said, the disadvantage set facing small retail is increasingly structural rather than merely competitive: rising commercial rents in prime locations, the labour cost of the staff quality that genuine expertise requires, and the inability to absorb inventory risk on the scale that price competitiveness demands are collectively making the small specialist model difficult to sustain in urban markets where costs are rising faster than the segment of consumers willing to pay the premium that genuine expertise commands. The long-term trajectory is toward fewer but higher-quality small specialist retailers in premium locations, with the mid-market small retail segment losing to large format and e-commerce.

3. Why do some people not like shopping in small shops?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The resistance to small shop retail reflects a set of real disadvantages that are well-founded rather than merely perceptual. Price is the most frequently cited concern: small shops typically cannot match the procurement economics that allow large retailers to price commodity goods competitively, which means the premium paid for small retail is real and visible in a way that requires specific justification for each category. Social comfort is a less frequently acknowledged but significant factor: small shops with knowledgeable staff create an implicit expectation of engagement that some shoppers find pressuring — the sense that browsing without buying generates a social cost, and that the level of attention from staff requires justification through a purchase.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The reasons professionals and busy urban consumers in particular underuse small specialist retail are typically practical rather than principled: time pressure, the inconvenience of operating hours that often do not match working schedules, the physical effort of visiting multiple specialist locations rather than a single large format store, and the uncertainty about stock availability that makes the visit potentially wasted. These are not objections to small retail's quality proposition — most consumers who articulate these preferences also acknowledge that small specialist retailers are often better in the categories where they operate — but to the operational context in which small retail operates. The implication for small retail strategy is that reducing friction (extended hours, online presence, appointment availability) is at least as important as quality of product and expertise.

4. What are the differences between online shopping and in-store shopping?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Online and in-store shopping differ structurally in the type of information they provide and the type of experience they create, which makes them appropriate for different purchasing contexts rather than simply alternatives on a convenience spectrum. Online shopping excels at providing comparative information across a large product set — prices, specifications, reviews, and availability — at very low search cost, which makes it the dominant rational choice for standardised products where specification is fully knowable prior to purchase. In-store shopping provides physical sensory information — weight, texture, fit, smell, the experience of using a product briefly before buying it — that remains important for categories where these attributes significantly affect purchase satisfaction and cannot be adequately approximated by photographs, descriptions, or reviews.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional retail distinction between channels is less about which is better in the abstract and more about which stage of the purchasing process each channel serves most effectively. For discovery and comparison — identifying what options exist and how they differ on measurable attributes — digital channels have replaced in-store for most categories and most consumers. For evaluation of physical attributes and the service interaction that converts consideration into purchase commitment — particularly in high-value or technically complex categories — in-store remains valuable in ways that digital channels have not yet substituted. The omnichannel retail strategies that are performing best are those that design each channel to serve the stage of the customer journey where it has genuine advantage rather than trying to make each channel perform all stages.

5. What are the advantages and disadvantages of shopping online?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Online shopping's advantages are concentrated in the categories where its structural properties — unlimited selection, price transparency, frictionless comparison, and delivery convenience — matter most, and its disadvantages are corresponding limitations in the categories where those properties are insufficient. The core advantage is search efficiency: finding the best available option across a global product set at minimum time cost is something no physical retail environment can replicate, which makes online shopping the rational dominant channel for any product category where specification is fully knowable and price is a primary decision variable. The core disadvantage is the absence of physical evaluation: return rates for online clothing purchases consistently run at two to four times in-store rates, which reflects the systematic gap between what product photography conveys and what physical inspection reveals.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The less-discussed disadvantages of online shopping for professional consumers relate to the quality of discovery rather than the quality of transaction. Physical retail browsing — particularly in specialist stores — facilitates the kind of serendipitous discovery of products one didn't know existed and wouldn't have searched for that algorithmic retail struggles to replicate: recommendation engines optimise for similarity to prior purchases rather than for the productive surprise of encountering something genuinely unexpected. The professional implication is that consumers who rely exclusively on online shopping may systematically underexplore their own preferences — the platform's logic narrows rather than broadens their effective consideration set over time.

6. Can consumption drive economic growth?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Consumer spending is both a cause and a consequence of economic growth, which makes the directional question of whether consumption drives growth more complex than a simple yes or no captures. In standard macroeconomic accounting, private consumption constitutes the largest component of GDP in most market economies — typically sixty to seventy percent in advanced economies — which means that changes in consumer spending have a large direct mechanical effect on measured output. The more interesting causal question is whether increases in consumer spending create the conditions for sustained productive growth or merely reflect it: the evidence suggests that consumption-led growth is sustainable when it is financed by rising productivity and income rather than debt, and unsustainable — as the 2008 crisis illustrated — when it is financed by credit expansion that outpaces income growth.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The policy debate on consumption as a growth driver reflects a genuine tension between short-run Keynesian demand management and longer-run supply-side economics. In the short run, consumer spending is the most reliable fiscal multiplier available to governments seeking to stimulate a depressed economy: stimulus that reaches consumers with high propensity to spend generates relatively rapid economic activity. In the longer run, however, growth driven by consumption rather than investment and productivity improvement tends to generate

inflation and external imbalances rather than sustainable output expansion — which is why most economists distinguish between consumption as a stabiliser of growth trajectories and investment and innovation as the drivers of the productivity growth that makes rising consumption permanently sustainable.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
propensity to spend	n phr		the tendency to spend a given proportion of income	xu hướng chi tiêu
fiscal multiplier	n phr		the ratio of change in income to change in government spending	hệ số nhân tài khoá
GDP	abbr		Gross Domestic Product — total value of goods and services produced	tổng sản phẩm quốc nội
Keynesian	adj	/ˈkeɪn.zi.ən/	relating to the economic theory that public spending can stimulate growth	theo học thuyết Keynes
procurement	n	/prəˈkjuə.mənt/	the process of obtaining goods or services	mua sắm, thu mua
omnichannel	adj		integrating multiple retail channels into a seamless customer experience	đa kênh tích hợp
consideration set	n phr		the group of products a consumer actively evaluates before buying	tập hợp lựa chọn đang xem xét
serendipitous	adj	/ˌser.ənˈdɪp.ɪ.təs/	occurring by fortunate chance	tình cờ may mắn
credit expansion	n phr		the growth of borrowing and lending in an economy	mở rộng tín dụng
external imbalance	n phr		a persistent surplus or deficit in a country's trade account	mất cân bằng kinh tế đối ngoại

2.44 Describe a natural place (e.g. parks, mountains)

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a natural place (e.g. parks, mountains). You should say:

- Where this place is
- How you knew this place
- What it is like
- And explain why you like to visit it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

There's a stretch of coastline in Phú Quốc — on the southwestern side, away from the main resort strip — that I first visited about three years ago with two friends who had a car and a vague plan to avoid the places mentioned in travel guides. We found it by accident, at the end of a road that wasn't supposed to go anywhere particularly interesting, and the combination of things we found there — an almost completely empty beach, a headland of weathered granite boulders, a line of casuarina trees that ran along the edge of the sand at an odd angle — has made it the reference point I keep returning to when I think about what a natural place should feel like. What I like about it isn't dramatic: the sea is ordinary, the beach is unremarkable by Phú Quốc standards, and there's nothing there in terms of facilities or points of interest. What it has instead is a quality of un-arrangement — the sense that the landscape wasn't composed for observation — that is increasingly rare even in apparently wild places, and which I find more restorative than anything more conventionally beautiful I've visited. I've been back twice since; I'll probably go again.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The natural place I find myself thinking about most consistently is a section of the Cúc Phương forest in Ninh Bình — not the well-visited central area near the park entrance but a trail about four kilometres in that you reach on foot after the other visitors have turned back. I went for the first time about five years ago with a group of colleagues, and the experience of reaching the genuinely undisturbed part of the forest — where the tree canopy closes overhead, the undergrowth thickens, and the ambient sound shifts from occasional human intrusion to something entirely unmixed — was disorientating in a way I hadn't been prepared for. What I return to it for is something that's difficult to describe without sounding mystical: there's a quality of scale and age in old-growth forest that recalibrates something about how one relates to time, and I find that my capacity for sustained focused thought — which is the primary resource that professional life continuously draws on — is noticeably better for several days after spending a day in that environment. I've recommended it to four or five people since; all of them had some version of the same experience.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
headland	n	/ˈhed.lənd/	a narrow piece of land projecting into the sea	mũi đất, mũi nhọn
casuarina	n	/ˌkæʒ.u.ˈær.i.nə/	a type of tree with needle-like leaves common in tropical coastlines	cây phi lao
canopy	n	/ˈkæn.ə.pi/	the upper layer of branches and leaves in a forest	tán rừng
undergrowth	n	/ˈʌn.də.grəʊθ/	plants growing under trees in a forest	thảm thực vật dưới tán rừng
old-growth	adj		referring to forests that have been undisturbed for a very long time	rừng nguyên sinh
disorientating	adj		causing confusion about direction or identity	gây mất phương hướng
recalibrate	v	/ˌriːˈkæl.i.breɪt/	to adjust or reset to a new standard	hiệu chỉnh lại
ambient	adj	/ˈæm.bi.ənt/	relating to the immediately surrounding environment	môi trường xung quanh
restorative	adj	/rɪˈstɔː.rə.tɪv/	having a healing or refreshing effect	hồi phục sức khỏe, tâm trí
un-arrangement	n phr		the quality of appearing natural and uncomposed	sự tự nhiên không được sắp xếp

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What kind of people like to visit natural places?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The population of people drawn to natural environments is more diverse than the stereotypical

image of outdoor enthusiasts suggests, and the motivations driving visits to natural places vary enough that clustering them into a single category obscures more than it reveals. The most reliably identified predictor of preference for natural environments in research is not demographic but experiential: people who have had meaningful positive experiences in natural settings earlier in life are significantly more likely to seek them as adults — which suggests that access and early exposure, rather than personality type, are the primary drivers of nature engagement. A secondary predictor is occupation-related stress: research consistently shows that people in high-cognitive-demand professions — where sustained concentrated attention is the primary resource in play — show higher than average preference for natural environments as restorative contexts, because natural environments are among the most reliable available sources of the involuntary attention and cognitive rest that demanding work depletes.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional understanding of who visits natural places has been substantially enriched by attention restoration research, which identifies restorative experience rather than recreation as the primary driver of natural place preference among working adults. This framing matters because it shifts the question from "what kind of person seeks nature" to "what kind of depletion does nature address"— and the answer, consistently, is that nature most strongly appeals to people experiencing the specific depletion produced by directed-attention work: sustained concentration, complex decision-making, and the management of competing cognitive demands. That said, access constraints mean that observed nature visitation patterns significantly underrepresent the latent demand among lower-income urban populations: the capacity to visit natural places is substantially shaped by transport, time, and cost factors that correlate strongly with socioeconomic status.

2. What are the differences between a natural place and a city?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The city-nature distinction is most productively understood as a difference in the relationship between human design and the physical environment rather than simply a difference in what is present or absent. Cities are environments where almost every element — buildings, roads, parks, transport systems, commercial spaces — reflects deliberate human design choices, which produces a pervasive quality of intentionality: every feature has a purpose and most direct one's movement, attention, and behaviour in specific directions. Natural environments, by contrast, are characterised by the absence or weakness of this design intentionality: they make demands on attention that are not directed at a specific outcome, offer sensory stimulation that is not commercially or functionally motivated, and allow movement patterns that are not channelled by the requirements of urban infrastructure.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional significance of the city-nature distinction is most apparent when considered through the lens of cognitive demands: the two environments make fundamentally different claims on attention. Cities are high-stimulus, high-stimulation environments that require constant directed attention — reading signs, navigating pedestrian traffic, making rapid decisions about movement and safety — in ways that are cognitively demanding even when they are experienced as routine. Natural environments, when experienced appropriately, require low directed attention and elicit high involuntary attention — the effortless, non-depleting engagement of sustained interest in the environment's own intrinsic variety — which is why well-designed studies consistently show restorative cognitive effects from time in natural environments even when that time is relatively brief.

3. How do natural places affect people's emotions?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The emotional effects of natural environments are among the most robustly replicated findings in environmental psychology, and they operate through multiple mechanisms simultaneously. The most immediate mechanism is physiological: exposure to natural environments — even relatively brief exposure, including to indoor plants or urban greenery — reduces cortisol levels, slows heart rate, and activates the parasympathetic nervous system in ways that produce measurable reductions in reported stress and anxiety. The psychological mechanisms are layered on top of this physiological baseline: natural environments reduce rumination — the repetitive self-focused thought that characterises depressive cognition — by providing sufficient external stimulation to interrupt internally-directed thought without making demands that sustain it.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The emotional effects of natural places on professional populations are particularly significant for what they reveal about the emotional costs of sustained urban professional life. The depletion produced by high-directed-attention work is not simply physical tiredness but a specific form of emotional exhaustion — reduced capacity for empathy, patience, and the absorptive engagement with other people's situations that most demanding professional roles require. Natural environments are among the few reliably identified contexts where this specific form of depletion is reversed rather than merely paused: the involuntary attention that natural settings engage recovers directed attention capacity while simultaneously reducing the emotional reactivity that exhaustion produces.

4. What can people gain from going to natural places?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The gains from natural place visits are multi-dimensional — physical, psychological, cognitive, and social — and their magnitude is consistently underestimated by people who have not experienced them directly, partly because the benefits are difficult to anticipate and partly because they tend to accumulate without being consciously attributed to the nature visit specifically. The most immediately accessible gain is stress reduction: the physiological and psychological relaxation response that natural environments reliably produce is beneficial independent of any particular activity undertaken in them. The less immediately obvious but possibly more significant gain is the restoration of the directed attention capacity that most contemporary work and social life systematically depletes — a restoration that has downstream effects on productivity, patience, and the quality of interpersonal engagement for days after the visit.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional case for regular engagement with natural environments rests primarily on the evidence for cognitive and creative restoration. The most practically significant finding is the relationship between nature exposure and the quality of divergent thinking — the capacity to generate novel ideas and unexpected connections that is foundational to creative problem-solving. Multiple controlled studies have found that prolonged exposure to unplugged natural environments significantly improves performance on divergent thinking tasks, which suggests that natural environments provide not just rest from directed attention

work but active cultivation of the associative thinking mode that complex professional problem-solving requires. The implication for professional life is that nature engagement should be treated as a professional resource rather than merely a lifestyle preference.

5. Are there any wild animals in the city?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Urban environments support surprisingly diverse wildlife populations — a fact that is consistently underestimated by urban residents who rarely observe it — and the trend in most cities globally is toward increasing wildlife diversity as urban design has become more attentive to the ecological value of green infrastructure. The species most successfully adapted to urban environments are those with high behavioural flexibility — birds such as sparrows, mynah birds, and corvids; mammals such as bats, rats, and in some cities foxes, deer, and even leopards in Mumbai — whose capacity to exploit the novel food resources and shelter opportunities that cities provide has allowed them to establish stable urban populations. The ecological significance of urban wildlife is increasingly recognised: urban green spaces, including parks, gardens, and road verges, form functional wildlife corridors that support biodiversity beyond what their individual size would predict.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional urban ecology perspective on city wildlife is that urban environments are increasingly important components of regional biodiversity — not despite their human-modified character but partly because of it. The specific food and habitat resources that cities create by accident — warm building surfaces, food waste streams, ornamental planting, and the reduction of predator pressure — have enabled certain species to sustain population densities in urban environments that rural landscapes don't support. The policy implication is that urban wildlife management should shift from suppression — the dominant historical approach for species considered pests — toward integration: designing urban green spaces, building envelopes, and waste management systems that support rather than merely tolerate the wildlife populations that have successfully adapted to urban conditions.

6. Do you think it is a good idea to let animals stay in local parks for people to see?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Managed wildlife presence in urban parks is a policy question whose answer depends substantially on which animals, in what numbers, with what level of management — and the range of defensible positions is correspondingly wide. The case for managed wildlife presence in urban parks is strongest for species whose welfare and safety needs can be adequately met at park scale, whose presence creates genuine educational and emotional value for urban populations with otherwise limited wildlife exposure, and whose interaction with park visitors can be managed at a level that prevents significant harm to either. The case against — particularly for larger or more demanding animals — rests on the animal welfare dimension: animals whose space, behavioural, and social needs substantially exceed what parks can provide will experience chronic stress in that environment regardless of how positively the experience registers for human visitors.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional animal welfare and conservation perspective on wildlife in urban parks

is that the question is less "should animals be there" than "which arrangements best serve both animal welfare and public engagement objectives simultaneously." The arrangements that best achieve both tend to be those where wild or semi-wild animals are present in environments that genuinely approximate their natural habitat requirements — which typically requires larger and more ecologically complex parks than most cities maintain — rather than arrangements optimised for human visibility at the cost of meaningful animal welfare. The conservation argument for getting this right is significant: urban residents who develop meaningful engagement with wildlife are more likely to support conservation policy and funding — which makes the quality of urban wildlife experience a variable with implications beyond the individual interaction.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
cortisol	n	/ˈkɔː.tɪ.səl/	a hormone released in response to stress	cortisol (hormone căng thẳng)
parasympathetic	adj	/ˌpær.əˌsɪm.pəˈθet.ɪk/	relating to the part of the nervous system that calms the body	hệ thần kinh phó giao cảm
rumination	n	/ˌruː.mɪˈneɪ.ʃən/	repetitive, unhelpful self-focused thinking	suy nghĩ lặp đi lặp lại, chiều hướng tiêu cực
divergent thinking	n phr		the ability to generate many creative ideas from a single prompt	tư duy phân kỳ (sáng tạo)
corvid	n	/ˈkɔː.vɪd/	a member of the crow family — crows, ravens, jays, etc.	họ quạ (chim)
wildlife corridor	n phr		a strip of land connecting habitat patches for wildlife movement	hành lang sinh thái cho động vật hoang dã
involuntary attention	n phr		effortless, undirected attention drawn naturally by the environment	sự chú ý không chủ ý, tự nhiên
green infrastructure	n phr		urban parks, trees, and green spaces that provide ecological benefits	hạ tầng xanh đô thị
biodiversity	n	/ˌbaɪ.əʊ.dəɪˈvɜː.sɪ.ti/	the variety of plant and animal life in a habitat	đa dạng sinh học
behavioural flexibility	n phr		the capacity of a species to adapt its behaviour to new environments	tính linh hoạt hành vi (loài động vật)

2.45 Describe a successful sportsperson you admire

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a successful sportsperson you admire. You should say:

- Who he/she is
- What you know about him/her
- What he/she is like in real life
- What achievement he/she has made
- And explain why you admire him/her.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The athlete I find myself genuinely admiring — and this is a distinction I make deliberately, since there are many athletes I follow without particularly admiring them as people — is Nguyễn Thị Ánh Viên, the Vietnamese swimmer who dominated Southeast Asian and Asian Games swimming for nearly a decade before retiring relatively young at twenty-five. I came to know about her seriously during the 2015 SEA Games, when she won eight gold medals in a single Games — a number sufficiently improbable that I initially thought the statistic must be wrong — and then spent time afterwards reading more about her training history, which was genuinely remarkable: she trained at the US Olympic Training Center in Colorado Springs for several years from early adolescence, largely separated from her family, under coaching standards typically reserved for American national team athletes. What I admire about her is less the medals themselves than what they represent about the sustained investment required to produce them: the specific detail that stays with me is that she was training at altitude, twice daily, through periods where her Vietnamese teammates were not training at all. The limitation of her story — that she reached a genuine ceiling at world championship level that Asian Games success didn't fully reveal — doesn't diminish what she produced within the actual competitive context she was operating in.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The sportsperson I most respect is Roger Federer — not because of his titles, which are well-documented and require no elaboration, but because of the specific way he chose to handle the final chapter of a remarkable career. Federer won his last Grand Slam in 2018, continued competing at the highest level while managing a persistent knee injury for four more years, and retired in 2022 at the Laver Cup in a final match played in partnership with Rafael Nadal — his greatest rival, with whom he then sat courtside and openly wept in front of a full arena. For a professional who had spent forty years cultivating an image of effortless composure, the decision to retire publicly, emotionally, and in deliberate partnership with the person who had beaten him more than anyone else was striking in its honesty. What I find professionally admirable about it is the apparent clarity of self-knowledge it required: the willingness to acknowledge limitation without minimising what was being lost, and to mark the ending with genuine emotion rather than the managed composure that sporting retirement ceremonies usually involve.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
altitude training	n phr		training in mountain-high-elevation environments to improve endurance	tập luyện ở độ cao
composure	n	/kəm'pəʊ.ʒər/	the state of being calm and in control of one's emotions	sự bình tĩnh, tự chủ
élite	adj/n	/er'li:t/	the most skilled or highest level in a field	đẳng cấp cao nhất, tinh hoa
rival	n	/'raɪ.vəl/	a person competing against another in the same field	đối thủ cạnh tranh
Grand Slam	n phr		one of the four most prestigious tennis tournaments	giải Grand Slam (quần vợt)
podium	n	/'pəʊ.di.əm/	the platform where winners stand to receive medals	bục nhận giải
endurance	n	/ɪn'dʒʊə.rəns/	the ability to sustain prolonged physical or mental effort	sức bền, khả năng chịu đựng
discipline	n	/'dɪs.i.plɪn/	a sport or field of athletic activity; also self-control in training	môn thể thao; kỷ luật tự giác
SEA Games	n phr		the Southeast Asian Games, a multi-sport event for the region	Đại hội Thể thao Đông Nam Á
graceful	adj	/'greɪs.fəl/	showing elegance and poise in movement or manner	duyên dáng, thanh thoát

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Should students have physical education and do sports at school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Physical education is one of the few school subjects whose benefits operate primarily through non-academic channels — physical health, mental health, social development, and the formation of habits that have lifelong consequences — which makes arguments for reducing or eliminating it in favour of academic subjects a mischaracterisation of what the curriculum is for. The evidence for school-based physical activity improving academic performance, not just physical fitness, is robust: students who are more physically active show measurably better concentration, attendance, and academic outcome on average, which means the trade-off between PE and academic time is less stark than it superficially appears. The social and character development dimension is less quantified but arguably as significant: team sport, competitive activity, and the experience of physical challenge in a structured social context develop specific capacities — resilience, cooperation, the management of winning and losing — that classroom-based learning does not readily replicate.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for mandatory physical education in schools is strongest not when made on fitness grounds — though those grounds are valid — but when made on mental health and habit formation grounds. Mental health outcomes for young people are increasingly poor across high-income and rapidly developing economies, and physical activity is among the most reliable non-pharmacological interventions available: it reduces symptoms of anxiety and depression, improves sleep quality, and builds the self-efficacy that protects against a range of adverse mental health outcomes. The habit formation argument is perhaps the most consequential long-term: the evidence consistently shows that physical activity habits established in childhood and adolescence are significantly more persistent into adulthood than habits formed later, which makes school-based physical education an investment in lifelong health that cannot be easily replicated in adult life.

2. What qualities should an athlete have?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The qualities that distinguish elite athletes from highly talented ones operating below their potential are overwhelmingly psychological rather than physical — a finding consistent enough across sports that it represents one of the more robust areas of sports science consensus. The most widely identified psychological quality is self-regulation: the capacity to maintain training consistency, manage motivation over periods when performance is not progressing, and recover from setbacks without the emotional cost interfering with subsequent performance. A close second is the capacity for deliberate practice — the specific cognitive disposition to seek out and engage with the aspects of one's performance that are weakest rather than consolidating competencies that are already strong — which distinguishes athletes who improve systematically from those who plateau at current competence.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional sports science answer to what qualities distinguish successful athletes has shifted substantially over the past twenty years from physical attributes to psychological ones. The most practically significant finding is that talent — in the sense of innate physical advantage — is a necessary but not sufficient precondition for elite performance, and that

the psychological qualities of self-regulation, deliberate practice orientation, and effective stress response are better predictors of who reaches the top from a given talent pool than physical attributes are. The coaching implication is that talent identification programmes that focus primarily on physical screening — the dominant approach in most sports — systematically miss the psychological qualities that determine who develops the identified talent into competitive success.

3. Is talent important in sports?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Talent matters significantly in elite sport but is neither necessary nor sufficient for the top level of performance — a nuance that the popular debate consistently misses in both directions. The “talent doesn’t matter, it’s all hard work” argument (popularised by Malcolm Gladwell’s 10,000 hours thesis) substantially understates the evidence for genuine genetic advantage in physical attributes relevant to sport: height, limb proportions, oxygen processing efficiency, and certain neurological response time characteristics are substantially heritable and provide real competitive advantages that training cannot fully compensate for. The opposite error — assuming that talent is the dominant variable — is equally wrong: the correlation between identified early talent and eventual elite achievement is much weaker than talent-scouting programmes assume, partly because early development advantage and mature competitive potential are only loosely related.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional sports science position on talent is that it defines the ceiling of what is achievable for a given athlete but that the distance between that ceiling and actual achievement is determined primarily by psychological and environmental factors rather than by talent itself. The practical implication — which talent-identification systems have been slow to absorb — is that the best predictor of who reaches elite level from a youth talent pool is not the initial level of measured ability but the quality of the coaching environment and the degree to which the athlete’s psychological development supports sustained deliberate practice over the years required to reach competitive maturity. Talent early-selects who is worth developing; it does not predict who will develop.

4. Is it easy to identify children’s talents?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Early talent identification in children is substantially less reliable than most talent detection systems assume, which creates significant costs both for the children selected and for those not selected. The core problem is developmental asynchrony: children of the same age vary substantially in their degree of physical and cognitive development, which means that many early “talent” indicators reflect maturity advantage rather than genuine athletic potential — a problem sufficiently well-documented in youth sport that it has a name, the relative age effect, referring to the systematic over-representation of children born early in selection years in talent programmes and professional sport. The children not selected on early screening indicators include a significant proportion who would have developed competitive potential if given equivalent developmental support — a systematic loss that most talent identification systems do not adequately account for.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The relative age effect is the most clearly documented failure mode of early talent identification, but it is not the only one. Early talent identification systems also systematically disadvantage children from lower socioeconomic backgrounds — who have less access to early specialisation, quality coaching, and the infrastructure costs of sport participation — and children whose particular talent profile develops later than the window most identification systems screen. The professional sports organisations that have developed the most sophisticated talent identification systems are those that have moved from point-in-time screening to longitudinal tracking — following athletes’ development trajectories over time rather than making selection decisions on single-point assessments — which is more expensive but substantially more predictively valid.

5. What is the most popular sport in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Football is unambiguously the most popular spectator sport in Vietnam — the national team’s matches consistently produce some of the highest television audiences of any broadcast event, and the emotional investment of the public in major tournaments, particularly the AFF Championship and qualifying rounds of the Asian Cup, is intense in a way that no other sport approaches. The participation picture is somewhat different: football participation among young men in urban areas is very high, but badminton, swimming, and martial arts may collectively account for more regular active participants across the full population including women and older age groups. The gap between football as spectacle and football as regular practice reflects a pattern common across Southeast Asia: the passion for watching the sport substantially exceeds the infrastructure available for broad-based participation.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

Football’s dominance in Vietnamese sporting culture is a relatively recent phenomenon at the national team level: Vietnam’s football history before the late 2010s was one of regional underperformance relative to the passion it generated, and the transformation under coach Park Hang-seo from 2017 onward — producing the AFF Championship win in 2018 and consistent regional competitiveness — created a positive feedback loop between competitive success and public investment of identity that significantly deepened the sport’s already strong cultural hold. The professional sports development implication of football’s dominance is both an opportunity and a constraint: the resource concentration it attracts is valuable for developing a single high-profile sport, but the degree to which it crowds out development investment in other sports creates a breadth vulnerability in Vietnam’s overall sporting profile.

6. Why are there so few top athletes?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Elite athletic achievement requires a specific conjunction of factors — genetic endowment, early access to quality coaching, sustained motivation through a multi-year development process, and freedom from significant injury — that is rare in any given population, and the rarity of that conjunction is the fundamental reason why top athletes are scarce. The genetic dimension is a necessary but not decisive factor: the population of people with the physical endowment relevant to a given sport is significantly larger than the population of elite athletes, which means selection at the genetic level is only the first of several

filters. The coaching and environment filter is arguably as selective: the quality of coaching and competitive environment available to most aspiring athletes in most countries falls significantly below the standard required to develop the physical endowment present in a broader talent population.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The scarcity of world-class athletes reflects the sequential nature of the development pathway rather than an absolute constraint on human potential. At each stage of development — initial identification, early specialisation, junior competition, late adolescent selection, and senior professional performance — a proportion of those with the potential for the next stage fail to progress because of factors that include injury, loss of motivation, insufficient coaching quality, financial constraint, or simple competitive misfortune. These sequential filters are multiplicative rather than additive: if each transition stage has a fifty percent pass rate, a pipeline of one thousand talented young athletes yields about thirty who reach professional senior level — a ratio that is broadly consistent with what youth-to-senior transition data in most sports shows. The policy implication is that widening the base of participation at the entry stage provides more proportionate elite output than almost any other intervention.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
relative age effect	n phr		the advantage children born earlier in selection years have in talent identification	hiệu ứng tuổi tương đối
deliberate practice	n phr		focused, intentional training specifically targeting weaknesses	luyện tập có chủ đích
self-regulation	n phr		the ability to manage one's emotions and behaviour in pursuit of goals	tự điều chỉnh hành vi
developmental asynchrony	n phr		uneven rates of development among children of the same age	sự phát triển không đồng đều
self-efficacy	n	/ˌself.ɪˈfɪk.ə.si/	belief in one's ability to succeed in specific situations	niềm tin vào năng lực bản thân
plateau	v/n	/'plæt.əʊ/	to reach a level where progress stops	dậm chân tại chỗ
elite	n/adj	/er'li:t/	the group with the highest level in a field	người xuất sắc nhất
endowment	n	/ɪn'dəʊ.mənt/	natural qualities or abilities a person is born with	tố chất bẩm sinh
talent pipeline	n phr		the structured process of developing young talent into senior athletes	đường ống phát triển tài năng
longitudinal tracking	n phr		following individuals over a long period to monitor development	theo dõi dọc theo thời gian

2.46 Describe an area / subject of science that you are interested in

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe an area / subject of science (biology, robotics, etc.) that you are interested in and would like to learn more about. You should say:

- Which area/subject it is
- When and where you came to know this area/subject
- How you get information about this area/subject
- And explain why you are interested in this area/subject.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The area of science I've become genuinely absorbed in over the past couple of years is cognitive neuroscience — specifically the question of how memory actually works, as opposed to how people casually assume it works. I came to it indirectly, through a popular science book about eyewitness testimony that a friend lent me in my second year, which led me to journal articles and eventually to following a handful of researchers on social media who post accessibly about their work. What gripped me was the finding that memory is not stored and retrieved like a file — it's reconstructed each time you remember, which means every act of remembering changes the memory itself, and which has specific and disturbing implications for how reliably any of us can trust what we think we know happened. I follow the field now through a mix of popular science writing and reading abstracts of primary papers when something specific interests me enough to want the actual data rather than the interpretation — which is more often than I expected.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The scientific field I find myself spending the most time reading about — somewhat unexpectedly, given my professional background — is epidemiology, specifically the methodological question of how to establish causation from observational data when randomised controlled trials are impossible. I came to it seriously during the pandemic, when watching the public debate about COVID evidence revealed how poorly most participants — including many with scientific credentials — understood what observational studies could and couldn't establish. What keeps me interested is that it's fundamentally a philosophical problem with enormous practical stakes: the tools epidemiologists use to simulate causal inference from correlational data — instrumental variables, difference-in-differences designs, Mendelian randomisation — are intellectually elegant in the way that good engineering is, and understanding them changes how you evaluate almost every empirical claim you encounter in public life. I read primarily through Substack writers who work across statistics and public health, which gets me to the methodological literature without requiring the kind of sustained technical immersion I can't sustain alongside professional demands.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
cognitive neuroscience	n phr		the study of the biological basis of thought and behaviour	khoa học thần kinh nhận thức
epidemiology	n	/ˌepɪˈdɪːmiˈɒlədʒi/	the study of how diseases spread and affect populations	dịch tễ học
randomised controlled trial	n phr		an experiment where participants are randomly assigned to different groups	thử nghiệm đối chứng ngẫu nhiên
causation	n	/kɔːˈzeɪʃən/	the relationship where one event directly causes another	quan hệ nhân quả
observational data	n phr		information gathered by observing without intervention	dữ liệu quan sát
Mendelian randomisation	n phr		a method using genetic variants to study cause and effect	phương pháp ngẫu nhiên hoá Mendel
reconstruct	v	/ˌriːkənˈstrʌkt/	to build again or reassemble from parts	tái thiết, tái cấu trúc
abstract	n	/ˈæb.strækt/	a brief summary of a research paper	tóm tắt bài báo khoa học
inference	n	/ˈɪn.fər.əns/	a conclusion reached through evidence and reasoning	suy luận, kết luận
correlational	adj	/ˌkɒr.ɪˈleɪ.ʃən.əl/	describing a relationship where two things change together without one causing the other	mang tính tương quan

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Why do some children not like learning science at school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Children's disengagement from school science reflects primarily the way science is taught rather than any innate resistance to science as an activity — a distinction with important implications for how the problem is understood and addressed. The dominant mode of science instruction in most school systems presents science as a body of established facts to be transmitted and tested rather than as a set of methods and practices for investigating questions — and this framing fundamentally misrepresents what makes science intellectually engaging. The most consistently effective pedagogical approaches to science engagement in research are those that preserve the investigative character of scientific practice: giving students genuine questions to investigate with real uncertainty about the outcome, rather than laboratory exercises whose results are already known and whose purpose is verification rather than discovery.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional education research perspective on science disengagement identifies assessment design as the most significant single driver of the problem. School science assessment in most systems is dominated by the recall of factual content — definitions, classifications, formulae — rather than the application of scientific reasoning to novel problems, which means that the skills required to succeed in school science are largely orthogonal to the skills that make science professionally and intellectually rewarding. Students who find fact-memorisation relatively unrewarding relative to their other capabilities are correctly reading that the content being assessed is not where science's real value lies — their disengagement is a rational response to a misalignment between what they are being asked to do and what science as a practice actually involves.

2. Is it important to study science at school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Science education at school level is important for reasons that extend well beyond the career-pathway argument — the vocational case for science study as preparation for scientific careers — which represents only a small fraction of the actual benefit. The more broadly applicable benefit is scientific literacy: the capacity to evaluate evidence-based claims, understand the logic of controlled experiments, recognise the difference between correlation and causation, and apply probabilistic reasoning to uncertain real-world situations. These are not specialist skills relevant only to scientific careers; they are foundational to the kind of informed citizenship that democratic societies require, and their absence is visible in the quality of public discourse around issues from climate change to vaccine safety to economic policy.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional case for school science education is strongest when made not on content grounds but on epistemological ones: the most valuable thing school science can transmit is not specific factual knowledge — which becomes outdated — but the methods through which reliable knowledge is generated and distinguished from unreliable knowledge. This epistemological dimension of science education is more important now than at any previous

point in history, because the information environment that people navigate as adults is noisier, more contested, and more deliberately manipulated than at any previous period, and the capacity to evaluate the quality of evidence rather than simply the authority of its source is the most significant available protection against misinformation at scale.

3. Which science subject is the most important for children to learn?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for biology as the most important science subject rests on its direct relevance to the most significant decisions that most people will make across their lives — decisions about health, diet, reproduction, environmental responsibility, and the evaluation of medical evidence — and on the fact that biological literacy underlies the public understanding of issues from pandemic response to agricultural policy in ways that other science subjects' content does not equally match at the level of everyday adult decision-making. That said, the question of which science content matters most is becoming progressively less important than the question of which scientific methods and reasoning skills matter most — and the answer to the latter question is likely to be statistical thinking, which underlies the interpretation of evidence in every science and most applied non-science domains.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional consensus in science education research has moved away from ranking science content domains toward identifying the cross-cutting skills that underlie scientific reasoning across all domains. The most widely identified candidate is probabilistic and statistical thinking: the ability to reason correctly about risk, uncertainty, sample size, base rates, and the distinction between statistical and practical significance is foundational to the correct interpretation of scientific evidence in any domain, and its absence is the most common source of the scientific misunderstandings that appear most consequentially in public discourse. If a hierarchy of science content is required, the most defensible ranking would favour content that directly scaffolds this kind of quantitative reasoning — which points toward statistics and probability as the most important, and toward whichever content domain provides the most accessible entry point to their practical application.

4. Should people continue to study science after graduating from school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Continued engagement with science after formal education is both increasingly important and structurally undersupported — most societies' systems for public science communication are significantly less developed than their systems for formal science education, which creates a deficit that individual initiative is required to fill. The case for continued science engagement rests primarily on the rate of change of scientific knowledge in domains directly relevant to adult decision-making: medical, environmental, nutritional, and technological knowledge is evolving rapidly enough that formal education provides only a snapshot of a field at a particular point in time, and adults who treat their school or university science education as their permanent knowledge base are therefore operating on increasingly outdated foundations. The good news is that the infrastructure for informal science education — quality popular science writing, accessible podcasts, well-designed online courses — has never been richer.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional case for continuing science education after formal schooling is strongest

for people working in domains where understanding the evidence base for decision-making is directly professionally relevant — which, in the contemporary economy, includes a significantly wider range of professions than science careers alone. Data literacy — the capacity to understand and critically evaluate quantitative claims — is now a professional requirement in fields from marketing to public policy to business strategy, and its foundations in statistical and scientific reasoning mean that maintaining and developing scientific literacy is increasingly a professional competency rather than merely an intellectual preference. The organisations that invest in science literacy as a professional development priority are those that have recognised that evidence-based decision-making cannot be delegated to specialist departments but needs to be sufficiently distributed across professional roles to be effective at the point of decision.

5. How do you get to know about scientific news?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

My engagement with scientific news is a patchwork of sources that I've assembled over time through a combination of recommendation and trial and error — weighted toward sources that explain the evidence behind findings rather than simply reporting results. The most reliable sources I've found are publications that employ specialist science journalists with deep domain knowledge rather than general journalists parachuting into science coverage: the quality difference between careful scientific journalism and the simplified, often misleading reporting that most general news outlets produce on science stories is significant enough that I've become quite selective about where I source my science news. For primary research that interests me enough to investigate further, I'll use Google Scholar or preprint servers like bioRxiv, though the habit of reading primary research is one I'm still developing.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

My science news consumption is primarily through curated newsletters — several of which are written by practising scientists or science journalists with strong domain expertise — rather than through mainstream news media, which I find consistently sacrifice accuracy for accessibility in ways that produce systematic distortions in how findings are communicated. The newsletter format suits professional reading habits: a reliable daily or weekly digest from a trusted source lets me maintain broad awareness of developments in fields relevant to my work without the time cost of active monitoring. For topics where my professional interest is more intense, I use RSS feeds from specific journal content alerts, which gives me access to abstracts as soon as papers are published rather than waiting for them to be covered by secondary sources.

6. Should scientists explain the research process to the public?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Scientists have both a professional obligation and a practical incentive to communicate their research processes to the public — and the failure to do so at scale is one of the most significant contributing factors to the current crisis of public scientific trust. The obligation dimension: publicly funded research is conducted on behalf of and with resources provided by the public, which generates a transparency obligation that is not adequately discharged simply by publishing in academic journals whose access and comprehension are restricted to specialist audiences. The practical incentive dimension: public understanding of how scientific

knowledge is generated is the most robust available inoculation against misinformation — people who understand that science is a self-correcting process rather than a pronouncement system are significantly more resilient to the selective citation of outlier studies and to the “scientists are divided” rhetorical strategy that is used to manufacture false uncertainty around well-established findings.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for scientists explaining their research processes rather than just their findings — communicating the logic of experimental design, the role of peer review, how replication failures are handled, and how confidence levels are established — rests on the observation that most public misunderstanding of scientific claims stems from misunderstanding how scientific knowledge works rather than from misunderstanding specific content. People who understand that a single study does not establish a finding, that effect sizes matter as much as statistical significance, and that the accumulation of replicated evidence over time is how scientific confidence is built are equipped to evaluate scientific news rather than simply receive it — and this equipment is more valuable than any specific factual content science communication can deliver. The practical challenge is that conveying process rather than findings is harder to make engaging, which is why the most effective science communicators are those who have found ways to make the practice of science as compelling a story as its results.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
peer review	n phr		the evaluation of research by other experts before publication	biên duyệt chuyên gia
replication	n	/ˌrep.lɪˈkeɪ.ʃən/	repeating a study to verify its findings	tái lập (nghiên cứu)
preprint	n	/'pri:.prɪnt/	a research paper shared before peer review	bản thảo trước phản biện
science literacy	n phr		the ability to understand and evaluate scientific information	hiểu biết khoa học
inoculation	n	/ɪˌnɒk.juˈleɪ.ʃən/	here, building resistance to misinformation in advance	tiêm phòng (nghĩa bóng: chống thông tin sai lệch)
epistemological	adj	/ɪˌpɪs.tɪ.məˈlɒdʒ.ɪ.kəl/	relating to the theory of knowledge and how we know things	thuộc nhận thức luận
effect size	n phr		how large a measured difference or relationship is in a study	độ lớn của hiệu ứng
statistical significance	n phr		the probability that a result is not due to chance	ý nghĩa thống kê
base rate	n phr		the underlying probability of an event in a population	tỷ lệ nền
misinformation	n	/ˌmɪs.ɪn.fəˈmeɪ.ʃən/	false or inaccurate information spread unintentionally	thông tin sai lệch

2.47 Describe a TV or online program you like to watch

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a TV or online program you like to watch. You should say:

- What it is
- What it is about
- Who you watch it with
- And explain why you like to watch it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The program I've been watching most consistently over the past year is a YouTube channel called Kurzgesagt, which produces animated explainer videos on topics across physics, biology, climate science, and philosophy — each video typically running about ten to twelve minutes and managing to cover genuinely complex ideas with enough accuracy to satisfy and enough simplicity to include people who don't have the specialist background. I discovered it through a friend who shared one video about the scale of the universe, and I've watched probably forty or fifty more since, usually alone late at night when I want something that engages my thinking without requiring me to be physically present the way a conversation or lecture would. What I value about it specifically — and what distinguishes it from most educational content I've encountered — is that it takes its audience seriously enough to present uncertainty as well as conclusion: it says "we don't know" when that's the honest answer, and it resists the pressure toward false resolution that most popular science content yields to. It's the only YouTube channel I've paid a subscription to.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The program I watch most consistently is a documentary series on Netflix called Abstract: The Art of Design, which profiles individual designers — graphic designers, architects, illustrators, shoe designers, set designers — through the lens of their practice and their philosophy. I started watching it about three years ago when I was between projects and had more discretionary evening time than usual, and I've returned to individual episodes multiple times since, which is unusual for me with documentary content. What keeps drawing me back is the quality of the thinking it makes visible: the designers profiled all articulate the reasoning behind their choices with unusual clarity, which means the series functions as a kind of sustained argument about what design is for and how deliberate aesthetic decisions encode values — an argument that I find relevant to my professional thinking even though my work is nothing to do with design in the conventional sense. I watch it alone, which feels more appropriate to how I engage with it — it's closer to reading than to viewing.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
explainer	n	/ɪk'spleɪ.nər/	a piece of content that explains a complex topic accessibly	nội dung giải thích đơn giản hoá
discretionary	adj	/drɪ'skreʃ.ən.ər.i/	left to individual choice; not compulsory	tự quyết, không bắt buộc
animated	adj	/'æn.ɪ.meɪ.tɪd/	produced using animation techniques	hoạt hình
profile	v	/'prəʊ.faɪl/	to write or produce a detailed account of a person or subject	làm hồ sơ chân dung, giới thiệu chi tiết
encode	v	/ɪn'keʊd/	to express something in a form that carries meaning	mã hoá, thể hiện ý nghĩa
subscribe	v	/səb'skraɪb/	to pay regularly for access to a service or content	đăng ký (dịch vụ, kênh)
aesthetic	adj/n	/i:s'θet.ɪk/	concerned with beauty and artistic appearance	thuộc thẩm mỹ
documentary	n	/ˌdɒk.jʊ'men.tər.i/	a film or program presenting facts about a real subject	phim tài liệu
philosophy of practice	n phr		the underlying principles and values that guide how someone works	triết lý thực hành
false resolution	n phr		presenting a complex issue as settled when it is not	kết luận giả tạo về vấn đề còn tranh cãi

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What programs do people like to watch in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Vietnamese television and streaming consumption patterns have diversified substantially in the past decade, with the shift from broadcast television to streaming platforms producing significant fragmentation of what had previously been a relatively homogeneous viewing landscape. The dominant viewing categories by time spent remain drama series — both Vietnamese-produced and Korean, with the latter having a cultural footprint in Vietnam that substantially exceeds its geographic scale — and entertainment formats including game shows, talent competitions, and variety programs. The demographic split is pronounced: younger urban viewers have largely migrated to streaming platforms and YouTube, where consumption is more personalised and on-demand; older viewers remain more attached to broadcast schedules and the shared cultural experience that simultaneous broadcast produces.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional media analysis of Vietnamese content preferences identifies several structural patterns that explain aggregate viewing behaviour. The strength of domestic drama production — particularly melodrama formats organised around family conflict, generational tension, and romantic complication — reflects the specific emotional anxieties of a society undergoing rapid social change: these narratives provide a safe space to explore the conflicts between traditional expectations and modern aspirations that are common lived experience for much of the urban Vietnamese audience. The parallel dominance of Korean content reflects a regional cultural industry that has invested heavily in the production of content calibrated to appeal across the specific social and emotional landscape of Northeast and Southeast Asian audiences — an investment that has produced a sustained competitive advantage over Western content producers whose content is less precisely tailored to this audience.

2. Do people in your country like to watch foreign TV programs?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Foreign content — particularly Korean and American — has a large and growing audience in Vietnam, driven primarily by the availability of streaming platforms that have made international content accessible at low cost and without the delays that previously characterised licensed broadcast distribution of foreign programs. Korean content occupies a particularly significant position: Korean drama series, variety programs, and more recently documentary and reality formats have penetrated Vietnamese viewing culture to a degree that amounts to what some cultural analysts describe as a soft power achievement — shaping aesthetic preferences, consumption habits, and aspirational frameworks in ways that extend well beyond entertainment. American content maintains a strong presence in the 18–35 demographic through platforms like Netflix, with genres including crime drama, thriller, and comedy performing best.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The appetite for foreign content in Vietnam reflects both the genuine quality of the international content available and the specific gaps in domestic content production that foreign content fills. The genres where domestic production is weakest — high-production-

value documentary, prestige drama with complex narrative structure, reality formats with high production sophistication — are precisely those where international content performs best with the segments of the Vietnamese audience whose consumption expectations have been raised by sustained exposure to global production quality. The cultural protection question that this raises — whether the scale of foreign content consumption is displacing domestic cultural production in ways that are harmful to Vietnamese cultural identity — is a genuine policy concern, though the evidence that content consumption preferences in entertainment are a meaningful proxy for deeper cultural identity is much weaker than protectionist arguments typically assume.

3. What's the benefit of letting kids watch animal videos than visiting zoos?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

High-quality wildlife documentary content and zoo visits serve partly overlapping but meaningfully different educational functions, and the framing of the question as an either/or understates how complementary they are when both are done well. The advantage of wildlife video over zoo visits is primarily one of ecological authenticity: documentary footage of animals in genuine wild habitats — exhibiting natural behaviours, in appropriate social and ecological contexts, at appropriate scales — provides a more accurate representation of animal life than zoo enclosures can typically deliver, and the narration that accompanies quality documentary content can provide explanatory depth that zoo visits, without a dedicated guide, typically cannot match. The counter-argument is experiential: the physical presence of a large or unusual animal — the scale, smell, sound, and movement — affects children differently than screen-mediated encounter, and this experiential dimension drives the affective engagement with wildlife that motivates conservation concern in ways that screen-only exposure may be less effective at producing.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The educational case for each modality rests on what it uniquely provides. Wildlife video provides scale and ecological context impossible to replicate in captivity: a documentary about elephant family dynamics, filmed over months, conveys information about elephant social life and intelligence that no zoo enclosure can approximate. Zoo visits provide sensory and affective engagement with physical animal presence that screen-mediated content cannot fully substitute for — and the research on what drives children's conservation values suggests that direct emotional engagement with animals is a more powerful driver than information alone, which gives in-person animal experience a specific value that cannot be straightforwardly replaced by however high-quality the documentary content is. The strongest educational approach combines both: documentary content to provide ecological context, zoo visits to provide emotional engagement.

4. Do teachers play videos in class in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Instructional video use in Vietnamese classrooms has increased substantially over the past decade, driven partly by the availability of digital teaching infrastructure and partly by the COVID-19 period's forced experimentation with remote and hybrid learning, which exposed both teachers and students to a much wider range of video-based instructional content than classroom practice had previously incorporated. The quality of video use varies enormously:

at its best, educational video provides access to demonstrations, phenomena, and visual explanations that classroom instruction cannot easily replicate — a chemistry experiment that requires equipment unavailable in school, a biological process too small or too slow to observe directly, a historical footage that makes the past immediate. At its weakest, classroom video use is a time-filling substitute for instruction rather than a meaningful instructional complement.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional education technology perspective on instructional video use identifies effective video pedagogy as a specific skillset that most teachers have not been systematically trained in, which explains why the increase in video availability has not produced proportionate improvements in learning outcomes at scale. The most critical dimension of effective instructional video use is integration: video that is positioned before instruction to activate prior knowledge and generate questions, or after instruction to consolidate understanding through different representational modalities, produces better outcomes than video used as a standalone content delivery vehicle. The common error is treating video as a replacement for teaching rather than as a resource that requires active pedagogical framing to maximise its value.

5. Do you think watching talk shows is a waste of time?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Characterising any form of media consumption as categorically a waste of time misapplies the concept: the value of any activity depends on what it provides relative to what else might be done with the time and what the person consuming it was seeking. Talk shows provide a specific value that other formats don't easily replicate: extended, unscripted conversation that allows the development of complex ideas in real time, with the friction and uncertainty that scripted formats eliminate — and this format at its best, in programs with substantive guests and thoughtful interviewers, is genuinely educational in a mode that is distinct from either reading or lecture. The weaker versions of the format — celebrity interview shows organised around promotion rather than substance, or political talk shows optimised for conflict rather than understanding — provide entertainment value rather than educational value, which may or may not represent waste depending on whether entertainment is what was sought.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional media critic position on talk shows as a format is that the variance within the genre is too large for categorical evaluation: the same structural format that produces shallow celebrity promotion also produces some of the most substantive long-form intellectual conversation available in audio-visual media. The podcast phenomenon — which is essentially talk show format liberated from broadcast scheduling and advertiser constraints — has produced a body of extended conversation content that represents a genuine expansion of the educational and intellectual value available from spoken audio-visual media. The most substantive podcast conversations with scientists, philosophers, historians, and practitioners in complex professional fields regularly exceed the depth available from any other popular media format — which makes the "talk shows are a waste of time" framing a category error rather than a sustainable critical position.

6. Do you think we can acquire knowledge from watching TV programs?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Television and streaming programs are significant vectors of knowledge transmission — the question is what kind of knowledge and under what conditions of viewing. Factual knowledge — information about the world, its history, its species, its geography, its cultural forms — is regularly and effectively transmitted through well-made documentary programming in ways that are accessible to audiences who would not seek the same information through reading. The more contested question is whether procedural and conceptual knowledge — how to reason, how to evaluate evidence, how to understand causal relationships — can be effectively transmitted through viewing, and the evidence here is more mixed: well-designed programs can scaffold this kind of knowledge, but passive viewing without engagement produces much thinner learning than active engagement with text.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional learning science perspective on television as a knowledge acquisition vehicle identifies the critical variable as cognitive engagement rather than medium. Passive viewing of even high-quality informational content produces shallow encoding with poor retention and limited transfer to novel contexts. Viewing that is accompanied by active processing — note-taking, pauses for reflection, discussion with others after viewing — produces substantially better knowledge outcomes from equivalent content. The implication for using television as a deliberate knowledge acquisition tool rather than as a passive entertainment medium is that the viewer's active engagement strategy matters more than the content quality — which is why the distinction between "watching to learn" and "watching for entertainment while incidentally learning" produces significantly different knowledge outcomes from identical viewing experiences.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
modality	n	/məʊ'dæl.ɪ.ti/	a particular method or form through which something is done	phương thức, hình thức
affective	adj	/ə'fek.tɪv/	relating to emotions and feelings	thuộc cảm xúc, tình cảm
encoding	n	/ɪn'kəʊ.dɪŋ/	the process of converting information into memory	mã hoá vào trí nhớ
soft power	n phr		influence gained through culture and attraction rather than coercion	quyền lực mềm
retention	n	/rɪ'ten.ʃən/	the ability to remember information over time	khả năng giữ lại thông tin
scaffold	v	/'skæf.əld/	to provide support structure for learning	cung cấp giàn giáo hỗ trợ trong học tập
instructional	adj	/ɪn'strʌk.ʃən.əl/	designed to teach a skill or provide information	mang tính giảng dạy
transfer	n	/'træns.fɜː/	applying learned knowledge to new situations	chuyển giao kiến thức
melodrama	n	/'mel.ə'drɑː.mə/	a dramatic form with exaggerated emotion and plot	chính kịch cảm xúc mạnh
fragmentation	n	/ˌfræɡ.men'teɪ.ʃən/	the process of breaking into smaller, separate parts	sự phân mảnh

2.48 Describe a quiet place you like to go

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a quiet place you like to go. You should say:

- Where it is
- How you knew it
- How often you go there
- What you do there
- And explain how you feel about the place.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

There is a reading room on the fourth floor of the National Library on Tràng Thi street that I've been going to since my second year of university — not the main hall, which fills quickly and has the ambient noise of a lot of people trying to be quiet, but a smaller specialist room at the end of a corridor that most people don't find without being specifically directed there. I go roughly once a fortnight when I have something I need to read without interruption — a paper with dense argument, a long text that needs sustained attention, anything that my apartment and its reliable distractions won't accommodate. What I value about it is partly the quiet itself and partly the specific character of the quiet: it's a room where the purpose of being there is understood, where nobody makes unnecessary noise because the social contract of the space includes not making unnecessary noise, and where the collective concentration of the people in it creates a kind of shared atmosphere that I find easier to maintain my own concentration within than I do when reading alone. I've done better work there consistently than anywhere else.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The quiet place I return to most reliably is a particular bench in a small community park about ten minutes' walk from where I work, which I discovered by chance during a long phone call that required walking and found myself returning to deliberately afterwards. It's not an impressive space — a modest park with the usual complement of elderly residents doing morning exercises and occasional dogs — but at certain times of day, particularly mid-morning on weekdays after the exercise routines have finished, it achieves a quality of quietness that I find genuinely useful. I go there when I have a decision to think through rather than work to execute — the distinction matters, because thinking through a decision requires a different cognitive mode than executing work, and the open, slightly underdetermined setting of the park supports the former better than any office or desk space I've found. I probably go three or four times a month, and the visits are short — rarely more than thirty minutes — but reliable in their effect.

 - **community park** (n phr): a public green space maintained for local residents
| công viên cộng đồng

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
ambient noise	n phr		background sounds naturally present in an environment	tiếng ồn xung quanh
social contract	n phr		the unspoken rules and expectations shared by a group	khế ước xã hội ngầm
sustained attention	n phr		the ability to focus on something for an extended period	sự chú ý liên tục
fortnight	n	/ˈfɔːt.naɪt/	a period of two weeks	hai tuần
complement	n	/ˈkɒm.plɪ.mənt/	the full number or amount of something expected	bộ đầy đủ, thành phần kèm theo
underdetermined	adj		lacking rigid structure or fixed outcome	không quá cấu trúc hoá, dễ ngổ
deliberately	adv	/dɪˈlɪb.ər.ət.li/	intentionally and with purpose	có chủ đích, cố ý
cognitive mode	n phr		the particular style of thinking engaged at a given moment	chế độ tư duy
specialist room	n phr		a room designed for a specific purpose or subject area	phòng chuyên biệt

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Is it easy to find quiet places in your country? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Quiet places in Vietnamese cities are not easy to find, and their scarcity is increasing as urbanisation accelerates and the density of both people and motorised traffic in urban areas continues to rise. The specific character of urban noise in Vietnamese cities — dominated by motorbike engines, construction, and the acoustic character of street-level commerce — is different in kind from the noise of many other urban environments and more pervasive:

it penetrates residential buildings at levels that make quiet reading or concentrated work difficult even indoors without deliberate acoustic mitigation. The exceptions that do exist — certain library spaces, a few well-managed parks during off-peak hours, some temple grounds — are relatively rare and often require specific knowledge of where and when they can be accessed at their best.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional urban planning perspective on quiet as an urban amenity is that it is systematically undervalued in planning frameworks relative to its actual contribution to quality of life and public health outcomes. Traffic noise — the dominant component of urban noise in Vietnamese cities — is associated in the epidemiological literature with sleep disruption, elevated cortisol levels, cardiovascular risk, and reduced cognitive performance at levels that make it a significant but underacknowledged public health problem. The planning tools for reducing urban noise are well understood — traffic management, vehicle standards, sound barriers, urban green buffer zones, acoustic building standards — but their implementation requires treating quiet as a public good worth investing in rather than a private matter to be managed by individual households through double-glazing and air conditioning.

2. How do people spend their leisure time in your country?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Vietnamese leisure patterns have diversified significantly over the past fifteen years, with the most significant structural change being the shift from collective and outdoor leisure toward individualised digital and indoor leisure — a shift driven primarily by the smartphone's penetration of every demographic segment and the resulting availability of effectively unlimited entertainment content accessible without leaving the home. The most time-consuming leisure activities by measured hours are now social media consumption, gaming, and streaming video — all screen-based, all individual or small-group rather than collective, and all relatively recent additions to the leisure landscape. Traditional collective leisure — time spent in extended family contexts, neighbourhood social spaces, and outdoor communal activities — has declined in time share without disappearing, and remains more robust in older and rural demographics than in young urban populations.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional sociology of leisure in Vietnam identifies a bifurcation between leisure as consumption — spending money on restaurants, entertainment venues, shopping, and experiences — and leisure as time — unstructured time spent without commercial purpose. Rising urban incomes have increased leisure as consumption substantially, which is visible in the growth of the food and beverage sector, entertainment venues, and the experience economy more broadly. More ambiguous is what has happened to leisure as time: working hours in Vietnamese urban professional culture are long by international comparison, and the smartphone has effectively colonised much of the previously unscheduled time that existed in commuting, waiting, and transiting — which means that the amount of genuinely unstructured, low-stimulation leisure time available to most urban professionals is smaller than it was before the smartphone era despite rising average incomes.

3. How does technology affect the way people spend their leisure time?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Technology's effect on leisure time is the most consequential and least adequately understood transformation of daily life in the smartphone era — consequential because leisure time is when the psychological maintenance and restoration that demanding modern life requires is supposed to happen, and the quality of that restoration depends heavily on what fills it. The primary effect of smartphone technology on leisure has been substitution: activities that previously filled leisure time — reading, socialised conversation, outdoor activity, genuine idleness — have been partly displaced by screen-based activity whose design is explicitly optimised to maximise time-on-platform rather than to maximise the user's wellbeing. The evidence that this substitution has had measurable negative effects on mental health outcomes — particularly for adolescents and young adults, but also for adults — is accumulating in ways that are becoming difficult for the research community to dismiss.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional analysis of technology's effect on leisure identifies the key variable as the degree to which technology functions as a tool chosen by the user versus an environment the user is captured within. Technology used as a deliberate tool to enable leisure activities the user has chosen — navigation for a hiking trip, a recipe app for cooking a complex dish, a language learning app pursued as a hobby — contributes positively to leisure quality without reducing agency. Technology that functions as an attentional environment — where algorithmic feeds continuously present the next piece of content before the user has made an active choice to seek it — reduces leisure quality by substituting the platform's agenda for the user's, which produces the characteristic simultaneous feelings of time-wasting and compulsion that most smartphone users recognise but find difficult to interrupt.

4. Do you think only old people have time for leisure?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The perception that leisure is primarily available to older or retired people reflects a confusion between leisure time — unscheduled time available for discretionary use — and leisure quality — the degree to which available time is actually experienced as restorative and freely chosen. Younger people often have more unscheduled time in certain life stages — the relatively unstructured evenings of student life, for instance — but experience it as lower quality leisure because it is accompanied by higher background anxiety about the future, social comparison pressure, and the expectation that it should be "productive." Older people often have less raw leisure time but higher leisure quality — partly because they have developed better capacities to resist the colonisation of unscheduled time by work and screen-based attention capture, and partly because they experience genuinely free time as more clearly legitimate.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional work-leisure balance research identifies a more complex relationship between age and leisure quality than the simple "retired people have more leisure" narrative suggests. The data on subjective experience of leisure consistently shows that working-age adults report lower leisure satisfaction relative to time spent on leisure than either younger or older cohorts — a finding that reflects not primarily time availability but the contamination of leisure time by work-related preoccupation, the difficulty of psychological detachment from work during non-working hours, and the residual guilt about leisure that professional cultures that valorise busyness systematically produce. Addressing leisure quality for working-age adults is therefore less a time management problem than a psychological and cultural one: the obstacle is not lack of time but the inability to fully inhabit the time that is available.

5. Why do old people prefer to live in quiet places?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Older people's preference for quieter residential environments reflects a combination of neurological, social, and life-stage factors that are more complex than simple noise sensitivity. The neurological dimension: auditory processing changes with age in ways that make background noise more cognitively costly — older adults have more difficulty separating signal from noise in complex auditory environments, which makes high-noise settings more effortful and less comfortable regardless of attitudes toward noise in the abstract. The social dimension: older people's social networks and daily activities typically require less proximity to the dense urban infrastructure — employment centres, entertainment venues, late-night social contexts — that high-noise urban environments provide access to, which means the trade-off between noise and proximity to urban amenity calculates differently for them than for younger people whose lives are more centred on those amenities.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional gerontological understanding of residential preference in older age identifies quiet as one element of a larger syndrome of preferences for environments that are manageable, high on autonomy, and low on the demands for rapid adaptation that high-stimulation urban environments make. Sensory overwhelm — the difficulty of managing complex, high-stimulus environments — increases with age for both neurological and energetic reasons, and the preference for quieter environments is partly a preference for environments where the cost of navigation and daily functioning is lower and where the surplus energy available for chosen activities rather than environmental management is higher. The policy implication is that supporting older people's preference for quieter environments — through both urban design and housing policy — is an investment in the active, autonomous ageing that produces better health outcomes and lower long-term care costs.

6. Why are there more noises made at home now than in the past?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Domestic noise levels have increased substantially over the past generation, driven by the proliferation of devices — televisions, computers, smartphones, smart speakers, gaming equipment — that continuously generate audio output, and by the erosion of the social conventions that previously maintained domestic quiet as a norm rather than an absence. The most significant single driver is probably the smartphone: its combination of constant notification sounds, social media audio, and video content has introduced a continuous low-level audio environment into domestic spaces that previous generations did not experience. A secondary driver is the architectural changes in urban housing — open-plan designs that lack the acoustic separation of traditionally divided domestic space — which means that household members' activities are more acoustically present to each other than they were in homes with more compartmentalised layouts.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional acoustic environment analysis of contemporary homes identifies the shift from analogue to digital household technology as the primary structural driver of increased domestic noise. Analogue household technology — refrigerators, clocks, heating systems — produced a relatively constant, predictable acoustic background that residents habituated

to rapidly. Digital household technology — with its notification sounds, voice responses, ringtones, streaming audio, and gaming content — produces intermittent, unpredictable audio events that interrupt habituation and maintain attentional alertness in ways that sustained background noise does not. The cognitive cost of this intermittent digital noise is larger than its absolute volume would suggest: the attentional interruption of a notification sound is disproportionate to its acoustic level, which means that domestic environments are more cognitively demanding for their inhabitants than simple noise measurement would indicate.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
acoustic separation	n phr		physical barriers that reduce sound transmission between spaces	cách âm, ngăn âm thanh
habituation	n	/həˈbɪtʃ.uˈeɪ.jən/	the process of becoming accustomed to a stimulus so it is less noticed	sự quen dần với kích thích
gerontological	adj	/ˌdʒer.ɒn.təˈlɒdʒ.ɪ.kəl/	relating to the study of ageing	thuộc khoa học về lão hoá
sensory overwhelm	n phr		a state in which too much sensory input causes distress or confusion	quá tải cảm giác
psychological detachment	n phr		the ability to mentally disconnect from work during off-hours	sự tách rời tâm lý khỏi công việc
attentional capture	n phr		when something involuntarily draws and holds your attention	sự thu hút chú ý không chủ ý
valorise	v	/ˈvæl.ə.raɪz/	to assign or increase value to something, especially culturally	coi trọng, nâng giá trị
acoustic mitigation	n phr		measures taken to reduce noise levels or impact	biện pháp giảm thiểu âm thanh
intermittent	adj	/ˌɪn.tɜːˈmɪt.ənt/	stopping and starting at irregular intervals	không liên tục, gián đoạn
open-plan	adj		(of a space) without internal walls or partitions	mặt bằng mở, không vách ngăn

2.49 Describe a good habit your friend has and you want to develop

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a good habit your friend has and you want to develop. You should say:

- Who your friend is
- What habit he/she has
- When you noticed this habit
- And explain why you want to develop this habit.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The habit I've noticed most in a close friend of mine — someone I've known since high school and who is now studying engineering — is her practice of writing down a short note to herself at the end of each day: not a diary exactly, more a brief record of one specific thing she'd learned or noticed that she hadn't known or seen before. I observed it properly for the first time during a trip we took together in our first year of university, when she pulled out a small notebook before sleeping and wrote for about three or four minutes while I was scrolling through my phone, and when I asked what she was doing she explained it so matter-of-factly — as if everyone did it — that I felt a mild embarrassment that I'd never thought to do it myself. What I want to develop isn't the mechanical habit itself — the writing, the notebook — but the underlying disposition it represents: the practice of active attention, of going through a day with the intention of noticing things rather than merely experiencing them as they pass. She has accumulated, over about three years, something like four thousand small observations about the world, and I'm consistently struck by how much more calibrated her understanding of things across different domains is than mine, and how directly that seems to trace back to the habit.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The habit a colleague of mine has that I most want to develop is what he calls "cooling time"— a practice of not acting on emails, messages, or decisions that carry emotional weight for at least twenty-four hours after first encountering them. He described it to me about two years ago over coffee when I was venting about an email exchange that had escalated more than I intended, and his response — calm, specific, slightly amused — was that the first draft of any emotionally significant communication should be treated as a working document rather than a final one, and that the gap between drafting and sending was where most of one's worst professional decisions could be intercepted. I noticed subsequently that his professional communications have a notably different register from most people's — more measured, more precise, consistently less reactive — and I have attributed this difference, correctly I think, to the cooling time practice. I've tried to implement it myself with mixed results: the problem is that the impulse to respond immediately is strongest precisely when the response most needs to wait.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
disposition	n	/ˌdɪs.pə'zɪʃ.ən/	a habitual tendency or inclination	xu hướng, khuynh hướng tự nhiên
calibrated	adj	/'kæl.ɪ.breɪ.tɪd/	carefully adjusted to be accurate	được hiệu chỉnh chính xác
register	n	/'redʒ.ɪ.stər/	the level and style of language appropriate to a context	văn phong, cách hành văn
intercept	v	/ˌɪn.tə'sept/	to stop or catch something before it reaches its destination	chặn lại
reactive	adj	/'riːæk.tɪv/	responding immediately and emotionally without deliberation	phản ứng theo bản năng, thiếu cân nhắc
escalate	v	/'es.ke.lert/	to become more serious or intense	leo thang, trở nên căng thẳng hơn
matter-of-factly	adv		in a calm and practical way, without emotion	một cách thực tế, điềm nhiên
underlying	adj	/ˌʌn.də'laɪ.ɪŋ/	forming the basis or foundation	cơ bản, tiềm ẩn bên dưới
cooling time	n phr		a period of delay before acting on an emotional impulse	thời gian để nguội (hạ nhiệt cảm xúc)
accumulate	v	/ə'kjuː.mjʊ.lert/	to gather or collect something over time	tích lũy

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. What habits should children have?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The habits most worth cultivating in children are those whose value compounds over time — habits whose effects are not simply additive but multiplicative, where consistent practice over years produces returns that dwarf what their immediate value suggests. Reading is the most widely cited example: the child who reads consistently for thirty minutes a day across ten years has accumulated not just the information encountered in those readings but the expanded vocabulary, improved syntactic flexibility, and enhanced comprehension capacity that the reading itself generates — capacities that benefit performance across academic domains far wider than literacy alone. Physical activity habits are in a similar category: the child who establishes consistent physical activity habits early is significantly more likely to maintain them into adulthood, with the long-run health benefits of that persistence far exceeding the immediate benefit of any single exercise session.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional child development research perspective on habits identifies the metacognitive habits — habits about thinking rather than habits of behaviour — as the most valuable long-term investment. Specifically, the habit of checking one's own understanding: of asking oneself whether one has actually understood something or merely feels that one has, and of being willing to invest additional effort when the honest answer is the latter. This metacognitive checking habit is one of the strongest predictors of academic performance across subjects and stages, is relatively underemphasised in education systems that focus on content delivery rather than learning quality, and is most effectively developed in early childhood when the habit loop is most easily established. The parallel professional habit — checking one's reasoning rather than just one's conclusions — is the adult analogue and produces similar compounding benefits across careers.

2. What should parents do to teach their children good habits?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Parents' most effective tool for transmitting habits to children is modelling rather than instruction — the demonstration of the habits they want children to develop rather than the articulation of why children should develop them. This is not merely a pedagogical opinion but a well-supported finding in habit formation research: children acquire the majority of their habitual behaviours through observation and imitation of people they identify with and admire, and the instruction dimension of parenting — the explicit telling of what to do — is significantly less predictive of children's actual habits than the modelling dimension. The practical implication is counterintuitive for parents who invest heavily in advice-giving: the most important thing a parent who wants a child to read consistently can do is read consistently themselves, visibly and without making it pedagogically pointed.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional parenting research on habit formation identifies environmental design as the most practically powerful tool available to parents — more powerful, on average, than verbal instruction or motivational appeals. The habit loop — cue, routine, reward — is most easily established when the environment makes the desired behaviour the path of least resistance: placing books in visible, accessible locations rather than on shelves in designated reading areas; making healthy food the easy default rather than the deliberate choice; structuring routines so that the desired habit occurs at a consistent time and in a consistent context, reducing the cognitive effort of initiation. Parents who design the environment for the behaviour they want typically produce more reliable habit formation than parents who rely primarily on instruction and enforcement.

3. What influences do children with bad habits have on other children?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The influence of children with problematic habits on their peers operates through a combination of social learning and norm formation mechanisms — children observe what the peers they interact with do, update their sense of what is normal based on those observations, and adjust their own behaviour accordingly. The social learning mechanism is well-established: children who regularly observe peers engaging in disruptive, avoidant, or risky behaviour are more likely to engage in it themselves, not because of peer pressure in the conventional sense but because the peer's behaviour updates the child's model of what is acceptable and available as a behavioural option. The norm formation dimension operates at a group level: in classrooms where disruptive behaviour is common, the individual cost of maintaining norms like attention, effort, and cooperation rises because the implicit social contract that makes those norms easy to maintain has been weakened.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional educational psychology perspective on peer habit influence identifies the mechanism as primarily normative rather than imitative — what changes is not the individual child's direct behaviour in response to observed peers but the child's perception of what is typical and acceptable in the relevant social group. This normative mechanism is why classroom composition effects — the documented influence of classmates' behaviour on individual children's academic and behavioural outcomes — are largest not in the domain of explicit imitation but in the domain of effort and aspiration: children who perceive that their peers invest effort and value academic achievement invest more effort themselves, while children who perceive that effort is unusual or stigmatised in their peer group invest less — independent of their own private values. The implication is that habits are socially regulated as much as individually chosen.

4. Why do some habits change when people get older?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Habit change with age reflects three distinct mechanisms that operate simultaneously: the shift in situational cues that trigger habitual behaviour, the evolution of intrinsic motivation as values and priorities change, and the physiological changes in reward sensitivity and impulse control that accompany ageing. The situational cue mechanism is the most immediately observable: habits that were triggered by the specific contexts of school, student social life, or early professional life — the gym visit on the way home from university, the social drink after lectures — tend to weaken or disappear when those contexts change, because the environmental cues that maintained them are no longer consistently present. The motivational shift mechanism is more gradual: the social and hedonic motivations that drive many young adult habits — novelty-seeking, social conformity, status signalling — typically weaken relative to health, stability, and quality-of-relationship motivations as people age.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional habit science perspective on age-related habit change identifies the transition from external to internal regulation as the most significant mechanism. Young people's habits are disproportionately sustained by external cues, social norms, and environmental structures — school schedules, peer group activities, family routines — and tend to be fragile when those external structures change. Older adults' more stable habits are more frequently

driven by internalised values and identity — “I’m someone who exercises regularly,” “I’m someone who reads before bed” — which are more resistant to environmental change because they are self-generated rather than externally sustained. The therapeutic implication of this pattern is that habit formation interventions that successfully build identity-level integration — where the habit becomes part of who the person is rather than merely something they do — produce substantially more durable behaviour change than interventions that rely on external cues, rewards, or accountability structures alone.

5. How do we develop bad habits?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Bad habits develop through the same mechanisms as good ones — the habit loop of cue, routine, and reward — with the difference that the reward they deliver is immediate and certain while their costs are delayed and diffuse. This asymmetry is the fundamental structural reason why bad habits form so readily: the brain’s reward circuitry is calibrated to respond to near-term, certain rewards rather than long-term, probabilistic ones, which means that behaviours delivering immediate pleasure, relief, or stimulation — regardless of their longer-term consequences — are powerfully reinforced by each repetition. The social dimension of bad habit formation is equally important: many problematic habits develop in social contexts where they function as bonding behaviours, markers of group membership, or appropriate responses to a dominant social norm — and in these cases, the habit’s social reinforcement is often more powerful than its individual reward.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional behavioural science analysis of bad habit formation identifies stress and depletion as the conditions under which most problematic habits are initiated. When cognitive and emotional resources are depleted — by work pressure, relationship problems, sleep deprivation, or sustained uncertainty — the brain defaults toward behaviours that deliver reliable immediate reward, because the executive function capacity required to delay gratification is among the first cognitive capacities to deteriorate under resource depletion. This is why most people’s bad habits are strongest under stress and weakest when they are rested and resourced — and why the habit formation interventions that rely on willpower and deliberate choice are least effective precisely when they are most needed. The structural implication is that managing the conditions of depletion — sleep, stress levels, workload — is more effective prevention of bad habit formation than instruction about the habits themselves.

6. What can we do to get rid of bad habits?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The most effective approaches to bad habit elimination focus on disrupting the habit loop at its cue stage rather than at the routine stage — changing the environment to remove or modify the cues that trigger the habitual behaviour rather than relying on willpower to resist the routine once it has been triggered. This cue-disruption approach is more reliable than resistance because it reduces the frequency with which the habit is activated rather than requiring sustained successful resistance to each activation — and because, unlike willpower-based resistance, it requires no cognitive or emotional effort at the moment of potential enactment. Complementary to cue disruption is replacement: identifying an alternative

behaviour that delivers a similar reward to the bad habit and establishing it as the default response to the same cue, so that the habit loop is redirected rather than simply broken.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional habit change research consistently identifies implementation intentions — specific, detailed plans specifying when, where, and how the desired behaviour change will be enacted — as the most effective single addition to any habit change programme. The specificity requirement is critical: "I will exercise more" has negligible effect on behaviour; "I will go for a thirty-minute walk when I leave the office on Monday, Wednesday, and Friday, changing my route home to pass through the park" has substantially more, because it pre-determines the decision rather than leaving it to be made under the cognitive conditions that prevailed when the old habit was being maintained. The professional implication is that the most valuable support a coach, therapist, or accountability partner can provide is not motivation or instruction but the structured development of genuine implementation intentions that are specific enough to actually govern behaviour at the moment of choice.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
habit loop	n phr		the cycle of cue, routine, and reward that underlies habitual behaviour	vòng lặp thói quen
implementation intention	n phr		a detailed plan specifying when and how a behaviour will be performed	kế hoạch thực hiện cụ thể
cue disruption	n phr		removing or modifying environmental triggers for a habitual behaviour	phá vỡ kích thích gây ra thói quen
depletion	n	/dɪ'pliː.ʃən/	the reduction of a resource to below its normal level	sự cạn kiệt (nguồn lực)
executive function	n phr		cognitive processes that enable planning, decision-making, and self-control	chức năng điều hành (nhận thức)
internalised	adj	/ɪn'tɜː.nə.laɪzd/	absorbed as part of one's own values or identity	được nội tâm hoá
hedonic	adj	/hɪ'dɒn.ɪk/	relating to pleasure as the primary motivator	thuộc về khoái cảm
multiplicative	adj	/'mʌl.tɪ.plɪ.kə.tɪv/	producing effects that multiply rather than simply add together	nhân lên, mang tính bội số
metacognitive	adj	/,met.ə'kɒɡ.nɪ.tɪv/	relating to awareness and understanding of one's own thought processes	siêu nhận thức
modelling	n	/'mɒd.əl.ɪŋ/	demonstrating behaviour for others to observe and imitate	làm gương, mô phỏng hành vi

2.50 Describe a time when you waited for something special that would happen

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a time when you waited for something special that would happen. You should say:

- What you waited for
- Where you waited
- Why it was special
- And explain how you felt while you were waiting.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

About two years ago I spent about four days at a small guesthouse in Đà Lạt waiting for the result of a university scholarship application that I'd submitted in February — the kind of waiting that is specific to outcome stakes large enough to make the interim period feel meaningfully suspended rather than simply passing. I had gone to Đà Lạt because I needed to be somewhere other than Hà Nội, where being in familiar surroundings while the result was pending seemed likely to produce a particular quality of unproductive anxiety that going somewhere else might interrupt. The waiting itself was not simply time passing; it had a specific texture — alternating between periods of genuine calm when I managed to engage properly with where I was and periods of recursive mental rehearsal of both possible outcomes — the kind of not-thinking-about-it that is also a form of thinking about it. When the result came through on the fourth day — the scholarship was awarded — the most immediate emotion was not joy but relief, and then a slightly undignified amount of crying in a café on Hồ Xuân Hương, followed by calling my parents.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The waiting experience I remember most precisely is the eighteen months between signing a contract for a project that required significant personal financial commitment and the completion date — a period during which I had enough information to understand what could go wrong and not enough certainty about whether it would to resolve the anxiety that awareness produced. Professional waiting at that level is different from event-based waiting; there is no specific moment of resolution anticipated, just an extended period of managed uncertainty in which professional responsibilities must be fulfilled regardless of what the private anxiety registers about them. What I learned about myself in that period — which was more useful than the outcome, which was satisfactory — was that my anxiety under sustained uncertainty is primarily cognitive rather than emotional: it manifests as inability to focus rather than as distress, which was information about how to manage similar periods in future and which led me to develop some specific practices about where and how I work during periods of high-stakes uncertainty.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
interim	adj/n	/ˈɪn.tər.ɪm/	the time between two events	khoảng thời gian chờ đợi giữa hai sự kiện
recursive	adj	/rɪˈkʊː.sɪv/	returning to itself repeatedly	lặp đi lặp lại chính nó
pending	adj	/ˈpen.dɪŋ/	awaiting delivery or resolution	đang chờ, chưa được giải quyết
sustained uncertainty	n phr		a prolonged state of not knowing an important outcome	sự không chắc chắn kéo dài
stakes	n pl	/steɪks/	the level of risk or importance attached to an outcome	độ rủi ro, mức độ quan trọng
resolution	n	/ˌrez.əˈluː.ʃən/	the act of solving a problem or reaching a decision	sự giải quyết, kết thúc
manifests	v	/ˈmæn.ɪ.fests/	shows or makes itself apparent	biểu hiện ra
cognitive	adj	/ˈkɒɡ.nɪ.tɪv/	related to mental processes such as thought and reasoning	thuộc nhận thức
rehearsal	n	/rɪˈhɜː.səl/	the act of mentally practising or going over something in advance	diễn tập trong tâm trí
satisfactory	adj	/ˌsæt.ɪsˈfæk.tər.i/	meeting expectations; adequate	thoả đáng, đáp ứng được kỳ vọng

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. On what occasions do people usually need to wait?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Waiting is distributed across a spectrum from the trivially inconvenient to the genuinely significant, and the occasions that require it fall into structurally distinct categories whose

different psychological profiles make their subjective experience quite different from one another. The most frequent category is logistical waiting: queues, traffic, appointment delays, service waits — brief periods of enforced inactivity that represent an aggregate time cost in modern urban life that is large and consistently underestimated. The most psychologically significant category is outcome waiting — the period between submitting a job application and receiving a decision, between completing medical tests and receiving results, between finalising an investment and discovering its return — where the waiting involves genuine uncertainty about matters of importance, and where the psychological management of the interim is a substantive life task rather than a minor inconvenience.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional categorisation of waiting occasions distinguishes between process waits — where the wait is a structural feature of a system that could in principle be designed differently — and outcome waits — where the wait is inherent to the nature of what is being awaited and cannot be eliminated by system design. Process waits in professional life are increasingly the target of operational improvement: queue management, appointment scheduling, service design, and digital service delivery have all reduced process wait times substantially in most developed service contexts. Outcome waits remain irreducible: the time required for a business decision to prove itself, a medical treatment to demonstrate efficacy, or a relationship to reveal its character cannot be compressed below its natural development time without reducing the quality of the information that the wait was generating.

2. Who behave better when waiting, children or adults?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Adults generally manage waiting better than children in observable behavioural terms — the likelihood of visible distress, disruptive behaviour, or vocal complaint in a queue is significantly higher for children than for adults — but the behavioural difference reflects capacity rather than preference: adults don't want to wait any more than children do, they are simply more capable of managing the frustration that waiting generates without externalising it in socially disruptive ways. The developmental explanation is straightforward: the executive function capacity for delay of gratification — the neurological machinery that allows a person to tolerate present deprivation for future reward — matures through adolescence and into early adulthood, which means that younger children are not choosing to behave badly while waiting but are genuinely less capable of managing waiting's frustration than adults are. The qualification is that adults are often worse at managing waiting than their surface behaviour suggests: adults who appear calm while waiting may be experiencing significant internal frustration, metabolising cortisol in ways that affect mood and performance for hours afterwards.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional developmental psychology perspective identifies delay of gratification as a capacity that develops progressively through childhood and adolescence rather than appearing in binary form at a particular age. The famous Marshmallow Test research — subsequently complicated by replication and contextual analysis — demonstrates that even young children show significant individual variation in delay capacity, and that the conditions of waiting (trust in the promise of future reward, availability of distraction strategies, quality of attention regulation) substantially predict performance independently of age. The practical implication for designing waiting experiences is that the conditions that make waiting tolerable for children — clear explanation of how long the wait will be, engaging distraction, genuine trust that the wait will end as promised — are also the conditions that make waiting most

tolerable for adults, which is why the most effectively designed queueing systems consider them regardless of the demographic composition of the queue.

3. Compared to the past, are people less patient now? Why?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The perception that contemporary people are less patient than previous generations is widely shared but difficult to establish rigorously, partly because patience was not systematically measured in earlier periods and partly because any comparison needs to disentangle genuine capacity change from changes in the situations that require patience. What can be said with reasonable confidence is that the digital environment has calibrated people's expectations about response times in ways that make waits that were unremarkable a generation ago — a week for a letter, a day for a telephone callback — feel unnatural now. Whether this recalibration of expectations represents a genuine reduction in patience capacity or simply an adjustment of reference norms — patience applied to different timescales — is a more genuinely difficult question that the available evidence doesn't straightforwardly answer.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional behavioural science analysis of patience changes identifies the smartphone and digital communication environment as having restructured the reward landscape in ways that may genuinely have affected patience capacity rather than merely recalibrated reference norms. Specifically: the habit of immediate gratification — the trained expectation that any information need, communication desire, or entertainment want can be satisfied within seconds — may have eroded the brain's practiced tolerance for delay in ways that affect patience across domains including those where digital acceleration is irrelevant. Whether this represents genuine neurological change or merely behavioural adaptation that would reverse with sustained environmental change is unknown, but the pattern of correlation between smartphone adoption and reduced measured tolerance for delay in experimental settings is strong enough to take the possibility seriously.

4. What are the positive and negative effects of waiting on society?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Waiting has both underappreciated positive dimensions and well-documented negative ones, and the social value of understanding them accurately is significant precisely because contemporary service design is almost universally oriented toward eliminating waiting, with the assumption that its elimination is exclusively beneficial. The positive dimension: waiting periods that are genuinely inherent to the nature of what is being waited for — the time required for a good decision to be made carefully, for a relationship to develop its true character — are epistemic assets, generating information that faster resolution would eliminate. The social practice of waiting also maintains norms of fairness in resource allocation: the queue is one of the few social mechanisms that distributes access to limited resources on a roughly equal basis independent of social status or financial capacity, which gives it a social equity function that purely efficiency-oriented service design can inadvertently eliminate.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional service design perspective on waiting's effects distinguishes between the objective duration of waits and their subjective experience — a distinction that matters because it reveals that many of waiting's negative effects are design-dependent rather than

inherent to the wait itself. Research on queue psychology consistently shows that uncertain, unoccupied, and unexplained waits are experienced as significantly longer and more distressing than waits of equivalent duration that are bounded (with clear communication about length), occupied (with something appropriate to do), and explained (with information about why). The implication is that much of the negative social effect of waiting is a failure of design rather than of patience — and that the effort invested in redesigning waits to be better-experienced would produce larger wellbeing gains than the effort invested in simply reducing wait times.

5. Why are some people unwilling to wait?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Unwillingness to wait reflects a complex of factors that include genuine time scarcity, learned expectations, personality variation in delay tolerance, and the specific emotional quality of the wait — and which factor is dominant varies significantly by individual and situation. The time scarcity dimension is real and often understated: people with genuinely constrained time budgets — working parents, people holding multiple jobs, those managing complex care responsibilities — experience waiting differently from people with more slack in their schedules, because for them a queue is not merely inconvenient but represents a direct cost imposed on other time-sensitive obligations. The expectation dimension is also real: people who have been consistently able to access services without significant waits develop a reference norm against which any wait registers as a deviation, which makes the same wait experienced by someone with a higher reference norm of waiting seem disproportionately frustrating.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional analysis of wait refusal — the decision to abandon a service rather than wait for it — identifies perceived value of time as the primary economic variable: people who place higher monetary or opportunity cost value on their time will rationally abandon waits at shorter durations than people who place lower value on their time. This is why wait refusal is concentrated among higher-income consumers and why premium pricing for queue-skipping — priority boarding, fast-pass queuing, expedited services — is a viable commercial strategy in markets where consumer incomes are distributed unevenly: the willingness-to-pay for time savings is directly correlated with the economic value of the time saved. The social equity dimension of this pattern — that the economically advantaged disproportionately transcend waiting while the economically disadvantaged wait — is a genuine fairness concern in service contexts that are nominally available to all on equal terms.

6. Where do children learn to be patient, at home or at school?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Both home and school contribute to the development of patience in children, but through distinct mechanisms and at different developmental stages — and the question of which contributes more is less important than understanding what each contributes specifically. Home is the primary site for the early development of delay of gratification: the attachment relationship and its characteristic experience of having needs met after a brief wait — the parent who takes a moment to respond, the meal that requires preparation — provides the foundational experience that waiting is both tolerable and reliably rewarded that underlies

later patience capacity. School extends this foundation into social contexts: the classroom requires waiting for one's turn, waiting for instruction to complete before acting, waiting for the group to be ready before proceeding — all of which rehearse patience in social rather than purely attachment contexts.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional developmental perspective on where patience is learned emphasises that the quality of waiting experiences matters more than the location. Children who experience waits that reliably resolve — where the promised reward actually materialises, where the explained wait actually ends when predicted — develop both patience capacity and the trust in delayed gratification that sustains it under pressure. Children who experience waits that are unreliable — where promised outcomes don't materialise, where the length of waits is consistently misrepresented — develop rational scepticism about delayed gratification rather than patience: the "impatience" that results from this experience is not a character failing but a rational response to evidence about the reliability of delayed reward. This finding has implications for both parenting practice and school design: the most important ingredient in patience development is not practice at waiting per se but practice at waiting in environments where the reliability of the wait's resolution is consistently demonstrated.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
delay of gratification	n phr		the ability to resist immediate reward for a later, larger one	trì hoãn thoả mãn
queue psychology	n phr		the study of how people experience and behave in waiting lines	tâm lý học hàng đợi
reference norm	n phr		the standard against which a current experience is compared	chuẩn mực tham chiếu
willingness-to-pay	n phr		the maximum amount a consumer is willing to spend for something	mức sẵn sàng trả tiền
epistemic	adj	/ˌep.ɪˈstiː.mɪk/	relating to knowledge and how it is formed	thuộc nhận thức, liên quan đến tri thức
Marshmallow Test	n phr		a classic experiment measuring delay of gratification in children	thí nghiệm kẹo marshmallow
fairness	n	/ˈfeə.nɪs/	the quality of treating people equally	sự công bằng
attachment relationship	n phr		the emotional bond between a child and their primary caregiver	mối quan hệ gắn bó (giữa trẻ và người chăm sóc)
opportunity cost	n phr		the value of the next best alternative forgone	chi phí cơ hội

2.51 Describe a time you saw something interesting on social media

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a time you saw something interesting on social media. You should say:

- When it was
- Where you saw it
- What you saw
- And explain why you think it was interesting.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

About eight months ago I came across a short video thread on Twitter — now X — where a materials scientist was explaining, in a series of about twelve posts, why cement is structurally unstable as a long-term building material and what the architectural implications of that instability are at the timescale of centuries. What made it genuinely compelling wasn't the information itself — which I had no prior knowledge of and found surprising — but the quality of the explanation: the scientist had clearly thought carefully about how to communicate a technical argument to a non-specialist audience, had made specific choices about what to simplify and what to preserve at full complexity, and had written with a directness that carried genuine intelligence rather than the performed accessibility of most science communication. I shared it immediately with three people — which is unusual for me — and two of them sent me something in return within the hour. What I remember about the experience is the specific pleasure of encountering someone thinking clearly about something in public, which social media relatively rarely produces and which is immediately recognisable when it does.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The most professionally consequential thing I've encountered on social media was a LinkedIn post by an urban planner in Copenhagen, shared about eighteen months ago, describing a small natural experiment that their city had inadvertently run: a parking lane that was temporarily removed for construction ended up, three years later, permanently converted to a cycle lane because the traffic impact of removing the parking — which had been predicted to be significant — turned out to be negligible. The post was interesting as a case study in induced demand, which I'd read about in the abstract but had never seen described with this quality of specificity — the planner had the before-and-after numbers, the community reaction timeline, and the political decision process detailed clearly enough that it read as genuine evidence rather than advocacy. I used it in a presentation about urban mobility patterns six weeks later, which is probably the most directly useful thing social media has generated for my professional work in recent memory.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
induced demand	n phr		the phenomenon where increased supply of a resource creates more demand for it	cầu cảm ứng (cung tạo ra cầu)
negligible	adj	/ˈneg.lɪ.dʒɪ.bəl/	so small as to be not worth considering	không đáng kể
compelling	adj	/kəmˈpel.ɪŋ/	powerfully attracting attention and interest	hấp dẫn, cuốn hút
thread	n	/θred/	a series of connected social media posts on a single topic	chuỗi bài đăng liên tiếp
case study	n phr		a detailed study of a specific real-world example	nghiên cứu điển hình
advocacy	n	/ˈæd.və.kə.si/	public support for a particular cause or policy	vận động, bảo hộ
non-specialist	adj		not requiring expert knowledge; accessible to the general public	không chuyên biệt, dành cho đại chúng
consecutive	adj	/kənˈsek.jʊ.tɪv/	following one after another without interruption	liên tiếp
directness	n	/daɪˈrekt.nəs/	expressing ideas clearly and without unnecessary elaboration	sự thẳng thắn, rõ ràng
specificity	n	/ˌspes.ɪˈfɪs.ɪ.ti/	the quality of being precise and detailed	tính cụ thể, chi tiết

1. Why do people like to use social media?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Social media's appeal operates through a set of psychological mechanisms that its designers understand well and have optimised for — which is a significant part of why engagement with these platforms is so persistent and difficult to moderate voluntarily. The most fundamental mechanism is social validation: the visibility of others' responses to one's own posts — likes, comments, shares — delivers a specific form of social feedback that activates the brain's reward circuitry in ways that are structurally similar to other variable-ratio reinforcement schedules known to produce strong and perseverant engagement. The secondary mechanism is social surveillance — the low-cost, low-risk capacity to maintain awareness of other people's activities, relationships, and self-presentations without the effort or social exposure of direct interaction — which satisfies a deep evolved interest in the activities and relative standing of one's social community that previously required significantly more effort and social capital to access.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional media psychology analysis of social media appeal identifies the combination of social connection, entertainment, and identity expression as the three primary functional gratifications that platform usage delivers. The social connection dimension is most powerful for people in life stages or circumstances where other-channel social contact is limited: the elderly, those with mobility limitations, people who have recently relocated, or anyone whose immediate social context is thin relative to their social needs. The identity expression dimension — the capacity to curate and present a self-image to a chosen audience — is particularly powerful for adolescents and young adults in identity-formation stages, for whom social media provides an unprecedented laboratory for trying out self-presentations and receiving social feedback on them at scale and relatively low cost. The entertainment dimension is the most commercially significant for the platforms themselves, because time spent in entertainment mode generates the largest volumes of the advertising inventory that underpins platform revenue.

2. What kinds of things are popular on social media?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The categories that consistently generate the highest engagement on social media platforms are those that combine high emotional activation with low information complexity — content that produces a strong immediate affective response without requiring sustained cognitive effort to process. This explains the structural dominance of short-form video (TikTok, Reels) over text, of visual content over prose, and of emotionally activating content — inspiring stories, outrage-inducing narratives, adorable animals, spectacular scenery — over balanced or nuanced analysis. The specific content categories most reliably popular are those that play to social curiosity — gossip, celebrity, relationship drama — and to social aspiration — luxury display, fitness transformation, success narrative — which together activate the social comparison and status-monitoring tendencies that constitute some of the most powerful and evolutionarily ancient drivers of human attention.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional content analytics perspective on social media popularity identifies emotional valence and shareability as the two most reliably predictive dimensions of content performance across platforms. Content with high positive or high negative emotional valence significantly

outperforms neutral content in engagement metrics, because emotional activation drives the sharing behaviour that amplifies distribution: people share content that made them feel strongly more reliably than content that informed them. Shareability is distinct from quality: content that is easily shareable — that makes the sharer look good, that expresses something the sharer wanted to express but couldn't articulate, or that signals group membership and values — travels further than content that is merely accurate or important. The structural consequence is that social media's popularity rankings systematically underrepresent accurate, nuanced, and complex content relative to its actual social value.

3. What are the advantages and disadvantages of using social media?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Social media's advantage and disadvantage sets are symmetrically related — the same features that produce genuine benefits also produce, in overuse or misuse, the corresponding harms. The connection benefit — the capacity to maintain and develop relationships with people across geographic distance at low cost — becomes the comparison harm when the comparison between one's own private experience and others' curated public self-presentations drives social anxiety and dissatisfaction. The information benefit — access to a vastly expanded range of information and perspectives that would previously have been inaccessible — becomes the misinformation risk when the same distribution dynamics that make accurate information accessible make inaccurate information equally so. The self-expression benefit becomes the surveillance and privacy cost when the data that constitutes one's self-expression is retained, aggregated, and sold in ways that most users do not meaningfully understand or consent to.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional analysis of social media's cost-benefit profile concludes that the distribution of costs and benefits is highly heterogeneous across users, use patterns, and life stages — which makes aggregate evaluations ("social media is good/bad") largely uninformative as policy guidance. For older adults using social media primarily for social connection and information access with relatively low time commitment, the benefit-cost ratio is positive and well-supported by evidence. For adolescents and young adults with high social comparison sensitivity using social media with high time commitment and primarily for social validation, the benefit-cost ratio is more clearly negative. The policy implication is that social media governance — through platforms, regulation, and education — should be designed around the demographic populations and use patterns where harms are largest rather than around categorical evaluation of the medium.

4. What do you think of making friends on social network?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Online friendship formation — using social media platforms as the initial contact point for relationships that may or may not develop into something substantive — is a genuinely legitimate mode of social connection that the cultural dismissiveness toward it frequently undervalues. The evidence that online-initiated friendships are structurally weaker than offline-initiated ones is mixed: what the research more consistently shows is that the same friendship quality factors — shared interests, genuine mutual investment, regular contact, emotional disclosure — predict friendship strength regardless of where the friendship was

initiated. The specific advantage of online friendship initiation is its capacity to connect people with unusually narrow or specialised shared interests that might not find one another in their immediate geographic context — a value that is particularly significant for people in life phases or circumstances where their immediate social environment provides limited prospects for meeting compatible others.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional sociological perspective on online friendship formation is that the internet has effectively eliminated the geographic constraint on social network formation in ways that produce significant welfare benefits for populations previously limited by that constraint. The most benefited populations are those whose social networks were previously most constrained by geography — people in rural or low-density areas, people with unusual or specialised interests, people belonging to minority communities too small to find adequate social connection in their immediate environment. The qualification is that the removal of geographic constraint has not eliminated the behavioural requirements of strong friendship — sustained mutual investment, reliability, genuine emotional availability — which require effort regardless of whether the friendship originated online or offline. Online friendship formation expands the opportunity set; it does not reduce the investment required to convert opportunities into durable connections.

5. Are there any people who shouldn't use social media?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of who should not use social media is more productively approached as a question about which specific use patterns are harmful for which specific populations rather than as a categorical exclusion question — because the evidence for harm from social media is much more specific in its demographic and behavioural targeting than the categorical framing suggests. The population for whom the strongest negative evidence exists is adolescent girls using high-visual-content platforms primarily for social comparison: this specific combination — developmental stage, gender, content type, and primary use motivation — shows the clearest and most replicable association with negative mental health outcomes including increased anxiety, decreased self-esteem, and elevated depression symptoms. The corollary is that different populations — older adults using social media for social connection, professionals using it primarily for information access — show the evidence pattern in a very different direction.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional public health perspective on social media harm reduction is increasingly moving from "who shouldn't use it" (a question whose answer only applies to extreme cases) toward "what conditions of use reduce harm for the populations where harm evidence is clearest." The conditions that most consistently predict positive rather than negative outcomes from social media use are: active rather than passive use (creating, communicating, and engaging rather than scrolling and comparing); time-bounded rather than unlimited use; use motivated by specific goals rather than habituated scrolling; and regular evaluation of whether the use is delivering the benefits the user intends. These conditions can be cultivated through design (platforms can build tools that support them), education (users can be taught them), and personal practice — which is a more tractable intervention target than exclusion.

6. Do you think people spend too much time on social media?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

"Too much time" implies a standard against which current social media usage is being measured, and the honest answer is that "too much" varies substantially by individual, use pattern, and what the social media time is displacing. For someone whose social media usage is displacing sleep, face-to-face social interaction, physical activity, or sustained focused work — activities with robust evidence of high personal value and whose loss is associated with measurable negative outcomes — the usage is genuinely excessive in a meaningful sense. For someone whose social media usage fills time that would otherwise be vacant, is used for genuine social connection and information access, and is not displacing valued activities, the "too much" judgement is significantly less well-supported, even if the absolute time involved looks large by conventional standards.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional research perspective on social media time use consistently finds that self-reported social media usage substantially understates actual measured usage — people typically estimate they spend forty to sixty percent less time on social media than their device logs show — which suggests both that much of the usage is more habituated and less deliberate than users believe, and that people's introspective evaluation of their own usage patterns is a poor guide to its actual character. The more productive approach to the "too much" question is functional rather than quantitative: the question is not whether the absolute time is large but whether the use is delivering the outcomes the user wants and whether the user retains genuine voluntary control over when and how they engage with the platform. Users who feel they could stop or reduce usage without difficulty and who find their social media use genuinely valuable are in a different position from users who feel compelled to use platforms they evaluate negatively — and the latter population is both substantial and underserved by the current design of most social media environments.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
variable-ratio reinforcement	n phr		a reward schedule where rewards come unpredictably, producing strong habitual behaviour	lịch củng cố tỷ lệ biến thiên
social surveillance	n phr		monitoring others' social activities and status through digital platforms	giám sát xã hội
curated	adj	/kju'rei.tɪd/	carefully selected and presented	được chọn lọc và trình bày cẩn thận
emotional valence	n phr		the degree to which content triggers positive or negative emotion	hóa trị cảm xúc (mức độ cảm xúc tích cực/tiêu cực)
shareability	n	/ʃeərə'bil.i.ti/	how likely content is to be shared by users	khả năng lan truyền
social comparison	n phr		evaluating oneself against others	so sánh xã hội
habituated	adj	/hə'bitʃ.u.eɪ.tɪd/	having become so used to something that it feels automatic	đã thành thói quen tự động
governance	n	/'gʌv.ən.əns/	the system of rules and practices to regulate something	quản trị
introspective	adj	/'ɪn.trə'spek.tɪv/	examining one's own thoughts and feelings	nội tâm, mang tính tự suy ngẫm
harm reduction	n phr		strategies to minimise negative consequences of a behaviour	giảm thiểu tác hại

2.52 Describe a natural talent (sports, music, etc.) you want to improve

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a natural talent (sports, music, etc.) you want to improve. You should say:

- What it is
- When you discovered it
- How you want to improve it
- And how you feel about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The natural aptitude I've become most interested in developing over the past year or so is what I'd describe as a facility for pattern recognition in unfamiliar domains — the capacity to look at a new system, whether it's a piece of music, an unfamiliar argument, or a set of data, and relatively quickly identify the structuring logic beneath the surface variation. I became aware of it first in secondary school, specifically in mathematics competitions, where I noticed I could often see the underlying structure of a problem before I had worked out how to solve it — and that awareness had developed, by the time I finished secondary school, into a reasonably conscious tool I could apply across subjects. What I want to do with it now is extend its application from the relatively narrow domains where it developed — mathematics and certain areas of language — into domains where I'm less practised and where the pattern-recognition skill would need to be rebuilt rather than simply applied: specifically music theory and visual composition, which I've started working on through a combination of structured online learning and deliberate practice with unfamiliar repertoire.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The talent I want to develop is less exotic than it might appear to describe: essentially, the ability to read people quickly and accurately in professional contexts — to identify temperament, motivation, and likely behaviour from brief interaction in ways that allow me to calibrate my communication and approach effectively. I noticed I had something in this direction about four years into my career, when a colleague pointed out that my first assessments of new team members were more often correct than those of colleagues with significantly more management experience — which suggested I had some capacity to read context-relevant signals that I hadn't been consciously cultivating. What I want to do with it is build it from an unreliable intuition into a more systematic and teachable skill: which requires, I think, both more conscious reflection on what signals I'm actually using when the intuition proves right, and more deliberate exposure to a wider range of professional types than my current role naturally provides.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
pattern recognition	n phr		the ability to detect regularities and structures in complex information	nhận dạng quy luật
aptitude	n	/ˈæp.tɪ.tjuːd/	a natural ability or tendency to do something well	năng khiếu bẩm sinh
repertoire	n	/ˈrep.ə.twaːr/	the range of material a person is skilled in	vốn thực hành, tổng thể kỹ năng sẵn có
calibrate	v	/ˈkæl.ɪ.breɪt/	to adjust carefully to fit a particular situation	điều chỉnh cẩn thận, hiệu chỉnh
deliberate practice	n phr		intentional, focused practice aimed at improvement beyond comfort zones	luyện tập có chủ đích
structuring logic	n phr		the underlying principle that organises a system	logic cấu trúc nền tảng
systematise	v	/ˈsɪs.tə.mə.taɪz/	to arrange according to an organised method	hệ thống hoá
intuition	n	/ˌɪn.tjuːʃ.ən/	the ability to understand something without conscious reasoning	trực giác
visual composition	n phr		the arrangement of elements in a visual work	bố cục thị giác
temperament	n	/ˈtem.prə.mənt/	a person's natural habitual inclination; character	tính khí, khí chất

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Do you think artists with talents should focus on their talents?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The question of whether talented artists should "focus" on their talents contains a prescriptive assumption that merits examination: the framing assumes that specialisation is straightforwardly beneficial for talented people, which is a significantly more contested claim in the domain of creative work than in domains where performance is more clearly measurable. The evidence from the history of artistic achievement consistently shows that many of the most significant works emerge from cross-domain influences — from artists who brought insights from one domain to bear on another, or who developed their primary talent through engagement with adjacent fields. The practical case for breadth rather than narrow specialisation during the developmental phase of an artistic career is substantial: the cross-pollination of influences, methods, and conceptual frameworks that exposure to multiple domains provides often generates the distinctive perspective that distinguishes serious artistic work from competent but derivative work.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional arts development perspective on specialisation versus breadth identifies stage of development as the critical variable. During the acquisition phase — when fundamental technical skills are being built — there is a strong case for focused practice in the specific domain, because technical mastery requires concentrated, repetitive work that generalised activity displaces. During the development phase — when those technical foundations are established and the artist is working toward distinctive creative expression — the evidence strongly favours breadth: the artists who develop the most distinctive voices are disproportionately those who engaged in the widest range of influences and developed the most expansive conceptual resources. The practical implication is that "focus on your talent" is good advice for children developing foundational skills and potentially bad advice for established artists working toward creative originality.

2. Is it possible for us to know whether children who are 3 or 4 years old will become musicians and painters when they grow up?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Identifying children's long-term creative destinies at age three or four from observation of their behaviour in early childhood is not reliably possible — not because early aptitude signals don't exist, but because the relationship between early aptitude and adult achievement in creative domains is significantly weaker than popular narratives about prodigy suggest, and because the environmental, relational, and motivational factors that determine whether an early aptitude develops into serious adult practice are at that age almost entirely unobserved and unpredetermined. What research on musical and artistic development consistently shows is that early aptitude signals — heightened sensitivity to pitch, unusual spatial reasoning, strong fine motor interest — are more evenly distributed across the population than outcomes, and that the developmental trajectory between aptitude and achievement is determined by factors including teaching quality, parental support, sustained interest, and the specific social contexts of practice that cannot be predicted from a three-year-old's behaviour.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The developmental psychology research on early identification of creative potential consistently

cautions against over-interpretation of childhood signals as predictors of adult creative careers. The famous research on musical development by figures like Sloboda and Davidson shows that early prodigies are not overrepresented among professional musicians in adulthood — because the qualities that produce exceptional early performance (early parental instruction, unusual memory, strong imitative capacity) are not the same qualities that produce exceptional adult creative work (the capacity to generate novel musical ideas under genuine creative constraint). The more accurate framing is that early childhood is a period when interests and sensitivities are revealed rather than destinies determined, and the most valuable adult response to a child's early artistic inclination is sustained, low-pressure cultivation rather than prescriptive career channelling.

3. Why do people like to watch talent shows?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Talent shows' appeal to audiences operates through a set of psychological mechanisms that are more complex than simple entertainment, though entertainment is certainly the primary surface driver. The most powerful mechanism is narrative identification: talent shows structure the development of individual competitors as personal stories with emotional stakes, social challenges, and character arcs — and audiences engage with these narratives in ways that activate the same empathic engagement mechanisms as fictional drama, producing sustained investment in individual outcomes that drives viewership across series. The second mechanism is the vicarious performance experience: watching skilled performers achieves something approximating the pleasure of high-level performance from the audience position — with the accessibility advantage that no equivalent performance capacity is required and the social advantage that the viewing experience is shared and discussable.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional media analysis of talent show appeal identifies democratisation as the format's most distinctive and commercially potent feature: talent shows present exceptional performance emerging from ordinary life circumstances, which validates the cultural belief that extraordinary achievement is available to anyone with sufficient talent and determination rather than requiring extraordinary background or resources. This narrative is emotionally satisfying because it aligns with broadly held aspirational values — and is commercially powerful because it recruits audience identification more effectively than formats featuring exclusively professional performers, for whom the audience gap is too wide to sustain similar emotional investment. The talent show format also satisfies the social evaluation drive — the evolved tendency to assess relative competence and status — by structuring public performance as explicit social competition with audience and judge evaluation, which activates this drive in a controlled and socially legitimate context.

4. Do you think it is more interesting to watch famous people's or ordinary people's shows?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The comparative interest of famous versus ordinary performers in talent-based entertainment formats is genuinely audience-dependent rather than categorically answerable — different audiences seek different things from performance viewing and will find the same content more or less engaging depending on what they are primarily seeking. For audiences primarily

seeking technical excellence — the genuine ceiling of performance quality in a given domain — established professional performers with years of highly focused practice will typically be more interesting to watch than ordinary performers, because the technical standards they can sustain are simply not accessible to people without that accumulated practice. For audiences primarily seeking narrative engagement and emotional investment — the journey story, the redemption arc, the underdog — ordinary performers are typically more engaging precisely because their position is closer to the audience’s own, which facilitates the identification that drives sustained emotional investment.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional entertainment ratings data generally supports the superior commercial performance of formats featuring ordinary people performing — the talent show format outperforms professional performance formats in audience size in most markets — which the professional analysis attributes primarily to the identification mechanism. Audiences watch professional performance from an appreciative but emotionally distanced position; they watch ordinary-person performance from a position of active social comparison and empathic engagement that produces stronger emotional responses and higher viewer loyalty across series. The psychological explanation is that the emotional stakes of ordinary-person performance are more immediately legible: the outcome matters more visibly in the context of a real life, and the performances’ quality is more honestly distributed across the success-failure spectrum in ways that make the narrative stakes feel genuine rather than managed.

5. Do you think it’s important to develop children’s talents?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Developing children’s talents is important, but the manner in which that development is pursued matters as much as the development itself — and the forms of talent development that are most culturally prevalent are often those whose methods are most likely to undermine the conditions that make talent development genuinely beneficial. The research on motivation and creative development consistently shows that talent development pursued in ways that make the activity intrinsically motivating — that preserve the child’s autonomous engagement, connect the activity to genuine personal interest, and maintain the experience of play and exploration rather than replacing it with performance pressure — produces better long-term outcomes in both skill development and wellbeing than talent development pursued under heavy extrinsic pressure. The most harmful pattern is the one cultural narratives about prodigy most romanticise: the highly pressurised, sacrifice-dominated early specialisation that produces technically impressive child performers but disproportionately results in burnout, disengagement, and the loss of the activity’s meaning by early adulthood.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional developmental perspective on children’s talent development identifies the primary risk as mistaking early performance for development. Systems that structure children’s talent development around competitive performance and public demonstration of current ability — competitions, recitals, auditions — systematically advantage children with high early performance capacity while disadvantaging children with higher developmental ceilings whose current performance level is lower. The result is that many of the most professionally productive adult talents — those with the broad conceptual foundations, robust intrinsic motivation, and adaptable skill sets that characterise the most creative adult practitioners — were not identified or developed by conventional early talent development systems, while many of the most visibly “talented” child performers went on to relatively limited adult achievement because the performance-optimised development they received

was not the development that generates the deepest adult creative capacity.

6. Why do some people like to show their talents online?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Online talent display satisfies several distinct psychological needs that performance in purely offline contexts cannot as readily fulfil — which explains why many people who would not seek performance opportunities in traditional physical settings are willing and eager to display their capabilities online. The most significant is audience scalability: online platforms allow performers to reach audiences of a size and composition entirely uncorrelated with their geographical location, physical access to institutional performance venues, or gatekeeping processes that regulate access to traditional performance opportunities. This is particularly significant for people whose skills are in domains that lack strong offline performance infrastructure — certain niche musical genres, unusual craft skills, hyper-specialised knowledge domains — where online platforms represent the only viable performance context for genuinely substantial audiences.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional analysis of online talent display as a social behaviour identifies identity affirmation as the primary psychological driver beyond pure performance motivation. Displaying skill publicly — receiving the social acknowledgement of capability that performance elicits — is a powerful need whose offline fulfilment requires access to performance contexts that are institutionally and socially mediated in ways that create significant barriers for people outside established performance networks. Online platforms have democratised that access in ways that allow the psychological benefits of public performance recognition — validation, community, identity establishment within a domain — to be accessed by performers who would previously have had no viable route to them. The commercial dimension — the potential for talent display to generate income through audience monetisation — adds a further incentive layer that has no offline equivalent for most performers, and that has created genuine economic opportunities for people whose skills were previously without viable professional expression.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
prodigy	n	/ˈprɒd.ɪ.dʒi/	a person with exceptional talent at an early age	thần đồng
democratisation	n	/dɪ.mə.krə.taɪ'zeɪ.ʃən/	making something accessible to all people equally	sự dân chủ hoá
intrinsic motivation	n phr		drive coming from internal enjoyment or interest	động lực nội tại
extrinsic pressure	n phr		pressure coming from external rewards or expectations	áp lực ngoại tại
burnout	n	/ˈbɜːn.aʊt/	physical and mental exhaustion from overwork or sustained pressure	kiệt sức (cả thể xác lẫn tinh thần)
audience scalability	n phr		the ability to reach a larger or different audience through a medium	khả năng mở rộng đối tượng khán giả
gatekeeping	n	/ˈɡeɪt.kiː.pɪŋ/	controlling access to opportunities through selection processes	kiểm soát cửa vào (cơ hội)
identity affirmation	n phr		the validation of one's sense of who they are	khẳng định bản sắc
monetisation	n	/ˌmʌn.ɪ.taɪ'zeɪ.ʃən/	converting something into a source of income	kiếm tiền từ nội dung
vicarious	adj	/vɪˈkeə.ri.əs/	experienced through another person's actions or emotions	gián tiếp, cảm nhận qua người khác

2.53 Describe a toy you liked in your childhood

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a toy you liked in your childhood. You should say:

- What kind of toy it is
- When you received it
- How you played it
- And how you felt about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The toy I remember most precisely from childhood is a set of wooden building blocks — simple rectangular blocks in three or four sizes, uncoloured — that my grandfather made for me when I was around four or five years old. He was a carpenter and made them from offcuts because bought toys were expensive, and they didn't look like the toys in shop windows: they were plain, slightly rough-edged, and had no instructions. I played with them for probably four or five years, and what strikes me looking back is how open-ended the play was — I built towers, bridges, roads, ships, walls, and things that had no name but seemed right while I was making them — in a way that felt genuinely inventive rather than directed toward a predetermined outcome. There was nothing in the toy that told me what to do with it, which I now think was precisely its value: the blocks didn't solve a problem or simulate another object, they offered raw material for whatever I decided the play was going to be, which required more imagination than any subsequently owned toy ever demanded of me.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The toy I remember most from childhood with most genuine warmth is a small mechanical model of a locomotive that I was given as a birthday gift when I was about six — not a working electric train set, just a solid metal model with paint worn off several surfaces which I later understood had been my father's before mine. I didn't play with it in the way I played with other toys: I didn't move it around or simulate journeys, I mostly handled it, examined it, and occasionally took it apart — it had several screwable components — and reassembled it. What I valued about it was something I couldn't have articulated at six but can now: the sense that it was a real object that had existed in the world before and would exist after, and that had a weight and solidity that the plastic toys I received more frequently didn't have. I still have it. It's on a shelf in my study, and I take it down with exactly the same quality of attention I gave it then.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
open-ended	adj		having no fixed or predetermined answer or outcome	không giới hạn, để ngỏ
offcut	n	/ˈɒf.kʌt/	a piece left over after cutting material for a specific use	mảnh vụn còn lại sau khi cắt
predetermined	adj	/ˌpriː.dɪ'tɜːmd/	decided or arranged in advance	được định trước
simulate	v	/ˈsɪm.jʊ.leɪt/	to imitate or represent a condition or object	mô phỏng
solidity	n	/səˈlɪd.ɪ.ti/	the quality of being firm and stable; substance	tính vững chắc, đặc chắc
reassemble	v	/ˌriː.əˈsem.bəl/	to put back together after being taken apart	lắp lại, ráp lại
imaginative play	n phr		play that uses creativity and the imagination to create scenarios	vui chơi sáng tạo, chơi tưởng tượng
attentive	adj	/əˈten.tɪv/	paying close and careful attention	chú ý, tập trung
inventive	adj	/ɪnˈven.tɪv/	having the ability to create or design new things	sáng tạo, có óc phát minh
raw material	n phr		basic material from which something is made or developed	nguyên liệu thô

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. How do advertisements influence children?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Children's susceptibility to advertising influence is substantially greater than adults' for a set of developmental reasons that advertising aimed at children is specifically designed to

exploit: children below approximately eight years old lack the cognitive capacity to recognise advertising's persuasive intent — the understanding that an advertisement's purpose is to change the viewer's preferences rather than to inform — which means they process advertising messages as informational content rather than as interest-motivated persuasion. The practical implication is that children who are exposed to advertising believe, in a relatively literal and unreserved way, that the characteristics attributed to products in advertisements are accurate descriptions of those products, rather than curated representations designed to generate desire. This credulity is commercially potent — children exposed to toy advertising report wanting those toys even when the advertised functionality is demonstrably unreachable — and developmentally consequential, because the norms around consumption and satisfaction that advertising exposure shapes during childhood influence consumer attitudes into adulthood.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional consumer behaviour research on advertising and children identifies pester power — children's ability to influence parental purchasing decisions through sustained requests — as the primary mechanism through which children's advertising translates into commercial outcomes. Advertising doesn't typically provide children with purchasing agency directly; it shapes their desire and preference, and those preferences are then expressed within family decision-making dynamics in ways that consistently and significantly influence adult purchasing. The research also shows that advertising influence on children extends beyond the immediate product category: sustained exposure to advertising shapes children's broader understanding of consumption as a route to social status, happiness, and identity — which are the conceptual frameworks that underlie adult consumer culture and whose seeds are planted in the formative period of childhood advertising exposure.

2. Should advertising aimed at kids be prohibited?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The case for prohibiting advertising aimed at children rests on the well-established developmental evidence that children lack the cognitive capacity to identify advertising's persuasive intent — which creates a meaningful parallel to the prohibition of other forms of persuasion whose targets lack the capacity to defend against them. Several jurisdictions, including Sweden and Norway, have enacted restrictions on children's television advertising precisely on this developmental protection rationale, and the evidence from these markets suggests that the predicted industry harms from prohibition are substantially smaller than was argued before implementation. The position against prohibition typically rests on parental primacy — the argument that parents rather than the state should manage children's advertising exposure — but this position understates the evidence for advertising's influence on family purchasing dynamics in ways that undermine parental autonomy rather than simply competing with it.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional public health and developmental policy perspective predominantly supports restrictions on advertising aimed at children under a developmental protection framework, though full prohibition is a stronger position than most research findings strictly require. The more precisely calibrated policy response — which the evidence better supports — is a combination of age-specific restrictions on advertising in children's contexts, requirements for advertising literacy education in schools, and industry codes that prohibit specific high-risk advertising techniques including celebrity endorsement by figures children identify with and artificial scarcity claims. The full prohibition case is strongest for specific high-harm product

categories — junk food, toy advertising whose demonstrated functionality is unreachable — where the gap between advertised and actual product benefit is largest and where the harm of exposure-driven desire is most direct.

3. What's the difference between the toys kids play now and those they played in the past?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The most significant structural difference between contemporary toys and those of previous generations is the shift from open-ended to closed-ended play affordances: traditional toys — blocks, dolls, balls, basic construction sets — offered raw material for play whose content and structure the child determined, while many contemporary toys — electronic toys with built-in programmes, single-purpose play sets organised around licensed media properties — predetermine the play narrative and reduce the child's creative contribution to execution within an already-defined framework. This shift is educationally consequential: open-ended play is consistently associated in developmental research with stronger development of creativity, problem-solving, and narrative imagination than closed-ended play, which means the toy landscape change has implications not only for the quality of children's entertainment but for the development of cognitive capacities that extend well beyond the play context.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional analysis of toy trends identifies two parallel movements over the past generation: screen-based digital toys have grown rapidly as a category while displacing many traditional toy categories, and physical toys have become increasingly tied to media properties — films, television series, video games — in ways that make the toy a consumption supplement to a media property rather than a self-contained play object. Both movements share the quality of reducing the child's creative autonomy: screen toys direct play through programmed interaction, and media-property toys direct play through pre-existing narratives that the child enacts rather than generates. The economic driver of both movements is the commercial interest in children's play forming part of an extended media consumption ecosystem — where the toy purchase reinforces and extends media consumption — rather than being a self-contained activity.

4. Do you think parents should buy more toys for their kids or spend more time with them?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The framing of this question as an opposition — toys versus time — captures a real tension in contemporary family life that deserves careful analysis rather than a simple answer in either direction. The developmental evidence is strongly consistent that relational time — sustained, attentive, engaged parental presence — is the most significant determinant of the dimensions of development that matter most long-term: attachment security, language development, emotional regulation, and the development of the social capacities that underlie adult wellbeing. Toys contribute to development through the quality of the play they support, but their contribution is substantially less significant than parental relationship quality, and no quantity of high-quality toys substitutes for the developmental value of genuine relational presence. The honest professional answer to the "more toys or more time" question is that the substitution of toys for relational time — which is what the question's framing more

often describes — always represents a poor developmental trade.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional developmental research on children's wellbeing is unusually consistent about the relative value of material provision versus relational presence: above a basic threshold of material adequacy, additional material provision adds minimal measurable developmental benefit, while additional parental relational quality adds substantial and sustained benefit across all dimensions of development that are meaningfully predictable in the long run. This finding is uncomfortable for consumer culture's framing of parental love as something expressed and calibrated through gift-giving — a framing that toy industry marketing is specifically designed to reinforce — but it is the finding that the evidence supports. The practical advice that developmental science generates is simple and consistently supported: the quality and attentiveness of parental engagement with children during play matters more than the quality of the toys being played with, and engaged play with simple materials consistently produces better developmental outcomes than unsupervised play with more sophisticated ones.

5. What's the difference between the toys boys play with and girls play with?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Gender differences in toy preferences are real but significantly smaller and more environmentally determined than the toy market's categorical gender segregation implies — a distinction with important implications both for how the evidence is interpreted and for what the appropriate industry and parenting response is. Research on toy preferences consistently shows that observed gender differences in toy choice are substantially reduced in environments where gender-congruent toy preferences are not specifically reinforced by parental guidance, marketing presentation, or social modelling — which suggests that a significant portion of the observed difference is the product of differential environmental shaping rather than purely innate preference. The strongest innate preference signals are for physical activity types — there is a reasonably robust sex difference in preference for rough-and-tumble play versus sedentary and social play that appears across cultures and that is likely to have some biological basis — but the translation of this preference into categorical toy type differences (construction versus nurturing toys, action versus relational toys) is substantially a cultural and commercial artefact.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional developmental psychology perspective on gender and toy preferences identifies toy marketing as a significant amplifier of relatively small innate differences into large behavioural divergences. The commercial incentive for the toy industry to clearly gender-differentiate its products is substantial — it doubles the market, because gender-specific toys discourage hand-downs and require separate purchases for boys and girls — and the resulting pink/blue division of toy retail environments shapes children's toy preferences through social signalling in ways that are then frequently mistaken for innate preference. The policy and parenting implication most strongly supported by the evidence is to deliberately broaden children's toy exposure across the gendered divide, not because innate differences don't exist but because the toy market's amplification of those differences deprives children of the developmental benefits that the other category of toys provides.

6. What are the advantages and disadvantages of modern toys?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

Modern toys' advantages are principally those of richness and safety: the range of available experiences — construction, narrative, simulation, physical activity, digital interaction — that the contemporary toy landscape provides is vastly wider than what was available to previous generations, and the safety engineering applied to contemporary toy design has substantially reduced the injury risks that characterised many traditional toys. The disadvantages are primarily structural: the shift toward closed-ended, commercially branded, and screen-based toys has reduced the developmental value of the play they support relative to simpler open-ended alternatives, and the sheer volume of available toys has contributed to the toy attention economy problem — children who have access to large numbers of toys engage more shallowly with each one than children with smaller selections, because the availability of the next option undermines the sustained engagement required for deep play.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional assessment of modern toys' developmental value identifies the quality of play affordances as the critical variable rather than the sophistication of the toy's design or technology. A well-designed modern construction set — one that offers genuine design constraint, multiple solution paths, and meaningful feedback — may offer superior developmental value to a simple pile of wooden blocks; a poorly designed electronic toy that directs play through preset programmes may offer inferior developmental value to either. The most significant disadvantage of modern toys as a category — rather than of specific toys — is the marketing and retail environment in which they are typically encountered, which is oriented toward desire generation and purchase frequency rather than developmental value, and which consistently leads to purchasing decisions that prioritise the toy's attractiveness at point of sale over its sustained play value after the initial novelty diminishes.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
open-ended	adj		allowing a wide range of responses or outcomes; not restricted	không giới hạn, để ngỏ
pester power	n phr		a child's ability to persuade parents to buy things through persistent requests	sức ép mè nheo (của trẻ)
play affordance	n phr		the type and range of play a toy enables or supports	khả năng trò chơi mà đồ chơi mang lại
gender-congruent	adj		matching expectations associated with one's gender	phù hợp với kỳ vọng giới tính
rough-and-tumble play	n phr		active, physical, often mock-aggressive play typical of children	trò chơi vật lộn, chạy nhảy sôi nổi
amplifier	n	<i>/'æm.plɪ.fəɪər/</i>	something that increases or intensifies an effect	bộ khuếch đại, yếu tố nhân lên
credulity	n	<i>/krɪ'djuː.lɪ.ti/</i>	a tendency to believe things too readily	tính cả tin
toy attention economy	n phr		the problem of children distributing attention thinly across many toys	kinh tế học chú ý trong trò chơi trẻ em
licensed media property	n phr		a brand or character owned by a media company used for products	tài sản thương hiệu truyền thông được cấp phép
parental primacy	n phr		the principle that parents have the primary right to make decisions for their children	quyền ưu tiên của phụ huynh

2.54 Describe the time when you first talked in a foreign language

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe the time when you first talked in a foreign language. You should say:

- Where you were
- Who you were with
- What you talked about
- And explain how you felt about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The first time I had a genuine conversation in English — as opposed to performing set phrases in a classroom — was at a hostel in Đà Nẵng when I was seventeen, during a family trip, with a young man from Australia who was travelling alone and who sat down at the same table at breakfast and asked where we were going that day. The conversation was, objectively, simple: he asked where I was from, what grade I was in, whether I liked school, what music I listened to — straightforward questions that my classroom English was technically adequate for — but what was remarkable about it was the shift in experience from using English as an academic exercise to using it as a tool for genuine exchange with a person who genuinely didn't know the answers to what he was asking. I couldn't hear my own accent clearly enough to be embarrassed by it, which helped. What I remember most precisely is the moment when he said something I didn't fully catch and I asked him to repeat it and he did, entirely without impatience, and I understood the second time — which was the moment I stopped being afraid that not understanding would end the conversation.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The first substantive conversation I had in English in a professional context rather than a tourist or academic one was at a conference in Singapore about eight years ago — I'd been at the conference for two days, attending sessions, but hadn't initiated any conversation beyond brief social pleasantries. On the third day, during a coffee break, a Singaporean researcher who worked in a field adjacent to mine asked me what I thought of a session we'd both just attended, and the question was specific enough — about a methodological issue in a paper that I'd noticed and found interesting — that I had something I actually wanted to say. The conversation lasted about twenty minutes and by the end of it I'd agreed to share a paper draft and had his email. What I noticed about the experience was the way that having something I genuinely wanted to say made the language difficulty feel substantially less prohibitive — which was the observation that changed how I prepared for professional English-language communication subsequently.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
set phrases	n phr		fixed, pre-learned expressions used in specific situations	cụm từ cố định, mẫu câu bài bản
genuine exchange	n phr		honest, authentic communication between people	trao đổi thực sự chân thật
substantive	adj	/ˈsʌb.stən.tɪv/	having real substance and importance	có chiều sâu, thực chất
pleasantries	n pl	/ˈplez.ən.trɪz/	brief, polite, social remarks	những lời xã giao nhẹ nhàng
methodological	adj	/ˌmeθ.ə.dəˈlɒdʒ.ɪ.kəl/	relating to the methods used in a particular field	thuộc về phương pháp học
prohibitive	adj	/prəˈhɪb.ɪ.tɪv/	preventing or making something difficult	cản trở, ngăn cản
adjacent	adj	/əˈdʒeɪ.sənt/	near or next to something; closely related	liền kề, gần gũi
impatience	n	/ɪmˈpeɪ.ʃəns/	the tendency to get irritated when things are slow	sự thiếu kiên nhẫn
academic exercise	n phr		a task performed for educational purposes without real-world application	bài tập học thuật không thực tế
hostel	n	/ˈhɒs.təl/	a type of inexpensive shared accommodation for travellers	nhà nghỉ tập thể dành cho khách du lịch

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. At what age should children start learning a foreign language?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The evidence on optimal foreign language learning onset identifies early childhood — between birth and approximately ten years old — as the period during which acquisition of native-like phonological competence, the capacity to perceive and produce the sound system of a foreign language without a strong accent, is most accessible. This phonological window — often called the critical period for language acquisition — closes progressively through adolescence, which means that learners who begin a foreign language during primary school age have a structural advantage in accent acquisition that subsequent learners cannot fully compensate for, however excellent their instruction or commitment. The practical implication is that the question of when to begin is primarily a question about the desired outcome: early start produces superior phonological outcomes; the motivational and metalinguistic benefits of learning that older learners bring can partially compensate for the phonological disadvantage of late onset, without fully eliminating it.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional applied linguistics perspective on optimal onset age is more nuanced than the “earlier is better” popular belief: while early start does produce the phonological advantages described, it also produces certain motivational and metalinguistic disadvantages compared to later starts. Young children are unable to use explicit grammar instruction efficiently — they acquire language only through input-based immersion — which means early foreign language instruction that relies on formal grammar learning is both developmentally inappropriate and empirically less effective than it would be for adolescent learners. The most evidence-supported recommendation is early onset prioritising high-quality communicative immersion — beginning when the school curriculum can provide sufficient instruction hours to achieve genuine communicative progress — rather than early onset with inadequate instruction time, which produces poor outcomes and may damage motivation in ways that harm later learning.

2. Which skill is more important, speaking or writing?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

The comparative importance of speaking and writing in a foreign language is learner-purpose dependent rather than abstractly decidable — and the question is therefore most usefully answered by examining what the learner needs the language for rather than weighing the skills in the abstract. For the majority of foreign language users in contemporary global contexts — people using English as a lingua franca in international professional, educational, and travel contexts — speaking is more frequently the skill engaged and its absence is more immediately conspicuous and consequential. The case for writing as the more important skill is strongest for academic and research contexts, where written production is the primary vehicle for professional contribution and where the quality of written communication is the primary mechanism of professional credibility.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional applied linguistics perspective identifies the speaking/writing hierarchy as a false dichotomy in the context of serious language proficiency development, because the two skills are neither independent nor competing for the same developmental resources — they reinforce each other in ways that make the dichotomy educationally unhelpful. The more productive framing for educational planning is to ask which skill needs to be prioritised given available instruction time and learner goals, recognising that optimal development of both speaking and writing requires specific instructional attention that neither automatically produces the other. The practical professional argument is that speaking fluency is more

immediately perceived and socially consequential in most professional contexts — a person's spoken English is the first and most socially salient indicator of their language proficiency in international interactions — which makes speaking the higher priority for most professional development purposes, without implying that writing is unimportant.

3. Does a person still need to learn other languages, if he or she is good at English?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

English proficiency provides significant access to a global communication infrastructure — it is the primary language of international academic publication, global business communication, and the content infrastructure of the internet — that would justify treating it as the highest-priority language investment for most people in most circumstances. The case for learning additional languages despite good English proficiency rests on three dimensions: the epistemic dimension (access to knowledge, literature, and cultural production in languages that is not fully available in English translation); the relational dimension (the kind of social access to people and communities in their own language that English interaction cannot provide); and the cognitive dimension (the evidence that bilingualism and multilingualism produce cognitive benefits that extend beyond language across working memory, executive function, and metalinguistic awareness). None of these arguments is decisive for every person in every context, but together they make a substantive case that language learning has value that English proficiency alone does not exhaust.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional argument for additional language learning beyond English is strongest in professional contexts where meaningful engagement with specific non-English-speaking communities or regions is part of the professional remit. The quality of professional relationships and cultural understanding accessible through a person's own language is substantially different from what is accessible via English intermediary — which is not merely a romantic or identity argument but a practical one with direct professional implications in fields including diplomacy, journalism, certain areas of business, and any professional field where deep cultural understanding is professionally valuable. The cognitive diversity argument — that engaging with the conceptual and grammatical structures of languages structurally distinct from English generates genuine new ways of thinking about problems — is less empirically established but has sufficient *prima facie* support to be taken seriously by professionals working in domains where flexible thinking is a competitive advantage.

4. Do you think minority languages will disappear?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The trajectory of minority language loss globally is well-documented and alarming: linguists estimate that approximately half of the world's current languages will be extinct by the end of this century, a rate of loss that has no historical precedent and that is driven primarily by the combination of urbanisation, globalisation, and the dominance of a small number of national and international prestige languages. The mechanism is primarily intergenerational: minority languages disappear when they stop being transmitted to children as primary languages, which typically happens when parents calculate — often correctly, in the context of economic opportunity — that their children's life prospects are better served by acquisition of the

majority language than by maintenance of the minority one. The revitalisation examples — Welsh, Māori, Hawaiian — demonstrate that language death is not inevitable when communities make deliberate revitalisation choices with adequate institutional support, but the preconditions for successful revitalisation are demanding and relatively rarely achieved.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional linguistics perspective on minority language futures identifies the policy intervention point as intergenerational transmission: the single most predictive variable for whether a minority language survives is whether parents speak it to children at home as the primary language of family interaction, and the most effective policy instruments for language revitalisation are therefore those that support and incentivise home language transmission — immersion schooling, community-based language programmes, economic support for minority language media and cultural production — rather than classroom language instruction alone, which has a poor track record of reversing transmission decline without complementary community-level interventions. The linguistic diversity loss that majority language dominance produces is a genuine cultural and intellectual cost that is systematically undervalued in economic development frameworks: each language encodes a unique cognitive, conceptual, and ecological knowledge system that is irretrievable once the last fluent speaker dies.

5. Does learning a foreign language help in finding a job?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Foreign language proficiency provides measurable professional advantages whose magnitude depends on the specific language, the specific job market, and the specific industry — which means that the general answer is yes, but the value varies very substantially with context. The clearest professional language advantage is for proficiency in the primary international business language — English — in non-English-speaking countries and industries with significant international exposure: the premium for English proficiency in the Vietnamese labour market, for example, is substantial and well-documented across multiple sectors. The advantage of additional languages beyond English is more industry-specific: Japanese, Korean, and Chinese proficiency carries significant premiums in manufacturing, trade, and investment contexts where those economies' companies are major actors; French and German proficiency carries value in specific European professional contexts; and Arabic proficiency is valuable in a specific set of diplomatic, commercial, and regional studies contexts.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional labour economics research on language premium consistently finds that foreign language proficiency adds measurable earnings and employment advantages, but that the effect is non-linear and contextually dependent in ways the popular framing of "languages help careers" understates. The primary mechanism is access expansion: proficiency in a language associated with a specific economic or professional network expands the set of positions, employers, and professional communities accessible to the candidate in ways that translate into both immediate hiring advantage and longer-term career trajectory differences. The secondary mechanism is professional communication quality: at equivalent positions, the ability to communicate effectively in the languages of key counterparts — clients, partners, colleagues, management — affects the quality of professional relationships and the effectiveness of professional output in ways that translate into performance assessment and promotion decisions, particularly at senior professional levels.

6. Which stage of life do you think is the best for learning a foreign language?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Each major life stage offers distinct advantages for foreign language learning that correspond to different aspects of the acquisition process — which means the “best stage” depends on what outcome is being optimised. Early childhood offers the phonological acquisition advantage: the neural plasticity of the first decade of life makes native-like accent acquisition possible in ways that become progressively more difficult after approximately ten to twelve years. Adolescence and early adulthood offer the motivational and metalinguistic advantages of maturer learners: the capacity to use explicit grammar instruction effectively, stronger analytical approaches to language structure, and the ability to engage with authentic cultural and professional content that provides the richest input. Adulthood offers the experiential advantage: adult learners have a richer conceptual and experiential store to draw on when interpreting and contextualising foreign language input, and those whose professional lives provide authentic communicative need for the language typically acquire it faster than learners in purely instructional contexts.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional applied linguistics consensus is that the most productive learning happens when neurological access (relatively young age, maintaining some of the critical period advantages) coincides with motivational intensity (genuine communicative need, strong intrinsic interest, or high-stakes professional requirement) and instructional access (high-quality input, opportunities for genuine communicative practice, effective feedback). These three conditions coincide most frequently in early adolescence with well-designed immersive schooling, and in professionalising young adults who combine high intrinsic motivation with authentic communicative need. The worst conditions for language acquisition — common enough to be worth identifying — are adult learners in low-frequency classroom instruction without authentic communicative need: the motivational, contextual, and input-quality conditions that acquisition requires are all absent, and the learning that results is both slow and poorly retained.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
critical period	n phr		a window of time in development during which language is most easily acquired	giai đoạn nhạy cảm (ngôn ngữ)
phonological	adj	/ˈfɒn.əˈlɒdʒ.ɪ.kəl/	relating to the sound system of a language	thuộc âm vị học
neural plasticity	n phr		the brain's ability to reorganise itself by forming new connections	tính dẻo của thần kinh
metalinguistic	adj	/ˌmet.ə.lɪŋˈɡwɪs.tɪk/	relating to thinking about and analysing language itself	siêu ngôn ngữ học
lingua franca	n phr		a language used for communication between people who don't share a native tongue	ngôn ngữ chung (trung gian)
intergenerational transmission	n phr		passing language or culture from parents to children	truyền thụ giữa các thế hệ
revitalisation	n	/ˌriː.vaɪˈtæl.aɪˈzeɪ.ʃən/	restoring or renewing a language or culture to active use	hồi sinh, phục hưng (ngôn ngữ)
minority language	n phr		a language spoken by a smaller group within a country or region	ngôn ngữ thiểu số
language premium	n phr		the additional earnings or career advantage from knowing a language	lợi thế/phần thưởng ngôn ngữ
immersive schooling	n phr		an educational approach where learning takes place mainly in the target language	giáo dục ngôn ngữ theo phương thức đắm chìm

2.55 Describe an occasion when you lost your way

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe an occasion when you lost your way. You should say:

- Where you were
- What happened
- How you felt
- And explain how you found your way.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

About two years ago I got thoroughly lost in the old quarter of Hôi An in the early evening — not dramatically lost, in the sense that I wasn't in any danger, but genuinely disoriented in a way that took me about forty-five minutes to resolve. I'd been walking without much attention to navigation, following what looked interesting rather than tracking where I was going, and the narrow, winding streets of the old quarter — which are visually similar enough that distinguishing one from another without a landmark reference is difficult — meant that when I eventually did try to retrace my route I couldn't reliably confirm which direction I'd come from. My phone battery had run down to about eight percent, which meant using Google Maps was available but felt like a gamble. What I ended up doing was finding a café, ordering something cold, sitting down properly, and then asking the very patient woman at the counter which direction the central market was — which I knew was near the river, and from the river I knew I could navigate back. The resolution was completely undramatic, but what I remember about the experience was the specific quality of mild panic that disorientation produces — a sensation that is disproportionate to the actual danger involved and that surprised me in its intensity given how objectively benign the situation was.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The most professionally inconvenient occasion on which I lost my way was during a visit to a Japanese city I'd never been to before — Osaka — when I emerged from the wrong exit of a subway station and was sufficiently disoriented that I walked in the wrong direction for about fifteen minutes before the landmarks I was expecting failed to appear. The specific problem with getting lost in an unfamiliar city abroad is that the usual recovery strategy — asking someone — requires a minimum of shared linguistic capacity that was substantially absent, and the visual orientation cues that would have been useful in a city I knew better were entirely absent. I'd been overconfident because I'd looked at the route on the map before the meeting and had judged it simple — two stations and a short walk — and the overconfidence had produced the specific inattentiveness that allowed the wrong exit to translate into a fifteen-minute delay. I arrived at the meeting approximately twelve minutes after the scheduled time, which was resolved by an apology that I believe was understood, and I now have a very specific ritual of photographing my intended route before entering any unfamiliar subway system.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
disoriented	adj	/dɪs'ɔːr.i.ɛn.tɪd/	confused about one's position or direction	mất phương hướng
retrace	v	/ˌrɪː'treɪs/	to go back along the same path you came from	đi ngược lại con đường cũ
benign	adj	/br'naɪn/	not harmful; gentle	vô hại, lành tính
overconfident	adj	/ˌəʊ.və'kɒn.fɪ.dənt/	excessively certain in one's own abilities	quá tự tin
orientation cue	n phr		a visual or sensory signal used to determine one's position	dấu hiệu định hướng
inattentiveness	n	/ˌɪn.ə'ten.tɪv.nəs/	failure to pay proper attention	sự thiếu chú ý
disproportionate	adj	/ˌdɪs.prə'pɔːʃən.ət/	too large or too small compared to something else	không tương xứng
winding	adj	/'waɪn.dɪŋ/	having many curves and turns	quanh co, ngoằn ngoèo
landmark	n	/'lænd.mɑːk/	a recognisable feature that serves as a guide	địa danh, điểm mốc
navigation	n	/ˌnæv.rɪ'geɪ.ʃən/	the process of planning and following a route	sự định hướng, điều hướng

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Why do some people get lost more easily than others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Individual differences in spatial navigation ability — the capacity to build and update an accurate mental model of one's position in physical space — are substantial and consistently demonstrated across research settings, which means that the question of why some people get lost more easily is at least partly a question about genuine cognitive variation rather than simply attention or experience differences. The cognitive component most predictive of

spatial navigation performance is the ability to construct, maintain, and update a spatial map — to keep track of how one’s position and orientation have changed as one moves through an environment — and individual variation in this capacity is both large and relatively stable across life stages once established. The practical overlay is the well-documented gender difference in navigation strategy: on average, people who navigate using landmark-based strategies — sequential reference to specific recognisable features — are more vulnerable to disorientation in visually uniform environments than people who navigate using metric strategies — maintaining a sense of Euclidean position relative to a known starting point.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional cognitive science explanation of navigation performance variation identifies hippocampal function — the brain region primarily responsible for spatial memory and cognitive map formation — as the major neurological variable, alongside experience and strategy. The experience dimension is significant in ways that are practically relevant: people who grow up in grid-layout cities — where spatial navigation is largely reducible to direction counting — tend to perform poorly in organic, irregular urban environments because they’ve never needed to develop the egocentric updating strategy that such environments require. The strategy dimension is the most practically teachable: navigation performance is substantially improved by explicit training in maintaining orientation rather than relying purely on landmark recognition — and the professional implication for frequently travelling people is that developing a consistent pre-navigation practice (map study, route photography, identifying a reliable anchor point) compensates substantially for underlying spatial reasoning variation.

2. Do you think it is important to be able to read a map?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The practical importance of paper map reading has declined substantially with the near-universal adoption of GPS navigation for everyday wayfinding — the scenario in which paper map reading is the available or optimal navigation tool is now relatively rare in most urban and developed-world contexts. The argument for maintaining paper map reading as a genuinely important skill is therefore primarily a resilience argument: GPS navigation fails or is unavailable in situations including battery depletion, signal absence in remote environments, network outages, and deliberate electronic interference — and the person who cannot navigate without digital assistance is genuinely helpless in these circumstances in a way that would have seemed exotic to any previous generation. The secondary argument is a spatial cognition argument: the research suggests that habitual GPS reliance reduces the development and maintenance of the internal spatial mapping capacity that underlies good navigation generally, which means that exclusive GPS use may produce a genuine reduction in navigational competence beyond the immediate convenience it provides.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional view on map reading skills identifies them as part of a broader category of spatial literacy that remains professionally relevant across a wider range of fields than the GPS-navigation framing suggests. Urban planning, architecture, logistics, field research, emergency management, and military planning all require the capacity to read and reason from maps in ways that are not fully supported by GPS navigation interfaces, because map reading involves extracting spatial relationships, scale reasoning, and landscape analysis that GPS turn-by-turn navigation does not require or develop. The broader spatial literacy point is also relevant: geographers and cognitive scientists have documented a consistent correlation between map reading competence and the quality of spatial reasoning more generally, which suggests that the deprecation of map reading as an everyday skill may have wider cognitive

consequences than the immediate navigational context implies.

3. Do you think it is important to do some preparation before you travel to new places?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Travel preparation is important, but the appropriate depth and type of preparation varies substantially with the nature of the trip, the destination characteristics, and the traveller's experience — and the polarisation between "heavy preparer" and "spontaneous traveller" identities in travel discourse somewhat obscures the more important distinction between preparation that serves the travel and preparation that substitutes for it. The most clearly valuable preparation is logistical: understanding transport connections, entry requirements, accommodation options, and the spatial layout of a destination produces genuine quality improvements across travel because it reduces the cognitive overhead of managing logistics in real time, leaving more available attention for the actual experience of the place. The over-preparation failure mode — where the itinerary is so tightly specified that unexpected opportunity, spontaneous deviation, and genuine discovery become difficult — is a real risk for certain traveller types, particularly those whose anxiety about the unfamiliar manifests as defensive over-planning.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional travel risk management perspective on pre-travel preparation identifies the preparation-spontaneity tradeoff differently depending on destination risk profile. For established, well-documented destinations with reliable infrastructure and services, the marginal safety value of thorough preparation beyond basic logistics is relatively small — the main downside of under-preparation is inefficiency and missed opportunity rather than genuine risk. For destinations with significant logistical challenges, safety concerns, or limited visitor infrastructure, preparation is qualitatively more important: the difference between an itinerary supported by advance bookings, emergency contacts, and medical preparation and one without is substantially a difference in realistic risk exposure that can have serious consequences. The professional implication is that preparation depth should track destination risk and complexity rather than traveller preference — and that the traveller identity investment in spontaneity should not override the practical safety calculus in high-complexity destinations.

4. How can people find their way when they are lost?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Navigating back from disorientation requires a specific set of cognitive moves — stopping, recalibrating, and finding a reliable reference point — that are frequently prevented by the affective response that disorientation produces, specifically the anxiety that drives continued movement in random directions rather than the deliberate halt and assessment that effective recovery requires. The first practical recovery step is therefore not physical but psychological: stopping movement long enough to allow a relatively calm assessment of what is known versus unknown about one's position. The physical recovery strategies that consistently work are reference-point identification (finding a feature visible from anywhere in an area — a mountain, a prominent building, a body of water — and using it to reorient) and strategic human inquiry (finding a reliable local informant rather than asking the first available person in ways that confirm rather than inform one's suspected position).

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional emergency navigation response identifies the STOP acronym — Stop, Think, Observe, Plan — developed in wilderness survival contexts but applicable across navigational disorientation scenarios — as the most reliably effective framework for navigation recovery. The Stop step is consistently identified as the most practically critical because the instinct to continue moving when lost — driven by anxiety and the feeling that movement is doing something about the problem — is frequently counterproductive and sometimes dangerously so. The Think and Observe steps involve systematic assessment of available position information: the angle of the sun, the flow direction of any water, distinctive sounds, visible topographic features, and any information from technology that remains available. The Plan step requires identifying the single most reliable recovery action given the observed information — which might be following water downhill, walking toward sound, or simply staying in place and making oneself visible — rather than committing to a direction without evidence.

5. Is a paper map still necessary?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

The necessity of paper maps has declined significantly as a matter of practical everyday utility — the overlap between the situations in which paper maps are useful and the situations most people actually encounter in their ordinary lives is now genuinely small in most urban and developed-country contexts. The argument for paper map maintenance rests substantially on resilience and edge-case reasoning: the person who relies entirely on digital navigation and then encounters a dead battery, signal gap, or device failure in an unfamiliar environment is in a qualitatively worse position than one who can supplement digital navigation with paper-based orientation. Beyond the resilience argument, there are specific user populations — elderly people, children, wilderness travellers, and people in regions with limited digital infrastructure — for whom paper maps remain the primary navigational tool and whose wayfinding needs are not well-served by the assumption of universal digital navigation capability.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional cartography and geographic information systems perspective on paper maps' continued relevance identifies the planning use case as the domain where paper maps retain clear advantages over digital alternatives. The ability to view a large geographic area in high resolution at a single glance — to see spatial relationships, scale, and topology simultaneously across an area that would require many smartphone screens to represent — is a genuine analytical advantage in planning, logistics, and strategic navigation contexts that digital zoom-and-pan interfaces only partially compensate for. Emergency management, military planning, field research, and infrastructure management all continue to rely on paper maps precisely because the planning-scale overview they provide is not well-replicated by the interface design of consumer GPS applications, which are optimised for real-time turn-by-turn guidance rather than spatial analysis and planning.

6. How do people react when they get lost?**Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)**

The range of reactions to disorientation is substantial and reflects both temperamental

variation and situational factors — including perceived risk level, time pressure, social context, and prior experience with being lost — that interact with individual disposition to produce the specific response. The most common immediate response is anxiety activation: the recognition of disorientation triggers a mild threat response that manifests as elevated heart rate, reduced cognitive flexibility, and a characteristic sense of urgency that often produces the counterproductive continued movement described earlier. The response diverges most clearly between people according to how they regulate the initial anxiety: those who can relatively quickly downregulate from the initial threat activation and engage the calmer assessment mode tend to recover from disorientation faster and more effectively, while those who remain in high-anxiety activation tend to make less effective navigational decisions and sometimes escalate mild disorientation into genuine navigation challenges.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional behavioural emergency research on disorientation responses identifies the "Lost Person Behaviour" framework — developed from wilderness search-and-rescue data — as the most systematically supported description of how different populations respond to being lost. The fundamental finding is that people consistently underestimate how lost they are and overestimate how effectively they are navigating toward resolution — a combination of overconfidence in position knowledge and commitment to the initially chosen recovery direction that produces systematic delay in seeking help. The professional implication for anyone who regularly operates in unfamiliar environments — field researchers, travelling professionals, adventure travellers — is to establish an explicit decision rule for when to stop independent recovery attempts and seek external assistance, specifying the rule in advance rather than making it in the moment when overconfidence and reluctance to acknowledge lostness are both operating at their most powerful.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
STOP acronym	n phr		Stop, Think, Observe, Plan — a survival framework for navigation recovery	phương pháp STOP trong định hướng khẩn cấp
recalibrate	v	/ˌriːˈkæl.ɪ.breɪt/	to reassess and adjust one's position or approach	hiệu chỉnh lại, xác định lại hướng
overestimate	v	/ˌəʊ.vər'es.tɪ.meɪt/	to believe something is better or more than it actually is	đánh giá cao hơn thực tế
egocentric	adj	/iː.gəʊ'sen.trɪk/	relating to one's own position as the reference point	lấy bản thân làm trung tâm (định hướng)
spatial literacy	n phr		the ability to understand and work with maps and spatial information	hiểu biết về không gian
hippocampal	adj	/ˌhɪp.ə'kæm.pəl/	relating to the hippocampus, the brain's spatial memory centre	thuộc hải mã, trung tâm trí nhớ không gian
resilience argument	n phr		a case for a skill based on its value in failure conditions	lập luận về khả năng phục hồi
threat response	n phr		the physiological reaction to a perceived danger	phản ứng với mối đe dọa
downregulate	v		to reduce the intensity of a physiological or emotional response	hạ thấp (phản ứng sinh lý/cảm xúc)
Lost Person Behaviour	n phr		a framework describing how people behave when they are lost	hành vi của người bị lạc đường

2.56 Describe a time when someone apologized to you

IELTS Part 2 — Cue Card

Describe a time when someone apologized to you. You should say:

- When it was
- Who this person is
- Why he or she apologized to you
- And how you felt about it.

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

About a year and a half ago a classmate of mine apologised to me for something that had happened six months before that — and the gap between the incident and the apology was what made the experience most interesting to reflect on. The original incident was relatively minor: she had shared something I'd told her in confidence with two other people in our study group, not maliciously, just carelessly, and when I found out about it I'd felt the specific kind of betrayal that is less about the information itself than about the evidence it provides about how one is regarded. I didn't address it at the time — partly because the incident felt too minor to make a formal complaint about and partly because I wasn't sure how to express it without seeming disproportionately upset. When she apologised, it was in person, specifically worded, and unprompted: she named what she'd done, said why it was wrong from her perspective, and didn't ask for a specific response. The apology wasn't an emotional transaction whose purpose was her being forgiven — it was simply an accurate account of what had happened and an acknowledgement of her responsibility for it — and the quality of it was, I think, what made it more effective than most apologies I've received.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The apology that has stayed with me most from my professional life came from a manager I worked under about six years ago who called me into his office to apologise for how he'd handled a performance review meeting about three weeks earlier — a meeting in which he had delivered critical feedback in a way that was accurate in content but poorly calibrated in tone and context, leaving me to process the feedback's professional implications and the manner of delivery's emotional impact simultaneously in a way that made neither processing properly possible. The apology itself was factual and specific: he said that he had prepared the content carefully but had not adequately considered how the delivery would land given the full context of my situation at the time, and that he should have done so. He didn't over-explain, didn't seek my reassurance that no lasting harm had been done, and didn't try to soften the original feedback retrospectively. What I found most useful about the experience was not the apology itself but the model of professional accountability it provided — the demonstration that acknowledging a mistake in delivery is not the same as denying the truth of the content, and that the two can and should be addressed separately.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
in confidence	adv phr		told as a secret; not to be shared	dưới dạng bí mật, được tin tưởng
unprompted	adj	/ʌn'prɒmp.tɪd/	done without being asked or reminded	tự nguyện, không cần nhắc nhở
calibrated	adj	/'kæl.ɪ.breɪt.ɪd/	carefully adjusted to be appropriate to the situation	được điều chỉnh phù hợp
retrospectively	adv	/,ret.rə'spek.tɪv.li/	looking back at or applying to past events	về sau nhìn lại, hồi tố
accountability	n	/əˌkaʊn.tə'bɪl.ɪ.ti/	the fact of being responsible for one's actions	trách nhiệm giải trình
disproportionately	adv	/ˌdɪs.prə'pɔː.ʃən.ɪt.li/	to an extent that is too large or too small	một cách không tương xứng
maliciously	adv	/mə'ɪʃ.ə.sli/	with the intention of causing harm	với ý định gây hại, một cách ác ý
emotional transaction	n phr		an interaction driven primarily by emotional need	giao dịch cảm xúc
acknowledgement	n	/ək'nɒl.ɪdʒ.mənt/	recognition or admission of a fact or situation	sự thừa nhận
performance review	n phr		a formal assessment of someone's work performance	đánh giá hiệu suất làm việc

Part 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Why do some people refuse to say "sorry" to others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Resistance to apologising reflects a complex of psychological factors that combine to make the simple act of acknowledging a mistake feel substantially more threatening than the

behaviour's face value suggests. The most fundamental mechanism is ego-threat: apology requires explicit acknowledgement that one has done something wrong, which conflicts with the self-concept of people who strongly associate their identity with being competent, fair, or morally good — and the cognitive effort required to protect a positive self-concept in the face of this evidence is often greater than the social cost of refusing to apologise. The power dimension is equally relevant: in hierarchical relationships, apologies traditionally flow from lower-status to higher-status individuals, and the expectation of upward apology — from a superior to a subordinate — violates a status norm that many people in positions of relative power are unwilling to challenge, because doing so is experienced as a status concession beyond the scope of the specific incident.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional organisational psychology analysis of apology avoidance identifies fear of liability as a significant institutional driver in professional and legal contexts — the concern that an explicit acknowledgement of wrongdoing will expose the apologisee to formal consequences including litigation, regulatory action, or formal disciplinary process. This concern is most acute in medical, legal, and corporate professional contexts, where explicit apologies have historically been used as admissions of liability in subsequent legal proceedings — and it has produced institutional cultures in which legal advice systematically overrides the relational and ethical case for acknowledgement. Several jurisdictions have responded by enacting "apology legislation" that explicitly excludes apologies from use as evidence in civil proceedings — precisely because the chilling effect of liability concern on the willingness to apologise imposes substantial relational and social costs across professional contexts.

2. Do you think people should apologize for anything wrong they do?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The universal apology norm — the position that any mistake or wrongdoing obligates an apology — is more nuanced in practice than its framing suggests, because the social and relational function of apology is better served by specific, well-considered acknowledgement than by reflexive apology for every minor infraction. The serial apologisee — the person who apologises constantly, for minor things, often preemptively — is a recognisable social type whose constant apologising typically communicates anxiety rather than genuine accountability, and whose apologies carry progressively less informational weight to the people who receive them frequently. The stronger position is that apology is most valuable — both functionally and ethically — when the wrongdoing is genuine, the acknowledgement specific, and the expression chosen with care rather than reflexively deployed as a social lubricant.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional ethics perspective on apology obligation identifies the severity, intentionality, and relational context of the wrongdoing as the variables that determine the nature and depth of the appropriate apology rather than obligating apology uniformly across all mistakes. For serious wrongs — those that cause significant harm, involve breach of trust, or reflect genuine moral failure — explicit, specific apology is ethically required and its absence represents a meaningful additional wrong. For minor, accidental infractions without significant impact — small disruptions, innocent misunderstandings, trivially inconvenient mistakes — the social norm of apology should be met but the magnitude of the acknowledgement should be calibrated to the magnitude of the wrong, because disproportionate apology for minor incidents creates social awkwardness and implicitly claims a greater severity than the incident warrants.

3. Do people in your country like to say "sorry"?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Vietnamese social norms around apology are characterised by a significant gap between the frequency of implicit acknowledgement — the avoidance of eye contact, the self-deprecating laugh, the gesture of deference that communicates awareness of having caused inconvenience — and the frequency of explicit verbal apology, which is somewhat less common in everyday social interaction than in British or North American social contexts. This gap reflects the importance of face in Vietnamese social interaction: explicit verbal apology, particularly in public or semi-public contexts, draws attention to the apologisee's failure in ways that increase rather than reduce face loss, making the implicit acknowledgement culturally more effective at restoring relational balance than the direct verbal admission that Western social norms typically expect. The pattern is nuanced by generation and context: younger urban Vietnamese are somewhat more likely than their parents' generation to use explicit verbal apology in close social relationships, reflecting the influence of international cultural exposure.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional cross-cultural communication perspective on Vietnamese apology norms identifies the distinction between high-context and low-context communication cultures as directly relevant. In high-context communication environments — where substantial meaning is conveyed through non-verbal cues, contextual knowledge, and implicit communication rather than through explicit verbal statement — the social work done by apology in low-context cultures is accomplished through different communicative means: in Vietnamese professional contexts, this means through gestures of deference, behavioural correction without verbal acknowledgement, and the re-establishment of relational harmony through acts of care rather than through verbal admission of fault. This pattern is not ethically deficient relative to explicit verbal apology norms; it reflects a different theory of how social repair is most effectively accomplished in the specific cultural context.

4. On what occasion do people usually apologize to others?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The occasions that most reliably elicit apology cluster around the categories of disruption, harm, and breach of expectation — but the specific occasions vary substantially with the social relationship context in ways that reflect the different apology norms operating in different relationship types. In close personal relationships — friendships and family — apology tends to occur after interpersonal conflict: after arguments, misunderstandings, and promises broken — when the relational damage is significant enough to require explicit acknowledgement for repair to begin. In formal and professional contexts — workplaces, commercial interactions, institutional settings — apology tends to be triggered by more specific and bounded occasions: delays, errors affecting others, misunderstandings with professional consequences, and breaches of professional commitment.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional analysis of apology occasions in organisational contexts identifies the service failure as the commercially and operationally most significant category — the moment when a product, service, or commitment fails to meet the expectation it created. Service recovery research consistently shows that effective apology for service failure — specific,

prompt, accompanied by demonstrated understanding of the impact from the customer's perspective — is among the most powerful tools available for restoring customer trust after failure, and is more effective than compensation alone in producing long-term relationship restoration. The institutional occasions that go under-apologised — relative to what the evidence suggests would produce the best relational outcomes — are the ambiguous failure occasions, where the attribution of responsibility is contested or unclear, and where the institutional preference for not conceding fault produces apology avoidance in exactly the circumstances where acknowledgement would do most good.

5. Do you think every "sorry" is from the bottom of the heart?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

Sincerity is not a binary property of apologies — apologies range across a spectrum from perfunctory social formulas whose communicative function is social lubrication rather than genuine acknowledgement, to deeply felt expressions of regret whose sincerity is difficult to doubt. The most common apologies in everyday social life — the "sorry" when bumping into someone on a pavement, the apologetic email opener that softens a request — are not from the bottom of the heart in any meaningful sense, and it would be both peculiar and somewhat exhausting to expect them to be: their social function doesn't require sincerity, only the performance of social awareness. The cases where sincerity genuinely matters — where the relational damage being repaired is significant enough that the apology's effectiveness depends on its being genuine — are identifiable precisely because the inadequacy of a pro forma apology in those contexts is immediately apparent to the person receiving it.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional psychological analysis of apology sincerity identifies the behavioural intention dimension — whether the apologisee genuinely intends to behave differently as a result of the acknowledgement — as the most reliable indicator of sincerity, more informative than the emotional expressiveness of the apology itself. Research on apology and forgiveness consistently shows that the quality of apology most predictive of successful relational repair is not emotional intensity but specificity and behavioural commitment: the apology that names what was done, acknowledges its impact from the other person's perspective, and identifies what the apologisee commits to doing differently, tends to produce more reliable relational repair than emotionally effusive apologies without the same specificity. Institutional apologies — from corporate entities, political figures, and public organisations — are most commonly evaluated as insincere precisely because they typically lack the behavioural commitment dimension: they acknowledge the harm but provide no credible mechanism for preventing its recurrence.

6. Are women better than men at recognizing emotions?

Sample 1: Student Persona (Band 7-8)

The evidence for average female superiority in emotion recognition tasks is reasonably consistent across research settings — studies using facial expression recognition, vocal affect identification, and emotion inference tasks typically find women outperforming men — but the magnitude of the differences is typically small, the overlap in the distributions very large, and the causal interpretation contested between those who attribute the difference to biological factors and those who attribute it primarily to differential socialisation. The

socialisation argument is well-supported: girls are consistently trained from early childhood to attend to, interpret, and regulate emotional information to a greater degree than boys in most cultural contexts, and the emotional attention and interpretation habits formed in that socialisation would be expected to produce the observed performance differences on emotion recognition tasks without requiring appeal to biological differences. The practical implication is that the observed differences are likely both real and substantially reversible — evidence from training studies suggests that explicit emotion recognition training produces performance improvements in both sexes that substantially close the average gap.

Sample 2: Working Professional Persona (Band 7-8)

The professional organisational psychology perspective on gender and emotion recognition identifies the occupational sorting mechanism as a significant confound in interpreting individual-level gender differences. Women are disproportionately represented in occupations that require well-developed emotion recognition capacity — primary education, social work, healthcare, human resources, counselling — which means that the average female advantage in emotion recognition studies may reflect occupational self-selection and practice effects as much as any prior individual difference. The research that explicitly controls for occupational role finds that the gender effect on emotion recognition is substantially reduced — suggesting that what looks like a stable gender difference is substantially a gender-correlated difference in occupational practice that, like the socialisation explanation, points toward a learned rather than fixed capacity. The professional implication is that organisations concerned with maximising emotion recognition capacity across their workforces should focus on training and role assignment rather than on demographic screening.

Từ	Loại	IPA	English Meaning	Dịch nghĩa
pro forma	adj phr	/ˌprəʊ ˈfɔːmə/	done as a matter of routine without real meaning	theo thủ tục, chiếu lệ
effusive	adj	/ɪˈfjuː.sɪv/	expressing feelings in an exaggerated, unrestrained way	phô trương cảm xúc, nhiệt tình thái quá
apology legislation	n phr		laws that protect apologies from being used as legal admissions of fault	luật về xin lỗi (bảo vệ quyền xin lỗi)
face loss	n phr		the damage to one's social reputation or dignity	mất thể diện
service recovery	n phr		the steps taken to restore customer satisfaction after a service failure	khắc phục sự cố dịch vụ
sincerity	n	/sɪnˈser.i.ti/	the quality of being genuine and honest	sự chân thành, thành thật
occupational sorting	n phr		the tendency for people to self-select into jobs that match their traits	phân loại nghề nghiệp theo đặc điểm cá nhân
confound	n	/ˈkɒn.faʊnd/	a variable that distorts the results of a study	biến số gây nhiễu
emotion recognition	n phr		the ability to identify and interpret others' emotional states	nhận dạng cảm xúc
behavioural commitment	n phr		a stated intention to change one's conduct going forward	cam kết thay đổi hành vi